Zero Counts

Posts Export — 631 posts — Generated March 22, 2026

Table of Contents

1. Finding The Rails (April 13, 2012)
2. 2013: The Year of 4K (January 8, 2013)
3. Editor's Choice: EDGE Extended (February 6, 2013)
4. Identity Crisis: Kids Know Best (March 20, 2013)
5. Journey: 1 Year Later (April 9, 2013)
6. Star Fox 64: Design Mission Accomplished (April 20, 2013)
7. Xbox One: Swinging for the Franchise Fences with Rare IP? (May 22, 2013)
8. E3 2013: Genre/Gender Breakdown (June 14, 2013)
9. Study attempts to identify risks for 'problematic' video game usage (September 24, 2013)
10. Study: Video games causing spike in music composer employment (September 25, 2013)
11. Opinion: Why we spend so much money to be so stressed out (September 26, 2013)
12. China creates Shanghai-based free trade zone, ending game console ban (September 27, 2013)
13. Looking Back on the League of Legends Championship Series Grand Finals (October 7, 2013)
14. September 2013's Best-Selling PSN Games (October 7, 2013)
15. Jane McGonigal: The game that can give you 10 extra years of life | TED (October 8, 2013)
16. Why the Red Cross cares how video games treat war crimes (October 8, 2013)
17. Russian government wants to help produce patriotic games (October 8, 2013)
18. Report: Chinese students forced to manufacture PS4 at Foxconn plant (October 10, 2013)
19. 1985: Burst and Bloom (October 15, 2013)
20. Wii U sees estimated 79 percent sales climb in North America (October 16, 2013)
21. Chris Grant on Reasons to Invest in PC gaming (October 18, 2013)
22. How Long Can Video Games Matter? (October 21, 2013)
23. Why video games are more Britney Spears and less Pink Floyd (October 22, 2013)
24. Why mobile games are so addictive (October 22, 2013)
25. How a video game could help children with food allergies (October 25, 2013)
26. Go Right by YouTuber RockyPlanetesimal (October 25, 2013)
27. Could Xbox One and PlayStation 4 actually fail? (October 28, 2013)
28. 5 Studies That Prove Video Games Are Good For You (November 5, 2013)
29. Study: Playing video games can increase brain size (November 5, 2013)
30. Game Play Has No Negative Impact on Kids, UK Study Finds (November 19, 2013)
31. GameStop global sales hit $2.11 billion, store sales rise 20.5 percent (November 21, 2013)
32. 'Disney Infinity' to introduce Princesses (November 21, 2013)
33. No girls allowed (December 2, 2013)
34. Give8Bit - How To Give While You Game (December 3, 2013)
35. PS4 Sells Over 2.1 Million Units Globally (December 3, 2013)
36. You could help real-world farmers by playing Cropland Capture (December 3, 2013)
37. Second gaming ceasefire held for Sandy Hook but skepticism remains (December 5, 2013)
38. If you love games, you should refuse to be called a gamer (December 9, 2013)
39. StarCraft 2 player receives the sport's first US athlete visa (December 15, 2013)
40. Launching Operation Supply Drop (December 16, 2013)
41. The Altamont Archives (February 4, 2014)
42. On Reading (February 24, 2014)
43. Save developers and you will save your soul (March 13, 2014)
44. Monument Valley - A Review (April 6, 2014)
45. Juxtaposition in Video Game Commercials (April 8, 2014)
46. Humanity in Hearthstone (April 17, 2014)
47. How video games can change the world, one child at a time (April 24, 2014)
48. 59% of Americans play video games (April 27, 2014)
49. Mariothon (May 3, 2014)
50. Mobile is burning, and free-to-play binds the hands of devs who want to help (May 9, 2014)
51. Re: Video games, art and noise (May 12, 2014)
52. Watch Dogs special editions total $1,240, but do you really need that hat? (May 14, 2014)
53. Rare is evaluating what to do after Kinect, says Phil Spencer (May 16, 2014)
54. Ben Kuchera on sex in Wolfenstein (May 20, 2014)
55. Layoffs hit Rare (May 20, 2014)
56. Jordan Shapiro on the current reading habits of children (May 21, 2014)
57. Polygon Human Angle: Queer Games (May 21, 2014)
58. Welcoming to new players (May 21, 2014)
59. Well played: On multiplayer behavior, discipline, and new interactions (May 22, 2014)
60. Osmo: New creative play (May 22, 2014)
61. Braving Blizzard and inclusion in games (May 22, 2014)
62. Ethnicity in film is to sexuality in games (May 22, 2014)
63. People of a certain age (May 22, 2014)
64. Dungeon Defenders studio lays off 20%, shift in company culture (May 23, 2014)
65. "what do you think about us copying the game?" (May 23, 2014)
66. Webster Goomez the stuffed Goomba (May 23, 2014)
67. NYT: 'Rusty's Real Deal Baseball Video Game Tests Haggling Skills' (May 24, 2014)
68. Super Mario Lovers (May 24, 2014)
69. Polygon: 'How gaming in wartime connected soldiers, a father and a son' (May 25, 2014)
70. Freakonomics Radio: 'Think Like a Child' (May 25, 2014)
71. Transistor OST (May 26, 2014)
72. IGN: 'Final Fantasy X's war on organized religion' (May 26, 2014)

73. The topic of misogyny (May 27, 2014)
74. Nintendo x YouTube Affiliate Program (May 27, 2014)
75. Journey dev raises $7 million (May 27, 2014)
76. Polygon: 'It's time to stop caring about new IP (just because it's new IP)' (May 27, 2014)
77. Microsoft not selling off Xbox (May 28, 2014)
78. Health tech Trojan horse (May 28, 2014)
79. #YesAllWomen (May 29, 2014)
80. Pretty In Pink (May 29, 2014)
81. Harmonix lays off 37 (May 29, 2014)
82. Polygon: 'Among the Sleep Review' (May 29, 2014)
83. Glenn Beck on Watch Dogs (May 30, 2014)
84. Tapped Out Intros Chester Dupree, The Simpsons Slacker (May 30, 2014)
85. Club Nintendo stuck in Mario Kart traffic (May 31, 2014)
86. Hail Mario (June 1, 2014)
87. BBC 5Live moves Game On into Primetime (June 1, 2014)
88. Video games crash course (June 2, 2014)
89. Tunnel vision (June 2, 2014)
90. The Guardian: 'Tetris: how we made the addictive computer game' (June 3, 2014)
91. Everything wrong with modern trailers (June 3, 2014)
92. 'Temple Run' sees 1bn downloads, mostly women (June 4, 2014)
93. GamesIndustry International: 'SOE GIRL Scholarship winner announced' (June 4, 2014)
94. More on Mario Kart (June 4, 2014)
95. Pipe Dream (June 4, 2014)
96. Passion (June 5, 2014)
97. The New Face of Gamers (June 5, 2014)
98. Polygon: 'E3 is loud, expensive, sexist and violent: It's also the only place to be next week' (June 6, 2014)
99. LEGO female scientists (June 6, 2014)
100. Nintendo consolidates, lays off 130 (June 7, 2014)
101. A new definition of manhood (June 7, 2014)
102. Game of Games (June 7, 2014)
103. The Sacred and Profane (June 8, 2014)
104. Player (June 8, 2014)
105. Grammy-nominated composer speaks up against union blockage of video game recordings (June 9, 2014)
106. Only on Playstation, Bro (June 9, 2014)
107. Microsoft at E3 (June 10, 2014)
108. Because, it's Nintendo (June 10, 2014)
109. Diversity at press events (June 10, 2014)
110. Sonic the Hedgehog feature film (June 10, 2014)
111. No females in Assassin's Creed Unity co-op (June 10, 2014)
112. Tumbleweed (June 11, 2014)
113. Final Fantasy 14 gets same-sex marriage (June 11, 2014)
114. Polygon: 'New deal could clear game musician strife' (June 11, 2014)
115. Mario Kart is moving units (June 11, 2014)
116. No girls allowed (June 12, 2014)
117. Splatoon (June 12, 2014)
118. The state of gaming in mainstream media (June 12, 2014)
119. Polygon: 'It's getting better: I spent an entire day at E3 playing as women characters' (June 12, 2014)
120. The problem with humanoids (June 12, 2014)
121. Gigantic DS (June 13, 2014)
122. Biophilia is headed to classrooms (June 15, 2014)
123. Nintendo And The Future Of Kids' Games (June 15, 2014)
124. Fanboy Wars (June 16, 2014)
125. Console sales jump 95% in May (June 17, 2014)
126. Personality (June 17, 2014)
127. Compliance for positive females, negative males (June 17, 2014)
128. Not from school (June 17, 2014)
129. There is no failure here, just change. (June 17, 2014)
130. Free speech and online creeps (June 18, 2014)
131. Real-world interaction (June 18, 2014)
132. Dual GamePad play (June 18, 2014)
133. The road ahead (June 18, 2014)
134. Rare and Lionhead are Crown Jewels (June 19, 2014)
135. #stopTDV game jam (June 19, 2014)
136. A Life Well Wasted (June 19, 2014)
137. Disrupting racism and sexism (June 20, 2014)
138. Console Wars: Game Gear (June 20, 2014)
139. Queue Dodge (June 20, 2014)
140. Minecraft: You make the story (June 22, 2014)
141. Sunday side note: Phil Collins (June 22, 2014)
142. Siracusa on the end of humanity (June 23, 2014)
143. "An intensity I'd never felt before in a game." (June 23, 2014)
144. Video Games: The Movie Trailer (June 23, 2014)
145. 1987 Nintendo (June 24, 2014)
146. IGDA surveys 2,200 devs on industry perception (June 24, 2014)
147. Minecraft enforces EULA (June 25, 2014)
148. 'Yes, vinyl prices are going up. No, I don't feel bad.' (June 25, 2014)
149. Android & Playstation TV (June 26, 2014)
150. Whack-A-Mole (June 26, 2014)
151. Level 1-1 (June 26, 2014)
152. Freemium v. Premium (June 27, 2014)
153. #LikeAGirl (June 27, 2014)
154. Hacking, puzzle-boxes and company culture (June 28, 2014)
155. Games Done Quick raises $700,000 (June 29, 2014)
156. Mindshift (June 30, 2014)
157. New technology (June 30, 2014)
158. App: The Human Story (July 1, 2014)
159. Bioware intros first gay male character (July 1, 2014)
160. Finnish Hearthstone tournament limited to male participants (July 1, 2014)
161. Oddworld and Malcolm X (July 1, 2014)
162. Console Love? (July 2, 2014)
163. Pixel Art (July 3, 2014)
164. Egoraptor just harshly criticized Ocarina of Time on the Internet (July 3, 2014)
165. Mario Kart 8 lifts console sales more than Titanfall or Second Son (July 5, 2014)
166. If not Disneyland or Nintendo... (July 7, 2014)

167. Kids react to Game Boy (July 7, 2014)
168. Gambling for Kids (July 8, 2014)
169. Tipping Point (July 9, 2014)
170. Binary Notions of Sex and Gender (July 9, 2014)
171. Right and Wrong (July 10, 2014)
172. Dota 2: Newcomer's Broadcasts at TI4 (July 10, 2014)
173. Madden NFL 15 Aims to Teach Football (July 11, 2014)
174. How chess shows that gender segregation in eSports might encourage more female leagues (July 11, 2014)
175. Coming Out Simulator 2014 (July 11, 2014)
176. The Untold Story of Unroll.Me (July 12, 2014)
177. Unpaid part-time job (July 14, 2014)
178. 8bit Football (July 14, 2014)
179. The Return of Crash Bandicoot and Spyro? (July 14, 2014)
180. Fabian Giesen's exit letter (July 15, 2014)
181. Order and Chaos (July 15, 2014)
182. A Tale of Two Trailers (July 15, 2014)
183. Historic Gaming (July 16, 2014)
184. The International on ESPN3 (July 17, 2014)
185. Sokobond: Chemistry-themed 2D indie puzzle game (July 18, 2014)
186. The Cat Mario Show (July 18, 2014)
187. Polygon pits Dota 2 champ payout against professional sports (July 20, 2014)
188. War Ensemble (July 23, 2014)
189. FFXIV Pixel Pride 2014 (July 24, 2014)
190. More on Minecraft (July 28, 2014)
191. League of Lessons: Why Gaming Matters (July 31, 2014)
192. Female Hollywood Numbers (July 31, 2014)
193. Harry Potter and Canon Management (July 31, 2014)
194. Building Blocks (August 3, 2014)
195. The Problem with Licensed Products (August 4, 2014)
196. Game Less Than One Hour Per Day (August 4, 2014)
197. 'How video games have the power to change real lives' (August 6, 2014)
198. Ed Catmull on Icons and Story in Games (August 7, 2014)
199. O Captain! My Captain! (August 11, 2014)
200. Visual Polish (August 11, 2014)
201. Assumption (August 13, 2014)
202. Journey on PS4 (August 13, 2014)
203. Ultra Street Fighter IV Ultras without Cinematic Camera (August 13, 2014)
204. 'Here's why I won't be playing Journey on PlayStation 4' (August 13, 2014)
205. Goal: 15 Percent Turnover Every Year (August 13, 2014)
206. 15 Percent Gamer (August 15, 2014)
207. Your Brain Sucks at Video Games (August 15, 2014)
208. The Gimmick Girl (August 21, 2014)
209. Influenced by Divorce (August 21, 2014)
210. Russ Frushtick says Goodbye to Polygon (August 22, 2014)
211. Switch to Sony (August 26, 2014)
212. Love is Strange (August 27, 2014)
213. Madeleines (August 27, 2014)
214. 'Trolls drive Anita Sarkeesian out of her house to prove misogyny doesn't exist' (August 27, 2014)
215. IGN Celebrates Nintendo's 125th Anniversary by Playing 125 Nintendo Games (August 28, 2014)
216. 'The Truth About Zoe Quinn' (August 28, 2014)
217. You're talking to a child (August 28, 2014)
218. The Metaphorical Grocery Store (August 28, 2014)
219. New Nintendo 3DS (August 29, 2014)
220. Grand Theft Mario (August 29, 2014)
221. Au contraire (August 29, 2014)
222. MMOs, English, and Experiential Learning (August 30, 2014)
223. 'How to attack a woman who works in video gaming' (September 1, 2014)
224. Social Justice Warriors? (September 2, 2014)
225. Rose Gold Lining (September 2, 2014)
226. Anamanaguchi on Song Exploder (September 3, 2014)
227. Chocolate-Covered Broccoli (September 10, 2014)
228. Will Ferrell's SuperMegaBlastMax Gamer Challenge (September 11, 2014)
229. Poisoned Well (September 13, 2014)
230. 'The most radical thing you can do to support women' (September 14, 2014)
231. 4K and the Console Gamer (September 14, 2014)
232. 'Everything is going to be OK. (September 15, 2014)
233. The Internet Rage Machine (September 15, 2014)
234. Sacrifice in the name of quality: Blizzard cancels Titan (September 23, 2014)
235. Anamanaguchi Pops It (September 23, 2014)
236. 'There and Back Again: A History of The Lord of the Rings in Video Games' (September 25, 2014)
237. Digital Amnesia (September 26, 2014)
238. Stats v. Story (September 30, 2014)
239. Welcome to Warp Zone! (September 30, 2014)
240. IGN's Top 125 Nintendo Games of All Time (October 1, 2014)
241. Portal's Influence on RAC's "Let Go (feat. Kele & MNDR) (October 1, 2014)
242. On Strike Teams, Design Councils, and Braintrusts (October 3, 2014)
243. Grant Kirkhope Releases Banjo-Kazooie OST on Bandcamp (October 4, 2014)
244. The Players' Score Enters Final Week of Funding (October 4, 2014)
245. 'I didn't know that. I thought we were having fun.' (October 4, 2014)
246. Sexism, Lies and Video Games: The Culture War Nobody Is Winning (October 5, 2014)
247. Hard-Working Schlubs (October 6, 2014)
248. The Element of Surprise (October 7, 2014)
249. The Innovators (October 7, 2014)
250. Myst TV Drama and Companion Video Game (October 8, 2014)
251. One Hell of a Talk from Anita Sarkeesian at the 2014 XOXO Festival (October 8, 2014)
252. Captain Toad is Genius (October 11, 2014)
253. Three Monkeys (October 13, 2014)
254. Exercising With Nothing But An Xbox (October 13, 2014)

255. 'Why the Two-Hour Game is the Future' (October 14, 2014)
256. A $60 Gamble (October 14, 2014)
257. 'How Reviews Impact Those Who Create' (October 14, 2014)
258. 'An irredeemably dark version of Alice's Adventures in Wonderland' (October 15, 2014)
259. 'My opinion is I hate it.' (October 16, 2014)
260. The Verge Reviews the New Nintendo 3DS (October 21, 2014)
261. Official Elder Scrolls Books Coming March 2015 (October 21, 2014)
262. Chris Kluwe's #Gamergate Piece (October 22, 2014)
263. RBI (October 22, 2014)
264. Clash of Clans Nearly Crushed Kansas City (October 27, 2014)
265. Nintendo Sees $244M in Profit (October 29, 2014)
266. Twitch Adds Game Development Category (October 29, 2014)
267. The Skin of a Rhinoceros (October 30, 2014)
268. K&K (November 1, 2014)
269. What is a game? And why it matters! (November 6, 2014)
270. Guerrillas (November 9, 2014)
271. Embargoes and Appetites (November 10, 2014)
272. Ustwo Offers 8 New Monument Valley Chapters for $1.99, Gets Hammered with 1-Star Reviews (November 11, 2014)
273. Assassin-in-the-room (November 11, 2014)
274. Embargoes and Appetites, Simplified (November 12, 2014)
275. Friendly Freemium Reminder (November 12, 2014)
276. Space Age Color Blindness Options (November 13, 2014)
277. 'A Passionate, Limited Core' (November 15, 2014)
278. 'New Video Games Shouldn't Be So Broken' (November 15, 2014)
279. Kate Upton and Game of War (November 18, 2014)
280. 'The making of Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker' (November 19, 2014)
281. Golden Age Thinking (November 19, 2014)
282. 'Disney can save Nintendo, and it would only cost $19 billion' (November 20, 2014)
283. Iterative vs. Redesigned Experiences (November 22, 2014)
284. 'Wii U Was A Better Console For Third-Party Games' (November 30, 2014)
285. 'Vox Media Valued at Nearly $400 Million After Investment' (November 30, 2014)
286. I think Smash Bros. is how all video games look to grandparents. (November 30, 2014)
287. The Verge Reviews Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker (December 1, 2014)
288. The Making of Lumino City (December 2, 2014)
289. Water Coolers, Spoilers, and Serial (December 2, 2014)
290. Monument Valley is Magic (December 3, 2014)
291. The Lord of the Rings and the Serial Cliffhanger (December 7, 2014)
292. Wii U is My Primary Console (December 9, 2014)
293. Chronological Console Crash Course (December 10, 2014)
294. Thank you, Peter Jackson (December 15, 2014)
295. Nostalgia, Feminism Top Merriam-Webster's Words of the Year (December 15, 2014)
296. 'The first “open narrative” game' (December 17, 2014)
297. Welcome to The New York Review of Video Games (December 17, 2014)
298. 'Nobody ever says "I don't care if the music sounds bad."' (December 17, 2014)
299. Secrets (December 18, 2014)
300. Winning Isn’t Everything (December 21, 2014)
301. St. George California Reserve Agricole Rum (December 27, 2014)
302. Old School Hip Hop is the new Golden Oldies (December 28, 2014)
303. 2014: Zero Counts Launch + Greatest Hits (December 30, 2014)
304. Jason Snell on Solo Blogging Stresses (January 1, 2015)
305. 5 Reasons to Run (January 2, 2015)
306. Xbox One's 7th Core (January 3, 2015)
307. Playing with Limitations (January 4, 2015)
308. ICYMI (January 4, 2015)
309. Greg Miller, Colin Moriarty, Nick Scarpino, and Tim Gettys Quit IGN (January 4, 2015)
310. One of These Days I'll Get It Right (January 5, 2015)
311. Kind of Meaningless (January 6, 2015)
312. Kinda Funny Perspective (January 9, 2015)
313. Online-Only Consoles (January 9, 2015)
314. On Copying (January 10, 2015)
315. Ideas Are Scary (January 12, 2015)
316. Jersey Ethics (January 13, 2015)
317. EyeWire (January 14, 2015)
318. Monument Valley in Numbers (January 15, 2015)
319. Nintendo Direct Play-by-Play (January 16, 2015)
320. How Does Game Length Affect Other Developers? (January 21, 2015)
321. More Battletoads (January 21, 2015)
322. Past, Present, Future Music Week (January 23, 2015)
323. GOTY: Rocksmith 2014 (January 24, 2015)
324. American Horror Story: McDonald's Museum (January 25, 2015)
325. Home Economics 2.0 (January 26, 2015)
326. Life in Japan (January 27, 2015)
327. Troll Masks (January 28, 2015)
328. Smooth McGroove on Upvoted (January 28, 2015)
329. The Super Mario Timeline (January 28, 2015)
330. Metroid Prime Trilogy for $10 (January 29, 2015)
331. Pretty Alright (January 30, 2015)
332. Pissing into the Wind (January 30, 2015)
333. Heroes of Might & Magic III HD Edition (February 2, 2015)
334. Garena Philippines Limiting LGBTQ Women from League of Legends Competition (February 3, 2015)
335. Club Nintendo Experiencing Heavy Traffic (February 3, 2015)
336. There is No End (February 3, 2015)
337. Square Enix Profit Doubles (February 4, 2015)
338. Fun v. Experience (February 5, 2015)
339. Provisional Reviews on Polygon (February 6, 2015)
340. Re Netflix-Zelda: What is Game of Thrones without George R. R. Martin? (February 6, 2015)
341. E3 2014: Genre/Gender Breakdown (February 7, 2015)
342. 21 Percent Delta (March 5, 2015)
343. Be more Disney, less Vegas (March 7, 2015)
344. Monument Valley, post-House of Cards (March 8, 2015)

345. One Tool to Rule Them All (March 8, 2015)
346. The New Normal (March 11, 2015)
347. PS4 Adds Console Wide Button Remapping (March 26, 2015)
348. The Oral History of Steve Barron's TMNT (April 3, 2015)
349. Nintendo's Trickle-Release of Retro Titles, Round 2 (April 3, 2015)
350. David Benioff on Writing Fiction v. Screenplays (April 14, 2015)
351. José James on Discovering Miles Davis, Jazz (April 14, 2015)
352. He Would Not Work in Oils (April 14, 2015)
353. Campaign Season (April 14, 2015)
354. Thoughts on Star Wars Teaser #2 (April 16, 2015)
355. Mario Kart 8 DLC Pack 2: Here We Go! (April 26, 2015)
356. All Killer, No Filler (April 28, 2015)
357. '200CC Is So Fast It's Starting To Break Mario Kart 8 Courses' (April 30, 2015)
358. Nintendo Attractions Coming to Universal Parks (May 7, 2015)
359. Would Disney Buy Nintendo? (May 7, 2015)
360. Buttons (May 30, 2015)
361. Mega Man 2017 (June 1, 2015)
362. The Future of Mario Double-Down (June 11, 2015)
363. Marco on Phil with John (June 11, 2015)
364. Mother Released on Wii U Virtual Console (June 14, 2015)
365. Niche (July 12, 2015)
366. Disneyland's 60th Nighttime Entertainment (July 28, 2015)
367. King's Quest (August 3, 2015)
368. The News Never Stops (September 16, 2015)
369. Lumino City on iOS (November 2, 2015)
370. How Videogames Are Saving the Symphony Orchestra (November 2, 2015)
371. Warcraft and Toontown (November 6, 2015)
372. Warcraft Plot (November 6, 2015)
373. Nerdist Interviews the Cast of Warcraft (November 7, 2015)
374. Polygon Skips Star Wars: Battlefront Review Event (November 13, 2015)
375. The Room Three (November 14, 2015)
376. "Science isn't always a great substitute for fun." (November 17, 2015)
377. Wii U on Target's T-Day Top Three (November 27, 2015)
378. Kobe to Retire (November 29, 2015)
379. Sierra Sets Date for King's Quest, Chapter 2 (December 1, 2015)
380. Porting Primer (December 6, 2015)
381. Star Wars: The Force Awakens (December 18, 2015)
382. Blind Gamer Beats Ocarina of Time (January 4, 2016)
383. Intel, Vox Media, Re/code and the Born This Way Foundation Launch #HackHarassment (January 7, 2016)
384. Have I Stopped Loving Video Games? (January 17, 2016)
385. Demo Mode: Rise of the Tomb Raider (January 18, 2016)
386. Lightning and Louis Vuitton (January 22, 2016)
387. Gaming likely to be big part of Obama's $4B computer science initiative (February 5, 2016)
388. Disneyvania (February 8, 2016)
389. Firewatch: A Review (February 20, 2016)
390. The Witness: A (Cheater's) Review (March 11, 2016)
391. Pokémon GOTY (July 13, 2016)
392. Uncharted 4: A Thief's End (July 30, 2016)
393. The Big Picture by Sean Carroll (August 2, 2016)
394. Nintendo 64 and Avoiding 'Sequelitis' (October 2, 2016)
395. Nintendo Switch and Parents (October 20, 2016)
396. WSJ: Banning Tablets Is Best for Children (October 24, 2016)
397. Ben Thompson: "What Nintendo is doubling down on is controllers" (October 28, 2016)
398. Comfortable (November 12, 2016)
399. Rogue One: The Sound of a Story (January 3, 2017)
400. Edwards: 'The wipes are the cheesiest thing in the world' (January 4, 2017)
401. Inside: A Review via 'Death by Video Game' (January 6, 2017)
402. Polygon's 2016 Games of the Year (January 8, 2017)
403. How the inventor of Mario designs a game (January 12, 2017)
404. Nintendo Switch Presentation 2017 Impressions (January 14, 2017)
405. Reggie Fils-Aimé: 'I don't mind how you interact with our IP as long as you're interacting with it every day' (January 15, 2017)
406. Nintendo Switch's 'dedicated smart device app' to allow consumers 'to play those connected experiences... while they're on the go' (January 15, 2017)
407. The Switch is a home console. The Switch is a "home" console. The Switch is a "home" console? (January 15, 2017)
408. Nintendo: Amusement Provider (January 18, 2017)
409. 'A Disney character in every home in America' (January 21, 2017)
410. FBI releases Gamergate investigation records (January 27, 2017)
411. Just (Quietly) Dance (January 29, 2017)
412. Jose Otero, IGN: 'Attaching and detaching [Joy-Con] from the [Switch] is satisfying to the point that it's almost addictive' (January 29, 2017)
413. Nintendo's Q3 Fiscal Year: Pocket Monsters (January 31, 2017)
414. 100 Nintendo Switch Titles in Development (February 1, 2017)
415. 'Is there an exodus from indie back to AAA?' (February 3, 2017)
416. 'Same playbook, just on a wider scale' (February 4, 2017)
417. The Verge: 'How the Xbox One and PS4 are helping bring Chinese indie games to the West' (February 4, 2017)
418. Nintendo's 'Conductor' (February 6, 2017)
419. Nintendo 3DS and NES Classic Still Out of Stock (February 7, 2017)
420. The Besties Are Back (February 9, 2017)
421. Nicalis: Switch development is 'light years ahead of what we were doing with Wii U' (February 9, 2017)
422. The Second Console (February 10, 2017)
423. 'On the internet, no one still knows you're a dog' (February 10, 2017)
424. Takahashi: 'reach that broader smart device audience and entice them to move towards Nintendo Switch' (February 12, 2017)
425. 'Metacritic' Still Matters, But For How Long? (February 13, 2017)
426. Humble Freedom Bundle (February 13, 2017)
427. GameStop Announces Midnight Switch Launch (February 22, 2017)
428. Eurogamer: 'Docked Zelda Stutters in Places Where the Mobile Experience Does Not' (March 3, 2017)
429. Phil Collins: Crash Bandicoot man (March 5, 2017)

430. Switch On, Switched Off (March 11, 2017)
431. 'The schoolyard is the entirety of the internet' (March 13, 2017)
432. Self-Competing and Time Blocking (April 23, 2017)
433. Hail Mario 2: Electrodrome Boogaloo (April 30, 2017)
434. WSJ is Breaking Nintendo (May 15, 2017)
435. Sold on Cross-Network Play (June 17, 2017)
436. E3 2017 (June 19, 2017)
437. Kudos to Nintendo's E3 Booth Team (June 19, 2017)
438. John Gruber's Review of the Nintendo Switch (June 29, 2017)
439. Brian Crecente says Goodbye to Polygon (July 11, 2017)
440. Sell My Old Consoles, I'm Off To Handheld (August 5, 2017)
441. The Cubs Way, Music, and Management (August 12, 2017)
442. Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle: "Just looking around is a joy" (August 27, 2017)
443. Why I love video games (September 11, 2017)
444. Traditional Games (October 19, 2017)
445. Super Mario Odyssey — A Review (November 19, 2017)
446. Good Enough (November 22, 2017)
447. New Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles Arcade Game (November 22, 2017)
448. Big-N's Big Year (November 28, 2017)
449. 'But then Nintendo released The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild' (December 9, 2017)
450. Nintendo Switch Sells 10 Million Units in 9 Months (December 12, 2017)
451. Nintendo of America launches Nintendo Power Podcast (December 23, 2017)
452. 'In 2017, I Turned to Video Games to Avoid Trump and Conspiracy Twitter' (December 27, 2017)
453. The Verge: 'Nobody would be talking about the Switch if it wasn't for the games' (December 27, 2017)
454. Joy-Confirmation (December 28, 2017)
455. Miyamoto: 'I always look for designers who aren't super-passionate game fans' (December 30, 2017)
456. Switch Sales Top PS2 in First-Year, Wii U Lifetime in Japan (December 30, 2017)
457. Dark Souls: Remastered Announced for Nintendo Switch (January 11, 2018)
458. 'Everyone feels lost all the time' (January 14, 2018)
459. Nintendo: Crazy Toy-Con Maker (January 17, 2018)
460. Nintendo Stock Jumps 4.2% After Labo Reveal (January 20, 2018)
461. Nintendo Switch Is the Fastest-Selling Console in U.S. History (January 22, 2018)
462. Nintendo Switch breaks records for first-year US sales (March 21, 2018)
463. Switch Ports Hamstrung by Mario Carts (March 24, 2018)
464. Cross-Network Play is "the Next Logical Step" (March 25, 2018)
465. Building Zero Counts (March 25, 2018)
466. In Rainbows (April 8, 2018)
467. Demystify Technology (April 8, 2018)
468. More Original Xbox Games Coming to Xbox One Backward Compatibility (April 10, 2018)
469. Polygon's God of War Review: 'You don't find collectibles; you find entire chunks of story' (April 12, 2018)
470. The rise of the ambient video game (April 17, 2018)
471. Most Video Games Are Too Long (April 17, 2018)
472. Video Game Music's Tremendous Power (April 18, 2018)
473. The Verge: 'My Xbox One S is now a meaningfully different console to my PS4' (April 21, 2018)
474. Griffin and Justin McElroy Depart Polygon (April 24, 2018)
475. Some Numbers That Illustrate Nintendo Switch's Massive Success (April 26, 2018)
476. Adjustable Charging Stand for Nintendo Switch (May 8, 2018)
477. Virtual Console kinda sucked (May 8, 2018)
478. Ben Thompson: 'Humans Run on Stories' (May 14, 2018)
479. Microsoft's Xbox Adaptive Controller (May 16, 2018)
480. Switch 2nd Unit Set (May 22, 2018)
481. Pokémon: Let's Go! (May 29, 2018)
482. PS4 Fortnite Accounts Are Blocked On The Nintendo Switch (June 11, 2018)
483. Sometimes Failure Leads to Opportunity (June 11, 2018)
484. Nintendo Tops E3 Tweets (June 21, 2018)
485. Xbox Switch "Better Together" Campaign (June 22, 2018)
486. The Hard Times' Hard Drive (June 30, 2018)
487. Bloomberg Businessweek: The Legend of Nintendo (July 1, 2018)
488. FastCoDesign: Why tech's favorite color is making us all miserable (July 4, 2018)
489. Kotaku: Octopath Traveler Is Nothing Like Final Fantasy VI (July 7, 2018)
490. Polygon: Captain Toad feels like "Nintendo experimenting within the Mario Universe" (July 12, 2018)
491. Hard to feel bad for a middle-aged white man (July 12, 2018)
492. He had discovered Time and Death and God (July 13, 2018)
493. Bloated from all he had acquired (July 16, 2018)
494. The nationalism of liberal Americans (August 4, 2018)
495. Old things (August 14, 2018)
496. Obama could actually win this thing (August 16, 2018)
497. Third Worlders are forward-looking (August 19, 2018)
498. You will find the future where people are having the most fun (August 23, 2018)
499. Modern life itself could make you sick (August 26, 2018)
500. Music seems to send us out on a quest for new experiences (August 26, 2018)
501. The television equivalent of the novel (September 1, 2018)
502. Xbox All Access Pass hardware, software, and services subscription (September 5, 2018)
503. The limitations make games fun (September 9, 2018)
504. Under the sail of generosity rather than selfishness (September 15, 2018)
505. We've misunderstood fun to mean enjoyment without effort (September 15, 2018)
506. The paradox of fun (September 15, 2018)
507. The Nintendo 3DS and the Importance of Ports (September 15, 2018)
508. Books Are My New Albums (September 24, 2018)
509. Cross-platform play coming to PS4, starting with Fortnite (September 26, 2018)

510. There are too many video games. What now? (September 28, 2018)
511. Hunch: Nintendo Revives “Super” Branding (October 3, 2018)
512. The Xbox One X makes a lot more sense in 2018 (October 29, 2018)
513. Hot Wheels don’t teach auto mechanics (November 11, 2018)
514. Washed Up Emo: ‘It felt like you were turning a page of a book that you’d never opened before’ (November 14, 2018)
515. If God cannot do this… (December 8, 2018)
516. One needed a handle, a lever, a means of inspiring fear (December 8, 2018)
517. What’s in a Creator? (December 16, 2018)
518. Vox Video Lab (December 17, 2018)
519. 2018 Reads (December 30, 2018)
520. Gruber: ‘There is a thing to being “Mac-like”’ (January 1, 2019)
521. The year in gaming controversies (January 2, 2019)
522. UK video games market is now 80% digital (January 3, 2019)
523. 20 Years of StarCraft (January 5, 2019)
524. Jim Guthrie and the Below soundtrack (January 18, 2019)
525. Activision, Microsoft, and Platforms (January 20, 2019)
526. Switch Is Selling Like Wii, Thanks To Traditional Nintendo Games (January 22, 2019)
527. Polygon: The battle between Steam and Epic Games Store is heating up (January 28, 2019)
528. Nintendo FY18 Q3 Earnings (January 30, 2019)
529. Microsoft’s Super Bowl Ad (February 1, 2019)
530. Real World Playbook (February 2, 2019)
531. Microsoft to Bring Xbox Live to the Switch (February 4, 2019)
532. Activision-Blizzard Employees Brace For Massive Layoffs (February 9, 2019)
533. Activision Blizzard cuts hundreds of jobs despite ‘record revenue’ year (February 11, 2019)
534. ‘A thin blanket against the cold reality’ (February 19, 2019)
535. Rumor: Microsoft Bringing Game Pass And Published Titles To Switch (February 20, 2019)
536. ‘But the answer is simpler when it comes to the real money maker for Microsoft’ (February 22, 2019)
537. Nintendo Knew How (March 9, 2019)
538. Game Boy Restored (April 20, 2019)
539. A Video Game Developed To Detect Alzheimer’s Disease Seems To Be Working (April 28, 2019)
540. Playdate (May 21, 2019)
541. ‘It’s like friendly punk’ (May 22, 2019)
542. ‘But when I play video games, I begin feeling guilty and even bored’ (July 7, 2019)
543. Fire Emblem: Management Simulator (August 29, 2019)
544. Video Games Do Not Exist (October 1, 2019)
545. Polygon’s 100 Best Games of the Decade (November 5, 2019)
546. Hail Mario 3: Revenge of the Stock (November 8, 2019)
547. Star Wars: The Rise of Skywalker — A Review (December 18, 2019)
548. Estimates: Nintendo Switch passed the Xbox One in hardware shipments (January 31, 2020)
549. NBCSW will broadcast video game simulations of Wizards and Capitals games (March 20, 2020)
550. GameStop is a garbage company (March 20, 2020)
551. The Comfort of Childhood Media During Lockdown (March 29, 2020)
552. VGC: 'Nintendo will reveal plans to re-release most of Super Mario’s 35-year back catalogue this year' (March 30, 2020)
553. 'Listen to me, motherfucker, listen' (March 30, 2020)
554. 'We’re not necessarily expecting [a setting like Animal Crossing] to be the real world, and maybe that’s partly why it works' (April 12, 2020)
555. Video games, hell yeah (May 13, 2020)
556. EndeavorRx: First Video Game Approved by FDA (June 17, 2020)
557. Good Sudoku and The Grid (July 31, 2020)
558. '[Sports are] forging a trail which the games industry would be wise to follow' (August 28, 2020)
559. Super Mario 3D All-Stars Announcement (September 2, 2020)
560. From WordPress to Gatsby (September 13, 2020)
561. IGN: ‘The Xbox Series S will not run Xbox One X enhanced versions of backwards compatible games, but will instead run Xbox One S versions of Xbox One and Xbox 360 titles’ (September 14, 2020)
562. Ben Thompson on Microsoft's Game Plan (September 17, 2020)
563. Vintage Nintendo games are good vibes made playable (October 4, 2020)
564. How Games are Changing the World (October 12, 2020)
565. Feminist Frequency: Gender Breakdown of Games in 2020 (October 16, 2020)
566. 'Nintendo’s game streaming strategy is not having one' (October 28, 2020)
567. 'Well, Nintendo Is Doing Great' (November 6, 2020)
568. The First Boy (November 28, 2020)
569. GBC, Blue/Gold Version (December 12, 2020)
570. Video "Games" in 2020 (December 27, 2020)
571. ITA Boys (February 16, 2021)
572. Nintendo's Wonder Bar (April 24, 2021)
573. Game Boy, White (May 5, 2021)
574. The Aether (July 5, 2021)
575. The Whale (Scout's Whale) (July 5, 2021)
576. The White Whale (July 5, 2021)
577. Resties Boy Advances (July 30, 2021)
578. GBA Daiei Hawks Restore (August 16, 2021)
579. GBA, Kirby Edition (August 16, 2021)
580. Game Boy Advance, Sunset (December 21, 2021)
581. Game Boy Advance, Mint (December 22, 2021)
582. Anybody's Game (January 1, 2022)
583. NYT: Making video game history (January 3, 2022)
584. Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: The Cowabunga Collection (March 10, 2022)
585. Random Access Controls (March 10, 2022)
586. Reggie Fils-Aimé on the Wii U Struggle (May 20, 2022)
587. Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Shredder's Revenge Review (June 20, 2022)
588. Ten Years of Zero Counts (July 18, 2022)
589. Nova198Nine (September 5, 2022)
590. Stratechery: Consoles and Competition (December 20, 2022)

591. Marvel Snap's Bedlam Highlights Mario Kart's Balance (December 21, 2022)
592. Monique Judge: ‘Bring back personal blogging’ (December 31, 2022)
593. My Favorite Things of 2022 (January 1, 2023)
594. Something Dissonant (January 2, 2023)
595. MegaMan X: Corrupted (January 4, 2023)
596. Project Leonardo for PlayStation 5 (January 4, 2023)
597. Stephen Totilo: ‘Gaming takes over everything’ (January 5, 2023)
598. Pentiment in The New York Times (January 7, 2023)
599. Nintendo Nintendos (January 10, 2023)
600. 'I Just Took the One with the Best Story' (January 18, 2023)
601. GameDiscoverCo: ‘Compulsion loops’, predatory monetization & you.. (January 18, 2023)
602. Zweisamkeit (January 18, 2023)
603. No Fail Mode (February 13, 2023)
604. 'Regret's a killer worse than death' (February 18, 2023)
605. Rewind My Heart (March 23, 2023)
606. Gunpei Yokoi, Game Boy creator: Our competition has a color screen? 'Then we're fine' (March 25, 2023)
607. Announcing Y-Button (April 20, 2023)
608. Miyamoto: 'The border of video game is becoming less and less set in stone' (January 4, 2024)
609. 'So don't get worried and sell all your shares' (January 27, 2024)
610. 'They’re getting away with it because everybody is doing it.' (January 29, 2024)
611. Avoiding Hell (May 10, 2024)
612. Video games are Millennials too (June 20, 2024)
613. Netflix: The New Blockbuster (August 9, 2024)
614. Switch 2 Teaser Impressions (January 18, 2025)
615. Speech Bubbles (January 19, 2025)
616. Y-Button: Andy Robertson (Ludocene) (February 25, 2025)
617. NYT: ”Metroidvanias: The Video Games You Can Get Lost In” (February 25, 2025)
618. Two Switch 2 Bugaboos (April 5, 2025)
619. Gaming is in its big tech era (April 8, 2025)
620. Polygone (May 1, 2025)
621. Press Reset: The Story of Polygon (May 1, 2025)
622. ’The people of Polygon deserved better’ (May 2, 2025)
623. ’An implosion supervised by idiots who have been grifted by other idiots who have been grifted by actual grifters’ (May 3, 2025)
624. Polygon’s Masthead (May 4, 2025)
625. Post Games: A new podcast by former Polygon Editor-in-Chief Chris Plante (May 26, 2025)
626. ’I just want more portrait mode games on my iPhone.’ (July 24, 2025)
627. ”I won’t cry if you leave.” (September 7, 2025)
628. Adam Grant's Mario Kart Theory of Peak Flow (September 16, 2025)
629. There is no such thing as a video game industry (January 17, 2026)
630. Still Super After All These (10) Years (February 1, 2026)
631. Microsoft Gaming CEO Phil Spencer Retiring, Xbox President Sarah Bond Resigning (February 21, 2026)

Finding The Rails

April 13, 2012

Categories: Health

Until college graduation, my life was on rails. I knew exactly what was supposed to happen, how to make it happen, and how long it would take to get there; there was an eventual goal. While one could see the light at the end of the tunnel, there were meandering duties and hobbies to be had: being in a band, getting your drivers license, entering and exiting relationships, maintaining a job, mowing the lawn, etc.

Then graduation comes. The idea that the path you've set for your life is no longer attainable or no longer interests you becomes a reality. You seem to be stuck with these meaningless tasks and jobs without a clear path to get you back on track.

The majority of video games today contain one large objective, a rail, and many minute "side-quests." While the player treks through the game, the concepts of time and duties never impede on the story. In Skyrim, for example, if you want to become a scholar, there is time for that. If you want to become a mage, there is time for that. So on and so forth. All the while, the main quest remains to be tackled. Differentiating from reality, the game's main quest never goes away and remains the game's eventual goal. The real-life anxiety manifested by the harbinger of time never has an effect on the in-game character

Paralleled against modern video games, it seems as if many people get caught up in the little things, duties or side-quests, which in turn pull their focus away from the larger picture or rail. Most of us have many dreams and aspirations but the more we are caught up in routine and tending to the "small stuff," the more impossible attaining these dreams appears to be.

I spend 40-hours a week in a cyclic job as a computer technician; no internal, rewarding progress made. While I better hone my skills in the realms of customer service and technical expertise, it does not get me any closer to writing a book or script or blog, building a video game or film, hosting my own entertainment news podcast, or becoming a Walt Disney Imagineer. The exhaustion created from my routine day job encourages me to spend my free time with my significant other and/or family.

I now realize that when presented with unlimited options and limited time, I am unsure of the path I would like to take. I consider myself a jack-of-all-trades; good at many things, exceptional at nothing. Amongst my college education, work, and hobbyist writing endeavors, I attempt to dabble in many fields, all in an attempt to discover my passion with the limited time I have to eventually decided on a career.

The recent post at HelloGiggles.com titled "Your Best Life" by Sarah May Bates elaborates on the idea that in the end, humans tend to regret working so much rather than appreciating time with family, traveling the world, and pursuing their passions. It also reflects on the idea that the little things get in our way:

> *"We feel we have to do everything or else the structure of life might fall apart. The mental energy we do reserve for ourselves is usually spent regretting something or worrying about something to come. Obsessing over things that cannot be affected with more obsessing." – Sarah May Bates, HelloGiggles.com*

While this passage is true, it does not take into account the fact that we work to make a means to enjoy life outside of work. The challenge I find is filling your work-life with a passion. If we are able to replace the forty-hours per week we invest in monotonous jobs and substitute it with our passions, we will inevitably end up with a more fulfilling life.

The other dilemma we struggle with regarding time is that it is a limited commodity. To my original point, in games such as Skyrim, there is time to seek out a multitude of professions and quests. In reality, we believe that there are life-markers that will lock us into our current position, such as getting married, having a child, and owning a house. I eye these markers with the idea that if I don't reach my goals by the time these life-markers come around, I will have missed my chance.

A game that actually allows players to experience the anxiety of time is The Sims. Something The Sims creators got right from the inception of the franchise was creating an anxiety within the player, forcing them to juggle priorities as their lives get more complicated: manage more and more relationships, have children, get to work on time. Unlike Skyrim, The Sims compresses the element of time to a point that makes the player feel helpless against it, unable to concentrate on their main story and instead are forced to manage the small tasks. In fact, the original Sims game provides no rails at all and instead forces the Sim to carry out chores until the day they die, creating the perfect example of why humans need eventual goals; not just buying new furniture.

I conclude with the idea that I am beginning to struggle with the thought of leisurely activities. Escaping to the world of video games, where one can take comfort in knowing they have absolute control of their own fate along given rails, fills me with anxiety. I know that my own fate and life-rails are constantly in a state of chaos and uncertainty. Henceforth, this is the struggle. Unable to calm oneself with control and limitations because one is too concerned over finishing every side-quest life throws at them and continuously searching for their own rails. Humans need rails as much as games do.

Originally published at TheStarrList.com

2013: The Year of 4K

January 8, 2013

Categories: Technology

If CES 2013 has proved one thing, it's that 2013 will be the year of 4K. Sony, LG, Samsung, Sharp, and Panasonic have all announced that they will be releasing 4K TVs in 2013. If you are unfamiliar with 4K, check out Wikipedia. In short, it is a screen resolution 4 times that of your 1080p HD TV. It is also standard that digital cinema is delivered in. When you brought your children (and yourself) to watch Wreck-It-Ralph this fall, chances are it was being delivered to you in 4K. But aside from this, why am I so excited about the advancement?

When Apple released the redesigned iMac line in 2009, it opened my eyes to a greater offering of pro-sumer grade products. I was amazed at the amount of pixels in the iMac's IPS enabled LCD displays. Apple decided that it's most popular desktop line would not rest on the laurels the industry set at 1080. Instead, they decided to redesign their all-in-one desktop with a display capable of a native resolution of 2560 x 1440. Thus began my inkling that the time of 1080 would be nearing its end.

In 2010, two key technological advancements hit. In June, Apple released the long awaited iPhone 4. Aside from its gorgeous design and custom A4 processor, it housed a 640 x 960, 326 ppi Retina display; a consumer electronic smartphone with pixels smaller than the naked eye can distinguish at optimal operating distances. I was fortunate enough to take one home the evening of its launch and, to my surprise, I had a hard time falling asleep. I kept waking up to unlock my iPhone as if I had never seen one before. This display was nothing I had ever fathomed. At this point I knew displays would not be getting clearer than this. Only larger. A plateau had been reached followed only by iPad (3rd generation) and now the MacBook Pro with Retina display; bigger displays.

Shortly after, in July of 2010, YouTube released a playlist of 4K streaming videos. While it goes without saying that a majority of the public did not have access to the 4K resolution projectors and/or displays needed to view these natively, these videos did shake the Earth in terms of size. Each video clocked in at roughly 2 minutes and took nearly 10-20 minutes to load, opening our eyes to just how slow our broadband connections really were. While the idea was certainly more appealing than the result, the 4K test footage was another step toward an inevitability.

Over the course of the next few years, TV manufacturers and video game and film studios began to offer gimmicks. Super-high refresh rates that magically turned Star Wars and The Godfather into cable soap operas. In a push to re-invent split screen multiplayer, Sony developed a TV specifically for Playstation 3 that, when wearing special glasses, allowed two players to only see what their character was doing, hiding the other's from view. Then 3D, the biggest gimmick of them all (and the one loads of us fell for).

As quickly as consumers latched on to those expensive TV's and weighty, battery powered 3D glasses, they were just as quickly setting them down. It didn't work in the '80s, it wasn't going to work now. Home-bodied consumers didn't want to worry about having enough glasses for everyone or what angle to sit to allow for the most people to see the screen at once (usually 2). Even Nintendo's glasses-free-3D 3DS couldn't keep up the hype. Gamers quickly began disabling it's 3D capabilities in lieu of increased frame-rate and battery life. It seemed that the only venue 3D would work in was the movie theater.

Now, in 2013, we finally have something to truly look forward to. 4K television. What makes 4K different than any other failed gimmick? Increased clarity and size. The same reasons we left VHS for DVD and DVD for Blu-ray. Only now has out technology finally caught up. Most digitally projected film is shot and projected at 4K resolutions. While not being able to release any other 2D technology before reaching cinema quality may make the TV industry shutter, it will provide consumers with huge piece of mind that they can comfortable settle into a medium.

This is all great for consumers in the present, but what does it mean for the the future of the industry? What new gimmick can be sold to us after 4K? 3D 4K? 8K? Roll back to 35mm? How will the TV and cable industry catchup and retool their studios and infrastructure to deliver 4K content? If 2 minutes of 4K footage takes 20 minutes to load over current broadband speeds, could this a step back for streaming content?

Sony has already announced that they will be offering "Mastered in 4K" Blu-ray discs (upscaled 1080 content). With the rights and a cornerstone on Blu-ray, Sony is sure to be first to market with true 4K physical media. I would not be surprised if 4K ends up to be the backbone of the imminent Playstation 4. While the initial prices for these TVs are a bit lofty, we should all be wise enough to realize that prices will begin to fall in the next few years, making these behemoths affordable for the average consumer.

So why am I so excited? The digital cinema standard of 4K will now be in our households. 4K is not a gimmick but a quality of picture and resolution we've had to buy a ticket to view. Until I am able to afford an IMAX screen, projector, and reels, I will be content with 4K quality. The gimmicks of yesteryear that were staving off the inevitably of 4K enabled TVs may finally be over! That is until TV manufacturers find the next wave of gimmicks (or until James Cameron decides we need to *live* in Pandora... oh wait). Wave goodbye to the HD catch-phrase. 4K is here... and here to stay for a long while.

Editor's Choice: EDGE Extended

February 6, 2013

Categories: Review



What is seemingly simple on the outside may spike your nostalgia on the inside.

Like many, I am often guilty of falling head over heels for media that pays homage to my childhood hobbies. In the case of video games, very few have been able to tap into my childhood gaming roots like that of Mobigame's EDGE Extended. While the game may be an additive to the original EDGE, it succeeds as its own title.

Gameplay

EDGE Extended's core objective is to move your cube from point A to point B as quickly as possible without falling off of the edge of the level, all the while collecting prisms on the way. Your cube's movement consists of crawling along the ground or scaling other cubes of the same height within a level's layout. Boundaries are not forsaken therefore one false move could put you over the edge, racking up your death count, and harming your final score.

Level scoring ranges on a scale of *A* to *D* with special *S* (Professional) and *S+* (EDGE Master) rankings based on completion time, *prisms* collected, and number of deaths (or lack thereof). Hang-time bonuses are given when the player holds the balance of their cube during mid-climb without completing the climb completely, a la manuals/grinds/plants in *Tony Hawk's Pro Skater*.

Each level offers a unique design and mechanics that keep the player riveted and guessing. The rate at which this simple 3D game is able to innovate is mind-blowing, offering unassuming players nostalgia of their first play through of *Super Mario 64*. Many popular platforming mechanics are aplenty throughout each level such as triggers that open bridges, temporary floors, shadow cubes, and even a Morph Ball-esque ability that provide additional challenges in reaching the each level's goal.

Visuals

EDGE Extended's visuals are reminiscent of the original *TRON*: blocky, greyscale level design sprinkled with lines of glowing hue. At initial glance, the game may seem a bore, however it's perfectly timed moments of shimmering colors send the mind racing back to a time of '90s-era sparkly stickers and Lisa Frank products, perfect for today's aging gamer.

Sound

Simply put, the sound design is sharp and smart. A plethora of shimmering chimes move the player through the menus while the soft cushioned thud of the cube satisfies the auditory sense. If that is not enough, the EDGE Extended soundtrack pays homage to the 8/16/32/64-bit melody heavy video game scores of yore such as Sonic the Hedgehog, various menu music, and *Super Mario 64* (I may be obsessed with this game…).

Overall

EDGE Extended is a love letter to historic platformers, memorable mechanics, and the video game music of yesteryear in the form of a casual iOS game. EDGE Extended is a game worthy of a $30 price-tag offered for only $3!

Trailer

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hfpv-18KKZw&feature=emb_title

EDGE Extended is available for iOS on the App Store.

Originally published on TheStarrList.com

Identity Crisis: Kids Know Best

March 20, 2013

Categories: Health

Why are you who you are?



I have been struggling with my professional path. I've poured countless hours into personality tests (MBTI, enneatype, etc.), asked close family and friends what they envision me doing, and have tried my luck exploring various professional and creative avenues (music, marketing, writing, programming, etc.) with little to no epiphanies. Days go by with my ego smashed and I'm left upset that others feel the wrath of my lack of self-confidence and drive. But I may have found a fix…

To center myself, I have begun to explore my childhood hobbies.

At my lowest point, I find solace in my earliest childhood memory playing Mega Man 2 on the original Nintendo Entertainment System. Not only do I mark this as the beginning of my fascination with video games but my obsession with technology and mystery altogether. The ability to control an 8-bit sprite paired with the question of how Rockman would adopt a boss' weapon paved way to the foundation of my creativity.

I spent many years prior salivating over LEGOs, namely the $99 flagship models. Even now, I'm having overly fond memories of the Ice Planet 2002 "Deep Freeze Defender" and Blacktron 2 "Aerial Intruder". Sure, I'd play with the sets after completing them, conducting a war between the knights of the "Royal Knight's Castle" and the thieves of the "Dark Forest Fortress", but more importantly, the idea of creating something new from an incomprehensible cluster of pieces into a formidable kingdom subconsciously encouraged my building and storytelling skills.

Away from toys and video games, I spent plenty of time in front of the TV. While I enjoyed several Nickelodeon TV shows such as *Guts*, *Legends of the Hidden Temple*, *Nick Arcade*, *Double Dare*, and *Wild & Crazy Kids*. I (like many) absolutely adored the *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles*. Even today, I can recite every piece of dialogue, mimic every sound, and predict every special effect from the original 1987 series. As tickled as I am that the TMNT have found their way back to the limelight in the forms of a CG cartoon, toys, comics, video games, LEGOs, and (soon to be) a film, I am more excited that today's youth can experience the lessons of family, humility, leadership, intellect, passion, and humor as I did when I was a kid.

In all, when I find myself in a funk, unsure of the next move to make or how I found myself in the position I am in today, I think back to how it all started. Like most, I enjoyed video games, but was drawn to the technology and mystery within them. Like most, I enjoyed LEGOs, but I discovered storytelling and handy-work. And, like most, I fell in love with a cartoon, but I found love, family, and identity.

While I spend the majority of my days searching for myself, my passion, and my next professional endeavor, I take comfort in understanding my foundation. It gives me pleasure assisting customers in the tech world, helps me bridge the gap between a geek and a people person, and grounds my interests in the tech and media/communication fields.

My challenge to you: Think back to those activities you loved as a child and consider why you loved them. Without a doubt, some of the answers you've been seeking lie within your fond childhood memories.

Originally published at TheStarrList.com

Journey: 1 Year Later

April 9, 2013

Categories: Review



Celebrating this generation's most important work of art.

Released to the masses on March 13, 2012, thatgamecompany's Journey re-ignited the "games as art" argument. It's beautiful and ethereal depiction of companionship, mystery, communication, evolution, and post-apocolypse paved the way to its chart topping success, numerous awards, and a Grammy nomination; a first for the video game medium.

One year later, Journey continues to top Playstation's charts, peaking during awards shows and best of lists. Amongst heavy-hitters and AAA titles, Journey's legacy continues.

There is also the outstanding success and importance of Journey's soundtrack. Composed by Austin Wintory, the soundtrack sprawls from eerie tension to a warm enlightenment, as demonstrated by tracks "Nadir" to "Apotheosis". Wintory's score went on to win numerous awards, dominating the Best Music/Audio category of nearly every video game award ceremony and became the first video game soundtrack to be nominated for a Grammy. One may argue that the standalone success, sweeping hooks, and inspiring melodies of the score continue to draw players to Journey and open conversations to new audiences.

With all of it's gravitas and praise, Journey is not without its nay-sayers. Many refute the piece as a "best of" contender due to its lack of traditional gameplay. Even I, an avid fan of the experience, struggle with the "games as art" argument and have the idea that we need to reevaluate our definition of "game." There is no doubt in my mind that Journey is a profound piece of art, but does it qualify as a game?

> *"Journey's primary mechanic was to move the player from point A to point B and tell a story and show off scenery. The puzzles are simple. The threats are sparse. Consequences are inconsequential." – Kyle Starr, IGN.com*

Regardless of one's feelings on whether Journey can be classified as a game, the experience is one that challenges our opinions of the world and each other. Clocking in at roughly 2 hours of intimate gameplay, Journey is best left as a solo experience to be completed in a single sitting, similar to a movie. The themes previously mentioned are deep and subtle, something we've come to expect from novels. And the score not only moves the story but, like the world's most important classical pieces, can be enjoyed apart from the visual experience.

One year (and one month) ago, Journey redefined art and interactive entertainment. It challenged storytelling, world building, and character evolution. It goes without saying that Journey is one of few crowning achievements of our modern society that should be experienced by all, gamer or otherwise.

Journey's PSN rank since launch. The following sales data as reported by the official Playstation Blog:

Top 20 PSN/Retail Games:

2013

- March: 2
    - GDCA 2013 – 6 awards including Game of the Year
    - BAFTA 2013 – 4 awards including Game of the Year nom
- February: 1
- January: 4

2012

- December: 1
    - VGA 2012 – 3 awards including Game of the Year nom
    - IGN's Best of 2012 – 5 awards including Game of the Year
    - Gamespot's Best Games of 2012 – 4 awards including Editor's Choice Game of the Year
- November: 18
- October: n/a
- September: 15
- August: 8
- July: 6
- June: 3
- May: 2
- April: 2
- March: 1
    - "A true gem; Journey surpassed expectations with many gamers. Be sure to pick up the soundtrack when it drops on April 10th." – Morgan Haro, Sony Community Manager, Playstation Blog

Star Fox 64: Design Mission Accomplished

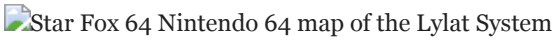
April 20, 2013

Categories: Design

With the recent releases of narrative driven AAA titles such as *Bioshock Infinite* and *Mass Effect* along with the next-generation looming on the horizon, the discussion of game design has yet again taken center stage. Large publishers are looking to balance the addictive re-playability of MMOs, the lucrativness of multi-player FPSs, and the rich immersion of single-player action-RPGs. On the other hand, indie developers such as thatgamecompany toy with the idea of striped down mechanics to balance heavy narrative as seen in *Journey*. Most games now attempt to implement "moral" decisions, often very polar and very poorly.

With today's technology, possibilities seem limitless for gaming's next-generation. However, as the past will show, limits without powerful hardware, online connectivity, and large player communities, can provide some of the best work! As untimely as it may seem, developers should look to games of the past for inspiration on the undiscovered future.

Example: *Star Fox 64*.


Star Fox 64 Nintendo 64 map of the Lylat System

Star Fox 64 championed the idea of a branching, non-linear "linear" story. As one may recall, the map shown above is presented to the player at the onset of Star Fox's journey. And, as most players began to discover, there remained a plethora of unvisited planets and galaxies by the game's end.

Without access to GamePro or online resources, most couldn't quite figure out why those extra stages existed or how to reach them. Those gung-ho enough to research, attentive enough to listen for, or lucky enough to stumble upon the difficult but more rewarding progression, could reap the rewards of a richer story, unique mechanics/vehicles/characters, and largely undiscovered levels. Buddhist like patience rewarded the mastery of repetition.

The beauty of this design lies in the fact that Nintendo developed a game of which 50% would remain untapped by many players. Nintendo taunted the player with what could be, teasing them with evidence of something more, and tucked mystery into each level with hidden paths and special instances. Choices made earlier in the game would not only effect Fox's path but offered different consequences in future levels including character cameos and extra help. They even built an entire mechanic and vehicle class, The Blue Marine, used on one level found on the hard path, Aquas.

Nintendo also innovated on the standard "difficulty selection" cliché that is still often used in today's games. Star Fox 64 tailored the game's difficulty to the player's ambition. If one was deft enough to unlock a level's secret path, they were rewarded with a more difficult stage rather than just increasing health of baddies or offering enhanced AI. As *Star Fox 64* displayed, baking in difficulty based on a player's abilities and determination allowed for Nintendo to create a unique path without compromising the integrity of the game's intended balance.

Star Fox 64's design may not be the exact answer the future of gaming needs, but it's innovation is. Multi-path design, story changes based on accomplishments, a unique take on difficulty settings, and it's ability to tease players with stages that require the practice and precision only replaying can offer are the sort of out-of-the-box thinking the industry needs in this time of change.

While *Bioshock* and *Bioshock Infinite* provide fantastic narrative, their mechanics and level progression never quite impress like *Super Mario 64* or *Final Fantasy X* of yesteryear. Call it age, but the feeling that the limitations set for developers in past provided more opportunity for unique game design seems to be ever present.

Risk is worth it. Even if a small few seek out all of the secrets of a game, it will ensure that it continues to be replayed, rediscovered, and re-loved. Defeating the tropes players are continually subjected to and letting the game unfold around the player's accomplishments and mindful exploration provide an infinitely more rewarding experience.

Xbox One: Swinging for the Franchise Fences with Rare IP?

May 22, 2013

Categories: General

With the recent news that Microsoft will be breathing new life into a 'historic' Rare franchise, a light bulb fired in my head. Could this be Microsoft's attempt to appeal to the playful/children's market that Nintendo has been rooted in for so many years?

Microsoft nor Rare have offered any insight to which franchise will be making a return; however, most of Rare's franchises have been well known within the gaming community since the N64 era. I would even argue that Rare's cast of characters and franchises are more recognizable and lovable than the majority of Microsoft's and Sony's combined.

After the Xbox One reveal, my "one" big take away was that Microsoft's focus is not specifically the gaming market, but *all* markets. It's not to say that people don't love the Halo, Fable, and Gear of War franchises, but why not capitalize on a children's market?

After the seemingly disappointing failure of Sony's *Playstation All-Stars* and Nintendo's continually draw of fantastic IP, Microsoft surely recognizes the importance of having a recognizable cast of characters to market to all-players, children through adults. While Nintendo's consoles may not appeal to many, their franchises surely do. Colorful legends like Mario, Zelda, and Star Fox appeal not only to the child within the adult gamer but also to children and the parents buying their games.

While *Killer Instinct* is the rumored refresh, it surely would not serve as the greatest marketing strategy; however, the select few of playful characters such as *Banzo-Kazooie*, *Jet Force Gemini*, and *Battletoads* could easily garner notoriety. Tone down a character like *Conker* and you've got another to add to the mix. While Donkey Kong is out of the question, Rare could take a lesson from Nintendo and develop a few more fun loving characters for each genre (*Star Fox* = dogfighter, *Metroid* = FPS, *Mario* = platformer, *Zelda* = adventure).

With a revival of Rare's IP, Microsoft could pull the franchise rug out from under Nintendo and make their gaming line-up more recognizable, vast, and nostalgic than Sony's.

What are your thoughts on the Rare announcement? Do you miss Rare Ltd.? Sound off in the comments!

Notable Rare franchises/games:

- Killer Instinct
- Goldeneye
- Banjo-Kazooie
- Jet Force Gemini
- Conker
- Perfect Dark
- Battletoads
- Donkey Kong 64

Originally posted on IGN.com

E3 2013: Genre/Gender Breakdown

June 14, 2013

Categories: Gender

Curious about male protagonist dominance in video games, I decided to do a little research...

The following post was originally published on my IGN blog on 6/15/13. It went on to be featured on the front page of IGN.com.

After all of the announcements at E3, I was curious to find out the genre breakdown between the games announced at E3 as well as their protagonist genders. To delve into this information, I pulled the original Big Games at E3 2013 list (156 games), mapped the platform section into a quantifiable "TRUE"/"FALSE" list, gathered genre lists from both IGN and Wikipedia, and researched the gender of the protagonist of each game.

Elaborating on the gender categories:

"Multi" being either:

- multiple characters to select from (ie. *Mario Kart 8* / *Killer Instinct* receive 1 count for "multi" although there are several characters to select from)
- customizable gender
- large customizable party

"n/a" being a:

- gender ambiguous character
- god-view game
- first-person with no direct gender association


E3 2013 Protagonist Gender Gistribution per Genre


E3 2013 Genre per Platform


E3 2013 Genre per Brand (pie chart)

Some key points:

- Sample size = 156 games
- 9 exclusively female protagonists (*Bayonetta 2, LocoCycle, Transistor, Barbie Dreamhouse Party, Beyond Two Souls, Magic The Gathering: Duels of the Planeswalkers 2014, Mirror's Edge 2, Lightning Returns: Final Fantasy 13, Time and Eternity*)

The most interesting bits of data show PS3 receiving more releases than any other console, Sony in general receiving more releases than any other brand, and Nintendo catering to female and multiple choice protagonists more than any other brand.

The following charts represent IGN's Big Games at E3 2012 list:


E3 2012 Protagonist Gender Distribution per Genre

Some key points:

- Sample size = 55 games
- 1 exclusively female protagonist (*Tomb Raider)*

This is still very much a work in progress as there is plenty of unknown data. Seeing as these charts only map E3 2013, there is no current assessment of industry trends; however, I am currently adding previous E3's to this research. I may be reaching out to the community for assistance in updating this data to slim down on the amount of unknown and update on previous E3s.

UPDATE; 2013-06-15, 12:15p: Added platform spread for announced games.

UPDATE; 2013-06-17, 12:15p: Added Genre breakdown based on Wikipedia classifications, Protagonist Distribution per brand, and Protagonist Distribution per Wikipedia Genre classification.

UPDATE; 2013-06-20, 12:10p: Wikipedia video game genres have been simplified for broad classification. Wikipedia classifies "Shooter" as a sub-Action genre. For the purposes of this study, "Shooter" has been given its own classification.

UPDATE; 2013-06-21, 9:15a: Added charts for Genres Per Platform and Genres Per Brand. Thank you all for your feedback and comments! Loving the discussion!

UPDATE; 2013-06-22, 3:45p: Changed Genres Per Brand charts to pie chart form. I will be adding IGN genre comparison soon.

UPDATE; 2013-06-25, 7:00a: Added data from E3 2012, refined key points including sample sizes and exclusively female protagonist counts.

Study attempts to identify risks for 'problematic' video game usage

September 24, 2013

Categories: Psychology

Mizzou News:

http://vimeo.com/75227903

Additional excerpt from the Frontiers in Developmental Psychology abstract

> *A new measure of individual habits and preferences in video game use is developed in order to better study the risk factors of pathological game use (i.e., excessively frequent or prolonged use, sometimes called "game addiction"). This measure was distributed to internet message boards for game enthusiasts and to college undergraduates. An exploratory factor analysis identified 9 factors: Story, Violent Catharsis, Violent Reward, Social Interaction, Escapism, Loss-Sensitivity, Customization, Grinding, and Autonomy. These factors demonstrated excellent fit in a subsequent confirmatory factor analysis, and, importantly, were found to reliably discriminate between inter-individual game preferences (e.g., Super Mario Brothers as compared to Call of Duty). Moreover, three factors were significantly related to pathological game use: the use of games to escape daily life, the use of games as a social outlet, and positive attitudes toward the steady accumulation of in-game rewards. The current research identifies individual preferences and motives relevant to understanding video game players' evaluations of different games and risk factors for pathological video game use.*

Study: Video games causing spike in music composer employment

September 25, 2013

Categories: Business, Music

Taylor Soper, GeekWire:

> *SoundCon found that the number of composing jobs remained flat until 2009, when growth in the space took off. As the graph above shows, SoundCon found that the dramatic increase was largely due to the arrival of Apple's App Store and the Facebook Application Developer.*

I can't help but feel Austin Wintory's Grammy nomination for the Journey OST will help inspire others as well. However, a paycheck is nice too...

Opinion: Why we spend so much money to be so stressed out

September 26, 2013

Categories: Psychology

Chris Dahlen writing for Polygon:

> *Like most people who use an alarm clock, I have an unhealthy relationship with stress. It hits me in the chest, disrupts my digestion, and wakes me up at all hours of the night — but it's also the reason I'm going to meet my deadline for this column. Life brings stress, but stress is also a self-inflicted wound, like we're suffering a blow that may never come.*
>
> *Not many people would call stress "fun," and yet video games can be stressful. We sometimes willingly pay money to be more stressed. This year gave us a bumper crop of stressful games, and the other day as I was tossing and turning at 5:00 am., I decided to rank them on the inside wall of my cranium. Lucas Pope's recent Papers, Please made it onto the list, and so did Richard Hofmeier's Cart Life. But I started with Nintendo's Pikmin 3.*

A great piece on the arc of human development and stress as depicted by three games:

China creates Shanghai-based free trade zone, ending game console ban

September 27, 2013

Categories: Business

Alexa Ray Corriea, Polygon:

> *Rumors that the 13-year-old ban would be terminated were confirmed earlier today by China's State Council. The Council published a set of regulations that will govern the "experimental" free trade zone to be set up in Shanghai. The rules put forth by the Council allow foreign companies that run production and sales in the zone to sell game consoles, once the hardware receives approval from China's Ministry of Culture.*
>
> *China's prohibition on game consoles began in 2000, but despite the ban, sellers have been able to bring game systems to China through Japan and Hong Kong. Online and mobile games have been permitted in the country and have become popular, bringing in high revenue with "freemium" models.*

It will be interesting to see how Microsoft, Sony, and Nintendo handle this…

Looking Back on the League of Legends Championship Series Grand Finals

October 7, 2013

Categories: eSports

Leah Jackson

> *When I eventually forced myself to stop taking pictures of epic cosplayers and merch, I found my way to my seat and marveled at the 13,000 people filing in to watch one best of five series of League of Legends.*

Is this a pitch for ESPNerd?

September 2013’s Best-Selling PSN Games

October 7, 2013

Categories: Business

IGN

AAA's show big growth on the digital storefront

Jane McGonigal: The game that can give you 10 extra years of life | TED

October 8, 2013

Categories: Gamification, Health, Psychology

TED

> *When game designer Jane McGonigal found herself bedridden and suicidal following a severe concussion, she had a fascinating idea for how to get better. She dove into the scientific research and created the healing game, SuperBetter. In this moving talk, McGonigal explains how a game can boost resilience -- and promises to add 7.5 minutes to your life.*

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lfBpsV1Hwqs

Less about games. More about gamification. All about health.

Thanks to @limshadey for the tip!

Why the Red Cross cares how video games treat war crimes

October 8, 2013

Categories: Society

Brian Crecente, Polygon:

> *Last summer, the International Review of the Red Cross published an article that more deeply examined the issue. The takeaway was that video games are an important method for disseminating information and that they can be used to raise awareness of war crimes, but often don't reflect the realities of war.*

International Humanitarian Law sounds like an interesting game mechanic

Russian government wants to help produce patriotic games

October 8, 2013

Categories: Society

Polygon

> *"A video game has to have not only an entertainment value, but it also has to teach and be conducive to patriotic education," Arseny Mironov, an aide to Russian culture minister Vladimir Medinsky, who heads the Russian Military History Society, told the Russian newspaper Izvestiya.*

Interested to see how this pans out. Propaganda or educational?

Report: Chinese students forced to manufacture PS4 at Foxconn plant

October 10, 2013

Categories: Business

Samit Sarkar, Polygon

> *Xi'an Technological University students spent two months at the Foxconn plant in Yantai, China, for a work-study program that ran from August to this week. Students from the program told Dongfang Daily that the internship was mandatory — their diploma would be withheld if they didn't participate, and if they attempted to drop out of the program early, they would lose six credits' worth of courses. The students also said they were given tasks outside of their areas of study, and sometimes performed manual labor.*

I blame binge-watching.

1985: Burst and Bloom

October 15, 2013

Categories: Society

1985. Burst of the video game. Bloom of the Millennial. My earliest memory: playing Mega Man 2. More specifically, Mega Man 2's "Bubbleman" stage. This event sparked a fire of imagination, set technological gears in motion, and built a bridge to the future. There was a majesty in that game that could only be delivered through the limitations of technology and connectedness of interactive control. At the early age of three, I experienced embodiment through an on screen character while simultaneously assuming god-like control over his actions. I could control the protagonist and create my own story.

I was in awe of this technology and aware enough to understand its infancy. The more I used it, the more wonder it cultivated. How are games created? How do they make those noises? What would this look like in five, ten, twenty years? Would I be able to live in these worlds? This wonder drew me to the technology industry.

Enamored, I sought video games as a necessity; something as substantial as food and water. This craving was not isolated to me; it shaped an entire generation.

The sounds, visuals, and interactivity provided a pool of imagination. The limitations of early consoles could not provide orchestral arrangements. Instead, repetitious patterns were drilled into our heads. They not only encapsulated the game we were playing, but they opened the world outside to a new soundtrack, creating a wealth of memories that could be tapped into from a few simple chirps. Hearing these primitive arrangements evolve felt like experiencing the birth of music. As hardware progressed, so did the complexity if the music. Repetitive pieces turned into grand and iconic themes, each game re-shaping the idea and importance of video game music.

While on-screen visuals provided a surreal sense of interplay between man and machine, screenshots were paintings. They opened minds to new possibilities. Images of upcoming games fueled the imaginations of would-be players. Gameplay mechanics had to be imagined. Reviews had to be accepted without video proof. Buying power was dictated by sprite design and blocky imagery.

The sprites we commanded (and spent tens-of-hundreds of hours with) became as familiar and important as The Lone Ranger, Bugs Bunny, and Lawrence Welk to the generations prior. From the introduction of idle animations to voice-over and motion-capture, we watched these on-screen characters evolve from blocky 16 x 16 figures to fully realized personalities. 20+ years later, we remain curious about their whereabouts, relevance, and impact on future generations. Life in a machine.

They were more than games in the traditional sense. Point-systems and completion-percentages were only a sliver of the grander experience. The more we practiced and started over from stage 1-1, the more we understood the core of these systems. Gaming taught us to recognize patterns; to harbor patience and solve puzzles. Some individuals would challenge boundaries in an attempt to break games. We could control the sprites better than our parents could. Finally, control over a domain we could call our own. We knew something foreign to most adults. Some even taught their parents how to play. The student was now the master.

Easter eggs, cheat codes, hidden characters, and secret areas were at the forefront of every schoolyard conversation. They sparked rumors and large threads of conversation; the viral video of the time. The

possibility that you may discover something first kept your drive peaked. Discovering in-game mysteries without prior knowledge meant profound, earth-shattering news for friends. Phone calls, bike rides across town, and late night gatherings were the beginnings of web-rings and blogs.

Our deep grasp on game mechanics shaped our understanding for real world systems and industries. We were harnessing a rich understanding for technology exponentially faster than the generations prior. We watched the gaming industry push the boundaries not only of hardware and software performance, but social connectedness. New cultures were birthed. An age where those previously suppressed could now open up and find harmony, respect, and support in like communities. The social structure of these communities flourished with ideas, stories, and education. Technological advancement and waves of new and easy ways for the world to connect sprouted from the minds of "geeks" and "nerds," eventually reaching a critical mass that welcomed everyone to confess and rally around their obsessions. Sudden realization that those who traced stats of organized professional sports were not so different from those that examined code; those that wore body-paint and jerseys to sporting events were not so different from those who constructed elaborate costumes or donned gaming memorabilia for conventions.

From console gaming's genesis, my generation has been in the unique position of watching an entire industry shape culture around the world. At an early age, we were empowered with animated characters and settings that we could control. Our imaginations were able to shape stories larger than "looking for a princess in another castle," filling in holes left by console limitations. Like many media types before it, those born into gaming now simply cannot fathom the excitement experienced while watching consoles and games evolve. We have gone along for a ride, curious about what is next, how to be a part of it, and how we can use it to change the world. The addiction to technological and societal evolution stemming from gaming has spawned a fervor for advancement, simplification, accessibility, and enabling.

This post was inspired by Robert Ashley's *A Life Well Wasted: Episode 3 - Why Game?*

Originally published on TheStarrList.com

Wii U sees estimated 79 percent sales climb in North America

October 16, 2013

Categories: Business

Alex Seedhouse, Nintendo Insider

> *Wedbush Securities estimates for NPD Group's next sales report, indicate that the Wii U has seen an estimated 79 percent increase in sales month-over-month.*

Link moves units.

Chris Grant on Reasons to Invest in PC gaming

October 18, 2013

Categories: Business, Society

Chris Grant, Editor-in-Chief of Polygon, on reasons to invest in PC gaming with the launch of next-gen consoles on the horizon. An incredibly good argument for anyone who cares about art, history, preservation, media, and/or video games.

Begin video at 24:08:

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=z8teBHQ6L8Q&feature=share&t=24m7s

> *The problem for me is that if we are going to consider video games as a viable, meaningful art form, we have got to stop the forced obsolescence of software every five years. It's untenable. We can't keep treating these things as disposable junkets that you play on your new toy and then throw out and get a new toy. These things have merit, they have value over time, they're still important, they're still valuable. We keep listening to two giant companies tell us that they're not and to get a new piece of hardware that plays new games.*
>
> *One of the really cool things about PC gaming is that you have the opportunity to assume some of this responsibility yourself. If your old game doesn't work and it frustrates you, somebody's probably hacked apart an executable that will work. Go look and see all the work people have done to get System Shock 1 to run properly because System Shock 1 is a really important game historically. Especially if you bought it in the past, which I did, being able to play it again now in the context of BioShock and in the context of Dishonored and all of these other games that have sort of been born off of that original philosophy. That's important to me and that is meaningful.*
>
> *As somebody who really feels connected to the history and chronology of games, I just got "last straw" with this new round of consoles which has seemingly, almost flippantly abandoned it's entire history. Sony will kind of coyly say "oh... well... the power of the cloud and Gaiki will do this..." Any request for clarification on how that's going to work is met with silence. I know Microsoft said the same thing but I don't buy it. So for me, some it's about that, it's about having some personal responsibility over what I've purchased, where it goes, what I can expect to do with my purchases, where I can give that money to and I increasingly just didn't want to pump another 200 x $60 a pop into a closed ecosystem that was almost aggressively [pushing obsolescence].*

Note: Prior to this quote, Chris fully acknowledged the difficulties around backwards-compatibility and the ability to simply plug in old consoles to play old games.

How Long Can Video Games Matter?

October 21, 2013

Categories: Art, Business, Society

Mitch Dyer, IGN

> *Furthermore, no game you and I are excited to play right now will continue to sell copies like A Tale of Two Cities. The majority of enjoyable games are disposable. Even the number of brands that could predictably succeed in this capacity is microscopic. Part of this comes from the brand problem, which is that every video game sequel seems to be about doing something better rather than having something to say. They don't really add to the art -- they improve on past mistakes. Games are too often too busy chasing the technology ahead of them that there's little room (or budget) left to chase anything else -- design, emotional engagement, or individuality, for instance.*

"A brave and brilliant article" or "Suddenly, I feel empty"?

Why video games are more Britney Spears and less Pink Floyd

October 22, 2013

Categories: Business, Society

Lorne Lanning, Oddworld CEO, quoted by Polygon

> *"Money, means, and the ideas that figure out how to do it without getting dull and standing on a soap box, which quite frankly nobody wants to listen to, and if they do they will go to documentaries. But as we are seeing, the more audiences realize that deeper content reflecting relevant truths can be more refreshing and engaging, [the more] we see documentary films having greater successes than ever in history. This is reflective of an evolving appetite that more people want more meaningful content and want to walk away from their experiences with more lasting impressions that add 'more value to their lives.'"*

I find it oddly coincidental that two similar arguments on the lasting power of video games were published by two of the largest video game publications on the same day. What is the catalyst?

The bulk of the indies that reach the market are more akin to the early days of gaming. There is much more experimentation; however, indie devs in this evolved market are not making games to turn a profit but express themselves through the means created by gaming forefathers, thus unintentionally shaking gamers out of an empty dark-age before it has time to swallow us whole.

I'm giddy thinking of the ideas and stories Ken Levine could tell without the pressure of sales figures. I can't be the only one who wished BioShock Infinite were simply an exploration game rather than FPS. Alas, shooters sell. Maybe Cyan could bring him in as a consultant on Obduction?

The answer for IGN's Mitch Dyer may lie on the Dark Side of the Moon. However, Toxic is a damn good song.

Why mobile games are so addictive

October 22, 2013

Categories: Design, Health, Psychology

Mark Griffiths, Nottingham Trent University, quoted by Yahoo! News UK

> *Patients recovering from chemotherapy have been shown to need less painkillers if their minds are occupied by games — and the same has been shown to work on children with skin conditions.*

The cognitive side effects of addictive games offer health awesomeness.

How a video game could help children with food allergies

October 25, 2013

Categories: Education, Health

Dave Tach, Polygon

> *Elizabeth McQuaid, a psychologist at Bradley Hasbro Children's Research Center, is overseeing the trial launch of a video game designed to help children with food allergies.*
>
> *McQuaid teamed up with developer Virtually Better to test a web-based game for children 8-12. Researchers hope the software, which puts players in scenes intended to help them learn more about food allergies, symptoms and reaction management, will reduce the risk of allergic reactions.*

Mmmmmm... educational gaming for health... yum :)

Go Right by YouTuber RockyPlanetesimal

October 25, 2013

Categories: Art

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kiePaAHK3jE

On the inside, a beautiful piece about persistence as told through the lives of iconic video game characters. On the outside, a reflection on our memories of early video games and the bonds we formed with these characters. A true testament to the story, animation, art, passion, and love developers pour into games to craft these unique experiences.

With it's brilliant cinematography and direction, I cannot think of a better piece to humanize video games, bringing my reasons for gaming to a whole new level.

Could Xbox One and PlayStation 4 actually fail?

October 28, 2013

Categories: Business

Colin Campbell, Polygon

> *The truer test comes next year when the race begins in earnest. "The two big guys desperately want to beat each other," said Wedbush analyst Michael Pachter. "The race is on to be the first through 10 million."*
>
> *He said that both companies view early adopters as a rich stream of customers for their online subscription models, that work out at about $5 each per consumer per month. A large community of active players is a selling point as well as a profit center.*

Assuming "gamer" referes to an aficionado of gaming culture.

Your's truly, Polygon Comment:

> *I'm just going to lob this out there and say that today's "gamer" prefers mobile and PC over console. Consoles now seem more fixated on "casual" experiences under the guise of "hardcore" (ie. CoD, GTA), taking advantage of the membership cash-cow and annual guarantee (ie. CoD, Madden).*
>
> *Assuming indies traditionally begin on mobile and PC platforms and grow to console if successful, they tend to focus ground-breaking and innovative ideas, albeit at the cost of small sales figures. This is similar to the pre-internet console days of yore.*
>
> *I am going to get eaten alive for this ABSOLUTE generalization but I thought I would entertain the idea.*

Re-thinking this comment, I don't understand why I originally thought it was a revelation that MSFT and Sony aren't after "gamers". Of course they aren't. They want the "casual" masses.

5 Studies That Prove Video Games Are Good For You

November 5, 2013

Categories: Health

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jom8qEl9WHo

So that's why I don't need glasses...

Study: Playing video games can increase brain size

November 5, 2013

Categories: Health

Samit Sarkar reporting for Polygon

> *In order to investigate this, the researchers asked 23 adults with an average age of 24 to play Super Mario 64 for at least half an hour a day, every day for two months. Compared to a control group of individuals who did not play any games during the study, the gamers evinced "significant gray matter increase" in three areas of the brain: the right hippocampal formation, right dorsolateral prefrontal cortex and bilateral cerebellum.*

Two study's on the positive size effects of game in one day?!

Game Play Has No Negative Impact on Kids, UK Study Finds

November 19, 2013

Categories: Health, Psychology

Games and Learning

> *Headed into the study, the authors wanted to study both television and video games, arguing that connections with attention disorders, anger and other problems might be connected to both. Still, researchers wondered if "games may have more powerful effects due to active user engagement, identification with characters and repeated rehearsal and reinforcement."*
>
> ***KEY FINDINGS***
>
> - *Exposure to video games had no effect on behavior, attention or emotional issues.*
> - *Watching 3 or more hours of television at age 5 did lead to a small increase in behavioral problems in youngsters between 5 and 7.*
> - *Neither television nor video games lead to attentional or emotional problems.*
> - *There was no difference between boys and girls in the survey results.*

In my own experience, the participatory nature of video games adds stress, problem solving, and exploratory functions that can enhance one's imagination. Speaking for myself (and hopefully many others), I feel that this medium has helped flesh-out ones creative passions be it storytelling, pattern assessment, communication, and/or technical know-how.

As I am currently writing a book, I have found it easiest to open up a world by envisioning how I would explore a video game. I am able to more effectively envision the world through a first or third person view by relying on the mechanics that have been built into some of my favorite video games. The ability to attach myself to video game characters has had a profound impact on my writing abilities. My book may or may not be very good but the ease of writing it has been nurtured by a lifetime of gaming.

How have you benefitted from gaming?

GameStop global sales hit $2.11 billion, store sales rise 20.5 percent

November 21, 2013

Categories: Business

Alexa Ray Corriea, Polygon

> *New software sales for the quarter increased by 43.1, which the company attributed to the "strong performance" of recently-released games — using Rockstar Games' Grand Theft Auto 5 as its strongest example example. New hardware sales rose 15.3 percent due to sell-through of the Nintendo 2DS and 3DS handhelds. Conversely, pre-owned sales decreased by two percent.*

Keep in mind that Nintendo does not offer hardware sales directly through digital retailer Amazon.com. This also does not reflect sales of next-fen consoles Xbox One or PS4.

High hopes for video game retailers?

'Disney Infinity' to introduce Princesses

November 21, 2013

Categories: Gender

USA Today

> *"Disney Infinity producer John Vignocchi says the Princesses' arrival marks the biggest rollout of toys for the action game since launching in August.*
>
> *'The female characters, especially the Princesses, were among the top requests,' says Vignocchi.*

The House of Mouse brings more girls to gaming.

No girls allowed

December 2, 2013

Categories: Business, Gender

Tracey Lien, Polygon:

> *President of the marketing firm A Squared Group Amy Cotteleer says that marketing is so powerful that it can shape our values and beliefs, and we're often not even aware that it's happening. Coca-Cola's marketing campaigns in the 1920s are the reason why the modern-day image of Santa Claus is a jovial, plump man in a Coca-Cola Red suit. Prior to Coca-Cola, there was no consistent image of Santa. He was often represented as a skinny man who sometimes wore green and sometimes wore brown. So if Coca-Cola could sell us the modern-day Santa, the game industry would not have had much trouble selling the idea that video games are for males.*

Kick off this detailed and gorgeous read explaining why video games are for boys and why that needs to change with this video:

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-CU040Hqbas

Tracey Lien and Polygon, thank you for this amazing feature. Now if you'll excuse me, I think there's something in my eye.

Give8Bit - How To Give While You Game

December 3, 2013

Categories: Charity

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7qyVoAfkAuk

Jude Ower, Playmob CEO:

> *Over the past couple of years, gamers have raised over 80 million dollars for charities that they care about through games that they love to play. Now this is us just getting started and we can do so much more. So we at Playmob have setup Give8Bit, a channel on Youtube where you can find out the latest campaigns to give as you game. Please subscribe and get involved.*

Make a difference while gaming.

Subscribe to Give8Bit on Youtube Follow Give8Bit on Twitter Like Give8Bit on Facebook

PS4 Sells Over 2.1 Million Units Globally

December 3, 2013

Categories: Business

Luke Karmali, IGN

> *Speaking about the global 2.1 million figure, House said, "It's an impressive and record-setting accomplishment for our company and for our industry, and we couldn't have done it without you. I want to personally thank PlayStation fans, both old and new, for your vote of confidence.*

PS4 sells gangbusters.

You could help real-world farmers by playing Cropland Capture

December 3, 2013

Categories: Business, Society

Dave Tach, Polygon:

> *Cropland Capture, a game hosted on the Geo-Wiki Project's website, tasks players with identifying cropland from Google Earth images. Players get points for identifying land and could win an Amazon Kindle, a Samsung Galaxy S4 and more through the game's ongoing tournament. According to a recent tweet from the game's official Twitter account, players have combed more than 300,000 square kilometers of land.*

Crowd-source gaming initiative to find better cropland.

Second gaming ceasefire held for Sandy Hook but skepticism remains

December 5, 2013

Categories: Politics

Tracey Lien, Polygon:

> *The event has also drawn criticism. One of the key issues raised during last year's event was the way in which a "ceasefire" inadvertently created a connection between violent video games and violent actions in the real world. With the media, politicians and various lobbies frequently making that connection on their own, it was seen as fuel for an already problematic image of video games.*
>
> *According to technology and entertainment writer Daniel Nye Griffiths, whose work has appeared in Forbes and Wired UK, while he doesn't doubt that the ceasefire is coming from a sincere place, such an event is tricky for multiple reasons.*

Shooter "ceasefire" sincerity stimulates sticky situation.

If you love games, you should refuse to be called a gamer

December 9, 2013

Categories: Education, Society

Simon Parkin, NewStatesman:

> *Video games are the most profitable medium in the entertainment industry. In the early 1990s Nintendo generated more annual profits than all of the American film studios combined. But despite its size, the medium's audience is often referred to as a homogenous group. Players and commentators talk of the 'gaming community', as if the cross-cultural, socially diverse mass of humans who play video games is somehow uniform in gender, race, age and class. The idiocy of the term is only too clear when applied to other media such as literature (the 'reading community'?), music (the 'listening community'?) or film (the 'observing community'?).*

A delightfully provocative read about the idea of *gaming as a community*. I will also recommend that you swing by GamesAndLearning.org and play through *Gone Home:*

StarCraft 2 player receives the sport's first US athlete visa

December 15, 2013

Categories: eSports, Politics, Society

Tracey Lien, PolygonPolygon

> *Professional StarCraft 2 player from South Korea Kim "ViOLet" Dong Hwan recently became the first person from the eSport to obtain a P-1A visa from the American government, his representatives at Cyber Solutions Agency announced.*

Launching Operation Supply Drop

December 16, 2013

Categories: Charity, Society

Russ Pitts, Polygon:

> *Machuga knows a guy, his Stryker driver in Iraq, who didn't make the transition. He got out of the military in 2005, then spent the next five years trying to reintegrate and failing. He reenlisted, got sent to Afghanistan.*
>
> *"Anybody who's been out of the military has that point in their life where they're kind of floating," Machiga says. "They're just like, they're not happy with civilian life, because there's nothing like the military out there. You find yourself driving past enlistment stations and thinking, 'I should just stop by. I'm not actually going to do it. I'm just going to go inside and see what's going on.' And he fell into that trap."*
>
> *Machuga wanted to send his buddy something to help him pass the time, so he put together a care package of video games. With help from Activision's Dan Amrich, he scraped together a set of Guitar Hero and DJ Hero games and shipped them out as a standard 20x20x20, under 70-pound care package, plenty to keep a soldier occupied. His driver loved it. And it got the other soldiers talking.*
>
> *"Suddenly a dozen guys from his unit start going, 'Hey, this is great, we could use some love too!' I was like, 'Oh shit, what have I started?'" says Machuga. "So I started packing up what was left and sent that as well. That's what snowballed the whole thing."*

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2dGDycidDlw

What helps soldiers? Food? Toiletries? Video Games?

The Altamont Archives

February 4, 2014

Categories: Music

The potential of a small town's music scene realized by a budding Information Age.

> *"Truth be told that growing old is a curse I couldn't wish on the best of my friends." – Steven Hopkins, Everything Everett – How Much*

After entering my late twenties, life feels a little less like a steady stream and more like a rushing river. I often find myself grasping for bits of nostalgia the way one would grasp for anchors in roots and rocks as they are swept away. That's not to say the river is chaotically thrashing me to impending doom or oblivion; it's simply moving me into the unknown faster than ever before. Weeks, months, and years fly by. Time has become my most precious commodity.

A few weeks ago, I decided to revisit an old demo recording from a high school rock band I had once been a member. As I listened back to each Seconds Late track, I found myself revisiting memories of joy, angst, and belonging. Once focused on the horrendous pang of the snare drum and out of sync strumming patterns, I was now honing into the energy and lyrics. These bits of audio were time capsule of an age on the cusp of smartphones and social networks. Messages were still handwritten. Landlines and 56K modems were still a thing.

Feeling nostalgic, I posted a status update to Facebook about revisiting these old memories. After a comment from a close friend and assistance from the greater community, The Altamont Archives were launched.

Central California

To paint the picture for those who have never been to California, it's not all mavericks and movie stars. Those who have lived in the state will tell you of pit between Los Angeles and San Francisco referred to as the Central Valley. Most acknowledge that the biggest things to cultivate this section of the state are cattle, farms, and cattle-farms. Aside from vast plains sprinkled with tiny towns with tiny names, this much is true.

Seconds Late // Seconds Late

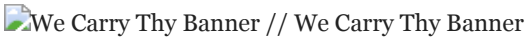
At the heart of this area is a town called Tracy. It is a commuter town fenced in between three freeways, two of which are the most used in the state (5 and 580). Most come to know this town in passing. Some recognize it's sister cities with a bit more enthusiasm (Modesto, Stockton, Livermore, Pleasanton, etc.). It is a city that is oft forgotten by passersby. Despite it's 70,000+ population, it is another spit of land on the way to a greater destination.

There is a mall and a movie theater. The citizens get together on Friday nights for high school football games. There are no buildings taller than three stories. The layout is mainly residential, lending industry to the east and commercial to the west. Though, these details are not unique to Tracy. Many of the neighboring cities to the east share a similar story. Those to the west just over the Altamont Pass have the luxury of cultural run-off from the East Bay and San Francisco.

Music Industry Shift

In the late ’90s, a unique millennial intersection of technology and music sparked a fire within the unassuming towns. A new brand of music was infusing the sounds of post-Nirvana grunge, the desperation and yearning of ’90s adult-contemporary, and passion-fueled punk rock. From New Jeresy to Washington, this sound had already penetrated much of the country. Other than local commercialized record stores and MTV, many of the Central Valley towns had no outside knowledge of this new sound. Unbeknownst to many, it came creeping over the landscape like a tidal wave in the dark.

In those days, the single record store in town charged upwards of $20 for CDs of which buyers only wanted 1 or 2 songs. Most discs were strictly of popular music and if they weren’t, nobody in these small towns had exposure to anything underground. Singles were not available in abundance and for groups of middle-school and high-school kids, $20 for a song was terribly over-priced.


We Carry Thy Banner // We Carry Thy Banner

By 2000, Napster hit with full force. Many were flocking to the Internet to pirate music for free. The initial response to peer-to-peer file sharing had high-school pirates with CD burners collecting $10 per disc loaded with song requests. Those privileged enough to jump on the DSL train early could turnaround a faster rate of customized playlists. At the onset of this trend, popular music was at the forefront. Those few blink-182 and Korn songs from TRL topped the piracy charts. It was not uncommon to stumble on a file named “Blink182 – New Song (unreleased)” only to find a Millencolin or MxPx track hiding inside. It was only a matter of time before these mislabeled tracks and word-of-mouth spread the names of less popular bands to the uneducated masses.

Napster had become the source of music discovery, thusly introducing small town folk to new sounds.

Building a Scene

Before Napster, many of these sounds were not readily accessible to those outside of major cities. And while it didn’t offer curated tracks or albums, it was enough to get peoples’ feet wet. The mix of common teenage culture and a new platform for music discovery had masses of angst-filled teens finding solace in choice punk rock and emo tracks. When one kid had just tripped over NOFX’s The Decline, another had stumbled across a handful of Mineral songs. The beauty of this timing meant that kids who were just beginning to pick up instruments were also getting lost in new music that spoke directly to them. Band’s in lonely parts of the country were singing about heartache, loss, and identity. For many in California’s Central Valley, this hit close to home.

The scene struck Tracy like a meteor. In the blink of an eye, everyone seemed to be in a band and those that didn’t were quick to associate with one. The trend seemed to dictate that everyone who wasn’t associated with an organized sports team had to be associated with the local music scene. These bands would practice in their garages and showcase to friends but lacked a proper venue.

As luck would have it, Les and Ronnie Trott, members of the Good Shepherd Community Church, were quick to notice the rumblings of a music scene and opened The Cellar Club.

> *“The Trotts, who attend the church next door, founded the club after noticing that teens did not have a place to hang out or a venue to play their music. Ronnie Trott used to host a variety show at the West Valley Mall, so The Cellar seemed like a natural progression.*
>
> *‘In Tracy, we saw kids having [to] play out in the street outside of the music store,’ she said.*

> *The couple figured the basement of the house at 1367 Parker Ave. could serve as an appropriate venue." – Jonathan Partridge, Tracy Press, December 14, 2001*

It quickly became evident that The Cellar Club had tapped a rich vein of passion, creativity, and community. It did not take long for the youth of neighboring cities and others in Tracy to hear of the buzz. Xerox copied flyers would circulate around the city, promoting shows at makeshift venues. The lobby of Tracy's Red Dot Recording Studio on 11th opened up while parents, organizations, and bands rented out The American Legion Hall. Bands and kids from miles around flocked to Tracy on Friday evenings to see their friends play, meet like-minds, and discover new bands and songs.


Flyer

At the scene's peak, the weekly decision between which show to attend became a paralyzing dilemma. On several occasions, band members would open at one venue, pack up and bolt to another across town to catch their favorite local band, catch-up with friends at another show, or to see if Holdfast would be debuting a new song. Missing a show altogether was devastating. It meant another week without escape from teenage politics and meeting up with a new found family.

Evolution

The lack of recording equipment and funds meant that Friday night shows were the only way to hear Don't Punch David, swoon over Anna Tarka, or sing-a-long to The Acceptables latest catchy anthem.

For most, recording was expensive and studios were not readily accessible. Many homegrown methods began to pop up. The use of shareware and 4-track recorders made it possible for a new bands to compile a few tracks together, burn a handful of CDs, and sell them for $5 at their next show. With little money and limited access to larger record stores, new music from local bands were highly sought after for fans and bands alike. For fans and friends, songs that were likely only heard once per month during a band's performance could now be replayed in cars, homes, and Walkmen. For most, these songs were more exciting and personal than anything on the radio or available on Napster. They were a means of comfort, pride, and evolution. To small town kids, the notion of a band's potential felt like a portal to a much larger world.


Family Tree // Family Tree

While the Internet was still figuring itself out, the inklings of Do-It-Yourself (DIY) media distribution were there. The birth of Geocities/Angelfire meant that every band could promote their upcoming shows. The lack of social media encouraged a frenzy of repeatedly checking MP3.com for a band's newest recording. While Napster was still present and distributing slices of the larger music industry, the scene's community seemed to nurture the bands in the area with intense and endearing love.

As much as they enjoyed watching their friends (and rivals) play, a careful audience would analyze how others were writing and performing. New techniques and conversations led to seeds of inspiration. At Friday night In-N-Out after-parties, members of the community were quick to share newly discovered music with others in hopes that it would help evolve the scene's sound. Music from The Get Up Kids, Counterfit, Further Seems Forever, Thrice, Thursday, Coheed and Cambria, Elliott and many others became sources of musical and lyrical influence.

At the onset, the scene was mainly comprised of bands that were attributed to some form of punk. A shift from these punk rock roots was splintering into post-hardcore and pop-punk. Members of

defunct bands joined up with others to create local supergroups. Sloppy power-chord punk was being replaced by tricky time signatures and pedal boards. Everything Everett were known to seamlessly move from their slick *Boys of Summer* cover into the brooding, atmospheric, heartbreak powerhouse *Mouse*.

Beyond the Borders

As the scene grew up, it's presence spread from Stockton to San Francisco. Shuffling musicians would lend their talents to other bands in other cities. The slew of untrained musicians now understood their instruments, honed their pop-sensibilites, and delivered energetic and mesmerizing performances. During Routine's (formerly Fixer) sets, audience members had difficulty choosing which highly technical musician to focus on.

As recording became more accessible, bands began to broaden their production technics. Verdu Harding played with layered vocals and programming, offering darker ballads a la Finch and Glassjaw. Holdfast's later recordings featured tight and powerful production while others began investing large amounts of time in learning engineering techniques. Many bands ventured to Turlock to record with Dan Petersen of Fairwell Madison while others set off to a professional studio in Oakland.


Family Tree // Family Tree

Around 2004, a majority of the scenes proprietors had made their way out of the region and set off to college, relocated, or took up adventuring in San Francisco. The technical prowess of Routine eventually parted ways, members breaking off into the American Football-esque Of The Swaying Sort, Counterfit influenced Family Tree, and Nada Surf tinged Lovetaker.

A collection of long-time friends formed Bel-Air Academy toured the country and released the full-length Repeat This Over on Stowaway Records, produced and engineered by Holdfast's Tim Eagerton.

After two self-produced full length albums, members of the defunct Fairwell Madison formed Evaline (formerly known as Holiday). As one of few success stories from the scene, they released two EPs (Postpartum Modesty. A Portrait of Skin, Patterned) and the full-length Woven Material, toured the globe, and played the London iTunes Festival in 2011.

Time/Place

The scene was a product of being grounded in a small town and the birth of digital enabling. It occurred at a unique time in a unique place. Before today's ability for anyone to self-produce audio at a near professional grade, early Internet technologies allowed established garage bands to showcase their scrappy recordings beyond their local fan base. Early webpage providers allowed for promotion of shows, news, and new content to markets that were once out of reach.

With today's technology, a single person can record a professional sounding full-length record, self-distribute, and promote across social media; all without leaving the comfort of their bedroom. In the early '00s, music discovery came in the form of an accidental download of a song that quickly turned into their discography; or a chance encounter with local legend who handed passed on a burned copy of a mysterious album in a dark rainy parking lot; these moments were life changing.

I like to believe that small music communities fostered by the cusp of the Information Age were something special. I like to think that this blip of time in these blips of cities actually mattered and that the bands deserved something bigger. I like to dream of the music they would have created if they were financially support and picked up by labels. I like to reminisce about a time when a local band's new song was the trending conversation at school; a time when the magic of a band's evolution unfolded, quite literally, in front of your eyes. Validation came in the form of agape mouths, awestricken faces, and congratulations at In-N-Out after-parites. Your closest friends, now family, sang your lyrics right back at you.

We built a tiny kingdom; something that never dawned on the eyes of pop culture, yet monumental enough to harbor a culture of its own. People believed in our scene. It was a savior, an adventure, and an identity at a time when most kids, especially those in small towns, didn't have one.

The Altamont Archives are a glimpse into these memories; a time capsule of sorts. A time when community and belonging did not come in the form of followers or likes, but in hugs and real-time praise. The energy of a show could not be broadcast on Instagram or Vine. You had to see it to believe it.

Maybe this post is the rambling of a man who has a hard time letting go, craved for nostalgia as he realizes 10 years suddenly slipped by. Maybe this post will strike a chord for those that played a part in one of the most memorable and sentimental times in his life. Maybe it will spread as a murmur to folk outside of the arena, reigniting memories of similar sacred pastimes. Maybe it will garner some interest from a semi-relevant editorial outlet or tech historians. Maybe it's just a way of reflecting; an opportunity to say, "I was in a band."

Originally published on TheStarrList.com

Available albums:

Bel-Air Academy – *Repeat This Over* (iTunes | Amazon MP3)

Bro Montana – *Defense* (iTunes | Amazon MP3)

Evaline – *Woven Material* (iTunes | Amazon MP3)
Evaline – *Patterned EP* (iTunes | Amazon MP3)
Evaline – P_ostpartum Modesty. A Portrait of Skin EP_ (iTunes | Amazon MP3)

Normal Like You – *Planes Trains & Automobiles* (iTunes | Amazon MP3)
Normal Like You – *The Worst of Many Flaws EP* (iTunes | Amazon MP3)
Normal Like You – *Your Reminder* (iTunes | Amazon MP3)

We Carry Thy Banner – *We Carry Thy Banner* (iTunes | Amazon MP3)

On Reading

February 24, 2014

Categories: General

Text has always challenged me. Regardless of copyright date, I look at books as insurmountable volumes rooted in earth's history, just as permanent and timeless as a mountain or sea. Even the simplest publications feel as if they have always existed, their authors fables to the present day.

And yet, I had always felt a strange desire to write my own novel; to join the ranks of the immortal mystics, scholars and dreamers before me; to create art in a timeless medium.

I grew up in a world that had just given birth to the video game; whose culture was firmly rooted in television soaps, sitcoms and late night specials; on the cusp of harnessnessing the Internet. It was easy to skirt around the written word with spoon-fed visuals and peer-less interactivity. The attention and focus required to unfold a 40-hour story could be easily condensed into a relatively similiar experience of a 2-hour film so why waste my time. With quick summaries from literary classmates and short prayers that a pop quiz wasn't in my near future, evading grade-school required reading was easy enough.

And then I discovered music. I joined a high-school punk band, and discovered vast amounts of angst fueled lyrics that I quickly paralleled to poetry. I found a connection to the sharp medium with content that could be as dense as a novel yet consumed quicker than a 30-minute televised drama. I toiled over the deeper meanings found in liner-notes and poems. I fell in love with the tiny format, incorporating it into my own lyrics.

This discovery sent me on a journey through college, attempting to challenge even the most admired poetry with lyrics from underground bands. Using this as fuel, I entered college English 101 with the assignment to write a short 5-10 page fiction. I had never attempted this sort of challenge before. I had never even focused the slightest bit of attention on the short-story format. After presenting my completed work (a piece judging myself through the eyes of a close friend), my professor planted the idea that I should pursue creative writing. I took the notion with a grain of salt and continued to focus on music, film and political science.

During the remainder of my college tenure, I realized that I would get lost in writing long-winded reports about Cuba's standing with the US, the impact of international gangs or research on comparative politics but hated reading the material. While I couldn't help but feel I was beginning to miss details by solely relying on lectures, cliff-notes and chapter summaries, I still could not bring myself to focus on the dense works in textbooks or even highly praised fiction.

Was it A.D.H.D.? Had the age of electronic media ruined my ability to focus? Little thoughts like these would trickle into my consciousness. While, others found solace in the great works of Tolkien and Vonnegut, I couldn't focus on Harry Potter.

Then I found The Egg; a short story so profound I trembled to my core. Immediately after the read, the harsh reality of how much I had missed by avoiding the written word came like a rushing tidal wave. Though reluctant, I decided to set off on a journey for beauty in a world built with text.

Like many, I had fallen in love with the Peter Jackson's adaptation of *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy. With such respect for the films, I felt a duty to read the source material. After completing *The*

Fellowship of the Ring, I noticed a change in my own vocabulary. Somehow, Tolkien's words had soaked into my unconscious and allowed me to produce sentences and convincing arguments with gravitas and ease. The impact of reading had become prevalent in my own nature.

I continued hesitating to dive into novels the same way I would dive into a video games of the same length; a realization that left me unable to argue that pouring 20+ hours into any given story was a waste. On top of this, there was a notion that writing was a primitive method of storytelling made better by music, film and video games. Yet, a splinter in my mind told me that there was a single thread that ran though all of these mediums; something that enabled the existence of sheet music, screenplays and punched tape.

The answser was paper. Paper has been a generational through-line for the invention of nearly all forms of art. This was the notion that would propel me to commit to the written word.

Thus, my exploration began. I needed to know how a novelist could invest weeks, months or years into a single piece of work. Just as my technical support training had taught me the inter-workings of computers, I needed to understand the inter-workings of story structure, character development and prose.

I decided enough was enough. If I wanted to understand this medium and conquer my Everest, I needed to write a novel. November 2013 was growing close. I decided to take on the NaNoWriMo challenge.

Since completing the challenge, I have had a much larger appreciation for the written word. That is to say I am beginning to understand the written word at both mechanical and artistic levels. I clamor at the chance to start a new book often times before I finish the last.

Yet, like the scar left on Frodo from the Morgul-blade, there is still a lingering pain in reading. I have not completely tackled the fear that there is simply not enough time to read; that too many profound novels will be left void of my awareness or time before my death that there is simply no point to start reading the wrong ones now.

I love to write. Often times, I dream about the idea of writing for a living. I used to be deterred by the notion that because I was never a reader, I will never be a writer. I now challenge this notion. I offer that it was not until I decided to write that I learned to read. Now that I have learned to read, I hope to learn to write.

Next up: On Writing by Stephen King.

Originally posted on Medium.com

Save developers and you will save your soul

March 13, 2014

Categories: Business

- 130 layoffs, Nintendo (Eurogamer, 6/6/14)
- 37 layoffs, Harmonix (Polygon, 5/29/14)
- 20% of staff across development and marketing, Trendy Entertainment (GamesIndustry International, 5/21/14)
- 16 layoffs, Rare (IGN, 5/19/14)
- [undisclosed] layoffs, PopCap (Polygon, 3/13/14)
- 700 layoffs, Disney Interactive (Joystiq, 3/6/14)
- 27 layoffs, Eidos (Joystiq, 3/4/14)
- [undisclosed] layoffs, Sony Santa Monica (Joystiq, 2/27/14)
- 70 layoffs, Irrational Games (Joystiq, 2/18/14)
- 12 layoffs, Eutechnyx (Joystiq, 2/18/14)
- [undisclosed] layoffs, Ghost Games (Joystiq, 2/1/14)
- [undisclosed] layoffs, EA Salt Lake (Joystiq, 1/30/14)
- 3423+ industry layoffs from 1/7/13 - 10/29/13 (GameJobWatch.com)

In a discussion on IGN's Game Scoop!, Daemon Hatfield, Greg Miller, Justin Davis, and Brian Altano discussed the Sony Santa Monica layoffs and the ongoing (and seemingly permanent) "ramp up / layoff" structure of AAA studios. During this discussion, the panel made comments around the need for the video game industry to unionize and operate in similar fashion to the film industry:

> ***Daemon Hatfield**: "I wonder if the video game industry should be more like the movie industry. You have a crew that works on a movie and when the movie is done, they go on to their next project. They are not full-time employees."*
>
> ***Greg Miller**: "Do you think as far as unionizing?"*
>
> *DH, Justin Davis, and Brian Altano confirm and agree.*
>
> ***DH**: "You have a director that runs a movie, he brings on his crew, they make the game..."*
>
> ***JD**: "You assemble a "dream team" for each project. A director has certain DPs and other key positions [and] likes to collaborate with the same people over and over. Presumably all of those people that are one step down also have people they like and they bring their whole crew with them. You get the one guy and then you get his crew."*
>
> ***GM**: "I guess that kind of already happens right?"*
>
> ***BA**: "Sort of."*
>
> ***JD**: "It happens a little bit but the issue is that it disrupts people's insurance and things like that. If there was a union, the equivalent of a SAG card or something, you could just move from project to project. In my opinion (and I haven't done a tremendous amount of reach on this), but on the surface it seems like something that would be healthy for this business."*

While, many devs may benefit from negotiated salaries, working conditions, hours, and insurance coverage, further research into unions does not seem to offer a terrible amount of protection from

layoffs. Nor does it appear that the film industry works this way.

According to Lawyers.com, how a union benefits an employee during a layoff is largely dependent on a collective bargaining agreement (CBA). In short, layoffs of union employees are usually handled on a measure of seniority. The source also goes on to mention the benefits of The Worker Adjustment & Retraining Notification Act (WARN):

> *Generally, WARN requires employers with 100 or more workers to give you 60 days' advance notice of some closings and "mass layoffs." A closing can mean the shut-down of a plant or facility. "Mass layoff" has very specific meanings, but basically it means that a substantial number of workers are being laid off for more than six months. -Lawyers.com*

Systems such as WARN would appear to be very valuable for developers in the wake of the seemingly immediate purge of Irrational and Sony Santa Monica employees.

There is a looming fear that if the industry continues at this pace, great artists, programmers, engineers, writers, and the like will be swayed away from from the games industry, potentially diminishing the quality of games released. There is no doubt in my mind that the allure of working on a video game will continue to attract skilled creatives; however, lengthy tenure is sure to wane.

Some will argue that AAA isn't for everyone and indie development is on the rise. While I agree, many of the skills possessed by indie devs were likely gained from experience at larger studios.

I have never been a developer, part of union, or involved in the film industry. I would appreciate any and all correction of the above information from those with experience.

Should video game developers unionize? Does the film industry actually work in this manner? Does a union offer more protection from layoffs than mentioned above? What is your solution to the state of video game development? Are things fine the way they are?

Monument Valley - A Review

April 6, 2014

Categories: Review

The beauty of brevity. The pleasure of paradox.



Ten puzzles. Ten gorgeous, mind-bending, paradoxical puzzles. This is a video game you will complete. In fact, Monument Valley may the first video game many will complete. This is by design.

> *"With so many games, people never see the end, because there's so many hours of gameplay, we wanted to make a game where you see the whole thing." - Dan Gray, Monument Valley Executive Producer in an interview with Polygon*

As a child, completing a game was a triumph. This was not due to lack time, rather heightened difficulty. Personally, my choice in games was largely based on franchise rather than quality. In turn, this provided me with a library of poorly designed "classics" such as Sonic The Hedgehog and Battletoads. Hours were spent replaying games from Stage 1-1 on to the point where I was forced to power down the console. Check points were few and far between. Save files were non-existent. When asking a video game funding parent if their child had completed any, you'd be hard pressed to receive a positive answer.

I wouldn't be surprised if this notion has persuaded many audiences away from video games entirely. If they cannot be finished, what is the point?

Now in my late-20s, working 10-12 hours per day, fitting in crucial exercise for a metabolism that seems all but lost, weekends spent running errands that have stacked up, and nurturing a relationship with my soon-to-be wife, I find very little free time to invest in my love for gaming. The minute-to-minute time I do find is spent reading pieces on Polygon or IGN, sharing these with the greater social media landscape. Echoed in Ben Kuchera's post "Parenthood makes gaming better by making time your most precious resource," the value of time skyrockets as we age. The pastimes of yesteryear begin to seem wasteful, yet we strive to retain a connection to our childhood identity. After all, it is the foundation of our dreams. It is who we are and where we are headed.

Since playing Final Fantasy X (recently remastered for PS3 and PSVita) in high school, I have searched for games with rich story. Until the rise of indies, these only seemed attainable through 15-40 hour bouts of character and world building, effectively turning a game into an interactive novel. Fitting one of these epics into my day-to-day has become a near impossible feat.

This is where Monument Valley succeeds. Piling mass amounts of beautiful art and ambitious puzzle design into a bite sized experience is the video game equivalent of a decadent cake. Too much is overbearing. Not enough is unsatisfying. There is a balance.

Monument Valley immediately finds it's footing through a rich color palette, a soothing soundtrack, and delicate animation. The player understands this world and its inhabitants. The story is used as a mysterious additive that comes secondary to exploring the gorgeous worlds built on paradoxical M. C. Esher design.

Puzzle solving through the discovery of paradox makes the player feel empowered and unstoppable. The experience of breaking illogical boundaries through new perspectives gives players the opportunity to live out their fantasies; it offers a sensation of seeing The Matrix or experiencing the paradox of Inception first-hand.

As the game progresses, the solutions to impossible geometry become more and more difficult to discover. It was not uncommon for me to consciously forget my knowledge of the real world and instead fall back on memories of mazes and Puzzlemania books of my youth. As the difficulty builds, the frustration of adulthood becomes more apparent. Our desire to know how things work is challenged to near breaking point. Even those with a basic understanding of code, animation, and design will scratch their heads and ask of the developers, "how did they do that?" Somehow, the player is able to move the on-screen character through paths that did not previously exist until viewing the vertical world from a different angle. Genius.

It seems the urgency for time has permeated the minds of the developers at ustwo. Monument Valley's 2-3 hour play-through is the perfect amount of that decadent cake. The experience of Monument Valley is sure to please both the hardcore gamer and casual audiences alike. In fact, it is the perfect example of the importance of short and sweet, possibly introducing these polarizing audiences to a new approach in game design as seen in Journey, The Room, or EDGE. And like that decadent cake, Monument Valley's length, design, and puzzles are mesmerizing enough to feel satisfied yet haunting enough to warrant constant craving. If DLC is abound, sign me up.

Monument Valley is available exclusively on iOS (iTunes)

Originally published on TheStarrList.com

Juxtaposition in Video Game Commercials

April 8, 2014

Categories: Business, Music

Textbook Tarantino or tired trope?

I recently re-entered the world of *BioShock's* Rapture by means of *BioShock: Infinite's Burial At Sea* DLC. As I moved about the underwater city, full of the Gatsby-esque architectural stylings of Frank Lloyd Wright, I heard familiar sounds from the 20s-40s cascade through the setting.

At first, these genuinely warm pieces lulled me into a comfort juxtaposed against what eventually becomes a dark and grotesque atmosphere. Though, after roughly an hour, the presence of the pieces became more noticeable than they had seemed in my first play-through of the original *BioShock*. I pawned this off to the Billie Holiday Pandora station I've practically had on loop since that original play-through.

However, I began to wonder if the use of happy/soothing/serene/moving music juxtaposed against aggressive and bleak circumstances may be overstaying it's welcome. Just as quickly as I had decided to push this notion out of my mind, I heard news of the new *Wolfenstein: The New Order* trailer making use of Martha and The Vandellas hit "Nowhere to Run." While the song my not be strewn throughout the entirety of the trailer, it made me wonder if my initial inkling was correct.

I have decided to compile a list of many video game commercials that take advantage of this marketing approach, starting with *Super Smash Bros.* in 1999. This is likely nowhere near a complete list, merely an example of a marketing technique that is becoming less and less subtle.

Is this approach still effective or tired?

Super Smash Bros. (1999)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K783SDTBKmg

Song: The Turtles - *Happy Together*
iTunes | Amazon MP3

Black (2005)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TplY6-UVPqc

Song: Giuseppe Verdi - *La Traviata: Noi Siamo Zingarelle*
iTunes | Amazon MP3

Gears of War (2006)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ccWrbGEFgI8

Song: Gary Jules - *Mad World (feat. Michael Andrews)*
iTunes | Amazon MP3

BioShock (2007)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dTyntbnSC_0

Song: Bobby Darin - *Beyond the Sea*
iTunes | Amazon Mp3

Dante's Inferno (2010)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9rbeAGdYk_0

Song: Bill Withers - *Ain't No Sunshine*
iTunes | Amazon MP3

Playstation 4: Perfect Day (2013)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=s0d9d-cdxhk

Song: Lou Reed - *Perfect Day*
iTunes | Amazon Mp3

Titanfall: Life is Better With a Titan (2014)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YGtMrF3cvZE

Song: Robbie Williams & Jonathan Wilkes - *Me and My Shadow*
iTunes | Amazon Mp3

PS4: Sharing Means Caring (Destiny) (2014)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5ed9e7yJKxY

Song: Josh Daughtery - Sharing Means Caring

PS4: Sharing Means Caring (Watch Dogs) (2014)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6SGtVryq8gw

Song: Josh Daughtery - Sharing Means Caring

Wolfenstein: The New Order (2014)

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dwjKMjIE1rs

Song (Original): Martha and The Vandellas - *Nowhere to Run*
iTunes | Amazon MP3

UPDATE: Thanks to Bob Mackey of Retronauts for the "Sharing Means Caring" recommendations.

Originally published on TheStarrList.com

Humanity in Hearthstone

April 17, 2014

Categories: Gender

How Blizzard is changing the diversity game.

It is an understatement to say that diversity in gaming has become a hot topic as of late. Themes of sexuality, racial prominence, and gender depiction are now a hotbed for passionate discussion across developer, journalist, and player communities.

From 2012 to 2013, the number of games showcased at E3 featuring a playable female protagonist rose from 2% to 6%. Reluctance to include the theme of sexuality is being countered more frequently by games such as *Gone Home*, *The Last of Us*, and *Mass Effect*. This is clear evidence that players are yearning for character dynamic and identity in their games. Video games are a medium that exudes immersion more than any other, and in turn becomes the perfect platform for sympathetic and relatable storytelling.

On April 16, 2014, Blizzard Entertainment released their latest foray *Hearthstone: Heroes of Warcraft* to the iPad. As a free-to-play (F2P) digital collectible card game (CCG) built by a AAA developer that prides itself on the promise of polish with a highly reputable back-catalog, it is an extremely inviting and sure to be incredibly popular download. From testing with a PC/Mac open-bata to trickling the iOS version out to Australia, New Zealand, and Canada prior to world-wide launch, Blizzard was sure this game would be a massive hit.

At the news of Hearthstone for iPad's launch, I was extremely excited to see what the buzz was about. After rave reviews across the industry, I could not wait to invest in this new Blizzard title that seemed perfectly suited for the tablet platform. Upon launching the game, I assumed I would be given the opportunity to select/create a character and possibly build a deck. Thankfully, I was wrong.

Ultimately, Hearthstone does not include a single protagonist. From Orcs to Elves, Druids to Barbarians, players are eventually offered the chance to unlock a collection of Heroes to chose from. Many veteran CCG players will understand this at the onset. What they may not realize is that they will be forced to begin their Hearthstone experience in a tutorial as Human Mage, Jaina Proudmoore. A female.

This tutorial consists of six 'missions,' each introducing details about the game's mechanics and subtleties. Each 'mission' sets the protagonist Jaina against an eccentric opponent, throwing out comical comments that unfold their caricature against a backdrop of the colorful and cartoony tones of the Warcraft universe. Jaina faces her six opponents in the following order:

- *Hogger* – Male, Gnoll Barbarian
- *Hemet Nesingwary* – Male, Dwarf Hunter
- *King Mukla* – Male, Gorilla
- *Lorewalker Cho* – Male, Pandaren
- *Millhouse Manastorm* – Male, Gnome Mage
- *Illidan Stormrage* – Male, Demon / Night Elf Hunter

Six males versus one female. This alone is a powerful statement that will likely slip into the unconscious if not willingly observed.

Sex aside, characters banter back and forth throughout matches. Each foe's optimistic attitude is met with Jaina's cautious yet powerful tone. The addition of voice-acting helps build a bond between player and protagonist. Like reading through Katniss Everdeen's struggles in *The Hunger Games*, it is nearly impossible not to build a trusting connection with Jaina, rooting for her to defeat each of the tutorial's quirky baddies.

The initial tutorial took me roughly one hour to complete. Once finished, I felt an attachment to Jaina. Not only had we defeated six opposing (male) Heroes without fail together, we had conquered the powerhouse that is Illidan Stormrage even though the game told us we couldn't. (A comical, clever and original design choice)

While Jaina and I must spend more time together in order to unlock additional playable Heroes and decks, I am not racing to change protagonists. This tutorial has certainly bonded me to Jaina and is likely to do the same for most players: young and old, male and female.

As subtle and simple as it may appear, Blizzard has made a bold move as a AAA developer in building a tutorial showcasing a powerful female protagonist against six male rivals. Forcing hardcore veterans and casual novices to learn from, protect, and assist a female protagonist in what has the potential to become the largest cross-platform game is a great leap for the cause of diversity in gaming; however, the job is far from done.

Hearthstone: Heroes of Warcraft is currently available for PC, Mac and iPad.

Originally published on TheStarrList.com

How video games can change the world, one child at a time

April 24, 2014

Categories: Education

Erin Hoffman, lead systems designer at GlassLab:

> *Learning is not broken. But testing is pretty broken. The way that we measure learning has been pretty broken.*
>
> *A lot of game developers are parents now, and they're starting to see their kids learn. They're starting to see what their kids are encountering in the education system. The education system is starting to realize, we feel like we're competing with this barrage of entertainment that's around kids, nonstop, all the time. I think initially that was shocking to them. TV is the enemy. Heavy metal is the enemy. Video games are the enemy. They're starting to ask, what if we could harness that instead of making it the enemy? So it's actually a parallel maturation. Both the education system is maturing into not seeing video games as the enemy, and game developers are maturing into seeing that there are things we can do with games other than just pure entertainment.*

Due to their highly addictive and engaging qualities, I've always felt that video games have "magical" potential to foster critical thinking and teach skills on a profound level. The ability to quantify various attributes over simple interactions has an insane amount of potential. (ie. how long does a player's finger hover over a particular object, how many Hearthstone cards did they analyze before making a play, etc.)

I recommend reading Sir Ken Robinson's "The Element" for more on standardization's inability to encourage an individual's potential. Similar to GlassLab, take a look at Knack.

59% of Americans play video games

April 27, 2014

Categories: Culture

Owen S. Good of Polygon on the Entertainment Software Association (ESA) 2014 Survey:

> *Other questions asked of the survey is whether parents view video games to be a positive part of their child's life; a majority — 56 percent — said yes, though some could view the figure as low given the nature of the question.*

I'd say the 56% is positive and more than likely an upward trend seeing that the average gamer age is now 31. Most of today's parents of 0~10 year-olds grew up with games. I believe they would likely state that games were a positive influence on their lives.

Erin Hoffman, Lead Game Designer at GlassLab Games on how commercial games can engage players in social causes:

> *Computers and video games have a history of teaching technology skills just by being the way they are, so to be able to get them into classrooms is a very powerful thing. I think you can make the argument that the new SimCity is the most sophisticated toy that's ever been developed, and it's just mesmerizing to look at and it's very real and empowering.*

I'd like to think this sentiment is shared by adults who grew up with video games.

Mariothon

May 3, 2014

Categories: Gamification

A Mario Kart running app.

Recently, Jane McGonigal's "Reality Is Broken" has encouraged me to spend a lot of time pondering what it would be like to be a game designer; constantly considering the artful blend of psychology and technology and its impact on the entertainment, fitness and education industries.

> *"ACHIEVEMENT UNLOCKED: wanted to break 6 mins in a mile time trial on the track; ran 5:45 and had more in the tank. #GeeksinSneaks" - Christian Spicer, @spicer*

#GeeksinSneaks

While on a jog with the gamified Nike+ Running app, I contemplated this hashtag. Aside from the Geeks in Sneaks meet up group and loads of gamified fitness apps (Wii Fit; Zombies, Run; Kinect Sports Rivals, etc.), I wondered if something more could be done to encourage those identified with the geek community to promote fitness regimes.

Initially, I had the lofty idea of organizing a crowd-funded #GeeksinSneaks race (5K, 10K, half/full marathon) full of cosplay, video game prizes and exclusive comics and geek apparel/memorabilia. If this idea were to draw a big enough crowd, its scale would limit the event to happening at fixed times in fixed areas. It may not be enough to encourage constant activity.

Then I thought about the Nike+ Running app. I am able to use this app on my own time. Day or night, weekday or weekend. While I appreciate the app's gamification elements, they have now worn off to some degree; however, they were enough to get a jogging regime to stick. I now use the app simply as a fitness tracker. I wondered, "is there another way make running a gamified experience and broadcast it to a massive audience?"

Then it hit me.

Nintendo has repeatedly stated that they have a renewed focus on the smartphone ecosystem and health. They also plan to release Mario Kart 8, a beloved franchise, on May 30th. While real-life Mario Kart already exists, I was unable to find Mario Kart adapted into a running game. What if Nintendo were to release a gamified smartphone running app with the mechanics of Mario Kart built in. Lets call it "*Mariothon*."

Mariothon

In Mariothon, players are able to set up a race with up to say four runners. Each player is required to where headphones with an attached button-mic to hear in game alerts and trigger events. At certain distances, players are awarded items (simulating Mario Kart's mystery boxes) that they can use at their leisure by clicking the button on their headphones.

For example, at a quarter mile, a runner earns a lightning bolt. Once used, an in-game alert informs all other runners in the game to walk until the effect wears off. Another variation might add time to

the paces of the competing runners. A banana peel might be used as a surprise attack when another runner crosses a certain geo-fence. Blue shells would have a direct impact on the leader, forcing them to stop dead in their tracks or pausing their “distance ran” meter. First to a specific distance wins!

Obviously, not every run will users want to incorporate the game element. In the event of solo runs, the app could serve as a simple run tracker with many of the same achievements offered in the Nike+ Running app. Cross-brand incentives could also award solo runs. Besting a 7-minute-mile or completing a 10K could unlock characters or tracks in Mario Kart or other console-based Nintendo games. (similar to Hearthstone’s unlockable WoW mount)

As a non-developer, I have no idea if linking players and dropping geo-fenced items is a possibility. I also understand that the initial development of this app would certainly be a huge undertaking. While this would join the many gamified fitness apps on the market, the Nintendo and Mario Kart branding may be enough for it to stick with a larger audience.

Any feedback would be greatly appreciated. Is this something that would interest you? Does this already exist? Has fitness gamification worked for you? If so, what fitness apps are you utilizing and how are they helping?

Originally published on TheStarrList.com

Mobile is burning, and free-to-play binds the hands of devs who want to help

May 9, 2014

Categories: Business

Barry Meade of Fireproof Games writing for Polygon:

> *In 2013 mobile games made over $10 billion globally and allegedly this is great. $10 billion sounds a lot, it is a lot, but the makers of Candy Crush alone took almost $2 billion. Throw in the top ten and there's most of your games market gone; hoovered up by ten cute grinding games that are clones of each other. Any remaining change from that money is scraped off the table and scattered across a games industry trying to service a billion devices.*
>
> *A 2 percent "engaged' audience does not seem towering in achievement for a creative industry that looks to draw its players into new experiences. We're living in a world where Netflix's content inspires hysteria in grown adults, so is mobile gaming really in the same league when 98 percent of its gamers spend more on pencil sharpeners than games made by our billion-dollar leaders?*

In my experience, *The Room* sparks the same water-cooler conversations for non-gamers that *Myst* did. It appears *Monument Valley* is doing the same, as experienced with my non-gaming colleagues. I think "the binge" has hindered the TV water-cooler conversation now that everyone is on their own schedule. Delivery of challenging and original yet "polished" and "possible" experiences can bring back the general audience gaming conversations we had on the playground.

Re: Video games, art and noise

May 12, 2014

Categories: Art

Finding a voice between pop and counter-culture.

4+ years ago, when I first launched TheStarrList.com as a Tumblr blog, I sought to explain underground and often dismissed media to the average reader. I donned the blog's subtitle with "Making Sense of the Media Around You" and filled it with weekly album reviews, DVD to Blu-ray comparisons, and "best of" lists.

I poured my energy into a Top 100 Albums of the 2000s post filled with 100 mini album reviews; ripped and analyzed The Sound of Music Blu-ray vs. DVD, projecting the comparison to an audience more concerned with post-hardcore music and Star Wars (though, I compared that too). There were even experiments with video game reviews from Uncharted 3 to Limbo and micro-movie reviews during Oscar season.

In 2012, I switched from Tumblr to WordPress format to focus on longer-form writing with a bit more structure and professionalism. To my surprise, the blog saw incredible growth, at least by my standards. TheStarrList.com was now a much richer and dynamic experience.

Two years later, I find myself wondering what its primary theme is as it's beginning to feel like a catch-all for my scattered thoughts.

Art and Noise

Required reading: Video games, art and noise | The Guardian

> *"It matters to me that on Monday morning, seven million Today listeners heard games being dismissed on the basis of a tiny minority of the annual output. It matters how consensus develops around new artistic forms." – Keith Stuart, The Guardian*

When I woke to The Gaurdian's "Video games, art and noise" by Keith Stuart, a lightbulb switched on. Stuart's arguments about loud yet uninformed "minority output" broadcasting to millions, discounting entire mediums and genres had my memory zipping back to my Tumblr blog.

Even with grand-scale digital publishing and hashtag/retweet filtration, there still remains a large population not savvy to the cultural trends of millennials and their collective, connected views of technology's impression on art. Suddenly it became clear why I had written pieces on Blu-ray remasters of classic films and a defensive for Skrillex.

In my line of work, a sliver of my time is spent curating niche content and broadcasting it to a large audience. Though popular consensus informs us that heavy-hitters will continue to rise to the top, I find more validity in the little guy. Generations will always include masses discounting change and evolution (queue Patton Oswalt on home birth), unwilling to invest the time and effort to understand what makes WhatsApp a worthy investment or dismissing replay rules in professional sports. Cultural relevance is the reason I continue to educate myself on topics I don't fully understand (and hopefully never will). I fear the day I will fail to understand my children.

> *"You would never debate the artistic potential of cinema by focusing solely on mainstream Hollywood films." – Keith Stuart, The Guardian*

In defense of Sarah Kent, I understand backlash when taking a hard stance on something I have either strong bias for and/or ignorance of. (See my discourse with @ryanruppe regarding Salon writer Jeff Bryant's "Common Core propaganda fails") Hopefully Keith's piece sparks re-evaluation of video games as art; with outreach to millions, simply writing-off an entire medium/stance/genre is extremely damaging. Raise questions. Avoid absolutes.

My Voice

All told, when I read Keith's piece, I found my voice. I simultaneously felt his passion for a discounted and controversial medium that is globally enjoyed by hundreds of millions (potentially billions) and understood why I feel the need to disperse nuggets of pop culture into pieces about demographically discounted art. (Queue Glenn Close's "Devil Wears Prada" cerulean sweater monologue)

> *"The education system is starting to realize, we feel like we're competing with this barrage of entertainment that's around kids, nonstop, all the time. I think initially that was shocking to them. TV is the enemy. Heavy metal is the enemy. Video games are the enemy. They're starting to ask, what if we could harness that instead of making it the enemy? So it's actually a parallel maturation." - Erin Hoffman, GlassLab*

It should go without saying that today's technology is ripe to educate on topics previously left abandoned in generational gaps succinctly. However, we are shown time and time again that there is need to challenge generational qualms and societal push-back. It is these generational gaps that keep me finely tuned to the video game industry and passionate about explaining its impact and relevance in the pop culture space.

At an early age, unlike sports or academics, I learn that I could best my parents at video games. It was a participatory and wondrous medium imbued with both technology and art that empowered me to level adult vs. child, teacher vs. student playing field. With that, I sign off referencing links to my reviews and opinions on games that may have been overlooked by the larger audience yet are critical to popular culture; the solitary theme that runs through my blog.

Thanks to Keith for opening my eyes to my writing through-line.

Humanity in Hearthstone: How Blizzard is changing the diversity game.

Monument Valley – A Review: The beauty of brevity. The pleasure of paradox.

1985: Burst and Bloom (formerly "Why Game?"): An ode to the impact of early console gaming.

Journey: 1 Year Later: Celebrating this generation's most important work of art.

Originally posted on TheStarrList.com

Watch Dogs special editions total $1,240, but do you really need that hat?

May 14, 2014

Categories: Business

Alexa Ray Corriea, Polygon:

> *If you were to purchase every special edition available for Ubisoft's open-world adventure Watch Dogs, you would spend just over $1,240.*
>
> *This includes all region-exclusive editions, such as Australia and New Zealand's ANZ Special Edition and the Europe, Australia and Asia-only Vigilante Edition, the only version that offers a wearable replica of protagonist Aiden Pierce's hat. You come away with 10 copies of the game — and don't forget about the season pass. Of course, you wouldn't be able to play every version because of console region-locking.*

While it's not quite the same discussion, this quote is relevant to the tax complicated purchasing strategies can have on both the consumer and business:

Mike Monteiro on the Amazon/Comixology model, aired on The Talk Show, ep. 80: Beats by Tim

> *What you never want to do with an addict, and I think comics readers are addicts, is show them a total. I would sit there at night just hitting buy, buy, buy, buy. So I'm just buying comics an issue at a time. Now, I go to the website and I get to see a total. 'Holy shit! I'm spending $35 on comics today. That's really a lot of money.' Then all of the sudden I'm thinking, 'well… I'm certainly not going to try this new one I've never heard of before. It might suck and I want to get out of hear under $20.'*

Rare is evaluating what to do after Kinect, says Phil Spencer

May 16, 2014

Categories: Business

Emily Gera, Polygon:

> *Xbox head Phil Spencer confirms Microsoft is working closely with U.K. developer Rare to evaluate the studio's future now that Kinect peripherals are optional for Xbox One systems, OXM reports.*
>
> *Despite the studio's history developing GoldenEye 007 and Donkey Kong Country, Rare was retooled as a flagship Kinect studio, releasing its first Kinect project Kinect Sports in 2010. Rare continued with this franchise, releasing Kinect Sports: Season Two and Kinect Sports Rivals.*

In May of 2013, following the news that Microsoft will be breathing new life into a 'historic' Rare franchise (turned out to be Killer Instinct), I wrote a piece about Microsoft's need to invest in child-friendly colorful characters and how Rare could pull it off:

Xbox One: Swinging for the Franchise Fences with Rare IP?

Seeing as the price-drop will likely draw more appeal from parents, Microsoft should invest in the children's market with Rare IP to set itself apart from PS4 and, dare I say it, Wii U.

Ben Kuchera on sex in Wolfenstein

May 20, 2014

Categories: Sexuality

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *Sex in games is almost exclusively used to give players, who are assumed to be male, something to ogle at between blood baths. The last place I expected a more realistic, and often touching, view of sex was the latest Wolfenstein game.*

Layoffs hit Rare

May 20, 2014

Categories: Business

Wesley Yin-Poole, Eurogamer:

> *While Microsoft did not confirm how many people had been let go, Eurogamer understands the number is around 16, a figure one source said was made up of some software staff, but mainly design and project managers. Kinect Sports Rivals was a 150 person project.*

A Microsoft spokesperson issued Eurogamer the following statement:

> *At Xbox, our goal is to constantly create new fun, social and interactive entertainment experiences. As part of Rare's commitment to this goal, we have made a decision to change our development process and methodology at Rare to best support our future projects, this has led to us reviewing the skills and the makeup of our development teams in our business.*
>
> *Rare continues to invest in our people and future projects.*

This news comes on the heels of Rare re-evaluating their direction after Microsoft's decision to offer Kinect-less Xbox One units. My thoughts to those let go. Layoffs list updated.

Jordan Shapiro on the current reading habits of children

May 21, 2014

Categories: Culture, Education

Jordan Shapiro writing for Forbes:

> *Of course, it is easier to frame the story as paper vs. digital. It gives us permission not to engage with our kids. We can blame the video games and apps rather than blaming ourselves. Parents need to take responsibility for raising thoughtful, empathic, open-minded adults. Books are a crucial part of the equation. But even if we eliminated every digital technology from our lives, our kids still won't read books unless we tell them in no uncertain terms that books are an important part of being an adult.*

Shamefully, at the age of 28, I have discovered that the substance contained in non-fiction books is unmatched by video games. I have never been much of a reader but have been challenging myself to read more and more each year.

This year, I have decided to do a majority of reading on my devices. Once I finish a book, I buy the print version as a trophy or *achievement*. Is buying a book twice crazy? Probably. But the author gets a small bonus and it has me yearning to read cover-to-cover. One step toward gamifying my reading experience.

Polygon Human Angle: Queer Games

May 21, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender, Sexuality

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XQB5snyJfXk

Mattie Brice, developer of Mainichi:

> *If I was to watch [Mainichi] be played anywhere it would be upsetting. Maybe upsetting is a good thing. I think we should be upset by games. I think that's a valid emotion to happen. It's not meant for me to feel good. It does make other people feel good because in a sense, this game has been validating. Many people are like, "Oh! I've had that experience too. I'm not alone."*

Human Angle is such a beautiful series.

Welcoming to new players

May 21, 2014

Categories: Business

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *In most games of this genre you earn currency which is used to buy items, potions and buffs that make your character more powerful. Picking the right items at the right time for your character is a huge part of both League of Legends and Dota 2.*
>
> *They were discussing the idea of removing the item shop altogether, and one of the game's designers was becoming, as Browder put it "emotionally distressed" at the idea of removing an aspect of the game that's a key part of the genre.*
>
> *There were people on the team against the idea of an item shop and a gold system, as they just allowed those in the lead to remain in the lead and crush the other side. It added a layer of complexity that may not be welcoming to new players.*

Worked well for Hearthstone.

I've been dreaming of a cross-over title since the original Warcraft III teaser, initially mistaking the rain of the Burning Legion as Zerg.

Well played: On multiplayer behavior, discipline, and new interactions

May 22, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender, Psychology

Patrick Stafford, The Atlantic:

> *That's why Wiseman and Burch say game makers should feel obligated, as creators of the most popular entertainment medium for boys, to inject some emotional nuance into their work.*
>
> *Making cooperation a part of gameplay is an easy way to do that. Many games already require players to use teamwork to win, but Burch and Wiseman say more can be done. Football matches require players to shake hand after every match—what if there was a digital equivalent?*

In middle-school, I sent a recruitment request email to a Quake clan leader (there has to be a better term for this) full of overly aggressive sentiment and profanity from my friend's computer. What I did not realize was that his father was able to track all outbound communication from the machine. I was later disciplined for my vulgarity by my parents and was forced to apologize to my friend's parents. Full of embarrassment, I learned that the type of dialog I had engaged in was not appropriate. I also learned that even seemingly "anonymous" communication could be tracked.

I also recall seeing the term "gg" for the first time after a Starcraft match. After learning that the acronym stood for "good game," I was taken aback. This may have been the first time I had seen resolute, positive communication in an online multiplayer setting. Sending "gg" at the end of each match became a ritual. This ritual can now be seen in Hearthstone. There has been much praise for Hearthstone's use of limited speech commands, with a majority of matches ending in, "Well played."

Fast forward a few years where I was called out by an openly gay high school classmate for being a "dick." I am uncertain as to exact circumstance but I do recall being deserved of this title. At that moment, I had become acutely aware of my thoughts, actions, and communication toward others.

Not only does removing abusive communication from a game create an uninhibited environment for play and experience, I would bet that it has a lasting impact on real-world perspective and interaction. As long as slanderous behavior is met with positive reinforcement from in-game peers, the cancer will grow. Those shrouded in anonymity may be wise not to display this behavior in public but will continue to bank harmful viewpoints in private until disciplined by peers, companies, or guardians. Here's to hoping Donald Sterling opened some eyes.

Discipline is necessary. I fear that those children continuing to engage in lewd behavior are not being disciplined or monitored. What is worse are the adults who continue to engage in such behavior that may never be disciplined or monitored.

One additional bit on innovative interaction in multiplayer games:

John Siracusa on Journey's use of multiplayer interaction in "Strange Game":

> *Though players can't harm each other, they can help each other. Touching another player recharges the power used to leap and (eventually) fly. In cold weather, touching warms*

> *both players, fighting back the encroaching frost. More experienced players can guide new players to secret areas and help them through difficult parts of the game.*
>
> *Journey players are not better people than Call of Duty players or Halo players. In fact, they're often the same people. The difference is in the design of the game itself. By so thoroughly eliminating all forms of negative interaction, all that remains is the positive.*
>
> *Players do want to interact; real people are much more interesting than computerized entities. In Journey, players inevitably find themselves having positive interactions with others. And, as it turns out, many people find these positive, cooperative interactions even more rewarding than their usual adversarial gaming experiences.*

Osmo: New creative play

May 22, 2014

Categories: Education

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CbwIJMz9PAQ

Pramod Sharma, Tangible Play CEO and co-founder, on skills machines can't replicate:

> *One is the social and emotional learning. How do we connect with people? There's a skill required in that. That's fundamental for anyone. In school, they don't know how to teach those kids.*
>
> *The second one is creative, out of the box thinking. How do you teach kids to be creative? The theory [from educators] is when you're using a device, or any gaming device, you're creatively always a function of what the device lets you do. The Wii, for example, you can do only a constraint of what the controller is. You cannot go beyond this.*

A simple modification turned creative moderator. Fascinating.

Braving Blizzard and inclusion in games

May 22, 2014

Categories: Business, Culture, Sexuality

Todd Harper writing for Polygon:

> *Meanwhile, the mere presence of prominent and respectfully portrayed women characters, characters of color, and queer characters is viewed as inherently political and thus anti-fun. It's another subtle, vicious knife in the side of us marginalized people who play games that says: you're second class. You're less valuable. If you show up, somehow you're removing the fun for everyone else.*
>
> *This construction where it's impossible to have "fun" and "inclusion" side-by-side by reflecting diversity in your games is a total illusion, a mirage thrown up to distract us from the simple fact that they just don't want to make that effort.*

Harper quoting Rob Pardo of Blizzard Entertainment earlier in the opinion piece:

> *"We're not trying to bring in serious stuff, or socially relevant stuff, or actively trying to preach for diversity or do things like that," he said. His example of a place where Blizzard struggles is portrayal of women.*
>
> *Pardo notes that "because most of our developers are guys who grew up reading comics books," Blizzard games often present women characters as a sexualized comic book ideal that "is offensive to, I think, some women."*

I find Pardo's comments about Blizzard's portrayal of women interesting when looking at the Hearthstone tutorial, granted the HS team may be far removed from Pardo's view.

A very brave piece. Well done.

Ethnicity in film is to sexuality in games

May 22, 2014

Categories: Culture, Sexuality

Jagger Gravning, Kill Screen:

> *While there is no modern Hays Code equivalent in contemporary American video games (the ESRB rates but does not censor) the manner that LGBT characters are being introduced to a broader audience in major games is through this same blowback-wary method of diligent self-policing. The writers allow space for an audience member to overlook or deny the homosexuality of a particular character if that's the way they would prefer to see things.*
>
> *Game writers like Rhianna Pratchett, who has stated that part of her would have loved Lara Croft to be gay, are instead artfully presenting these characters in a manner that is more aesthetically palatable to players (and likely their concerned parents) who might find explicit same-sex love too lurid or off-putting a subject to handle with frankness in a video game.*

Gravning continues:

> *For many years, if a film did focus on a black character, the story would generally be about that character's experience being black, like The Jackie Robinson Story or Guess Who's Coming to Dinner and many blacksploitation films. It took time for producers, and perhaps audiences, to realize there could be stories involving non-white characters that didn't have to revolve around their ethnicity.*

I wish I had read this prior to Harper's post. A brilliant contextualization of today's human rights issues displayed on a canvas of modern media; ethnic tip-toeing in early 20th century filmmaking vs. LGBT tip-toeing in early 21st century video game making.

People of a certain age

May 22, 2014

Categories: Culture, General

Excerpt from "Three Strikes, You Shout" by Philip Michaels:

> *The people who read Moneyball as teenagers and had enough talent to play baseball are just coming into their own as Major Leaguers. The ones who became sportswriters are working their way up the chain in journalism, where they'll eventually supplant the columnists who see advanced stats as something to be derided instead of understood. And the rest, the vast majority who simply remain fans of the game, will wonder why anyone ever argued about something so obvious.*
>
> *'The world is run by people of a certain age,' [Rany] Jazayerli said in his podcast. 'And once people who grew up with these principles reach a point in their life where they are naturally in positions of influence, that's when you'll start to see changes made.'*

My thoughts on the importance of video games and the influence on those that play to a tee.

Dungeon Defenders studio lays off 20%, shift in company culture

May 23, 2014

Categories: Business

Comments from Darrell Rodriguez, CEO of Trendy Entertainment, as they appear on GamesIndustry International:

> *Currently, we are not profitable, but we have products in the pipeline to get us there. We are in between launches, so our cash flow is a concern. We are taking the necessary steps to fix this to ensure Dungeon Defenders II gets out the door at the great quality people have come to expect. We're at a critical time where execution and performance is essential to our ongoing success.*
>
> *...*
>
> *We are doing this very unpleasant action with respect, empathy and compassion in consideration of the great work that these people have contributed to Trendy.*
>
> *...*
>
> *As discussed last time, a lot of the culture had already shifted upon my arrival. I'm working closely with devs and leads to create more openness and better communication at all levels of the company. Cultural change does not happen overnight, but we have ongoing efforts to work on better cross-departmental communication, getting the leads directly involved in product planning and holding consistent company wide meetings to ensure we are all on the same page. There's a long way to go, but we're on our way*

Rodriguez's statements on culture change are well met. Healthy company culture is key and appears to be a hot topic in light of the layoff crisis plaguing development studios as of late. My thoughts to those affected. Layoff list updated.

"what do you think about us copying the game?"

May 23, 2014

Categories: Business

Howard Tsao of Muse Games on publishing Guns of Icarus Online, blogging on Gamasutra:

> *Part of our embodiment of steampunk was to infuse it with influences from cultures of the world. In their attempt to exploit this, the publisher then asked for "stereotypes" of different cultures. Reason? They claimed that stereotypes are more easily distinguishable. We thought this was flirting with racism, but once again, the publisher claimed to know better. The art style that we settled on was more in the spirit of Miyasaki or early Final Fantasy games. That is not inherently a bad thing; it's just not what we wanted or agreed to. We decided to make a compromise to keep the relationship going.*
>
> *With the project hanging in the balance, teetering on collapse, I made the trip to Taiwan. After a day of sitting in a claustrophobic meeting room, it came down to either accept an extended prototype with the lower pay or be terminated. We decided to terminate and get out of the contract and the relationship. Then, I got a phone call from the publisher's CTO. On the phone, he posed this question: 'If you wanted to go through with termination, what do you think about us copying the game?'*

Hooked after part 1. Looking forward to parts 2 thru 5.

Webster Goomez the stuffed Goomba

May 23, 2014

Categories: Children, Psychology

Susan Senator, writing for Cognoscenti, on "Webster Goomez" the stuffed Goomba:

> *A day or so later, Ben remarked that Webster was 'kind of adorable.'*
>
> *Adorable? Did I hear that right? Never had such a word come out of Ben before. I quickly recovered my cool and tried not to make too big a deal out of it, so as not to embarrass him. But inside, I cradled that word, longed to hear it again, hoping I hadn't imagined it. But no, this was for real. A few days later, I heard Ben describing a different character as 'cute.'*

Cute :)

NYT: 'Rusty's Real Deal Baseball Video Game Tests Haggling Skills'

May 24, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Stephen Totilo, The New York Times:

> *This is where Nintendo toys with convention. You're supposed to haggle with Rusty, who, remember, is a virtual dog, not a living person. You're supposed to get him to lower his price for the rest of Bat and Switch and for his other nine games. According to the plot, Rusty is stressed. His wife has left him. He's overwhelmed by his 10 kids. He'll bend to make a sale. One of his kids even coaches you about how to haggle with his dad, how to flatter, cajole or hardball your way to a lower price. Press Rusty well enough, and each game can be had for less than $2.*

After playing along with Nintendo for a moment, I saw myself buying up every mini-game in this entry. Every hook seems perfect. This game will be a hit.

Super Mario Lovers

May 24, 2014

Categories: Sexuality

The Ellen DeGeneres Show:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CmuXJTuudyE

Bobby Moynihan and Sacha Baron Cohen would make a great Mario and Luigi.

Polygon: 'How gaming in wartime connected soldiers, a father and a son'

May 25, 2014

Categories: Culture, Military, Parenting

Richard Grisham, host of Press Row Podcast, writes for Polygon:

> *Modern communication technology has made the hardship of deployment easier both for soldier and family, but the close connection in the field still can create an awkward burden. One night, Fields called back to his family at "kind of an emotional time.*
>
> *"I heard my son talk in the background and he said 'Dad, I can't wait for you to come home and be safe'," Fields said. "It was his concerned voice that told me he was reaching out to try and make a link.*
>
> *Fields felt the need to "meet him halfway." He thought back to Call of Duty, and if he could play it with his son when— or if — he returned home.*
>
> *"I immediately walked up to the battalion aid station because I knew ...there was a young kid, one of those guys that wasn't that guy who's gonna be in the gym lifting 300 pounds and chewing tobacco, and a 'man's man'; he is a little soft-spoken and a lot of people thought that he was a kinda odd," Fields said.*
>
> *Still, this odd kid, Spec. Jameson Lindskog, was well known for his skill at Call of Duty. Fields, a 20-year veteran and command sergeant major, approached him.*
>
> *"I said 'Lindskog, your job is to teach me this game,'" Fields remembered.*

Connection between two soldiers; connection between father and son. Powerful story. One hell of a read.

Grisham:

> *The story of Fields and his unit is depicted in the documentary The Hornet's Nest, which premiered in theaters on Friday.*

Operation Supply Drop:

For more on the military and gaming, read/watch Polygon's feature on Operation Supply Drop; a charity committed to sending video games to troops in the field.

Freakonomics Radio: 'Think Like a Child'

May 25, 2014

Categories: Business, Children, Gamification, Work

Economist Steven Levitt, Freakonomics Radio:

> *Video games are fun. My son, Nick, who's 11-years-old, could play video games for eight hours straight. Could Nick work at a job, say at McDonald's, for eight hours? No. So it seems to me, what you take away from that is if you could make a job as fun as a video game, then you'd have all of the 11-year-old boys in the world, and probably the 15-year-old and 20-year-old and maybe even the 30-year-old boys lining up at your door trying to take that job.*

This sentiment is very much echoed in game designer Jane McGonigal's book Reality is Broken. A worthwhile read on the fulfilling benefits of games and updating the today's workplace / social constructs to be more game-like.

Levitt continues:

> *I think fun is so much more important than people realize and I've seen it in academics. When I interview young professors and try to decide if we should hire them, I've evolved over time to one basic rule: If I think they love economics and it's fun for them, then I'm in favor of hiring them. No matter how talented they seem otherwise, if it seems like a job or effort or work, then I don't want to hire them.*

In March of 2013, I wrote about the idea of circling back to childhood hobbies when I am feeling lost. Many of those hobbies I am still fond of today. They act as fantastic through-lines that keep me on track when I feel I have strayed too far off course or have lost sight of my path. See also Finding Your Calling published on The Art of Manliness on the idea of pursuing *vocation* rather than a job or career.

Transistor OST

May 26, 2014

Categories: Music

Darren Korb, Transistor OST composer, as quoted by Polygon:

> *I tried to create a genre for myself to work within, which I ended up calling 'Old-world Electronic Post-rock.' After a lot of experimentation, I zeroed in on electric guitars, harps, accordions, mandolins, electric piano, and synth pads as some of the primary textures in the game. Each of these instruments tries to express some component of that genre mash-up.*

I have been raving about the Transistor OST since its release and have yet to play the game. With every spin I hear different post-hardcore notes, ranging in soaring delay driven guitars to gritty programmed beats in the vein of Thrice, The Dear Hunter, The Sounds of Animals Fighting, Deftones, Radiohead, or O' Brother. On occasion, the OST takes turns into haunting carnival themes or dark jazz motifs a la Tom Waits. This album is a must own.

IGN: 'Final Fantasy X's war on organized religion'

May 26, 2014

Categories: Religion

Toby McCasker writing for IGN:

> *The only thing keeping people together, curiously, is the church of Yevon. 'Church' is a misnomer seeing as Yevon is Spira. Spira is a theocracy, and despite how colourful and carefree its archipelagos and cities might seem, it is also a fascist theocracy. That kind of dualism is intentional, and represents FFX's broader Buddhist subtext. Hey what? We'll get to that. In the meantime, if you go against Yevon, you're gonna have a bad time.*

I played Final Fantasy X in high school. I was searching for an identity and was cynical of everything. The game's opinions on organized religion, technology, and the afterlife had a profound effect on me. Every new motif locked in my attention as if Billy Madison was trying to express how I'm important it was.

Needless to say, FFX was the first video game that showed me the medium had a substantial voice and was about more than just fun.

A terrific read.

The topic of misogyny

May 27, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender, Psychology

Jessica Valenti, The Guardian:

> *Before the mass murder he allegedly committed, 22-year-old Rodger – also said to have been killed Friday night – made several YouTube videos complaining that he was a virgin and that beautiful women wouldn't pay attention to him. In one, he calmly outlined how he would "slaughter every single spoiled, stuck-up, blond slut I see".*
>
> *According to his family, Rodger was seeking psychiatric treatment. But to dismiss this as a case of a lone "madman" would be a mistake.*
>
> *It not only stigmatizes the mentally ill – who are much more likely to be victims of violence than perpetrators of it – but glosses over the role that misogyny and gun culture play (and just how foreseeable violence like this is) in a sexist society. After all, while it is unclear what role Rodger's reportedly poor mental health played in the alleged crime, the role of misogyny is obvious.*

Any mention of video games in this column? No.

Relevant to video game culture? Hugely.

I continually praise and promote Polygon for continuing to cover controversial topics such as gender in gaming (amongst many others); be it the portrayal of female characters, hostility toward female gamers, the privilege of male gamers, or women working in the games industry. However, as these articles are published, many in the community appear irritated by the growth of cultural focus on gaming websites. It is infuriating to see these types of pieces battered down by ignorant rants, chalked-up as "click bait," or dismissed by a community who just wants to "have fun." It's a shame that a community built around "fun" attempts to put such important conversations to bed the instant they are published.

As more and more conversations detailing misogynistic culture are injected into mainstream outlets, the more they should be praised. The next time you read a piece in this vein, offer your gratitude to the author for braving (sadly) the inevitable hostility, broadening the conversation, and challenging our cultural norms.

A very brave and critical piece by Jessica Valenti. My thoughts to those affected by this heinous act.

UPDATE: Brian Koppelman: "As The Father Of A Daughter"

> *As the father of a daughter, I feel complicit. I've been at poker games, football games, street fairs and business meetings, on message boards and in email chains, where I've heard comments about women, tinged with a particular kind of frustrated anger, that I have chosen to ignore. Because it's easier to ignore them than to be ostracized, thought unmanly, excluded. As the father of a daughter, I promise, from this moment on, to have zero tolerance, to be vigilant, to remember that all women are someone's daughter, and to be brave enough to remind others of that, when they need reminding.*

UPDATE: Polygon: 'Where are the women in eSports?'

Michal "Carmac" Blicharz:

> *We are not focused on expanding our demographic beyond who we currently reach because our core audience is growing every year. Historically all attempts to target non-core eSports demographics have been failures. Various companies have tried simplification, gender segregation, mainstream-friendly rule sets and other similar things but does not work. It is not authentic as it alienates the immensely large core audience in the hope that someone new might pick it up. We don't see the point.*

48% of gamers are female (ESA, 2014). Male physical advantage: ~0. Male mental advantage: ~0.

First comment: AngryChad:

> *Why is it always about women in gaming lately? You even mention in the article that 21-34 is the targeted demographic, so why aren't you asking why older people are also being left out?*

Ready to pull my hair out.

Nintendo x YouTube Affiliate Program

May 27, 2014

Categories: Business

Mike Futter, Game Informer:

> *Nintendo is taking a step in the right direction here, but it is far from the open policy taken by publishers of all sizes, including Devolver Digital, Deep Silver, and Ubisoft. Based on what little we understand right now, it appears that YouTube creators will need to be part of the affiliate program in order to monetize. This would give Nintendo some control over content, and it could choose to remove those creators it later disapproves of for whatever reason.*

I see others following suit.

Journey dev raises $7 million

May 27, 2014

Categories: Business, General

thatgamecompany:

> *We are proud to share the news today that our studio has entered the next phase of development on our upcoming project and has raised an additional $7 million in funding. We are happy to partner with Capital Today and a team of other investors who share our vision in making meaningful interactive experiences that inspire, connect, and emotionally touch the hearts of players around the world.*
>
> *With this new investment, our studio is able to scale up development efforts to focus on making the best game possible in the same spirit as flOw, Flower, and Journey. We'll also begin laying the infrastructure to self-publish, market, and distribute on our own terms for this next project and beyond.*

Cannot wait.

Polygon: 'It's time to stop caring about new IP (just because it's new IP)'

May 27, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Ben Kuchera:

> *I'm not saying that we shouldn't celebrate new ideas in games, I'm saying that new franchises and game titles aren't any more or less likely to deliver them than games in an existing series.*

Bingo, Ben.

I'm not sure the last time I cared about new IP. Frankly, I'm more excited to hear how Nintendo will reinvent Mario again.

Microsoft not selling off Xbox

May 28, 2014

Categories: Business

Satya Nadella, Microsoft CEO, tells The Verge:

> *I have no intent to do anything different with Xbox than we are doing today.*

Did anybody actually believe this would happen?

Health tech Trojan horse

May 28, 2014

Categories: Business, Health

Holly Green writing for Polygon:

> *Integrating new technology into our daily lives relies upon accessibility, affordability and ease of use. Where motion control is concerned, video games are the perfect Trojan horse.*

A great piece on the health benefits of motion control.

I've failed to look at video game motion controls as a power player in the physical therapy industry. I don't doubt that motion controls will fade away from the consumer video game market. However, it is worth noting that these tools do exist and have been invested in while, at the same time, lifestyle betterment (health, environment, social, etc.) has become a huge focus in the tech landscape. I don't think this is the end of Kinect.

#YesAllWomen

May 29, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender

Jessica Valenti of The Guardian on #YesAllWomen:

> *Part of the obstinate disbelief seems to be a need to protect the privileges of sexism: associating misogyny with a mass murder would mean having to recognize just how dangerous misogyny really is and - if you're partaking - giving it up. Some men want to believe that they can continue to call women "sluts" and make rape jokes without being part of a broader cultural impact. But they can't: sexism, from everyday harassment to inequality enshrined in policy, pollutes our society as a whole and limits our ability to create real justice for women.*

Jessica Valenti doing magnificent work at The Guardian. A must read for all, especially those partaking in communities largely supported by anonymity.

Pretty In Pink

May 29, 2014

Categories: Culture

Keith Stuart, The Guardian:

> *Obviously, I'm not saying that video games were better in the 80s – I'm old but I'm not mad. I'm saying that they really understood the anarchy inherent in rejecting bleakness. While city rich kids and Wall Street yuppies flashed their brick-sized phones, the commodity the rest of us traded in was fantasy – not as escapism, but as statement.*
>
> *The casuals, the New Romantics, the goths, the grebos, the whizz kids, the geeks, they weren't retreating, they were attacking. No thanks, keep your jobs in the city and your braying Sloanes. Let's play Bubble Bobble and read Smash Hits. Our heroes are pop stars, hip-hop artists and Japanese game developers. At least that's how I felt.*

A wonderful read.

Somewhere in this piece, I was reminded of the role post-hardcore played in the wake of 9/11; a seemingly counter-culture voice saying, "don't retreat. Understand this new world. Things are different." Only after understanding could we sling-shot back with the dream-pop anthems swirling in our streaming playlists today. However, it was this "new world" that fostered the then middle and high-schoolers who are now developing today's games. It's time for games to sling-shot back.

Mario Kart anyone?

Harmonix lays off 37

May 29, 2014

Categories: Business

Harmonix spokesperson to Polygon:

> *Harmonix is in the process of restructuring our organization to bring it into alignment with our current and future product development plans. Unfortunately, this means making the difficult decision to reduce the number of full-time staff. We sincerely appreciate the work of each and every one of these employees. Harmonix is working to ensure that those affected are well taken care of as we make this change.*

The spokesperson also offered that these layoffs are unrelated to the unbundling the Kinect. My thoughts to those affected.

Layoff list updated.

Polygon: 'Among the Sleep Review'

May 29, 2014

Categories: General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2BUqy70CjxQ

Philip Kollar, Polygon:

> *I have a nine-month-old child myself, and when he wakes up in the middle of the night sobbing and shaken, I cannot help but wonder what it is that could be torturing the dreams of someone so young. Among the Sleep posits an answer by letting players journey through its two-year-old protagonist's darkest nightmares.*

Between Gone Home and Among the Sleep, the first-person narrative is crawling into innovative territory.

Glenn Beck on Watch Dogs

May 30, 2014

Categories: Culture

Glenn Beck on Watch Dogs as quoted by Polygon:

> *This game is teaching you to hack into whatever is docked in your bedroom. What the heck is wrong with us? What are we thinking? We are inviting this into our home and our lives. We are teaching our kids for entertainment purposes.*

If you have the time to worry about Watch Dogs, you have the time to read this.

Tapped Out Intros Chester Dupree, The Simpsons Slacker

May 30, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Ryan Reed, Rolling Stone:

> *Dupree, who rocks a purple beanie and heaphones, isn't a complete newcomer to the Simpsons universe (having been mentioned verbally in the 2012 episode "Gone Abie Gone"), but he hasn't yet appeared on the series. Previously, the app debuted another new character, Kumiko Nakamura, for a limited run before she appeared as the Comic Book Guy's romantic interest in the Season 25 episode "Married to the Blob." The snarky, comical app often features tie-ins to the series, allowing players to acquire items connected to upcoming episodes.*

Riding the wave of exclusive character integration. Smart.

Tapped out is available for iOS and Android.

Club Nintendo stuck in Mario Kart traffic

May 31, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Mike Futter, Game Informer:

> *While this may be frustrating, I try to see the positive in server issues like this. Nintendo has clearly been successful with its free game offer (and Mario Kart 8 is quite good) as people are crowding in to take advantage of the bonus title. You've got until July 31 to claim your game, though. There's no rush.*

Good call.

Since opening my copy of Mario Kart 8 last night (7p PST), I've had intermittent success signing in and have yet to redeem my freebie. Login and site navigation still feels sluggish. Still looking forward to my copy of Pikmin 3.

UPDATE: The following message was posted to club.nintendo.com roughly 2 hours ago:

> *Club Nintendo is currently unavailable due to site maintenance. We apologize for any inconvenience.*
>
> *Remember to hang on to your product registration codes and make a note of your serial numbers - we'll be back soon so you can register your products.*
>
> *Please note, it is not necessary to register your hardware to begin your warranty. This is done automatically at the retailer when you purchase your product. However, please check back to register your products for Club Nintendo benefits, including hardware warranty extensions.*
>
> *Forum users please note, the Tech Support Forums will be in read-only mode during this time. All existing Forum topics, posts, and replies will remain available for those looking for technical assistance with Nintendo products. No new threads or messages can be created until Club Nintendo is back up.*
>
> *Please try back later.*

UPDATE 2: Club Nintendo seems to be back online, still with some spotty maintenance around account management.

UPDATE 3: Pikmin 3 is go.

Hail Mario

June 1, 2014

Categories: Business, General

On Friday night, something beautiful happened. Something I hadn't experienced in roughly 15 years. 4-player split-screen local multiplayer.

For close to three hours, a group of four late-twenty somethings, two of which had rarely touched a controller since Nintendo 64 (let alone given a thought to the medium since), celebrated the beginning of their weekend with pizza, beer, and the newly released *Mario Kart 8*. There were no chat headsets, lag times, or slanderous rants. Just loads of laughter, blue-shell equalizing, and repetition of the reminiscent phrase, "I love video games."

Early Embargo

On May 15th, Nintendo lifted the review embargo for *Mario Kart 8*. Critiques for a game consumers couldn't get their hands on began springing up across the web, heralding it as "the best pure Mario Kart experience yet" and "the king of the mascot kart circuit." Nearly every day after the embargo's end, journalists (game and otherwise) taunted would-be players, trumpeting the game's brilliance.

I asked Polygon's Ben Kuchera what he thought of the early embargo. His quick and brief response:

> *I guarantee you it helped pre-sales*.

If my buying habits of were any indication of the market at large, he was right.

Freebie

Not resting on chance from reviewers, Nintendo decided to offer up one of four free games when US and Canada Mario Kart 8 owners registered their game with Club Nintendo before 7/31/14. Expecting to see a slew of sub-par Wii branded titles, I was pleasantly surprised to see a selection of solid entries valued at $40 and up: *New Super Mario Bros. U*, *Pikmin 3*, *The Legend of Zelda: Wind Waker HD*, and *Wii Party U*.

If a near certain purchaser was still hesitating to pre-order after stellar reviews, a deal like this would put them over the edge.

The Plant

Playing that night, I'd go as far as to say that the four of us would fall as outliers on a graph of expected launch day players. The fact that I owned a Wii U was a shock in it's own right. Our guests that evening had yet to even see the console a year-and-a-half after it's launch.

What would have been a more likely scene would be clusters of parents that grew up with the franchise watching their own children tear into the game, possibly taking a swing at the old Nintendo 64 Rainbow Road now and again.

Outliers or not, I'd be hard-pressed to believe that the four of us were the only Mario Kart old timers celebrating on release day. It came as no surprise when I heard one of our guests convince himself

that he would be investing in the console if only for Mario Kart. The mention that he could also download *The Legend of Zelda: A Link to the Past* on the system seemed to solidify his notion.

Old Timers

Mario Kart 8 proves that Nintendo is deeply in tune with generational gaming gaps. As our *Link to the Past* lover so eloquently put it, the ease of entry to *Mario Kart 8* iterates on the tried and true idiom "it's like riding a bike" with an updated "it's like playing Mario Kart."

From the first race to the last, we would chuckle at my fiancée's incessant need to comment on how gorgeous the levels looked. Funny at first, I couldn't help but look closer at the imagery in the courses. It became evident that Nintendo is unabashedly gunning for Disney-level aesthetics; a tactic to win over most demographics.

If a level of unmatched flow and fun can be reached seconds into the first race, franchise elders will certainly double take at the sight of the *Wii U + Mario Kart bundle* during their next visit to Target.

Final Lap?

In '91, with a 10-7 lead, the Dallas Cowboys bet on a Hail Mary pass against the Washington Redskins at the end of the 1st half. Troy Aikman's successful touchdown pass to Alvin Harper would give the Cowboys a 17-7 lead to eventually topple the Redskins, 24-21; the first Redskins loss of the season after an 11-0 start. No early Hail Mary, no game ending win.

Nintendo gambled for positive reviews two weeks before launch, is now chalking up at least $40 in games to every US and Canadian Mario Kart owning household, and prays that their Trojan horse will be the spark to move units. Since release, the game has received stunning accolades, Club Nintendo has been brought down by what can only be assumed as immense traffic for free games, and at least one Wii U newcomer is being tugged at by curiosity.

When people think of video games, a large majority picture a mustachioed plumber in a red hat, but Master Chief and the *Minecraft* universe are only 3 points down. There are still many plays to be made but a well-timed, well-calculated marketing play this big could be enough to save the game. *Mario Kart 8* may give Nintendo the lead they need to send a message to the HD Twins: Nintendo's race is not over.

BBC 5Live moves Game On into Primetime

June 1, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Adam Rosser, host of 5Live's Game On:

> *It's great news for the show and for 5Live. They've finally started to listen to my wild protestations. 5Live's Saturday Edition has, with its coverage of tech and web news, established a beachhead that we're able to exploit. Adding Game On into the station's Let's Talk About Tech strand will get the content out to an existing audience and draw in a new cohort of listeners.*
>
> *We'll be covering E3 and Gamescom, of course. As centrepieces of the calendar they're key to getting a handle on what's coming up and I suspect that this year we'll get a much clearer idea of what the landscape's going to be like for the new consoles.*

I am delighted to see this news. The market is hungry and I'm happy that major broadcasters are catching on. Fingers crossed Game On doesn't go the way of G4.

Subscribe to Let's Talk About Tech on iTunes.

Video games crash course

June 2, 2014

Categories: Business, Children

Keith Stuart, The Guardian:

> *For people who don't play video games, they can seem like a strange and vaguely threatening interloper into the household.*
>
> *These noisy yet seemingly seductive things are on computers, on smartphones and tablets, and on expensive consoles that your kids will tell you everyone else has. And if you're not buying them for your children, your children are probably playing them elsewhere.*
>
> *Even if you never intend to play a game in your life, you should probably know about them – if only to understand what it is that drags other people in.*

Stuart continues to churn out great work over at The Guardian. As stated, this piece is a must for parents and (honestly) everyone else. The piece highlights everything from free-to-play to the state of major developers, financials to education; plus some Hearthstone, Monument Valley, and Mario Kart 8 love. Good to the last sentence.

Tunnel vision

June 2, 2014

Categories: Culture, Health

Robert Kingett, legally-blind video game reviewer with cerebral palsy via IGN:

> *In multiplayer games I will always be at a slight disadvantage because I can't look at multiple parts of the screen at once because of my tunnel vision. It's like looking through a toilet paper roll all the time. My cerebral palsy hinders me as well but not in games like MAGIC, or similar because that's strategy. I do have a stutter and people who want to be gamers are quick to point out I sound "retarded" or "like I am disabled." It saddens me to see that there are not many true gamers anymore who just enjoy gaming no matter how unskilled someone is. I actually know some mentally disabled people who play better than most, and when I say play, I mean their spirit.*
>
> *I've experienced a lot of that, and I just don't understand why people say some of the things that they say. It's not going to create an elite gaming world full of epic gamers who know every Easter egg known to man. Gamers will game, no matter who says what. I'm a gamer and I will game on. I enjoy the art and everything else video games have to offer and that means enjoying it with all kinds of people. There are even cases of people being flat out derogatory to other races on video games. Again, I don't understand why. I don't want people like that ruining it for us gamers.*

Kingett on what developers can do to make their games more accessible:

> *There are three words I'd say that makes a video game completely accessible. Customization, choices, and alternatives. Have a game very customizable in all assets and you will have an accessible game. Have caption customizations where deaf players can have captions in a font that they want to have. Make your HUD's customizable so visually impaired players like me can change the map size, the radar size, the crosshair size and shape, have assist, control mapping options, different control styles - just make your game very customizable unlike anything anyone has ever seen before.*

A must read.

The Guardian: 'Tetris: how we made the addictive computer game'

June 3, 2014

Categories: History

Alexey Pajitnov, Tetris programmer, writing for the The Guardian:

> *Next I put together the procedures for manipulating the pieces: pick a tile, flip it, rotate it. But the playfield filled up in 20 seconds flat. Also, once you'd filled a line, it was kind of dead, so why keep it on the screen? So I made each full line disappear, which was key. I was a pretty good programmer and it took me about three weeks to get something controllable on screen. I pretended I was debugging my program, but in truth I just couldn't stop playing it. When other people tried it, they couldn't, either. It was so abstract – that was its great quality. It appealed to everybody.*

Everything wrong with modern trailers

June 3, 2014

Categories: Business, General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ci6lMQNLKZU

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *A trailer has one job: To sell you on the game. Its sole purpose is to move you closer to making a purchasing decision. It may ditch the game's actual visuals for pre-rendered or even live-action footage, or live-action with so many special effects that it may as well be CG. It's not there to give an accurate representation about the game, it's there to get you to buy something. That's it.*
>
> *That's what a trailer does from the point of view of the publisher, but as a player I want to learn something about the game. I don't particularly care if the trailer uses in-game footage or not, a live-action trailer can just as easily tell us something about the tone and setting of the game using other means. Some of the Halo trailers, for instance, did a great job of setting up the scale of upcoming games and the sense of loss without showing much of the battles themselves. The "Believe" ad was a great trailer, as it told me something about the game. It got me interested because it made me feel something.*

Unlike those on Twitter (referenced in the main article), I found the Wiz Khalifa track a breath of fresh air from the dub-step action epics and juxtaposed warm-and-fuzzy shooter reels. I also enjoyed watching a simple (mostly) side-shot mano-a-mano CG(?) fight in lieu of an over the top action sequence packed with cameo after cameo.

However, where the teaser is refreshing under the lens of style, it lacks the substance necessary to elicit excitement for this game. Grumpy Kuchera wins again.

'Temple Run' sees 1bn downloads, mostly women

June 4, 2014

Categories: Business, Gender

Andrew Webster delivers Temple Run and Temple Run 2 joint analytics:

> *Alongside the milestone, Imangi also revealed a number of details about its audience, which helps to illustrate the changing landscape of mobile games. 60 percent of all players are female, for instance, and the game is most popular in China, which accounts for 36 percent of all downloads. The next largest market is the US at 21 percent.<*

Changing landscape indeed.

GamesIndustry International: 'SOE GIRL Scholarship winner announced'

June 4, 2014

Categories: Business, Education, Gender

Laura Naviaux, Sony Online Entertainment's senior VP of global sales and marketing:

> *SOE has prided itself on being a major catalyst of women's involvement in our industry. As our company continues to evolve and diversify our portfolio, we've found it imperative to refine our approach with game art and development, seeking out varied perspectives from the current and future leading voices in the industry. The market for compelling and original online game experiences is rapidly evolving and as a publisher it is our responsibility to listen and celebrate the spectrum of play styles among our global community, and deliver innovation in art, design and technology.*

Congrats to scholarship winner Erin Loelius.

More on Mario Kart

June 4, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Nintendo press release:

> *Nintendo reported today that the game sold more than 1.2 million total units across Japan, Europe and the Americas during its first weekend on the market.*

Excluding Mario Kart 8, Mario Kart Advance remains the weakest entry in the series at 5.91 million units. There is work to be done.

Liam Martin, Digital Spy:

> *Mario Kart 8 has boosted weekly Wii U console sales by 666% in the UK.*

My prediction is looking up.

Pipe Dream

June 4, 2014

Categories: Business

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *Mario Kart 8's sales numbers are amazing. The attach rate between the game and the console is something that every console holder should envy, but the problem is that with so few consoles there is a ceiling to the total number of sales Mario Kart 8 can do. Even assuming the game will cause systems to move, it's likely to be the worst-selling game in the existence of the series.*
>
> *On the other hand, Watch Dogs is now the best selling new IP in the history of the video game business. It's very hard to find any apples to match with these oranges; Ubisoft matched a game that was announced in near-perfect fashion with a huge marketing spend and a release that spanned five consoles. The news would be more interesting if the sales didn't break records.*
>
> *These two events tell us much about the opportunities in the video game industry right now.*

I am a huge fan of Ben Kuchera and his opinions. While I usually agree (at least somewhat), I cannot help but find this one extremely impractical. Though Nintendo is filling a bathtub with buckets rather than a lake with flood-gates, what happened to the argument that software sells hardware?

Global Hardware Totals (in millions) via VGChartz:

- Wii U: 6.21
- Xbox One: 4.57
- Xbox 360: 81.33
- PS4: 7.82
- PS3: 82.82

To evaluate the total Watch_Dogs market, let's use the delta between current and prev-gen consoles + countless PCs. That is 151.76+ marketable machines. If this is the case, Ubisoft has successfully sold 4 million units of Watch_Dogs to an install-base of 151.76 million consoles + countless PCs. Nintendo has successfully sold 1.12 millions units of Mario Kart 8 to an install-base of 6.21. That is less-than 2% vs. 18% attach rate.

I actively applaud Ubisoft's impressive figures but I see the success of Mario Kart 8 greater. Regardless of release date, Wii U unit numbers fall between Xbox One and PS4; Mario Kart 8's success is only going to grow that number. How quickly that number grows remains to be seen, but early reports are positive.

To add, Ben's dream of a multi-platform Mario collection release to third-party consoles seems appetizing albeit backwards. We will eventually see the release of the Mario catalog on the Wii U (and possibly 3DS) via the virtual console with added community support with the possibility of updated visuals (don't cross your fingers). And, assuming Nintendo does not release Mario to third-party consoles, rather than release in a single bulk collection, the fan-base will continue to salivate at the trickling of legacy releases. To be completely forthright, I can't remember a legacy release that I

continued to play after 5-10 hours. Nintendo would be shooting themselves in the foot by releasing an HD legacy collection to Wii U owners let alone third-parties.

Though Nintendo admits they are already looking to the Wii U's successor, any viable company should have a road map. Giving up the ghost only perpetuates the idea that Nintendo is weak. Instead, Nintendo's ability to rebound a dire situation" with Mario Kart 8's abundance of positive press and a phenomenal attach-rate (low install-base aside) should be considered an extremely gargantuan feat, offering a positive outlook on the future of Wii U.

My dream is that Nintendo 180s this dire situation with an impressive uptick in Wii U numbers and continued IP prominence.

Passion

June 5, 2014

Categories: Business, Culture, Work

Leigh Alexander writing for Gamasutra:

> *I mean, I still don't like the question, but I've come to dislike the prompt to passionately deliver a litany of "what I'm playing lately" a little bit more. The "lately" is the cloying part. As if for participation in this field it's not just enough to enjoy games, to think critically about them, to play them sometimes. To spend all your time making them, as some do. It's that you also must devote yourself to clawing ever uphill, passionately, as a consumer. Like if you were all at a buffet, and you came back to the table with only what you liked on your plate and not everything, you are merely a casual eater.*
>
> *Casual! I am enjoying exploring familiar old design spaces. I really am excited to find the energy and motivation to revisit that Final Fantasy X HD remaster. And I am playing a lot of Puzzle Craft, an utterly inane but soothing and manageable "casual game." And that is it. I reckon I am not very "passionate" about games, in the way I feel I am supposed to be. I am that woman who likes farm games, who everyone brings up in every sexist article about "games for women." I feel pressured to apologize.*

This may be my favorite piece of the year-to-date; chock-full of quotable lines and familiar feelings. Alexander's sentiment cuts to the core of The State of Gaming. I rarely play video games. I average two AAA titles and a handful of indies as my yearly allotment. As a substitute, I scrape together bits of time to check-in on industry news; Five-minutes here, ten-minutes there. Rather than commenting, I parse together thoughts on pieces in a blog format conducive to my limited time and incessant need to "be in the know."

While I'm able to justify why I game, Alexander eloquently justifies why I don't. This piece is a must read.

The New Face of Gamers

June 5, 2014

Categories: Culture

Matthew DiPietro, VP of Marketing & Communications at Twitch:

> *Since the Twitch community has been in an ever-increasing spotlight for the last few years, more and more people have been trying to wrap their heads around the Twitch phenomenon. They ask: "Why in the world would anyone want to watch other people play video games?" That's still a very common question, believe it or not.*

Miranda Sanchez at IGN sums the data:

> *According to the study, gamers are more social than non-gamers and have better connections with their families. The report said that 72% of gamers play games with their friends, and found that "spending time with their families (82% vs. 68%) and parents (67% vs. 44%) are top priories."*
>
> *Additionally, the study said gamers are more likely to have a college degree (43% vs. 36%), are more optimistic about their career goals (67% vs. 42%), and are more likely to have a career they want to be in (45% vs. 37%).*
>
> *The study also addressed the demographics of gamers; 52% of gamers are male, 48% are female, and as much as 73% of Millennials, 62% of Generation X, and 41% of Baby Boomers are playing video games.*

Fun with numbers. Also loved Gruber's take on Twitch.

Polygon: 'E3 is loud, expensive, sexist and violent: It's also the only place to be next week'

June 6, 2014

Categories: Business, Culture, General

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *The features you enjoy, the in-depth interviews you want to read, and the informed work that comes from your favorite sites will often start at a conversation at a bar during an event like E3. Every conversation at E3 is an opportunity to find and share information about the industry and games we all love, and that's why we go. The giant video screens are a distraction from the real work, not a part of it.*

LEGO female scientists

June 6, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender, General

LEGO:

> *We're very excited to release Ellen Kooijman's Female Minifigure set, featuring 3 scientists, now entitled "Research Institute" as our next LEGO Ideas set. This awesome model is an inspiring set that offers a lot for kids as well as adults.*

From geochemist Ellen Kooijman:

> *As a female scientist I had noticed two things about the available LEGO sets: a skewed male/female minifigure ratio and a rather stereotypical representation of the available female figures. It seemed logical that I would suggest a small set of female minifigures in interesting professions to make our LEGO city communities more diverse.*

Did I mention that I love LEGO?

Nintendo consolidates, lays off 130

June 7, 2014

Categories: Business

Nintendo in a statement to Eurogamer:

> *The measures include the consolidation of the current European headquarters in Großostheim (Germany) to Frankfurt (Germany), the closure of the warehouse and office in Großostheim, as well as outsourcing and reorganising some functions.*

My thoughts to those out of work.

A new definition of manhood

June 7, 2014

Categories: Children, Gender, Parenting

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Nx8RRIiP53Q

Colin Stokes, TEDx:

> *Another thing that's really unique about "The Wizard of Oz" to me is that all of the most heroic and wise and even villainous characters are female.*
>
> *Now I started to notice this when I actually showed "Star Wars" to my daughter, which was years later, and the situation was different. At that point I also had a son. He was only three at the time. He was not invited to the screening. He was too young for that. But he was the second child, and the level of supervision had plummeted. (Laughter) So he wandered in, and it imprinted on him like a mommy duck does to its duckling, and I don't think he understands what's going on, but he is sure soaking in it.*
>
> *And I wonder what he's soaking in. Is he picking up on the themes of courage and perseverance and loyalty? Is he picking up on the fact that Luke joins an army to overthrow the government? Is he picking up on the fact that there are only boys in the universe except for Aunt Beru, and of course this princess, who's really cool, but who kind of waits around through most of the movie so that she can award the hero with a medal and a wink to thank him for saving the universe, which he does by the magic that he was born with?*
>
> *Compare this to 1939 with "The Wizard of Oz." How does Dorothy win her movie? By making friends with everybody and being a leader. That's kind of the world I'd rather raise my kids in -- Oz, right? -- and not the world of dudes fighting, which is where we kind of have to be. Why is there so much Force -- capital F, Force -- in the movies we have for our kids, and so little yellow brick road?*

Take 10 minutes to watch this great TEDx Talk by Colin Stokes. I'm not sure how it escaped me that all Pixar protagonists were male until Merida (*Brave*). Looking back on my childhood, I am able to recall watching *The Wizard of Oz* again and again. I don't think the themes of leadership and friendship completely sunk in at that young age; however, the limited and choice amount of violence certainly made me fear conflict much more than any war story.

During last year's E3 Expo, I couldn't help but feel there was an increase in games featuring a female protagonist. Not resting on a hunch, I decided to investigate which new titles featured female protagonists versus the year prior. Looking IGN's Games of E3 lsts for both 2012 and 2013, I found that the inclusion of female protagonists in games announced at E3 jumped from 2% in 2012 to 6% in 2013.

I'm looking forward to breaking down this year's data and may be asking for a bit of help with a publicly shared database (via Numbers for iCloud). My early numbers show 18% male, 3% female, 10% multi, 4% n/a, and 65% unknown.

UPDATE: Updated numbers the night before E3 are as follows:

26% male, 4% female, 17% multi, 9% n/a, 44% unknown.

My data (based on IGN's Games at E3 2014) is publicly available and I encourage readers to reach out on Twitter (@_stateofgaming) or email with any recommended changes. Some "unknown" data can be implied but, without proof, I'll be waiting until official announcements have been made before I update the chart.

Game of Games

June 7, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Author Blake J. Harris on his new book, Console Wars, as quoted by Polygon:

> *My biggest influences on business writing are Ben Mezrich and and Michael Lewis. But the actual greatest influence on the narrative style has to be Game of Thrones. Because, really, that's what this story is. It's all these different families or corporations and entities competing for this one seat at the top of the table that they all think they deserve for a variety of different reasons. Or that they believe that they should inherit — because it's their God-given right or because they have the right strategy, and they deserve it.*

I've been extremely excited for this read. I might have to shelve Catmull and Swift in lieu of Console Wars, or Game of Games.

The Sacred and Profane

June 8, 2014

Categories: General

Garnett Lee of Garnett on Games discussing a call from listener James on the idea of the sacred and profane nature of games:

> *On the one hand, we have the mechanistic part of the game: the things that you do in the game, the systems that support those actions, the environments they take place in. On the other hand you have the designed aspirations: the story a game wants to tell, the emotions it wants to draw out of you, the atmosphere and imagination that it wants to inspire as you play the game.*

My earliest childhood memory is of playing Mega Man 2. When I first saw the game, I was blown away by the dual-layers of tech and toys. There was something uniquely special and alive about Mega Man that would act as the catalyst for my interest in the games space. After hearing Garnett's bit, I now realize that the power of Mega Man was in his simple and subtle "blink" animation. This interest became further perpetuated when an idle Sonic broke the fourth-wall, tapping his foot as he glared directly at me.

Player

June 8, 2014

Categories: General

Garnett Lee of Garnett on Games on exclusively multiplayer vs. exclusively single-player games:

> *We still have vestiges of the prior generations where it's just sort of natural for those us who have been playing games for a long time to think of single-player as "the game" and multiplayer as "the extra you get with the game." I think that that influences us at times. However, I think that there are a number of multiplayer only games that you can point to that are very, very successful as stand-alone multiplayer games beginning all the way back with Team Fortress 2.*

I was really hoping Garnett would have mentioned early dice, board, or card games.

Games require two or more players. The term "player" is embrued with human characteristics. We often forget that games can not only involve challenges with other humans but also ourselves, computers or luck. Single-player video game experiences are multiplayer experiences against computers.

From solitaire to geopolitics, humans enjoy games. We enjoy games because there is a level of risk and challenge involved that (typically) does not seal our fate. There is variety in experience, chance and strategy. If a single game provided the same experience over and over again, it would become boring. Single-player video games provide humans with a computerized variety of ways to enjoy games in solitary fashion; new mechanics, settings and competition are introduced over the course of a single game and my vary with each play-through. Online multiplayer experiences allow for the same type of human variety that is experienced when playing a dice, board or card game; the receptive mechanics, settings, and characters are a shell for a battle of experience, chance and strategy.

Exclusively online multiplayer is a remote evolution of human-to-human competitive play; however, all games are between multiple players. It is not a debate of "single-player" versus "multiplayer" game design as all games are multiplayer. It is simply a debate of preference between solitary and communal. Not all video games need to played against a computer; not all video games need to played against a human.

Grammy-nominated composer speaks up against union blockage of video game recordings

June 9, 2014

Categories: Business, Music

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jqvraGNfKVY

Austin Wintory, Grammy-nominated composer, on the AFM Videogame Agreement:

> *This contract created an untenable situation. Composers and musicians have continued to need to earn a living in this industry. Those musicians and composers therefore we've been forced to work without union sanction because the union has failed to signed any video game companies to work with them in almost two years.*
>
> *After having successfully recorded the iOS game HORN with AFM musicians, I attempted to do the same with THE BANNER SAGA. The unusable contract forced me elsewhere, and I soon found the remarkable Dallas Wind Symphony. This collaboration happened as a direct result of the AFM's unusable contract, and I am now being punished for simply doing my job under those circumstances.*

I continue to be deeply moved by Wintory's Journey OST. It's a shame to see anyone punished for creating music, especially that as brilliant as Wintory's.

Only on Playstation, Bro

June 9, 2014

Categories: General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0z01EYAjkNM

Sony has an IP problem. Short of Little Big Planet 3 and Uncharted 4, none of the other titles seemed to grab. While the exclusive experiences are interesting, their application to existing and expected titles feels lackluster. The chunk of time dedicated to the Playstation ecosystem felt like a slow, redundant message from announcements past. Sony needed to display PS4's ease of development with ready-to-go titles rather than a collection of non-surprises releasing in 2015.

In 2013, Sony promised potential. In 2014, they are having a hard time executing.

Microsoft at E3

June 10, 2014

Categories: General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XsV4E0JUlsw

Keith Stuart, The Guardian:

> *Broadcast live over the internet to millions of viewers the world over, the message couldn't be more clear: last year's emphasis on the strength of the Xbox One as a multimedia and live TV platform was a mistake. This is a games machine that also does other stuff that no one here really wants to hear about.*
>
> *At the end of a pummeling 90 minutes of game announcements and confirmations, Spencer took to the stage again and said, "thank you for making your voice heard, thank you for helping us shape the future of the new Xbox." Basically, it's what Microsoft has been saying for the last six months – we listened, we changed, now eat this.*

The 2014 Microsoft sounded a lot like the 2013 Sony. I would have loved for Microsoft to double-down on their original DRM and Kinect strategy, offering up an entertainment ecosystem that could have set Xbox One outside of the HD Twins comparison. Alas, their indie games showcase offered up impressive tiny titles that could end up system sellers, and that says a lot.

Because, it's Nintendo

June 10, 2014

Categories: General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GisRY6h100U

Nintendo did not apologize or ignore; they listened. Playful jabs at current conversations (eerily close to the last IGN NVC) and admittance of shortcomings was a nice touch to the digital event. That said, the 46-minute presentation left something to be desired. A blowout of late 2014 Smash Bros. content will not be enough to whet the appetites of naysayers.

Nintendo is wise to focus and build out the Mushroom Kingdom with *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker*, more Yoshi, and Amiibo. Even wiser to remind audiences where their gaming experiences started.

Diversity at press events

June 10, 2014

Categories: Gender

Danielle Riendeau, Polygon:

> *It wouldn't hurt the publishers to pay more mind to diversity when choosing people to speak at press events. And it would certainly help make E3 a slightly more welcoming place for the rest of the 75 percent or so of people that make up the population. White men are a minority in the world, and video games have an international audience.*

My E3 2014 Genre/Gender Breakdown data is still in the works but this makes me think I should include ethnicity as well. View my current data here.

Sonic the Hedgehog feature film

June 10, 2014

Categories: General

Polygon: 'Sonic the Hedgehog feature film to blend animation with live action'

With this news and the reminder of the *Ratchet & Clank Movie*, Nintendo would be crazy not to be exploring this option for the Mushroom Kingdom right now…

No females in Assassin's Creed Unity co-op

June 10, 2014

Categories: Gender

Alex Amancio, Ubisoft creative director, as quoted by Polygon:

> *It's double the animations, it's double the voices, all that stuff and double the visual assets, especially because we have customizable assassins. It was really a lot of extra production work.*
>
> *Because of that, the common denominator was Arno. It's not like we could cut our main character, so the only logical option, the only option we had, was to cut the female avatar.*

How was this not mapped out in pre-production?

UPDATE: The Internet is ablaze. The sad part is that this title will still rake in millions, likely billions. We continue to give time to a developer that does not give time to its audience or games. If it's not ready, don't ship.

Paul Tassi, writing for Forbes, on the 2013 Assassin's Creed IV: Black Flag announcement:

> *I like the Assassin's Creed series, but indefinite annual releases could prove to be too much of a good thing. Of course, this is asking a company to choose the artistic integrity and quality of its series over money, which in this day and age almost never happens. Ubisoft seems to think they can maintain both, but that seems like a hard bet to take.*

I've said my piece on Twitter but I'll repeat: If you subscribe to the idea that it's just a game, great. Include diversity. If you subscribe to the idea that video games influence behavior, great. Include diversity. If you subscribe to the idea that production time ran out, delay. Include diversity.

Whatever angle you approach this from, whatever lens you look through, there is no good excuse for a AAA game co-developed by ten studios and arguably the most successful video game developer and publisher in the world not to include diversity in a game-mode dependent on diversity.

UPDATE 2:

Official statement from Ubisoft to Kotaku:

> *We recognize the valid concern around diversity in video game narrative. Assassin's Creed is developed by a multicultural team of various faiths and beliefs and we hope this attention to diversity is reflected in the settings of our games and our characters.*
>
> *Assassin's Creed Unity is focused on the story of the lead character, Arno. Whether playing by yourself or with the co-op Shared Experiences, you the gamer will always be playing as Arno, complete with his broad range of gear and skill sets that will make you feel unique.*
>
> *With regard to diversity in our playable Assassins, we've featured Aveline, Connor, Adewale and Altair in Assassin's Creed games and we continue to look at showcasing diverse characters. We look forward to introducing you to some of the strong female characters in Assassin's Creed Unity.*

This statement feels pretty vapid.

Tumbleweed

June 11, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Keith Stuart, The Guardian:

> *A big announcement at Sony's press conference was that the PlayStation 4 would be able to easily handle free-to-play games and that dozens are already in development. You could almost see the tumbleweed blowing across the stage. Core gamers don't want to hear that. Core gamers, weirdly, cry for innovation then cheer loudest for old stuff they recognise. You know, when games were games and you paid once and they were yours forever.*

Stuart continues:

> *It is no wonder Sony and Microsoft are crawling over each other to sign the indies. No wonder they're looking at the procedurally generated space game No Man's Sky and Capy Games' adventure Below with awe and wonder. These are innovations they understand - they're not about business models, they're not about new audiences who are hard to predict, they're about new ideas within the scope of traditional games. Indie developers are nostalgic but they have the freedom to take the mechanics forward and play with them, just as Tim schafer played with the idea of point-and-click adventures in the 1990s.*

Final Fantasy 14 gets same-sex marriage

June 11, 2014

Categories: Sexuality

Naoki Yoshida, Director and Producer of Final Fantasy 14, as quoted by Polygon:

> *People within Eorzea will be able to pledge their eternal love and or friendship in a ceremony of eternal bonding. And this will be open to people regardless of race, creed, and gender. Two players…if they want to be together, in Eorzea, they can-through this eternal bonding ceremony.*
>
> *We discussed it and we realized: within Eorzea, why should there be restrictions on who pledges their love or friendship to each other? And so we decided to go this way.*

Polygon: 'New deal could clear game musician strife'

June 11, 2014

Categories: Music

Austin Wintory, Grammy-nominated composer for Journey:

> *It's not a silver bullet, but any sign of progress I think can be cause for optimism. But I'm an idealist.*

Wintory's protest of the AFM Videogame Agreement here.

Mario Kart is moving units

June 11, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Reggie Fils-Aime, President of Nintendo America, as quoted by Polygon:

> *It's one of the things I have to do with certain media, remind them, look, for us, the drive toward the holiday began a couple of weeks ago with Mario Kart 8, and that's off to a fantastic start. For us, on a global basis, and certainly here in the United States, it's driving hardware, which is great to see.*

Sounds like I was on the right track.

No girls allowed

June 12, 2014

Categories: Gender

Tracey Lien on Polygon's Friends List podcast:

> *If all the games you're playing exclude women and all the media you're consuming excludes women, that's going to chip away at your mind in some way. It's going to shape your worldview in someway. I think that is potentially damaging to kids growing up playing these games but also to women who are playing them and feeling excluded. There's really no reason for it.*

In light of the recent Assassin's Creed news, this short discussion between Lien and colleague Megan Farokhmanesh hammers at every nail in the Women in Games conversation. Lien is the writer of the No girls allowed, a must-read look back on early video game marketing and the creation of the "boys club" vacuum.

Splatoon

June 12, 2014

Categories: Children, Gender

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8L54s2m1dPs

Paul Tassi, excerpt from Fanboy Wars:

> *But as the industry matured, game makers started creating characters players cared about. Plots were contrived that could actually hold gamers' attention. Players openly wept when Cloud's beloved Aerith died in Final Fantasy VII. They gasped in disbelief during the finale of Star Wars: The Old Republic when it was revealed that the character they controlled was a villain the whole time.*
>
> *Much of this was accomplished with rudimentary pixels and polygons, without anything approaching realistic graphics, the often purely text-based dialogue echoing the silent films of the '20s. Over the last decade, an explosion in gaming technology has allowed games to become almost photorealistic. Characters are sharply drawn, with professional voice actors inhabiting the speaking roles. Scripts take years to write, and stories can take a decade or more to be told over a series of games with three or more installments.*
>
> *When the developers pull off these feats, games can become a transformative storytelling experience. Games actively put the player in the main character's shoes, rather than forcing him or her to exist as a passive observer with no control over the protagonist's actions.*

E3 presented a stark difference between the photorealistic, mature titles presented by Microsoft and Sony contrasted against Nintendo's doubling-down of a vibrant, cartoony atheistic. After listening to Jeff Cannata, Jeff Mattas and Matthew Burnside damn near wax-poetic about *Splatoon* on the latest episode of DLC (along with the success of *Mario Kart 8)*, I am reminded that playful, non-narrative experiences are just as important as photorealistic, "transformative storytelling experiences."

Splatoon as a playful territory shooter comes off as a hyper-realization of the Super Soaker wars I had growing up. Though the characters appear to be asexual, some inference can be made by stereotypically established gender attributes. This comes off as clever, well-thought art direction, allowing those who want to attribute gender to do so while others can be indifferent. Either way, the impact for children (likely the target audience) is immeasurable. The no-brainer act of allowing a child to conquer a map in the gender or appearance that best represents them is a simple way to reinforce a positive message about misguided gender dominance. Regardless of the chosen gender, everyone is on equal footing and contributing to a common goal. Only by allowing gender choice can that message be sent.

Online multiplayer carries a message that opposing virtual characters are exactly representative of the person on the other side. In reality, for all intents and purposes, gender is a near inescapable implication we carry with us, from simple Super Soaker wars to political war rooms. In virtual worlds (especially online), our gender is implied by the avatar we choose. Without choice, we all become the same (likely male) individual.

The state of gaming in mainstream media

June 12, 2014

Categories: Culture



Photo via Polygon.

This is why I write.

Polygon: 'It's getting better: I spent an entire day at E3 playing as women characters'

June 12, 2014

Categories: Gender

Elisa Melendez writing for Polygon:

> *When I look at Ubisoft's recent remarks, I can't even feel anger anymore, just dismay and disappointment. I hoped I could enjoy those same feelings of seeing a version of my gender identity, in co-op, with my husband, a French Lilith and Roland of sorts, overthrowing the monarchy one hidden blade at a time. Knowing just how close they came, and the women they had before them, including in their multiplayer outings, is no salve to the wound. It's salt.*
>
> *But, then, I remember Nisha and Athena, Val and Maggie, Fiona, Yvette, and Sasha, and the hunter and speeder. I will still probably play Assassin's Creed: Unity, and I will more than likely love it. But maybe not as much as I know I could. That doesn't take away from the fact I spent an entire day at E3 playing different kinds of video games as women characters, and in some cases women of color.*

Great perspective on a side of E3 we unfortunately aren't hearing more about.

The problem with humanoids

June 12, 2014

Categories: Gender, General, Politics, Religion, Sexuality

Scott Benson, animator of Night in the Woods, as quoted by Polygon:

> *I think working with animal characters, which is something I've done in animation work for years, you can identify with it a bit better. If we had made Mae a really specific person with a specific ethnicity and weight, and all this different stuff…*
>
> *I think a lot of people can see themselves in Mae. If we were hyper-specific with our humanoid characters, it becomes more and more exclusive. There is something really inclusive about more abstracted humans.*
>
> *When people draw fan art of Mae, everyone makes her look different. They make her look like themselves. That's exactly what we want.*

I had a lot of trouble writing Splatoon. I'm still not sure it delivers the intended message, or is any good for that matter.

I started with the nugget that games can simply be games, ignoring the fact that the slight variance in asexual character design could be implied as male or female. This thought led me down a rabbit hole. If gender can be construed, what about skin tone, ethnicity, sexuality, political ideals, spirituality? Where does it stop?Humanoid character design, however slight, is a delicate thing.

Gigantic DS

June 13, 2014

Categories: General

Tracey Lien, Polygon:

> *[Takashi] Tezuka told Polygon the people on the tools team typically don't design video game courses — they only build the tools for Nintendo's game designers to use. In this particular instance, the tools team was working on a Mario course editing tool when they decided to pitch it to Tezuka as a standalone game.*

The Wii U GamePad + TV is effectively a gigantic Nintendo DS. Nintendo found success in the interactive second screen experience of the DS. *Mario Maker* seems like a great way to push the GamePad. Rather than pushing a passive off-screen experience, taking a note from the DS is a fantastic idea.

Aside from unboxing my Wii U, I had completely glossed over the GamePad stylus.

Biophilia is headed to classrooms

June 15, 2014

Categories: Education

Vanessa Thorpe, The Guardian:

> *[Björk's] initiative, funded by the Nordic Council, is designed to be non-academic and has already been used in an informal way in Iceland. In an interview with the Observer magazine to be published next week , she said the programme had been "really popular with kids who have ADHD [attention deficit hyperactivity disorder] or dyslexia" because it gets away from the classroom-bound, traditional nature of the Icelandic curriculum. "Unfortunately, it means we have to sit down and write a curriculum, and that's a contradiction."*

Biophilia was such a brave and ambitious project (I expect nothing less of Björk). Stellar news.

Nintendo And The Future Of Kids' Games

June 15, 2014

Categories: General

Jordan Shapiro, Forbes: E3 From A Father's Perspective

A great run down of Nintendo's E3 offerings. It sounds more and more like the Big N stole the show, and without a live press event mind you.

Fanboy Wars

June 16, 2014

Categories: Business, Culture

Forbes writer Paul Tassi's *Fanboy Wars* focuses on the fifteen-year span between the early 2000s and today's gaming empire and the intense impact "fanboys" have had. It details the beginning of the Sony and Microsoft living room war to Facebook's $2 billion Oculus acquisition. This quick 70-odd page read acts as a great refresher for those with interest in the space and a primer for those looking to familiarize themselves with the modern industry while trimming the fat of history.

Following the likes of Jane McGonigal, Tassi needs face-time to preach the power behind fanboyism. His ideas are a realization that today there exists a single community manifesting great power in an unlikely place; a community that can course correct multi-billion dollar companies yet heartless enough to lay waste to its own kind. While only the tip of the iceberg, I fear that the book will only fall on a choir of gaming peace-keepers and business types rolling their eyes at the idealism found in the pages.

My one large critique of *Fanboy Wars* is Tassi's neglect to mention the seemingly poisoned and downtrodden heart of the industry: Developers. While he spend much time lamenting over harsh criticism developers receive from fanboys, he skips over the harsh reality developers face in studio turnover. His miss at the potential upside of Xbox One's DRM for industry devs leaves his argument a bit unbalanced. Whether or not Microsoft's original DRM strategy would have been a boon against the industry's continuous and tragic staff up/layoff pattern remains to be seen, but even a brief adage about the potential benefits to a new console experience would have been refreshing. Hopefully this insight will be saved for Tassi's next piece.

All told, Tassi mustered up a quick, easy-to-digest summary of today's gaming world. While his grander message is a realization of the incredible power in oft-scorned fanboyism, *Fanboy Wars* doesn't offer much depth for those already harboring intense focus on the industry; however, the book works as a great catch-up for new comers to the industry. Here's to hoping that *Fanboy Wars* is a prelude to a something greater.

Console sales jump 95% in May

June 17, 2014

Categories: Business

Luke Karmali, IGN:

> *The NPD Group's video game sales report for the month reveals that console sales jumped up a massive 95 percent year-on-year to $586 million, with console software sales also climbing 57 percent to $274 million.*
>
> *Titles singled out for praise on the games front include Watch Dogs and Mario Kart 8, with the latter being largely responsible for Wii U sales jumping up 85 percent despite only being on sale for two days of the month. Despite this, the Wii U was edged out by Nintendo's 3DS handheld, which took second place behind Sony's PS4 in terms of the best-selling hardware of the month.*

Software sells hardware. This is impressive for all systems considering the spike occurred before E3. I'm really looking forward to June's figures. My money is on Wii U. Hail Mario.

Personality

June 17, 2014

Categories: Business, General

Griffin McElroy, senior editor at Polygon in an interview with The Indoor Kids:

> *When we founded Polygon, it was based on the idea that there are games writers who are out there who are really bright and really good at what they do. We wanted it to be a little bit more personality based, not entirely about us but I think there is some value to, "I have writers that I adore, I'm going to value them higher." There's not a lot of demand for that.*

I used to follow IGN incessantly. At times I felt like an addict, continually refreshing their page for the more news. I began contributing blog posts in the hopes of offering more content, one of which was featured.

Then I stumbled upon Polygon. At first glance, there was promise; however, based on prior viewing habits, I was disappointed by the content. While I was initially attracted to their modern design, I looked at the abundance of larger features and opinions as pretentious... Until I decided focus on their writers.

Polygon is now my go-to games site. I constantly find myself scrolling through their feed, scanning for new pieces from Chris Plante, The Brothers McElroy, or Grumpa Kuchera. My Twitter feed is littered with the likes of Danielle Riendeau and Phil Kollar. On occasion, a piece from Brian Crecente will spark curiosity. Last year I deemed Tracey Lien "Journalist of the Year." I will go as far as to say that the work of the Polygon team inspired me to read... inspired me to write.

That's not to say I dislike IGN's features. Justin Davis continually pulls at my nostalgic heartstrings, and I don't think I ever read a piece by Keza MacDonald (now of Kotaku UK) I didn't agree with. The problem is that most of the content feels like the voice of IGN, not the voice of the writer.

Baseball diehards can tell you the subtleties in team dynamics. There can be diversity under the same umbrella. Many more sites need to embrace the privilege of instant educated opinion. If the games community cannot foster intelligent conversation on its own, someone must lead the way.

Generally, if I dislike a highly anticipated album upon first listen, it ends up becoming one of my favorites. I hated Cursive's "The Ugly Organ," anything by Mark Kozelek, and The Beatles; now I can't stop listening. I felt the same about Polygon; now I can't stop reading.

Compliance for positive females, negative males

June 17, 2014

Categories: Gender

ScienceDirect:

> *We found support for the hypothesis that, in general, women would gain more compliance with friend requests than men. We also found support for the hypothesis that women making positive utterances would gain more compliance with friend requests than women making negative utterances, whereas men making negative utterances would gain more compliance with friend requests than men making positive utterances.*

This sounds in-line with Rosalind Wiseman and Ashly Burch's findings.

Not from school

June 17, 2014

Categories: Education

Lorne Lanning, creator of Oddworld in an interview with Polygon:

> *I'm a kid who learned how to read from Sesame Street, not from school, so I believe in the power of media to make a better world.*

I had an eerily similar thought this morning. I'm a kid who learned how to type from AIM, not from school, so I believe in the power of experiential learning to make a better world. This is something I believe to be at the heart of video games.

There is no failure here, just change.

June 17, 2014

Categories: General

Russ Pitts:

> *There will be those cynical few who consider my departure an admission of some kind of failure that they, watching from the sidelines, predicted long ago. They will say, "I told you so." And that's OK. They're right. They did tell us so. But that was the easy part.*
>
> *Throwing rocks from the gallery at those who are trying to do something ambitious is no great accomplishment. I'd rather be the one who rolls up his sleeves and tries to accomplish something inspiring, even if it may fail. Even if it won't last.*
>
> *But there is no failure here, just change. I'll never be ashamed of the ambitious dreams we built at Polygon, and I'll never be afraid to try again. Hopefully my modest successes will inspire others to do their own great, ambitious things and build their own dreams.*

There is a sinking feeling in my gut. No sooner had I posted this, I learn of Russ Pitts' departure from Polygon. For those unfamiliar with Pitts, his work on Operation Supply Drop and GlassLab are nothing short of earth-shattering. There is only a bright future for such a talented writer. Godspeed.

Free speech and online creeps

June 18, 2014

Categories: General

Jessica Valenti of The Guardian on Elonis v. United States: whether threats made on social media are protected by free speech.

> *No one is arguing that people can't say hateful things or call people names; the emails I get calling me a "slut" and a "feminazi" are immoral, but they're not (and shouldn't be) illegal. Threats and the invasion of privacy, though, are different – even in the most public of places: your right to be a "creep" doesn't trump everyone else's right to a life free from violence and the fear of it.*

Real-world interaction

June 18, 2014

Categories: Culture

Max Temkin, creator of Cards Against Humanity in an interview with Wired:

> *There's something super addictive and super satisfying about just sitting down with your friends and having that real-world experience. I think a lot of the times people play Cards [Against Humanity], they have this great time and they often attribute it to the game, but it's really just that the game was the pretext for them to sit down and have this real world interaction.*

Card games typically imply real world interaction because they are (in large part) physical items. For an industry founded on arcades, schoolyard stories, and fighting over controllers, it's funny how quickly the notion of local multi-player gaming seemed to disappear the near instant consoles integrated online multi-player. I won't wax poetic about my recent experience playing Mario Kart 8 again, but there is a magic in local multi-player gaming.

Dual GamePad play

June 18, 2014

Categories: General

Shigeru Miyamoto on dual GamePad play as quoted by IGN:

> *From a technical standpoint, I think if we decided to pursue that, technically we would be able to and we can perform system updates that would allow for that. It's also very interesting from a gameplay perspective idea because there are a lot of possibilities with two GamePads. But, at the same time, taking that kind of approach would again be a drain on resources and require us to continue to utilize our development resources for that. So then it would become a question of where do we want to devote our resources: Is it to creating regular GamePad games, or creating games centered around two GamePads?*

Nintendo's E3 digital event proved they are only scratching the surface of single GamePad interactivity. While it would show the power and unique experience of the Wii U, they are right to focus resources on foundation over decor.

The road ahead

June 18, 2014

Categories: Business

Chris Grant, Polygon's editor-in-chief:

> *This month, we lost some of our team. This includes Russ Pitts, one of the founding editors of the site, along with Tom Connors and Adam Barenblat, two of the most talented and hardest-working people we had. These decisions are never easy, and Russ, Tom and Adam are people I have considered, and will still consider, friends.*
>
> *We never thought starting a video game outlet in 2012 (has it been that long already?) was going to be easy and we've learned a lot in the last two years. We learned that there's an incredible opportunity to tell in-depth stories about the people — both fans and creators — that make video games what they are. But we've also learned exactly how hard it is to do that with consistency and how much appetite there is for that kind of coverage.*
>
> *We're very proud of the feature writing and video work we've done, but producing that content is expensive and requires that all (or at least nearly all) of those pieces are smash hits. When you're publishing two to three pieces like that a week, bringing in the audiences day in and day out is tougher than we'd imagined it would be way back in 2012. Lesson learned.*
>
> *Will Polygon still make incredible features? We absolutely will. What will change is the frequency.*

As previously stated, Pitts is a hell of a writer. As for Connors and Barenblat, their work inspired me to revisit my dreams of working in film and became the hook for my fondness of Polygon. I'd have happily paid for any of their features.

Rare and Lionhead are Crown Jewels

June 19, 2014

Categories: General

Phil Harrison, Microsoft Studios Europe, in an interview with Eurogamer:

> *We are very fortunate in having Rare and Lionhead in the UK as crown jewels of Microsoft Studios.*
>
> *Rare is working on a couple of things at the moment, which we will announce at the right time. But I'm really excited by the things they're doing and I believe you will be as well when you hear about them.*

At E3 2014, Nintendo won over the hearts and respect of longtime fans by investing in first-party favorites, doubling-down on the Mushroom Kingdom, and acknowledging classic IP. Microsoft is not blind to the effectiveness of this move.

Killer Instinct was rebooted last year and Conker is making his way into *Project Spark*. My suspicions still lie here.

#stopTDV game jam

June 19, 2014

Categories: Culture

Polygon:

> *Jam entries will focus on teen emotional wellness and deal with issues including physical and online bullying, dating violence, suicide prevention and depression.*

A Life Well Wasted

June 19, 2014

Categories: Culture, History

An internet radio show about videogames and the people who love them.

I am revisiting Robert Ashley's A Life Well Wasted. If you're a fan of *Radiolab*, the music of *I Come To Shanghai* or Jim Guthrie, and culture and history, you should be listening too.

Disrupting racism and sexism

June 20, 2014

Categories: Gender, Race

Sarah Jeong of The Guardian on the anonymous nature if Uber:

> *It's doubtful that Uber specifically set out to improve the lives of African-Americans. But the company accidentally did something that anti-discrimination statutes and awareness-raising campaigns were unlikely to ever achieve. It's not exactly a huge blow to racism, but still: technology is changing how people of color experience and are represented in the world, and it's all the more remarkable that much of this was never intended in the first place.*

A very interesting read on technology's inadvertent effects on racial and gender discrimination.

Console Wars: Game Gear

June 20, 2014

Categories: History

Excerpt from "Console Wars" by Blake J. Harris:

> *Kalinske nodded, returning to the moment. But before the girl could fix him a drink, she suddenly became transfixed by the Game Gear and, as with the well-dressed man, the world suddenly shrunk around her. Well, would you look at that, Kalinske mused, while having a revelation that would shape Sega, the videogame industry, and the face of entertainment as a whole. Videogames weren't just for kids; they were for anyone who wanted to feel like a kid. Anyone who missed the freedom and innocence that comes with endless wonder. Videogames were for everyone; they just didn't realize it yet.*

I vividly remember seeing the Game Gear for the first time. A neighbor boy of my grandmother's showed off *Shinobi* on the sidewalk in front of her house. Coming from the colorless world of Game Boy, the idea of rescuing different colored ninjas was a revelation. Until then, I had to imagine what Mega Man and the Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles looked like in full color. Say what you will about its viewing angle, the Game Gear was magic to me.

Queue Dodge

June 20, 2014

Categories: Business

Riot Games:

> *From the beginning, we've focused on culture. We operate on a foundation of shared mission, values, passion, trust, and mutual respect. If someone gags on the unique flavor of our culture, they'd be doing themselves and the company a disservice to hang on just for the paycheck. Culturally aligned people and teams are more effective, and alignment around mission and values allows us to better serve players. We've designed Queue Dodge to help self-identified mismatches move on in an open, positive, and constructive way.*

Quit with 10% salary up to $25,000 within 60 days of employment. Interesting; however, most find it takes 6-8 months to feel at home. I wonder if a decision at a yearly evaluation would be better or too late; too much invested by both ends to severe ties.

Minecraft: You make the story

June 22, 2014

Categories: Education, General

Harlem Grey writing for Gamer Headlines on Minecraft:

> *The indie sand box game that would rock the world and give indie developers recognition. The other games on my list did great things for their genre, Minecraft revolutionized what it means to be indie. Low budget, little support, one man developing it. The Alpha was released on PC in 2009 and would later on rise in popularity, many updates saw the growth from the alpha into the game we have today. Minecraft fully represents the quote at the top of the page, it's not the most beautifully detailed game, it has no story but the success of this game is all from you. You make the story, the world and the character in the simplest way.*

Last week in my office, a mother brought her son to work and stationed him in an unused cubicle. He was equipped with nothing but a MacBook Air and headphones. Hours later, my colleague whispered for my attention and told me to look into the boy's cubicle. Like the rare sight of a beaver build a dam, my colleague and I quietly watched in amazement.

This kid was flying through the world of Minecraft at breakneck speed, building up and tearing down the environment, crafting explosives to drill into its natural water-supply. He was architecting the world in his imagination in real-time. Unlike our need to buy specific LEGO sets for certain pieces we required, his limits were overcome with a quick toggle to YouTube a video teaching new techniques.

This jumping back-and-forth between learning and application, curiosity and realization, and the drive to engineer a universe was incredible to watch. Minecraft has the power to unlock imagination in ways we only dreamed of as children.

Sunday side note: Phil Collins

June 22, 2014

Categories: Music

Katie Drummond, The Verge:

> *I love Phil Collins because his melodies are catchy as hell. I love him because his lyrics are often unintentionally hilarious and he just owns them anyways. I love him because that 3:40 drum crash on "In The Air Tonight" gets me every damn time.*
>
> *Mock me all you want. After all, this isn't a salute to the prowess of Deadmau5 or Pharrell or some other musical act you won't be ruthlessly derided for appreciating. But guess what? Phil Collins makes catchy tunes, catchy tunes are fun to listen to, and you're probably not as cool as you think you are anyways. So pour a glass of wine, close all the curtains, and get ready…to dance into the light.*

The master of pop hooks; the harbinger of gated reverb; the purveyor of heartbreak and melancholy. Sounding a bit like a robot is pretty awesome too. One of my top 5 favorite artists, no shame.

Great picks, Katie. Now, back to that musical adaption of *Bicentennial Man* I've been working on…

Siracusa on the end of humanity

June 23, 2014

Categories: General

John Siracusa, Accidental Tech Podcast #70, 5:34-9:28:

> *Are video games more like apps or more like movies? I mean this in one specific respect that I don't think we touched on. Although we didn't bring this up in the show specifically, the whole "personal computers are like trucks" metaphor that has been discussed that I think Steve Jobs wrote up many years ago, and that people don't need a Mac Pro to post to Facebook and read websites and check their email and stuff. Despite the fact that the Mac Pro does all of these amazing things, they're probably not going to use them.*
>
> *The amount of technology we have and the features available far exceed what any person is ever going to want to to with it. That's why I say it's like apps, I guess I should have said is it more like a computer where we know personal computer technology is available now that is far beyond the needs of what regular people want to do with computers.*
>
> *I'm comparing that to movies where the technology available to make movies has gotten better by leaps an bounds. You could take the crappiest blockbuster movie like Transformers back in time fifty years and show it to somebody, and on first viewing they would not have been able to compute how terrible the movie was because they would be amazed at the visuals. They would be like, "This is magic. I don't understand where this came from. This must be an alien artifact," because they wouldn't understand how we put all those visuals on the screen.*
>
> *I think (in movies anyway) the mass market appetite for increasingly amazing things is not satisfied. It's not like, "Well, you know, once we can do reasonable practical effects like Raiders of the Lost Arc, that's all we'll ever need. There's no upside to making it better. People don't need the Mac Pro of movies, they've got by perfectly fine with the iMac. Stick with the feature set that's available on Raiders of the Lost Arc. No need for Jurassic Park. No need for the advances in CGI we have today. No need for all of the CGI used in television shows to do backdrops and stuff. Sets are fine. We've pretty much got this set." I don't think that's the case.*
>
> *It's not like the only people who care about more features, more technology, more amazing stuff are the people who are super into movies and the casual moviegoers are like, "I don't need CGI, practical effects are fine with me." I think the appetite is essentially unlimited for amazing visuals in movies, setting aside the stupidity of scripts and all the other stuff that have always been the same. It's not as if movies got good enough and people are like, "Nah. You don't need to improve them anymore." They keep trying to improve them. It doesn't mean everything they try to do is better. 3D is an attempt to improve it and may or may not be better. Maybe people don't like that. Higher frame-rate, same deal. High-definition television, I think that's an improvement that people say, "Yes. We do like that better." They don't say, "Standard-def's good enough. I'm not a power user of television. I don't need high-definition television." No. As soon as you see high-definition you're like, "Screw that old thing. We want the new thing."*

> *The question about video games is what are they more like? Are they more like the PC where increasing power is like, "Nah. I don't need that." Or is it more like movies where there is seemingly infinite appetite of the mass market for making them better in ways that involve technology and money. I think for video games so far (I don't know if this will always be true), they seem a lot more like movies to me in that any time people say, "What about when a $99 puck gets as powerful as a PlayStation 4, then we're all set, right?" No, because people will still want the power that the PlayStation 5 or 6 offers. Why will they want that? Because they always want that. Because their appetite for better games and better graphics and things that more power can do is unlimited. It's not like a computer where it's like, "You don't need all that technology in that Mac Pro. You just want to check your email."*
>
> *Games are different. If you can have a vast, fully realized, realistic looking city with amazing draw-distances and amazing physics and everything, people want that. They don't know or care how it works, they're playing the game. It's much different than using the computer to do something.*
>
> *I know the appetite isn't exhaustible, but we haven't exhausted it yet.*
>
> *...*
>
> *We never get to the point where games are good enough and then it just stops and stays that way. There's always something more you can do. Even for stupid 2D genres and stuff like that, you can always do something more with more technology, with more memory, with more sensors, with more "who knows what." That more than anything is going to keep the $400 boxes alive for much longer than I think people think.*

Marco adds a bit about how he doesn't know anyone that cares about the best graphics except people who self-describe as gamers.

Siracusa continues:

> *It's not just better graphics. That's the whole problem. Ya, maybe only the self-described gamers care about this and purchase on it, but there's enough of them to sustain the market. For everything else, as that technology increases, new types of games become possible. You couldn't do live-action Lord of the Rings without computer effects. You just couldn't film that. You could do it with puppets maybe or people in costumes but it just would not have the kind of appeal. You don't need to know or care about the technology involved in making that to appreciate Lord of the Rings. Not to get hung up on the high-def versus standard-def but it's about what's on the screen. You can do different kinds of things.*
>
> *If you were to take any current game developer and say, "What if I gave you 100,000x the memory, the bandwidth, the whatever, what could you do?" They wouldn't just make their existing games with more polygons and higher-res textures. They would be like, "With that, I could make make a different kind of game. I could make a hiking **simulator** that people will love." At a certain point you get to the holodeck. There's different categories of games, especially with physics and materials. With a lot of the things you do in games, everything feels like a set where it's just a rigid polygon with predefined destructive things. Once technology gets to the point where you can do real, arbitrary destructibility, whole new...*

> *people who weren't so interested in games before suddenly be interested if they can realistically take a baseball bat through a showroom of super-cars and it doesn't just feel like you're triggering a bunch of destruction animations.*

Marco:

> *We'll have to rethink cities.*

Siracusa:

> *There's different categories of games you can have. The hiking **simulator** thing is a joke I had when I was a kid but I'll bet there probably is a hiking **simulator** now. We've gotten to a point where the visuals in games are enough that people who are only interested in visuals would never have been interested in 16-bit games and NES games and Pong or anything like that. But suddenly, when games start to pass some threshold of realism, whole new categories of people become interested. Even if it's only like the "dear hunter" **simulator** type things. Those people were not interested in playing Super Mario Bros., but once you can **simulate** dear hunting in a way that they find appealing, suddenly you open up an entire new market.*
>
> *I think the insatiable appetite for better technology for games isn't because people know or care or understand the technology, it's the same as the insatiable appetite for increasingly ridiculous visuals, again Transformers, despite the fact that the rest of the movie is terrible, people go see these movies because the visuals are amazing. You say, "They're amazing now but they can't get anymore amazing. Surely, ten years from now, the visuals will be exactly the same and no person will ever go into a movie and be wowed." I don't think that's the case. I think people will always want to see something amazing. I think people will always want to play something amazing. I think increases in technology will only open the market because you'll be able to do different things, not just the same things we're doing now, but fancier.*

Marco adds a bit on risk and the marginalization of power vs. affordability/portability. He uses the example that box offices sales are getting worse as people have more to do than just see a movie.

> *Spreading attention is one thing. No one can help if suddenly too many things are going on and people just get spread too thin. That could happen to anything: TVs, movies, anything like that.*
>
> *The one thing video games has going for it is, conceptually if not into the specifics of a box that you connect to your TV, games are basically at the end of the line, tapping their foot impatiently saying, "You guys can do whatever you want, TV, movies, live theater, music, all that other stuff, but we'll be here in the end when you're all gone because our logical conclusion is the holodeck which will sort of end humanity." Because once you can realistically **simulate** anything and not distinguish it from real life, we'll just be dead in our little virtual-reality sensor-tubes within ten years.*
>
> *That's the endgame. The endgame is omnipotence; the illusion of omnipotence. Know everything, do everything, indistinguishable from reality. That's going to come out of gaming. It's not going to come out of television, it's not going to come out of live theater, it's not going to come out of music. Gaming is trying to get there. It's not going to get there in*

> *our lifetime (obviously), but way out, thousands of years in the future, games are the only form of anything and eventually destroy the entire human race.*
>
> *Gaming has that one good thing going for it in that it's not going to go away and if we do get spread to thin because of other factors, it'll come back because it's at the end of the line waiting for all of us.*

There have been many arguments about the term "video game" and what it actually means in today's world. Many "games" no longer incorporate elements of games (e.g. *Journey*), causing critics to coin terms like "interactive experiences." I think Siracusa's talk shines light on a better word for modern games (especially first-person design) that has been right under our noses: Simulations.

There are games (e.g. *Super Mario Bros.*, *Uncharted*), there are simulations (e.g.. *Journey*, *Dear Esther, Gran Turismo*), and there are those that incorporate both (e.g. *Halo*, *Mario Kart*). The problem is that no one wants to hear the term "simulation." For most, simulations have been boring since *Flight Simulator 2000*. On the other hand, games have been fun for centuries.

As we move closer to an Oculus future, we move further away from "video games." If anything, I'd argue that the term "video game" does more harm than good for the industry's larger appeal, carrying the baggage of a childish activity regardless of what studies show. "Simulation" may not be perfect the perfect term but it's a word that should be incorporated more often.

"An intensity I'd never felt before in a game."

June 23, 2014

Categories: General

Arun Rath, NPR's All Things Considered, experiencing ADR1FT using Oculus Rift at E3:

> *Honestly, I don't care about the goal of the game. I was just so excited to be in outer space. I could happily spend hours just exploring the environment. But here's the weirdest part of the experience - I had this deeply emotional feeling of being transported, an intensity I'd never felt before in a game. [Adam] Orth says he wants to set a motion to take gamers beyond the standard, violent, action games.*

Orth:

> *And there's nothing wrong with those games. They're great. I love them, and I have made them, and I play them. But I don't want to make them any more. And I want to tell emotional stories. And that device is allowing me to tell them in a way that I was not able to do it before.*

Simulation.

Video Games: The Movie Trailer

June 23, 2014

Categories: General, History

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ETSKGdtrMK8

Should be a fun look back if nothing else.

1987 Nintendo

June 24, 2014

Categories: Business, History

Excerpt from "Console Wars" by Blake J. Harris:

> *[Peter] Main's approach to sales and marketing coincided with [Minoru] Arakawa's overarching philosophy of "quality over quantity." As Nintendo exploded, there were plenty of opportunities to make a quick buck (hardware upgrades, unnecessary peripherals), exploit the company's beloved characters (movies, theme parks), or dilute the brand by trying attract an audience older than Nintendo's six-to-fourteen-year-olds. But these kinds of things didn't interest Arakawa. He wasn't driven by making money, at least not in the short term. What propelled him, what kept him up at night, was a desire to continually provide Nintendo's customers with a unique and flawless user experience. As proof of this never-ending obsession, he set up a toll-free telephone line where Nintendo "Game Counselors" were available all day to help players get through difficult levels, and he initiated the Nintendo Fun Club, which sent a free newsletter to any customer who had sent in a warranty card. Both programs were very costly and could have been offset by charging small fees or obtaining sponsorship, but Arakawa believed that doing so would compromise Nintendo's mission.*

Not a whole lot has changed.

IGDA surveys 2,200 devs on industry perception

June 24, 2014

Categories: Culture, Work

Tracey Lien, Polygon:

> *When it came to the factors influencing society's negative view of games and the people who make them, 68 percent of respondents said reports of the industry's working conditions were a contributing factor. Sexism in games followed closely at 67 percent. 62 percent of respondents named the perceived link to violence as a factor. 51 percent said sexism in the workforce was a problem, while 49 percent attributed the negative perception to the perceived link to obesity. 42 percent of respondents blamed the lack of overall diversity in the industry.*

Minecraft enforces EULA

June 25, 2014

Categories: Business

Keith Stuart, The Guardian:

> *The grievance many Minecraft fans had was simple: although these terms had always been present in Mojang's Minecraft EULA, they had never been enforced over the three years since the game's launch. Mojang had always fostered a laissez faire sensibility; it had pushed Minecraft as an open platform, freely customisable by both players and server providers. But now it was tightening the leash. And people were angry.*

Never say never. Mojang is in the right. If you are going to build a business under a given set of rules, comply and seek community-fueled change with the first-party for the future. While many will ask for Mojang to target the bad apples, the scale of a piecemeal crackdown would be nigh impossible to complete given the global nature of the greater Minecraft server spread. Their EULA was built with this in mind.

'Yes, vinyl prices are going up. No, I don’t feel bad.'

June 25, 2014

Categories: Business

Jason Tate:

> *And if there’s anything I’ve learned by reading the posts of music listeners online for over a decade: they hate when bands make money. I’m only half kidding here, but I can’t think of any other industry where I’ve seen the consumer of a product be downright caustic if the creator is turning even a marginal profit.*

Great short read. A small reason for my excitement at Xbox One's original DRM strategy.

Android & Playstation TV

June 26, 2014

Categories: Business

John Gruber:

> *The most surprising (to me) part of Google's Android TV announcement today was that Sony would be integrating it into their 2015 TV sets. Why in the world would Sony agree to integrate what is obviously a direct competitor to Playstation TV in its own TV sets?*

Subsidization? Lack of confidence? A Google play for PlayStation cross-branding? Vice versa?

I don't think Sony is terribly worried about Android's role in gaming, especially against Sony's library of PlayStation back-catalog (though, maybe it should be). At the same time, incorporating other Google services (media and otherwise) will likely serve as a marketing boon for Sony. Nonetheless, it is an odd move.

Whack-A-Mole

June 26, 2014

Categories: Education

Jordan Shapiro, Forbes:

> *By themselves, gameplay actions seem fairly meaningless. For example, most first person shooters are essentially just complex three dimensional virtual simulations of the carnival classic: whack-a-mole. We've seen it with many different skins and themes: military, zombie, duck hunting, dinosaurs. Something pops up and the player needs to react quickly–strike a moving target before you miss your chance.*

Well put. Great piece.

Level 1-1

June 26, 2014

Categories: Design

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZH2wGpEZVgE

> *Of all the 8-bit greats, Super Mario Bros. has some of the best examples of well used affordances and well designed learning curves, and it does it all without blocks of text or requiring people to actually read the manual.*

Level 1-1 or World 1-1? Either way, great video. Go Right.

Freemium v. Premium

June 27, 2014

Categories: Business

Neil McFarland, director of games at Ustwo (Monument Valley), as quoted by Gamesindustry.biz:

> *Freemium effectively focuses on a niche - they just happen to be whales who spend unlimited amounts of money. Despite freemium games being seemingly for everyone, they're not really.*
>
> *...*
>
> *[Premium's] clearly not the best business model, but it was about our passion and the need to communicate something about gaming; a meaningful contribution to the medium, and to not overstay our welcome. Just give people something and that's it - we're not going to press you for endless hours of your time.*

I thank the team at Ustwo for a fulfilling and concise experience. Only 90 minutes yet the sights and sounds of Monument Valley still linger in my mind. Relinking my review here.

Looking forward to the release of the Monument Valley original soundtrack by Stafford Bawler, Obfusc & Grigori.

#LikeAGirl

June 27, 2014

Categories: Gender

http://youtu.be/XjJQBjWYDTs

Hacking, puzzle-boxes and company culture

June 28, 2014

Categories: Business, Gender

Lucy Boyes on her Boyes Club blog:

> *The second example of hacking – the magical shortcut approach – is a whole different problem. It's fine for inanimate objects and codebases, assuming the "magic" does actually work, but in the context of human beings it's an appalling way to operate. The idea that you can "hack" human things – people, culture, communications, you name it – is at least somewhat predicated on the puzzle box mentality. The linked example describes a particular way of perceiving women which can lead men (assuming this is a cis, hetero scenario) to believe that there's a magic combination of words, actions and/or behaviours which will convince a woman to give up the "prize" of sex to men who figure out the puzzle. It's a mentality which keeps pickup artist in lucrative business selling books and lecture dates. And this leads to all kinds of not-okay behaviours, like persistent stalking, harassment, creeping, etc., because the dude's entire framework of belief tells him that if he just keeps trying hard enough he will eventually unlock the magic sex box.*

Awesome, and it gets better…

> *This pertains to hacking culture thusly: the myth of the incredible founder, while it exists, legitimises doing fucking stupid shit to your people in the name of culture. The guy in charge thinks he's in charge because he's The Best. He succeeded by being The Best. And the most obvious way to make the company more successful as a whole is for everyone to be More Like Him. Which is why so many startups have crippling long-hours cultures (and lionise said crippling cultures even as everyone is balls-deep in the business of burning out), and why the culture and how the company relates to people is allowed to be run according to the whimsy of someone who hasn't spent long enough thinking about how the world works to realise the unlikelihood, the tenuousness, of their own success. They drink their own Kool-Aid, and then they make everyone else drink it too.*

Terrific read. Worth every word. Follow up with Klei.

Games Done Quick raises $700,000

June 29, 2014

Categories: Charity

Polygon:

> *Summer Games Done Quick, the mid-year fund raiser of Speed Demos Archive, nearly tripled the amount it raised in 2013, hauling in $713,000 over a week long stretch, the proceeds of which go to Doctors Without Borders.*

Mindshift

June 30, 2014

Categories: Education, Health

Fast Company:

> *A platform that changes the input to a simulation or video game based on the user's physiological state.*

Alan Pope, NASA Scientist, as quoted by Fast Company:

> *In terms of applications, we're looking for places where this can be deployed as a form of entertainment and also training. There are a number of situations where someone could be trained using a video game-like task. It could be sharpshooters in the military, surgeons who would need to control their attention and anxiety--any kind of task that puts pressure on someone while they're performing the task with their hands or manually.*

While I struggle with my internal "simulation" v. "video game" terminology debate, I thought I'd share this neat interactive mechanic.

New technology

June 30, 2014

Categories: History

Excerpt from “Console Wars" by Blake J. Harris:

> *Uemura’s Super Famicom dazzled on numerous fronts. The new console could generate 32,768 unique colors (the Genesis had 512) and eight channels of audio (the Genesis had six), and it could retail for 25,000 yen (about $250). Yet despite his best efforts, Uemura was unable to incorporate backward compatibility without greatly increasing the price (by about $75). Yamauchi discussed this issue with his son-in-law, Minoru Arakawa, who harbored plans to soon release a U.S. version of the system. Arakawa pointed out that compact discs had recently begun to replace cassette tapes and vinyl records without causing much of a stir. Perhaps modern consumers were becoming savvy enough to realize that new technology tended to make previous iterations obsolete. They concluded that Nintendo was strong enough to deal with the possible backlash and couldn’t afford to hold off on a 16-bit system any longer.*

I'm having too much fun with this book. An entertaining David and Goliath story for the modern era, chock-full of video game nostalgia and fantastic trivia that went right over the heads of my generation. Not to mention plenty of "history repeats itself" moments.

App: The Human Story

July 1, 2014

Categories: Children, Design, Education

Björn Jeffery, Toca Boca:

> *Making apps for children: it's not a perfect science, it's more like art. This is sort of shaping kids' memories of them growing up. That's a big responsibility. That's something we should be taking very seriously.*

A big responsibility indeed.

'App: The Human Story' looks to be an extremely compelling, promising and well crafted documentary about the history and future of apps. The roster isn't half bad either.

Bioware intros first gay male character

July 1, 2014

Categories: Sexuality

David Gaider, Dragon Age series writer:

> *Dorian is gay—he is, in fact, the first fully gay character I've had the opportunity to write. It added an interesting dimension to his back story, considering he comes from a place where "perfection" is the face that every mage puts on and anything that smacks of deviancy is shameful and meant to be hidden.*
>
> *...*
>
> *I suppose this aspect of Dorian will make him controversial in some corners, but I was glad to include it. It made writing Dorian a very personal experience for me, and I'm hopeful that will make him seem like a fully realized character to fans in the end.*

I spent last weekend attending a same-sex wedding. Amongst the 150 or so attendees, not a soul spoke ill will or against the act of love. If anything, there was a palpable aura of support for the newly weds. Those I had assumed would turn their nose up to the ceremony watched with vivacious smiles, tears and cheering. The attendees soaked in the ceremony with deep admiration for a couple who had spent 7+ years braving potential criticism, backlash and rejection from their own bloodlines for challenging tradition.

While I was out of town for the wedding, San Francisco was holding its Pride Celebration. While I could not attend, I was very proud to be part of an attending organization who actively (and prominently!) showed their support for those who continue to live in fear, are ignored and cast aside by the mainstream.

Be it two people in marriage; hundreds at work; thousands in school; or millions participating in sports, games and global events; communal bonding is a wonder. To feel included, acknowledged and represented in a community is even more special.

Finnish Hearthstone tournament limited to male participants

July 1, 2014

Categories: eSports, Gender

Ben Kuchera, ladies and gentlemen:

> *Games that, through their very design, seek to give players a level playing field are rare, and should be celebrated by inviting everyone who wants to play to compete. To take such a well-designed and welcoming game and force segregation due to the outdated ideas of your organization is not just wrong, it's offensive. It spits on the spirit of the game and the hard work done to avoid that sort of outmoded thought on competition.*

I'll mention my post on misogyny but it's worth jumping straight to Polygon's 'Where are the women in eSports?'

Update: The IeSF has reversed its decision.

Blizzard:

> *One of our goals with eSports is to ensure that there's a vibrant and also inclusive community around our games. We do not allow the use of our games in tournaments that do not support this, and are working with our partners to ensure they share the same goal.*

Worth relinking to Humanity in Hearthstone.

Oddworld and Malcolm X

July 1, 2014

Categories: Culture, Design, History

Lorne Lanning, creator of Oddworld, in an interview with Wired:

> *I wanted to drive inspiring characters who felt low, like I did, who was in deep crisis, but by just sticking to it, they could prevail through a way that was almost entirely empathetic and not aggressive. We didn't want the stereotypical musclebound hero with a gun. I was never a big Schwarzenegger or action fan. It never inspired me.*
>
> *...*
>
> *Stranger was a tough character with a different kind of dilemma. The reason he doesn't like guns is because his whole life he's been sought after and had to disguise himself. That was inspired by Malcolm X. He was an amazing figure and in the movie Spike Lee does this scene where he's in prison and straightening his hair with acid. This older guy schools him and say that's not him, he's trying to be something he's not. That's a pivotal moment, where a strong, brilliant character feels so overwhelmed that he tries to be something else, but when he accepts who he is he becomes something amazing.*

Worth reblogging Lanning's stance on education through media.

Console Love?

July 2, 2014

Categories: Business

Keith Stuart, The Gaurdian:

> *Perhaps the newfound respect is a sign that the industry has matured. The average age of a gamer now is 35, and you can't refuse to talk to the marketing executive at your firm because they own an Xbox One not a PlayStation 4 so they smell. At the same time, consoles are no longer the kings of the gaming block. Smartphones have created a massive new audience of casual players, and the PC has had something of a renaissance thanks to the Steam digital games service and the rise of indie developments like Minecraft. It's not me v you in consoles anymore, it's us v them.*
>
> *In some ways it's a shame. Great game design, great art even (OK, let's not go there right now), is born from conflict and chaos, not from cosy chats and shared admiration. Grudging respect is fine, but I half yearn for the days when we spent so long with our consoles of choice that they became part of our identity, and identity is always forged in opposition.*

I don't think we can be so naïve to think that the "console war" discussions of old are not still happening behind closed doors. I believe the PR for both companies are wise to the impact of negative, name-calling campaigns under the magnifying glass of social media. They are also likely to avoid the same negative lambasting mirrored in online communities, a now infamous trait of the video game industry.

Perhaps the biggest reason the battle has turned into "us v them" goes back to the HD Twins conversation. Both consoles are so strikingly similar (especially now, with the removal of DRM and Kinect from Xbox One) that there isn't much weight behind console v console jabs. If anything, this argument now lives on in the HD Twins v Wii U conversation.

To add, the 2014 E3 press conferences for both Sony and Microsoft appeared to mirror the other's message from the previous year. In 2013, Sony was heavy handed on games. In 2014, that message was delivered by Microsoft. Likewise, Microsoft's 2013 E3 messaging was miscellaneous media services such as all-in-one entertainment and exclusive TV shows. This appeared to be the underlying message in Sony's 2014 conference.

Lastly, as if I haven't spoken of it enough, Console Wars by Blake J. Harris is an entertaining read about the Nintendo v Sega console wars during the late '80s / early '90s. Worth your while.

Pixel Art

July 3, 2014

Categories: Design

Sam Byford, The Verge:

> *Instead, pixel art is best thought of as video gaming's most characteristic visual style, one that was forged throughout the history of the medium and is inextricably linked to it.*

A great post at The Verge today. Pixel art is and forever will be the most emblematic representation of the video game medium.

Adam Saltsman, creator of *Canabalt*:

> *Pixel art doesn't always spell everything out. It can be pretty minimalist and evocative that way. Often when you are looking at pixel art you are seeing more than is actually there.*

After Nintendo released *The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time 3D* in 2011 (a remastering of 1998's original *LoZ: OoT*), many were quick to point out that it had been rebuilt as the game you remember, not the game it actually was. Our imaginations have the wondrous ability to fill in blanks and fill out details that may not actually be there. This seems to be the reason I have no quandary with the evolution of Mario. I have never questioned this:



from this:



Red cap, mustache, overalls? Sure, that's Mario.

Egoraptor just harshly criticized Ocarina of Time on the Internet

July 3, 2014

Categories: Design

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XOC3vixnj_0

> *Is looking around a room and finding an eyeball in a wall really super fun for people? Like, the game is 3D now so everything isn't laid out before you like a map anymore, so I get that there's this sense that you walk into a room and aren't getting all the information about the room right away. But is stopping your forward motion, stopping everything to look for a diamond to whack that's in a soulless crevasse in the wall so you can open a door that leads to another room with a locked door and some other silly open-sesame trick... is that fun?! Is this what you want?!*
>
> *Let me explain something. A puzzle is something you have all the information for. The only thing standing between you and the solution is your own ability to put the pieces together in the right way. The satisfaction you obtain from solving a puzzle is from the "a-ha!" moment when the pieces fit and you have only yourself to blame for it.*
>
> *If you're missing a piece, how are you even supposed to get to a conclusion? You rack your brain; run in circles; go, "what do I fucking do?!" until you find the last piece on a whim and suddenly it all makes sense. You say, "Well shit!" or, "Ah, come on!" The satisfaction doesn't come from the door opening, it comes from the puzzle itself. If the puzzle itself isn't satisfying, well there you go. The puzzle itself isn't satisfying.*

Arin Hanson just ripped apart my favorite game, and I am very okay with that. Great video on game design and (ultimately) Nintendo's return to the origins of the Zelda franchise. Worth every second.

Mario Kart 8 lifts console sales more than Titanfall or Second Son

July 5, 2014

Categories: Business

Tim Ellis, GeekWire:

> *According to console sales data from VGChartz, Nintendo was selling an average of about 29,000 Wii U consoles per week prior to Mario Kart 8's release. The week Mario Kart 8 hit store shelves, over 130,000 Wii U consoles were sold. Even three weeks after the release, sales were still more than double their pre-Luigi-Death-Stare levels. All-told, Mario Kart 8 has sold an additional 207,000 Wii U consoles in just three weeks.*
>
> *But it gets even more interesting when you compare the Wii U's big system-seller with the exclusives that have come out in the first half of 2014 on the other two consoles.*
>
> *March saw the release of both Titanfall for Xbox One and inFAMOUS: Second Son for Playstation 4. The sales boost from Titanfall only lasted two weeks and moved about 94,000 additional Xbox One consoles. The sales boost from the Seattle-set Second Son lasted three weeks and moved an additional 106,000 PlayStation 4 consoles.*

I can't help myself: Hail Mario.

If not Disneyland or Nintendo...

July 7, 2014

Categories: Children, Culture

Jordan Shapiro, Forbes:

> *Disney characters are not as familiar to my kids as they were to me when I was their age. Perhaps it is because they have tablets, gaming consoles, and laptops. Their pop culture universe is dominated by Minecraft, Mario, Clash of Clans, and Pokemon. YouTube gamers are celebrities to them. While they (and I) enjoy those new Mickey Mouse shorts on the Disney Channel, we rarely set out to watch something because of the Disney brand.*

I love Disneyland. Probably more than most. So much so that my NaNoWriMo novel took place within the gates if the Magic Kingdom. I have long dreamt of becoming a Walt Disney Imagineer; brainstorming, collaborating, and bringing to life grand new experiences for park guests. The idea of immersing myself in work that turned imagination into reality (even if it meant laying the brick myself!) always sounded... right.

However, I had an eerily similar thought last night. After setting down my copy of Console Wars by Blake J. Harris, I asked myself if I'd rather work for Disney or Nintendo?

Nintendo is full of characters *I* grew up, full of characters *I* love. Being born in 1985, the year the Nintendo Entertainment System (NES) was brought to North America, Mario, Mega Man (Capcom aside), and Link (rather, the name I chose) were the characters that ushered me into the world, and I them. These characters had no personality, just a mission and they need *me* to achieve it. They required immersion and connection.

Being raised in a world where the participatory nature of video games was quickly becoming the norm, I'm not sure how much observing a character or watching the moral to a story unfold actually affected me. I was obsessed the Aladdin's Genie because he made me laugh, but until I really understood the nuances of storytelling and scope of reality (probably somewhere in mid-high school), I'm not sure I really identified with any Disney character. I just knew I wanted to be the good guy.

After spending the weekend enjoying *Mario Kart 8* with my fiancée, I thought about how much joy the characters of the Mushroom Kingdom brought me; I thought about how excited I was for *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker*, or how I would jump at the opportunity to buy the next *Luigi's Mansion* installment, or how I wish Nintendo would launch a Princess Peach and Daisy centric title.

Don't get me wrong, working as a Walt Disney Imagineer or in Nintendo's Treehouse sounds like more than any fan could ever ask for. But given an equal opportunity at both, I'm not sure which I would choose. I don't think I'm the only one from my generation who sits on this fence.

In a connected society full of massive, customizable, open worlds and bite-sized mobile games, will post-millennials fantasize about either? If we live in a perpetually fantastic world, does reality become the new fantasy?

Kids react to Game Boy

July 7, 2014

Categories: Children, Culture, History

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0pCp8g-VjOs

Game over. Get off my lawn.

Gambling for Kids

July 8, 2014

Categories: Business

Mark Sorrell, Children's Media Yearbook as excerpted by The Guardian:

> *Well there are a few issues here. Freemium apps aimed exclusively at kids are actually pretty rare and, thanks to a number of high profile missteps, certainly not getting any more popular.*
>
> *A look at the top kids' apps charts reveals that, rather uniquely, the top grossing apps are paid and not free. That's definitely not true of the adult-orientated categories. The hubbub of the past two years has worked, and the kids market has largely got its house in order.*
>
> *The problem comes when kids play games that are aimed at adults, but that children also adore. We've already established that kids love games and can deal with game mechanics that are at a far greater level of complexity than they exhibit in other areas of their development.*

Later…

> *But there is a gradual understanding that within freemium, it's not the more mercenary and mendacious techniques that are the most successful. A well designed freemium game uses money as a way to increase player agency and allow an extra form of expression rather than as a gating mechanic or devious trick. Spending money in many of the more successful freemium games is a symbol of the player's enjoyment, not capitulation.*
>
> *And when it comes to children interacting with these games, well, it's not like we haven't historically been teaching kids to say, gamble, anyway.*
>
> *Panini Sticker books, those are definitely gambling for kids, and they sell six billion stickers a year. Those little LEGO Minifigure packs with a random minifig are gambling for kids. LEGO are the world's biggest toy company*
>
> *A closed packet containing a random prize has been an acceptable way to stop a child from making terrible, horrible noises in a public place for decades.*

LEGO did not become the world's biggest toy company by selling blind packs of random minifigs to crying children. LEGO neared bankruptcy prior to obtaining a license for the Star Wars franchise. The success of that license spun into numerous other licenses for *Harry Potter*, Marvel *and* DC, *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles*, etc. LEGO also spun these franchises into lovable video games (free of in-app purchase), movies, and many other merchandising endeavors. They are not a company who has rooted their business practice in micro transactions for digital commodities or goods.

Andrew Sielen on his Reality Prose blog:

> *In 2004 the LEGO group was in trouble. They were losing money and losing market share to other toys and entertainment products. In order to address some fundamental issues in their business, they needed to cut costs. Leading up to this crisis, LEGO bricks had been adding new designs and colors without consideration for the cost to the business. LEGO*

> *went through a large reorganization and cut the production of unique elements in half, the variety of colors in half, and the number of suppliers by 80%. This, in addition to an increase in licensed sets and an expansion into video games, saved the LEGO Company.*

Sure, the "blind pack" is a form of immediate gambling and a successful side business but it also encourages diplomacy in trading. It's the same practice that never stopped *trading* card or vinyl figure collectors from growing their collections and offering up the pastime of a scavenger hunt for the whole set. If a "whale" happened to have a massive amount of extraneous coin, they could easily buy the lot of a "blind" collectible box with probable certainty that they would complete a series. Or they could walk into any trading card shop and shell out for that rare Kobe Bryant rookie card without hesitation.

What happened to building a franchise and the "long game?" Video game sequels, be it *Super Mario Bros*. or *Sonic The Hedgehog*, are just iterations of the same game. Trickle in a new characters, mechanics, and levels and you've got yourself a sequel. Those that fell in love with the characters and gameplay from the first iteration are likely to scramble for the next.

Take a look at the Pokémon franchise. The first iteration of the game (red and blue) offered the first 151 Pokémon. However, each version only included 140 of said 151, 11 of which were exclusive to each version of the game. A single player *could* purchase both versions of the game along with two Game Boys, link them up and trade amongst themselves. However, the likelihood that a parent would allow for such an investment for 11 extra Pokémon was highly unlikely. Instead, children were encouraged to trade amongst their friends with the different version of the game.

This crazed investment of time, energy and community built a sustainable franchise... from collectibles. Just as with trading cards or any other expanding collectible sensation, offering more collectibles was an opportunity for more revenue; therefore, more and more Pokémon were created. This has continued for 16 years over several handheld console generations and spawned TV shows, movies, and various other merchandizing opportunities.

Carnival games still exist even though we know they are rigged, but we keep coming back for the chance of triumph. Even monetary gambling offers a chance at monetary and physical return. Sorrell's cover of an IAP's ability to "increase player agency and allow an extra form of expression" acknowledges the industry's nearly unanimous "thumbs-up" of aesthetic IAP. Though, I'm not sure I see how buying a new dress for Barbie and "gambling" are linked.

The success of in-app purchases comes from whales. Children are not whales. Sorrell inadvertently touches on this with mention of games for adults vs. games for children. The problem is that these games are marketed and available without restriction to all age groups. It seems to me that if an IAP dev can wrangle a few bucks out of a unsuspecting child and ignorant parents, that child may come to believe that the nature of games is to pay for progress, thus a spiral.

The first time I played a console game and realized I did not have to feed the machine another quarter, I was sold. Once I owned the console, I could enjoy limitless play albeit at the hefty cost of a console and *finished* games. I learned to save and research for fulfilling experiences and communal discussions. Turns out, that trade-off was something millions were willing to make. The arcade vs. console era taught me more about money management than begging my parents for another roll of tokens.

Update: Howard Phillips, as quoted in "Console Wars" by Blake J. Harris:

> *Play itself is very rewarding for children. Maybe in some respects there's a little too much play, but play is still important. And there's this whole social opportunity, this currency of interaction, with friends, family, and even strangers. That kind of attitude extends beyond the playground, so I was really happy to be expressing that aspect of games.*

Tipping Point

July 9, 2014

Categories: Technology

Andrew House, Sony Computer Entertainment president, as quoted by IGN:

> *Then the third one is virtual reality. There's just a sense that we have that the technology is again reaching that tipping point, it's on the cusp of being something that really delivers you true presence, of feeling like you're in another world. When that's delivered it's really magical and I think that how far, how large, how quickly that's going to become a major part of what we do remains to be seen, but we definitely think the magic of that experience leads you wanting to pursue it.*

Admittedly, I have not tried Oculus Rift or Project Morpheus. Call me a naysayer but I just don't see something as isolating as VR taking off. I don't think the audience will be as small as to call it niche, but I think the mainstream will find that strapping goggles to one's face in a group setting is a bit sickening. We are already seeing a slight backlash to smartphone usage in group settings.

This statement comes on the heels of a Samsung's 'Gear VR' headset leak. Three major companies are now investing in VR without a crystal clear vision of the future of this tech. At least not a vision we've been shown. Maybe I'm wrong but I don't think abundant '80s dreams of wearables and VR are an indication of "where the puck is headed." At least not in any capacity advertised thus far.

Update: I should point out that I speak solely from the perspective of gaming; though, I have been reminded that PC gaming is primarily enjoyed in solitary environments. This is likely to be the heaviest hitting market for gaming VR. To add, the implications on accessibly experience (be it gaming, simulation, or otherwise) and real world simulations seem promising. Take a look at Chris Kluwe's TED Talk on augmented reality and empathy.

Binary Notions of Sex and Gender

July 9, 2014

Categories: Gender, Sexuality

The newest version of Dungeons & Dragons launched on July 3, 2015.

Dungeons & Dragons, 5th Edition: Basic Rules v0.1:

> *You can play a male or female character without gaining any special benefits or hindrances. Think about how your character does or does not conform to the broader culture's expectations of sex, gender, and sexual behavior. For example, a male drow cleric defies the traditional gender divisions of drow society, which could be a reason for your character to leave that society and come to the surface.*
>
> *You don't need to be confined to binary notions of sex and gender. The elf god Corellon Larethian is often seen as androgynous or hermaphroditic, for example, and some elves in the multiverse are made in Corellon's image. You could also play a female character who presents herself as a man, a man who feels trapped in a female body, or a bearded female dwarf who hates being mistaken for a male. Likewise, your character's sexual orientation is for you to decide.*

Right and Wrong

July 10, 2014

Categories: Children, Parenting

Jessica Chobot on The Nerdist Podcast:

> ***Jessica Chobot****: This is not a kids (necessarily) hobby anymore. When you're selling game consoles at like 600 bucks a pop and games at 60 bucks a piece (or AAA titles because you've got your indies and they're a little cheaper, but you get my point), that's not just a child's hobby.*
>
> ***Chris Hardwick****: And not only that, but I think the inherent value of [video games], just like you said with your dad, is how you guys bonded. That's how Chloe [Dyskra] and her dad bonded.*
>
> ***JC****: Totally. But you always hear the shit stories about, "Oh, kids are shooting up because they play too much Call of Duty." Well, what about the father and daughter relationship that grew…*
>
> ***CH****: It all boils down to your responsibility as a parent. And video games can be amazing if you're a responsible parent, if you're engaged. If you're not a responsible parent, video games are not the thing that fucked your kid up. Something was going to get that kid sooner or later; (joking) whether it was backward masking on record albums or Devil worship…*
>
> ***JC****: Elvis dancing in front of the television…*
>
> *I will stick with this until the day that I die: There is no excuse for parents to complain about games giving their children bad ideas to go do awful things because there are parental controls on the consoles, there are parental controls built into your TVs now, there are warning labels on all of your games, you have to have a license to even purchase them.*
>
> *Yes, if they really wanted to go out there and get it [they'll] find it. But if they are trying that hard to get on something you've told them "no" to multiple times and you have no idea what the hell is going on, then that lies in your lap, nobody else's.*
>
> ***CH****: I also feel like "things," like games, "things" are inherently neutral. They don't have any value except for the value people place on them. If someone has the right value system going into something, they're not going to interpret that thing as, "this is what I should go do." They need the right system in place in order to process those things.*
>
> *My parents let me watch all kinds of stuff when I was a kid. The reason I became obsessed with stand-up was because my parents didn't censor, I mean I couldn't watch porn … but the idea that if you have good values going into something you're probably going to take it in a better direction than if you didn't.*
>
> *But I'm talking out of the side of my face because I don't have kids.*
>
> ***JC****: Just to play Devil's advocate, I've only had one time where I've played a game that I walked out and the first thing I saw were targets. That would be Grand Theft Auto.*

> ...
>
> *That's when I was like, "Whoa. Now I can kind of see the angle of that argument." But still, you have the morals in check because you were raised properly, and also the fact that I'm thirty-something-years-old and I can play a game like that and know the difference between right and wrong.*

I've had similar feelings after long sessions with *GTA*. I've also had similarly profound feelings after watching movies, if not more so. A good adventure movie can make me want to adventure. A good motivational movie can pump me up. A good action movie can give me fantasies about speeding around traffic or doing impossibly dangerous stunts. Nevertheless, I don't engage in dangerous or immoral behavior because I know the difference between right and wrong.

Is it possible that movies offer heightened emotive states due to their passive nature versus the participatory nature of video games? Does being able to participate in virtual acts of running, jumping, and shooting allow us to vent those fantasies rather than creating curiosity after simply watching?

On the note of parental controls, willingness to learn new technology is a huge factor in parenting. That said, tech developers also have a responsibility to provide clear and accessible controls for their audience. Not because older generations may struggle with implementation (heads up, many millennials are now parents), but because consumer UI should not be difficult to use.

Last bit: *ET* scared me. The original *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles* movie is dark. *Gremlins* appeared to be a children's movie but felt creepy and disturbing. I look at movies like *Super 8*, *Transformers*, and the new *TMNT* reboot and have to wonder if "children's" movies are slowly harkening back to the darker tones established in the '80s and early '90s.

I spent a lot of my early childhood watching movies like *Alien*, *Predator*, *Fire In The Sky*, *Conan the Barbarian*, and *Mad Max*. I'd like to say that I turned out to be a pretty decent human being.

Alas, I too am talking out of the side of my face.

Dota 2: Newcomer's Broadcasts at TI4

July 10, 2014

Categories: eSports, Technology

Vlad Savov, The Verge:

> *Valve is trying to tear down this barrier of entry to what is already its most popular game ever with the introduction of a new round of Newcomer's Broadcasts at TI4. These video streams offer alternative commentary on the tournament's matches, where the game's jargon is either filtered out or explained so as to improve the spectating experience for the uninitiated. Alas, though the goal is noble, the execution has so far been uneven. The commentators come from the same roster that does the regular game broadcasts and they struggle between being overly simplistic — "the green bars above their heads" represent each hero's health and LAN means Local Area Network — and utterly impenetrable with discussions of "ganking," "popping the Aegis," and being "blown up by the Dagon."*

I have yet to plunge myself into the MOBA craze but this seems like a novel idea, and not just for eSports. While watching a recent San Francisco Giants game, I joked with friends about substitute commentators that continually get sidetracked. What I didn't suggest (but began pondering) was the inclusion of commentating for the novice viewer, breaking down different stats and rules. It would certainly be interesting to see commentary track choices rated by depth not only built into eSports broadcasts but services such as MLB.tv and NFL Network too.

Madden NFL 15 Aims to Teach Football

July 11, 2014

Categories: Design, Education

Samit Sarkar, Polygon:

> *I went through a few Skills Trainer exercises during an EA press event in New York yesterday, with Doeberling explaining the setup. We started out with the Cover 2, a key scheme for defending the pass. I thought Courtney's voice-over, augmented by on-screen visuals, did a terrific job of explaining how to identify the Cover 2 on the field: two deep safeties, with cornerbacks giving your wide receivers five yards of space.*
>
> *The game then displays the gaps in the Cover 2 — the areas on the field in which you'll be more likely to find open receivers — and finally, tells you the offensive plays that are best suited to exploiting those spots (Flood, Smash and Verticals). After the tutorial, Skills Trainer moves into drills, and awards medals based on how often you succeed.*

Later...

> *Skills Trainer is now part of the onboarding process for Madden 15; the first time you boot up the game, it'll encourage you to check out the mode. This is a step in the right direction. It's not enough to include these tutorials in sports games, because hardcore players will ignore them and newcomers may not be able to find them. And unlike the start of an action title or shooter, it's tough to make a tutorial out of a default exhibition game in a sports title. What's even more encouraging is that with Madden 15's Skills Trainer and Gauntlet, Tiburon may have found a way to make studying fun.*

I haven't played a sports game since *NHL 10*(?), but I can attest that I'd love to see more effective sports education built in. I have always wanted to join the greater sports conversation but have never found a way to engage with it. My best attempt was stat tracking my brother as he played *World Series Baseball* for the Sega Genesis; though, I chalked it up as an excuse to play with my dad's new laptop...

I have a suspicious inkling that this doubles as an attempt to increase viewer and passerby engagement in NFL games. Either way, it's a nice piggyback on yesterday's post about alternative (e)sports commentary. File under edTech?

How chess shows that gender segregation in eSports might encourage more female leagues

July 11, 2014

Categories: Gender

An interesting piece over at Polygon.

Emily Gera, Polygon:

> *Chess historically has featured gender-segregated tournaments; This has nothing to do with differences in skill levels between the genders, however, MindSports International development manager and chess coach Eduardo Sajgalik tells us. Rather it's the best method of helping smaller demographics grow.*

Coming Out Simulator 2014

July 11, 2014

Categories: Design, Sexuality

A half-true game about half-truths.

Danielle Riendeau, Polygon:

> *No matter how many pride parades I attend, or how much volunteer work I do, or how long I live in the generally accepting city of San Francisco, a part of me will always be that terrified 17-year-old, worried that her family won't love her any more. Case' game hit me right there.*

Just completed a play-through. In the span of 10 minutes, I felt my blood boil, heart race, and gut wrench. Very brave and inspiring sim. Brought me back to this post.

Well done, Nicky Case.

The Untold Story of Unroll.Me

July 12, 2014

Categories: Gender, Technology

Perri Blake Gorman, co-founder of Unroll.Me:

> *Personally I love being a woman in tech. There is nothing that has helped me be more memorable than being a woman. Our first piece of press happened when Courtney Boyd Meyers (@CBM), then at The Next Web, reached out to us. She asked to write a piece because she had seen me tweeting about it. As a female founder you get on people's radars. That press was followed by a post by Lifehacker which generated over 26,000 signups in 24 hours.*

A great outlook on the ongoing and magnified diversity problem in the tech (and gaming) industry. Just unsubscribed from 85 newsletters, rolled up 29. My favorite part are the Most Unsubscribed / Most Rolled Up awards.

Unpaid part-time job

July 14, 2014

Categories: Design, Work

Jeffrey Jaques, writer and illustrator of Questionable Content, as quoted by The Guardian:

> *Playing with jerks, is no fun. Having a stoned college kid tell me I suck and can't fucking shoot when I'm just learning an FPS is no fun. Being stuck at level 40 in World of Warcraft when all my friends are level 60 and don't have time to help me catch up is no fun. Having to play any multiplayer game for 25 hours a week to remain competitive ... that's not fun, that's an unpaid part-time job.*

Likewise, I don't have 40 spare hours to dedicate to the story of a single game. I grew up awed by Final Fantasy and dreamt of having the time to play a full story. Since seeing *FFVII*, I've completed two: *FFX* and *FFXIII*.

I'm coming to find that games with dailies such as *Hearthstone* or with "three star" achievements such as (famously) *Angry Birds* or *Mario Kart 8* allow for quicker bouts of manageable playtime.

8bit Football

July 14, 2014

Categories: Art, Culture, Design

Relive the biggest plays from the 2014 World Cup with Matheus Toscano's 8bit Football blog.

Toscano, as quoted by The Verge:

> *People want to see how their favorite players and teams would look like in 8-bit style. Whenever they can recognize someone, even if it is only represented by only a few pixels, that usually makes them laugh.*
>
> *Most people who grew up in the '80s and '90s could experience playing football video games with such graphics. Whenever we see something similar, it brings back memories from childhood.*

Worth relinking to my previous post on pixel art.

The Return of Crash Bandicoot and Spyro?

July 14, 2014

Categories: General

Andrew House on Crash Bandicoot and Spyro, as quoted by Telegraph:

> *In concept, it is something we've been thinking about and discussing, and this is a shift for us. We've started to say that maybe there isn't anything wrong with going back and looking at characters that people still talk about, that were a big part of their childhood or their youth. I definitely wouldn't close the door on that.*

I've mentioned before that Microsoft needs to invest in aged Rare IP such as *Banjo-Kazooie*, *Jet Force Gemini*, and *Conker* (now coming to *Project Spark*). Blinded by their "success," I however neglected Sony's need to do the same.

It goes without saying that Nintendo is on the upswing. The value of their family friendly franchises are at the heart of why you can never count them out of the console race.

Mascots are identity. At the very least, Microsoft can lean on Master Chief but that only scores them a slice of the audience. (Granted a very big slice.) Sony has... Nathan Drake? Kratos? Sackboy and Sly Cooper are nice and all but hardly recognizable outside of Sony diehards. This all became very apparent with the release of Playstation All-Stars Battle Royale.

Nintendo's franchises, like Disney's, are approaching timelessness. As the HD Twins continue to struggle in setting themselves apart, Nintendo is only going to gain foothold with releases that focus on familiar faces. Microsoft and Sony need to adopt color and a little family franchise flair.

I'm sad to hear that working with *Crash Bandicoot* and *Spyro* would be "a shift" for Sony, but good on House for acknowledging this question. Great on Telegraph for asking.

Update: Prior to the launch of Sonic The Hedgehog 2 ,circa 1992, as excerpted from "Console Wars" by Blake J, Harris:

> *According to a recent national survey, Sonic was now a more recognizable American icon than Mario, MC Hammer, and even Mickey Mouse.*

Fabian Giesen's exit letter

July 15, 2014

Categories: Technology

Ex-Valve contractor Fabian Giesen's exit letter:

> *Part of this has to do with the direction of the project. With AR, there's a variety of information display/visualization applications, all of which are at the very least interesting and could turn out to be tremendously empowering in various ways. The endpoint of VR, on the other hand - all engineering practicalities of first aiming for a seemingly easier goal aside - seems to be fundamentally anti-social, completing the sad trajectory of entertainment moving further and further away from shared social experiences. (As I have mentioned multiple times, I find the limited, formalized, abstracted and ultimately alienated social interactions in most forms of online gaming to be immensely off-putting).*

Later, offering context:

> *And having an immersive virtual environment - hey, MMORPGs even without VR get people to sink lots of time into them, and if anything that's probably gonna be more pronounced in the VR version - that is set up to, ultimately, generate ad revenue (and hence prioritize the needs of the advertisers over the desires of its users) is just an inherently gross concept to me.*
>
> *All these trends have been there for a long time. I used to be hypothetically antsy about a major ad-run operation going long in VR. Now that Facebook has bought Oculus, that's not a hypothetical anymore.*
>
> *Now, I'm writing this just as the kerfuffle about Facebook running psychological experiments on their users is ebbing. This is not surprising; if you're trying to maximize engagement (and thus ultimately ad revenue), these are the kinds of trials you run, because you want to know what to show to people.*

I still find it fascinating that three major companies are investing heavily in a novelty space.

Regarding social network involvement: Within the past few months, the increased rate of social networking notifications and ads has become more apparent. I don't need to know if a friend just posted a status update, I don't need to know that two games journalists I follow are discussing the WWE, and I don't need to be asked if I know somebody with a random notification.

Don't get me wrong. There will certainly be stellar avenues for VR in the forms of education, sports, and accessibility. Relinking my thoughts on VR piggybacked on Andrew House's comments about Sony's plans for the space.

I thoroughly enjoyed reading *Ready Player One*. I am not ready to live it.

Order and Chaos

July 15, 2014

Categories: Design

Richard Lemarchand, as quoted by Polygon:

> *Capy Games, makers of Sword and Sworcery EP and their recent new arrival Super Time Force, and of the forthcoming Below. No two Capy Games are alike — they boldly experiment with the form and content of their games — but their fans follow them for their identity of stylishness, experimentation and playability.*
>
> *They say that one of the best business plans you can have is to identify a product or a service that you passionately want, but that does not yet exist. The chances are that millions of people around the world will want it too, and your passion for whatever it is that you're creating will ensure that you make something of high quality.*
>
> *So it's my firm belief that as game developers, we should trust our instincts, and cultivate our tastes. Whatever it is that you care about passionately, devote yourself to seeking out the best of it in the world, figure out what makes it good, and bring your discoveries to the games that you make.*

This is the same reason I become incredibly excited at the mention of new Portugal. The Man or Cursive albums. These bands are shapeshifters, built on the idea of changing rather than defined sounds.

On the other hand, I will continue to purchase Minus The Bear records on trust of the consistency of their sound. The times they stray away are the times they lose me. There's something to be said about the complimentary nature of variance and consistency, order and chaos, and our need for both.

A Tale of Two Trailers

July 15, 2014

Categories: Culture

Chris Plante, Polygon:

> *The trailer is misleading. I know when Assassin's Creed Unity is released, this isn't the game I'll get. It will be about movement and daring escapes and history and spectacular set pieces and drama. That's the game I want to play.*
>
> *But marketing plays a role in game development, especially at the level of multi-million dollar AAA games. And if the studio gets the sense that non-stop-bloodshed is what the audience wants, they will ensure that's what it receives. Only if we speak up, will the studio look at its audience differently. Until then, they will act off the rapturous applause they receive at E3 when a someone's head explodes like a watermelon thrown off a 7-story building.*
>
> *If you'd like an example of a trailer that conveys a different marketing method, look no further than the history-focused vignette Ubisoft ran yesterday in Europe. It hints at fictional conspiracy theory near the end, but overall it's a fine primer on the history of the French Revolution. Maybe Ubisoft has divided their marketing, targeting different audiences with different trailers. Maybe this is them having their cake and eating it, too. Marie Antoinette would be proud, even if she never said anything about cake and that idiom is English.*

Fantastic piece by Plante.

The two trailers mentioned, in respective order:

Revolution Gameplay Trailer

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DBNfenWTCXg

Inside The Revoltion

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0WosijMCEEI

Historic Gaming

July 16, 2014

Categories: Design

Colin Moriarty, IGN:

> *Indeed, players have to do very little in Valiant Hearts other than get through its short campaign, and even if you opt to do only that, it seems impossible not to get caught up in its passion and emotion. Valiant Hearts really resonates not only as a game, but as a wonderful teaching tool, one that makes history interesting and fun, just like it was when we played The Oregon Trail as young kids.*
>
> *Hopefully, Valiant Hearts: The Great War is a sign of more good things to come not only for those of us who love video games, but for those of us that understand the amazing power of history, too. History doesn't have to be boring or dry. In fact, it never is, if it's presented right. Valiant Hearts: The Great War is all the proof you need.*

Interesting read after yesterday's *Assassin's Creed Unity* piece by Chris Plante.

My high school summers were spent taking history classes. This was in an attempt to get ahead in my curriculum and to condense my history lessons into shorter timeframes. Needless to say, I hated history until playing in the fictional world of *Assassin's Creed*... even *Uncharted* for that matter.

If there is one educational avenue games and simulations have succeeded in, something I too learned from *Oregon Trail*, it is their ability to immerse us in and teach us about the past. Even the most stripped down gameplay or overly embellished fictions can be successful in delivering historically accurate lessons and stories that stick. Like Plante, *history* is the reason I am drawn to the Assassin's Creed games. Not neck stabbing.

The International on ESPN3

July 17, 2014

Categories: eSports

Pretty huge news via The Verge.

Some of my thoughts on Dota 2's Newcomer's Boardcasts and sports education.

Sokobond: Chemistry-themed 2D indie puzzle game

July 18, 2014

Categories: Design, Education

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2pMhIn-nRcM

This game looks fun, gorgeous and powerful. Coming to Steam on July 21st. Eventually being released on iOS and Android.

The Cat Mario Show

July 18, 2014

Categories: Business, History

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3zqtFxuEnLg

In 1988, Nintendo distributed a first-party magazine called *Nintendo Power* full of reviews, previews, strategies, and tips and tricks. With the eShop channel, and programs like *The Cat Mario Show*, Nintendo seems to have found a great alternative to the magazine.

I'm very happy to see a focus put back on tips and tricks. Bolting to drug store magazine aisles to read *GamePro*, *Nintendo Power*, and *EGM* while on errands with my family remains one of my fondest memories. I remember flipping directly to the tips and tricks sections to see if any of the games I owned were being featured. In the event I found on, I'd scribble down the code or attempt to embed the button combinations into my muscle memory. In all honesty, clever tips and tricks were enough to sell me on a games I did not own; more so than actual previews and reviews.

Polygon pits Dota 2 champ payout against professional sports

July 20, 2014

Categories: eSports

A very interesting read on how professional and eSports players are paid out after winning championship titles. Owen S. Good, Polygon:

> *So. Next time someone asks you if eSports are a real sport, you can show 'em the receipt.*

War Ensemble

July 23, 2014

Categories: Children, Education, Music

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kFd2Mi2FTzs

This is enough to sell me on Rocksmith 2014.

FFXIV Pixel Pride 2014

July 24, 2014

Categories: Sexuality

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=P5f8BvmZC_Y

To celebrate the addition of same-sex marriages in *Final Fantasy XIV: A Realm Reborn*, the Rough Trade Gaming Community took to the streets of Eorzea in the inaugural FFXIV Pixel Pride parade.

J. Bryan Lowder, Slate:

> *I must say, having watched both the real thing [Pride Parade in New York City] back in June and now this, the Rough Trade parade seemed—pixilation aside—the more joyous of the two.*

More on Minecraft

July 28, 2014

Categories: Children, Education

John Gruber, Daring Fireball:

> *It's almost impossible to overstate just how big a deal Minecraft is for my son and his friends.*

The popularity and power of Minecraft continues to amaze me. Players tend to remain glued to the game/simulation for hours on end, not just playing but creating, experimenting, collaborating, sharing and learning.

Here's a relink to Polygon's piece on how the United Nations is utilizing Minecraft.

League of Lessons: Why Gaming Matters

July 31, 2014

Categories: Children, Education

Great read on connecting from Wiseman.

Rosalind Wiseman, Anti-Defamation League:

> *Young people who game know our bias and the ignorance this bias comes from. It's this reactivity about games that can make it much more difficult for us to develop strong relationships with young people. It's also undeniable that gaming is an essential part of many students' lives. We have an obligation to know about this incredibly diverse world so we can effectively help children and teens navigate it with informed, constructive guidance.*

Female Hollywood Numbers

July 31, 2014

Categories: Gender

Time:

> *Hollywood's woman problem is well-documented: researchers at San Diego State University found that women made up just 15% of protagonists, 29% of major characters and 30% of all speaking characters in movies last year.*

Still better than the video game industry, but not far off. Also, I am slacking on my follow-up to the E3 2013 Genre/Gender Breakdown.

Harry Potter and Canon Management

July 31, 2014

Categories: General

Variety:

> *Warner Bros. Entertainment has conjured up the Harry Potter Global Franchise Development team, based in both London and Burbank, to "develop and execute a high-level strategic vision for the Harry Potter brand and its ancillary businesses," Warner Bros. said Wednesday.*

We've seen similar strategies with the Lord of the Rings (Middle-earth Enterprises) and Star Wars (Lucasfilm Story Group) franchises. I am all for unified canon management and more Harry Potter. Seems like great news for a potential Harry Potter MMO...

Polygon:

> *Warner Bros. Entertainment is not currently commenting on any involvement the team might have with future Harry Potter video games.*

Building Blocks

August 3, 2014

Categories: Culture, Technology

Martin Scorsese, as quoted by FirstShowing.net:

> *We have many names for what we do – cinema, movies, motion pictures. And…film. We're called directors, but more often we're called filmmakers. Filmmakers. I'm not suggesting that we ignore the obvious: HD isn't coming, it's here. The advantages are numerous: the cameras are lighter, it's much easier to shoot at night, we have many more means at our disposal for altering and perfecting our images. And, the cameras are more affordable: films really can be made now for very little money. Even those of us still shooting on film finish in HD, and our movies are projected in HD. So, we could easily agree that the future is here, that film is cumbersome and imperfect and difficult to transport and prone to wear and decay, and that it's time to forget the past and say goodbye – really, that could be easily done. Too easily.*
>
> *It seems like we're always being reminded that film is, after all, a business. But film is also an art form, and young people who are driven to make films should have access to the tools and materials that were the building blocks of that art form. Would anyone dream of telling young artists to throw away their paints and canvases because iPads are so much easier to carry? Of course not. In the history of motion pictures, only a minuscule percentage of the works comprising our art form was not shot on film. Everything we do in HD is an effort to recreate the look of film. Film, even now, offers a richer visual palette than HD. And, we have to remember that film is still the best and only time-proven way to preserve movies. We have no assurance that digital informaton will last, but we know that film will, if properly stored and cared for.*
>
> *Our industry – our filmmakers – rallied behind Kodak because we knew that we couldn't afford to lose them, the way we've lost so many other film stocks. This news is a positive step towards preserving film, the art form we love.*

Earlier today, I vocalized a theory to a colleague that within the next two years we will experience a technological "rubber band effect." It's not to say that we will fall out of love with the magic that tech provides or that we are desensitized to the magic, more so a realization that there are places where magic is not needed. Music production is over bloated and uncomfortably tight, there is an eeriness that all eBooks are the same weight and thickness, and the reliance of post-weathering filters and blurs on digital photos are non-starters. All different approaches to "improve" on digital mediums or mock analog as novelty, now overly used splinters in the senses.

I also predict an increased interest in non-fiction books in lieu of race-to-the-bottom listicles and online publications full of obnoxiously placed online ads. I'm not sure if it fits into the same argument but it feels like there is some overlap here.

Digital is becoming tiring. Surely a great outlook for a blogger.

The Problem with Licensed Products

August 4, 2014

Categories: Design



Monopoly may be the most iconic board game out there. Its minimal design compliments the dry complexities of balancing mortgages, taxes and lengthy play.

That careful consideration is apparently thrown out the window with licensed versions, most recently MONOPOLY: The Legend of Zelda Edition.

The centerpiece Link on this board game mash-up is the worst eyesore. It's a tiring distraction that takes me away from the other details. I would have much preferred a subdued Triforce behind a centered Monopoly logo, or just a lone gold and green Monopoly logo. Even the symbol collage on the cover of *Hyrule Historia* holds a fairly robust LoZ history. Why not pop that in the center of the board.

Aside from the obnoxious centerpiece, the box uses the same cartoon green from *Hyrule Historia*, a book I've walked away from purchasing number of times based on the shade of green alone.

It's a sad state of affairs when officially-licensed video game products that don't look like officially-licensed video game products are few and far between. Maybe this is why fan art is so prevalent and highly-regarded. (Hint, hint)

If you're going to build physical items from virtual worlds (especially cartoony ones), tailor them to the aesthetics that work in the real world. Make them fit. We do not live in Hyrule nor The Mushroom Kingdom. It's likely no mistake that Mickey's Toontown rests at the rear of the Disneyland. It is of pure novelty while the rest of the park feels inhabitable.

Game Less Than One Hour Per Day

August 4, 2014

Categories: Children, Health, Psychology

Pediatrics:

> *Low levels (3 hours daily) of game engagement was linked to key indicators of psychosocial adjustment. Low engagement was associated with higher life satisfaction and prosocial behavior and lower externalizing and internalizing problems, whereas the opposite was found for high levels of play. No effects were observed for moderate play levels when compared with non-players.*

It took me a second to wrap head around this. I wish the clearly defined moderate play. My interpretation:

- Less than 1 hour of play (low): Positive effects
- 0 (non-players) or 1-3 hours of play (moderate): No change
- More than 3 hours of play (high): Negative effects

Update: The BBC offers more clarity.

'How video games have the power to change real lives'

August 6, 2014

Categories: Culture, Education, Health, Military

A fun piece cataloging the impacts of the technology used in video games on urban planning, PTSD, education and more.

Daniel Nye Griffiths, The Guardian:

> *Games are incredibly successful training systems – but all they usually do is train people how to play within fictional worlds. As the tools employed to make them evolve, the potential is there to engage with the real world. In this way, video games offer the power to capture, comment on and change lives.*

Ed Catmull on Icons and Story in Games

August 7, 2014

Categories: Art, Culture, Technology

I had the fortunate opportunity of seeing Ed Catmull, president of Pixar Animation Studios, Walt Disney Animation Studios, DisneyToon Studios, in a moderated conversation today.

During the Q&A, an audience member asked Catmull if there exists a current icon who fills the roll of Walt Disney, a man known as a figure who focused on the impact of technology on human experience and story and delivered his message to the public via TV broadcast. While my head went straight to Neil deGrasse Tyson as a viable figure, Cutmull's answer was quite interesting.

A bit of Catmull's reply, paraphrased by yours truly:

> *You can't make another Walt or another Steve or another John. I think this is a problem the games industry faces. They make great experiences but have a hard time telling great stories. I think we have yet to see who will make that happen.*

He deliberately went out of his way to focus on the games industry. He had also made reference to the games industry earlier in the discussion; however, the context is now escaping me.

O Captain! My Captain!

August 11, 2014

Categories: General

I have always said I'd lose it the day we lost Robin Williams. The man's work always seemed to help me make sense of this world.

As Genie, he taught me that anything was possible. As Peter Banning, he taught me to never grow up. As John Keating, he taught me how to look from a different perspective. As Sean Maguire, he taught me the importance of companionship.

Growing up a child of divorce, I never saw my father as often as I'd liked. My father is a child at heart and I can never get enough of his company. When he wasn't around, I was able to find his humor and guidance in the performances of Robin Williams. I will never be certain of how I made a connection between my father and Robin, but losing Robin feels a lot like losing family.

RIP, Robin Williams. My thoughts go out to the Williams family.

Visual Polish

August 11, 2014

Categories: Design

Ed Catmull, excerpt from Creativity, Inc.:

> *For all the care you put into artistry, visual polish frequently doesn't matter if you are getting the story right.*

Assumption

August 13, 2014

Categories: Gender

Megan Farokhmanesh of Polygon, in conversation with Nate Fox of Sucker Punch, on the inclusion of Fetch as a playable character in Infamous: First Light:

> *Until now, Infamous has never given a female character a leading role. This was largely because of the assumption that "we thought that the demographic of game players were dudes and they identified with dudes," Fox said. He pointed to BioWare's Mass Effect series; in 2011, the developer said only 18 percent of players chose to play as a woman. That number was reiterated during a PAX East panel last year.*

I love the admittance of assumption. Happy to see this message being spread throughout AAA Dev teams.

Journey on PS4

August 13, 2014

Categories: General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H7KOA_k79yo

Colin Moriarty, IGN:

> *Graphically, the new treatment is most impressive with Journey, but maybe that's because I only played through a brief portion of Swan's black-and-white intro sequence. Journey was a looker on PS3; it's somehow even more beautiful on PlayStation 4. The lighting effects, the sand, and the way your character's robes move and sway make for an aesthetically impressive experience. Journey truly is an incredible, emotional game, and it seems that it's set to remain so on next-gen hardware. I'm not so sure I actually want to play it again on PS4, but that's because I promised myself I'd only play it once through on PS3. The game resonated with me so much that I'm afraid seeing it all again would ruin that experience.*

John Siracusa must be excited.

Ultra Street Fighter IV Ultras without Cinematic Camera

August 13, 2014

Categories: Design

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zcEO77xw20I

The Verge:

> *It's actually more fascinating to watch the way that different fighters' complicated Ultra moves spread out, unobscured, across the stage. If you just want to see what the martial arts style of your favorite character looks like without the game's normal careful cutting, you can click over to YouTube, where they're separated out with bookmarks.*

I was just telling a colleague how much I wish I had learned 3D modeling and animation. This video drives my longing home.

On the topic of *Street Fighter*, take a few minutes to enjoy Pete Holmes' star-studded and hilarious Street Fighter: Red Tape. Kumail Nanjiani's Dhalsim is tremendous.

'Here's why I won't be playing Journey on PlayStation 4'

August 13, 2014

Categories: Art

Colin Campbell, Polygon:

> *Already, just playing a few minutes of Journey on PlayStation 4, I'm reminded that the moment-to-moment playing of the game is not as mystical as the memory of it as a complete thing. That the first time I meet another player in the game is never going to match the joyous original. The nice feeling of the wind is just an echo of that last section of the game, that wraps it all up so satisfactorily.*

I often tell myself that I will take another trip through the work of art that is *Journey*. After all, the experience only lasts roughly one-and-a-half hours. However, every time I sit down to try, I'm unable to launch the game for the same reasons Campbell discusses. I do listen to Austin Wintory's fantastic, Grammy-nominated soundtrack frequently and I think it is enough for me to relive the majesty and memory of *Journey*.

Goal: 15 Percent Turnover Every Year

August 13, 2014

Categories: Work

Ed Catmull, Creativity, Inc.:

> *I know of one gaming company in Los Angeles that had a stated goal of turning over 15 percent of its workforce every year. The reasoning behind such a policy was that productivity shoots up when you hire smart, hungry kids fresh out of school and work them to death. Attrition was inevitable under such conditions, but that was okay, because the company's needs outweighed those of the worker. Did it work? Sure, maybe. To a point. But if you ask me, that kind of thinking is not just misguided, it is immoral. At Pixar, I have made it known that we must always have the flexibility to recognize and support the need for balance in all of our employees' lives. While all of us believed in that principle—and had from the beginning—Toy Story 2 helped me see how those beliefs could get pushed aside in the face of immediate pressures.*

15 Percent Gamer

August 15, 2014

Categories: Culture

A must read that hits close to home. Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *If I had to make a T-shirt for myself in the same theme as the silly one from E3 — and we've joked about this around the office — it would say something like "15 Percent Gamer." That sounds about right. I play games for work, and I write about them and talk to the people who make them. I love them, but they're one thing in a group of things I love. Not the biggest thing.*
>
> *I sit on calls about financial results and have long conversations with people in the industry about what's going on and why. When I close my laptop at the end of the day, I get to help take care of my five kids, and we do homework, watch movies, go out, make food. I may fly something, I may spend time with my wife, I may read a book. Most nights I don't play video games for fun, but when I do I love it.*

Your Brain Sucks at Video Games

August 15, 2014

Categories: Design

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=drPBIiuSWso

Anthony Carboni:

> *We blame everything when we suck at games: lag, the controller, bad framerates- but here's a fun fact: your brain is built to be terrible at video games and everything is usually your own fault.*

The Gimmick Girl

August 21, 2014

Categories: Gender

Jack Moore on Mo'Ne Davis and Emma March:

> *The narrative of the gimmick girl in sports is doubly damaging. Not only does it foster a lower expectation of women's abilities—in both genders—it also creates an assumption that women aren't earning their spots when in reality they are almost certainly facing even higher standards than the men they compete against.If the sports world is truly going to house gender equality, we need to give girls the freedom to choose their sports. We need to stop pressuring them to take the path of least gender resistance. And we need to stop holding them to a higher standard when everything else is already working against them.*

Great read on gender equality in sports. Bring me right back to the Finnish Hearthstone Tournament and gender segregation in chess. A very interesting conversation.

Influenced by Divorce

August 21, 2014

Categories: Children, Design

Joe Russ, developer of Jenny LeClue, as quote by Polygon:

> *Growing up in a family of divorce is all about choices, and how your parents' choices can greatly affect you — at least as much as them. It's about accepting that sometimes the right choices have tough consequences.*
>
> *These are the things I want players to be able to explore in the game and be part of in writing the narrative with us. Growing up is about making these choices and learning to live with the consequences. Becoming an adult is, for me, about understanding that you have responsibility for your actions.*

Divorce is an interesting well of inspiration. This concept sounds intriguing. Looking forward to playing Jenny LeClue.

Russ Frushtick says Goodbye to Polygon

August 22, 2014

Categories: Media

Russ Frushtick:

> *But, there comes a day when you feel like you're not learning as much as you were, or you're not conquering as many new challenges as you used to. Even with awesome, amazing jobs like this, there comes a time when you feel like you need to try something fresh. Something new. That's been buzzing in my ear for the last few months and, as of two weeks ago, I let my boss, Chris Grant, know that I was taking the leap. (He was super cool about it, by the way.)*

I've always enjoyed Frushtick's work. Sad to see him leave Polygon and the games media-at-large but happy to see him leave on his own terms. Godspeed Frushtick. Looking forward to the August Besties more than ever.

UPDATE, 5/3/16: Russ is back:

> *It's been nearly two years since I left and an educational two years at that. I took a break from the gaming industry and expanded into new areas. I wanted to broaden my professional experience, get out of my comfort zone, and dive into some new things. I worked with some great companies and great people but there was always a tugging. A desire to return to return to this place and work with these amazing people.*

Great news. And what does this mean for the future of Besties?

Switch to Sony

August 26, 2014

Categories: Business

Eric Johnson, Re/code:

> *According to data provided to Re/code, an April Nielsen study found that 31 percent of PS4 owners did not own Sony's previous console, the PlayStation 3, but did own an Xbox 360 or Wii. Seventeen percent did not own any last-generation console.*
>
> *The people surveyed were Americans, age 7 to 54, and were a subset of a total of 1,200 "active gamers" surveyed by Nielsen between February and April.*
>
> *However, there's one big caveat to the survey, which is that it asked only what consumers currently owned at the time of the survey, not what they had owned in the past. So, people who sold their PlayStation 3 in order to buy a PlayStation 4 would've been marked down as non-PS3 owners.*
>
> *Assuming that most people didn't do that, though, the numbers underscore why launching at a $100 lower price point than the rival Xbox One was so beneficial for Sony.*

These numbers are much bigger than I would have thought. I knew the PS4 was out pacing both the Xbox One and (not surprisingly) the Wii U, but 17% adding consoles to their homes is astounding. Sure, they may have had PS2s, Xboxes, and Gamecubes, but 17% after the longest generation cycle, I assume it's safe to say these are new console owners… if we are assuming of course.

Love is Strange

August 27, 2014

Categories: Children, Culture

Ryan Gilbey, The Guardian:

> *They have decreed that Love is Strange should have the same rating as Saw III ("strong grisly violence and gore, sequences of terror and torture, nudity and language"), My Bloody Valentine ("graphic brutal horror violence and grisly images throughout, some strong sexuality, graphic nudity and language"), and the new Sin City film ("strong brutal stylised violence throughout, sexual content, nudity, and brief drug use").*
>
> *It's an insult to anyone's intelligence to find that Love is Strange received its R for nothing more than "some strong language". What – not even a teensy-weensy bit of terror and torture? No grisly images or graphic nudity? I wonder if the director, Ira Sachs, feels a bit like the faithful spouse accused erroneously of adultery: if he is going to be pilloried anyway, maybe he should have committed the crime for which he is being punished and thrown in a few chainsaw murders just for the hell of it.*

Two nights ago, my fiancée and I watched *Captain American: The Winter Soldier*. Mid-way through the action packed, gunplay heavy film, she looked over at me and said, "it's amazing they blame video games for gun violence."

She echoed my thoughts exactly. I felt that I had seen more violence in this semi-children's film than any video game I had played over the past year. There was something unnerving about the amount of bullets spraying into the air, masses of headshots, and deadly explosions. Something Polygon brought to light after this years E3 Expo. It was a feeling I'd also experienced weeks prior at a showing of *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles*. Both films are rated PG-13.

I'm not saying that overboard gun violence shown in films is a problem; though, I am now easier unsettled than I when I saw *The Matrix* in high school. All I'm saying is that if violence isn't the reason for an R rating, then we need to reevaluate the measure of two f-bombs (something kids are prone to hearing multiple times per day on streets, schoolyards, and homes) and/or expressions of sexuality or acts of sex that are completely natural landing R ratings. If a 13-year-old, nay the swaths of children that watched *Captain America: The Winter Solider* and/or *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles*, can handle lengthy gun battles and on-screen death, then a bit of language and sexuality is not going to hurt any.

Update: Ghostbusters, rated PG. Kids of the 80s sure turned out rotten.

Madeleines

August 27, 2014

Categories: Children, Culture, History

'In loving memory of video games' by Chris Plante, Polygon:

> *They're my madeleines, you could say, transporting me back to the days my love of video games was personal and private, only shared with the neighbor kids and never ever disclosed at school, where it would have been taken for a weakness. The world has changed.*

A beautiful piece by Plante.

Relinking to 1985: Burst and Bloom by yours truly. More reminiscing can be found in Console Wars by Blake J. Harris.

'Trolls drive Anita Sarkeesian out of her house to prove misogyny doesn't exist'

August 27, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender

Adi Robertson, The Verge:

> *The threats against Sarkeesian have become a nasty backdrop to her entire project — and her life. If the trolls making them hoped for attention, they've gotten it. They've also inexorably linked criticism of her work, valid or not, with semi-delusional vigilantism, and arguably propelled Tropes vs. Women to its current level of visibility. If a major plank of your platform is that misogyny is a lie propagated by Sarkeesian and other "social justice warriors," it might help to not constantly prove it wrong.*

I am deeply troubled by all of this. My thoughts to Sarkeesian and those affected by these incredibly disturbing acts of lunacy.

IGN Celebrates Nintendo's 125th Anniversary by Playing 125 Nintendo Games

August 28, 2014

Categories: History

IGN:

> *It's Nintendo's 125th anniversary! Yes,waaaay back in September 1889 "Nintendo Koppai" was founded as a playing card manufacturer. But over the last 40 years or so, Nintendo has grown into one of the most prolific, successful, and beloved video game makers anywhere.*
>
> *To celebrate, all month long we're playing 125 of of the greatest Nintendo games ever made. So come on this journey with us, and relive some of our fondest Nintendo-made memories.*

I'm having a blast watching through this series. Short Let's Plays of classic Nintendo games from NES through Wii U. Kick off your binge with Justin David and Tim Gettys playing one of my favorites, *Super Mario 64*.

'The Truth About Zoe Quinn'

August 28, 2014

Categories: Gender, Media

Elizabeth Sampat:

> *I keep using the word "survive" but I can't help but wonder: is this surviving? What parts of me are surviving? Can any woman escape this whole?*
>
> *That's the thing. The truth is, a lot of the women who are being driven away have never met or interacted with Anita or Zoe. A lot of the women in our industry exist in a constant state of fear. Women who make games and would never dream of connecting their face or real name with a Twitter account, just in case. Women who would never go indie. Women who are terrified of starting a crowdfunding campaign but who can't get their dreams funded any other way, and so their dreams just die.*
>
> *Are you okay with this? Is this the industry that you want?*

An insightful must read from Sampat.

You’re talking to a child

August 28, 2014

Categories: Gender, Media

David Auerbach, Slate:

> *Now a harder suggestion: Police yourselves. When an impetuous member of Anonymous “revealed” the wrong person as Michael Brown’s shooter, many other members aggressively and publicly condemned the member. You’ve got to do that, too. When the more infantile and hateful members of the online gaming contingent harass a woman, you should remind them what the actual goal is, and tell them that they’re tripping themselves up. Remember that you’re talking to a child, in spirit if not in actual fact. If you police yourselves, Reddit and Steam moderators won’t have to. This is not an easy task, but it is possible. Self-organizing communities are one of the miracles of human civilization.*

The Metaphorical Grocery Store

August 28, 2014

Categories: Gender, Media

Chris Plante, Polygon:

> *Two groups are at opposite ends of this moment:*
>
> *One side has folded its arms, slumped its shoulders while pouting like an obstinate child that has learned they are getting a little brother or sister but wants to remain the singular focus of his parents' affection.*
>
> *The other side has opened its arms, unable to contain its love and compassion, because they understand they are no longer alone.*
>
> *This week, the obstinate child threw a temper tantrum, and the industry was stuck in the metaphorical grocery store as everyone was forced to suffer through it together. But unlike a child, the people behind these temper tantrums are hurting others. It's time to grow up. Let's not wait until next week to start.*

I am very happy to see writers Auerbach and Plante echo each other's sentiment of "childish rhetoric." I'm even happier that Plante is escalating this conversation to include the reality of the situation.

New Nintendo 3DS

August 29, 2014

Categories: General

Earlier today, Nintendo announced refreshed 3DS and 3DS XL units, simply called the New Nintendo 3DS. Kotaku has a great breakdown of the Nintendo Direct event including screens of important slides highlighting auto-brightness, the external build, viewing angles, swappable battery, retro button comparison, and more.

I have been eagerly awaiting (and anticipating) a standard 3DS refresh. While it doesn't look to be trimmed down in size (these things look like Fisher-Price toys), I'll take the new internal enhancements to the 3 1/2 year-old 3DS, gargantuan 3DS XL, or striped down 2DS.

In the days of the original DS, there were tons of games I felt I was missing out on but was not satisfied with the hardware. I was pleasantly surprised when the DS Lite was announced. I vividly remember racing out to pick up one up on launch day. This device rekindled my love for Nintendo and video games as a whole. I can't say that it will offer the same life changing experience, but I will likely be racing out for the New Nintendo 3DS. Interesting name.

Grand Theft Mario

August 29, 2014

Categories: Design, General

Rob Fahey, GamesIndustry.biz:

> *At the same time, though, Nintendo itself has a conception of "casual" and "core" that probably isn't shared by the majority of sites reporting Miyamoto's comments. Miyamoto talks not about themes but about enjoyment of challenge as the distinction between the two groups. To him, a supposedly "adult" game full of blood and ripe language could be utterly casual if it spoon-feeds players with dull, linear gameplay. Meanwhile, a brightly coloured Mushroom Kingdom epic could qualify as "core" if it challenges players in the right way. Consequently, Nintendo's family-friendly IP and the broad appeal of its themes is entirely compatible with a focus on "core games", to Miyamoto's mind. What he's talking about changing is something at the root of design, not the thematic wallpaper of the company's games; he wants to challenge people, not to force Nintendo's artists to remove all the primary colours from their Photoshop palettes.*

Later:

> *Under Miyamoto's watchful eye, they'll also be challenging and engaging; but anyone taking his comments on "passivity" as near-confirmation that we'll see Grand Theft Mario down the line is utterly misreading the situation.*

Fahey hits the nail on the head. One of the reasons I am rarely drawn to the FPS genre and "core" titles is the sense that I'm simply playing the same game with a new skin. The last one to do so was the BioShock franchise and that hooked me with story and slightly better "wallpaper," not challenge.

I enjoy Nintendo titles not only because challenge ever-present; their palettes, characters, and universes are full of life. I am certainly not the first to say that Nintendo titles are as much children's games as Disney/Pixar titles are children's films. *Up* didn't leave a dry eye in the house, *Wall-E* toyed with nostalgia and love only adults could understand, and *Wreck-It Ralph* was full of lessons of sacrifice only relatable to an 18 and older crowd.

Nintendo is not hitting reset; they are expecting us to.

Au contraire

August 29, 2014

Categories: Gender, Media

Dennis Scimeca, The Daily Dot:

> *One of the complaints is that if Quinn were a man who slept with women supposedly for influence, the games press would have been all over the story instead of remaining silent and ignoring the story out of fear they'll be tarred with accusations of sexism.*
>
> *Au contraire. Were the story about a man sleeping with women it would be even less of a story. Readers would virtually high-five the male developer because we celebrate male sexuality and punish female sexuality in our culture.*
>
> *Don't take my word for it. There's decades of scholarly research to demonstrate the point. But it's kind of a lost cause to ask these audience members to bother with research. Anita Sarkeesian has produced some of the best-researched and documented studies of sexism in video games out there. Her critics accuse her of "cherry-picking" her data, however, which boggles the mind.*

I'm with Fleishman.

MMOs, English, and Experiential Learning

August 30, 2014

Categories: Design, Education

Phys.org:

> *The computer games that appear to be most effective for the development of English vocabulary are those known as Massively multiplayer online role-playing games (MMORPG), a genre of role-playing computer games in which a large number of players interact with one another in a virtual world.*
>
> *"As a player you simply have to be able to understand what's being said, to read English and to interact yourself by both writing and speaking English," says Liss Kerstin Sylvén, Associate Professor at the University of Gothenburg, who conducted the study together with Pia Sundqvist, Senior Lecturer in English at Karlstad University.*

I've always considered localization to be the bottleneck in the globally connected society; though, I've never considered it's use in MMOs. Maybe I just assumed that all players were connecting to local servers. Apparently not.

My little sister was adopted from China at age 9. She hadn't had any experience with the English language at the time, nor had she acquired the ability to read or write in her native language due to the lack of adequate education in the orphanage. All of our initial communication was handled through Google Translate. However, within months of being immersed in an English speaking culture, her use and understanding of English skyrocketed at an extremely rapid pace.

On a simpler yet similar note, my own typing skills (not necessarily my grammar) greatly improved by the use of AIM, mIRC, and Battle.net outside if school. Mavis Beacon or other education based software didn't hold a candle to what I was learning through practical, real world use.

When forced to learn a skill because the greater population or infrastructure will not conform to your own methods while their's is efficiently serving the same function, you are forced to learn. I believe this is the trick with edTech and game-based learning. Build a "core" game with limitations and challenges where the player is forced to apply different skills or types of thought to win instead of a "game" that is purely and unabashedly focused on *teaching* a particular skill. Flashing lights, fun noises, and achievements can only go so far. It needs to be an engaging (and possibly addictive) game to teach. Experiential learning is key.

'How to attack a woman who works in video gaming'

September 1, 2014

Categories: Gender, Media

Jenn Frank, The Guardian:

> *See, the best, most successful hate campaign dreams big. For some, it isn't only about targeting one woman, two women, or a handful of women. The endgame is to frighten all women out of the video games industry – no matter what they write, film, create or produce – and to additionally frighten anyone who would support them.*

Social Justice Warriors?

September 2, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender, Media

An all-star roster of games journalists joined Adam Rosser on BBC Radio 5 live's Game On for a discussion on the "social justice warrior." Some of my favorite moments below:

Pat Garratt, VG247:

> *I've seen many squabbles on the Internet and they do sort of go the way of the dodo. I think what we are actually seeing is this section of the gaming community is about to be pushed out. I think that's why their so angry. It's literally like taking a toy away from a child. If you actually take a toy away from a child, they just completely freak out. This is exactly what is happening, I think.*

Dan Person, GamesIndustry.biz:

> *There's an awful lot of psychology and studies into this idea of the online personality; This idea of the power of anonymity, and the keyboard warrior and what that kind of does to people when you take away the consequences of actions in that way. That's still a relatively new area of study. The Internet is certainly, in human terms, a very recent invention.*
>
> *I think when you get unfettered and unregulated communities of young, let's face it, mostly men who are operating in this way without any kind of adult or intelligent supervision, they can become very quickly violent and vile and unpleasant. That echo chamber can accentuate that effect. And then when somebody comes into the playroom and says, "hey guys. You know you should stop doing that and perhaps behave like adults," there is often that phase of tantrum, basically. And if those children happen to be handling a large blunt object, then that can become dangerous.*

Keza McDonald, Kotaku UK:

> *The Internet gamifies people. It turns you into someone who's not a real person. You're some imaginary thing on the end of a Twitter handle. It makes it easier for people to behave inhumanly towards you. Anyone who basically decides to do cultural criticism of games that goes beyond just the assessment of software will probably come up against people who ask them, "why can't you just talk about the game?" Again, for these people, games are systems that are self-contained and for them the community and the world of gaming is also a system that is self-contained. So as soon as you start trying to place it in a real world context or you start talking about it in a way that they're not used to, I think that it really confuses people and upsets them.*

Rose Gold Lining

September 2, 2014

Categories: Gender, Health

Mackenzie Craven, Rose Gold Lining:

> *Let's rewind. I'm 26 years old. Freshly married. And healthy! That young, dumb kind of healthy that convinces you it's okay to only see the doctor when you need a prescription filled. You drink green smoothies and run half marathons, therefore you're untouchable – right? Life has been good in this blissful, newlywed, dumb-healthy bubble – perfect, even. Filled with morning coffee and walks to the farmers market hand-in-hand with my husband, Kenny. Bike rides to the breweries, hikes with our dog Hugo. I ate the chia seeds and I wore out my running shoes, so I was completely blindsided by my diagnosis. I have breast cancer?*

Brilliant, brave, and honest. One of the best pieces I've ever read. Take a moment to read and appreciate this woman's work. #KenzieKicksCancer

Anamanaguchi on Song Exploder

September 3, 2014

Categories: History, Music

Peter Berkman and Ary Warnaar, Anamanaguchi:

> *There's a big community of people who will take old Nintendo's from 1985 and use them as synthesizers; people in Sweden, New York, Japan, London; taking apart these old video game consoles and old home computers and using them as synths instead of game consoles. They'd write software specifically for producing music on them.*
>
> ...
>
> *The appeal isn't necessarily using the actual console. The appeal is the limitations. You get such a shortened language of electronic music. It really simplifies the idea of how to build the sounds that you want from the simplest building blocks. It's kind of expanded to using this language of simple digital music but applying it to everything else as well.*
>
> ...
>
> *The cool part about the NES as a sound chip thingy, you get all this bit-quantization which means it has 16 values for volume. When a note fades out, it looks like stairs instead if a diagonal line.*

First off, Song Exploder is a brilliant podcast by Hrishikesh Hirway. Rather than explain it in my own words, here's the official description:

> *A podcast where musicians take apart their songs, and piece by piece, tell the story of how they were made.*

If you're not subscribed, do so now.

I have been a fan of Anamanaguchi since hearing *Another Winter* in the *Scott Pilgrim vs. The World: The Game* demo in 2010. The song sent my mind racing back to the NES era gaming. There is such a comfort in 8-bit sounds.

Anamanaguchi has put out two EPs, a series of singles (including my personal favorite, *Airbrushed*) as well as a debut full-length in the form of a kickstarted double LP titled *Endless Fantasy*. Last year, I had a great time writing up an experimental dual-review of the record against Vampire Weekend's *Modern Vampires of the City* which you can find here.

Give this Song Exploder episode a listen. It's fascinating to learn what goes on behind electronic (namely chiptune) music.

Chocolate-Covered Broccoli

September 10, 2014

Categories: Design, Education

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FktsFcooIG8

Daphne Bavelier, TEDxCHUV: 'Your brain on video games':

> *Now, at this point, a number of you are probably wondering well, what are you waiting for, to put on the market a game that would be good for the attention of my grandmother and that she would actually enjoy, or a game that would be great to rehabilitate the vision of my grandson who has amblyopia, for example?*
>
> *Well, we're working on it, but here is a challenge. There are brain scientists like me that are beginning to understand what are the good ingredients in games to promote positive effects, and that's what I'm going to call the broccoli side of the equation. There is an entertainment software industry which is extremely deft at coming up with appealing products that you can't resist. That's the chocolate side of the equation. The issue is we need to put the two together, and it's a little bit like with food. Who really wants to eat chocolate-covered broccoli? None of you. And you probably have had that feeling, right, picking up an education game and sort of feeling, hmm, you know, it's not really fun, it's not really engaging. So what we need is really a new brand of chocolate, a brand of chocolate that is irresistible, that you really want to play, but that has all the ingredients, the good ingredients that are extracted from the broccoli that you can't recognize but are still working on your brains. And we're working on it, but it takes brain scientists to come and to get together, people that work in the entertainment software industry, and publishers, so these are not people that usually meet every day, but it's actually doable, and we are on the right track. I'd like to leave you with that thought, and thank you for your attention.*

I'm currently playing Valiant Hearts: The Great War. In speaking to the colleague that recommended the game, I told him it feels like perfect edutainment. An extremely engaging action-puzzler, rich with gorgeous music and gut-wrenching narratives, that also aims to teach the historical significance and effects of World War I. A new brand of chocolate.

Will Ferrell's SuperMegaBlastMax Gamer Challenge

September 11, 2014

Categories: Health

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9Lw-2ZGvyLw

WillFerrellHatesCancer.org:

> *Hello people of the video game universe…its your friend Will Ferrell!*
>
> *How would you like to join me for a delightful evening of playing video games together? The only appropriate answer is YES!*
>
> *I want to throw one of the coolest video game events in the history of mankind, possibly even dating back to the time of the dinosaurs, and I'm extending this challenge to gamers: Raise $375,000 for charity and children with cancer and then I'll host the event on October 26th…..AND, one lucky winner (aka one of you reading right now) could join me for this life altering moment in beautiful San Francisco!*
>
> *I'll bring the roll of quarters, all I ask is for you to make a donation in support of children and families suffering from cancer.*

Sounds like a good contest/kickerstarter for a great cause. Head over to WillFerrellHatesCancer.org for more information.

Poisoned Well

September 13, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender

Zoe Quinn, as quoted by The Guardian, on Gamergate:

> *I think right now the well is incredibly poisoned: it's likely a losing battle and that's incredibly disappointing. I also feel like discussing ethics and fairness is antithetical to a campaign originated in and motivated by a fair bit of misogyny and harassment.*

Does it say anything that my Twitter usage, gaming news consumption, and overall web browsing is down by a considerable amount?

It is exhausting to think that digital mobs and trolls may never be stopped due to the anonymous and unquantifiable nature of the digital space. I was young and dumb too, saying things in Quake and Starcraft chat rooms that were likely horrific by today's standards. But I was an in monitored child. It wasn't until real classroom debate, introduction to socially aware music and film, and being called out for my idiocy in person by a respected peer that I wised up.

Is that what we are dealing with? Are these children? Adults? Are they bluffing for fun? How many are there? A handful? Dozens? Hundreds? What failed their social growth?

In the real world, we can identify the source of seemingly monstrous shadows. In the digital world, shadows are the source.

'The most radical thing you can do to support women'

September 14, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender

Anita Sarkeesian, as quoted by The Verge:

> *One of the most radical things you can do is to actually believe women when they talk about their experiences.*
>
> *…*
>
> *Falsehoods about me are initially pushed by detractors who use them to post to 4Chan and Reddit to rally more people to the cause. It's bouncing from Twitter to Tumblr to Facebook to YouTube and back again. Once the cascade reaches a critical mass, it no longer matters what the facts are. It becomes a viral meme.*

I really wish I had the privilege see Sarkeesian speak. Such an inspiring and perseverant woman. Opening and closing to a standing ovation at the XOXO Festival. Amazing.

4K and the Console Gamer

September 14, 2014

Categories: Technology

John Archer, writing for Forbes:

> *What every single person who gets caught up in these hilariously petty arguments fails to recognise is that actually the PS4 and Xbox One are both past their sell by dates. In fact, they've been living on borrowed time from the very day they launched. Why? Because neither of them truly support 4K.*
>
> *This argument might initially seem a stretch to 'normal' people not involved day to day in the inner workings of the AV industry. But I'm confident that within as little as 12 months most of you will agree that their inability to deliver games at a '4K' or Ultra High Definition (UHD) resolution of 3840×2160 pixels – or something close to it, at least – will make both the supposedly 'next generation' consoles feel like yesterday's news.*

I don't know anything about John Archer or his qualifications so I take his opinion about 4K penetration with a grain of salt. However, I would love to believe that 4K will be taking the speedy and monumental strides Archer claims. Relinking to my (premature) excitement about the adoption of 4K.

But where does this fit in with console gaming? Contrary to Archer's argument, I don't believe the core console gamer will put up much of a fuss as long as 1080 is the maximum render their console of choice offers. If anything, there will be a continued and tired assault from PC gaming enthusiasts as to why this is a sign that PC gaming is better. Though he's speaking on the software front, I believe the points made Polygon's Chris Grant on console software's generational obsolesce are relevant.

I won't lie and pretend that the resolution differences between the Xbox One and PS4 don't bug me. Even if a huge difference between the two can hardly be seen, there is discomfort in knowing that the specs of the Xbox One can't quite keep up with the PS4. This coming from a guy that continued to enjoy the original Wii long into the PS3/Xbox 360 cycle. But when the difference is as stark as two-fold, graphical comparison must be shelved and each individual system taken on it's own merits. *Metroid Prime 3: Corruption* was a hell of a sight on Wii. Likewise, *The Last of Us* seemed to be on another level against other PS3 titles. That said, it is a far cry from saying core gamers will be upset about not performing at 4K if neither of the HD Twins can perform at that rate.

I won't hold my breath, but wouldn't it be something if the Wii U's successor rendered 4K resolutions in time for the next-gen Legend of Zelda?

'Everything is going to be OK.

September 15, 2014

Categories: Business

Mojang.com, regarding Microsoft's Minecraft acquisition:

> *It was reassuring to see how many of your opinions mirrored those of the Mojangstas when we heard the news. Change is scary, and this is a big change for all of us. It's going to be good though. Everything is going to be OK. <3*

If I were a Minecraft player, these words would not bode well with me.

John Gruber after Apple's September 2014 Special Event (iPhone 6, Apple Watch):

> *Believe it or not, this might be the biggest tech news of the day in the Gruber household.*

I believe it.

The Internet Rage Machine

September 15, 2014

Categories: Culture

Peter Cohen, iMore:

> *These days the Internet Rage Machine swings into overdrive at the drop of a hat. Everyone uses almost every excuse to get angry about whatever they can. Because rage drives traffic, and traffic can drive revenue when you run a web site that's dependent on page impressions and unique visits to generate traffic for advertisers. For some people, it's all about going viral and getting eyes on your pages.*
>
> *And for others, it's just about venting your spleen because it's the Internet, and that's what people do because they're angry all the damn time or they just want to be heard and acknowledged.*

Context aside, Cohen crushes Internet rage. If you're going to offer feedback, positive or negative, make it specific and constructive. If you're going to vomit nonsensical ignorance/hate/rage, don't. I'm done listening.

Sacrifice in the name of quality: Blizzard cancels Titan

September 23, 2014

Categories: Business, Design

Blizzard co-founder and CEO Mike Morhaime, as quoted by Polygon:

> *It's always really, really hard to make those kind of decisions. It was hard when we canceled Warcraft Adventures. It was hard when we canceled StarCraft Ghost. But it has always resulted in better-quality work.*

I have a new found appreciation for calling it quits on high-stakes, heavily invested projects. Apple, Nintendo, Pixar — companies I deeply admire — share a singular characteristic: Sacrifice in the name of quality. The iPod OS came from Pixo, a company founded by two ex-Apple Newton developers. The history of the *Animal Crossing* franchise is rooted in the short-lived Nintendo 64DD. Even Pixar knows a thing or two about canceling huge investments.

Ed Catmull, Creativity, Inc., on the cancellation of *Newt*:

> *There are some who will read this and conclude that putting this film into production in the first place was a mistake. An untested director, an unfinished script—it's easy to look back, after the shutdown, and say that those factors alone should have dissuaded us at the outset. But I disagree. While it cost us time and money to pursue, to my mind it was worth the investment. We learned better how to balance new ideas with old ideas, and we learned that we had made a mistake in not getting very explicit buy-in from all of Pixar's leaders about the nature of what we were trying to do. These are lessons that would serve us very well later as we adopted new software and changed some of our technical processes. While experimentation is scary to many, I would argue that we should be far more terrified of the opposite approach. Being too risk-averse causes many companies to stop innovating and to reject new ideas, which is the first step on the path to irrelevance. Probably more companies hit the skids for this reason than because they dared to push boundaries and take risks—and, yes, to fail.*
>
> *To be a truly creative company, you must start things that might fail.*

While *Titan* is (sadly) added to the list of cancelled Blizzard projects (it still pains me to think of *StarCraft: Ghost*), I commend the company for sacrificing in the name of quality. I have always deeply admired Blizzard.

Anamanaguchi Pops It

September 23, 2014

Categories: Music

Today Anamanaguchi released their new single "Pop It." It's a bit of a departure from chip-tune pop-punk but I can't argue with the hooks. This band is too good. Really wish I had enrolled in the School of Chip-Tune.

UPDATE: "Pop It" is now featured in this Target commercial. That is huge.

'There and Back Again: A History of The Lord of the Rings in Video Games'

September 25, 2014

Categories: Design, History

Alexa Ray Corriea, Polygon:

> *The Tolkien Estate still firmly holds the score of books and snippets that fill out the world of Arda beyond The Lord of the Rings and The Hobbit — called Tolkien's legendarium — close to its chest. Christopher Tolkien upholds his position as keeper of the keys to Middle-earth; the IP remains split; and The Silmarillion is still locked away, out of reach from those who might adapt Tolkien's deeper mythology.*
>
> *But after more than 30 years of video game adaptations, things don't seem to be slowing for developers like Turbine and Monolith Productions. With The Lord of the Rings Online still bringing in players and Shadow of Mordor poised up against other major franchises like Dragon Age and Assassin's Creed, it looks like the industry will still be talking Tolkien for years to come.*

A fascinating dive into The Tolkien Estate. Tremendous piece by Corriea.

Digital Amnesia

September 26, 2014

Categories: Culture, History, Technology

A must see 50 minute documentary on digital record keeping and our history.

Internet Archive founder Brewster Kahle, Digital Amnesia:

> *We're going to want archives of every form, of all of the different generations: Physical form, the micro-film form, when they lived on CD-ROMs, when they're on hard drives, when they're on the next optical polygraphic whatever. We're going to want to keep each one of these generations to make sure that we have a way of knowing what really happened and not make it so that people can go and change the past.*

I am all for digital goods and less physical clutter, but there is something so fleeting about it. I recently wrote about my theory of technological rubber-banding; a craving for analog technologies in an increasingly digital world.

I'm not sure if I've brought up my practice of buying physical (preferably hardback) books once I complete the ePub version. Why not start with the physical version? Reading books has always been a personal challenge. I find it less daunting to visualize and feel one page at a time on a static tablet rather than see exactly how much more I have to read in physical space. Then why the physical version? I use it as a trophy and physical memento of the book. Too quickly do I forget the contents of books. Seeing one that I have completed on my shelf is a positive reminder that I have not only finished reading the book but that I had actually read it at all.

Over the past few years, I have grown deeply concerned over the preservation of digital history, beginning with early software including video games and code printed in the backs of magazines. It became even more alarming when I heard the following quote from Blake J. Harris, author of Console Wars, on the HarperAudio Presents podcast:

> *When you're a kid, you're not always conscience of how you choose your interests. I always felt like it wasn't a choice to play video games. It was part of your lifestyle.*
>
> *Getting a Genesis for my birthday a few years ago reminded me of all of that. I hooked it up, thinking it would be sort of nice and nostalgic to play these games again, but I found that not only was it that, but these games were still very enjoyable and very challenging.*
>
> *Knowing that this was such a big part of my life and that there were so many hours spent and so many entertaining games and aspects to the culture, I went to Barnes & Noble on 86th Street. It's an enormous Barnes & Noble. I asked where the video game history section was, assuming it would be near the film history or music history sections. The woman pretty much laughed at me. That it was pretty amazing. For an industry that's bigger than music and film, there was not only a video game history section but when I asked for one of the books on Sega and Nintendo, the woman told me there was no such book that they could even order. The only thing they had on video games in the entire store was walkthrough guides.*
>
> *That was kind of shocking to me. It wasn't like a light went off and I thought, "I will fill this need!" But I did.*

Even more shocking is the vanishing of historical online events in MMOs and the like; events that are completely digital yet full of human, communal interaction. This is one of the most re-listenable podcast episodes I have found. I still have a hard time not tearing up during the close:

Stanford University gaming curator Henry Lowood on the Library of Congress commissioned "Preserving Virtual Worlds" project, as heard in A Life Well Wasted: "Gotta Catch 'em All":

> *In terms of practical projects, there are basically two things:*
>
> *One is preservation of games. We have, for example, the Cabrinety Collection. We have roughly 25,000 games from before the early 1990's.*
>
> *Also, a lot of work that we are doing is on how the heck we're going to be able to make sure people have access to games and especially the multiplayer networked games and things that happen in those games 50, 100, 200 years from now. How are we going to save that history knowing that for other media such early film much of that early history of was lost?*

Jason Scott, digital historian, Digital Amnesia:

> *The half-life of software is insane. The fact that we go from "this working" to "this not working" in not just the span of a lifetime but in the span of less than a generation. And I mean unreadable. Like unreadable, physically unreadable because the signal is gone. Or physically unreadable because there's no device to read it or the documentation is gone.*

Earlier this year, a friend of mine and I rounded up as much audio content from our time playing in bands in the early 2000s that we could find and launched the Altamont Archives. (Written article here.) While we were able to scrounge together a majority of the content, much of it was lost to bad CDs, no backups, no access to master recordings, and low-kbps audio rips. It's gut wrenching to remember that there were songs you loved that you will never hear again. Complete memories lost.

I am less concerned about changing the past and more concerned about forgetting the story of the Information Age. I recently had a nostalgic back-and-forth with game designer Pete Vigeant about hearing our first MP3. Until then, we were convinced computers would only ever be capable of MIDI output and unable to deliver high-quality organic sound. It was a blip in time that will likely be forgotten or at the very least delivered as a footnote in a grade school history textbook. But to our generation, it was (to use Vigeant's words) "sorcery."

Stats v. Story

September 30, 2014

Categories: History

Love this.

John Gruber with Ben Thompson on The Talk Show:

> ***JG**: I have a good friend, Matt, who's a fellow Yankee's fan. His theory is that there's two types of sports fans: Stats fans and story fans. Now, anytime you try to say there's only two types of people, of course there's a grey zone. Some stats guys are a little bit into the story side and some story guys are still interested in some of the stats. I'm a story guy though, in his telling. I just don't get into the numbers that much. I believe in clutch hitting. I believe in clutch performance. I know that's one of the stat's guys' things, like the baseball prospectus guys (Bill James, etc.), that there's a theory they try to backup that there's no such thing as clutch hitting.*
>
> *You say there's no such thing as clutch hitting, and I say Derek Jeter. I don't see how you could deny it.*
>
> *The whole Jeter "Farewell" thing is just chock-full of all sorts of statistics and stuff like that. But one of the most amazing ones is (and this is off the top of my head, I'm not going to look it up), he's played 158 post-season games. A regular baseball season is 162 games and most guys would be lucky to play 158. Even players who aren't insured take a game off here and there. So he's played easily the equivalent of a full regular season, all post-season. Which by definition is only against the very best pitchers and opposing teams. Every post-season game is against a team who was good enough to make it to the post-season. And he's got like a .320 career post-season batting average. Enough that it would win the batting title most years. And that's in the post-season.*
>
> ***BT**: That's really impressive because batting averages drop significantly in the post-season.*
>
> ***JG**: Right. Because the pitching is so much better. So much better. Really, that's the way to win post-season baseball games, is to have amazing pitching.*
>
> *Remember the White Sox, when they won in 2006? Whatever year it was. Whatever year the Chicago White Sox won a decade ago, they won the World Series in four games. Their four pitchers pitched four complete games. It was unbelievable. They had four pitchers who caught fire, were just unhittable, and they just went "one, two, three, four. The World Series is over."*
>
> ***BT**: It's like having a hot goalie in hockey or something. You can just shutout everything else.*
>
> ***JG**: And tech is exactly the same. There's story guys and stats guys.*

Reading it back, I am reminded of Jon Hamm's brilliant opening monologue to the 2013 ESPYs.

I am also reminded why I remain focused on the games industry. I have been fortunate enough to grow along side a budding industry from its toddlerhood (1985) to the behemoth it has become. The video game industry has yet to shake it's growing pains but its effect on pop-culture at large has been breathtaking to watch. (While writing this, Pharrell released the video game inspired music video for "It Girl", (and it may be a good indication of what is wrong with the culture).)

Over the course of the next-gen launch, the focus has been on story. None more so than Nintendo. Focus all you want on stats, Nintendo's story is still one to believe in.

Welcome to Warp Zone!

September 30, 2014

Categories: Music



Producer, musician, and fashion designer Ken Nana has released his debut EP, Welcome to Warp Zone! As the name suggests, the 6-track instrumental EP was inspired by Super Mario levels (keep an ear out for *Super Mario Bros. Super Show!* samples) and is comprised of futuristic airy beats a la *Radiohead*, *FKA twigs*, and fellow future-beat-making, space-minded, skate-punks *Infinity Shred*.

Download for free at NanaLifestyle.com. Support at the iTunes Store. Cover art by Curtis Parker.

IGN's Top 125 Nintendo Games of All Time

October 1, 2014

Categories: Design, History

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_oD83lergBU

To round out their 125th Nintendo Anniversary celebration, Nintendo has released their the same Let's Plays I've been thoroughly enjoying for over a month).

IGN:

> *Nintendo merely publishing a game that was developed by a third party does not make it eligible - for a game to be considered a "Nintendo game" in our eyes, Nintendo has to have had a hand in the development process itself. This excludes games like Golden Sun (developed by Camelot and published by Nintendo) and Meteos (developed by Q Entertainment and published by Nintendo).*

The lack of third-party games published by Nintendo never crossed my mind. A truly impressive catalog from a truly revolutionary company. Again, a story I can believe in.

Portal's Influence on RAC's "Let Go (feat. Kele & MNDR)

October 1, 2014

Categories: Music

RAC on Song Exploder:

> *I actually used this application called Melodyne. It's sort of like Auto-Tune but it's all done manually, so it's not really automatic in that sense. You can really mess with a vocal and kind of turn it into this mechanical thing. Really play with the formant. There's all this stuff that you can do and I use that pretty extensively in this song.*
>
> *There's this trick with Melodyne; it's basically when you remove all the variations, it creates this kind of robotic sound. That's what I did a lot with Kele's vocal, not in the verses but during these sections, which I actually got from the video game Portal.*

I am a big fan of RAC. *Strangers* quickly became my go-to jogging album when I lived in San Francisco. As RAC puts it, "a pop album with substance." RAC's inspiration from Giacchino's work on LOST and perspective on remixing versus original work are interesting. Great episode of an incredible podcast.

For those who come here for games industry commentary unfamiliar with his work, check out RAC's *Nintendo Vs Sega* and *Nintendo Vs Sega 2*.

On Strike Teams, Design Councils, and Braintrusts

October 3, 2014

Categories: Business, Design

Philip Kollar, Polygon:

> *Though Blizzard had split into multiple teams working on different games, part of Metzen's approach to keep the culture together was to ensure that those teams still worked together in some ways. To accomplish this, the developer came up with the idea of "strike teams."*
>
> *"A bunch of people who are specifically not on the team for a game, who don't have any sort of connection to the game, come in and look at your game," says StarCraft 2 director Dustin Browder. "They go, 'Wow, that's dumb! I hate it!' They're not nice. We don't want them to be nice. At some point, these games are going to go into the wild, and you're going to ask people for real money for them. Strike teams are supposed to come in and go, 'This is really good! This is really bad! I'm not going to tell you how to fix it, but you've got to do something.' And then they walk off."*
>
> *In addition to strike teams, games frequently appear before Blizzard's "design council," a gathering of all of the game directors and lead designers throughout the company. Between strike teams and appearances before the design council, one thing regarding Titan became clear: It wasn't shaping up.*

If Blizzard's cancellation of Titan reminded me of how Pixar handles things, "strike teams" and the "design council" certainly sound like a Pixar Braintrust.

Ed Catmull with Amy Wallace, Creativity, Inc.:

> *The Braintrust, which meets every few months or so to assess each movie we're making, is our primary delivery system for straight talk. Its premise is simple: Put smart, passionate people in a room together, charge them with identifying and solving problems, and encourage them to be candid with one another. People who would feel obligated to be honest somehow feel freer when asked for their candor; they have a choice about whether to give it, and thus, when they do give it, it tends to be genuine. The Braintrust is one of the most important traditions at Pixar. It's not foolproof—sometimes its interactions only serve to highlight the difficulties of achieving candor—but when we get it right, the results are phenomenal. The Braintrust sets the tone for everything we do.*
>
> *In many ways, it is no different than any other group of creative people—within it, you will find humility and ego, openness and generosity. It varies in size and purpose, depending on what it has been called upon to examine. But always, its most essential element is candor. This isn't just some pie-in-the-sky idea—without the critical ingredient that is candor, there can be no trust. And without trust, creative collaboration is not possible.*

I'm sure most successful companies have strike teams/design councils/Braintrusts of their own. It's just not every day you get to hear about it from the best of the best.

Grant Kirkhope Releases Banjo-Kazooie OST on Bandcamp

October 4, 2014

Categories: History, Music

Kyle Hilliard, GameInformer:

> *Grant Kirkhope, composer for Rare who created the Banjo-Kazooie soundtrack along with many others, has posted the soundtrack in its entirety online for download.*
>
> *When we say the entire soundtrack, we mean everything. Among the 164 tracks, you will find familiar tunes, but you will also find the small musical cues and fanfares related to things like opening doors and collecting certain objects.*

I've been streaming the *Super Mario 64* OST from YouTube at work a lot lately. (Yes, YouTube.) I understand Nintendo has a sales strategy in place for their OSTs (see *Super Smash Bros. 3DS* Sleep Mode OST), but come on. Want the Super Smash Bros. OST? Here's the deal (emphasis mine):

> *Buy and register both the Super Smash Bros. for Nintendo 3DS and Super Smash Bros. for Wii U games to receive a special soundtrack from Club Nintendo!*

I'm not sure how Kirkhope is able to release this content, but he's got my money. (And I've got a great Nintendo 64 era OST in ALAC.) Download here.

Someone call Koji Kondo and tell him we are ready for his box set.

The Players' Score Enters Final Week of Funding

October 4, 2014

Categories: History, Music

Kickstarter:

> *We want to make an in-depth documentary on the personal and cultural impact of video game music. Have you ever paused a game just to hear the music play? There are thousands of artists inspired by those same sounds.* ***Cover bands*** *are performing phenomenal versions of nostalgic music and* ***chiptune artists*** *are challenging themselves with the original game music methods. Tribute albums are causing collaboration and communication between fans and their* ***favorite composers****. Remix communities are resulting in new composers to score the next generation of games. Festivals are developing into friends and families all because of video game music. We want to capture this phenomenon from many different angles to showcase the amazing communities, people, and effects this music has fostered.*

Speaking of spending money on OSTs, this interesting Kickstarter has entered its final week of funding. Sign me up.

'I didn't know that. I thought we were having fun.'

October 4, 2014

Categories: General, Media

Dialog between Carl Casper (Jon Favreau) and Ramsey Michel (Oliver Platt), Chef:

> ***CC****: What exactly are you doing here?*
>
> ***RM****: I'm eating the food. I'm eating your food.*
>
> ***CC****: I thought my food was needy and cloying.*
>
> ***RM****: Well, I didn't think you'd want to serve me, so I sent somebody else to pick it up.*
>
> ***CC****: What happened between us, that really knocked me for a loop. I mean, you robbed me of my pride and my career and my dignity. And I know people like you don't usually care about that kind of thing…*
>
> ***RM****: That's not necessarily true.*
>
> ***CC****: But you should know it hurts people like me. 'Cause we're really trying.*
>
> ***RM****: You started a flame war with me. Are you kidding me? I buy ink by the barrel, buddy. What are you doing picking a fight with me? I wouldn't challenge you to a cook off.*
>
> ***CC****: I thought I was sending you a private message.*
>
> ***RM****: I didn't know that. I thought we were having fun. It was theater. By the way, what the fuck were you cooking? You totally shat the bed, buddy. How could I back that? You were one of my early boys.*
>
> ***CC****: I had no control over the menu.*
>
> ***RM****: Whatever the case, okay? You seem to be cooking for yourself again. Because this shit is sensational. I mean, really, really good.*
>
> ***CC****: Thank you.*

I really enjoyed this movie. Very simple and to the point. Good food is great, my opinion on critics (including myself) is iffy at best, and Twitter can be terrible. In a world of limited text, context counts. Inspiring, real stuff. Well done, Favreau.

Sexism, Lies and Video Games: The Culture War Nobody Is Winning

October 5, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender

Leigh Alexander, writing for Time:

> *As video games unshackle from old constraints, traditional fans double down on keeping the treehouse sacrosanct. The tension between "games as product" and "games as culture" is visible within these online controversies as everyone invested in the industry watches to see which will "win". Someone should tell the internet conspiracy theorists they can relax — we'll absolutely, definitely have both.*

One of Alexander's many terrific pieces. Another great bit at Daring Fireball. (via Peter Hollo)

Hard-Working Schlubs

October 6, 2014

Categories: Media

Jeremy Parish writing on his 2-dimensions.com blog:

> *Video games are made by hard-working schlubs, and they're written about by hard-working schlubs, and both categories of schlub do so in service of the hard-working schlubs who do their schlubbing so they can afford to buy video games. We're not so different, you and I.*

Great perspective piece on 10+ years working in the gaming press. I have Parish, in part, to thank for where I am today. From one hard-working schlub, schlubbing to afford to write about video games on the side (because I can't help it either), to another hard-working schlub: Thank you.

The Element of Surprise

October 7, 2014

Categories: Music, Psychology

I have a problem.

I rarely use a hands-free solution to select music while driving with passengers. Directions? No problem. Texting? Forget about it. But with music, I believe in the element of surprise. I believe in it so much, I will risk taking my eyes off the road for it. I have a problem.

If I say to my phone, "play 'Dreams' by Fleetwood Mac," I am sure my audience will have already imposed a judgement on the familiar song without actually being lulled into the pent up, sultry piece. Don't get me wrong. "Dreams" is a phenomenal song and I could never sing enough praise about it, but it's that simple introductory drum-to-bass fill that puts it over the top. It's the hook that lights you up when it surprises you on the radio or in your playlist/mixtape. Entering into the song with the intro, "play 'Dreams' by Fleetwood Mac," kills the element of surprise. Most people (your truly included) will have already jumped to Stevie howling "it's only right" over the somber drums, bass, and swelling guitar. If not that, then the legendary chorus. I can't imagine the intro is their first thought.

For context, other examples include:

- "You Make My Dreams" - Daryl Hall & John Oates
- "Don't Stop 'Til You Get Enough" - Michael Jackson
- "Higher Ground" - Stevie Wonder
- "Understanding In A Car Crash" - Thursday
- "Sussudio" - Phil Collins
- "Invisible Touch" - Genesis

Until consumer tech is able to read minds, I don't think this is a problem for technology to solve. The real problem here is caring way too much about what other people think. That is a problem I need a solution to now.

The Innovators

October 7, 2014

Categories: Culture, Technology

Earlier this evening, I had the very fortunate privilege of attending The Morris Series: Leadership and Innovation, featuring Walter Isaacson put on by The Aspen Institute. Even more fortunate that today is the release date of his latest book, The Innovators.

The introductory illustrated timeline of innovation in the book reads with the following dates:

- 1993 (Mosaic, AOL)
- 1994 (Web log and directory, Pathfinder)
- 1995 (Wiki Wiki Web)
- 1997 (Deep Blue)
- 1998 (Google)
- 1999 (Blogger)
- 2001 (Wikipedia)
- 2011 (Watson)

The decade long gap between 2001 and 2011 is a bit alarming. Was it glazed over as said decade has been under careful watch by Isaacson's primary audience and may read as redundant? Is it simply that he aims to address said decade within the book? I'm hoping for the latter.

Not only did the late '90s account for the blossoming of the Internet as we know it, but 2001 marks the year of the September 11 attacks. Two critical events intersecting on a single timeline. Add in adolescence (the insane flourishing of ideas, rebellion, and independence — this particular generation referred to as "millennials" by some), and you have the perfect mixture for... something...

If not from himself, this "something" is what I hope someone of Isaacson's stature addresses. A large majority of the fresh engineering talent, and possibly the next round of innovators, moving into the professional workplace witnessed both the late '90s blossoming of the Internet as well as the September 11 attacks during adolescence. That *must* shape the philosophical and social ideas surrounding up-and-coming technology in a profound way, and I would love to know how.

Myst TV Drama and Companion Video Game

October 8, 2014

Categories: General

Deadline:

> *“Cyan’s goal in working with Legendary is not just to create a compelling TV drama but to develop a true transmedia product that will include a companion video game that extends the story across both media,” the company said. “Seventy percent of tablet owners use their device while watching TV at least several times a week. Cyan sees the potential to push the boundaries of interactive storytelling to a new level.”*

Seems like good timing with the return of Twin Peaks and the nostalgia surrounding the LOST 10 year anniversary.

That said, I don't feel the second-screen experience has been the revolution that hopefuls (HBO, etc.) had cracked it up to be. I have a difficult time pulling myself away from a good story to send an email, text, or surf the web. I have a hard time believe that "70 percent" is enjoying good TV. While a new Myst companion game sounds enticing, I have extreme reservations that I'll be able to enjoy a world as rich and mysterious as Myst simultaneously on TV and iPad. The best I can picture is a children's TV-esque situation where the actors on-screen "wait" for you to complete a puzzle before proceeding.

On the other hand, I love Myst and have very vivid memories of talking through the games with both my step-father at home and father 400 miles away. I enjoyed the game so much that I convinced my grade-school teacher to allow me to write a book report based in the strategy guide. Needless to say, I'll be tuning in.

One Hell of a Talk from Anita Sarkeesian at the 2014 XOXO Festival

October 8, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender, Media

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ah8mhDW6Shs

Anita Sarkeesian, XOXO Festival:

> *For these detractors, it is easier to believe that I'm a skin-bleaching, mind-controlling, video-game-hating, scam artist involved in a masterful long-con than it is to believe that the tide is turning in gaming. That larger numbers of developers and fans are challenging the sexist status-quo and embracing the ideas and critiques expressed in my work and the work of many other women doing the same cultural criticism.*

That about sums up #gamergate. We are extremely fortunate to brave folks like Sarkeesian facing this head-on.

Captain Toad is Genius

October 11, 2014

Categories: Design, General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=32nV2PKIv5Y

In June 2014, during Nintendo's E3 Digital Event, a short, minute long trailer for *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* was tucked between two larger developer interviews for *Yoshi's Woolly World* and the much talked about *Legend of Zelda* for Wii U. Not only was the trailer a bit hidden, it was never verbally acknowledged throughout the course of the 45-minute event. It was a curious trailer, but was the one that stuck with me long after E3. A splinter in my mind.

For those unfamiliar, the origin of *Captain Toad* is rooted in bonus stages strewn throughout the *Super Mario 3D World* world map. As players collect stars and progress through the game, Captain Toad stages are unlocked. More from the *Super Mario 3D World* Wikipedia entry:

> *Additional Green Stars can be earned in Captain Toad levels, where players control the slow Captain Toad as he navigates puzzle-like stages using the GamePad's functionality, and Mystery Houses, where players must clear a series of challenges with short time limits.*

Not only is Captain Toad slow, he does not have the ability to jump; a staple in the Mushroom Kingdom. The player is forced to keep their wits about them, outsmarting the level design by means of the camera, shifting their perspective over the tiny cube-shaped levels. This imposition of limits is integral to great game design. It makes for gameplay that almost feels foreign amongst the landscape of current shooters and platformers. Strategy becomes the emphasis.

In late August, in an interview with EDGE Magazine, Shigeru Miyamoto made comments about the state of "core" vs. "casual". The interpretation from Rob Fahey at GamesIndustry.biz hit the nail on the head:

> *At the same time, though, Nintendo itself has a conception of "casual" and "core" that probably isn't shared by the majority of sites reporting Miyamoto's comments. Miyamoto talks not about themes but about enjoyment of challenge as the distinction between the two groups. To him, a supposedly "adult" game full of blood and ripe language could be utterly casual if it spoon-feeds players with dull, linear gameplay. Meanwhile, a brightly coloured Mushroom Kingdom epic could qualify as "core" if it challenges players in the right way. Consequently, Nintendo's family-friendly IP and the broad appeal of its themes is entirely compatible with a focus on "core games", to Miyamoto's mind. What he's talking about changing is something at the root of design, not the thematic wallpaper of the company's games; he wants to challenge people, not to force Nintendo's artists to remove all the primary colours from their Photoshop palettes.*

I think this is exactly what we can expect from *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker*.

On top of great level design, the aesthetic design preserves the same gorgeous caliber we've seen in *Mario Kart 8* and *Super Mario 3D World*. The levels are lush and appear to be brimming with tiny details, animations, humor, and secrets. I will echo my Hail Mario piece and say that "Nintendo is unabashedly gunning for Disney-level aesthetics; a tactic to win over most demographics."

To add, filling out a Toad with unique characteristics rather than the ambiguous, multi-colored placeholders they have traditionally been known as (see *New Super Mario Bros. Wii*) brings more definition to the Mushroom Kingdom. And with this new, unique character comes new, unique gameplay. *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* shows that Nintendo is looking to explore the depths of the Mushroom Kingdom, and proves that there is more there than just simple platformers. We haven't seen much of this dynamic since the *Luigi's Mansion* series; a stand-alone IP centered on a familiar character with unique gameplay and design.

When playing *Super Mario 3D World*, I race for every Captain Toad level the instant they are unlocked. They are clever, challenging departures from the platforming world Mario inhabits. Something tells me I am not the only one of the few million *Super Mario 3D World* players to do so. For those unfamiliar with Captain Toad, they will be pleasantly surprised with the over 70 gorgeous, challenging, classic Nintendo designed levels to explore. For those few million that have already had a taste of Captain Toad, you can bet they are itching for more of the playful puzzle mini-game. And assuredly, with Nintendo's move to DLC (*Mario Kart 8*) , there will be plenty more to come.

Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker debuts in Japan on November 13, 2014. Subsequent release dates as follows:

NA: December 5, 2014
EU: January 2, 2015
AUS: January 3, 2015

Three Monkeys

October 13, 2014

Categories: Accessibility, Design

Jordan Erica Webber, The Guardian:

> *In that demo, a sprite called Yoska teaches the player how to use their hearing to hunt a bird and shoot it down with a bow and arrow and fight bandits and goblins with a sword. It sounds like something you'd expect to do in a modern big-budget RPG, which Willey says is intentional: "What we're really aiming for is an audio game that has a kind of AAA [those with the highest development budgets and levels of promotion] feel about it."*
>
> *That should appeal to vision-impaired players such as Harlow, whose experience of "real video games" before he lost his sight has led him to consider many audio games "kind of bad, and just not entertaining". But Willey and Satizabal both hope sighted players will enjoy the game too, so that they can have a shared experience with those who are vision-impaired.*

Sounds extremely interesting and like a great focus for game development. Start any piece with the words *Super Mario 64* and you'll have my attention.

Exercising With Nothing But An Xbox

October 13, 2014

Categories: Health

Stephie Grob Plante, writing for xoJane:

> *The free songs -- including "Counting Stars" by OneRepublic and "#thatPower" by will.i.am ft. Justin Bieber -- are not necessarily my jam(s), but it's hard to complain about free. As I scroll through the song purchase options, I grumble at the glut of current(ish) tracks and dearth of classics. Swipe, swipe, swipe -- WAIT: "Creep" by TLC for $1.99?! I hadn't planned on buying anything, but...sold.*
>
> *With one solid tune and a wealth of moves like "Niece," "Rejectin," and "Pros and Cons," my childhood aspiration of becoming an In Living Color Fly Girl -- a very real, very unattainable dream -- feels within reach, at least from the confines of my 12x16 living room.*

Hilarious read; surprising results.

'Why the Two-Hour Game is the Future'

October 14, 2014

Categories: Design, General

A great article by Colin Campbell at IGN exploring the gaming community's need and desire for shorter yet emotionally fulfilling games such as *Journey*, *Limbo*, and *Dear Esther:*

> *[...] the two-hour narrative game has arrived as something with a definite beginning, middle, and end. It's a story that is designed to be played through entirely in one sitting. It does not demand the kind of time-investment of a game like Mass Effect 3, nor does it attempt to persuade you to join a sub-culture of online enthusiasts like Call of Duty. Nor is it crafted to ensnare you with addictive tricks, like Angry Birds. It is downloadable and priced at the cost of a movie ticket and a bag of popcorn.*

The article includes interviews with game developers Jenova Chen (*Journey*), Dan Pinchbeck (*Dear Esther*), Edmund McMillen (*Super Meat Boy*), and Dino Patti (*Limbo*).

Dan Pinchbeck:

> *[...] we've got this slightly weird situation where it's all or nothing, right? It either has to be something that basically takes you the amount of time it takes you to have a bowel movement or it's got to last you for six months. There's nothing in the middle and that just seems weird and crazy.*

The article also explores developer's desires to work on smaller games due to the developer's ability to experience creativity more freely rather than be pressured by massive, corporate controlled budgets and large, separated development teams.

Jenova Chen:

> *If you make something artistic you need to reach a very strong coherence in the development team so the game has a singular voice. A very clear vision, so that the audience who experience the game can clearly get that voice or get the vision. If you have hundreds of people working on something there's no way of working on the game towards the same direction. When you have three hundred people working on something the game just felt like a huge crowd of people singing but they're not well orchestrated. It sounds loud, it sounds impressive, but you don't know what they are singing. You don't know what the game is about.*

A worthwhile read that I can get behind!

Recently, I have found that I have very little time to invest in gaming. When I do find that time, I do not want to attempt jumping into a massive story, knowing I'll likely forget what was going on, forget how the mechanics work the next time I play it, or never finish the game, nor do I want waste my time on grinding in an MMO or flinging birds into bricks.

[This was originally posted on 4/18/12 on my previous thestarrlist.tumblr.com blog; reblogged in regard to Ben Kuchera's piece *To hell with longer games, tell me how SHORT your game is*.]

A $60 Gamble

October 14, 2014

Categories: Business, Media

Host of the DLC podcast Jeff Cannata to co-host Christian Spicer regarding the Driveclub launch:

> *I think you brought up a really interesting point in saying, "we should be able to return these games." The idea that this industry as a whole has figured out a way to convince the public that they can't return broken products, that you buy it and you're screwed, that there's no lemon law for software, is a little bit ridiculous.*

After hearing this, I was immediately reminded of why I continue to base my video game purchases on reviews. If a return policy and/or less expensive price-tag was put in place, would I be willing to take more chances? I'm not entirely sure. But as it stands, I am not willing to take, as DLC guest Brian Brushwood put it, "a $60 gamble."

'How Reviews Impact Those Who Create'

October 14, 2014

Categories: Business, Design, Media

Speaking of reviews, here's a interesting follow-up from the side of developers.

Brian P. Shea, IGN:

> *Ultimately, reviews should never be viewed as the final word on a game. Instead, they're guidelines for readers to apply to their own personal taste. If a review gives a game a 7.0 and cites poor multiplayer a one of the game's issues, but you don't intend on playing the multiplayer, you can synthesize that review and conclude that you might be very likely to enjoy the game more than the critic - and that's OK.*

A worthwhile read but I maintain that a 7.0 persists as a flag. It is likely going to deter consumers from a $60 gamble "to apply their own personal taste."

'An irredeemably dark version of Alice's Adventures in Wonderland'

October 15, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender, Media

T.C. Sottek writing for The Verge:

> *Still, it's important for reasonable people to speak up, if only to set the terms of reality — something Gamergate's most hardcore supporters don't even seem to grasp. Gamergate's echo chamber is an endless rabbit hole of paranoia, like an irredeemably dark version of Alice's Adventures in Wonderland. The entire affair is built on trolling, counter-trolling, anger, and ignorance; Gamergate's forums exhibit deranged skepticism in almost everything, including vicious doubts about every woman who speaks up against harassment and threats. Entire threads have been devoted to accusing Sarkeesian and other recipients of hatred and violence of running false-flag campaigns to elevate their own status. In their world, everyone who's not on their side is a "shill" who's lying for attention.*

Not long ago, I was celebrating the social brilliance of *Twitch Plays Pokémon;* a weeks-long, virtual slog with an estimated 658,000 participants that, looking back, actually had tremendous potential for mass frustration, intimidation, and organized harassment. Instead, the community-at-large generated spontaneous and fascinating politics, factions, deities, usurpers, and home-brewed mythology that eventually panned in favor of progress and the completion of the game.

Needless to say, I am completely floored by the idiocy and insanity of Gamergate.

'My opinion is I hate it.'

October 16, 2014

Categories: General

Dialog between Gil Pender (Owen Wilson) and Ernest Hemingway (Corey Stoll), Midnight in Paris:

> ***GP**: Would you read it?*
>
> ***EH**: Your novel?*
>
> ***GP**: Yeah, it's about 400 pages long, and I'm just looking for an opinion.*
>
> ***EH**: My opinion is I hate it.*
>
> ***GP**: Well you haven't even read it yet.*
>
> ***EH**: If it's bad, I'll hate it because I hate bad writing, and if it's good, I'll be envious and hate all the more. You don't want the opinion of another writer.*

If you're not sold on this exchange, I'll do you one better. A beautiful film. Made for nostalgists like myself.

The Verge Reviews the New Nintendo 3DS

October 21, 2014

Categories: General

Sam Byford, The Verge:

> *The 3DS is worth owning for the same reason the Wii U is: its software library is spearheaded by Nintendo, one of the most consistent and talented developers in the world. There's no doubt that smartphones have taken a big chunk out of the DS' user base, but all that proves is that a whole lot of people bought a DS because it was first to what we would now call smartphone-style games. In 2014, many smartphone games are fantastic; very few of the fantastic ones are traditional video games. And if you like traditional video games, you should absolutely own a 3DS.*

I love my Wii U. Really looking forward to owning a New Nintendo 3DS.

Official Elder Scrolls Books Coming March 2015

October 21, 2014

Categories: General

Official Bethesda Blog:

> *Not since Encyclopedia Britannica's heyday have volumes of books looked this cool and demanded to be on your bookshelf. With The Elder Scrolls Online, two volumes covering "The Land" and "The Lore" feature never-before-seen art and extensive lore surrounding the game. Meanwhile, by popular demand, the Skyrim series offers the first opportunity to get all of the game's in-game text across three volumes.*

I always thought it would be great to read written versions of heavy-narrative games. Even with multiple "choose-your-own-adventure" storylines, the writers could choose a plot line to get the point across.

There are plenty of game universes I want to explore (*Elder Scrolls*, *Mass Effect*, and *World of Warcraft* to name a few), but don't have 60+ hours to spare on side-quests, menu navigation, and controller mechanics. Don't even get me started on the time dolled out to obsessive character creation.

While these *Elder Scrolls* "lore" books may not be my ideal solution, they are certainly a better intro to the universes than spin-off, expanded, and/or non-canon storylines.

Chris Kluwe's #Gamergate Piece

October 22, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender

Chris Kluwe:

> *All the real gamers? They're the developers now, the reviewers, the writers and the players who remember a time when you couldn't download a virtual copy of your game, but instead had to go to a Toys"R"Us and hope they had it in stock. The real gamers, both men and women, look at your frantic rantings about "ethics in videogame journalism," and they shake their heads sadly, wondering how you could get sucked in by some script-kiddie /b/tards and conspiracy-nut celebrities gleefully using you as a smokescreen for misogynistic hate. They look at the rich diversity of games that exist now, and they are THRILLED, because no one ever thought we'd get this far, and real gamers like PLAYING GAMES.*
>
> *I know game developers, personally. I know game reviewers, personally. You know what else I know? That both developers and reviewers know each other quite well, because this industry used to be very small. One where you had to be a gamer to want to make a game, or to write reviews, because the money certainly wasn't NFL money. It absolutely wasn't the billion-dollar industry it is now, with games pulling in just as much as blockbuster movies. It was a group of people, doing what they loved, making games, and playing games, and a lot of them are still there, and they're friends!*

In true Kluwe fashion, this piece is delightfully entertaining, well written, and cuts the bullshit.

Speaking of Toys"R"Us, remember these things? Am I dating myself?

RBI

October 22, 2014

Categories: General

2014 World Series, Game 2, Bottom of the 6th: Billy Butler's single brings Lorenzo Cain home, putting the Royals in the lead 3-2, kicking off an inning long rally that would lead to a game winning victory.

Watching this, I was immediately reminded of the wave of pride felt when landing Little League RBIs. The pride was not from the run per se. In my 11th Little League season, I averaged .016 at the plate. I wasn't expected to hit. I was a decent fielder and had a good arm. It's likely I was left in to bat simply because I was not the worst of the 10-12 man team. Close, but not the worst.

I'm not sure what it was about specifically about Butler's RBI, but the memory of this feeling came racing back the way they do when the smell of ABS hits your nose after opening up your first action figure since 1992. There was something potent about it.

In an instant, I was reminded that I've always been a supporter. Whether it is acting as consigliere, assisting behind an email account, or starting a record label solely because I believed in the record, I've always been one to recognize deserving talent and do my best to help said talent get where they need to be. Even with a .016 batting average, I never tired of trying to get my teammates home. And there was no better feeling than getting the star player across the plate. For a moment, Number 1 needed Number 9. Bunting with a man on was infinitely more fulfilling than swinging for the fences with none. (Yes, even I expected to put one over. Every kid does.)

Thanks for the sense of identity, Butler. Congrats on the win.

Clash of Clans Nearly Crushed Kansas City

October 27, 2014

Categories: Design

The Kansas City Star:

> *“Maybe I need to cut back some of my hours on it,” Cain said in July. “I think I’m going to cut back on it a little bit.”*
>
> *Cain was laughing at the time. He may not have been aware that his coaches did not find humor in the situation. The frustration intensified later that month as the Royals frittered away their temporary lead on the Detroit Tigers. As the season burned, “Clash of Clans” acted as the fiddle.*

I just started playing *Clash of Clans*. What a terrible experience. From the get go, it's clear how developer Supercell is laser focused your wallet. To build your city, upgrade defenses, or recruit an army, you need builders. To get builders, you need gems. Other than the pinches of gems that trickle in every day or so, you're teased to pay up. 500 gems for $4.99, 14,000 for $99.99, and everything in between.

The real game is whether or not you can beat the game at its own game; can you last without spending a dime. Unbelievable how people subject themselves to prolonged periods of this crap. In my defense, it serves as a great Pomodoro timer.

Congrats to the Royals on the win. On to Game 7. Such a fun series.

Nintendo Sees $244M in Profit

October 29, 2014

Categories: Business

Nintendo:

> *With respect to "Wii U," Nintendo released "Mario Kart 8" globally in May, which has continued to show steady sales, as well as "Hyrule Warriors," released in September in the overseas markets, which has gained popularity. The worldwide sales of the "Wii U" hardware and software were 1.12 million units and 9.4 million units respectively.*
>
> *...*
>
> *Since the May release of "Mario Kart 8," the "Wii U" platform has been experiencing improved sales momentum.*

Mario Kart 8 remains far and away my go-to Wii U game. I love it. My fianceé loves it. I frequently listen to the soundtrack at work. (Some choice words here.) When I can't sleep, it's enjoyed with a nightcap. Not to mention that it's challenging. Five months after release, I'm still chipping away 100cc stars.

Yours truly, June 1, 2014:

> *Nintendo gambled for positive reviews two weeks before launch, is now chalking up at least $40 in games to every US and Canadian Mario Kart owning household, and prays that their Trojan horse will be the spark to move units. Since release, the game has received stunning accolades, Club Nintendo has been brought down by what can only be assumed as immense traffic for free games, and at least one Wii U newcomer is being tugged at by curiosity.*

Twitch Adds Game Development Category

October 29, 2014

Categories: Design, Media

Polygon:

> *The Game Development category was launched on Oct. 16 and works exactly the same way as a category for a specific game on Twitch. But in this case you're tuning in to watch people develop games live, rather than watch someone playing a released title.*
>
> *"We conducted a Twitch Town Hall session at PAX Prime which is when we let our community share ideas they would like to see implemented on the platform," said Marcus "djWHEAT" Graham, Twitch's director of community and education. "The idea of having a section for game developers was suggested and it resonated with the audience, so that inspired us to add it as a category."*

Twitch has yet to hook me, but this might do the trick.

The Skin of a Rhinoceros

October 30, 2014

Categories: Culture, Sexuality

Tim Cook, writing in Businessweek:

> *Being gay has given me a deeper understanding of what it means to be in the minority and provided a window into the challenges that people in other minority groups deal with every day. It's made me more empathetic, which has led to a richer life. It's been tough and uncomfortable at times, but it has given me the confidence to be myself, to follow my own path, and to rise above adversity and bigotry. It's also given me the skin of a rhinoceros, which comes in handy when you're the CEO of Apple.*

K&K

November 1, 2014

Categories: General

I married the woman of my dreams today. She is challenging and fierce; exuberant and loving. She has improved my perspective on life and attitude toward myself more than any other. She has taught me to love food and jazz and design; important things that require planning but leave room for spontaneity to fill the cracks. She has shown me the importance of patience and slowing down; enjoying a good cup of coffee and a solid read before the workday. She has opened my eyes to a side of life I thought only existed in insanely impossible Nora Ephron films. She is my mentor, my biggest supporter, and my lover. And I am Mrs. Kelley Clarke Starr's biggest fan.

What is a game? And why it matters!

November 6, 2014

Categories: Art, Design

http://youtube.com/watch?v=H0ReU2tvLFo

Yours truly, June 23, 2014:

> *There have been many arguments about the term "video game" and what it actually means in today's world. Many "games" no longer incorporate elements of games (e.g. Journey), causing critics to coin terms like "interactive experiences." I think Siracusa's talk shines light on a better word for modern games (especially first-person design) that has been right under our noses: Simulations.*
>
> *There are games (e.g. Super Mario Bros., Uncharted), there are simulations (e.g. Journey, Dear Esther, Gran Turismo), and there are those that incorporate both (e.g. Halo, Mario Kart). The problem is that no one wants to hear the term "simulation." For most, simulations have been boring since Flight Simulator 2000. On the other hand, games have been fun for centuries.*
>
> *As we move closer to an Oculus future, we move further away from "video games." If anything, I'd argue that the term "video game" does more harm than good for the industry's larger appeal, carrying the baggage of a childish activity regardless of what studies show. "Simulation" may not be perfect the perfect term but it's a word that should be incorporated more often.*

In any case, a very enjoyable argument from Jamin Warren and PBS.

Guerrillas

November 9, 2014

Categories: Design, Military, Politics

Excerpt from “The Bone Clocks” by David Mitchell:

> *I didn’t know what to say. The car edged past a crowded Internet café, full of slack-jawed boys holding game consoles and gazing at screens where American marines shot Arab-looking guerrillas in ruined streetscapes that could easily be Baghdad or Fallujah. The game menu had no option to be a guerrilla, I guess.*
>
> *Nasser fed his cigarette butt out of the window. “Iraq. Broken.”*

Always an interesting perspective.

Embargoes and Appetites

November 10, 2014

Categories: Media

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *When a game's embargo isn't up until the day of launch you need to be careful. If it isn't up until a few hours after the game is launched you should probably run screaming the other way. That's not a signal that the game may have middling reviews, that's a signal that the publisher is trying to sell copies before the word hits the street.*
>
> *It could also meant the game is still being worked on, but any embargo past midnight the night before is sketchy as hell. It's a way to weaponize embargoes, and the best thing to do is to hold off until you can read about the game in detail.*
>
> *...*
>
> *You should always be on the lookout for these situations. The earlier a review hits, often the more confidence the publisher has in the game.*

Earlier this year, I commented that Nintendo "gambled for positive reviews two weeks before launch". Looking back, this was definitely less of a gamble and more a projection with confidence.

From a publisher's perspective, I understand careful consideration over embargo dates. However, if a consumer cares deeply about a reviewer's opinion, there should be no problem in waiting for a trusted opinion. The day-and-date state-of-mind is poison.

This does not, however, address the problem of protection from broken product. This is not film or music— botched playback would never escape manufacturing; a bad bounce would never escape the studio. Pre-orders for products so deeply rooted in real-time mechanics and engineering, notoriously subjected to time crunches and annual release dates, cannot wisely be considered for pre-order without subjection to reviews. While I implore patiently waiting for reviews on this type of product, release date and post-release date embargo lifts, as Kuchera implies, are cowardly and bullshit.

Pre-release embargoes are important, as is our appetite for new product.

Ustwo Offers 8 New Monument Valley Chapters for $1.99, Gets Hammered with 1-Star Reviews

November 11, 2014

Categories: Business, Design

@ustwogames:

> *Seems quite a few people have gone back and 1 star reviewed Monument Valley upon update because the expansion was paid. This makes us sad.*

Terribly sad news. Admittedly, I initially tweeted the new levels were free upon seeing that my app had automatically updated to 2.0. After a quick check and 'duh' moment, said tweet was deleted and replaced with the following:

> *Monument Valley 2.0 by @ustwogames is out! $1.99 IAP for 8 new chapters: https://t.co/5diI1iys0V*
>
> *My review of 1.0: http://t.co/vNJ9V7vBZz*

I'm so thrilled that the folks at Ustwo decided to release additional content for Monument Valley. The game is an artistic treasure; mind-bending and beautiful. Worth well over $6 for the complete package, if you ask me.

Eli Hodapp at TouchArcade has a brilliant piece on the dilemma. Likewise, John Gruber's take is spot on. Relinking to some other worthwhile pieces on free-to-play and premium models:

Ustwo: Monument Valley "left money on the table" with premium pricing Ustwo director of games Neil McFarland on the creative benefits of avoiding free-to-play via GamesIndustry.biz.

Mobile is burning, and free-to-play binds the hands of devs who want to help Barry Meade of Fireproof Games writing for Polygon.

Finishing with an excerpt from my Monument Valley 1.0 review, dated April 6, 2014:

> *It seems the urgency for time has permeated the minds of the developers at ustwo. Monument Valley's 2-3 hour play-through is the perfect amount of that decadent cake. The experience of Monument Valley is sure to please both the hardcore gamer and casual audiences alike. In fact, it is the perfect example of the importance of short and sweet, possibly introducing these polarizing audiences to a new approach in game design as seen in Journey, The Room, or EDGE. And like that decadent cake, Monument Valley's length, design, and puzzles are mesmerizing enough to feel satisfied yet haunting enough to warrant constant craving. If DLC is abound, sign me up.*

Signed up for $1.99 this morning. Would have given more if they asked.

Assassin-in-the-room

November 11, 2014

Categories: Design, Gender

Polygon's Quality Control is a fantastic short-form podcast hosted by Justin McElroy in which video game reviewers (primarily from Polygon) offer insight to their review of a particular new release and answer listener questions.

On today's episode, Polygon Reviews Editor and guest Arthur Gies elaborated on his review of *Assassin's Creed: Unity*.

Upon reading Gies's review, I was taken aback by the lack of mention to the E3 hubbub surrounding Ubisoft creative director Alex Amancio's comments regarding the lack of playable female avatar's in co-op:

> *It's double the animations, it's double the voices, all that stuff and double the visual assets. Especially because we have customizable assassins. It was really a lot of extra production work.*

I posed the following unabridged question to Justin via email:

"Arthur seemed to avoid the elephant-in-the-room regarding female playable characters in co-op. While Polygon (and Arthur) has/have made sexualization and representation an impetus for review scores in the past (see Bayonetta 2 (albeit, on the opposite side of representation)), why was this not addressed? Did Arthur feel that female representation did not affect AC: Unity's overall review? Did he feel the damage had already been done and no more worthwhile discussion could be added? Or was it that Arthur simply wanted us focus solely on the end-product, sharing the detail we may miss when distracted by the elephant?"

Arthur's response, time stamp 8:20, edited for clarity:

> *I mean Arno is the character in the game. And I don't think women are treated particularly well in the game; It's certainly not even close to the most egregious misstep that I've seen in a game this year with regard to that kind of subject matter. And honestly, the game has so many other problems to discuss that at a certain point I feel like I'm running out of reader patience or attention span to get to the heart of the statement that I'm trying to make.*
>
> *With Assassin's Creed: Unity, the traversal problems that the series has had for years and the massive technical issues and a really underwhelming story are all things that undermine Unity very seriously. I could go on at length at various things in the game that bother me but those are the most substantive things that hurt the game. It could still have been a fantastic game despite the absence of women in it as playable avatars. [If that were the case], that might have been a discussion I could have had, but that wasn't as material as everything else.*

Thanks for the time and clarity, Arthur.

Embargoes and Appetites, Simplified

November 12, 2014

Categories: Design, Media

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *This is how publishers should begin looking at their launches: Players with set time and budget concerns are looking for reasons not to buy a game, and the better your game works at launch, the more reasons we have to pick it up.*
>
> *There is always a choice to be had, even if that choice consists of playing the things we haven't yet finished. A bad launch takes you out of the running, and stressed-out players may almost be happy to see you go.*
>
> *This is another reason why pre-ordering games is a terrible idea, and waiting to buy is so smart. If you're not locked into a purchase you can simply buy another game, or wait for things to become more stable. There are people who ran out to pick up Unity yesterday only to get to work and read the reviews. Or worse yet they opened it, played it and are now stuck with a product they can't return.*

A simpler way to read yesterday's rant.

Friendly Freemium Reminder

November 12, 2014

Categories: Business

@ustwogames:

> *That's it, we're giving up the premium game. Next time we're just going to sell you 500 coins for $2 instead.*

Love this tweet.

Relinking to some thoughts I had on *Clash of Clans*; a gross, empty, unfulfilling, time and wallet suck.

Space Age Color Blindness Options

November 13, 2014

Categories: Accessibility, Design

@Spaceageapp:

> *Making sure Space Age is colorblind friendly.*
>
> 
> *Space Age, colorblindness options*

Awesome accessibility awareness. And top level too. (Tap Options on the title screen and there they are!) That alone earned Big Bucket Software my $3.99.

Space Age: A Cosmic Adventure is currently available for iOS. Looking forward to playing. Also hearing great things about the soundtrack by Cabel Sasser.

'A Passionate, Limited Core'

November 15, 2014

Categories: Culture, Media

MIT lecturer Michael R. Trice on #GamerGate numbers, emphasis his:

> *In both the case of tweets and RTs about 500 accounts create half of the total volume in the conversation. Regular daily participation floats around 3,000 users. Then there's a large body of several thousand accounts dipping a toe in the conversation.*
>
> *This suggests that however organized or unorganized the movement, the conversation around #GamerGate on Twitter has a central core limited to a few hundred highly active accounts. The total mass of the conversation is in the tens of thousands, though over 80% of those members are involved on less than a daily basis.*

Interesting case study. Social media can certainly act as a megaphone for tiny groups and individuals. These small groups get even louder when they play to our natural sensitivity toward criticism, threats, and negativity. An 8-year-old kid and sound as legitimate and scary as a group of fully capable 28-year-old adults.

'New Video Games Shouldn't Be So Broken'

November 15, 2014

Categories: Business, Design

Luke Plunkett, Kotaku:

> *I get that making games is hard. That publishers force deadlines on teams, that accounting for millions of players is rough work, that a myriad of technical complexities mean completely eradicating bugs is an impossible task.*
>
> *As a paying customer, though, I just don't care anymore. Why? Because right now, the blockbuster video game industry is taking more than it's giving back.*

Another good read about the growing trend of broken games, the need for bigger testing budgets, and the call not to pre-order games.

Plunkett continues:

> *If a car, or DVD, or rice-cooker, or phone, or basically anything else launched with significant parts not working, or not working as well as advertised, it'd be slammed. People would demand their money back, and they would get it, because there is an expectation that when you pay money for something, it works.*

My similar thoughts from November 11, 2014 below:

> *This does not, however, address the problem of protection from broken product. This is not film or music— botched playback would never escape manufacturing; a bad bounce would never escape the studio. Pre-orders for products so deeply rooted in real-time mechanics and engineering, notoriously subjected to time crunches and annual release dates, cannot wisely be considered for pre-order without subjection to reviews. While I implore patiently waiting for reviews on this type of product, release date and post-release date embargo lifts, as Kuchera implies, are cowardly and bullshit.*

Hat tip to Brett Batesole.

Kate Upton and Game of War

November 18, 2014

Categories: Business

Paul Tassi writing for Forbes:

> *It just seems like a strange pairing, and I think if Upton or her support staff understood the industry more, they'd realize that Game of War is a relatively spammy title compared to other offerings in the video game industry, and rather beneath one of the most famous supermodels in the world. Though I suppose what was almost certainly a multimillion dollar paycheck for no more than a few day's work will draw all the kind words the game requires.*
>
> *It's an interesting, unsettling age we live in where games can be bad by nearly anyone's standards, but still be hugely profitable with enough marketing to herd easily-addicted players toward a microtransaction-stuffed title. It seems to be working quite well with Game of War, but I'm not sure how long these kinds of titles can continue to find success, as they seem to have a short shelf life once players get tired of being milked endlessly.*

While I find the *Game of War* marketing campaign adolescent and lazy, I don't have a problem with Upton being placed in ads or the game itself any more than I do Kevin Spacey in *Call of Duty: Advanced Warfare*. I'm sure she was offered a fine deal for her likeness. In-game celebrity is something we should be getting used to. (Peter Dinklage voiceover in *Destiny*, *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood*)

Regarding Tassi's thoughts on the longevity of "these kinds of titles", *Transformers: Age of Extinction* grossed $1.09B. Bay's *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles* grossed $474.4M. I hope you see what I'm getting at here. And I'm a huge TMNT fan.

UPDATE: It looks like *Game of War* has released a new version of their Twitter campaign, reading "Will you be the hero?" vs. "Will you be my hero?" Note that the banner image differs as well, with less of an upfront focus on Upton. Context suggests "the" seems more in-line than "my", but is this a variant or a rebrand?

'The making of Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker'

November 19, 2014

Categories: Design, History

Danielle Riendeau of Polygon in an *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* producer and director Koichi Hayashida and Shinya Hiratake:

> *"We began with Super Mario 64," Hayashida told Polygon via video conference. "While Super Mario 64 was quite an interesting game, we heard that roughly 20 percent of gamers found it too difficult," he said, brandishing a copy of the Nintendo 64 game. "We kept that comment that the game was too challenging and made games like Super Mario 3D Land and Super Mario 3D World with that in mind."*
>
> *But, in making 3D Land and 3D World, the team felt it was getting away from a fundamental design principle that made Mario 64 so special: the idea that the levels were a sort of "diorama" or a "garden in a box," entire worlds contained in relatively compact structures. In creating the Captain Toad stages for Mario 3D World, the studio was able to go back to that idea, and keep the challenge level accessible.*
>
> *That's how the team created the handful of stages starring Captain Toad for Super Mario 3D World. They represented a different style of play from the traditional 3D platforming in the rest of the game — slower paced and more cerebral, they offered players something of a refresher between obstacle courses and cat-powered wackiness.*

In addition to the variety of interesting cross-overs and spin-offs, it seems like Nintendo has been a bit more open as of late, offering more peaks behind the certain.

As for Captain Toad, I love that *Super Mario 64* stands as its foundation. However, my favorite part of *Super Mario 64* is the challenge. It is always great to take a swing at impossibly difficult missions year after year. There is almost a "young grasshopper" feel to it. I hope *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker's* accessible "challenge level" isn't too far removed from *Super Mario 64*.

Either way, this interview solidifies my thought that Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker is genius.

Golden Age Thinking

November 19, 2014

Categories: Culture, Technology

I've never felt as old as I had this morning. I kicked off my day watching Stuart Brown's Brief History of [Video Game] Graphics. On my commute to work, I listened to Johns Gruber and Moltz discuss '80s computing technology on The Talk Show.

Being born in '85 (we may as well call it '86), some of topics discussed in both of these pieces grazed the edges of my memory but weren't so far off that I couldn't muster up a sliver of recognition or plausibility for the topic at hand. However, many of the subjects and terms (DOS, floppy disks, "raster", 8-bit, etc.) had me pining for life in an earlier time. A time when faster, smaller, cheaper meant a Gameboy vs. Gameboy Pocket; not a 250GB 2.5" HDD vs. 3TB of cloud storage. It may seem crazy to wish for a pre-Internet era, but then again, Golden Age Thinking is crazy.

Paul (Michael Sheen), *Midnight in Paris*:

> *Nostalgia is denial - denial of the painful present... the name for this denial is golden age thinking - the erroneous notion that a different time period is better than the one one's living in - it's a flaw in the romantic imagination of those people who find it difficult to cope with the present.*

I then got to thinking about my mother's lack of interest in technology. She's on a candy-bar phone, still abides by a phone book, and prints out directions from MapQuest. Maybe she was never focused on her Golden Age as much as she is comfortable living in it. Where she stands in the current tech landscape is likely a Golden Age for others.

I love technology, but at some point (and I don't feel it's too far off) I will I call it quits on trying to keep up? Will I settle in what will become a future someone's Golden Age? All I know is that this morning, I was the guy in the 7 year old car (my wife drives the new one) listening to talk radio (podcasts) on a 2+ year-old smartphone (I've been upgrade eligible for months). And today's music is terrible. And I've been to a movie theater once in the past year. And there will never be better TV than Seinfeld. And I don't understand EDM (Electronic Dance Music / Erotic Dancing Miley / Exorbitantly Deep *Minecraft*). And I'm comfortable.

'Disney can save Nintendo, and it would only cost $19 billion'

November 20, 2014

Categories: Business

Steve Bowler, writing for Polygon:

> *Disney wouldn't see Nintendo as a hardware company or even a software company, just as they didn't see Marvel as a comic book company. Nintendo holds some of the best intellectual property in the world, from Mario to Link. Kids are still wearing Mario and Luigi shirts next to their classmates wearing Minecraft and Iron Man logos.*
>
> *There are incredible properties, from Metroid to F-Zero, that would offer Disney huge opportunities in everything from film to theme park attractions. Nintendo, when looked at through the lens of an acquisition, is a bundle of amazing, well-known characters and worlds that are criminally underused.*
>
> *Nintendo is the last company that owns characters that could compete with the worlds that Disney already controls, and adding Mario to the Disney original characters, Marvel superheroes and Star Wars would mean that Disney all but owns entertainment as a whole.*

I initially scoffed at this article as a pipe dream so many of us have already had (especially yours truly), many after watching *Wreck-It Ralph*. One could sketch Nintendo franchise themed rides over a map of Disneyland. (Peach's Castle in the hub, Metroid and Star Fox in Tomorrowland, Fantasyland becomes Hyrule, Donkey Kong in Adventureland, etc.) We have all certainly envisioned a reboot of the *Super Mario Bros. Super Show* using *Super Mario 64* to current era models, worlds, and voices(?). Of course this sounds awesome/mind-blowing/impossible.

But then the reality of it all hit:

Star Wars is Disney.

Marvel is Disney.

It was as if I had never really given weight to the thought. Nintendo has always been so evident and ripe to fit along classic Disney franchises. But Marvel and Star Wars? Put in the context of Disney buying Nintendo and Nintendo just seems like a no brainer put up against the other two.

On the flip-side, the majority have been spelling doom for Nintendo for years. And Nintendo has been putting up one hell of a fight. Let's see how these *Super Smash Bros.* numbers do.

[UPDATE]: How about that ad to the right of the piece?



Iterative vs. Redesigned Experiences

November 22, 2014

Categories: Design, History

Everyone seems to have a solution for Nintendo. They need to develop for iOS. They need to stop making consoles. They need to be purchased by Disney. My two cents? They need to reinvent their properties.

The Nintendo 64 is my favorite video game console. It's not due to the use of polygons, 3D environments, and the fact that it looked much better than Playstation. It's that beloved franchises were reimagined, reinvented, and redesigned.

Super Smash Bros. Wii U was released yesterday. I've played all of the versions prior, and they are all fine games, but they are all iterative. For this reason, I hesitated to drop another $59.99 on an experience I'd already had. Needless to say I made the purchase after soaring reviews, but a morsel of remorse lingers. I more or less know what I'll be getting.

Super Mario 64 could have just as easily been another side-scroller, albeit with better visuals. *The Legend of Zelda: The Ocarina of Time* could have been another top-down adventure. *Donkey Kong 64* could have gone a number of pre-existing directions. Sure the Metroid series skipped the Nintendo 64 generation but *Metroid Prime* could have been another 2D platformer. The fact of the matter is that these titles reinvented their respective franchises. The worlds and characters we loved were shown in a new light and perspective. Sure, they are great games but they reinvented the way we thought about the franchises. This is what makes them so special.

Nintendo stepped out of the box to deliver entirely new experiences. *Super Mario 64* was a new way to think about Mario; a new standard in-addition-to, not in-lieu-of: Mac vs. iPhone; not iPad vs. iPhone.

Super Mario Bros. 2, *3*, *World*, and *3D Land/World* are iterative of *Super Mario Bros.* while Super Marios *Sunshine* and *Galaxy* are iterative of *Super Mario 64*. This is not the same problem as sequels and spin-offs.

If the doomsayers are correct and Nintendo's failure is eminent, redesigns are going to be required to prevent it. So far, the majority of first-party titles on Wii U are iterative: *Mario Kart 8*, *Super Smash Bros. Wii U*, *Super Mario 3D World*, *Pikmin 3*, *Donkey Kong: Tropical Freeze*. While not every redesign has worked in Nintendo's favor (I'm looking at you, *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* is genius; while it's not a new take on a old classic (because there is no old classic!), it's a new perspective from the Mushroom Kingdom. Until then, it's back to smashing and karting.

'Wii U Was A Better Console For Third-Party Games'

November 30, 2014

Categories: Design

Michael Thomsen, writing for Forbes:

> *Playing games that have extended the design patterns of the last generation on Wii U—Batman: Arkham Origins, Call of Duty: Ghosts, Mass Effect 3, FIFA, Splinter Cell: Blacklist—there is a palpable sense of an era having designed itself into a corner. The addition of a second screen integrated into the controller does indeed feel like gimmickry, but its gimmickry that reveals the thoughtlessly repeated design ideas of the games themselves more than the controller and its touchscreen. Gimmickry is the heart of play, the redirection of something toward a purpose that's not immediately obvious to produce a sense of discovery and surprise. What's often described as depth in play is only just a proliferation of branching gimmicks, each leading to a variety of roughly equivalent automations, the choice between which conveys a kind of intimate fragment of personhood to some other player familiar with the sleight-of-hand bylaws and what passes for alternatives to them.*
>
> *Even when used as just a map screen, the Wii U's controller points to a dimensional complexity in play that's absent in the more computationally powerful PS4 and Xbox One. Playing half-hearted ports with minimal investment in the new play apparatus, there is a greater sense of possibility and strangeness than anything I've felt from higher screen resolution, more non-playable characters, or more elaborate physics simulations. But since most third-party developers have abandoned Nintendo's small gesture toward a new kind of thinking about play, whatever advancement their machinery could have led to will remain a theoretical abstraction.*

'Vox Media Valued at Nearly $400 Million After Investment'

November 30, 2014

Categories: Media

The New York Times:

> *Anton Levy, head of General Atlantic's Internet and technology team, said his firm — like other investors — had typically avoided content creators like Vox in favor of platforms with many capabilities like Facebook and Alibaba. Lately, he said, the firm has had a change of heart.*
>
> *"We think we are at an inflection point," he said. "For the next five years, you are going to have the next generation of media platforms emerge. There are parallels to cable in the '80s. There is going to be a huge amount of value creation."*
>
> *The chief executive of Vox Media, Jim Bankoff, has made no secret of his ambition to build his company into a kind of Time Inc. of the 21st century; that is, a multipublication giant with reach into young, affluent homes across the country on topics as diverse as sports and real estate.*

The moment I laid eyes on Polygon, I was taken aback by its noisy design, overblown articles, nondescript headlines...

And then it scrolled forever. And ads were limited or nicely designed. And its design reacted to my device in real-time. And the features featured unique layouts. And the video production was on another level. And the "nondescript" headlines were enticing. And the "overblown" articles were full of fantastic journalism and entertaining personality. And the "noisy" design was unlike anything I had ever seen.

I latched on to Polygon's community and began posting lengthy, passion fueled comments. I realized that these were not comments, they were blog posts. I used those "comments" as the foundation for a new WordPress blog titled *The State of Gaming*, which I later renamed *Zero Counts*.

From Polygon to The Verge to Vox.com, Vox Media has changed the way I consume content. Every article includes something of interest. Every layout choice is surprising and exciting. Their dedication to personality, engineering, and design is second-to-none. Congratulations, Vox Media. I saw this coming from a coast away.

UPDATE: Polygon editor-in-chief Chris Grant has sent out the following tweet:

> *Nov was @Polygon's best month yet, w/ 10.5m uniques. That's 140% over last Nov, which had 2 new consoles! Thx so much for reading, everyone!*
>
> *— chris grant (@chrisgrant) December 1, 2014*

It's so great to read about this success. Great job, Polygon Team.

I think Smash Bros. is how all video games look to grandparents.

November 30, 2014

Categories: Design, General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q8a3yEWMYlA

Polygon video producer Griffin McElroy showcasing the new features of *Super Smash Bros. Wii U* to Polygon managing editor Justin McElroy on *Polygon's Overview*, time stamp 14:06:

> ***JM**: Griffin... do you ever look at Smash Bros., when you're me, and think, "I bet this is how all video games look to my nani?"*
>
> ***GM**: Ya, I think so. Ya, probably. Are you saying that because it's just like really crazy and hectic and inscrutable? Or because it's like, "Ahh! You gotta use the Pac-Man to eat the Marios!"*
>
> ***JM**: Like both, I guess. I think Smash Bros. is how all video games look to grandparents.*
>
> ***GM**: Probably. Maybe.*

It's not just grandparents:

> *Watching the Super Smash Bros. Wii U 50-Fact Extravaganza. My brain stopped comprehending at no 9. What the hell happened to video games?*
>
> *— Kyle Starr (@_kylestarr) November 16, 2014*

I've put in a few hours and I'm still not sure I know what I'm doing.

The Verge Reviews Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker

December 1, 2014

Categories: Design, General

Andrew Webster, The Verge:

> *Whatever fate awaits the Wii U, Nintendo is doing just about everything it can to make sure the console has some amazing games. It may not have third-party support, but Nintendo's own releases feel exciting in a way they haven't for years. At a glance, Captain Toad seems like a throwaway game, a weird little spinoff starring a character no one really cares about. Yet it's one of the best puzzle games of the year, and another one of a growing number of reasons to pick up a Wii U.*

The Verge calls *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* "a hidden gem"; I called it "genius". Needless to say, I cannot wait for December 5th.

The Making of Lumino City

December 2, 2014

Categories: Art, Design, General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JO6t6H19CUk

Brave. Daring. Ambitious. Inspired. Inspiring. Beautiful.

Not twenty minutes before watching this video was I listening to Howard Shore's *The Hobbit: An Unexpected Journey* soundtrack, ruminating on what it must have felt like to be involved in such a massive, all-consuming project as *The Lord of the Rings* film franchise. I often fantasize about working as a builder or set designer on those projects, bringing Tolkien's Middle-earth to life. Imagining the construction of *Lumino City* brings about the same thoughts and is far more compelling than the game itself, and boy what an amazing game it looks to be.

State of Play's *Lumino City* will be available tomorrow, December 3rd, via Steam for Mac and PC. Official trailer below.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5l6aSfIyS1k

Water Coolers, Spoilers, and Serial

December 2, 2014

Categories: Culture, General

On the way to work, my wife and I caught up on *Serial*. On our commute home, she mentioned that Zach Braff had tweeted about the podcast:

> *The @serial podcast is an amazing articulation of stellar storytelling. I also love regular cereal.*
>
> *— Zach Braff (@zachbraff) December 4, 2014*

I can't look through my Twitter feed without seeing a mention of *Serial*. Everyone's onboard. Everyone's got a take. But the extent of sharing is "OMG! WTF! #serial" We are all on par with Laura's confusion in episode 8.

Serial is great. Definitely not my favorite podcast, but it's a spectacular display of fine editing and editorial guidance. But more importantly, *Serial* has brought back the water cooler conversation. Everything about *Serial* thus far is based on presumption. If you tried to explain what is happening, you'd leave behind mountains of critical detail. Because the questions hurdle by ad nauseam, there aren't answers big enough to spoil the show. Think *LOST*, with hatches and polar bears and Dharma, but rooted in the nonfiction investigation of a 1999 homicide case with cell records and reenactments and Jay. This is pre-meditated in the sense that Sarah Keonig and the *Serial* crew know that answers won't come easy. There are no spoilers. This is great storytelling and we are along for the ride.

This thought led me to other serialized media. Serialized TV is larger than ever, but the good stuff (*Game of Thones*) is adapted or released in bulk (*House of Cards*). I kid, I kid. Admittedly, I have not watched *True Detective*. But in all seriousness, TiVo culture and binging has struck deep fear in sharing too much about nightly TV. While this sounds like a backwards argument against on-demand podcasts, again, Serial doesn't offer enough answers to divulge spoilers. Again, this is great storytelling.

This led me to thoughts on film. What was the last (semi-)pre-meditated, non-adapted, serialized film series released? *Pirates of the Caribbean* (2 & 3)? *The Matrix* (2 & 3)? *Star Wars* (5 & 6)? Nearly every (if not all) serialized film series released within the past few years has been adapted. *Harry Potter*. *Hunger Games*. *Divergent*. The answers to these series have been lying around in text years prior to the film's release. The best we can hope for is that we haven't read the book or the film is so far off from the source material that it feels like a unique experience.

We need more original, pre-meditated, serialized content. Someone write an original three part film trilogy with segments so good they can stand on their own as solid films. Someone conceptualize a three, four, or five season TV show from start to finish. Calculate the journey or take us along for the ride. Stop adapting. Stop playing by ear. If you do play by ear, root it in nonfiction. Make sure you can't make stuff up.

I realize this is less a message to creators as it is to producers, with overhead and risk to take into consideration. But if you want to give us story, allow us to risk *our* time and money. Trust creators.

Tomorrow, my wife and I will listen to episode 10 of *Serial* and the most we'll be able to share is "OMG! WTF! #serial"

Monument Valley is Magic

December 3, 2014

Categories: Art, Design

Myke Hurley of Relay FM interviewing Neil McFarland, Director of Games at ustwo:

> ***MH**: Visually, Monument Valley's levels, they focus a lot on optical illusions and trickery. How much more difficult is that to develop for than just creating a straight "go from here to here" type level?*
>
> ***NM**: It offers a lot of different challenges. We're trying to delight people. There is that moment of delight when you turn the Penrose triangle around, you see it for the first time. Something goes from 2D to 3D and you suddenly see a connection that's not there. It's magic. For us, it was a drive to see how many of those we could uncover and re-engineering things and playing and trying and failing and getting it right and getting it wrong. It's not easy but we were following our noses and following intuition and just seeing how many of those moments we could find within the concept.*

The software engineering behind video games is still beyond me. Even so, I couldn't help but wonder just how ustwo were able to engineer *Monument Valley's* impossible yet traversable objects on the fly. Magic is right.

Relinking my review of *Monument Valley* 1.0 here.

The Lord of the Rings and the Serial Cliffhanger

December 7, 2014

Categories: Culture, General, History

Ryan Gilbey, writing for The Guardian:

> *In this Netflix-fixated age of instant gratification, the Lord of the Rings and Hobbit trilogies did something both antiquated and radical: they restored to cinema-going the old-fashioned thrill of the serial cliffhanger. The difference is that 1940s and 1950s audiences had only to wait a week to find out the resolution. Middle Earth enthusiasts, on the other hand, had to while away an entire year between episodes.*
>
> *Future generations consuming the whole shebang over several days of binge-watching will do well to remember that – and to raise a tankard of mead to those comrades who fell before the finishing line, or who said: "Sod this for a game of soldiers, I'll wait for the DVDs so I can fast-forward through all the boring bits." (One character in Kevin Smith's comedy Clerks II described the first trilogy as: "Three movies of people walking to a fucking volcano!")*
>
> *Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone was released in November 2001, a mere month before the first Lord of the Rings film (The Fellowship of the Ring).*
>
> *But with the exception of the seventh and eighth outings, the Harry Potter films are self-contained, with no explicitly loose threads left dangling between pictures.*
>
> *Audiences had experienced little to compare with the protracted suspense at the end of The Two Towers, when the slithering Gollum is apparently poised to murder Frodo and Sam. Jackson played the long game and took a gamble that audiences might want to play it, too.*

Aside from the fact that "Middle Earth enthusiasts" already knew the ending, this is exactly what I'm talking about.

Wii U is My Primary Console

December 9, 2014

Categories: Design

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *That reality is rather quickly washed away by the fact that the Wii U has built the best library of exclusives of the current consoles, and that's another trend that won't likely end anytime soon. It would be hard to turn the Wii U into your primary console — there are simply too many games that will never be on the platform — but it's equally hard to ignore Nintendo's latest piece of hardware. There are simply too many amazing games that won't be available on any other console.*
>
> *This situation replicates what happened in the last generation: The argument between the PlayStation 4 and Xbox One is ongoing and contentious, but you don't really need both. If you want to make sure you hit as many software high points as possible, you need a PlayStation 4 or Xbox One and a Wii U. The same way you needed a PlayStation 3 or Xbox 360 and a Wii.*
>
> *We've gotten to the point of the Wii U's life cycle where it's clear that owning the system, if you're serious about playing the best games on the market, has become mandatory.*

Since *Mario Kart 8* was released, I have had no problem making the Wii U my primary console. And while I adore *Mario Kart 8*, I'd argue that the Wii U is worth it for *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* alone. It is rich with content and polish, is gorgeous and challenging, and is one of the most innovative games I have ever played. The hits keep coming.

Aside from *Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor*, I'd argue against Kuchera and state that there haven't been any PS4 or Xbox One titles that have made me want to shell out for one or the other. And, again, outside of *Shadow of Mordor's* Nemesis System, innovation and is something this new generation is severely lacking.

Chronological Console Crash Course

December 10, 2014

Categories: Health, History, Parenting

Very interesting read.

Andy Baio:

> *What happens when a 21st-century kid plays through video game history in chronological order?*
>
> *Start with the arcade classics and Atari 2600, from Asteroids to Zaxxon. After a year, move on to the 8-bit era with the NES and Sega classics. The next year, the SNES, Game Boy, and classic PC adventure games. Then the PlayStation and N64, Xbox and GBA, and so on until we're caught up with the modern era of gaming.*
>
> *Would that child better appreciate modern independent games that don't have the budgets of AAA monstrosities like Destiny and Call of Duty? Would they appreciate the retro aesthetic, or just think it looks crappy?*
>
> *Or would they just grow up thinking that video game technology moved at a breakneck speed when they were kids, and slammed to a halt as soon as they hit adolescence?*

I've always wondered how this sort of thing would play out. For the selfish sake of revisiting the past, I've always envisioned doing the same with my future children.

On the topic of experimentation, I was forced to play baseball, soccer, and piano with no interest in the topics. I wanted to be around computers and gadgets. While I ditched soccer and (regretfully) piano after two or three years, I ended up playing baseball for ten with a peak batting average of .069. Needless to say, my time spent on the diamond is not a fond memory, but my parents insisted I play an organized sport. Turns out I learned more playing bass in a high school punk band, collaborating, booking, planning, and managing finances, than playing organized sports. Some kids enjoy music; some enjoy baking; some enjoy technology. Find their jam and run with it. There are ways to develop well rounded people outside of their passion.

Thank you, Peter Jackson

December 15, 2014

Categories: General

I used to stare at my step-father's collection of *The Lord of the Rings* as an impassable mountain. Novels intimidate me. So when word let out that *The Lord of the Rings* was being adapted for film, I was thrilled. My perspective of the volumes on that bookshelf and the trouble I had with their language painted a picture of the gargantuan undertaking the adaptation would be. Not to mention the prospect of a story so legendary being brought to life in my lifetime was exhilarating. I had always been jealous of those who saw *Star Wars* in the theater; a piece of science-fiction/fantasy so groundbreaking it would have a lasting impact not only on cinema, but on the culture-at-large. I was convinced that *The Lord of the Rings* would be my equivalent. Bonus: (I thought) I could get away without reading the books.

I set any skepticism I had aside and I went into *The Fellowship of the Ring* all-in; convinced, without a shadow of a doubt, it would be the greatest thing I had ever seen. I was ripe for disappointment. Alas, Peter Jackson's vision turned me into as big of a Lord of the Rings fan as anyone could be. It wasn't the story or the characters. They were mesmerizing and with my lack of knowledge, their tweaks went unnoticed. It was the production value and scale of this work that floored me. I had never witnessed anything of its magnitude. The special effects were like none other and the pacing, tone, and art were calculated and vivid. But the thing that put the films over the top was the baffling accomplishment of its principle photography:

> *Principal photography for The Lord of the Rings film trilogy was conducted concurrently in New Zealand for 274 days from October 11, 1999 through to December 22, 2000. Pick-up shoots were conducted annually from 2001 to 2004. The trilogy was shot at over 150 different locations,[1] with seven different units shooting, as well as soundstages around Wellington and Queenstown. Peter Jackson directed the whole production, while other unit directors included Alun Bollinger, John Mahaffie, Geoff Murphy, Fran Walsh, Barrie Osbourne, and Rick Porras. Jackson monitored these units with live satellite feeds, and with the added pressure of constant script re-writes and the multiple units handling his vision, he only got around 4 hours of sleep a night.[2]*

I would later receive the extended edition of *The Two Towers* as a Christmas gift and pour over it and its bonus features many a high school night. Deep in the burrow of my poster laden teenage room, I would sit with headphones, transfixed by what I was watching. (I also absorbed a self-depricating message on the methodical pacing of the story through the image of the Ents.) To this day, the work behind these films amazes and inspires me. For as much as I love *Star Wars*, I felt I was right about *The Lord of the Rings* being my generational equivalent. It was a risky undertaking at a scale never before seen. Influential breakthroughs in cinema, technology, and logistics are rooted its production. I will forever dream to be part of something on its scale.

I needed more Middle-earth. I wanted every licensed video game, continued to pour over special features, and discussed the films at length with friends. I recall the instant I finished watching *The Return of the King* for the first time, I yearned for an adaption of *The Hobbit*. While I was sure it would eventually happen, I grew increasingly unconvinced that Jackson would be a part of it. On several occasions he emphasized that he was finished with Middle-earth and productions of its scale:

> *Nobody's ever shot three huge movies before and I think the most interesting thing I've discovered over the last 14 months is exactly why nobody's ever done that. Now I know. And therefore, I won't be doing it again.*

Needless to say, I was overjoyed when I learned that Jackson would be taking the helm on *The Hobbit*. And while many scoffed at the announcement that the children's novel would be split into two films, I was bursting with excitement. One film was not nearly enough Middle-earth to tide me over. In the back of my mind, there was a small part of me that wished for three. There is something so satisfying with a trilogy, be it the beginning, middle, and end or a pseudo three-act structure. But based on the page count, I understood two films was likely already stretching it. That was until I read the book. I came away from the novel shocked at how dense it was. I wondered how it *wouldn't* end up being three films. And to my surprise and delight, a third film was announced.

I agree with Ben Kuchera in saying "we have nothing to lose, and everything to gain" when it comes to *more* from our favorite franchises. If *The Hobbit* films were bloated, so what. If one is unhappy with the end product, they still have the book. As mentioned, I had only read *The Hobbit* months before the first film was released, and I was shocked that they would have attempted to squeeze it into two films, let alone one.

The announcements of return characters, story tweaks, and additions always gave me the feeling that *The Hobbit* films were more a celebration than a production to stand on its own. Sure, there is moral and epic material there, but it feels like I was watching a party thrown for the cast and crew of such an incredible feat. Do I think *An Unexpected Journey* and *The Desolationof Smaug* are in-line with the masterpieces that are *The Lord of the Rings* films? No. On par with the *Star Wars* prequels? Far above. The inescapable CGI on both the settings and characters (namely the orcs) are an eyesore, and the dwarves' makeup doesn't feel quite as realized as Gimili's, but the films allow me to bask in the majesty of Jackson's vision of Middle-earth again. And that's more than I could ever ask for.

Many my say "Jackson will be back for *The Silmarillion*." I'm not counting on it. Not after reading Alexa Ray Corriea's history of *The Lord of the Rings* in video games:

> *The Tolkien Estate still firmly holds the score of books and snippets that fill out the world of Arda beyond The Lord of the Rings and The Hobbit — called Tolkien's legendarium — close to its chest. Christopher Tolkien upholds his position as keeper of the keys to Middle-earth; the IP remains split; and The Silmarillion is still locked away, out of reach from those who might adapt Tolkien's deeper mythology.*

If *The Silmarillion* does come around, my bet is that Jackson won't be more than an Executive Producer.

I've never finished reading *The Lord of the Rings*. Two-thirds at best. And I only read *The Hobbit* months before the first film's release. Yet, because of these six films, I have a profound fondness for franchise as a whole. Two patient, pre-meditated, serialized trilogies (albeit based on existing fiction) as efforts that have gone unmatched are triumphs to behold. When it comes up in conversation, when I see snippets on TV or a passages from the book, or when I hear one of Howard Shore's iconic pieces, my mind goes to another place for hours at a time. Jackson's perseverance through the filmmaking and scope of Middle-earth encourages me to dream. It inspires me to undertake something bigger than myself. Thankfully I live in a world where in an instant I can tune

into something that ignites that fire inside. For that, I am forever grateful. Thank you, Peter Jackson, for braving this project. I'm so glad to have experienced it in its entirety over these past thirteen years.

Nostalgia, Feminism Top Merriam-Webster's Words of the Year

December 15, 2014

Categories: Culture, Gender, Media

Merriam-Webster:

> *The next two words on the list, nostalgia and insidious, saw huge increases in use this year, primarily because of their entertainment connection. Nostalgia was used in discussions about the television series Mad Men and Boardwalk Empire, and other cultural milestones like the 50th anniversary of the Beatles' arrival in America. "We saw more than a 100% increase in lookups of nostalgia this year," says Kory Stamper, an Associate Editor at Merriam-Webster. "It was certainly used in reference to pop culture and television, but it was also used as a way to frame larger political discussions. We spotted examples of nostalgia used in connection with the annexation of Crimea and the defeat of Eric Cantor. People often think of nostalgia as a return to 'good old days,' so these uses that go beyond the personal may have surprised some readers and sent them to the dictionary."*
>
> *...*
>
> *Lookups for feminism were strong throughout the year, as the word was used in many highly publicized comments–from the Supreme Court's Hobby Lobby decision to the Gamergate controversy. One big spike came after TIME announced its 100 Most Influential People–a list including Beyoncé, Miley Cyrus, and Pharrell Williams. TIME's claim that 2014 was the "year of pop feminism" sent many people to the dictionary.*

In 2014, more than ever (and for reasons other than Merriam-Webster's), I seemed to obsess over the idea of *nostalgia*. It coursed through many of my pieces including Hail Mario, Golden Age Thinking, and Iterative vs. Redesigned Experiences. It also seemed to be a common theme strewn out through several of Nintendo's recent first-party titles: The Excitebike Arena in *Mario Kart 8*, *NES Remix*, and the plethora of new characters and legacy nods in *Super Smash Bros.* to name a few.

On the topic of *feminism*, it is very interesting to see just how large the Gamergate conversation has become. 2014 felt like a truly remarkable year for the feminist movement and this list offers a small shred of proof.

'The first “open narrative” game'

December 17, 2014

Categories: Design

Ken Levine, creator of Bioshock, writing for Matter's *New York Review of Video Games* feature:

> *There are two games that really kicked off what we think of as the modern “open world” game: Super Mario 64 and Grand Theft Auto III. These games unshackled the player from linear progression through a game’s levels. I think Shadow of Mordor is the first “open narrative” game. You’re not just checking off missions in a variable sequence. You’re changing the dramatis personae. Whenever you succeed or fail, the characters in the story respond to your actions, and not in the manner of a branching “choose your own adventure.” It is an excessively simple, yet impressively flexible, crime story.*

Welcome to The New York Review of Video Games

December 17, 2014

Categories: Culture, Media

Chris Suellentrop, intro to Matter's _The __New York Review of Video Games _week long feature:

> *Welcome to _The __New York Review of Video Games. _If that name conjures for you an anachronistic, elbow-patched editor sitting at a dimly lit desk amid piles of plastic Atari 2600 cartridges and Sega Dreamcast discs, then good. It has done its job.*
>
> *If not, then let me try this:*
>
> *Video games are almost a $100 billion industry, sure. But video games do not matter only because they are large. They are also a new popular art, the kind of thing that comes along once a century. Two intertwined forces, computers and interactivity, have changed the world radically over the past 50-odd years. What is a video game? It's a creative work—a competition, a story, an experience—that exploits the intersection of those two forces.*

This is an incredibly important feature, comprised of great minds and personalities. A must read not only for video game enthusiasts, but those involved in the culture-at-large. So, everyone.

'Nobody ever says "I don't care if the music sounds bad."'

December 17, 2014

Categories: Design

John Gruber, The Talk Show:

> *In general, I would rather read an interesting, well-written novel that's poorly typeset than read a terrible novel that is beautifully typeset. Of course. That's the difference. Even me as somebody obsessed with typography would agree with that. Whereas with music, nobody ever says "I don't care if the music sounds bad," like at a technical level. It's fundamental to listening to music. But as the person making the device, that should be the obsession.*

Relinking similar thoughts about broken video games from myself.

Secrets

December 18, 2014

Categories: Culture, Design

Robert Thompson, director of Syracuse University's Bleier Center for Television & Popular Culture, on Serial, as quoted by Wired:

> *"So as people discovered that podcasts can be compelling in their regular media consumption, maybe we should've seen Serial coming from a mile away," Thompson says. "As podcasts get more and more sophisticated, of course one is going to say 'Wow, look at Fargo, Breaking Bad, The Sopranos—look at all these great stories being spread out and talked about before the next episode comes. Why not do it with a podcast?' It seems so inevitable."*

Serial is unique in the sense that you as a listener are along for the ride. You are experiencing it with Sarah Koenig and the Serial crew. You're being let in on a secret. And if you don't listen right away, the secret is already out.

Not all serialized content lends itself to brilliance. Serialization is not the key. Great storytelling is the key. That's not to say that episodic content can't house great story too, but the water cooler conversation is dismantled by the uncertainty that others may not have the same desire to catch the latest episode. There is no grand secret.

What I would like to see from more podcasts, books, movies, TV shows, and video games is complete pre-meditated stories built out and enfold in chunks, teasing audiences along toward a grand reveal. I wonder if Tolkien experienced a fortunate accident? In the case of Serial, the experience has been a layer deeper. The audience has been tuning in to someone else unraveling a secret. And whether or not Koenig solves the mystery, the truth is finite.

Winning Isn’t Everything

December 21, 2014

Categories: Culture, History, Media

Excellent piece by Ian Bogost:

> *Myopia is the worst side effect of a hypothetical century ruled by games—or by any medium, for that matter. Whether or not the 20th century was the century of film, its proponents were never so brazen about dreams of its dominion. You don’t see filmmakers and filmgoers deriding other media for their lack of indexicality or visual sensuousness, penning manifesti for the forthcoming reign of the cinematic century, or inundating Twitter with hatred for anyone who squints at the idea that the medium of film might also bear some flaws. To dream of an age ruled by a singular medium is to dream a dream of isolation, for the comfort and sufficiency of the familiar. Myopia starts as affinity, but it ends as fascism.*

St. George California Reserve Agricole Rum

December 27, 2014

Categories: General

Charles Yu, writing for The Wall Street Journal:

> *It's at this point, while having my second dialogue with St. George, that I come to a formulation of a new worldview. If writing about music is like dancing about architecture, then writing about alcohol is like dancing about alcohol, especially if you write about it while drinking it. Or something like that; I don't know. I think my analogy went fuzzy halfway through. That's the thing about rum criticism. It is the most honest art form, in that it allows you to demonstrate the effects of the product directly on the comprehensibility of your prose. Case in point: the previous sentence. Now, if you'll excuse me, I have some rum to eat.*

Fun read. Sounds great.

Old School Hip Hop is the new Golden Oldies

December 28, 2014

Categories: History, Music

Rolling Stone:

> *While radio stations have seen their audience decrease as tech-savvy consumers flock to satellite radio and streaming audio, broadcasters might have finally found a format that can lure listeners back to FM: Classic hip-hop. Playlists that shine the spotlight back on artists like the Notorious B.I.G., Naughty By Nature and Missy Elliott are currently sweeping the nation, with major broadcasters like Radio One, iHeartMedia and Cumulus Media frantically changing the format of underperforming stations to the sounds of classic hip-hop, the New York Times reports.*

This makes perfect sense. Hip hop debuted around 1979 — 35-ish years ago — now dubbed "Old School". "New School" hip hop began around 1983 and carried through to the early '90s — 22-ish years ago. The broader era of "Golden Age" hip hop spans mid-80s to early-90s — call it 25-35+ years go. In 2015, this is a 25-35+ years old genre.

So, what are "oldies"?

Oldies, Wikipedia:

> *In the 1980s and 1990s, "oldies" meant the 15 years from the birth of rock n roll to the beginning of the singer-songwriter era of the early 1970s, or about 1955 to 1972, although this varied and some stations chose 1950-1969.*

Doing the math, in the 1980s and 1990s, "oldies" encompassed a format including music from 25-35+ years ago. I may be mistaken but Golden Oldies have always seemed like a tried and true radio station format.

2014: Zero Counts Launch + Greatest Hits

December 30, 2014

Categories: General

In April 2014, I realized my blog *TheStarrList* had taken a hard turn into gaming. It was time to start something new. I gathered up those gaming-centric posts from *TheStarrList* along with several lengthy comments I had made on *Polygon* and *IGN* articles and stuffed them into a blog formatted after John Gruber's *Daring Fireball*. In May 2014, I launched *The State of Gaming* with the intention to focus on business, controversy, culture, education, history, health, and other topics in the gaming industry. After a link on *Daring Fireball*, I decided to cool-down the blog's pretentious title into something more personal. I recalled a childhood debate: When considering "lives" in video games, does "x1" mean you are on your last, or does zero count?

Writing about games has long been a dream of mine, but there has always been insecurity in indulging in entertainment critique and commentary. For lack of better terms, *Zero Counts* has tapped into a rich well of inspiration, passion, and creativity. By surrendering my inhibitions about games writing, I have written more frequently and published more on varied topics than ever before.

Without further adéu, here are the most popular posts from launch year, 2014:

1. Hail Mario (linked by Daring Fireball)
2. Humanity in Hearthstone
3. Club Nintendo stuck in Mario Kart traffic
4. Old School Hip Hop is the new Golden Oldies (retweeted by Ben Thompson)
5. Save developers and you will save your soul

Looking forward to even more writing in 2015.

Jason Snell on Solo Blogging Stresses

January 1, 2015

Categories: Media

Here's a great bit about the anxieties of being a new, lone blogger from Jason Snell on *The Talk Show with John Gruber*, time stamp 1:18:50 - 1:32:45:

> *Being a one person operation, if you're busy writing a deep-think-piece about something that's going to go on for a thousand words, you're not writing things to post to the site today. I feel like, with a less established site like mine, I definitely feel pressure to keep the lights on every day and try to balance those things. You have a different pace. You can post some links and then you put out a bigger piece every so often.*
>
> *I like your pace but I don't feel like I can do that right now. I feel like I need to keep the heartbeat a little stronger because I'm trying to establish myself and pick up an audience I may not have captured yet.*
>
> *The review of the Retina iMac was an example. It took me two or three days to write that. One of my challenges was always should I keep writing this now, or should I stop and find something short to write and post to the site just to let people know I'm still alive while I'm also writing this longer piece. Trying to find that balance is tricky.*
>
> *Again, not being on a team anymore, and being just myself, I've learned the powerful lesson of how little one person is capable of producing versus a staff.*

Snell, formerly of *Macworld*, launched the fantastic Six Colors blog in 2014.

5 Reasons to Run

January 2, 2015

Categories: Health

This post originally appeared on my previous blog, TheStarrList, on 1/12/13 and earned me an IGN Community Spotlight profile. Reblog comes courtesy of Ben Kuchera's Four ways to become a happier gamer, and person, in 2015

---

1. Boost Your Brain Power

Generally, we are all fans of music. Whether it's dance, metal, hardcore, or pop, we can usually identify something upbeat or driving in our iTunes Library. While upbeat music is great for getting pumped up, short of studying chord progressions and lyrical meaning, there is little payoff to listening to the same set of repetitive tracks on every jog. For some, music may actually be the reason they dread running. Next time you're out, try a podcast!

Similar to talk radio, there are tons of free and unique podcasts in the iTunes store. From cooking tips to comedy, tech talks and TED Talks, there is something for everyone. Subscribe to a few podcasts and load up your iPod. Have a smartphone? Download a podcast app for your iOS or Android device!

If podcasts aren't your thing, try an audiobook. I once heard a story of a runner who would listen to suspense novels while training. Only while training would he allow himself to listen to the books and, assuming they were any good, this tactic kept him from wanting to stop running. It also conditioned him to crave running. During races, he allowed himself to indulge in a playlist of upbeat music. This helped change the pace and created a fresh experience.

Understandably, podcasts and audiobooks are certainly not as upbeat as music. However, unless your are sprinting for a time, a good jog requires endurance over speed, and an informative podcast or suspenseful audiobook will certainly keep you at your paces.

2. Fresh Air

While treadmills are great during extreme weather or the night, nothing comes close to an outdoor jog. As simple as it sounds, a bit of fresh air can do wonders for the soul. After a long workday or at the tail end of being bedridden, busy city streets or a refreshing view of distant mountains can provide for a cleansing of the mind and clear thoughts. Stepping away from your belongings for 20-60 minutes can be enough to remind you of what is really important in life, provide a little inspiration for that project you're working on, or help sift out those feelings of anguish toward a troublesome co-worker.

As you run, breathe in and take a look around. Get out into the world to remind yourself that the world is much larger than your immediate surroundings. If you are lucky enough to cross paths with another jogger, remember to pass along the motivation with a friendly wave, thumbs-up, or high-five. Tell yourself that those drivers on their commute home are looking at you in envy, wishing they had your drive. Your efforts will certainly inspire others.

3. Game On

When I began running, I was fairly overweight. Unbeknownst to me, my body did not behave the way it did in high-school. I was still expecting to be able to eat the same junk food and plop down in front of video games with no severe consequence to my body. I was sorely mistaken. I knew that I needed to do something to get back into shape. I had heard about Nike+ and decided to take a leap of faith. I invested $300+ (a lot to a college student) into running equipment, an iPod, and the Nike+ sensor. I began to play a new kind of video game.

We can all appreciate a good game. Most of us grew up playing board or video games because they provided competitive and, in most cases, friendly fun. For those that need a little extra push to head out on a jog, making a game of it can do the trick! Several companies are *gamifying* the workout experience and the Nike+ service is leading the way! Nike+ not only keeps records of run/walk history including miles run, calories burned, and average pace, it also includes cross-community challenges. See where you rank amongst your friends on the weekly leader-board, be the first to reach 100 miles in the office, or challenge your best friend to a calorie burn competition! As you run and compete, you will earn achievements and kind words from world-renowned athletes, pushing yourself to run a little farther next time or maybe try one extra jog per week. *Gamifying* the jogging experience is a great way to stay motivated and provide a new kind of gaming experience!

Nike+ is offered through GPS iOS and Android apps as well as a shoe sensor (and iPod dongle in needed) for specially designed Nike+ enabled shoes.

4. Solitude

Everyone needs a little "me" time. Similar to tip 2, solitude can help provide clarity and peace-of-mind. Leaving you to your own thoughts can allow you to sort out those items that have been filling you with anxiety or allow you to solve that problem that's been gnawing at you for the past several days. For some, solitude can assist in inspiration or a moment of clarity. The ability to completely escape the needs of others and detach oneself from the rest of society undoubtedly allows us to sort out what is really important and a stimulating jog only enhances the experience.

5. Multitask

For those of you that have trouble carving out a chunk of your day to exercise because there is just simply "too much to do," you likely crave productivity. The best part about jogging is that the four tips listed above can all be achieved on a single run.

Over the course of several years, I have realized that multitasking is my biggest motivation to run. As often as possible, I will set aside 1-2 hours to jog and blog. After turning on my Nike+ app, I quickly throw on a podcast. Be it John Gruber's Apple-centric *The Talk Show*, obscure stories across America on *This American Life*, or staying up-to-date with the latest video game industry news with *The Indoor Kids* or *IGN's Game Scoop*, these podcasts not only fill my interests but they provide me with ideas.

Throughout the course of a single outdoor jog, I am afforded the luxury of audible inspiration through podcasts and sightly inspiration through my environment. I am disconnected from social media, e-mail, and text messages and am able to focus on myself. If I am able to push myself a little farther and a little harder, I may beat the stats from my last run. By the end, I am usually able to churn out an

idea or two for my blogs. Within 1-2 hours, I have satisfied my desire to be productive by gaming, thinking, mentally cleansing, and blogging... and exercise!

Xbox One's 7th Core

January 3, 2015

Categories: Design, Technology

A very interesting read from Richard Leadbetter at Eurogamer:

> *Up until recently, both Xbox One and PlayStation 4 have reserved two entire CPU cores (out of eight available) in order to run the background operating system in parallel with games. Since October, Microsoft has allowed developers access to 50 to 80 per cent of a seventh processing core - which may partly explain why a small amount of multi-platform titles released during Q4 2014 may have possessed performance advantages over their PS4 counterparts in certain scenarios.*
>
> *However, there's no such thing as a free lunch, and the additional CPU power comes with conditions and trades attached - however, there is the potential for many games to benefit. Firstly, developers need to give up custom, game-specific voice commands in order to access the seventh core at all, while Kinect's infra-red and depth functionality is also disabled. Secondly, the amount of CPU time available to developers varies at any given moment - system-related voice commands ("Xbox record that", "Xbox go to friends") automatically see CPU usage for the seventh core rise to 50 per cent. At the moment, the operating system does not inform the developer how much CPU time is available, so scheduling tasks will be troublesome. This is quite important - voice commands during gameplay will be few and far between, meaning that 80 per cent of the core should be available most of the time. However, right now, developers won't know if and when that allocation will drop. It's a limitation recognised in the documentation, with Microsoft set to address that in a future SDK update.*

The concessions Microsoft has been making to the Xbox One (revised DRM model, "dis-Kinect", price-drop, bundles, and now opening the seventh processing core) are admirable, and considering the recent spike in sales, certainly make for an interesting future for the console war. However, these are just that — concessions. Sony has continued to stay the course with compelling hardware and a simple story. Not to mention this is another hit against Kinect and the original vision of Xbox One.

Playing with Limitations

January 4, 2015

Categories: Design

I've linked to Ken Levine's piece on *Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor* before, but now that I've begun to play the game, an observation struck me.

Levine's piece revolves around choice in video games, explaining the genesis of the "Would you kindly" moment:

> *When it comes to story in video games, at best there's an illusion of choice. At worst, there's no choice at all. In our work, we tried to say, Well, pal, you really don't have a choice. So let's see if we can use that concept to mess with your head. And hence was born the "Would you kindly" moment in BioShock, a moment in video game history primarily remembered for reminding us that, when it comes to player choice in narrative, our medium is limited indeed.*

This moment is an iconic take on agency in video games. When playing through *Bioshock: Infinite*, I took to sniffing out additional commentary on the medium: Does "Booker DeWitt" really mean "Booker, do it," a nod to "Would you kindly?" Are infinite paths a commentary on respawning? I enjoy the idea of playing *with* a medium's limitations rather than ignoring them. SHARP's Quattron qual pixel technology was a gimmick, but I thoroughly enjoyed the marketing campaign.

In the case of *Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor*, the protagonist, Talion, is merged with the wraith of Elf Lord Celebrimbor, imbuing Talion with immortality. When killed, Talion respawns and the of Orc rankings are stirred, starting with the Orc who slain Talion last. This justifies respawning and retains a consequence for death.

Video games are inherently fantastic. Meta-rules to mask limitations are not necessary, but with increasingly realistic worlds, they certainly make the experience feel tighter.

Naughty Dog better have a good explanation for Nathan Drake's resistance to bullets.

ICYMI

January 4, 2015

Categories: Media

Teddy Wayne, The New York Times:

> *Pre-Internet, we accepted that media had a mayfly's life span: Yesterday's news was yesterday's news, and that was it. If you were the creator of it, you made peace with the notion that people either saw it or didn't when it appeared, and you moved on; there was no alternative.*
>
> *If it lingered in the public consciousness, it was because of its durability, not repeated reminders. Content had finite endings and deaths, not asymptotic approaches and long-term vegetative states from which resuscitation is always an option.*
>
> *Consumers had to make similar bargains: If you went out on a Thursday night during the 1990s, you missed NBC's "Must See TV" schedule (unless you taped it) and understood that it would be a while before you could see it again. (It helped, too, that there was less media competition in previous decades and, in the case of TV, that dramatic series were generally less complex, so that missing an episode of "Dynasty" might not set you back as far as skipping one of "Breaking Bad.")*
>
> *Now, with just about every airing of a much greater number of shows obtainable at any moment, there is no excuse for missing one — and, therefore, a more urgent compulsion to catch up, in case you missed it.*

Greg Miller, Colin Moriarty, Nick Scarpino, and Tim Gettys Quit IGN

January 4, 2015

Categories: Media

Kinda Funny Games Patreon:

> *In September, you changed our lives. We launched a Patreon for Kinda Funny, and your response was beyond (BEYOND!) our wildest expectations. The support, the Tweets, the shares -- it all showed that we really had built the community of best friends we're always talking about. And, once we knew that, all we wanted to do was make more content for you.*
>
> *Enter Kinda Funny Games. Now that we don't work for IGN, we can talk about the stuff you've always wanted us to talk about on YouTube -- games.*

I was initially taken aback by this news. Four iconic personalities leaving IGN?! There must be bad blood. I was wrong. After 3+ decades of experience at one of the leading video game publications, backed by 1755 patrons at the time of this publication, and a deep desire to speak their mind at any given time, these guys are braving the unknown and entering into an excited new era of media.

I thoroughly enjoyed Keza MacDonald of Kotaku UK's (ex-IGN) thoughts on the news:

> *What all this proves is a) god dammit, journalists and media personalities ARE worth money, and b) you can be funded by 5% of your audience*
>
> *— Keza MacDonald (@kezamacdonald) January 5, 2015*

This reminded me of some thoughts I posted in June 2014, derived from Griffin McElroy's interview with The Indoor Kids:

> *Baseball diehards can tell you the subtleties in team dynamics. There can be diversity under the same umbrella. Many more sites need to embrace the privilege of instant and educated opinion. If the games community cannot foster intelligent conversation on its own, someone must lead the way.*

As an employee of a large tech firm, I deeply understand the desire to freely speak about the industry you are a part of and the prohibitions instated. The benefit Kinda Funny Games has over other would-be media personalities is an established fanbase; however, that makes it no easier to cast aside benefits, workplace friendships, and security.

While I can't say I am a fan of their humor, I do enjoy their critique of video games. Godspeed, Miller, Moriarty, Scarpino, and Gettys.

One of These Days I'll Get It Right

January 5, 2015

Categories: Music



Jim Guthrie has composed incredible soundtracks for the iOS classic *Superbrothers: Sword & Sworcery EP* and documentary *Indie Game: The Movie*. For *One of These Days I'll Get It Right*, Guthrie teamed up with producer Solid Mas to release a throwback hip-hop remix record of his work from both soundtracks. It is chock-full of themed movie quotes, turn-table scratches, and an insidious vibe. The most notable record in recent history I can compare it to is RJD2's *Deadringer*.

One of These Days I'll Get It Right is a brilliant album that is much more than just a collection of simple remixes. Like LEGOs, Guthrie and Solid Mas have torn down completed sets and reimagined them as something wholly original. A worthy purchase if you are a fan of Guthrie, hip-hop, film, or a sound from yesteryear.

iTunes | Bandcamp

Kind of Meaningless

January 6, 2015

Categories: Media

Griffin McElroy on the *The Besties* finale, time stamp 3:32:54:

> *Maybe music is the closest comparison but there is no other industry, there is no other media where genres are these huge barriers between… There are people who play fighting games who are categorically different than people who play RPGs. I don't think there are as many genres an any other medium and I certainly don't think that there's as big a divide between those genres.*
>
> *Not only that, but games by their very nature are interactive, meaning… your experience playing the game is going to be different. So by their very nature, there's no guarantee that two critics played the same thing. I feel like those divides and those experiential differences that you have with a game are only getting bigger and bigger and bigger. That means that calling something your game of the year is completely… Of course it is because you're the type of person who likes that type of game and you had that very specific experience playing that very specific type of thing. It just seems kind of meaningless.*

Kinda Funny Perspective

January 9, 2015

Categories: Media

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *What I want this story to do is to put into perspective how much money it costs to get to that point. There is no huge flood of cash here, this is four people working very hard to make a very decent livable wage in content. That $408,000 a year is a workable budget for a four-person media company, but it's far from obscene. It's a realistic budget for the work they're going to be doing.*
>
> *It's also very possible that in terms of hours worked and money cleared on a per-person basis they're making less than they made at IGN. What they're earning is the possibility of greater success, and that success will be owned by them free and clear. That's an amazing feeling.*

A colleague of mine and I discussed many of these points moments after the news broke, of which I posted here:

> *As an employee of a large tech firm, I deeply understand the desire to freely speak about the industry you are a part of and the prohibitions instated. The benefit Kinda Funny Games has over other would-be media personalities is an established fanbase; however, that makes it no easier to cast aside benefits, workplace friendships, and security.*

It's scary that Kuchera felt the need to write this piece. Hard to believe that most didn't run these numbers themselves, if just to flirt with the idea of starting their own Patreon. (Then again, Kuchera is more privy to the zeitgeist of games media than myself.)

Without a doubt, *Kinda Funny* will be a challenging venture; however, the opportunity to break-even creating and owning what you love is a challenge worth taking.

Online-Only Consoles

January 9, 2015

Categories: Design, Technology

Dan Stapleton, IGN:

> *When Microsoft announced the Xbox One in 2013, it was going to require an always-on internet connection to function. After backlash from gamers and Sony's gloating proclamation that the PlayStation 4 would play games just fine without the help of the internet, Microsoft backed down and dropped the requirement (except for a one-time console activation). As it turns out, Microsoft's initial approach was more realistic about the modern reality of how games are made, and what's effectively required in order to have a reasonably stable experience with a physical copy of a game you buy off the shelf today. Your console will indeed run without a connection, but your disc-based games may not give it much to work with.*

This piece started and ended exactly how I wanted it to; picking up with Microsoft's original (and much maligned) "always-on" strategy, and ending with today's "always-on" gaming reality.

Ben Kuchera recently spoke with former AAA developer Keith Fuller for this tragicomic piece on the instability of recent AAA titles. In short:

> *This sort of thing is more common than you think, and it leads to muddled, unfinished and often buggy releases. It's not a matter of including the kitchen sink; developers are sometimes tasked with adding a hot tub at the last second as the project develops.*

Stapleton touches on the fact that patches are blessing, but I seem to remember a time when there weren't even a reality. Maybe I'm showing nostalgic naivety, but I'm having a *very* difficult time recalling game-breaking bugs from the pre-PS3/Xbox 360 era. But can today's AAA, reality-verging games truly exist in a non-patchable world?

Games are more complex than they have ever been. The benefits of more powerful hardware are simply enablers. In 30+ years, we have moved from simple sketches of fantasy to unparalleled productions that now challenge reality. Global resources are required to make today's video games. That doesn't begin to scratch the surface of the time and resources it takes to generate cutting-edge animations and textures in highly detailed main characters, let alone randomly generated NPCs. I *imagine* it's easier to create windblown hair now than five years ago, but nothing compared to the two frames it took in 1988. Just because a console "can" doesn't make it any easier create.

As an aside, allow this 2011 piece from Gamesradar entertain you: how I wish Microsoft would have stuck with their original strategy.

On Copying

January 10, 2015

Categories: Business, Design

During episode 30 of the excellent Exponent podcast, Ben Thompson and James Allworth spin off into a fantastic bit about patents, copyright, and innovation. Allworth's polarizing take should whet your appetite:

> *Copying each other doesn't blunt innovation; It spurs innovation.*

During a chance encounter at the 2002 Warped Tour, Geoff Rickly of Thursday offered me a single piece of advice: Never be afraid to steal. It certainly runs in-line with quotes such as "Good artists copy; Great artists steal," and "That great poets imitate and improve, whereas small ones steal and spoil." At the time, Rickly was an idol of mine. His words struck deep.

As previously mentioned, Zero Counts was inspired from episode 105 of The Talk Show with John Gruber, I completely redesigned Zero Counts with my first practical foray into HTML, CSS, and PHP. (Archive.org capture from 12/18/14.) In less than one years time, my writing, design, and coding skills have vastly improved, all thanks to copying Daring Fireball.

Ideas Are Scary

January 12, 2015

Categories: General

I love awards shows. The awards themselves don't matter, but the shows are generally entertaining and inspiring. George Clooney put it best:

> *For the record: If you are in this room, you've caught the brass ring. You get to do what you've always dreamed to do and be celebrated for it, and that just... it ain't losing. I don't remember what awards Lauren Bacall won. I just remember her saying, 'You know how to whistle, Steve? You just put your lips together and blow.' And I have no idea what kind of hardware Robin Williams took home. But I sure remember "carpe diem" and, 'Seize the day, boys. Make your lives extraordinary.' I never forget that.*

He described exactly what awards shows mean to me. Recognizing newly iconic pieces of acting, writing, cinematography, music, directing, etc. Though I had only seen a handful of films last year, *maybe* only two nominees, Clooney's speech connected the dots and reminded me why I was watching. Needless to say, I was enjoying the show.

Then, during a latter commercial break, a little monster appeared on screen:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sfmQvc6tB10

A fire ignited. I was watching something play out on television that had been living in my head for the past five years. *That fucking monster... that fucking idea* ruined the Golden Globes!

Years ago, I had an idea for a story. A little creature has found itself alone in the "real-world". Frustrated, I dug up my unfinished idea, last modified on 10/4/10, and posted it to Twitter:

> *He awoke to a light. This warmth was unfamiliar to him. As he sat up, he peered down at his hands. He had never seen them before. They seemed to emanate streams of dark smoke. He slowly sat up.*
>
> *He began to walk. He had come to find that he was walking down a crowded sidewalk, passing shop windows. While looking through the windows, he noticed his reflexion. He stopped. He was a tiny figure, no more than four feet tall. His cartoon like body was shrouded in streams of smoke. His large eyes glowing solid red.*
>
> *Nobody seemed to notice him standing there, staring into the glass. Nobody seemed to notice him at all. Hesitantly, he turned and proceeded down the busy street. As he walked, he could not help but notice every person was holding hands with another, be it man and woman, man and man, or female and female. At the end of the busy street, he came to a crosswalk. He decided to cross the street.*
>
> *This street was much quieter. It was also much shorter for it was only home to one restaurant. He stopped in front of one of the large windows and gazed inside. Every table was full. At each table sat a couple laughing or smiling while sharing a bottle of wine. He hesitantly turned and continued down the street. He came to another crosswalk.*

> *This next street was home to a playground. This playground was full of happy children, all of which seemed to be accompanied by both of their parents. The parents pushed their children on swings, threw baseballs back and forth, and played hide and seek together.*
>
> *This was all becoming a little overbearing for him. He was not used to these surroundings. He was quickly growing tired of the happiness that surrounded him. He was living within a nightmare. No, he was a nightmare living within a dream.*

Good or bad, finished or not, the visualization of this isolated creature, alone in the real-world, growing into something beautiful and shutting down prejudice and rejection was exactly what I wanted to depict. This was an idea I thought I could get back to at any time. It was *my* idea and *no one* was going to take it away.

Ideas can be frustrating. They are easy to push aside for another day. But if an idea is realized by someone else, it's defeating (and can ruin the Golden Globes). Especially when it is used in a brand-beefing commercial.

Ideas *are* scary, but become scarier when you realize they are not sacred.

Jersey Ethics

January 13, 2015

Categories: Race

Chuck Klosterman, replying to an inquiry regarding the use and sale of Negro league jerseys in the MLB, The New York Times:

> *What makes this instance complicated is not just the specter of race but also the fact that M.L.B. doesn't have any institutional continuity with the Negro leagues. It would be different if the National League had merged with the Negro Southern League or if the American League had annexed the Kansas City Monarchs franchise. But that's not what happened; instead, the various clubs simply folded, and the players moved on. So when Major League Baseball celebrates the Negro leagues, it's celebrating a past that technically doesn't belong to it and that exists only because of its past prejudice. Does that make the celebration unethical? Considering the league's espoused motives, I would say no. But it is a little strange. Your discomfort is not without merit.*

Enlightening read on a topic I am shamefully undereducated on but have always felt uneasy about. There is a *giant* gap between trendy and respect. I fear many purchases are made for the former.

This short Q&A is worth the read. And if anyone has any good reads on the Negro leagues (man, that is a tough term to say/write/use), I'm all ears.

EyeWire

January 14, 2015

Categories: Education, Gamification, Health

Years back, an odd desire to complete a coloring book developed. I never scratched the itch, but I may have just found a solution: *EyeWire*.

Gareth Cook, The New York Times:

> *In 2012, Seung started EyeWire, an online game that challenges the public to trace neuronal wiring — now using computers, not pens — in the retina of a mouse's eye. Seung's artificial-intelligence algorithms process the raw images, then players earn points as they mark, paint-by-numbers style, the branches of a neuron through a three-dimensional cube. The game has attracted 165,000 players in 164 countries. In effect, Seung is employing artificial intelligence as a force multiplier for a global, all-volunteer army that has included Lorinda, a Missouri grandmother who also paints watercolors, and Iliyan (a.k.a. @crazyman4865), a high-school student in Bulgaria who once played for nearly 24 hours straight. Computers do what they can and then leave the rest to what remains the most potent pattern-recognition technology ever discovered: the human brain.*
>
> *Ultimately, Seung still hopes that artificial intelligence will be able to handle the entire job. But in the meantime, he is working to recruit more help. In August, South Korea's largest telecom company announced a partnership with EyeWire, running nationwide ads to bring in more players. In the next few years, Seung hopes to go bigger by enticing a company to turn EyeWire into a game with characters and a story line that people play purely for fun. "Think of what we could do," Seung said, "if we could capture even a small fraction of the mental effort that goes into Angry Birds."*

EyeWire is the most addictive and challenging coloring book I have tried. It's easy to loose track of time while filling in the neuronal wiring, not to mention the increased level of difficulty that follows the tutorial. Bonus: It's for science!

Monument Valley in Numbers

January 15, 2015

Categories: Business

An official (and of course beautiful) chart of sales figures, analytics, and other interesting stats from ustwogames. My favorites:

- $5,858,625 revenue
- 50% of players who started the game completed it
- 53% of time and 64% of dollars were put into *Forgotten Shores*, the optional DLC expansion, compared against the main title.

Monument Valley is a truly remarkable game. Relinking my review of Monument Valley 1.0 and Neil McFarland's thoughts on Freemium vs. Premium.

Download Monument Valley for iOS.

Nintendo Direct Play-by-Play

January 16, 2015

Categories: Business

http://youtu.be/t6zgkp1YBRw

What began as a review of the 1/14/15 Nintendo Direct turned into a play-by-play reaction piece.

From the top:

Puzzle & Dragons Z + Super Mario Bros. Edition (3DS)

The presentation kicks off with a *Bejeweled* clone. It seems completely unnecessary to create a "Super Mario Bros. Edition" of a game that is not focused on IP. I've always felt the same way with *Super Puzzle Fighter II Turbo*. (More commonly known as *Puzzle Fighter*.) The first sight of the characters catch my eye, but I am no more apt to play once I see the style of game. It's a cheap trick. To challenge myself, I recently tested *Marvel Puzzle Quest*. Same *Bejeweled* experience in a IP wrapper.

How about a new *Super Mario RPG*?

Pokemon Shuffle (3DS)

I don't see how this is any different than *Puzzle & Dragons Z*. These types of games seem entirely based on luck. I was quick to counter my own point with *Tetris* but a) in *Tetris*, the player can see their next piece, and b) *Tetris* focuses on single piece placement, not masses of unordered chaos falling from the top of the screen. "In-game purchases" for more lives? Terrible. It all feels too much like a slot machine.

Regarding the life meter hearts, does zero count? (I had to do it.)

Wii Games on Wii U

With the new Wii Games on Wii U, eShop purchased Wii games are displayed on the Wii U menu. However, launching an eShop purchased Wii game simply launches the software in the existing Wii emulator. This means Wiimotes are expected.

Satoru Iwata, 8:36:

> *There are some Wii software icons on the Wii U menu. These icons are for Wii disc titles that been reproduced as downloadable software for Wii U. And you can start each game directly from the Wii U menu without first going into Wii Mode. Wii U's backwards compatibility with Wii was developed by switching the hardware function to Wii Mode. Because of this, in the past, we couldn't distribute Wii disc software for download on Wii U. Now that we can reproduce Wii disc software on Wii U, we can make these titles available to download. And some of the Wii games that were compatible with Wii Classic controller can be played using only the Wii U GamePad too.*
>
> *The Wii console has an extensive software catalog, but Wii U owners may not have had the chance to play some Wii games even if they were interested in playing them when those titles were first released. We hope these new possibilities will allow Wii U owners to enjoy these Wii games more easily.*

Prior to watching the Nintendo Direct, and without any discretion, I jumped at the chance to purchase *Super Mario Galaxy 2*. I was fairly disappointed when I realized that the eShop Wii Games were not Wii U ports, rather downloadable titles with shortcuts to the Wii Mode.

I only play my Wii U with the GamePad. I have a few Wiimotes lying around from my Wii days but only break them out if additional controllers are needed for local multiplayer. If Nintendo is expecting new Wii Game players to purchase these titles on Wii U, wouldn't complete GamePad functionality make sense? Instead they are expecting Wiimotes at the ready. To my knowledge, there is no Wii U bundle that includes Wiimotes.[1]

On a positive note, I am very happy to see that the *Metroid Prime Trilogy* will be making it's way to the eShop. I played through Prime 3 and loved the experience.

Kirby & the Rainbow Curse (Wii U)

This game looks gorgeous. The textures and animations take me back to *ClayFighter*, albeit with more polish and charm.

I still don't understand how games *requiring* touch input benefit during TV + GamePad gameplay. The prime mechanic of this game looks to be drawing on the GamePad. I'm not sure how players will avoid a purely GamePad experience. I'm all for the Off-TV Play feature of Wii U. I use it all the time when my wife is watching TV. However, when a game requires GamePad touch input, I have trouble adapting (*Pikmin 3)* or I simply play through the experience on GamePad alone. The gameplay of *Kirby & the Rainbow Curse* seems better suited for the head-down, (sorta) focused nature of the 3DS.

Pretty neat Amiibo support assuming the special unlocked abilities are **completely** optional.

Spring amiibo

Can't wait for my Mega Man Amiibo.

Mario Party 10 (Wii U)

I remember spending countless nights playing the N64 and GameCube editions of *Mario Party*. I really hope this iteration brings the series back to its glory days. (Mainly because my wife will join in.) But I'm already a bit turned off when 1/3 of the modes are locked to Amiibo only support. I know I'm not going to win this battle, especially with a company that thrives on accessory purchases + the new trend of NFC figurines, but when I say Amiibo support should be completely optional, pieces of a game should not be missing/locked to Amiibos. Cosmetic additives, customizations on the go, and save data sure. But entire chunks of pre-built game? Mario Amiibo Bundle aside, selling 2/3 of a game at full price is lousy business.

But there's more...

Bill Trinen:

> *If you decide to use your Super Smash Bros. Amiibo in Mario Party 10, you will need to erase that figure's Smash Bros. Amiibo data.*

You will need to erase the save data from one of the highest rated, most popular Wii U games out there. Nightmare.

Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker amiibo Functionality

Okay. Forget everything I said about Amiibo. I'm in!

But seriously, adding a simple hide-and-seek feature to an existing game is a great way to implement this technology. The core game exists without Amiibo while adding the optional "hide-and-seek for Pixel Toad" is no different than coin collecting, diamond fetching, or golden mushroom digging. Good move.

Splatoon (Wii U)

The addition of a social hub-world and what appears to be deep character customization adds so much to this game. My question: Will the Inkling replace the Mii?

I am still very excited about Splatoon.

Hyrule Warriors DLC: Tingle and Young Link

Young Link looks awesome.

Xenoblade Chronicles X (Wii U)

Since it was known as *X*, I have been intrigued by this title. I have only ever dipped into *Xenosaga Episode I: Der Wille zur Macht* but have always been attracted to the series' cool and atmospheric design. More compelling: The big and lush visuals coming from a Nintendo box. It looks like the *Lord of the Rings* Fellowship traversing *Avatar's* Pandora. Less compelling: That pop-in at 19:58.

Mario Vs. Donkey Kong: Tipping Stars (Wii U/3DS)

I'm a big fan of donating to my favorite creators. Likewise, I love the idea of tipping Level Creators with the stars you earn, helping them unlock new design pieces.

Also, very nice to see Nintendo build in cross-by support for the 3DS and Wii U versions of this game.

Project Treasure (Wii U)

Huh?

Elliot Quest (Wii U)

Fun looking throwback title.

Blek (Wii U)

Painting-maze-pretty-shapes-cute-sounds... Did you say that this has been featured in museums? I'm in.

Citizens of Earth (Wii U/3DS)

A wacky RPG drawing heavy inspiration from Double Fine in which Mitt Romney looks to have been voted Vice President of Earth. Looks entertaining.

Gunman Clive 2 (3DS)

Love that art direction.

Moon Chronicles: Eps. 2, 3, 4 (3DS)

Was Episode 1 any good?

SEGA 3D Classics (3DS)

Get that *After Burner II*!

Etrian Mystery Dungeon (3DS)

I don't get the whole "loot hunting" thing.

Story of Seasons (3DS)

Sort of a *Harvest Moon* reboot.

Fossil Fighters Frontier (3DS)

Archeology + Dinosaur Pokémon. Sounds addicting.

New Nintendo 3DS

I have been waiting for a redesigned standard, non-XL version of the 3DS before entering the 3DS market. I loved the portability of my DS Lite and have never been able to shake the feeling that I'm holding a Fisher-Price toy when using an XL. Not to mention it makes that terrible 800 x 240 pixel density look even worse.

The fact that Nintendo will not be releasing the new 3DS non-XL in the US was baffling until I saw this tweet:

> *@gamespite It might not be low-priced ENOUGH. We're a 2DS/XL market*
>
> *— JC Fletcher (@jcfletcher) January 14, 2015*

Bingo. I had completely forgotten about the 2DS but it looks like the it's push will be even stronger. One new feature of the New 3DS XL is NFC support.

Reggie Fils-Aimé:

> *You'll be able to power up your Super Smash Bros. series Amiibo on the go with all of the gear you've already unlocked in the game.*

Unless you've erased it to play *Mario Party 10's* Amiibo Party mode. Also, no AC adapter. Here's Nintendo's comment to Polygon:

> *"Rather than raise cost of New Nintendo 3DS XL by charging consumers for a component they may already own, we are giving them the option to only buy if they need an AC adapter," a Nintendo representative told Polygon. The spokesperson noted that the New 3DS XL is compatible with the same AC adapter used by all 2DS, 3DS, 3DS XL, DSi and DSi XL devices.*

I've always appreciated having more than one power adapter around the house. Just this morning, I used my wife's MacBook Pro power adapter as it was in a nearby room rather than fetching my own.

Nintendo cannot assume their customer is upgrading just to save a few bucks. Poor, disappointing decision.

Code Name: S.T.E.A.M. (3DS)

Looks great. Ideal Amiibo support.

ACE COMBAT ASSAULT HORIZON LEGACY+ (3DS)

Think *Street Fighter* titles are bad?

I miss air combat games.

Xenoblade Chronicles 3D (new 3DS)

A very impressive port of *Xenoblade Chronicles X*.

IronFall (3DS)

Looks like *Gears of War* for handheld.

Monster Hunter 4 Ultimate (3DS)

Are these games worth playing?

The Legend of Zelda: Majora's Mask (3DS)

I have such fond memories of *Ocarina of Time* and will always regret not playing the original release of *Majora's Mask*. My ears perked when they announced the Majora's Mask edition of the new 3DS XL. However, no game (or power adapter) included. I am completely stumped at the decision to release a special edition model of the console without bundling in the game the design is inspired from. If this was bundled with *Majora's Mask*, I would have put some serious thought into purchasing one of these, regardless of console size. Then again, I opted out of the Windwaker Wii U bundle. Those Zelda markings would have driven me nuts.

Conclusion

> *No 3DS non-XL in the US? Nintendo, what in the shit are you doing — Griffin McElroy (@griffinmcelroy) January 14, 2015*

Consumers are, by no means, sold on Nintendo hardware. We are living in a world where far superior hardware runs rampant and on the cheap. It is more apparent than ever that Nintendo is putting their might behind precious IP and highlighting that they are world-class software developer. I will continue to wait for the New Nintendo 3DS non-XL, something that might feel a *little* less like toddlers toy. And hey, with that extra money I saved, I'll get to buy an official charger!

Side note: I still find it intriguing that Nintendo is continuing development of 3D.

[1]Ben Thompson points out that the Mario Kart 8 Wii U Deluxe 32GB Bundle included a red Wii Remote (and Wii wheel accessory). This bundle is no longer available.

How Does Game Length Affect Other Developers?

January 21, 2015

Categories: Business

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dcT6MoVmIvg

Ben Kuchera in an accompanying piece on Polygon, emphasis my own:

> *People like to say that games are getting shorter, and this is a bad thing, but the data doesn't support that view of the industry. A shorter game can be made for less money which leads to lower prices which means more people buy it ... and so on. But it's also tricky to assume you know what other people want out of their games. Maybe they want to buy one or two games a year that will last nearly forever. In that situation, long games are the best.*

My comment originally posted on said accompanying Polygon article, edited:

> *How does game length affect game sales of other publishers? I have yet to purchase Dragon Age: Inquisition because I haven't yet completed Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor. Developers and publishers must see a hit in sales due to the fact that their potential audience is still wrapped up in a competitor's (would you consider them competitors?) product.*
>
> *I'd certainly love to experience more games that developers pour their souls into, I just don't have the time. And when I'm spending $40-60 on a game, you can bet I want to finish it.*

Game length must certainly cut into competing game sales. I'd love to see some investigation into this topic.

Need to know:

- What is the market size? (Total video game consumers? How many of those own PS4/Xbox One/both?)
- How many consumers eligible to purchase both *Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor* and *Dragon Age: Inquisition* purchased both/one of these titles?
- How many consumers are interested in both titles? (Past data might include consumers who purchased both a Batman: Arkham title and Mass Effect/Dragon Age title)
- How many purchasers completed one/both title(s)?

More Battletoads

January 21, 2015

Categories: Business, General

During today's Windows 10 event, head of Xbox division and Microsoft Studios Phil Spencer was unabashedly sporting a *Battletoads* t-shirt. Polygon followed up:

> *When asked, Spencer told Polygon, "I don't think I've ever worn a t-shirt that's been a complete head fake. I don't think I have... have I? I wouldn't do that." So if it's not a "head fake," we'll consider it a confirmation of more Battletoads.*

Rare games could be system sellers in my book. Relinking to last year's post, *Xbox One: Swinging for the Franchise Fences with Rare IP?*

Past, Present, Future Music Week

January 23, 2015

Categories: Music

All things considered, I had a pretty good week; A fan re-cut of *The Hobbit* films was released (I have yet to watch), the *State of the Union* was pre-published to Medium, and news that the *Super Bowl* will be available for streaming outside of broadcast TV were some of the highlights.

But on a personal level, I felt like I hit the jackpot: Music releases that have switched me on! And early in the year, no doubt. Here are worthwhile releases from the recent past, unfortunate present, and previewed future.

Minus the Bear - *Lost Loves*

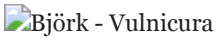

Minus the Bear - Lost Loves

Minus the Bear easily fits into my top 5 bands. Though, they had slipped out of my consciousness as of late. It wasn't until I saw AbsolutePunk's Most Anticipated Albums of 2015 that I decided to check in on the happenings of my top 5. Turns out, Minus the Bear released *Lost Loves*, a collection of B-sides and rarities, in October of 2014.

The record of miscellaneous memories may be the best scrapbook collection I have ever heard. The most prominent sound throughout is that of Dave Knudson's iconic tap-guitar. This was the element of Minus the Bear that originally hooked me; however, I felt it had progressively faded into the background for the likes of calculated noise looping and quirky electronics. *Lost Loves*, taken as a cohesive album rather than b-sides, feels like the Minus the Bear of yesteryear. Between the swaths of delay, floaty synths, and lush guitar-tapping, there is a futuristic, dystopian, Bonnie and Clyde, car chase vibe throughout, likely brought on by the opener's lyrics "*Your mark has made you his / And If you want to live let me suggest this / Get a gun and get a car*."

I had already heard (and collected) five of the ten gems on this record, but the album was well worth the purchase.

Björk - *Vulnicura*

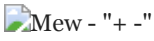

Björk - Vulnicura

Much to the dismay of Björk and her people, I took the leak of *Vulnicura* as a fortunate mishap. Since, hearing Further Seems Forever's cover of "Pagan Poetry" in 2007 and, thusly, falling head-over-heels for it's source album *Vespertine*, I've had a slight obsession with Björk. Needless to say, I was thrilled when I learned that *Vulnicura* would be released on 1/20/15.

The opening track of a Björk album typically paints a picture of what's to come. *Vulnicura* is no different. The album opens with somber strings followed by an exhaustingly precise vocal arrangement unique to Björk. If *Vespertine* is rooted in quiet and icy harp-filled beat-patterns, *Vulnicura* shows off Björk's keen awareness of the delicacy of strings layered under abruptly honest lyrics. There is an air of *Medulla* on "Lionsong" and *Biophilia* on "Noget", but the record feels more like a spiritual successor to *Vespertine* than any other; A successor to my favorite Björk album.

[*Afterword*] Turns out I wasn't mistaken about the similarities to *Vespertine*. If you'd like a full review of *Vulnicura*, look no further than Spencer Kornhaber's at The Atlantic. Devastating.

Mew - + -


Mew - "+ -"

Mew has always felt like the perfect blend of Minus the Bear and Björk: Wildly frantic fantasy epics tucked behind accessible "indie stadium" rock. Angelic/demonic guitars quirk, shift, and jolt on top of spacey synths, chugging bass, and driving drums that are in overwhelming control of their cadence and timing.

This past week, Mew announced the pre-order of their upcoming album, + -. "Satellites", the opening track to + - (and first song showcased from the record), is the closest Mew has come to returning to the *Frengers* opener "Am I Wry? No". It's an uplifting, galactic epic fit for a Rush record from an alternate universe, sprinkled with a tale of complex feelings on simple love. Sparking guitar is followed with a wide-open synth, both paving the way through dancing verses and dreamy choruses. "Satellites" is Mew at their finest. I cannot wait to see what the remainder of this album has in-store.

GOTY: Rocksmith 2014

January 24, 2015

Categories: Education, Music, Review

Not much weight should be put on Game of the Year. Just ask Griffin McElroy. And for a guy who obsesses over the industry, I'm ashamed to say that I had only played a handful of last year's releases. While I played the best of the best, *Mario Kart 8*, *Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor*, and *Broken Age* to name a few, nothing has kept me coming back like *Rocksmith 2014*.

Apologies for the late review. I had only started playing days before the New Year.

Gameplay

I was a latecomer to the plastic-partying hysteria of *Guitar Hero*. My brother talked me into picking up *Rockband* (*Guitar Hero* with drums and a microphone for those unfamiliar) as a family activity. We had a blast, but I was never able to pry myself away from the drum kit. With a small background in music, the five-button toy guitars never satisfied. The drums were the closest I could get to a life-like experience. After leaving my high school rock band days well behind me, an itch for the satisfaction in controlling a real instrument began to percolate.

At it's core, *Rocksmith* is built around the iconic *Guitar Hero* design: A reverse *Star Wars* crawl of notes streaming toward a fretboard with the player expected to strike said note at the right time. Where *Rocksmith* differs is the use of a real guitar; 138 notes vs. *Guitar Hero's* 6.

From the get-go, I was extremely impressed by *Rocksmith's* accuracy of note and chord recognition. Honest strikes and near misses are fed back in real-time just like *Guitar Hero*. Inaccuracies happen but typically err on the side of the player. Sure, there are inconsistencies here and there. If I missed a note in a chord, *Rocksmith* generally let it slide. However, when I can feel and hear exactly what I am playing, I know I am a cheat. (No amount of "gimmes" could extinguish my weight of guilt.) I didn't need *Rocksmith 2014* to tell me I was wrong. I was just as eager to jump back into the ring.

The player is offered three paths: lead guitar, rhythm guitar, and bass. In the instance of lead guitar, techniques are slowly introduced during the "Learn A Song" mode. They are also readily available in "Lessons". The player starts by playing along with a songs using well spaced single notes. These notes slowly advance into chords, bends, slides, hammer-ons, pull-offs, tapping, etc. The scale of techniques offered by the game is shocking, not to mention the depth of the lessons and range of songs that utilize each technique.

Core

Where *Rocksmith* shines is the Learn A Song mode. There is a surprisingly vast array of songs in the catalog: from The Ramones to Rush to The Dear Hunter to Minus the Bear(!) to Mastodon. The player fas the choice to play each song straight through or focus on objectives such as mastering a bridge, finishing with a certain level of accuracy, or playing a mini-game that teaches a technique used in the song.

The killer feature, however, is *Rocksmith's* ability to scale the difficulty of each song on the fly based on how well the player is performing. As I coolly played through La Sera's "Love That's Gone",

strumming full E5s and delicately plucking scattered notes, I was sure I had mastered the patterns. I was then caught off guard by a C#m that, at first, had only included A-flat and D-flat. After a few play-throughs and a headfake chorus, the chord had evolved, incorporating an E and another A-flat. Replaying the same song over and over without having to manually change difficulty is great. But more importantly, scaling the difficulty between individual sections previously mastered is brilliant. Imagine every time you played through World 1-1, new obstacles were introduced in the areas you excelled in.

Extras

In addition to learning songs, *Rocksmith 2014* is packed with a plethora of supplemental modes, all serving individual importance and, quite possibly, to different audiences.

"Lessons" focus on individual techniques with accompanying videos and monitored playback that end in full songs. Lessons are repeated until mastered and are fairly enjoyable to revisit. Even the simple ones taught me something. And yes, the videos can be skipped.

"Guitarcade" focuses less on technique and more on music theory. Numerous surprisingly well designed games teach core skills in volume control, scales, and chord changes, among others. Be it the *Streets of Rage* style "Scale Warriors" or the *Star Fox* homage "Star Chords", the level of detail in design, music, and art is top-notch.

That said, I have yet to jump at playing any of the "Guitarcade" mini-games. I don't find them quite as engaging as the core "Learn A Song" mode or "Lessons". Their presence within the greater *Rocksmith* game are a prime statement on edutainment; layering education on top of existing games (or vice versa) rarely produces a great experience. (Guitarcade) Building them together generally produces a far more engaging product. (Learn a Song)

To round out the list of features, "Session Mode" allows the player to build a band for an endless jam session. Similar to Apple's GarageBand and Logic drummers, the band members the player chooses work *for* the player, not separately from the player. The AI play styles dynamically shift based on the player's strumming patterns and rhythms.

Even with my lukewarm response to the "Guitarcade", I can see a universe in which each of these secondary features are shipped as fantastic stand-alone products. To bundle them into the same package as the already fantastic core game is without a doubt a triumph in its own right. There is a level of finesse, execution, and love put into "Lessons", "Guitarcade", and "Session Mode" that seem to have be missing from major releases of late.

Falling Short

Where *Rocksmith* falls short is in guiding the player through recommended songs, lessons, and mini-games. It is clear that there was a desire to emphasize recommended paths, but it feels poorly executed. Rather just pressing "play" and letting *Rocksmith 2014* take the wheel to automatically jump from song to mini-game back to the same song with an emphasis on a single verse and so forth, the player is forced to manually jump around in hopes that the recommendations are truly applicable.

In the case of playing "recommended" songs, I felt like I was playing through the entire catalog rather than focusing on where my skills needed work. In no time, Rocksmith took me from Johnny Ramone

to Alex Lifeson before I could handle Dave Grohl. It took about 4 hours of play to realize sorting by "difficulty" rather than "recommended" was my desired style of play.

Conclusion

It's been nearly 15 years since I began playing in a rock back. Nearly 15 years since the dream of becoming a rock star ever surfaced into my consciousness. Time, money, space, studies, work, responsibility: These things began to take priority after high school. The thing that made me feel most alive was put aside. It's a shame that more effort was not made, that I lacked the confidence to perform on my own, or that I wouldn't set aside a few hours a day to practice. (Also, I was never that good.) The older I got, the more I watched my rock 'n roll glory days fade away.

Rocksmith 2014, through it's brilliant use of familiar design, great song catalog, and level of detail, is quite possibly the best piece of edutainment software out there. Not only is it engaging, it is educational *and* addicting. It is by no means perfect, with "recommendations" being a botched effort on potentially the strongest feature. But what it gets wrong pales in comparison to the core features it gets right. With surprise after surprise, "wow moment" after "wow moment", *Rocksmith 2014* kept hitting me in all of the sweet spots. And most importantly, it brought me back to my guitar.

Amazon | Rocksmith 2014 requires a guitar and a specialized 1/4 audio to USB cable.

American Horror Story: McDonald's Museum

January 25, 2015

Categories: General

Desiree Echevarria:

> *I have a pretty apathetic stance when it comes to McDonald's — I don't love it, but I certainly don't hate it the way some McDonald's-shamers do. But I recently got a new job with an office within walking distance of a McDonald's. And since I generally don't care about what I put in my body when I'm in the middle of a work day, I gave it a try. On the outside, it looked like a perfectly normal McDonald's — in fact, even a little boring, as it's attached to a run-of-the-mill corporate office building. But when I walked inside, my jaw hit the floor. The restaurant had all these bizarre statues on display in the eating area. And I mean BIZARRE.*

Possibly the most hilarious/terrifying thing you'll see today.

Home Economics 2.0

January 26, 2015

Categories: Education, Technology

I've spent the better part of my career in technical support roles; hours upon hours equating RAM to freeways and CPU-cores to cooks in a kitchen. Countless individuals taking backup advice with a "ya, sure" and a head nod. People terrified over the word "server" and unassuming over the word "cloud". It baffles me how such basic knowledge is so foreign.

We spend large parts if not the majority of our days wrapped up in feeds and phones, devices and displays. How is it that none of us understand the fundamentals of how they operate?

I am not talking about the Science, Technology, Engineering, or Mathematics (STEM) behind everyday objects. I am not talking about teaching higher level concepts or tinkering with "niche" concepts like geometry, chemistry, or physics. I am talking about the everyday. I am talking about principle understanding of devices we fear to go without. Tools we use more than anything else in our lives!

Why is it that computer classes are electives? Why is it that those enamored with video games are the only ones *expected* to understand the relationship between browser tabs and RAM? Why is it that those obsessed with science fiction, participating in chess club, or enrolled in AP classes are the only ones *expected* to understand the severities of hard shutdowns? Why should cookies, encryption, or battery drain be mysteries to anyone born into today's world; mysteries to those touching unfathomable technology at 12-months-old?

This is not STEM. This is fundamental. This is commonplace. This is home economics.

Wikipedia:

> ***Family and Consumer Sciences*** *(FCS), also known as* ***home economics****, is the profession and field of study that deals with the economics and management of the home and community.[1]The field deals with the relationship between individuals, families, and communities, and the environment in which they live.*
>
> *As a subject of study, FCS is taught in secondary schools, colleges and universities, vocational schools, and in adult education centers; students include women and men. It prepares students for homemaking or professional careers, or to assist in preparing to fulfill real-life responsibilities at home. As a profession, it includes educators in the field and human services professionals.[2]*
>
> *The field represents many disciplines including consumer science, nutrition, food preparation, parenting, early childhood education, family economics and resource management, human development, interior design, textiles, apparel design, as well as other related subjects. Family and Consumer Sciences education focuses on individuals and families living in society throughout the life span, thus dealing not only with families but also with their interrelationships with the communities. Other topics such as sexual education, food management, and fire prevention might also be covered.*

Not a single mention of computers, yet nearly half of our time is spent in front of a screen. (Source: KPCB)

The misunderstanding or incomprehension of OS differences, dot-version subtleties, and computer languages can be expected. What should *not* be expected is the misunderstanding of "memory" versus "disk space" or the incomprehension of a kilo/mega/giga/tera/petabyte.

I do not fault those without basic computer knowledge or those born into this embarrassing system. There are simple things about computers I'm sure I do not wholeheartedly understand. There are simple things I use *every day* that I don't understand. I drive a car to work and still have a very little idea of how it operates. I'm intimidated by the cable, electric, and gas lines in my home. Hand me a toggle bolt (yes, I had to look it up) and I would swear it was a missing piece from an Erector Set. I'm a music junkie and I *still* have a hard time wrapping my head around the technology behind vinyl records and cassette tapes, let alone speakers themselves!

The lack of basic knowledge about the technology we utilize day-in and day-out, the technology we can't go five minutes without touching, tapping, refreshing, or waking gives me chills. I'm sure I get more pleasure from solving technological problems for people than most, but I sure as hell get tired of the same questions day-in and day-out. I know this is *much* bigger than a blog post, but his needs to stop. Redefine Home Ec 101 and make it mandatory.

Life in Japan

January 27, 2015

Categories: Media

Matt Leone, Polygon:

> *When we launched Polygon's cover stories last year, I wrote that one of our goals was to do something different each month. One month could be a behind-the-scenes story on a AAA game, like we did with Call of Duty. Another could be a feature about the fall of a company, like we did with THQ. And this month, we're trying something else — instead of posting one feature, we put together an online magazine about Japan's game industry.*

I'm just now dipping into this collection. 17 stories, gorgeous cover art, and a jukebox; a brilliant take on the digital magazine. The effort and resources Vox Media puts behind their editorial continues to amaze and inspire. Really looking forward to experiencing all this has to offer.

Troll Masks

January 28, 2015

Categories: Gender, General

Adi Robertson, The Verge:

> *How much of it is just an act? How much does it actually matter? How much empathy should we feel when we read something that genuinely seems like a cry for help, when the entire premise of modern-day trolling is that the internet is just a giant game of make-believe, and you're a fool to do more than point and laugh?*
>
> *None of this is encouraging, especially when you know that just mentioning it puts you in the crosshairs, too. It doesn't prove that there's some hidden decency to reach or some way to impose offline consequences (I haven't looked up anything about these people's real identities, and I don't plan to.) It doesn't prove anything about what kind of person does this, because someone's web presence doesn't necessarily indicate much about their everyday lives. All it proves is that this isn't some barrage of throwaway insults in a vacuum. Given enough time, whether it's created out of deep resentment or teenage thoughtlessness or deliberate, sociopathic calculation, even the most one-dimensional troll mask can start to come alive.<*

Great read.

Smooth McGroove on Upvoted

January 28, 2015

Categories: Business, Media, Music

Smooth McGroove on the Upvoted Podcast, timestamp 17:45:

> *It's such a niche thing that I had going, and still do. Not a lot of people played these video games, especially in Oklahoma. Most people that I'd encountered had heard of Zelda and maybe played a Mario game or something like that. Whenever it came to the people that I encountered day-to-day, most people would have never been supportive of this. They would have just said, "Oh, that's a fun thing but keep your day job." It was really the feedback that I got back from the Internet that gave me enough confidence and willpower to reinforce my own drive to do this.*
>
> *It was April of 2013. I quit giving [drum] lessons, I finished up my last semester at college, and from then on it was a good year-and-a-half straight of just singing, recording, mixing.*

On fans:

> *The fact that they were willing to not only watch a video or listen to a song but make a comment under the YouTube video or buy a song from one of the places I license with. It was when I started a Patreon that they were willing to donate a dollar for every video I put out.*
>
> *All of these things coming together was huge for me. It felt so big. It felt like... I can't even describe it really. It was that feeling that allowed me and gave me the confidence to squash not only the doubts, but to push forward the stuff that I really wanted to do, which was make music in some form, some way. It just happened to be through this video game music platform with me singing all the instruments.*

Upvoted is the newly debuted podcast from Reddit. Every episode is hopeful and inspiring, especially for silly dreamers.

My personal favorite McGroove jam here:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iW_Ct49H1ng

Find all of Smooth McGroove's albums on iTunes.

The Super Mario Timeline

January 28, 2015

Categories: Fun, History

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UGTddc62fXc#t=528

Speaking of silly dreamers, how about this gem. I like the idea of *Donkey Kong* leading to *Mario Bros*. I especially love the part where Bowser throws in the towel and Mario becomes a sports tycoon.

[Via Polygon]

Metroid Prime Trilogy for $10

January 29, 2015

Categories: General

Headed straight to Nintendo.com, signed in, purchased, and redeemed to remotely download on my Wii U at home. A seamless experience, assuming I have enough space on my Wii U.

I've only played through *Metroid Prime 3: Corruption*, but I enjoyed every bit of the experience. Gorgeous worlds, beautiful score, and a stellar if not the best use of the Wii Remote + Nunchuck.

As a reminder, current Wii Games on Wii U do not support the GamePad. Like This caveat is a problem.

[Via Polygon]

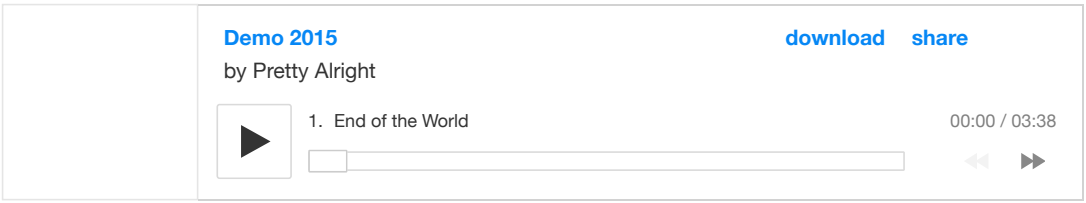
Update: Apparently, I didn't have enough free space. I returned home and turned on my Wii U expecting to see a *Metroid Prime Trilogy* icon, but there was none to be found. Nor a confirmation or error message present. Confused, Iollowed the instructions here, deleted *Super Smash Bros*. (sacrilegious, I know), and completed the download.

If Wii U can receive remote instruction to download, it should be able to fire back status updates. It's not that I would be able to do anything about it, but at the very least I would know what to expect when I arrived home. This is especially alarming for large games. Instead of side-stepping hours of download and install time while at away or sleeping, customers will be disappointed to find that the download never even started. While I'm all for patience in the name of entertainment, I am passionately opposed to misguiding expectations. Under promise and over deliver. Not the other way around.

Pretty Alright

January 30, 2015

Categories: Music



Ben C, a friend of mine, shared his band's new demo with me. I was incredibly impressed. A strong influence from Band of Horses with Grizzly Bear and My Morning Jacket sprinkled about. I especially enjoy "Even When You Don't Sing".

On a personal level, Pretty Alright sounds like a combination of Alexander J. Roberts, Team Hate Nelson, and Of The Swaying Sort. Give it a listen.

Pissing into the Wind

January 30, 2015

Categories: General

My phone has become a magic 8-ball of sorts; more 8-ball than magic. It can do phenonominal, unimaginable things but it can't give me existential answers. No matter how many times I race to it when it vibrates; wake it, hoping to find an at-reply from someone of notoriety; imagine Wordpress telling me my blog "is on fire"; there is never an answer. Nonetheless, my phone is a little black oracle. Today, it showed me some great things: *Song Exploder* with John Roderick, Marc Maron on *The Moment with Brian Koppleman*, Andrew Sullivan's departing post:

> *How do I say goodbye? How do I walk away from the best daily, hourly, readership a writer could ever have? It's tough. In fact, it's brutal. But I know you will understand. Because after all these years, I feel I have come to know you, even as you have come to see me, flaws and all. Some things are worth cherishing precisely because they are finite. Things cannot go on for ever. I learned this in my younger days: it isn't how long you live that matters. What matters is what you do when you're alive. And, man, is this place alive.*

I started *Zero Counts* to express my thoughts on the video game industry. Back then, I called it "The State of Gaming". Shortly after it's inception, I was quoted on *Daring Fireball*. Now, not a day goes by that there isn't an urge to appeal to John Gruber. Every word I write, every passage I compose is critiqued by the "Gruber in my head". I can't shake it. Every entry comes with hopeful anticipation that my phone *might* vibrate with a Twitter notification— Gruber favorited or, better yet, retweeted the associated tweet. Or best case scenario, he linked to my post on *Daring Fireball*, hopefully leaving an inkling of praise or simply stayed neutral. It would be enough to validate me, at least for a little while longer; until I had built a sustained audience.

This wasn't the first time this itch came alone. In 2008, my one and only vlog was posted to the front page of CNN.com for my favorite music of the year. (I still agree with my picks.) Maybe I was supposed to be a Youtube music reviewer. If so, I probably missed my opportunity. I never posted another. In 2010, I was cast into IGN's Community Spotlight for blogging about non-gaming topics on a gaming website. Maybe I was supposed to be a non-gaming gaming blogger. If so, I probably missed my opportunity. Which brings us to the *Daring Fireball* quote for a piece on *Mario Kart 8*. Maybe I was supposed to be a games journalist or analyst. I am currently trying to ride that wave.

I'm pissing into the wind; throwing mud at the wall; hoping and praying that I will find exactly what it is that sticks for me. That thing that I can't go another second without writing. There is an itch for conversation; I can't help myself from blogging and tweeting throughout the day. And I will continue to piss into the wind and throw mud at the wall. I will look to my phone, listen to an inordinate amount of podcasts, and scrape my Twitter feed for answers. Surely, someone out there knows who I am, but it sure as hell isn't me.

I've never read anything from Andrew Sullivan. For a Political Science major, that appears to be a crime. No doubt an influencial man and writer. The recent news surrounding his departure from blogging has me thinking a lot. If he can give this platform his all for fifteen years, I know I can too. I just hope I find a little something along the way.

Heroes of Might & Magic III HD Edition

February 2, 2015

Categories: General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pdeTku2vhmc

One of my all-time favorite games has been re-released on Steam, iOS, and Android. I spent countless hours with *Heroes of Might & Magic III* growing up, and during my late-twenties nostalgia trip, had been itching to play again. The HD sheen doesn't do much more than make the game look like what I remember playing, but I'm thrilled they kept the jagged animations around.

Steam | iOS | Android

[Via The Awesomer]

Garena Philippines Limiting LGBTQ Women from League of Legends Competition

February 3, 2015

Categories: eSports, Gender, Sexuality

Garena Esports (empahsis my own):

> *For any events we do, we always want to make sure we are able to have an inclusive environment where no one feels left out, and of course for everybody to enjoy. On this angle, we believed that allowing more to be eligible to join is obviously the answer and as many of our female teams have expressed -- Lesbian, Gay, Transgendered Women members are their friends too. On the other hand, for any competitions, we seriously look at ensuring there's a fair level playing field for all participants. And there are arguments and concerns from other participants who disputes that Lesbian, Gay, Transgendered Women members* ***may probably have*** *some unfair advantage.*

I have zero tolerance for the twisted logic/suspicion/assumption that one's physical traits, let alone sexual orientation, "may probably" provide them "some unfair advantage" in a competition based purely on mental prowess. Unbelievable.

[Via Polygon]

Club Nintendo Experiencing Heavy Traffic

February 3, 2015

Categories: Business, General

Club Nintendo:

> *We're experiencing heavy traffic at the moment, so accessing your account may take a little longer than usual and you may see display issues with your account when logged in. Please note that you'll have until 6/30/15 to redeem your rewards. Thank you for your patience.*

Yesterday, Club Nintendo announced a massive sale in conjunction with the discontinuation of the loyalty program, offering physical goods as well as Wii U, Wii, and 3DS downloadable titles at discounted redemption rates. I have since experienced issues a) accessing the page or b) signing in.

In May 2014, Club Nintendo experienced similar server strain due to heavy traffic generated by the *Mario Kart 8* free game offer.

There is No End

February 3, 2015

Categories: Media

Ludwig Kietzmann, Joystiq:

> *How can you envision an end when your purpose is to be in motion, always? Where do you stop if what you make, write and think is inextricable from the moment? We poured a bit of our heart and humor into each little vessel – a news story, an opinion, a review – paraded it for thirty minutes and then watched it fall off the page to make room for the next one. And the next. And the next. There is no end.*
>
> *I just compared blog posts to heart vessels, by the way, and you should know how irritated I am by that. It's just reporting. It's just video games. It's just… what we did.*

Square Enix Profit Doubles

February 4, 2015

Categories: Business, General

Gamespot:

> *In the home console space, Kingdom Hearts HD 2.5 ReMIX sold well, and catalog sales were also "strong," Square Enix said. Meanwhile, the publisher added that Final Fantasy XIV and Dragon Quest X are "making favorable progress."*

Unrelated: *Kingdom Hearts 2.5 HD ReMIX* is what prompted me to sell my PS3.

To my surprise, an Amazon shipment notice informed me that the game was on its way. The pre-order had slipped my mind as I had placed it nearly a year prior. I was already on the cusp of pulling the trigger on a PS4 when this IGN bit put me over the edge. I stuffed my unopened *Kingdom Hearts 2.5 HD ReMIX* back into the post, traded-in my PS3 and Xbox 360, and picked up a PS4.

I have no doubt that these games will end up on PS4. Worst case, another reason to subscribe to *Playstation Now*.

Fun v. Experience

February 5, 2015

Categories: Design, Media

Justin McElroy on the *Dying Light* episode of Polygon's Quality Control podcast, edited for clarity:

> *I think in our profession, our desire is to have an experience and then be able to move on to the next one. There is a pressure on us to be comprehensive in our knowledge and awareness of the medium. So, for a game that can reveal everything it has to say in three or four hours, there's a real attraction because we can have the entire experience and move on to the next thing.*
>
> *I think that people who are playing games for fun maybe don't have the same sort of voracious compulsion to get to the end, which I would separate from rushing through a game. I think it's more of a desire to have had the full experience and then be able to move on to the next thing.*

This describes exactly the reason I play video games now. Unlike McElroy, I am not *expected* to have comprehensive knowledge and awareness of the medium, but for the sake of my blog and personal interests, I try to. I certainly love writing about video games and the industry at large, but actually playing video games has become more about connecting with the zeitgeist rather than enjoying and immersing myself in the experience.

In my gaming heyday, I could pour countless hours into *Tony Hawk's Pro Skater*, *Starcraft*, and *Heroes of Might & Magic III* simply for pleasure and to perfect my strategies. I played *Star Fox 64* over and over just for fun. I spent an obscene amount of time playing *Final Fantasy X* just to be swept away. Today, there are plenty of video games I enjoy (see my reviews of *Monument Valley* and *Rocksmith 2014*), but it has been a long while since one has repeatedly beckoned to me to spend hours playing for fun. Instead, I find myself dipping into a game for a few hours to understand it on a mechanical, design, and experience level just to be part of the conversation. Hell, I spent $60 on *Super Smash Bros. for Wii U* only to tap out after 2 hours. (Queue Nani McElroy.)

Provisional Reviews on Polygon

February 6, 2015

Categories: Design, Media

Arthur Gies:

> *Whatever factors were preventing publishers and developers from setting their games loose upon consumers in an unfinished state have become less pressing, apparently. I'm not actually interested in calling any particular publisher or platform holder out here, as I don't think I have enough fingers to point at them all. The point is, simply, that it's becoming harder and harder to know, even on release day, if a game will function on day one, two, three or indefinitely.*
>
> *I don't think this is going away. In fact, for the time being, I am absolutely positive it won't. It will be some time before publishers get the hint that this isn't ok, where they move beyond lip service about "making it right" and actually start doing the right thing and delaying games that aren't in a state fit to be sold. I don't know what it will take for this to happen. I don't know what the final straw will be for consumers to push back.*
>
> *That said, I think there's more we can do to serve our audience and offer some modicum of caution and warning about games we have reservations about.*

Like clocks and cars, video games are two-fold: wondrous products made functional by mechanical innards. Video games are at once magical experiences full of narrative, music, design, and animations; at the same time highly mechanical, dynamic pieces of software full of the nuts and bolts of computer science.

Playing a video game is an individual, singular experience. As Griffin McElroy has stated before, "games by their very nature are interactive, meaning… your experience playing the game is going to be different." Therefore, the critique of a video game's artistry (design, narrative, visuals, music, etc.) should hold little weight to an individual. Where a video game's critique *should* be heavily considered is it's functionality. If a manufacturer isn't going to hold up their end of the consumer protection bargain (or be bad business, even better if the outlets can forewarn.

I am excited by this stance from Polygon. Video games are artistic illusions that only work if they are fully functional. If the undying mechanics are broken, the illusion is broken, too.

Re Netflix-Zelda: What is Game of Thrones without George R. R. Martin?

February 6, 2015

Categories: Business, Media

The Wall Street Journal:

> *The video streaming service is in the early stages of developing a live action series based on "Zelda," about an ordinary boy named Link who must rescue a princess named Zelda and save a fantasy world called Hyrule, said a person familiar with the matter. As it seeks writers to work on the show, Netflix is describing it as* ***"Game of Thrones"*** *for a family audience, this person said.*
>
> ...
>
> *As it is still seeking a writer to work on the series, Netflix has a long road to travel before a "Legend of Zelda" series actually becomes a reality. It's also possible that Netflix or Nintendo will kill the project before it gets off the ground.*

Considering Netflix's vision without a writer, I'd say this has a *very* long road to travel.

E3 2014: Genre/Gender Breakdown

February 7, 2015

Categories: Gender

Continuing my research of video game genre and protagonist/main character gender, here is the collected data from E3 2014. The sample list of 152 video games was sourced from IGN's Games at E3 2014, platform data mapped to a quantifiable “TRUE”/”FALSE” list, genre lists collected from both IGN and Wikipedia (limited to primary genre), and the main character gender researched to the best of my ability.

Elaborating on the gender categories:

“Multi” being either:

- multiple characters to select from (ie. *Mario Kart 8* / *Killer Instinct* receive 1 count for “multi” although there are several characters to select from)
- customizable gender
- large customizable party

“n/a” being a:

- gender ambiguous character
- god-view game
- first-person with no direct gender association











Some key points:

- My data can be found here. (Numbers online)
- Sample size = 152 games
- 13 exclusively female protagonists/main characters vs. 47 exclusively male protagonists
- Female protagonists by year:
    - 2012: 2%
    - 2013: 6%
    - 2014: 9%

Additional reference:

- E3 2013: Genre/Gender Breakdown, along with E3 2012 data

21 Percent Delta

March 5, 2015

Categories: Children, Design, Gender

Polygon's Charlie Hall reporting from GDC 2015:

> *Rosalind Wiseman and Ashly Burch collaborated to create their survey in the spring of 2014. Wiseman, herself a teacher, educator and author, was able to deliver the survey to 1,583 students aged 11 to 18 over the course of the year. The results, the authors say, are enough to turn the games industry's understanding of gender issues on its head.*
>
> *The most compelling data point for game developers is the fact that girls in high school are far more likely to prefer to play female characters than boys of the same age are likely to prefer to play male characters.*
>
> *Only 39 percent of high-school aged boys surveyed preferred to play as male characters, while 60 percent of high-school aged girls preferred to play as female characters.*
>
> *That 21 percent delta, the authors say, is more than enough reason for game developers to rethink who their main characters should be going forward.*
>
> *"We as developers," Burch said, "understandably ... are afraid of our games not selling.*
>
> *"It's terrifying to imagine that your game's not going to sell. But it could be that we are falsely attributing the success of past games to things that don't actually matter to the kids that are playing them."*

Since hearing Rosalind Wiseman on The One You Feed podcast, I've been an avid fan of her and Ashly Burch's work. In case you missed it, their GDC 2014 talk on *The Connection Between Boys' Social Status, Gaming and Conflict* is worth the watch.

See also: My recent breakdown of protagonist gender and video game genre from the games announced or highlighted at E3 2014.

Be more Disney, less Vegas

March 7, 2015

Categories: Business, Design

IGN's Seth G.Macy reporting from PAX East:

> *"Any item that affects game play," he told the audience, can be acquired "through grinding." He compared his ideal F2P model to Disneyland, saying that when a person visits the park, they have the choice to spend money as they see fit once inside, but they can still enjoy and experience all the park has to offer. He contrasted that with Vegas, where the push to spend to increase enjoyment is non-stop.*
>
> *"Be more Disney, less Vegas," he said. Bleszinski also said that Boss Key is watching and taking note of the people on the forums and on reddit who are offering suggestions and participating in the community, hinting that they will be rewarded for their participation.*

This seems like a *very* misguided comparison. Bleszinski seemed to skip the part where you pay to enter Disneyland. Get the most out of a $99 single park ticket means a Disneyland guest will spend anywhere from 11 to 16 hours in the park. Guests can bring food and drink into the park, but the realistic chances of anyone bringing in three meals plus snacks sounds overly ambitious. Needless to say, food will be purchased. And if a guest has gotten by without spending a dime inside of Disneyland, they still paid to enter. This is no where near a free-to-play model.

Monument Valley, post-House of Cards

March 8, 2015

Categories: Business

Michael Martin, IGN:

> *Main character Frank Underwood (Kevin Spacey) is seen playing and describing the game in the fifth episode of the hit Netflix series. As a result, the game has soared into the top 10 top paid apps on iTunes, where it currently resides at number five and is number three in the paid games category on the Google Play store. The game did not rank in the top 25 on either app store before appearing on the show.*
>
> *Speaking at GDC 2015, ustwo lead designer Ken Wong said the show's producers reached out to the developer about the game appearing in House of Cards at no cost to the studio, according to IB Times.*
>
> *"They called us up and they said, 'Can we use your game?' and we said 'Yes,'" Wong said.*

One Tool to Rule Them All

March 8, 2015

Categories: Business, Design, Technology

An important read about Tim Sweeney and Epic Games covering Unreal Engine, it's use in interactive experiences from cinema to video games, the potential of VR and AR, and the state of free-to-play.

Chris Plante, The Verge:

> *When asked if Unreal Engine 4 will span the next 10 years, Sweeney says that it's for the foreseeable future, that Unreal Engine will get to "the promised land," a vision of the future Sweeney's hinted at earlier in the day during his speech at the Game Developers Conference. "This is the word I was afraid to use earlier. This is the convergence of all these forms of media."*
>
> *Technologists, media theorists, and game designers spoke of the convergence ad nauseam in the 1990s, when film and video games came together in a garbage fire of media that could neither be called a good game nor a good film. In the 2000s, the convergence was replaced with the notion of transmedia, with entertainment spread across different mediums, connected through a shared universe or narrative. However Sweeney believes the convergence is making a comeback, that the graphics world is seeing humans and technology meeting at a unified point. Sweeney sees photorealistic 3D objects and lighting and virtual reality attracting game designers, sure, but also industrial designers, architects, and film makers to engines like Unreal Engine 4.*
>
> *In this future, or present if you ask Sweeney, lessons learned from one field, say an architect designing a virtual building, can be applied to games or film, and likewise. Sweeney believes the potential application of the engine across all fields increases exponentially as information is shared.*
>
> *All of this raises the question: does Epic Games identify purely as a games company? "We're realizing now that Unreal Engine 4 is a common language between all these common fields." Sweeney doesn't see the industries as all that different. More interesting than Sweeney's prediction of field-sharing information and experience is the speculation of the fields in some ways merging together. For their most recent demo, Epic Games partnered with Weta to create a VR demonstration featuring the dragon Smaug from the The Hobbit.*

The separation between game and experience and art is becoming more defined. Under the guise of this piece, interactive experiences such as *Journey* and *Dear Esther* feel like the blossoms of Tim Sweeney's greater vision, most recently demonstrated with Smaug.

Update: I failed to mention the main reason why this important. Not only does the diversity of Unreal Engine 4 practical uses help clarify the categories of computer generated media, there's this:

> *... this year, Unreal Engine 4 is free — the company asks for a 5 percent royalty for any commercial product made with the engine that makes more than $3,000 a quarter.*

Commercial product: a product that can make money (i.e. video games, VR/AR experiences, movies, TV shows, YouTube shorts, amateur animations, etc.).

The New Normal

March 11, 2015

Categories: Health

Another tremendously powerful post from Mackenzie Craven:

> *So here is a snapshot of my post-cancer life, my new normal. I'm back at work full time, squeezing my 40 hours in any way I can with at least 1 of the aforementioned appointments each day. I'm getting mapped for radiation today – once those daily appointments start, my calendar is going to fill up even more. My free time mainly consists of getting my stretching time in to improve the mobility in my arm, but I do try and work out when I can (now that I can). And other than that, I'm just… trying my best to remember how to enjoy life, and to remember what normal even is. It isn't easy. Some days all I want is for people to acknowledge I'm still recovering from this whole nightmare and cut me some slack, yet other days I swear I will scream If I get another sympathetic face and a "how are you feeling?" I don't even want to THINK about cancer one moment… then suddenly it is the only thing on my mind. I'm laughing, I'm crying. I'm a survivor; I'm a victim. I'm fine! I'm not fine. I'm… a contradiction. Every day I put on my best normal face and fool the world around me that I'm doing as well as I'm leading on, yet every day I get frustrated that the world thinks I'm back to normal. I don't have hair, eyelashes or full range of motion in my arms – but I also don't have cancer. Baby steps.*

PS4 Adds Console Wide Button Remapping

March 26, 2015

Categories: Accessibility

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *The screen at the top of this story doesn't look like much. It's a simple interface that allows you to swap any one button on the Dual Shock 4 for any other button. It's a screen that makes gaming a much better place.*
>
> *"Console wide button remapping is a huge deal for physically impaired gamers. One of the most commonly requested accessibility adaptation AbleGamers receives is for custom controller's that move buttons to more comfortable positions," Steve Spohn, COO of the AbleGamers charity; told Polygon.*
>
> *"If you have limited movement in one arm, only one functioning hand, or even limited digit movement, button positioning is everything. And even more so if you have a neuromuscular disease such as muscular dystrophy where you fatigue more easily depending on what buttons you need to press."*
>
> *The push for full customization in button mapping has been going on for years, and some companies are better than others when it comes to offering the feature. What Sony has done is make the conversation obsolete by offering the option at the console level. This is a huge deal for many gamers.*

The Oral History of Steve Barron's TMNT

April 3, 2015

Categories: General

March 30, 2015 marked the 25th anniversary of the original *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles* film. In commemoration, The Hollywood Reporter rounded up several cast and crew members to recount the making of the highest grossing independent film at the time.

The Hollywood Reporter:

> ***Gray**: I always thought it would be interesting to have someone who was coming out of MTV videos to amp this up visually. To make it a little bit younger. Director Steve Barron was suggested to us. We looked at his reel. He had done all this great stuff with A-ha. He had done "Billie Jean" with **Michael Jackson**. He had a very good visual style.*
>
> ***Steve Barron, director**: I didn't want to do something that was bloody. I didn't want to watch that film. Funnily enough, Batman came out at the same time. It was that sort of tone I was already aiming for. The films that I loved, there was a sense of humor but a sense of peril as well. Of real peril, of grounded peril. Like something that had repercussions for what you did but had a wonderful sense of fun with it. I was a big fan of Ghostbusters.*
>
> *...*
>
> ***Eastman**: For an independent film, it was beyond our wildest hopes. We liked the final movie and we hoped people would like it, and [the fact] it did as well as it did was fantastic. Of all the versions of Turtles that have been optioned over the past 30 years now — and certainly in the entertainment arena — the first movie stands out as our hands-down favorite version.*

If Barron's *TMNT* is not my favorite movie, it easily slides into my top 5. I just wish Street Fighter would have been as successful.

Nintendo's Trickle-Release of Retro Titles, Round 2

April 3, 2015

Categories: Business

Sam Byford of The Verge on Nintendo's trickle-release strategy for Virtual Console:

> *Here are some movies you can watch right now on Netflix without causing the value of film as a medium to implode: Raging Bull. Fargo. Manhattan. Pulp Fiction. Chinatown. Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid. Amélie. Trainspotting. Apocalypse Now. Rocky. These are movies that a lot of people probably pay several dollars each for on iTunes (or, well, DVD) à la carte, yet their availability on Netflix doesn't hurt their classic status. Nintendo has by far the most valuable back catalog and intellectual property in gaming; even if it only made its own titles available and ignored third parties completely, it'd have a vast library that a lot of people would be willing to pay monthly for.*
>
> *Sure, some will pay the cost of a month of Netflix for Super Mario 64 this month. But what about next month? I can't imagine Donkey Kong 64 or Paper Mario drawing similar revenue, but they're exactly the kind of title people would dip into out of curiosity under a subscription model. In a world where EA is offering access to all but its newest current console games for just $30 a year, this doesn't seem like the hardest of calls.*

When Nintendo began trickling out retro titles for the Wii Virtual Console, I shared Byford's strong aversion to the slow, methodical rollout of games that had been available on past consoles (and ROMs) for years. At the mention of Super Mario 64 coming to Wii U, and Wii titles before that, the aversion never surfaced.

That the comparison of video games to film is an "apples vs. oranges" debate. Consumption of classic movies takes markedly less time than consumption of classic video games. With little time to focus on a single game, let alone the plethora or titles released every week/month, it's nice to put the brake on "the binge" with an unhurried drip. A subscription service would not only bombard players with a catalog as stress inducing as Netflix's, it would also surely waste away subscribers dollars spent vs. content consumed.

Regarding price, for titles I love and want to re-experience, *Donkey Kong 64* and *Paper Mario* being two of them, I am more than happy to shell out $9.99 ($2.00 if I've already purchased on Wii) to relive the experience. On the other hand, I see what Byford is getting at regarding titles I had never played. Many of these legacy DS games are going to be a hard sell for me, especially when pit up against some of my fondest memories.

David Benioff on Writing Fiction v. Screenplays

April 14, 2015

Categories: Art

Game of Thrones co-creator David Benioff on Aisha Tyler's Girl On Guy podcast:

> *Writing dialogue. I love it. That's the fun part for me. The hard part for me is writing the descriptions. There's just something great about writing 'INT. RESTAURANT. DAY/NIGHT'. A production designer's going to figure that shit out. I don't have to worry about it. I'm just going to write what the characters are saying.*
>
> *I still love writing novels. Writing fiction to me... I still think of it as the highest form of writing, but it's so fucking hard and it's torture for me. I don't have fun doing it. I have fun writing screenplays.*

An extremely honest and reassuring quote. What aspiring writer doesn't want to hear a quote like this from one of the co-creators of the most ambitious show on television?

José James on Discovering Miles Davis, Jazz

April 14, 2015

Categories: Music

American jazz and hip-hop vocalist José James during a 'Meet the Musician' event at the Apple Store, Kurfürstendamm:

> *I couldn't believe one artist had made 50 albums. I pull one out and I look at the back and it has four tracks on it and each track is 18-minutes long. I'm thinking, "I can't listen to this. I want value." I was looking for the one with twelve tracks on it.*

So incredibly peculiar how we subscribe value. I too ran into the same quandary when experiencing Miles Davis for the first time. Then I thought back to listening to "The Decline" on repeat. And "2113" after that. And "Goodbye Sky Harbor" after that. And "Cicatriz E.S.P." after that. And "Drop" after that. And "Chimera Obscurant" after that. And "Dauðalagið" after that.

Cumulative time does not equate to value. I'll be damned if I couldn't listen to "So What" on loop for the rest of my life.

He Would Not Work in Oils

April 14, 2015

Categories: Art, Culture, Society

Seth Godin on The Moment with Brian Koppelman:

> *If you think that you were born to paint in oils, or you were born to speak the truth about income inequality, or you were born— it's just not true. If Vincent Van Gogh were born today, he would not work in oils. If Steve Jobs had been born 500 years ago, he would have done something else.*
>
> *So what is the authentic version of Vincent Van Gogh? There isn't one. What there is is someone who sought out a series of emotions that he could create for himself and gifts he could give other people through his work. And what I'm getting at is yes, we need to be consistent in honoring the truth of what we came to say.*
>
> *But I also know that if I'd been born one block away from where I was born to different parents, or if I had been born in Yugoslavia, the fact that I'm here talking to you about these things would not have occurred. This is not the authentic expression of my DNA.*

Excellent reminder.

Campaign Season

April 14, 2015

Categories: Politics

Over the weekend, I had an interesting conversation with a relative. The conversation was not interesting so much as my reaction was interesting.

This relative asked what school I had gone to and I replied with the addition that I had majored in political science. Without hesitation, he responded, "let's talk about politics." My reply, "let's not," went in one ear and out the other.

To backtrack, I had become extremely passionate about politics during my senior year of high school. Over the course of my college career, I shied away from pursuing my innate passion to debate ethics, policy, and humanitarian issues. However, after many twists-and-turns, majors and minors, I found myself holding a BA in political science.

Back to the conversation.

Naturally, it veered into Hillary Clinton's announcement for the 2016 presidential bid. My relative's qualm against her was that electing her as president "would put Bill back in the White House," but "Bill was a good president." My confusion began here.

Then my blood began to boil. I hadn't felt this way in a long time. But I wouldn't let it get the better of me. I was wiser than I was in high school and college. I had learned not to speak up when I didn't know 110% of what I was talking about.

But I snapped.

After a few unproven assumptions about how things would pan out if she were president, I interrupted:

"If Hillary is elected, there are going to be folks that never let go of the email scandal. If Ted Cruz is elected, there are going to be folks that never let go of the fact that he was born in Canada. Just like the folks that wasted four years plus *another* four years questioning Obama's birth certificate.

"Too much time is wasted. This shit doesn't matter."

It was quick, tame, and uneducated in the context of all things political. But even without all the answers and a well crafted strategy (of which I only ever had in school), I fought back; something I hadn't done in *years*.

To be clear, I do believe that Hillary's email scandal is a big deal. But under the context of my argument, it helped... maybe. I'm rusty. Cut me some slack.

In any case, the campaign season is upon us. Every four years, many "sports ball" tech nerds like myself get fired up during this time. It is a spectator sport we get interested in. And unlike fantasy sports, selecting your candidates and propositions actually affect real-life.

In the next week or so, my passion around campaign season will likely cool down. Like the baseball season, I'll stay focused during opening week, putter out during mid-season, and ramp back up during the final third. But for once in quite some time, I feel fired up. And I like it.

Thoughts on Star Wars Teaser #2

April 16, 2015

Categories: General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ngElkyQ6Rhs

1. I could have sworn they were pulling audio from Return of the Jedi. (Mark Hamill still sounds youthful.) Until Luke's line: "You have that power, too."
2. And if this is truly new dialogue, Luke state's that his 'father *has* it." Has. Not had.
3. It's fun to imagine Vader is still around, but whether it's clever audio splicing or Luke referring to the omnipresent (Force ghost[1]) Anakin, I say Vader is dead and gone.
4. Finn is a trepidatious Stormtrooper recruit. The chaotic stormtrooper battle scene affirms his worries and he chooses to leave the Empire (or equivalent faction). This is the first time we witness the weight of war and death on soldiers in the post-prequel films.[2]
5. I need to figure out a way to be a part of this upcoming series of Disney Star Wars films.
6. I hate zoom. (1:28)

---

[1] Thanks for the heads up to @AlexandreSitbon. The term was slipping my mind.

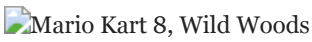
[2] *Correction*: Sad Ewok.

Mario Kart 8 DLC Pack 2: Here We Go!

April 26, 2015

Categories: Design

Mario Kart 8 DLC Pack 2 was released on April 23, 2015. The addition of *Animal Crossing's* Villager and Isabelle as well as Dry Bowser don't do much for me. Likewise, new karts have never been something I glamour for, often selecting the standard kart for every race. (I dig classic!) However, the new *Crossing* and *Bell* cups include some of the most gorgeous video game visuals I have come across, Nintendo game or otherwise.


Mario Kart 8, Wild Woods

As I was racing through the new and original *Wild Woods* track, I was itching for Dry Bowser to hop out of his kart and explore. (I've experienced similar feelings racing through *Shy Guy Falls*, *Dolphin Shoals*, and *Toad Harbor*.) Likewise, the *Animal Crossing* track turns the traditionally isometric town into a truly inhabitable world.

A racing game feeling inhabitable speaks volumes.

A breathtaking "open-world" *Legend of Zelda* is a reality. Likewise, Nintendo has shown stellar execution of HD visuals in *Mario Kart 8*. This adds up to trigger a craving for the next iteration of 3D Mario games to be set in a seamless HD universe; freeing itself from stage selection and selective star quests and instead opting in for a connected Mushroom Kingdom.

This does not mean an "open-world" Mario game. I am no champion for open-world games. In fact, I often loathe them. I become distracted by side-quests and/or feel forced spend hours completing unnecessary tasks to progress the story or grow the game only to be forced to backtrack or fast-travel to previously completed areas. More and more I feel "open-world" means "lock-in", encouraging players to invest obscene amounts of time in a single game to the point where they are afraid or ashamed to give it up.

I would love to see the next iteration of 3D Mario games open up into semi-open, adventure style platformers à la *Jak and Daxter*. No overworld. No stage select. No "painting portals". Missions are discovered throughout the Mushroom Kingdom in lands akin to *Thwomp Ruins*, *Cheep Cheep Beach*, and *Moo Moo Meadows*, each gated by the traditional "star-requirement".

I previously posted some thoughts on Iterative vs. Redesigned Experiences:

> *Super Mario 64 could have just as easily been another side-scroller, albeit with better visuals. The Legend of Zelda: The Ocarina of Time could have been another top-down adventure. Donkey Kong 64 could have gone a number of pre-existing directions. Sure the Metroid series skipped the Nintendo 64 generation but Metroid Prime could have been another 2D platformer. The fact of the matter is that these titles reinvented their respective franchises. The worlds and characters we loved were shown in a new light and perspective. Sure, they are great games but they reinvented the way we thought about the franchises. This is what makes them so special.*

More than just a great racing game, I believe *Mario Kart 8* provides a glimpse at the future of the Mushroom Kingdom. Like *Super Mario 64* dropped the "3D game design" mic, a fully connected

Mushroom Kingdom could bring the 3D adventure-platformer back into the limelight and showcase exactly how it should have been done 15+ years ago.

All Killer, No Filler

April 28, 2015

Categories: Design

The *Just Cause 3* trailer is here. *The Witcher 3: Wild Hunt* is upon us. *Dragon Age: Inquistion* surprised with "Game of the Year" at DICE. And I'm tired of open-world.

More specifically, I'm tired of side-quests.

The first post to relaunch my personal blogging, Finding The Rails, attempted to capture an idea that like RPGs, there is a tricky balance to life between rails and side-quests. After a year out of college, I found difficulty in finding focus in my professional growth. School always provided a rail; you stay on track and graduate. What was often heard but never comprehended was the idea that after school, life changes. Priorities change. Responsibility kicks in. Time flies by. Emotions are juggled.

Somewhat recently, I purchased a PS4 — in large part to play *Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor*. I had completed the main quest, but throughout my playthrough, I continually felt compelled to seek out side-quests and collectibles. Like commanding an unruly Graug, I felt I had to continually redirect my attention to the main goal. Thankfully, I had completed enough side-quests and gathered enough collectibles to level Talion up enough progress through to the (lackluster) end.

This should not have been the case. Side-quests and collectibles should not be necessary to complete a game. Arguably, the greatest games of all time were played in a roughly linear manner. *Super Mario Bros*. (and most of its iterations) is (are) extremely linear and hold up today. Mega Man games provide boss patterns that streamline the game's experience. Hell, even Final Fantasy games feel largely liner amongst the *Skyrims* and *Dragon Age: Inquisitions* of today. (Yes, I am giving *FFXIII* a pass — nay, credit — for it's extreme use of linear gameplay, especially when *FFVII* and *FFX* feel like average adventure games amongst the throng of open-world, 100+ hour games of today.)

It goes without saying that hours upon hours of gameplay lure consumers to the idea that value is based on dollars spent per hour played. (Sales strategy? Definitely. Blocking mechanism against rival product? Possibly.) But when three hours of an 80+ hour game feel like a slog, how can one be expected to reap the entire value?

Today, Polygon published a piece from Tristan Ettleman on the trends of low-income gamers:

> *I expected to find a robust multiplayer game at the core of every low-income gamer's library. Industry trends, the "content galore" allure of multiplayer gameplay and my own experience led me to believe that sticking to a popular online game was the most cost-efficient way to maintain a passion for video games.*
>
> *That's not the case. Time is another resource that's in short supply when you're struggling to pay the bills, so shorter, story-based games become a big draw.*

This is an interesting observation, and one that does not stop at the low-income gamer.

I recently purchased *Dragon Age: Inquisition* and *Far Cry 4*, both of which topped countless "Best of 2014" lists. I'll be damned if I didn't feel tricked into playing side-quest after side-quest before fully comprehending the story and stakes. Even the controls and mechanics still felt foreign after hours and hours of play. I've given my two-cents about exploitative gameplay, and even though these lengthy

AAA titles aren't picking at my wallet every few minutes, they've certainly got me pissing away $60 for upwards of five hours of playtime before I'm tapped out. All for the allure of spectacular visuals, the promise of storytelling, and conversation amongst the gaming community.

Books are focused. Movies are focused. Music is focused. Most pre-GTAIII video games are focused. My job, my relationships, my life is/are not. Call it another "get off my lawn" moment, but I need some focus in my games.

All killer, no filler.

'200CC Is So Fast It's Starting To Break Mario Kart 8 Courses'

April 30, 2015

Categories: Design

Yannick LeJacq writing for Kotaku:

> *Normally, busting outside of the normal confines of a level in Mario Kart 8 requires a) some sort of glitch or bug to be present and exploitable, or b) a hack of the game like the ones two modders famously performed last year. Kart racer and Reddit user dizzyzane wasn't using any special hacking tricks, though. He was just driving really, really fast thanks to Mario Kart 8's game-changing new 200CC speed class.*

Love this. Like that moment when a toddler goofs, turning a harmless accident into a humorous event. Makes you appreciate the calculations behind great level design and game balance. (Though, it appears breaking Music Park's ceiling was already possible in 150CC, just not to this extent, as per kingdomharms's Reddit reply.)

EDIT: Thinking on it, I'm a bit mixed about 200CC. On one hand, if 200CC is truly a new feature, the fact that more levels were not broken open with the increased speed is a testament to Nintendo as a quality game maker. That is, unless, 200CC was planned from the get go; to which 200CC would have been a business strategy for increased play time / player investment. If that is the case, I'm always miffed at the holding back of content. (See also: Mario Party 10 under Nintendo Direct Play-by-Play from 1/16/15)

Nintendo Attractions Coming to Universal Parks

May 7, 2015

Categories: General

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *Universal has theme parks in Orlando, Hollywood, Japan and Singapore, and it's currently unknown which parks will be getting these attractions, or what the attractions with entail. The most recent large addition to Universal Orlando was the well-received Wizarding World of Harry Potter, and the addition of Nintendo characters and rides could be a potent weapon against the competing Disney resorts. It sounds like we're going to have to wait a bit more details. "The immersive experiences will include major attractions at Universal's theme parks and will feature Nintendo's most famous characters and games," the press release said. "More details will be announced in the future, as the Nintendo and Universal creative teams work to create specific concepts."*

After the success of the Wizarding World of Harry Potter, I trust Universal to do a respectable job with Nintendo's IP. While I often daydream about a dedicated Nintendo theme park, I don't belive their IP alone is enough to engross visitors for a full day.

My wife's immediate reaction: "Legoland is screwed." Interesting that Universal seems to be playing LEGOs own game: license out massive, mixed brand IP for a variety of experiences, personalities, and worlds under a single umbrella.

I'd comfortably say that since the early 2000s, Disney resorts felt like the only go-to theme park destinations. Today there is certainly more reason to divide time bewteen multiple resorts.

With Disney's admission prices skyrocketing, the inclusion of Marvel and Star Wars, Tomorrowland and Jungle Cruise films launching, and Universal's expansion of the Wizarding World of Harry Potter married with Nintendo attractions, the theme park industry is in for exciting times.

Also, very fun to watch Nintendo's rapid expansion outside of the dedicated console video game market. For a company who's traditionally been set on a singular market, they've certainly made some very quick moves outside of their comfort zone.

Would Disney Buy Nintendo?

May 7, 2015

Categories: Business

Shortly after posting my thoughts on the announcement of Nintendo attractions in Universal Parks & Resorts, Ben Thompson reached out and asked a simple question:

https://twitter.com/benthompson/status/596365952100347905

I've posted a couple of pieces about the cross-over between Disney and Nintendo, most relevant to the possibility of a Disney acquisition of Nintendo on 11/21/14:

> *Star Wars is Disney.*
>
> *Marvel is Disney.*
>
> *It was as if I had never really given weight to the thought. Nintendo has always been so evident and ripe to fit along classic Disney franchises. But Marvel and Star Wars? Put in the context of Disney buying Nintendo and Nintendo just seems like a no brainer put up against the other two.*
>
> *On the flip-side, the majority have been spelling doom for Nintendo for years. And Nintendo has been putting up one hell of a fight. Let's see how these Super Smash Bros. numbers do.*

(Turns out those *Super Smash Bros.* numbers have done pretty well. Nintendo's fiscal year 2015 report states 6.75 million units for 3DS, 3.65 million units for Wii U.)

Thinking a bit more about butting up Nintendo's cast of characters next to Disney's, there is an odd dissonance that begins to materialize.

Personality

Nintendo's IP (Mario & Co.) compete directly with Disney's foundational IP (Mickey & Co.). They serve a like purpose for both brands, only Nintendo's are largely mute and and lack archetypes. It's difficult to identify with Mario, Link, and Samus and I think that would be a problem for Disney. That's not to say Mickey, Minnie, and Donald are easy to identify with, but what has grown from their foundation are characters like Ariel, Elsa, and Aladdin. Likewise, Marvel and Star Wars characters such as Spiderman and Han Solo exude heavy archetypes that fans, child or adult, latch on to.

It may seem like nonsense in the context of playful, lighthearted entertainment, but archetypes are hooks. I'm a big *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles* fan, a team of four heavy archetypes. When playing as a child, I would pick which Turtle I wanted to be and act out their personality. Likewise, selecting a favorite Avenger (Captain America) adds a vast array of color to playtime or personal ethics. I'm not sure how kids go about acting out Mario vs. Luigi. (Other than a death-stare I suppose.)

Fight

Time and time again, Nintendo has shown that they can put up a fight. Most recently, with Wii U's stagnant numbers, Nintendo tightened and polished mainstream hits like Mario Kart and Super Smash Bros. to help move the console back to relevancy.

Nintendo President Satoru Iwata during the 2015 fiscal year financial results:

> *Specifically, I believe it was significant that "Mario Kart 8" and "Super Smash Bros. for Wii U" were released in the same year and that we have been able to maintain users' active use of these titles months after their respective releases.*

Lately, Nintendo has also been oddly quick to diversify and even innovate, entering into a new product category with Amiibo (of which 10.5M have already shipped), speaking with TV & Film creative houses, and most recently partnering with Universal to enter into the theme park market.

All of this speaks to Nintendo's steadfast attitude and the pride that builds after proving themselves to the nay-sayers. From weird controllers to the motion-control frenzy to off-screen play, they remain resolute in their foundation as innovators; trusting themselves when embarking on new endeavors. Given the choice of the guarantee of making a buck or flopping with a new creative product, I trust Nintendo to stand-by the flop until it makes a buck.

I believe Nintendo sees themselves as the Little Mac to Disney's Mike Tyson; a worthy underdog in the entertainment ring.

Price, or return?

Back to Ben Thompson's initial question. Ben made the comment of "too pricey." Disney bought Marvel and Lucasfilm for $4B each. Nintendo is currently holds a market cap of $25.73B. Disney currently stands at a market cap of $185.96B. Note that I have very little knowledge of how the financial markets work or if the price to buy would be based off of market cap. That said, I don't entirely believe Nintendo would be too pricey, rather a return on an investment of $25.73B would stand to be an extremely long-game.

In a world where Disney owned Nintendo, I highly doubt any Nintendo property or product would see a rise comparable to that of the $2B in market cap the second teaser trailer for *Star Wars: The Force Awakens* generated for Disney. Nintendo's current video game business would holdfast while their toy and other consumer products division would certainly expand. But, again, I don't see a singular product, movie, or experience (let alone the speculation of success!) that would net as quick and massive a return as $2B. For Disney to see a valuable return on a Nintendo acquisition, I see Disney utilizing not only Nintendo IP but Nintendo's game design infrastructure to boost the Disney Interactive brand, giving the weight and timelessness Nintendo franchises have to Disney games.

Lack of voice

Speaking of timelessness, I believe video games can be too timeless. In regard of Disney; their vault; and founding ideology of past, present, and future; time is key.

Great video games are seemingly endlessly re-playable for generations. Not to mention that the lack of captivating story elements in most Nintendo games means that they are typically always relevant because, well, they are not relevant at all. There is a tiny bit of nostalgia involved when playing a game you grew up with, but it's not the sort of remembrance we give to artists of film and TV. It wasn't until I saw Wreck-It Ralph that I my nostalgia meter peeked. I accredit this not to my remembers of the games, but the fact that Disney payed homage to my own private memories.

Likewise, video game production value has reached not what I would call a plateau, but a current landscape that spans generations. New 8/16-bit games are just as relevant as photo-realistic AAA

titles. In the world of film, throwback production like *The Artist*, while great, can be considered novelty. That same sense of great timely novelty is what gives weight, connection, and excitement when seeing Han Solo on screen again. Possibilities are endless in video games that lack great voice talent. Because of this, I'm afraid that sense of great novelty and nostalgia would never happen on a mass scale for video games the way Disney would need it to.

Would Disney buy Nintendo? I say no. Disney doesn't need Nintendo. Nintendo doesn't need Disney.

Buttons

May 30, 2015

Categories: Business, Design

Over the past week or so, I've learned that you can play *Splatoon* with two controllers taped together. I've also learned that *Batman: Arkham Knight* is a sprawling complicated buffet of gaming genres.

While the latter *may* be less about controls, I'm going to bet a "complicated buffet of gaming genres" would be a whole lot less daunting if I didn't have 17 input methods on my PS4 to use at a moment's notice:

- D-pad (up, down, left, right)
- Left joystick
- Right joystick
- Circle
- Square
- Triangle
- X
- L1
- L2
- L3
- R1
- R2
- R3
- start
- options
- clickable touchpad
- PS button

After you're done digesting all of that, take a moment to get to know your Xbox One Wireless Controller.

As Ben Thompson pointed out:

https://twitter.com/benthompson/status/603954550060355584

Beyond casuals, this is a problem for returning and often busy players. The fear of returning to a video game after days, weeks, or months of not playing – hell, the fear of picking up any video game to begin with – may stem from the problems above. Tutorials are commonplace in video games. Half the time I forget what the tutorials taught me. But instead of digging through menus for a refresher, I return to button mashing and familiarity for the sake of progress.

I began playing video games with the following inputs:

- D-pad
- A
- B
- Select
- Start

Today, most people start with less: A touchscreen. Even with an unabashed fondness for the admittedly hideous and complex Nintendo 64 controller, I've taken to iOS games that require simple gestures and brief touches but offer rich experiences.[1] (See: *Alto's Adventure*, *The Room*, *Monument Valley*)

Whether or not *Journey* can be considered a "game", it is an award-winning experience that only utilized for 44% of the PS3's buttons. While all buttons were used in *The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time*, it_ _did something extremely interesting: Auto-jumping. When I first played the game, I thought it crazy that jumping was defined by the world, not the player. But I got used to it and eventually loved it. It made perfect sense. In a physical world of button fatigue, a virtual world helped establish what was critical to player timing and what was trivial based on surroundings.

I've been dipping in and out of *Far Cry 4* lately. I haven't come across a good instance where *I* should be the one to define when to grapple or it necessary to control the climb mechanism. (Granted I've only played for a few hours.) Grappling seems trivial. On the flip-side, *Dragon Age: Inquisition* controls my use of potions based on programming, default or player defined. Potion use is trivial. Your character needs to be healed, so the game heals you. The player need not press a button.

I certainly have a reverie for the days of 5 inputs. A colleague and I spent time handling an original Game Boy last week, remembering just how comfortable and satisfying the early handheld felt. (The feels and travel of it's buttons are a thing of beauty.) The more I sit back and think about the backwards oddity of shutting out an extremely large swath of consumers while deterring those who are ripe to purchase but are fatigued and tired of re-learning, the more I picture grandma's remotes.

---

[1]UPDATE: Super Mario Run nailed it.

Mega Man 2017

June 1, 2015

Categories: General

Today, Capcom announced plans for a new Mega Man animated series.

Capcom-Unity:

> *Dentsu handpicked **Man Of Action Entertainment**, creators of Ben 10 and Generator Rex, to create, write and executive produce the all-new **Mega Man **animated series. Disney/Marvel's Academy Award®-winning feature Big Hero 6 utilized the characters and team created by Man of Action, the bi-coastal creative studio and writers' collective formed by creators and acclaimed comic book writers Joe Casey, Joe Kelly, Duncan Rouleau and Steven T. Seagle. Marvel called upon Man of Action to produce and write Ultimate Spider-Man and Marvel's Avengers Assemble for their successful launches on Disney XD. The new **Mega Man **series has a target air date of 2017, coinciding with the franchise's 30th anniversary.*
>
> *"We are very excited about the opportunity to introduce an all-new **Mega Man** to loyal fans and kids," said Kinoshita, commenting on the deal. "Having a celebrated character from Japan reimagined by Man Of Action is the ideal project for Dentsu Entertainment USA."*

I'm trepidatious.

The original Mega Man sprite epitomizes not only onscreen character design, but humanized robot design. A user controlled robot with the face of a boy; a face begging for life. And so, he blinks.



He recycles programmed movements when he jumps or takes damage. Nothing more. Nothing less. He doesn't pretend to become tired or irritated at the player. Why would he? He is a killing machine, awaiting commands from his user.

That's why, during the *nearly* perfect *Super Smash Bros.* Mega Man trailer, the magic of Mega Man breaks down between 0:44 and 0:47. He stops. He breathes. He shows emotion:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JmCVzjGVFy4

It's not that I worry about the new Mega Man animated series. I will always have the original Mega Man sprite. It's that I hope that Man Of Action Entertainment will be able to pull off not only a loveable character, but a loveable robot.

Hats off to Baymax. Let that be the seed for the return of the Blue Bomber.

The Future of Mario Double-Down

June 11, 2015

Categories: Design

I've been playing a lot more *Mario Kart 8* lately and recently played through Moo Moo Meadows. My wife loves this course. It is simple and old, recently made beautiful. Maybe it's the lighting, but I get a similar vibe from Moo Moo Meadows as I do Wild Woods. Call me crazy, but I'm doubling down on the direction of the next 3D Mario.

Marco on Phil with John

June 11, 2015

Categories: Business, Culture, Design, Gender, Technology

On June 9th, 2015, Apple's Senior Vice President of Worldwide Marketing Phil Schiller, a man who has spent half of his life at Apple Inc., joined Daring Fireball's John Gruber on stage for a live episode of *The Talk Show*.

Here's a bit from Marco Arment:

> *This meant a lot for both John and podcasting. Apple sent an executive to be interviewed on a podcast, and one of the highlights of John Gruber's career as a writer didn't involve writing at all.*

To quote Marco further, "I'd listen to their podcast." It will be remembered.

Mother Released on Wii U Virtual Console

June 14, 2015

Categories: Business

Hours ago, Nintendo released the 1989 Japanese title *Mother* to the Wii U Virtual Console as *Earthbound: Beginnings*, localized in English for the first time ever. Until now, the only exposure to the *Mother* series English audiences have had was 1995's North American release of the critically acclaimed *Mother 2*, released as *Earthbound*.

The Virtual Console was the biggest selling point for the Wii for me, and it continues to be for the Wii U. My latest Wii U purchases include *Super Metroid*, *Donkey Kong 64*, and *Paper Mario*. The release of *Earthbound: Beginnings* is certainly interesting and a direct message to the hardcore/loyalist/older audience.

Paired with *Super Smash Bros.* and accidental Amiibo announcements, as well as the reboot of the Nintendo World Championship, Nintendo seems to be drawing a lot of eyes as E3 nears.

[_EDIT_: After browsing the Nintendo eShop, it appears Wii games are not considered Virtual Console titles. I've removed _Metroid Prime Trilogy_ and _Super Mario Galaxy 2_ from my list of recent Virtual Console purchases. That doesn't change the fact that my most recent purchases have been legacy titles. Thanks to @AlexandreSitbon for encouraging my research.]

Niche

July 12, 2015

Categories: Business, Design

Seattle Post-Intelligencer:

> ***Q**: Bill Gates said recently that he thinks Nintendo will be more of a niche player in the future, with Sony and Microsoft battling for the number one spot. What do you think of that characterization?*
>
> ***Iwata**: Talking about the definition of the niche, or niche market, I really have the completely opposite opinion. The people the other companies are targeting are very limited to those who are high-tech oriented, and core game players. They cannot expand beyond that population. We are trying to capture the widest possible audience all around the world. (He cited the example of Nintendogs, a new virtual pet game for the Nintendo DS handheld machine that has taken off in Japan.) In other words, we are trying to capture the people who are even beyond the gaming population. So for that kind of company, we don't think the term "niche" is appropriate.*

RIP Satoru Iwata.

Disneyland's 60th Nighttime Entertainment

July 28, 2015

Categories: Design, General

I remember Disneyland's 50th like it was yesterday. 50 Mickey's hidden throughout the park. Golden Ears that sold out within hours of park opening. But most of all, I remember the firework show, "Remember...". It took guests through memorable moments of each of the park's past and present rides. Moments that many of these guests had experienced firsthand, likely that same day. And to make "remembrance" of those firsthand accounts all the more immersive and visceral, fireworks and lasers enveloped the audience standing in and around Main Street's Central Plaza. It was awesome, breathtaking, and surprising. It was the part of the celebration that will stick with me forever.

The 60th's Paint the Night parade followed by the Disneyland Forever firework show will not. The parade, a bombastic cacophony, flirts with the idea that it is the next evolution of the original Main Street Electrical Parade, utilizing over 1.5 million LED lights. Unfortunately, whimsy and character are stripped from the show in the name of gigantic displays, unnecessary rear projected faces (made famous by Midway Mania's Mr. Potatohead), and a thudding and messy electronic/dub-step Owl City score. The *only* favorable takeaway I had was the brilliance of Mack's (Cars) 3D LED ball trailer.

In the vein of l Remember..., Disneyland Forever kicks off before the inception of Disneyland, in the orange grove before it, and mashes a seemingly unrelated Walt quote followed by seemingly unrelated Disney films from Mary Poppins to Winnie the Pooh to Jungle Book to Lion King to Frozen into a mish-mosh arch of past to current Disney hits. The show attempts to stretch the Main Street immersion created for Remember... by projecting an ever-shifting array of backdrops on *all* of Main Street's buildings. It's is a nice gesture to the folks standing in the trench, but it ends up becoming an unfulfilling distraction from the fireworks and story as it's truly difficult to make out the projections against the building details themselves. And then there was something about the fireworks being a goodnight kiss. No cohesion.

Not to sound like an old stickler, but back-in-my-day imagination was key. The closest equivalent I can pin this spectacle to is the Star Wars prequels and their over reliance on CG. Now it seems Disney has injected the over stimulation today's kids have with smartphones in strollers in Disneyland right into the park entertainment itself. It's a noisy, chaotic, and confused affair that leaves nothing left to the imagination but the wonder of how many plush toys from aging Disney franchises they can sell before the night's end. All I wanted to do after Remember... was ride every ride again by night's end.

King's Quest

August 3, 2015

Categories: Review

"Cheri...! How do you spell 'Sierra?'" a question I would often shout to my step-mother from an adjacent room. Their PC housed a game called *Quest for Glory*. Somewhere between my limited knowledge of MS-DOS and the English language, I would ask and re-ask this question, eventually running the prompt C:\sierra\glory.exe. To add to the naivety, I didn't learn how to intiate mouse control until my dad's friend (and *King's Quest* junkie) relayed the message to me. For years, I had been playing a point-and-click without, well, a mouse to point and click.

Nonetheless, today is different; though, not entirely far off. I've completed the first chapter of the *King's Quest* reboot on PS4 without a mouse. And boy, did it feel great.

At heart, I'm a *Quest for Glory* kid. In any case, my memory serves *King's Quest* far from simplistic and innocent, but dashed with bits of humor and challenge. That said, the personally and puzzles in the reboot feel more realized and extemely fitting.

Princess Bride notes ring hard and true, from a grandfather's storytelling to a cast including Wallace Shawn (and Christopher Lloyd, not to be left without mention!), but it's all a lovely addition and somewhat apt recalling of the memories of playing the (or those in spirit to the) original game. The humor and trials dance between easy no-brainer to truly challenging exercises of "wit." And while most of the game's writing and development is close to that of a better than average Disney film with clever storytelling devices strewn about, there is one surprising and appreciated moment that brings some weighty emotion; its effect ringing subtly through the remainder of the chapter.

The first of five chapters, A Knight to Remember, resolves with satisfaction. The art direction is gorgeous, animations fluid, and the writing is sure to land a few square chuckles with all age groups. The game comes off as a Disney movie that you play. Not to mention it took much longer than I had expected to complete. While I'm one for concise games these days, it felt appropriate that *King's Quest* had more to ofter than anticipated. This coming after viewing a score of 6.5 from one of my favorite game reviewers.

King's Quest is a worthy play and I am eagerly looking forward to the next chapter.

The News Never Stops

September 16, 2015

Categories: Media

The news never stops. Sometimes, this blog does. But only because the News never stops.

Lumino City on iOS

November 2, 2015

Categories: Art, Design



Developer State of Play:

> *Lumino City has been created in a unique way. Everything you see on screen was made using paper, cardboard and glue, culminating in the building of a 10 foot high model city. Laser cutting was used to create finely detailed environment, and miniature lights and motors were built in to bring it to life.*

This game is truly a work of art. Not to mention the captivating execution of story just moments in.

"Winner of numerous international awards including the BAFTA for Artistic Achievememt..." For some reason, regrettably, I held out on playing the Mac version. Happy to have this in my pocket. Looks stunning on iPhone 6s.

Lumino City is now available for iOS.

How Videogames Are Saving the Symphony Orchestra

November 2, 2015

Categories: Art, Business, Music

Sarah E. Needleman, The Wall Street Journal:

> *In Philadelphia, the 80-year-old Mann Center has held videogame concerts since 2012. Representatives say the shows attract as many as many as 6,500 attendees, roughly double the average attendance at classical concerts.*
>
> *The growing popularity has helped offset a decline in U.S. orchestra ticket sales. Over the past decade, such sales have declined at an average annual rate of 2.8%, according to a soon-to-be-published report commissioned by the League of American Orchestras, an advocacy group.*

While I had known of the popularity of these concerts with Video Games Live, whose album Kickstarters for Volumes 3 and 4 raised $285,081 and $187,646 respectively, et al., I had no idea of this level of success. Likewise, I was a bit surprised to see "The Legend of Zelda: Symphony of the Goddesses" perform on "The Late Show With Stephen Colbert", but a bit less so now.

The piece continues:

> *Unlike classical-music performances, videogame shows feature arrangements that blend looping tracks of music designed to match various moments in a game, such as a slow, eerie medley of piano, percussion and string as the videogame character navigates a castle dungeon.*

I think there's something here. Two years back, in a post titled 1985: Burst and Bloom, I wrote the following:

> *The sounds, visuals, and interactivity provided a pool of imagination. The limitations of early consoles could not provide orchestral arrangements. Instead, repetitious patterns were drilled into our heads. They not only encapsulated the game we were playing, but they opened the world outside to a new soundtrack, creating a wealth of memories that could be tapped into from a few simple chirps. Hearing these primitive arrangements evolve felt like experiencing the birth of music. As hardware progressed, so did the complexity if the music. Repetitive pieces turned into grand and iconic themes, each game re-shaping the idea and importance of video game music.*

Back to the WSJ piece, a quote from illustrator Mathew Grigsby:

> *I developed a taste for classical music through videogames.*

I echo this sentiment.

Warcraft and Toontown

November 6, 2015

Categories: Design

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2Rxoz13Bthc

News of a *Warcraft* movie with the involvement of Duncan Jones and Legendary Pictures has had me excited for years now. Unfortunately, this trailer does not.

I've eagerly awaited every Blizzard in-house cinematic since *Starcraft's* in 1998. (If I recall correctly, it shipped on the *Warcraft II: Beyond the Dark Portal* disc.) I don't believe Blizzard's in-house cinematic team had much to do with this film. And if true, that is a sad fact.

In the games, the orcs' robust physique is met with nearly as robust human physique. Blizzard's own in-house cinematics reflect this as well:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=akzF_rU1Fqg

Physique aside, the use of real actors against what appears to be a solely computer-generated backdrop and animated rivals is jarring. (See also the *Star Wars* prequel trilogy and *The Hobbit*) I thought we were working passed this. I thought the gag of cartoons working in Hollywood was in the process of being shuddered. Confused about how real actors would look in either the orc or human role, I figured they'd both be bolstered by CGI. I figured wrong. On the upside, the close-ups of the orcs look great.

I'm not a World of Warcraft player, but within an hour or so of the Warcraft Movie trailer premier, a cinematic trailer for *World of Warcraft: Legion*, the upcoming WoW expansion was released. This is the kind of visual consistency I was hoping for:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eYNCCu0y-Is

All I'm saying is the unbelievable visual inconsistency of animated characters and backdrops alongside real actors is tired. Give me real *or* fake. If both, let's stick to the *Who Framed Roger Rabbit* and *Space Jam* gags.

Warcraft Plot

November 6, 2015

Categories: Design

Wikipedia:

> *Azeroth stands on the brink of war as its civilisation, led by the humans, faces a fearsome race of invaders: orc warriors fleeing their dying world, Draenor, to find their place in another. As a portal opens to connect the two worlds, known as the Dark Portal, the humans face destruction while the orcs face extinction. Anduin Lothar (Travis Fimmel), leader of the humans, and Durotan (Toby Kebbell), leader of the orcs, are then sent on a collision course that will decide the fate of their family, their people and their home, in which war has many faces and everyone fights for something.*

Maybe the trailer wouldn't have been such a miss if they stuck to this description?

Regarding my last post, how come one of the female orcs (Garona? Draka?) doesn't get the GCI treatment? Seems to heighten the awkward balance between the animated and unanimated.


Warcraft movie, female character

Nerdist Interviews the Cast of Warcraft

November 7, 2015

Categories: Design

Nerdist nabbed an answer to a question in my previous post. It's Garona.

From WoWWiki:

> *Garona Halforcen is a half-orc half-draenei quest giver for the Horde in the Twilight Highlands. Like most others, she believed she was half-human until the truth was revealed to her. She is an assassin and a spymistress.*

From the Nerdist interview, it appears Garona is half-orc half-human, which, in the visual language of the Warcraft Movie, seems to justify her unanimated self. I don't think it works and still lends itself to an awkward visual balance.

Daniel Wu, playing the part of Gul'dan:

> *If they don't seem real, it's going to be hard as an audience to get into the character. But they are very real. And they are very compelling as CG characters. Like two minutes into the film, you forget that they're actually CG characters.*

They don't seem real. However, I said the same of *Avatar*. And after a few minutes into that film, I was onboard.

Polygon Skips Star Wars: Battlefront Review Event

November 13, 2015

Categories: Media

Polygon:

> *Review events are a reality of the industry, and in the case of multiplayer-oriented titles, they make sense — it's very difficult to organize 20-40 people in different locations remotely at the same time, and we introduced provisional reviews this year to account for server uncertainty. We've attended review events this year when it made sense to do so, including events for Call of Duty: Black Ops 3, Metal Gear Solid 5: The Phantom Pain and even Battlefield Hardline.*
>
> *But we will not participate in review events that tie our hands in ways that restrict us well after the general public has full access to the game in question. With that in mind, we'll be playing the full version of Star Wars Battlefront on EA Access this week, along with many of you, without support from EA. As we have not agreed to any advance access or accepted any coverage restrictions, our provisional review will be live once we are confident in the opinions of our pair of reviewers.*

The Room Three

November 14, 2015

Categories: Review


The Room Three, image 1

On occasion, usually during App Store visits, the question whether Fireproof Games had released the (by my standards) highly anticipated third entry of *The Room* series bubbles up. Admittedly and shamefully, I don't follow Pocket Gamer or Touch Arcade with any sort of regularity. (Changing that now.) To my surprise, I had come to find out about the release of *The Room Three* in Ben Kuchera's argument as a gamer for switching to iOS:

> *The release of The Room 3 finally broke me. Last night I went to my local AT&T store, suffered through the inevitable awful wait, and traded in my Galaxy Note 4 for an iPhone 6S Plus.*

Let this in-and-of-itself give credence to *The Room*. And not just the third entry, but the series as a whole.

The Room series stakes its claim on connected hyper-schewmorphic puzzles, set in a *Myst*-style photorealistic environment, all for the sake of solving a mystery. You crank gears, adjust mirrors, light fires, slide latches, and flick switches in an attempt to find out where the hell you are, how the hell you got there, what all of these cryptic symbols and anicent references mean, how deep the rabbit goes, and what pathological nut case is stringing you along. For a symbolic, deep-meaning, puzzle junkie such as myself, it's perfect.

In the first entry, the player was tasked with getting to the center of a box. Said box rests in "the room". To open the box, you must solve the puzzles *of* the box. The more the player digs, the tricker puzzles become; the deeper the mystery gets.

The Room Two expands beyond the box, donning the player with a special eyepiece to see hidden messages scattered about. This sequel also expands movement, allowing the player to scour rooms for clues and secrets. It dabbles deeper into the classical elements (earth, wind, water, fire) to find The Null.


The Room Three, image 2

The Room Three takes movement and depth one step further with the addition of areas (levels) to explore and a new lens addition for your eyepiece; one that allows the player to dive deep into the miniature mechanics of the machines seen about. To use a mechanism for one puzzle, you must solve the puzzle within the mechanism.

I found there to be a bit of repetition with the puzzles, not to mention some overly obvious and seemingly pointless tasks. (Yes, I will slide that thing to the left because I have no other option to do anything else.) But that's the charm of *The Room*. It always has been. Sticking a key in a whole won't do anything unless you turn the key, right?

The mysticism and cryptic nature of *The Room Three* felt a bit lackluster. Not many otherworldly references or hair-raising messages. (Granted, it's been two years since I've spent time with *The Room Two*. Maybe this was the case there as well.) It felt hallow. Not necessarily that the dark charm and

personality had been altogether lost, but maybe that the developer was too fatigued with adding puzzles to a world so large that depth took a backseat to time.

Which brings me to the awe inspiring essence of *The Room* series. Regardless of the charm falling flat or the occasional overt obviousness, the mind-bending machines and realism Fireproof Games continues to dream up is inspiring to the point that it's excruciating. There is dazzle and surprise around every corner; astonishing cleaverness in every puzzle; perfectionism in art direction and machanics.

Predictably, *The Room Three* was a delight to solve. Truly a treasure through to the end. Though sadly, it was the end that finally kicked the cleverness up to my desired notch. I continue to think on what mad scientists and otherworldly designers continue to craft such detailed experiences.

"Science isn't always a great substitute for fun."

November 17, 2015

Categories: Design, Fun

Justin McElroy, in a short and sweet dual-review with Dave Tach at Polygon:

> *For example: New weapons and items unlock at what feels like a glacially slow pace, but that forced me to focus on becoming competent with the items I had on hand and genuinely improving. Compare that to Call of Duty, where I tend to flit between the shiny objects I seem to unlock after every round and never really live with one long enough to become deadly. For a casual fan like myself, that's a big plus.*
>
> *Admittedly, that slow pace (along with the lack of weapon customization) left me without the compulsive burning desire to play "just one more game" only to see what new trinket was right around the corner. It's an impulse that games like Call of Duty and Destiny have down to a science, but science isn't always a great substitute for fun.*
>
> *I want to play more Battlefront because it's just that: It's fun.*

I vividly recall spending hours with the original *Star Wars: Battlefront* for PS2. An hours more with *Star Wars: Battlefront II*. They were unlike any shooter I had ever played. And surprisingly for a licensed game, they were fun.

Back to the piece. Dave Tach:

> *With the notable exception of Boba Fett (and even he has a bizarre and unwieldy control scheme), I have much more fun as an anonymous Rebel or Stormtrooper. Their modes are much more interesting than the movie hero power trip.*

I recall feeling initially jarred when diving into the original. I had come in with the expectation that I'd be questing as one of the franchises heroes, and it turned out to be my first experience of the Star Wars universe outside of the perspective of said heroes. I quickly became fond running missions in anonymity. I had an avatar in the Star Wars universe with no preconceived story arc. In turn, anonymity only amplified my desire to continue playing.

I've been looking forward to the *Star Wars: Battlefront* reboot for a long while now.

Wii U on Target's T-Day Top Three

November 27, 2015

Categories: Business

Business Insider (via My Nintendo News):

> *Target had its biggest online shopping day ever on Thanksgiving.*
>
> *"Demand outpaced 2014's record Thanksgiving performance, making it Target's biggest day for online sales yet," the retailer said in a release.*
>
> *The record-breaking sales online were driven by three items: the Apple iPad, Apple Watch, and Wii U gaming console, the company said.*

Kobe to Retire

November 29, 2015

Categories: Sports

The New York Times:

> *Kobe Bryant of the Los Angeles Lakers has decided to retire after this season.*
>
> *The 37-year-old Bryant made the announcement in a post on The Players' Tribune on Sunday. The decision was not totally unexpected, given that Bryant has said many times in recent weeks that he was considering making his 20th NBA season his last.*
>
> *There's no more wondering now.*

A thank you and best of luck to Bryant. I've got a rookie card and autographed basketball somewhere.

At the time of this post, "Dear Basketball" is throwing a 503. Regardless, I'm utterly impressed by the pull the The Players' Tribune has managed.

Also, no link to the original post from NYT? Weird.

Sierra Sets Date for King's Quest, Chapter 2

December 1, 2015

Categories: General

Polygon:

> *King's Quest: Rubble Without a Cause, the second of five chapters in The Odd Gentlemen's King's Quest, will begin rolling out in two weeks, publisher Sierra announced today.*
>
> *The episode will be available Dec. 15 on PlayStation 3 and PlayStation 4 in North America. It will launch the following day on Windows PC, Xbox 360 and Xbox 360, and in the rest of the world on PS3 and PS4.*
>
> *...*
>
> *The Odd Gentlemen is also changing up the way King's Quest plays from chapter to chapter. Korba told Polygon that while A Knight to Remember was based on the open puzzle-solving structure of the first two King's Quest games, Rubble Without a Cause is "more inspired by [King's Quest 3: To Heir is Human]. It's a bit darker and centers on an escape mechanic." The Odd Gentlemen also added the ability to skip dialogue.*

Interesting to hear that the gameplay style will change between episodes. The continued homages to the original titles are a nice touch.

Porting Primer

December 6, 2015

Categories: Design

Bridging the Generation Gap: Porting Games to New Platforms by Tom Bennet of Polygon.

From remasters to down-ports to cross-platform development, this is a brilliant introduction to the world of video game porting. Audio version read by Dave Tach via Polygon Longform podcast.

Separate from porting, I am ever intrigued by the following:

> *Commentators have also levelled criticism at the arguably destructive nature of certain re-releases. These titles exist on a spectrum; to use film as an example, there is an obvious difference between Criterion's restoration work and LucasFilm's treatment of the Star Wars films.*
>
> *Cifaldi argues that true remasters — distinct from remakes or reinterpretations — respect the original artistic intent. "If we're talking about The Last of Us Remastered, we're talking about 3D assets," says Cifaldi. "You're actually going to the original source elements and presenting them in an even cleaner way than before. And I would argue that that is a totally valid approach for that kind of game; it is the equivalent of putting [Star Trek:] The Next Generation on Blu-ray." [Edit: This paragraph originally omitted the Star Trek reference from Cifaldi's quote.]*

Is there any legitimacy in stating 2D animation is more evergreen than 3D? Are 8 and 16-bit sprites poorer quality 2D animations, or are do they stand in a class all their own? Are there any instances of 3D animation that stand the test of time?

I can look at Mario's first primitive 8-bit version without any cringing. Mario's 64-bit likeness on the other hand is rough on the eyes. In the world of cinema, there is no batting an eye to any classic hand-drawn animation. But even with today's advances CG characters and worlds thread a fine-line between believable and terrible.

I guess what I'm trying to ask is is 2D definitive?

Star Wars: The Force Awakens

December 18, 2015

Categories: Review

SPOILERS!

I'm being torn apart. Did I like it? Yes. Did I love it? No. Did it live up to the hype? Maybe. My pros/cons list weighs heavily on the dark side, but the experience steers the franchise toward the light.

The film opens with a fleet of stormtroopers storming a village. In one particular instance, as one goes down, another, FN-2187 (quite obviously Finn for anyone who's seen the trailers), without firing a shot, has a sudden change of heart about being part of a war-machine. Is this his first fight? Was the death of that particular comrade important? The audience would be better served if we understood the bond between Finn and the downed stormtrooper, or if there was some understanding that this was FN-2187's first fight.

Not to mention that Finn's introduction is mixed with a barrage of other main characters Poe, BB-8, Kylo Ren, and Captain Phasma within the first ten minutes. This all felt like a lot to digest.

It's not until Rey's introduction where the film begins to establish its language and context. The pace slows, allowing the audience to grasp the stakes through osmosis rather than force-feeding. Though, it's not hard to feel enchanted when Rey is on-screen. Daisy Ridley is the star of the show and only becomes larger when backed by "Rey's Theme"; John Williams's breathtaking score for our new hero. (Fear not. BB-8 is a marvel!)

On the topic of characters, I never got on-board with Finn. He feels more like a Star Wars uber-fan living out his fantasies than true-blue Star Wars lore. But maybe that's because Finn is the only character that doesn't *really* have a Star Wars legacy identity. Rey acts as a brilliant blend of Han and young Obi-Wan while Poe waxes a bit "pilot" Luke. If anything, Finn's overly comedic performance rings closer to Jar-Jar than any other legacy character. That's not to discount everything John Boyega brings to the table, namely his performance in the Takodana bar and his lightsaber battle against Kylo Ren. But in large part, I began to dread his appearance on-screen. I would have gladly traded the abundance of Finn for the lack of Leia's most talented pilot, Poe.

If there was one thing *The Force Awakens* is not short on, it's dog-fights. Battles overall, for that matter. However, while dog-fights are a boon for a Star Wars fan, not one of these takes place in space! What's a Star Wars movie without a war amongst the stars?! (This may not be the fairest gripe, but it's an observance worth bringing up.) In any case, ground combat felt fantastic, with practical explosions and the bodies of stormtroopers flying about; CG effects seemingly only used for blaster fire.

And while I loved the idea of J.J. making a point to bring back a heavy use of practical-effects, they began to feel heavy handed at times. Jakku's village felt like it paid great homage while Takodana's bar felt exhaustive. Other instances of aliens and droids painted some scenes well. But in large part, it all felt a bit too much. Excessive b-role and cuts to random characters feel strewn about just for fan service and proof that they were committed to the idea of practical-effects. (I wonder if my fretting is just jarring reaction to the modern reliance of CG…?)

As heavy-handed as the practical-effects were, the allure they have been brought on to create is thrown out when two major characters appear as CG constructs. Like Finn's out-of-place character, these characters took me out of the world that J.J. had constructed and put me back into the tried-and-tired trope of major CG reliance.

On the flip side, the lack of large scale CG set pieces and battlegrounds made this epic feel eerily small. Each scene feels like a specific set piece rather than a fleshed-out world. (There are similar scenes in *The Hobbit* films and *Indiana Jones and the Kingdom of the Crystal Skull*.) Suffice to say, most of the sets (and some of the acting and scene transitions) made the movie feel like a stage-play.

For all of the negative I can bring up about *The Force Awakens*, I cannot help but think about the good, the warm, and the fresh. This is why I'm torn. (Okay, add Kylo Ren's struggle to the list. It was extremely human and relatable on multiple levels.)

Good: It's a Star Wars film that feels like an Abrams film. While the characters, design, and story feel fairly true to the Star Wars universe, the film feels far removed from the language Lucas established with the original trilogy and certainly the prequels. So much so that I still feel like I'm having to check my opinion against what I've come to know and expect of Star Wars films, even the great ones. (Am I bothered simply because what I expect of this universe feels alien? Is that bad? Am I guarding myself from another *Phantom Menace* folly?) This is a good thing. "Enhancements" aside, we will always have the original trilogy and it's refreshing to see a new take on this universe.

Warm: There are call-backs and nods. A lot of them. Maybe too many of them. But every single one feels like a treat that I apparently can't get sick of. (They felt more natural the second time around.) Say what you will of *The Hobbit* films, it was nice to see the cast back together. The same feeling is exuded in *The Force Awakens*. Even more so. Some of the references feel forced, but that is too be expected. I imagine the audiences experiencing the Star Wars saga (well, episodes IV-VII) straight through or for the first time won't be as phased by the obvious.

Fresh: The final scene. Our reunion with Luke opens the story in ways that *The Empire Strikes Back* had no other option but to fill in after the fact. Never has there been a Star Wars film where the future was so foreign to the audience but so presumably mapped by writers. (The script for Episode VIII was finished before the release of Episode VII. Unprecedented for a non-prequel *Star Wars* film.) We know bigger things are coming and I'd argue that Episode VII simply exists to whet our appetites. That's not to say it's a cliffhanger, but through Luke, the mysteries and color of today's *Star Wars* universe are on the cusp of being revealed.

[EDIT]: *Added paragraph about set pieces and stage-plays.*

1/1/16: *Edited and revised after second viewing.*

Blind Gamer Beats Ocarina of Time

January 4, 2016

Categories: Accessibility, Design

Rich McCormick, The Verge:

> *His final video, uploaded on January 2nd, shows him using the same method to defeat Ganon, the game's pig-faced final boss. Particularly important in Garrett's playthrough was the use of the hookshot — a Zelda mainstay that fires a retractable chain — as a form of echolocation. When Garrett fired it against a wall, he'd hear a telltale clang; if he fired it into thin air, it would reach the end of its tether before returning to his hand, spooling backwards with a different noise.*

Utterly fascinating. Congratulations, Terry!

Intel, Vox Media, Re/code and the Born This Way Foundation Launch #HackHarassment

January 7, 2016

Categories: Culture, Health, Media

Kara Swisher, re/code:

> *The first knee-jerk reaction of those who think completely free speech is the paramount rule of the Internet is simple: Stop whining, you stupid girl, and take it, because everyone should be able to say exactly what they want, however they want and in whatever way they want to say it.*
>
> *It's a canard of an argument, designed to turn a complex issue into a reductive black-and-white debate where no one can come to any agreement.*
>
> *Still, it's always set up this way when anyone attempts to make the more obvious point that free speech is not as free as all that in the real world, where there are numerous social repercussions for behaving in a rude, obscene and appalling manner.*
>
> *Simple example: If you loudly tell a woman she deserves to be raped for speaking her mind on any subject in the public square, at a party or at work, there's a pretty good chance you'll get ejected from there and, at the very least, you'll be subject to much-deserved derision and censure.*
>
> *Not so on the Internet, where such talk is all too common and much too tolerated. Which is why Intel, Vox Media, Re/code and the Born This Way Foundation are coming together to co-create Hack Harassment (#hackharassment), a new, collaborative initiative to fight online harassment and provide safer, more inclusive online experiences.*

Have I Stopped Loving Video Games?

January 17, 2016

Categories: Culture


Final Fantasy X, to Zanarkand

This past Christmas, I received an Xbox One. Months prior, I had joked that I wanted the console just to set it up, but probably never play it. (I get immense satisfaction out of setting up new electronics or updating existing ones.) Like every joke, there is a bit of truth to it. Who am I kidding? It wasn't a joke at all.

The fact is, I rarely play video games anymore. When I can't, when I'm at work, on a long drive, or otherwise, I yearn for hours with *Super Mario 64*. I look forward to tackling my pile of shame. But when I'm at home with a few hours to kill, instead of playing the games I do own, I'll scour gaming sites and digital storefronts looking for something new, occasionally squandering $40-60 on a game, playing it for an hour or so and then never touching it again. (*Super Smash Bros. Wii U*, *Assassin's Creed: Syndicate*) I'll even shell out for bite sized experiences, play for a few minutes, then never open the app again. (*Brothers*, *Lumino City*)

While mulling over the notion that video games may not be for me anymore, I was struck by John Gruber in conversation with Dan Fromer on his own *The Talk Show* podcast:

> *It never occurs to me to play video games. If I time travelled back and talked to my 10, 11, 12-year-old self, I think that'd I'd have lots of good news to tell you on John Gruber. I think he'd be very happy abut his future. But I think of all the things he'd be most surprised by is that I would tell him, 'you're going to grow up and have the financial ability and the flexibility in your daily schedule to own and play any video game you want, for as long as you want, practically speaking. And you're not going to.'*
>
> *I think that my 12-year-old self would instantly suspect that whoever this guy is who does kind of look like me and was well cast to play the person who's going to prank me and tell me that it's me when I'm 42, is obviously full of shit, because there's no chance that if I could spend four or five hours every night playing cool video games, I wouldn't be doing it.*

Times change. Do people?

As soon as I begin playing a video game, I'm struck by a massive wave of guilt. I'm not accomplishing anything. I very, very rarely feel deeply moved or impacted by the game. Come to think of it, my first and only play through of *Journey* (2012) may be the last meaningful experience I had with a game. Maybe the massive sea of gorgeous and groundbreaking video game releases sparks a deep desire to remain up to speed with the zeitgeist; now have the financial means to play any video game I want, I can finally hack it in schoolyard conversations about the latest and great console.

Or maybe it's that I don't play with other people; that the best part of video games is sharing the experience with a group of people, be it competing with others, watching other people play, or playing in front of an audience. Like books, TV, and film, maybe there is something inherently communal about video games, even single-player campaigns. I spend plenty of time reading Polygon.com, listening to gaming podcasts and soundtracks, and watching trailers and gaming related gag videos on YouTube. Maybe this auxiliary input is a misguided attempt at connecting with a community of

people that can relate to the emotional ties of certain games or the awe of those games that push the medium thus technology thus society forward.

If it's community, surely tweeting and blogging about video games would suffice for output, right? Wrong. Face-to-face personal interaction is what I'm missing. The experience and excitement of a group of people in it together. And if that's true, the idea of engaging over an ethernet connection and microphone do not appeal to me — to be completely honest, the idea of my wife listening to a one-sided conversation while I play *Destiny* sounds humiliating. (Those who do enjoy online multiplayer games, please forgive my ignorance.) And if blogging about video games doesn't satisfy childhood dreams of becoming a video journalist, maybe *Zero Counts* is a waste of time. (It's not. I can't quit you! But why, if I find it hard to play?)

Maybe it's that I've recently taken to books. Last year, I read more books in a single year than ever before. Same the year before that. While I'm learning to enjoy reading, I'm learning more about the types of books I enjoy reading. More so, I'm in a pursuit to not only identify the types of books I enjoy, but a pursuit to find myself somewhere in the wealth of words out there. From presidential biographies to Pulitzer Prize fiction to Steve Martin's Born Standing Up, I'm sure something somewhere in these books will clear a little bit of this messy path called life. I've had a few instances of feeling truly satisfied in my career and hobbies, but that satisfaction wears off. Instead of beginning my search for what's next when the road of satisfaction ends, spiraling into a hurricane of desperation, it's likely a better use of my time to find and plan my next move.

While finding myself is certainly one of, if not *the* most important priority, another priority is having fun and experiencing new things.

Tor Bair, "Your Life Is Tetris. Stop Playing It Like Chess":

> *However, life does get faster. Every day we live is a smaller percentage of our total life, and we perceive time as moving more quickly. Our responsibilities grow until tasks we should sincerely enjoy are treated as annoyances or mindless distractions.*

I fell in love with video games because they seemed to open up new worlds, experiences, and fanatical and practical ideas. The fictional universe in *Final Fantasy X* inspired artistic benders while the innovative arch of *Star Fox 64* or nemesis system of *Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor* inspired me to rethink my own real world systems. I used to ready myself for computer science classes with 30 minutes of *Picoss DS*. 3D puzzlers like *Myst* and *The Room* series continue to push me to reevaluate perceived limits.

So, like books, maybe I just need to find and hone-in on the types of games I love. Maybe I need to be okay with limiting my catalog; that while there may be earth-shattering experiences in games and books I wouldn't normally play, life is too short and expensive to take chances on something I may not enjoy. But that seems like a crappy way to live.

I've been playing with the idea of starting a column called "Demo Mode" on Zero Counts. Simply put, Demo Mode pieces would be game reviews of free demos. (*Demo Mode: Destiny* is nearly in the can.) in large part, demos are enough to experience the bulk of what I want to know about a game: the story's foundation, visuals, and mechanics. Understanding these three bits help me feel informed amongst a community I grew up wanting to find my place in.

So maybe time is changing me. Maybe I just get more satisfaction out of marriage, family, work, and books. But in the end, my desire to want to love and play video games does not rest. Nor should it. I love tweeting and writing about games. I love reading Ben Kuchera's opinions. I love learning about the inside of the industry from Relay FM's wonderful new podcast *Remaster*. I love Dave Tach's daily updates on Minimap and Polygon's Longform editorial about the crevasse of video games that often slip past our periphery.

But if I'm being completely honest with myself, I'm just chasing the high of booting up *FFX* on PS2 for the first time.

Demo Mode: Rise of the Tomb Raider

January 18, 2016

Categories: Review



In the shadow of Naughty Dog's *Uncharted* series, I'm not entirely sure it's fair to say Square Enix's 2013 *Tomb Raider* reboot set a bar, but it certainly showed that Square Enix has the chops to add a fair contender to the photorealistic action-adventure genre. To say it another way, if it weren't for the lack of wit, I wouldn't have been surprised if Nathan Drake made a cameo. That is a compliment.

Uncharted similarities aside, I imagine *Tomb Raider* was a welcome reboot of the franchise. Missing a chance with the original *Tomb Raider* series, 2013's *Tomb Raider* was my first-ever jaunt with Lara Croft, and it certainly had me yearning for adventures with her. The mechanics felt nice. There were enough collectibles to make its linear nature feel a bit more open. And it was certainly gorgeous.

However, having never played the original *Tomb Raider* series from the late-90s, I was unfamiliar with the concept of raiding tombs. Thinking back on my play-through, the reboot had very little to do with it's namesake. Many *Tomb Raider* reviews called out the lack of the core aspect of the franchise. In any case, my enjoyment with the reboot left me unquestioning of the game's title.

Square Enix's sequel/prequel (the trial doesn't paint a fair picture of the timeline) *Rise of the Tomb Raider* appears to have a greater focus on tomb raiding. Various reviews have highlighted that this new focus paired with an open-world nature make for a compelling follow-up and something that is varied enough from the first.

During the *Rise of the Tomb Raider* trial, I did not have an opportunity to experience either of these aspects. It opens with the player scaling an icy and crumbing mountainside — an *Uncharted 2* opening train-scene equivalent — to a lost city and a tomb within. The visuals are stunning and, like the first, the mechanics feel polished. (This coming off of *Assassin's Creed: Syndicate* which feel clunky to a franchise novice. A story for another post.) After entering the ruins of the lost city, the player is treated with a fairly simple puzzle of rising water and platforming. Unchallenging, but it gives the impression that this type of puzzling will be core to the remainder of the game.

The hour-long trial is ripe with cinematics: the opening, a few during the mountain climb, a flashback highlighting Lara's father, and the ending. I'd hope that the remainder of the game strays away from the heavy-handed cinematics and quicktime events, opting to focus more on puzzling within tombs. The trial ends in a rushed cinematic with an unnamed baddie, a "shootout" with two henchmen, and a race out of the tomb before it comes crashing down.

Without relying too heavily on reviews elsewhere, the trial of *Rise of the Tomb Raider* feels like more of the same, albeit a bit prettier than the first title in the franchise.

Lightning and Louis Vuitton

January 22, 2016

Categories: Art, Business, Culture


Final Fantasy XIII Lightning, Louis Vuitton

Teddy Dief, developer of Hyper Light Drifter and Kyoto Wild, writing for Polygon:

> *Square Enix — a major international video game company — thinks that the Louis Vuitton-wearing chic folk of the world might sometimes come home from their fancy parties and boot up their PlayStation 4 or Xbox One. Or you know what? Their Wii U. The fashion in Splatoon is so fresh that it's inspiring a massive fan zine.*
>
> *I mean, I'm excited because this is further evidence that the world outside video game enthusiast culture is acknowledging that:*
>
> - *Games are for adults too!*
> - *Game players have fashion sense!*
> - *There are a lot of women playing games!*
> - *Fashionistas might be super into turn-based combat!*
>
> *The stereotypes of old are toppling left and right! It's a delicious massacre.*
>
> *[...]*
>
> *Imagine what could happen!*
>
> - *"Diesel to release a line of Bayonetta-inspired pants"*
> - *"Nintendo reveals Ralph Lauren outfit DLC for Super Smash Bros."*
> - *"Lululemon teams up with Hyper Light Drifter for a new line of athletic wear"*

The three Final Fantasy games centered around Lightning each take an average of 37.5 hours to beat. If these Louis Vuitton designs were to become available in-game, that's an unprecedented amout of product placement screen time.

Gaming likely to be big part of Obama's $4B computer science initiative

February 5, 2016

Categories: Education

Polygon:

> *Game designers know how to create engaging, fun and compelling experiences, he said. They also know how to design an experience that strikes the balance between being hard enough to push a person to learn, but not so hard that it discourages them. Finally, he said, games are great at stealth assessment.*
>
> *"When you hit level 60 in World of Warcraft, you don't then take a paper and pencil test; getting to that point is an indication that you're good at the game," Kalil said.*
>
> *Applied to education, those design tenets can be used to create adaptive learning customized to the needs of individual students.*
>
> *"You're always going to need great teachers, but I think there are a number of ways video games can contribute," he said. "Not only will they help with getting more students involved, it will ensure strong interest."*

Disneyvania

February 8, 2016

Categories: Design

The release and my playthrough of *The Witness* happened to coincide with a ramp-up in my video game podcast consumption. (Maybe not so much a coincidence than a subconscious attempt to glean a hints from podcasters.) Through this, I came across a couple of keen observations of the game's design that I had not considered:

Idle Thumbs, ep 248, 14:55:

> ***Jake Rodkin****: It uses so many rules of Disneyland-esque design and video game level design to make it easy to navigate, but it's not built assuming there's that huge framework of video game messaging beneath it.*
>
> ***Chris Remo****: That Disneyland thing is a good comparison. Video game designers have often—for good reason—and accurately pointed to Disneyland as a really useful design touchstone. Not for the experience of the rides themselves, but for the design of the actual park.*
>
> ***JR****: Disneyland is the closest we have in real life to a constructed open-world level.*
>
> ***CR****: Areas are connected where there's an intuitive sense of structure, but when you're in any given place, it feels like it's entirely enveloping you.*
>
> ***JR****: Until you come around a corner and then the foliage and architecture perfectly frames on a sightline – spire that is in a waypoint to a different land of the park.*
>
> ***CR****: And The Witness is totally like that.*

I completely agree. The *Idle Thumbs* crew may also have unraveled a core reason why I loved *Myst* so much. And quite possibly why I love Disneyland so much.

Jared Petty on *IGN's Game Scoop!, ep 376, 3:27*:

> *This is a secret Metroidvania game. In a Metroid game, you get to an area. You can't get far. You go off to a different area. You find a power-up. (In this case, the power-ups are not items you find in the game. It's the knowledge that you gain through working out a different set of puzzles.) You get frustrated. You go off to a different area. You learn something. You come back. Boom! You get through.*
>
> *Sometimes you can "bomb-jump" your way around it by figuring out something by being clever that you got a little ahead of. Or a little more doggedness or experimentation. It's a neat game.*

A very neat game.

Firewatch: A Review

February 20, 2016

Categories: Review



It goes without saying *Firewatch* is an aesthetic marvel. Just look look at the gameplay screenshot above. Better yet, head to firewatchgame.com and get your fill. But it's what lies within the exterior beauty that *Firewatch* shines.

Without taking the *Up*-like blow out of the first act, the game finds protagonist Henry having taken a job as a fire lookout in Shoshone National Forest, Wyoming. Henry communicates with Delilah, a veteran lookout in another watchtower, via radio through choice-driven narrative queues (à la *The Walking Dead*, *Choose Your Own Adventure*). Shortly after the opening, the two find themselves tangled up in a self-provoked mystery.

Throughout my play-through, I became so concerned for Henry's safety that my own certainty about the wilderness and its role as a haven for the unknown and unexplainable began to fulfill itself. However, it's at the mercy of a few cheap tricks that this unsettlement is allowed to creep in. One early trick creates the suspicion that something bigger is going on and you're the only one not in on the secret. Another instills the fear of looking down or turning a corner; two actions that become impossible to avoid and occur at breakneck frequency throughout the entirety of the game. Campo Santo makes it impossible not to feel anxious.

The answer to the game's mystery will be unsatisfying, but only because this is the wrong puzzle. I'd argue the real answer is to *why* the game's mystery is unsatisfying. Therein lies the revelation. Ultimately,_ Firewatch_ shows that one's own ego and neurosis can overshadow important details; that our narcissism and persistence to seek the puppet-masters blur what is right in front of us. Without doubt, an interesting mystery unfolds for Henry and Delilah; but it's an exposé in egoism that lies at the heart of *Firewatch*.

The Witness: A (Cheater's) Review

March 11, 2016

Categories: Review



It started by "stumbling" across discussions about the game, convincing myself that I was listening to the *Idle Thumbs* podcast because I felt that it warrants my attention (true); not because *The Witness* was mentioned during a particular episode (false). Or because I hadn't listened to *IGN's Game Scoop* in months, missing a show that hooked me on video game related podcasts (true); not because *The Witness* was mentioned in a particular episode's show notes (false).

Like many growing up in the late '80s, early '90s, I was a fan of *Myst*. The game took the adult world by storm and after my father and step-father both began discussing its puzzles with me, I felt I had something to offer these grown humans. I spent large swaths of time on a mysterious island, solving puzzles and eventually pouring over a strategy guide; a "book" I later convinced my 2nd grade teacher would serve well for a book report.

And boy, do I love *The Witness*. To a point.

> *You know, the thing about Braid: I loved it, I loved the atmosphere, I loved the visions, the softness of it. It kind of felt like a piece of silk you could run your hands through. It was a lovely, lovely game. But here's the thing that didn't work for me: It got so tough that my need and want to experience more of its world was absolutely challenged by my feeling that I wasn't clever enough. I kept going back to find out more about the world, feeling more and more stupid. After a while, I thought, This game is dumb. Now I think I was wrong, by the way.*
>
> *— Peter Molyneux, in an interview with Tom Bissell, Extra Lives*

I'm sure I underestimate myself by thinking I would have never completed the game without a guide. The game thrives on the notion of beating the player down only to let them realize they could find the solution all along. There were plenty of times when I pondered giving up, only to persevere and surprise myself the following day. But after 215 puzzles and frustrating "Tetris" logic, enough was enough.

After weeks of setting the game aside for *Firewatch*, Tom Bissell's "Extra Lives", and *Veep*, the allure and curiosity of *The Witness* wore off. I was no longer itching to out-do myself. I just needed to know what the *The Witness* would amount to. Was the experience worth it?

Many reviewers point to discovery and breakthrough as the reward. That once the player is spoiled with hints, the spell is broken. While those moments of besting oneself are certainly empowering, I found cheating my way through the second-half to be enjoyable as well.

I was able to appreciate the full genius behind the game. Had I spent 20-100 hours attempting to slog through the insanely brilliant puzzles for weeks, months or years, there was still no certainty I'd finish the game. By cheating my way through *The Witness*, I was able to see and appreciate all of the ludacris and awe-inspiring puzzles throughout.

> *I don't want to invest in a game that I'm going to put 200 hours in because I'm never going to put 200 or 100 or 50 or 20 hours into a game. I'm just not going to do it. But something like this, which is substantial to me, it's longer than a movie but it doesn't become a lifestyle either.*
>
> *— Jason Snell on Firewatch, The Incomparable podcast, episode 290*

It's very hard for me to spend 20 hours let alone 200 on a single game, as clearly evidenced by my quick drop off from games like *Skyrim* and *Grand Theft Auto IV*. Sure, I'm attempting to play through the entire *Final Fantasy* series, but it's a repetitive mobile effort that I dip into for 20 minutes at a time. (You're not missing much of a story in the first *Final Fantasy* to warrant consecutive hours of play.)

Lastly, experiencing *The Witness*'s devilish penultimate puzzle — two randomly generated, timed mazes of mixed logic intended to thwart cheaters — was a welcome surprise. As I closed in on the end of the walkthough, I was stopped dead in my tracks by a puzzle that could not be documented or shared. I was forced to figure this one out on my own. It certainly wasn't the most difficult puzzle in the game, but it's a puzzle that could only be appreciated (and likely solved) by someone who had learned enough to stretch their rusty two-week-old *Witness* muscles.

Oh, what a frustrating ordeal the penultimate puzzle must be for those who had decided to cheat their way though the entirety of the game; stopped short of victory at the 1-yard line. It would have been easy to overlook adding this trick, but is a **perfect** fit for a game that prides itself on using assumption to shoot-down the player's knowledge. (Hats off, Team Thekla!)

The penultimate puzzle alone leads me to believe that Jonathan Blow and his team wanted a community to blossom, sharing hints, tips, and solutions across the global community. Why else would there be only one randomly generated puzzle? It suddenly made me feel less guilty for succumbing to a walkthrough.

Do I feel cheating spoiled the game for me? Absolutely not. That said, I strongly advise pushing oneself to the brink of insanity, solve the puzzle that brought you there, then do it a few more times. Understand the language of the puzzles. Only then will it be rewarding to experience the building of The Mountain, the final tricks, the puzzles within puzzles, and the tightly woven secret of the island. Only then will the player truly understand the frustrating brilliance of *The Witness*'s final puzzle.

Blow and the Thekla team put together an experience that will be talked about for years to come. And they took a very high risk placing the final puzzle where they had. The spiraling essence of zooming out to see the whole connected thought is a lovely thing. So much so that the idea that *The Witness* has players seeing puzzles in the real-world is completely legitimized.

Sure, all of this could have been said from a player who finished the game without cheating, and likely with greater appreciation and satisfaction. But I know I ended up a whole lot less frustrated yet still deeply satisfied.

Pokémon GOTY

July 13, 2016

Categories: Culture, History, Media


Pokémon Go on iPhone, Pokémon Blue on 3DS

The year is 1998. I'm standing in Toys"R"Us, holding a slip of paper that reads "Pokémon: Blue Version - $29.95".

"Are you sure this is the game you want?" my father asks.

Confidentially, I respond, "Yes."

Now 30-years-old and in the media business, I'm watching headline after headline roll in:

- Times Reporter Descends Into Pokémania — The New York Times
- What is really behind the Pokémon Go craze — The Washington Post
- When you're a kid, Pokémon Go is a portal to a magical world — The Verge
- Pokémon Go is everything that is wrong with late capitalism — Vox
- Thanks To Pokémon Go, I Walked More In 2 Days Than I Do In A Normal Week — SELF
- Pokemon GO gets people out and about, and that's a good thing — Australian Science
- How Shelters Are Using Pokémon Go to Help Homeless Animals — POPSUGAR
- This Pokémon Go naming scheme is our greatest achievement as a species — Polygon

It seems every outlet is writing about the phenomenon that is *Pokémon GO*; seemingly the second coming of the franchise in North America. And for someone who grew up poring over GamePro and EGM, there is a small bit of vindication every time a major publication like the Times or the Post covers video games in a positive light.

The game has "almost certainly exceeded 65 million American users", Nintendo's share price has risen 53%, and all of my feeds (TV included) have been taken over by this game. Over and over, I read stories of the diverse communities engaging in *Pokémon GO* **together**. People everywhere partaking in arguably the world's largest Easter egg hunt **together**. They are discovering destinations and landmarks in their hometowns via PokéStops and Gyms **together**.

The biggest shock of all came when our lawyer informed me that she'd caught a Bulbasaur over the weekend.

Caught a Bulbasaur.

Caught!

For someone who grew up with the original Pokémon Red and Blue versions, the dawn of the franchise, that sentence shouldn't exist.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vXZ7guchLCQ

This whole thing is looney, nuts, insane even. This is a game rooted in green, red, and blue plastic Game Boy cartridges and 11 MB black and white (green) software from the late-90s. But for a child of the late-80s / early-90s, it's all surreal, strange, and beautiful to watch.

The *franchise* is once again re-shaping ideas about gaming and technology. The *game* itself is re-shaping ideas about community and education. *Pokémon GO* joins other experience, culture, and zeitgeist defining titles such as *Pong*, *Super Mario Bros.*, *Tamagotchi*, *Golden Eye*, *World of Warcraft*, and *Minecraft*. For that, I deem *Pokémon GO* "Game of the Year".

And yes, it's July.

Uncharted 4: A Thief's End

July 30, 2016

Categories: Review


Uncharted 4, Nathan Drake looking

What does it take to be moved— deeply and profoundly moved? Stories of grandeur can impress ideas of excellence and glory. Stories of adventure can make us yearn for thill and mystery. Stories of family can reflect the importance of closeness and bonding.

Real life events certainly have the power to move. Novels tackled this ages ago. Music has transformed the world around us for eons. Film figured it out approximately 100 years ago. And within the past 20 years, video games have begun tugging at heartstrings, imbuing wonder, and leaving players in awe.

Uncharted 4: A Thief's End, the latest and possibly last chapter of suave treasure-hunting protagonist Nathan Drake's adventures, is certainly not the first video game to entertain the idea that some titles in the medium are closer to film than they are to chess. There have been countless titles that have made the case that the narrative in today's video games outshines most summer blockbusters — *BioShock* (2007), *Final Fantasy VII* (1997), *The Last of Us* (2013), and *Mass Effect* (2007-2012) to name a few. As early as 1995, in an abrupt turn of events, players watched the heroic and noble Mega Man turn against Asimov's first law during the finale of *Mega Man 7*, holding his Mega Buster up to a surrendering Dr. Wily, exclaiming, "I am more than a robot!! Die Wily!!" While not the most striking piece of dialog, it was a profound moment for a video game at the time.


Mega Man 7, Mega Man vs. Dr. Wily

The Uncharted franchise's namesake is in big action during gameplay. Gigantic and tightly choreographed sequences unfold while the player is still in control. To this day, it's something that feels inconceivable to players who grew up with *Super Mario Bros*. Over the course of four games within the franchise, developer Naughty Dog doubled-down on the technically awe-inspiring moments with each title; be it scaling train cars that are dangling off the side of a mountain (*Uncharted 2*) or fist-fighting in a battered and rapidly descending cargo plane (*Uncharted 3*). Story beats and character development didn't quite take a backseat, but they were never quite at the forefront of the games. By the third entry, Naughty Dog pushed the predefined story boundaries, but was never able to outshine the action.

After *Uncharted 3*, Naughty Dog stepped away from the franchise, putting it's effort into a brand new story. *The Last of Us* delivered what is arguably the most affecting story from a AAA title yet. A survival story of two individuals, the grizzled Joel, who's young daughter was killed during confused military frenzy amongst a virus-outbreak, and Ellie, a young girl with the only known immunity to the virus. Over the course of the game, the two strangers argue, protect, bond, and fight together, building a relationship unseen in video games prior.

The lessons learned by Naughty Dog and the development of *The Last of Us* are clear as day in *Uncharted 4*. Never has the Uncharted franchise felt so human and connecting. While *Uncharted 3* swung for the fences, it never quite delivered. But with every turn of a corner, every new setting, every chapter, Uncharted 4's story beats like a racing heart. Be it the relationship between Nathan and his brother Sam, Nathan and his wife Elena, Sam and veteran treasure hunter and father-figure Sully, or

even the tales of Captain Avery and the lost pirate city Libertalia being explored through the game. Every one of these stories delivers and ultimately delivers a whole greater than its parts.

Nathan's struggle between leaving a life of adventure and exploration for a life of normalcy and marriage is remarkably easy to connect with. The unknown and freedom of one's past challenged by stability and relationships is something most struggle with. To add, the power of reigniting a relationship with a plundering brother once thought dead adds a significant amount of weight to Nathan's difficult decisions and ultimately mistakes. Uncharted 4 offers a surprisingly complicated web of relationships that keep the player hungry to find out what happens next. And unlike most lengthy video games, there is a beautiful simplicity to the story that is easy to come back to weeks after setting the controller down.

But what of a video game's story if the atmosphere isn't correct. Surely the benefit of experience a story in the medium of a video game must include visuals and music and mechanics. Suffice to say the visuals are outstanding, possibly the best a console has produced to date.


Uncharted 4, Drake and Sully looking out over vista

Buying into the world of *Uncharted 4* takes little effort at all. Its outstanding graphical fidelity, animation, and motion-capture performance deliver convincing characters and settings. Nathan Drake is as real as any Hollywood hero. And shockingly more convincing as a fully CG character than the real actors strewn about the Warcraft movie.


Warcraft Movie, Lothar with Orcs

Not to digress into a critique of the *Warcraft* film, but it's worth mentioning that *Uncharted 4*'s visuals and performance are a great example of the power of strong narrative without the presence of flesh-and-bone. To put it succinctly, the game is captivating.

(While we're on the topic and to give credit where credit is due, the photorealistic Orcs backed by stellar performances. Like *Avatar* before it, there are moments that are dumbfounding when one realizes what is unfolding onscreen is fake. Just look at Orgrim!)


Warcraft Movie, Orgrim

It's not to say that the life given to Nathan Drake by the folks at Naughty Dogs and the performance from Nolan North weren't incredible in past entries, but there is something truly magically about how Nathan emotes and interacts in *Uncharted 4* that makes him believable.

Like the story, the mechanics and fluidity of the game have slowly evolved with each iteration. While the first Uncharted title felt much like a demo of things to come, the level of polish given to the player's controls during extraordinarily big moments feels just as amazing as it did in *Uncharted 2*. That said, the overuse of sliding down gravelly paths and using Nate's new grappling hook felted a bit tired halfway through the game. The repetition of these interactions has a tendency to make story feel slower than it should at time and almost like the player hasn't progressed much. Slow motion via repetition. There are even moments when Nathan pokes fun at having to slide or grapple again and again.

But if the mechanics are the worst part, and they certainly are not even mildly bad, what of the music? The three previous entries found composer Greg Edmonson at the helm, defining *Uncharted*'s iconic and booming theme. Edmonson's work gave a lift to the sense of adventure and thrill. But like the

story, the time Naughty Dog took away from the franchise seemed to open the possibility for new talent and new perspectives. And for a story so strong and rife with conflict, the timbre had to change.

In comes Henry Jackman, composer most recognized by his work on Captain Americas *The Winter Soldier* and *Civil War*, *X-Men: First Class*, and Disney's *Wreck-It Ralph* and *Big Hero 6*. The breadth of Jackman's work shines in *Uncharted 4*, adding dark and somber themes to an otherwise epic adventure, namely the heartbreaking "A Normal Life" theme that is sprinkled throughout interactions between Nathan and Elena, displayed most effectively during Chapter 17: For Better or Worse. It's enough to bring you to your knees.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z-iYdAaRQ4o

There isn't enough that can be said about the impact of the Uncharted franchise. It reimagined what it means to interactive with a digital experience. It's captivating performances and writing gave life to characters typically seen as avatars. The franchise is a masterclass in the possibilities and power of video games. Most of all, it showed the importance of not rest on your laurels and how care and patience can evolve greatness into something truly special. If this really is the end of the Uncharted franchise, I'm sad to see it go. But better to burn out than to fade away. And what better to burn out on a note that genuinely moves technology, narrative, and players.

Thanks for one hell of a ride, Nate and the Naughty Dog team.

The Big Picture by Sean Carroll

August 2, 2016

Categories: Review

God, you little devil.



Sean Carroll's *The Big Picture: On the Origins of Life, Meaning, and the Universe Itself* is a primer for the state of science today. But at the heart of book lies a core belief and explanation for poetic naturalism. Just what is poetic naturalism? Here's Carroll in an interview with WIRED's Eric Niiler:

> *Atheism is a reaction against theism. It is purely a rejection of an idea. It's not a positive substantive idea about how the world is. Naturalism is a counterpart to theism. Theism says there's the physical world and god. Naturalism says there's only the natural world. There are no spirits, no deities, or anything else. Poetic naturalism emphasizes that there are many ways of talking about the natural world. The fact that the underlying laws of physics are deterministic and impersonal does not mean that at the human level we can't talk about ideas about reasons and goals and purposes and free will. So poetic naturalism is one way of reconciling what we are sure about the world at an intuitive level. A world that has children. Reconciling that with all the wonderful counterintuitive things about modern science.*

For a layman, Carroll breaks down today's fundamentals of science to painstaking detail (outside of the use of equations) and builds them back up to something simpler that speak to the justification for poetic naturalism. He dives into physics, philosophy, quantum mechanics, biology, and many other fields. He tackles many questions that are asked from casual daydreamers and the depths of Sci-Fi alike. And it all comes wrapped in an idea that there lies something between atheism and theism.

Carroll strives to pit Science against Theism on an even playing field, or one that's as level as possible; Modern science challenging the ever shrinking God of the gaps. But for all of Carroll's scientific professing, he is careful never to discount just how vast the gaps remain. By sheer virtue of his lessons on Bayesian credences, he never shuts out theism entirely, always leaving the door unlocked and possibly cracked open.

> *We'll see that the existence of life provides, at best, a small boost to the probability that theism is true—while related features of the universe provide an extremely large boost for naturalism.*

Chapters and sections read like deep troughs with a steep decline. As soon as the reader is introduced to a concept, Carroll has them barreling down a chasm at breakneck speed, only to bring them up for air in the last few paragraphs. I understood hardly a lick of the depths, but that's okay. The meat lies in the simplified 30-percent of the pages. I took the rest as hard scientific justification, in the event the reader has any doubts as where Carroll comes up with these notions.

After 433 pages, Core Theory and quantum mechanics and multiverses and up quarks and down quarks are still a mystery to me. But what I did learn — what I can say without a shadow of a doubt — is with as much as we've discovered of the Universe, we still know very little. Maybe that will always

be the case. Maybe there will always exist the God of the gaps with those gaps shrinking exponentially, but never quite stamped out.

Nintendo 64 and Avoiding 'Sequelitis'

October 2, 2016

Categories: Design, History

Sam Machkoveh, Ars Technica:

> *Perhaps most notably, this was the last console on which Nintendo could rehash its older characters and series without fielding non-stop complaints about "sequelitis." The console's best first-party games were mostly sequels—Super Mario 64, Ocarina of Time, Mario Kart 64, Star Fox 64, F-Zero X, even Wave Race 64 and _Excitebike 64_—and yet all of them felt incredibly new thanks to their steps up to fully 3D engines. Nintendo had been a purely 2D game-making company for nearly a decade, yet it somehow pulled off the transition to 3D gaming in pretty much every way that Sega flubbed its own total overhaul.*

Yours truly, in a November 2014 post titled *Iterative vs. Redesigned Experiences*:

> *If the doomsayers are correct and Nintendo's failure is eminent, redesigns are going to be required to prevent it. So far, the majority of first-party titles on Wii U are iterative: Mario Kart 8, Super Smash Bros. Wii U, Super Mario 3D World, Pikmin 3, Donkey Kong: Tropical Freeze. While not every redesign has worked in Nintendo's favor (I'm looking at you, Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker is genius; while it's not a new take on a old classic (because there is no old classic!), it's a new perspective from the Mushroom Kingdom. Until then, it's back to smashing and karting.*

Pokémon Go was the most recent example of a redesigned rather than iterative experience. Real-world Pokémon is an experience many fans have yearned for since the days of Red and Blue (or Green). Nintendo's decision to make Niantic, Inc.'s *Ingress* a venue for real-world Pokémon was not only brilliant, but for a company that's built their namesake on changing our perspectives, hidden-in-plain-sight.

With surprise experiences like *Pokémon Go* and Nintendo's further foray into the new terrian of smartphone hardware, we are sure to see at least a handful of redesigned experiences on mobile. With the NX, my hopes are not so high. But if anyone can reimagine the console experience, it's Nintendo.

Nintendo Switch and Parents

October 20, 2016

Categories: Children, Design, Parenting

Parents surrender their phones and tablets to their children. E.g. child clamours for device—iPhone, iPad, or otherwise—the parent surrenders said device to child. Child commences gaming and/or YouTube.

This is anecdotal, of course. My wife and I have no children. But we've seen this time and time again with friends and family.

And if it's not the guardian's own device, it's a separate device dedicated to gaming and/or YouTube for the child.

From the POV of a parent, wouldn't it be nice to keep your device on your own person?

From the POV of a child, wouldn't it be nice to have your own device dedicated for gaming/YouTube without the other unnecessary calendar/email/messages/etc apps?

Enter the Nintendo Switch. A dedicated seemingly state-of-the-art-ish portable/home console multiplayer-ready uncompromised gaming device, surely ready for YouTube when on wifi (an optional data plan would be even better), by the greatest game designers on the planet, Nintendo.

https://youtu.be/f5uik5fgIaI

While **none** of the talent in the trailer appear to be under the age of 20—even donning *red cups* at a rooftop party!—the Switch could be a game changer for the household.

Of course, it will come down to Nintendo's ability to attract third-party devs—a feat they have struggled with since the Nintendo 64. And not just any third-party titles, but titles outside of Nintendo's own legacy: education, infants, toddlers, etc. Lock down the third-parties with simple development and distribution, and (price willing) the Switch will be a boon for parents and children alike.

Children: here's a device for the things you care about.

Parents: take your devices back.

WSJ: Banning Tablets Is Best for Children

October 24, 2016

Categories: Children, Parenting

Christopher Mims, The Wall Street Journal:

> *Friday, the American Academy of Pediatrics validated my experiment, recommending that children younger than 18 months get zero screen time, and those ages 2 to 5 be limited to one hour a day—half of its prior recommendation. The group recommended that the hour be "high quality programming" that parents watch with their children.*

Later in the piece, Paul Bettner, co-creator of Words With Friends and founder of Playful Corp:

> *"I've seen from my own life and my children that there's great social interaction, great hand-eye coordination stuff, lots of storytelling and getting involved in the narrative, a lot of learning and skill building when children play videogames alone or together," says Mr. Bettner. He limits his children to two to three hours a day, and encourages them to play videogames rather than watch shows.*

In my post Nintendo Switch and Parents, I wanted specify that while the Switch might be a boon to both parents and children, by no means should a device be used as a replacement for babysitting nor physical modes of play.

I think the title of this Mims's piece is misleading. That said, I like Bettner's philosophy.

Ben Thompson: "What Nintendo is doubling down on is controllers"

October 28, 2016

Categories: Design

Ben Thompson, in his latest weekly free Stratechery piece, "Surface Studio, Nintendo Switch, and Niche Strategies":

> *What Nintendo is doubling down on is controllers, another smart move. I argued in 2014 that controllers are so important to the user experience of consoles that they will hold off general purpose devices like Apple TVs when it comes to living room gaming; Nintendo's bet is that they can attract gamers who want mobility by offering high fidelity control that smartphones can not.*

First and foremost, you should subscribe to Ben's Daily Update. $10 per month gets you *the* best business/technology analysis out there.

Second, Ben's observation is something I should have realized and mentioned in my "Nintendo Switch and Parents" piece. As a reminder, I wrote the following, emphasis just now added:

> *Enter the Nintendo Switch. A dedicated seemingly state-of-the-art-ish portable/home console multiplayer-ready uncompromised gaming device, surely ready for YouTube when on wifi (an optional data plan would be even better), by the greatest game designers on the planet, Nintendo.*

By uncompromised, I was eluding to those features we consider critical to console gaming: power, fidelity, and breadth. One item that skipped my thought was physical controllers. Because physical controllers have been a staple of console gaming since the beginning, it was easy to overlook. But the importance of Nintendo doubling-down on physical controllers for the Switch, seemingly ignoring touchscreen capabilities based on the Switch trailer (however, patents may reveal otherwise), cements the vision, nay dream of portable console-level gaming.

Comfortable

November 12, 2016

Categories: Politics

Comfortable is something I am not right now. I am not comfortable with a Donald Trump presidency. I am not comfortable with America's image to other countries. I am not comfortable with explaining to American children how this happened. I am not comfortable for women, the LGBTQ community, and people of color. I am not comfortable with any of this.

Uncomfortable is certainly the least of the emotions I am feeling now; far behind terrified, horrified, stupified, scared, shaken, gutted, disappointed, sad, guilty. But for a white Californian male, discomfort is resounding. I weep for the groups across the nation who feel geniuine terror at their core.

If there is one thing that has been magnified for me it's that I was too comfortable under the Obama presidency. I was so comfortable with President Barack Obama at the helm that I stopped paying attention to Washington and the American People. It's a shameful statement for someone who works on the periphery of the news industry and who has dreams of becoming a writer and, possibly, journalist.

At the start of the campaign season, I felt "fired up." This was a vow to myself to pay attention. To watch the campaign closely. As it tumbled along, I felt comfortable with Clinton's campaign, tactics, and temperament. That comfort grew by the fact that she was going up against Trump. How could anyone in their right mind vote for a politically untested, inexperienced, misogynist businessman who avoided paying taxes and was running on a campaign of xenophobia? Clinton had this in the bag! Once again, I became too comfortable and took my eye off of the details of the campaigns, the polls, and the People.

Being uncomfortable for the first time in a long time is a wake up call. If that's coming from someone in the most comfortable of blue states, that certainly says a lot about the discomfort in America now. Hell, it might say more about the discomfort in America before now.

I grew up in what can be described as a left-leaning purple county (+7.3% Dem) and city (+10.6% Dem). I remember a someone saying that our town was as close to the Bay Area that Republican candidates felt they could successfully campaign. 53% of my county voted for Clinton; 42% for Trump.

My hometown was a potpourri of football players and farmers, punk rockers and commuters. I had a glimpse of blue sentiment in parts of town and cities to the west, and familial relationships in heartedly red counties to the south. I was never spoken to about politics or beliefs at home.

That would change when I discovered punk rock and a class called AP Government. A fire was sparked and propelled me to obtain my bachelors degree in political science. But I stopped there. Graduating in 2009 under an Obama presidency, the comfort kicked in and the fire went out.

A troublesome, odd campaign cycle and a trip to D.C. in October 2016 were enough to stoke the fire again, but it felt too late. I felt to uninformed in what the Obama administration had and had not done, secretary Clinton's record (good or bad), and the state of rural America to hold educated conversation with others about the need to cast a Clinton vote. Beyond my given enthusiasm for a female leader and her common-sense views of equality in this great nation, my message became, "vote

for her because you shouldn't vote for him." It wasn't enough for her, it wasn't enough for my arguments, and it wasn't enough for the People.

I don't know what the next step is. It's safe to say that many of us don't. That is what is so uncomfortable about this election. Did Trump simply play a base of America? Is this for ego? What does it mean that he's flipped between a registered Republician then Independence Party then Democratic then Republician then nothing then Replublician parties? Does a "successful business man" not have the temperament for this job? Did he really see something we all didn't? Is *he* really smart enough to find loopholes and dodge taxes? Can we trust him on Twitter? Can 140 characters warrant a trade war with China? Can 140 characters spark nuclear warfare? He certainly doesn't want to go down as a failed president by committing to the promises made to his base, but he won't want to be called a liar by them either, right? What does he actually stand for? How will he govern? Isn't human decency the threshold for the job? How the hell did this happen? What happens next?

I am trying to not let fear get the best of me. Trying to quell many of these thoughts by rationale. But not knowing what this man stands for or trusting any of his actions is deeply uncomfortable.

I'm unsure of my next actions. I'm letting this sink in. I'm going for long jogs, focusing on work, and cascading into stiff drinks, hoping I'll come out with some form of clarity and action. Until then, my wife and I have chosen to donate monthly to the ACLU and Planned Parenthood and are actively looking to other organizations, liberties, and efforts that may have the steepest of uphill battles ahead of them.

I do not blame president Obama or secretary Clinton. I blame myself for being comfortable in my own privledged bubble. Now, I am comfortable that my discomfort will propel me to be better informed, studious, and vocal.

Some podcast episodes that have helped console my discomfort:

The One You Feed - Post Election Mini-Episode

Slate's Political Gabfest - The “Even Longer National Nightmare” Edition

Vox's The Weeds - Trumpocalypse Now

The Talk Show With John Gruber - Holiday Party

Rogue One: The Sound of a Story

January 3, 2017

Categories: Film, Music

Michael Giacchino (*Lost*, *Star Trek*, *Up*) is the first Star Wars film composer to step foot in John Williams' shadow.

Giacchino in an interview with Anthony Breznican, Entertainment Weekly:

> ***Entertainment Weekly: So you were a late addition to the _Rogue One _crew…***
>
> ***Michael Giacchino:*** *Yes, literally the last thing I expected I'd be doing this month would be this. I mean we were literally planning a vacation when I got the call asking if I could come and talk to them about it. At the time, it left me with literally four and a half weeks to write. So it was one of those decisions where you're like, okay, well… And I was talking to my brother about it. He goes, "Oh, come on. You've been writing this score since you were 10! You can do this."*

Giacchino, the long time J.J. Abrams collaborator, had replaced Alexandre Desplat (*Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows*, *The Grand Budapest Hotel*).

> ***EW: What inspirations will we hear in the music?***
>
> *MG: It does borrow from traditions that both John [Williams] and George Lucas borrowed from when they made the original Star Wars, you know. George was looking at Flash Gordon, the old serials, and John was looking at [Gustav] Holst and different composers along the way to get a baseline for what he wanted to communicate. There is a wonderful musical language that John put together for the original films. I wanted to honor that vernacular but still do something new with it, something that was still me in a way.*

My great friend Scott Kawai often makes the case that Michael Giacchino is the next John Williams, with a style heavy of colorful and memorable themes. Without reading too much about *Rogue One*, I assumed he had been the first choice for the film. The revelation that Desplat was the first choice was a shock to me. Desplat's music is certainly incredible with an air of moody atmosphere, but does not strike me as "Star Wars". I'd kill to hear his take on *Rogue One*.

There are inclinings of the saga's legacy in Giacchino's score— curious woodwinds and dancing percussion at the opening of "He's Here For Us"— but there is a drive in the timber that strikes less fantastic and more brooding. It is immediately clear that the "stories" have room for exploration and departure from the "saga". There are ties back to the episodic series, but at their core, Giacchino's pieces are something new and derivative; they are always less memorable, iconic, or sure of themselves. Nonetheless, there are many times when the presence of brass brightens and lifts what is ultimately a grittier film to something more familiar and nostalgic— something more reminiscent of Star Wars.

As for the touches of William's throughout Giacchino's score, The Force Theme is heard when Bail Organa enters the frame. Likewise, The Imperial March is heard during Darth Vader's appearance. During the film's finale, both themes are heard as two iconic characters make stunning (re-)appearances, which can be heard in "Hope" on the film's soundtrack.

However, the one that struck me the most was the piece backing *Rogue One*'s title card, the finale of "A Long Ride Ahead" on the soundtrack. Briefly teasing Williams' Main Title sequence, it kicks off the iconic C-G half-notes but branches into something new and less confident.

> ***Kathleen Kennedy says they're trying to break from some of the traditional Star Wars tropes, like doing away with the opening crawl. Sounds like that applies to the music as well?***
>
> *Kathy said that to me, too — "No one is asking you to do what was done before." I feel it's important to be me, but in this universe, we're working within. That was sort of the challenge. It was never sort of, "Oh, you have to do this, this, and this." It was always just: "Here are the emotions that we need to cover."*

As a story outside of the saga, Giacchino's freedom is extremely evident, for better or worse. My question is whether or not Giacchino's score will be the audible language of all Star Wars stories to come, or just specifically *Rogue One*? Even more specifically, is *Rogue One*'s title card sequence strictly *Rogue One*'s title theme, or has Giacchino defined the theme for all Star Wars stories?

The other changes—the omission of the opening crawl, lower-left location queues, a lone title card—are so heavy-handed that it leads me to assume the themes Giacchino has established for *Rogue One* will permeate future Star Wars stories.

Edwards: 'The wipes are the cheesiest thing in the world'

January 4, 2017

Categories: Film

Regarding differences between Star Wars story and saga films, I failed to notice the omission of the iconic Star Wars 'wipe' in *Rogue One*.

Rogue One director Gareth Edwards, in an interview with Empire:

> *4. The famous 'wipes' do exist in other cuts*
>
> *We did have versions of the film [with] wipes, and then it just felt like we were doing it because we could. The wipes are the cheesiest thing in the world. The only time you can ever do it and not be cheesy's in Star Wars. There's part of me that wanted the wipes and things like that, but the film is supposed to be different. We were given a license by the studio to be unique from the others, and we just took that license and ran with it as an excuse to try and be a bit more out there.*

While I won't disagree with Edwards, I think "cheesy" is the wrong word. Whimsical, perhaps?

Inside: A Review via 'Death by Video Game'

January 6, 2017

Categories: Art, Media, Review

Simon Parkin, *Death by Video Game*:

> *Games achieve chronoslip because they replace the real world with a new one that moves to its own laws of physics and time. This reality engages us totally, and we synchronise with its tempo.*
>
> *Video games, from the simplest card game to the most vividly rendered fantasy world, consume our attention. When we become lost in a book, we enter a state where the fabricated world and its characters seem to real and pressing that we lose all sense of time. Small wonder it's so easy to lose oneself in a good game, where one becomes not only an eavesdropper or onlooker on a world, but also an active participant in its action and drama. Video games go further than other fiction: they revolve around us and react to our every choice and input. Just as a piano needs a pianist or a violin needs a violinist, video games are lifeless without us. They need a player in a way that a film does not need a view to function.*


Death by Video Game

Simon Parkin's book, *Death by Video Game*, categorizes 12 different facets of video games that, for better or worse, make the medium addicting. Reading it, I felt vindicated. I wasn't alone in my reasons for play, and was enlightened about the reasons others gravitate toward the activity.

As an entertainment medium, video games offer escape, control, and story. As a technology, they push the bounds of simulated physics, animation, textures, and lighting. As a social platform, they foster community via global communication and participation — each of these facets evolving rapidly year over year. In my lifetime, I've gone from playing limited, albeit revolutionary, 8-bit single-player side-scrolling jaunts to open world massively multiplayer online role-playing games to photorealistic action-adventure juggernauts.

After finishing the read — a difficult one to put down, mind you — came a steadfast itch to pick up a controller. *No Man's Sky*, an exploration game with over 18 quintillion procedurally-generated explorable planets, which is briefly touched on in the book, had just been released. And *Inside*, Playdead's successor to their melancholy indie hit *Limbo*, was gathering incredibly high marks.

In the debate of open-ended vs short story, I will always choose short story. Therefore, *Inside*.


Inside

Players are thrust into a dark and wooded area as a boy being hunted by mysterious men in trucks; dogs seek you as their prey. Peak *X-Files*. Once you have escaped the wood, you happen upon a farm and cornfield. Deceased wildlife pepper the dreary, fog-laden landscape. And what's that worm-like thing sticking out of that pig?

You are eventually lead into the factory cum rabbit hole. The dark and cryptic mysteries you've experienced within the 10 minute introduction pale in comparison to what is "inside."

More than their incredible art style, subtle and gradual storytelling with layers of mysteries, answers, and more questions, and impeccable taste for atmosphere, developer Play Dead's fantastic switch-a-roo two-thirds into the game sticks with the player. A shock and horror convention is elegantly flipped on it's head leaving you, the player, scrambling to rework your preconceived notions about the story and characters. It's challenging, and in hindsight, speaks to the reaction and thought process of being wrong that so many feel today. Can we really be so sure about our truths? Are our beliefs simply sold to us by a manufactured narrative that elicits good as evil, god as grim, heaven as hell? How perceptive can we truly be? Is our mind a slave to the brain? Are we really in control?

It's difficult to discuss Inside without giving too much away; therefore, I will leave you with an appropriate quote from what turned out to be an appropriately timed and, ultimately, serendipitous read, the aforementioned *Death by Video Game*:

> *Moreover, video games flatter us: their worlds exist for our benefits, and usually, revolve around us. A video game requires a player: without input, it is inert. Our world, by contrast, seems indifferent to us. The cogs around us, both natural and human-made, turn regardless of our interest or input. It is sometimes difficult to know whether we matter, whether anyone cares. When a company loses our details or forgets about us for some reason, we talk of being 'lost in the system.' This is how loneliness is seeded in the human heart: a sense that the world and all of its people are indifferent, oblivious.*

Polygon's 2016 Games of the Year

January 8, 2017

Categories: Review

I'm proud to say that I played three of the 10 games chosen as Polygon's 2016 Games of the Year, my reviews of which you can find below:

- *Inside*: A Review via 'Death by Video Game'
- *Firewatch*: A Review
- *The Witness*: A (Cheater's) Review

I also played *Uncharted 4*, which I thought to have a profoundly moving story and absolutely stunning visuals. My review, which somehow finds room to discuss *Mega Man 7* and 2016's atrocious *Warcraft* film, can be found here.

Also of note, *Pokemon Go* took the world by storm, something unprecedented in video games since the Wii. It may have seemed ambitious to deem it Game of the Year in July, but I'll argue that due to its cultural impact, I wasn't wrong.

How the inventor of Mario designs a game

January 12, 2017

Categories: Design

The explainer people at Vox put together a nice distillation of Shigeru Miyamoto's design philosophy:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K-NBcPoYUQI

I imagine this interview was filmed during Miyamoto's monstrous press tour for *Super Mario Run*. Love the inclusion of beautiful animations and archival footage by Vox's team.

For more on the design of World 1-1, watch Dan Emmons' breakdown 'Level 1-1 - How Super Mario Mastered Level Design'.

For more about the business side of Nintendo, read 'Console Wars' by Blake J. Harris.

For more about his characters and *Super Mario Run*, watch/listen to Miyamoto's interview with Katie Linendoll at Apple SoHo.

Nintendo Switch Presentation 2017 Impressions

January 14, 2017

Categories: General, Technology

On Friday, January 13 at 1 PM Japan Standard Time, Nintendo unveiled new details about their Switch "home" console. While hard tech specs didn't make an appearance — I thought for sure Nvidia would have been showcased — deeper insight to the Joy-Con, play styles, and 2017 library were provided. Above all, what the keynote will be remembered for is an awkward Squid Researcher.

https://youtu.be/JsiRY521Nis?t=1774

Nintendo Switch will launch in "Japan, US, Canada, major European countries, Hong Kong, and other territories" on March 3rd. It will retail in Japan for ¥29,980, the US for $299.99, and varying prices in the European territories. Software will not be region locked, which is an incredibly big move for Nintendo.

Pre-orders for the Switch went up after the event and appear too have quickly depleted.

Presentation

As a whole, the presentation felt backwards and tonally awkward. Without building any hype, Nintendo opened with launch dates and pricing. The Joy-Con demonstration as well as the trailers for first-party titles *1-2-Switch* and *Arms* felt long-in-the-tooth. At least two of the presenters garnered "WTF" moments that also seemed to throw off one of the translators. And then there was Hisashi Nogami's *Splatoon 2* appearance as a "Squid Researcher".


Hisashi Nogami, Splatoon 2 reveal

Nintendo makes cute games and they've done cute things during presentations, but they've never struck me as outlandishly awkward. The *Splatoon 2* portion sapped the presentation of its professionalism, which feels odd to say as it's a game about squid children shooting paint at one another. At it's core, Switch is a toy. But it's audience doesn't treat it that way. Nintendo is a global company. It has been since the Wii, and certainly before that to its core, 30-somethings audience.

Even for the crazy toymaker, there has been something professional about their presentations, marketing, and — since the Wii — industrial design. The latter of which is present in the Switch. The system's design is as plain as ever and comes in stark contrast to a squirt-gun wielding executive taking the stage.

Switch

Note the quotes around "home" in my intro. Early in the presentation, Nintendo stated that the Switch is a "home" console:

> *7:45: "Nintendo Switch is a video game system for the home."*
>
> *8:14: "Nintendo Switch has been designed to be a home console gaming system that gives you the freedom to change your play style."*

Within 30 seconds, Nintendo hammered on the idea that Switch is built for the home. It felted pointed and explicit. It's an important point. The Switch is intended to be the dream: a home console you can take with you.

Modes of play include:

- TV Mode: "Typical video game style."
- Tabletop Mode: "Play video games in front of a screen with others, wherever you like, even away from the TV."
- Handheld Mode: "Take it with you and play indoors, outdoors, or anywhere you like."

On the point of battery life, Nintendo claims that the Switch will have two-and-a-half to six hours of battery life when in a portable mode. Studies show that 3 or more hours of gaming can being to have negative psychosocial effects.

The Switch will also offer 8-person local multiplayer in portable mode. Depending on adoption, this could be a killer feature. The capability alone screams that Nintendo is gunning for a new generation of portable gaming.

Last but not least, it was great to see Nintendo adopting USB-C. Color me shocked that Nintendo, the company that passed up HDMI on the 2006 Wii and was still using resistive touchscreens on the 2011 3DS and 2012 Wii U, would ship a device with the latest standard in USB technology.[1]

Joy-Con

These are impressive little gizmos with a funny name. From what I could count, they include:

- 7 gameplay inputs (buttons) on each controller
- Analog stick
- NFC (shown on right, but presumably both)
- Home button (right)
- Camera button (left)
- Accelerometer and gyro sensors
- "-" (left) and "+" (right) buttons
- Motion IR camera (right only)
- HD rumble

The HD Rumble demonstration claimed that the sensation of a glass with one, two, or three ice cubes rattling as well as the glass filling up with water could be felt in a single Joy-Con. The best I could figure was that HD rumble include three independent rumble motors, allowing for altered effects.

It's worth noting that when the Joy-Con are separated from the Switch itself, the right Joy-Con features a joystick in its center. I can't imagine this feels great. I guess I'll leave it up to a company that shipped a controller with an analog joystick in its center to make that call.

Games

We've known about *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* since 2013. And the October 2016 announcement of Nintendo Switch teased a new 3D Mario game. Two staples we, without a doubt, knew we were getting. Even *Skyrim* was a fairly sure certainty for the platform.

1-2-Switch

The equivalent of *Wii Sports* for Wii and and *Nintendo Land* for Wii U, *1-2-Switch* is Switch's tutorial game. It looks extremely awkward, but I'll blame that on the all to lengthy Mexican standoff demonstration. For better or worse, it was a solid reminder that Nintendo is a toy company.

Arms

Interestingly, Nintendo introduced a first-party fighter. But not just any fighter. In true Nintendo fashion, *Arms* is also a shooter of sorts. A fighter-shooter hybrid labeled as a "Fighting sports game." It looks like it might even be fun without motion controls. Like other Nintendo franchises before it, it appears to feature a cast of (possibly) memorable characters such as Spring Man and Ribbon Girl. Will *Arms* be the next Wii boxing or Splatoon? What do you think of the name?

Splatoon 2

While Wii Remotes (how did they not go with "Wiimotes"?!) were available for Wii U, Switch seems like a much more natural fit for *Splatoon*. As far as motion control shooters go, I loved the feel of *Metroid Prime 3* on Wii. It's also nice to see Nintendo doubling-down on this new franchise.

Super Mario Odyssey

Mario is out of the Mushroom Kingdom, and seeming into the real-world. At least for some portion of the game. *Super Mario Odyssey* is meant to evoke "the excitement when visiting unknown countries for the very first time." The visuals look incredible, relying heavily on shadows and environmental physics. This is in contrast to another visually impressive Mario game — *Super Mario Galaxy*, which used an opposite lighting effect on Mario, providing a white shine around his model. While the visuals and openness of *Super Mario Odyssey* look sunning, there is something discomforting about seeing the cartoonish Mario next to Sim-ish humanoids. I'm most looking forward to this game.

Xenoblade Chronicles 2

I've always wanted to dive into the *Xenoblade* series, and this might be the title that does it. The art design is imaginative and the scale looks impressive. The blue armor and prominence of a helmet on one of the characters kept screaming "Mega Man" and had me scraping credits in search of any possible crossover. The one thing I couldn't shake from this trailer was the scene of a character riding a lion-like creature. The frame-rate seemed very low and jittery. A similar jarring moment occurred during the *Xenoblade Chronicles* trailer in the Nintendo Direct 1.14.2015. (See my note mid-way down the page.)

Project Octopath Traveler

Boy, oh boy, does this game look great! Next-level *Paper Mario* meets Retro *Final Fantasy*? It's titles like this that make me excited for the portability of the Switch. Something about retro stylings screams "personal" and "portable" to me.

Skyrim

I've been itching for a portable version of *Skyrim* since I tried playing on Xbox 360. *Skyrim* is a game to get lost in; to spend hours with. But to spend hours taking over the TV in our house would be unconscionable. Needless to say, I never got more than three hours into this game on Xbox 360. I'm very much looking forward finally working through this game on my own portable screen.

Ultra Street Fighter II: The Final Challengers

There was a brief clip of a *Street Fighter* game during the final Switch video. Like others, I immediately thought we'd seen a glimpse of the Virtual Console on Switch. Alas, it appears to be a standalone version of *Ultra Street Fighter II: The Final Challengers*.

Mario Kart 8: Deluxe

I kept wondering if the glimpses of *Mario Kart* throughout the presentation were a new *Mario Kart* game. But they appeared too similar to *Mario Kart 8*.

Low and behold, Nintendo will be re-releasing *Mario Kart 8* for the Nintendo Switch as *Mario Kart 8: Deluxe* with some extra bells and whistles:

> - *Pop some balloons in the revamped Battle mode, complete with Balloon Battle and Bob-omb Blast.*
> - *Inkling Girl & Inkling Boy from Splatoon, King Boo, Dry Bones, and Bowser Jr. join the roster!*
> - *Players can choose a new Smart Steering feature which makes driving and staying on the track easy for novice players and kids even at 200cc*
> - *Returning items include Boo, the item stealing ghost, and the Feather, which gives you a high jump in battle mode.*

Mario Kart 8 is one of the greats. Some of my fondest video game memories are of playing that game. (Not to mention, my fondest Zero Counts moment!) I wholeheartedly agree with Stratechery's Ben Thompson:

https://twitter.com/benthompson/status/819777416222502913

Super Bomberman R

I don't have much to say about *Super Bomberman R*. I was never a huge fan of the Bomberman series. I do recall playing a ton of *Blaster Master Jr.* on Game Boy. I mainly wanted call out my nostalgia and affection for *Bomberman 64*.

The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild

Breath of the Wild is a Switch launch title. Nintendo presented this as huge news, but it comes off more as a confirmation to quell fan fears. Beyond that, not too many additional details were given. The new, extended trailer showed off the breadth of the open Hyrule as well as new and familiar characters. And while cartoony, the tone of the narrative seemed fairly adult.

My favorite part was the *Vanilla Sky* ending to the entire presentation. Open your eyes...

Bringing It Together

At the very beginning of the keynote, Shinya Takahashi gave a quick run-through of Nintendo's past consoles. It had a nice Apple-y touch, focusing on the innovation and lessons of the past to brought Nintendo to the Switch:

- Famicom (NES): Shipped with two controllers
- Game Boy: Pioneered portable video games as we know them today
- Super Famicom (SNES): Added X & Y and L & R shoulder buttons
- Nintendo 64: Introduced the first analog joystick and rumble (Rumble Pak) to a controller
- GameCube: Included a handle with the intention to be a home console could move from location to location
- Nintendo DS: Touchscreen portable gaming
- Wii: Brought motion controls to the mass market
- Wii U: Enabled console gaming off the TV

Without question, Switch is another unique and possibly industry changing device. Like Apple, Nintendo often skates to where the puck is headed, defining industry trends. And without question, the biggest dream of all is being able to take your home console on the go.

---

[1]I am so thrilled that USB-C seems to be taking off like it is. Within months of Apple going whole hog on their MacBook and MacBook Pro lines, I've purchased a Drobo 5C and ROLI Lightpad Block that are also equipped with USB-C. Now I'll be able to add Nintendo Switch to the mix.

Reggie Fils-Aimé: 'I don’t mind how you interact with our IP as long as you’re interacting with it every day'

January 15, 2017

Categories: General

Reggie Fils-Aimé, in an interview with TIME's Matt Peckham:

> ***TIME: Mr. Iwata once said of the Wii that he wanted it to be “something that you turn on right after turning on the TV.” Do you still think like that?***
>
> *Reggie Fils-Aimé: I would say that our thinking has evolved, in that we envision the consumer having a direct experience with our intellectual property (IP) as the core foundation of the company. Meaning, I want you to love what you’re doing with Zelda, with Animal Crossing, with Smash Bros. Nurturing that love for the IP is the overarching objective.*
>
> *How we will do that will now be executed in a variety of different ways. It’ll still be executed with a dedicated gaming system or systems. It’ll be executed through mobile. It’ll be executed through licensed merchandise. It’ll be executed in other ways, like what we are doing with Universal Studios. So it’s not so much changing the way you interact with your TV. It really is all about how you interact with our IP.*
>
> *And part of the reason why this has evolved is, you talk to a lot of millennials, and they don’t really have the same type of engagement with their TV that I grew up with. They’re interacting with other screens now, and they’re just as happy interacting with those other screens. And so that has caused us to really continue refining our proposition. In the end, I don’t mind how you interact with our IP as long as you’re interacting with it every day.*

Nintendo Switch's 'dedicated smart device app' to allow consumers 'to play those connected experiences... while they're on the go'

January 15, 2017

Categories: General

Nintendo.com:

> ***Online lobby and voice chat***
>
> *Our new dedicated smart device app will connect to Nintendo Switch and let you invite friends to play online, set play appointments, and chat with friends during online matches in compatible games—all from your smart device.*

Reggie Fils-Aimé offered WIRED's Chris Kohler soke additional color:

> *The reason for that is, it continues to reinforce our commitment to online, and do so in a way that will enable the consumer to enjoy their Nintendo Switch and to still be able to play those connected experiences—like Splatoon, like Kart, like fill in the blank—while they're on the go. Instead of having some sort of bulky gamer headset, you'll be able to do it right off your smartphone, put in your earbuds that you use for your standard mobile device. We think that's a pretty sweet solution. That's part of the overall opportunity that we see in a subscription service.*

This is another novel idea. Perhaps it unburdens the Switch by offloading online communications and interactions to the smartphone, possibly conserving battery life and performance. Moreover, it seems to suggest that the Switch can continue online interactions when away from Wi-Fi.

It might also make for a nice Switch + AirPods experience.

The Switch is a home console. The Switch is a "home" console. The Switch is a "home" console?

January 15, 2017

Categories: Design, General

Chaim Gartenberg reporting for The Verge:

> *Storage-wise, the Switch includes 32GB of onboard memory, which feels dramatically low in today's age of 500GB and 1TB Xbox Ones and PS4s, especially with the modern focus on downloadable titles. However, storage can be expanded through the use of microSD cards. Games for the Switch will come on physical GameCards, which may help alleviate the console's onboard storage space by offloading most of the storage requirements for each game to the individual GameCards.*
>
> *Lastly, the Switch can connect to the internet through an 802.11ac Wi-Fi connection, with the ability to connect to up to eight Switch consoles at once for local multiplayer. Additionally, the Switch will be able to connect using Ethernet using a USB LAN adaptor with the dock.*

I keep needing to remind myself that the Switch is a "home" console you can take with you. That *is* the dream.

But the fact that the dock does little outside of charging and video output, not to mention the need for a USB LAN adaptor for an Ethernet connection, begs the question, "can Nintendo keep up with this 'home' console marketing push?"

The Switch is a powerful tablet with novel input devices. Curious to see how many players use it while docked. Also curious to see if developers cater to battery life over fidelity and performance.

UPDATE: Nintendo's UK website now lists the Switch's technical specifications, confirming separate wired LAN adapter:

> ***Communication features***
>
> *Wireless LAN (IEEE 802.11 a/b/g/n/ac compliant) / Bluetooth 4.1 (TV mode only. A wired LAN connection is possible through the use of a commercially available wired LAN adapter.)*

Nintendo: Amusement Provider

January 18, 2017

Categories: Design, General

Takashi Mochizuki, The Wall Street Journal:

> *Rivals were pursuing high-end games with ever-greater technical sophistication. "We looked back at what Nintendo has done, and when you think about it, it's really been an amusement provider," Mr. Koizumi said. The Switch's concept of playing games anywhere with anyone was born.*
>
> *"When the concept was set, most of the Switch's basics came together quickly," he said. "Things like, you have to be able to take the controller outside, and you'll need two of them."*
>
> *The 48-year-old Mr. Koizumi, who has participated in making titles in popular Nintendo series such as "The Legend of Zelda" and Mario, said one of the first decisions was to attach the two controllers to the console, making a self-contained unit that can be taken anywhere for two-person play.*
>
> *"You could go out with a hand-held game device, but you can't play with others if they don't have the same device," he said. "We wanted to provide people with more options to play games."*

Mochizuki has done a nice job extracting a top-level perspective of the Switch from his interview with Yoshiaki Koizumi.

Between Fils-Aimé's comment about consuming Nintendo IP and Koizumi's amusement provider bit, Nintendo has circled the identity wagons.

'A Disney character in every home in America'

January 21, 2017

Categories: Gender

Keith Gluck, The Walt Disney Family Museum:

> *Then one day in 1932, Walt received a phone call from an affable fellow named Herman "Kay" Kamen, a Kansas City advertising man. He had a vision of putting a Disney character in every home in America. Intrigued by his energy, and already dissatisfied with his current deal, Walt invited Kamen out to California to hear his proposal. During the meeting, Walt and Roy quickly learned that not only did he have great ideas, but they were also all on the same page in terms of only allowing high quality merchandise to be stamped with the Disney name. On July 1, 1932, Kamen signed with Disney. The contract outlined a 50/50 split of the profits, a deal with which both sides were highly content.*
>
> *Kamen wasted little time realizing his vision. Soon Mickey and Minnie could be found in department stores everywhere, adorning such products as: napkins, wallpaper, books, phonographs, all types of clothing, hairbrushes, toys, and much more. Mickey products extended beyond the store shelves as well, thanks to annual, then biennial, merchandise catalogs published by Kamen.*

I thought Reggie Fils-Aimé's comment sounded familar.

FBI releases Gamergate investigation records

January 27, 2017

Categories: Culture, Media, Politics

Adi Robertson, The Verge:

> *The FBI appears to have made a serious investigation of some threats, but at least one email thread suggests there were breakdowns in communication with the subjects of them. "We feel like we are sending endless emails into the void with you," complained one sender. Based on the timing and location details, this was Wu, who published her own account of the experience on the same day. Overall, at least one report indicates that centralizing the investigation in San Francisco limited its jurisdiction. It's also not clear how familiar some of the FBI agents involved were with common internet services. Twitter is sometimes referred to as "Tweeter," and one email mentions suspects using "Thor" (probably Tor) for security.*
>
> *Via Twitter, Wu said that the threats the FBI discussed were only a fraction of the ones she sent them, and that the agency was largely unresponsive to her attempts to provide evidence. "All this report does for me is show how little the FBI cared about the investigation," she told The Verge. "As I remember, we had three meetings with the FBI, we had two meetings with Homeland Security, we had three meetings with federal prosecutors in Boston. Almost nothing we told them is in this report." She confirmed that the juvenile mentioned above had been making death threats using his father's phone; he was apparently grounded as punishment.*
>
> *This report was actually released as part of a Freedom of Information Act request last year, although at that point, it was difficult to verify whether the recipients had modified its contents. Since "Gamergate" was never really an organized movement, none of the people mentioned in the report are "members" of it, and some incidents predate the controversy, like a bomb threat against Anita Sarkeesian at the 2014 Game Developers Conference. But if anything, this emphasizes that Gamergate per se was one facet of a larger culture war — which it's now been almost completely absorbed into.*

I often wonder why it is I'm so fixated on video games and their culture. I initially started writing on the topic to help bridge what I felt was a chasm between "average joes" and "nerds". These were worlds I strattled growing up, often hiding my adoration for video games because I was afraid to be uncool.

Later, after seeing my little brother and cousins take to the medium, I sought to bridge a chasm between parents and video games. I focused my writing on the health and education impacts of video games.

Today, in the midst of American uncertainty and woe, I wonder if thinking about video games anymore than escapism is worthwhile. Certainly, there are bigger things. But then I recall Gamergate; what I see as the first emergence of the "alt-right". As Ezra Klein refered to it on his podcast episode with writer Ta-Nehisi Coates, it was another moment of the merging of partisan and ideological identities:

> ***Ezra Klein****: I thought Gamergate was one of the most interesting things to happen in the last couple of years.*
>
> ***Ta-Nehisi Coates****: Because that had to do with politics, right? Like, why is this happening?*
>
> ***EK****: Why did American political sites, Breitbart and Salon, develop an interest in an argument about whether video game sites were unduly influenced by some kind of personal relationship? When you say what happened out loud it sounds ridiculous.*
>
> ***TC****: It's hard to make it make sense.*
>
> ***EK****: My big Rosetta Stone in American politics for the last 20 or 30 years is partisan and ideological identities merged: if you're a Democrat, you're a liberal; if you're a Republican, you're a conservative. That didn't used to be true. Once that happened, it set the stage for all of these other identities to align: where you live, who you marry, what you think about 12 Years a Slave, what you think about video game fights on the internet. The stronger this sorting mechanism becomes, the more lethal the collisions between it become.*

Video games span a hearty set of demographics. It's a medium that has taken the entertainment industry by storm. And it's a medium that enjoys a massive online community, many players of which partake in anonymity. As ideologies and interests merge, it is important foster an inclusive and understood community, especially a community that encompasses the majority of American households.

It is important to write and talk about video games—even in anonymity (looking at me)—possibly now more than ever. And it goes without saying that a large swath of current day writers, artists, and activists were raised on and are familiar with the medium and likely its communities, let alone Tweeter and Thor.

Just (Quietly) Dance

January 29, 2017

Categories: General

Xavier Poix, Managing Director of Ubisoft's French studios, in a corporate update interview on UbiBlog:

> ***Is the Switch going to revolutionise the market like the Wii did?***
>
> ***XP**: The Wii attracted a very large audience – including kids and families – because it offered, on one hand, the motion controls, allowing for intuitive interactions with the console and on the other hand games with a strong social component. These aspects gave us the opportunity to develop Rabbids and _Just Danc_e, for example. The Switch will probably have a similar impact, thanks to the mobility offered by the console. You don't have to have a home console and a mobile console anymore; there's one console, which is mobile, that you can bring anywhere.*

Nice to see these comments, but that line-up doesn't strike me as all to weighty. I see the value in the audience Ubisoft is targeting, especially after their experiences on the Wii and Wii U, but what of Ubisoft's AAA games like *Assassin's Creed*, *Far Cry*, and *Watch Dogs*? How will those hold up on the Switch?

And has anyone reported on the Switch's speakers? I can't imagine *Just Dance* being a thrill in handheld mode.

Jose Otero, IGN: 'Attaching and detaching [Joy-Con] from the [Switch] is satisfying to the point that it's almost addictive'

January 29, 2017

Categories: Design, General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IvCQQucF-Ak

Jose Otero, IGN, timestamp 3:11:

> *Outside of the tiny face buttons, the analog sticks, digital triggers, and shoulder buttons feel solid and well made.*
>
> *The Joy-Con are surprisingly comfortable and versatile in the hand too. And attaching and detaching them from the console is satisfying to the point that it's almost addictive.*

I remember feeling satisfaction attaching and detaching Controller and Rumble Paks from the Nintendo 64 controller's expansion port.

I can't wait to get my hands on this thing.

Nintendo's Q3 Fiscal Year: Pocket Monsters

January 31, 2017

Categories: Business

Nintendo announced their third-quarter earnings for the fiscal year to mixed reaction.

6.45 million 3DS units were sold (10% increase YoY), driven by strong *Pokémon Sun and Moon* performance with 14.69 million units sold. In a press release, Nintendo points to the popularity of *Pokémon GO* as helping boost sales of *Pokémon Sun and Moon*, as well as boost hardware sales outside of Japan.

I'm fairly shocked by the 3DS numbers. The six year old, 240p handheld apparently still has legs amongst the massive mobile market. While I'd say that may be good news for the Switch, a "home" console that's performance seemingly can't match that of the PS4 or Xbox One, the 3DS starts at half the price of the Switch, $150 sliding up to $199 for an XL, and boasts a 1000+ game library[1].

I know the Switch is marketed as a home console, but I can't help but see it as a great handheld. With that perspective, and a guess that the Switch will see a price drop and bundle by holiday, it'll still have a way to go before challenging the 3DS.

The highly anticipated and advertised *Super Mario Run* only converted approximately 5% of it's 78 million downloads—about 4 million paid transactions. For a fantastic game, 4 million feels below my assumed "core" Nintendo base numbers.

Needless to say, 78 million iOS-only downloads is a lot of Mario icons on pocket computers at one time or another. This fits nicely with Nintendo's renewed focus of "interacting with [Nintendo IP] every day." And that's just iOS. Android will see *Super Mario Run* in March this year.

Overall, Thomas Whitehead of Nintendo Life captured my feelings about the results quite nicely:

> *The most recent financial reports can fit whatever agenda you want. They can be construed as worrying and a sign of a company in difficult times, or interpreted as a demonstration of Nintendo's strength and positive prospects. There are numbers to support both sides of the argument - the reality is that they represent a company still in transition, modernising its approach, utilising and boosting successes, while also dealing with mistakes and failures. The 3DS thrives, the Wii U dies, revenues come for an app in which Nintendo had limited involvement, and all of this with Switch and more mobile games to come.*

I remain very positive about Nintendo's future. Their IP and first-party games can't be beat and are appearing everywhere, while the Switch *seems* like the "dream" console, pre-orders of which are already difficult to come by.

This is easy for me to say. I adore Nintendo. I can't say the same for younger generations who grew up along side Minecraft rather than Mario. Is the new "Nintendo IP every day" strategy too little too late, or did Big-N hold out just long enough?

---

[1] **UPDATE**: The 1,000+ number is a combination of all games de-duped by region and format. Seeing as the 3DS is region locked and a fairly slim amount of players would even attempt to play non-

localized games, it's not fair to say 1,000+ games.

Additionally, Polygon's Brian Crecente stumbled across an interesting set of data in Nintendo's earnings report:

> *Stuffed in amidst Nintendo's quarterly earnings report was an interesting, updated look at the number of games released for every system going back to NIntendo's first.*
>
> *I grabbed the numbers, which are broken down into three regions for each platform, and built a little chart with them for easier comparison.*

As Crecente mentions in his post, 85 games have already been announced for the unreleased Nintendo Switch— already over half of the Wii U's US library. If the populous reclassifies the Switch as a handheld console which I imagine it will, the Switch has a big mountain to climb considering it's home console development costs and Nintendo's set-top game library trend.

100 Nintendo Switch Titles in Development

February 1, 2017

Categories: Business

Nintendo President Tatsumi Kimishima during the Q3 FY2016 financial briefing:

> *Next I will provide a follow-up report about our software publisher partners. After the presentation on January 13, we have continued to receive requests from more and more software publishers who want to develop games for the system. At the presentation, we announced that there were over 80 titles in development from more than 50 software publishers, but that number has now climbed to over 100 titles from more than 70 publishers. Please look forward to more announcements about the software lineup in the future.*

Only 165 Wii U titles were ever released in the US—the least amount of titles for any Nintendo console—followed by the Nintendo 64's 297.

This third-party interest seems promising.

'Is there an exodus from indie back to AAA?'

February 3, 2017

Categories: Work

Simon Parkin, writing for Gamasutra:

> *It would be too much of a stretch to imply that, five years after the explosion of indie game development, we're witnessing a widespread return back to large studio development. It is, however, undeniably true that, for every indie success story, there are scores of independently produced games that have failed to make a mark or to provide, for their creators, a viable new career. And as such, many are returning to more orthodox roles within established studios.*

Parkin continues to ship fantastic work.

While game development is certainly it's own beast, the perspectives in this piece will hit home for anyone who has moved from corporate culture to self-employment or startups. I'm also a fan of Teddy Dief's (*Hyper Light Drifter*, Square Enix Montreal) faux three hour meeting:

> *He keeps a daily faux three-hour meeting in his shared calendar in order to ensure he has time to do "deeper work."*

I strongly recommend Parkin's 2015 book here.

'Same playbook, just on a wider scale'

February 4, 2017

Categories: Politics

Brianna Wu—software engineer, game developer, and South Boston congressional candidate—on the Tomorrow podcast with Josh Topolsky of The Outline:

> ***Josh Topolsky****: It seems like we're in a particularly rotten place in America right now. We have Trump controlling the White House in a way—and with people like Steve Bannon—that seems dangerous. It feels somewhat out of control. I assume you're following this pretty closely.*
>
> ***Brianna Wu****: Steve Bannon—this is the editor in charge of Breitbart—legitimized vast parts of Gamergate. This is extremely personal to me.*
>
> ***JT****: He is, in many ways, a major figure in the "alt-right" and Gamergate movements which are linked. I mean, they seem very linked to me.*
>
> ***BW****: It's the same people. It's the exact same people; same playbook, just on a wider scale.*
>
> ***JT****: Let's talk a little bit about your experience with Gamergate. You dealt with enormous amounts of harassment from these people. Really violent and vile.*
>
> ***BW****: Violent. I had to leave my house. They targeted my company's financials repeatedly.*

This is a great listen.

Wu speaks from first-hand experience to the source, damaging effects, and cascading effect of Gamergate and it's current place in American politics.

It's easy not to take a term with the word "gamer" in it seriously. But, as Wu explains, the lack of serious investigation into Gamergate and knowledge of tech in general is likely a big part how we ended up in this mess. It's candidates like Wu—with deep knowledge of tech, engineering, privacy, and security—that will truly revolutionize the US government and make America 21st century ready again.

The Verge: 'How the Xbox One and PS4 are helping bring Chinese indie games to the West'

February 4, 2017

Categories: Culture, History, Politics

Andrew Webster, The Verge:

> *For 14 years — starting in 2000 — the Chinese government enforced a ban on video game consoles. Between 2014 and 2015, both the Xbox One and PlayStation 4 made their long-awaited and overdue debut. Microsoft described its release as a "monumental day" and celebrated by lighting up the Shanghai skyline in bright Xbox green. Sony's chief executive Kaz Hirai told The Telegraph that "I think that we will be able to replicate the kind of success we have had with PS4 in other parts of the world in [China]."*

The lifting of the Chinese console ban is not news, but the fact it was a thing still blows my mind. Where were you in 2000? Can you imagine your life without console games from then til now? It may sound like a silly question, but video games are a massive part of 21st century culture. Wild.

Regardless, a very cool and interesting story.

Nintendo's 'Conductor'

February 6, 2017

Categories: Business, Design, Work

Matt Peckham, writing for TIME, with a great profile of Nintendo's Shinya Takahashi:

> *"If all of Nintendo's content creators were to be seen as a symphony, then Mr. Takahashi is our conductor," says Nintendo of America boss Reggie Fils-Aimé, when asked to contrast Takahashi's role with Iwata's. "What I mean by that is, it's his decision to bring the different players in our orchestra onto a particular game or a particular initiative. He's the ultimate decision maker in what gets played by the symphony or what gets created by Nintendo as a company."*
>
> *And to follow the metaphor through, audiences rarely get to see the conductor's face. "He's been creating this big show, but because you only see his back, you really don't know him all that well," adds Fils-Aimé. "But he drives the orchestra and he sets the pace and the bar for the performance."*
>
> *Fils-Aimé pushes back on positional comparisons between the preeminent role Takahashi now plays with the myriad ones performed by Iwata, Nintendo's former "ultimate decision maker," calling them "different roles, different times, different needs of the organization." What's changed, he says, is that after Iwata's passing, the company decided it was time to ask its less visible luminaries to step up. It's a a philosophy others in the company, like Miyamoto, have espoused in passing for years.*
>
> *"The people that came out in the presentation, when you look at it from the perspective of Nintendo, they're actually not new at all," says Miyamoto of the varied group chosen to rep Nintendo's Switch during the system's January feting. Miyamoto, whose hands have touched virtually all of Nintendo's storied IP, will be 65 this year, while the company's new president, Tatsumi Kimishima, turns 67 in April.*

Takahashi has a storied career with the company. I especially love his history with *Wave Race 64* and *1080° Snowboarding*, two of my favorite Nintendo 64 titles. His views on management are similarly inspiring.

Nintendo 3DS and NES Classic Still Out of Stock

February 7, 2017

Categories: Business

Chaim Gartenberg, The Verge:

> *To put it plainly, with the Nintendo Switch launch right around the corner, the current inability to purchase the 3DS should seriously worry anyone without a preorder in place. Because if the Switch turns out to be as successful as the NES Classic or 3DS have been, fans could be facing yet another tough choice between a long wait or a grey market gouging for a Nintendo console.*

Looking on Target.com, there's not a single 3DS within 100 miles of Palo Alto. 250 miles on BesyBuy.com. Prime availability through Amazon is limited to Pikachu Yellow and Pokémon 20th Anniversary XL editions for $300+ through forth-parties. A new 3DS XL retails for $199. The Switch retails for $299.

I've shared Gartenberg's concern since missing the Switch's pre-order allotment. Not to mention the continued unavailability of the NES Classic. And being the dummy I am, I already traded my Wii U in at GameStop in anticipation of the Switch's March 3 release date—$200 burning a hole in my pocket. This is crazy. At the very least, take my order and send when ready.

I've got a feeling I'll be staring at my copy of *Breath of the Wild* longingly for a while.

The Besties Are Back

February 9, 2017

Categories: Media

Polygon:

> *Though we still don't have a great explanation as to why, the first ever Polygon podcast has returned on a monthly basis. Join The Besties (Russ Frushtick, Griffin McElroy, Justin McElroy and Chris Plante) as they nonsensically attempt to pick the "best" game released in January 2017.*

I was introduced to *The Besties* when I moved to San Francisco in 2013. Any time I was walking the city, out on a jog, or commuting to work, there was a fair chance I was listening to *The Besties*. Their comradely and banter provided me company during those moments when my wife was away. (Such is the power of podcasts!)

Over the past two years, what was a monthly show turned annual. This surprise relaunch of the monthly cadence is just what I, nay the world needs right now.

Nicalis: Switch development is 'light years ahead of what we were doing with Wii U'

February 9, 2017

Categories: Business, Design

Tyrone Rodriguez, the president of Nicalis, speaking to Polygon about developing for Nintendo platforms:

> *"The Switch is, by far the easiest and most programmer friendly so far," he said. "I know this sounds like lip service to Nintendo, but it's actually not. If this wasn't true, we wouldn't be able to get these games up and running as quickly as we have, and we wouldn't be able to have a launch title. It's light years ahead of what we were doing with Wii U."*

Nicalis has developed 18 games, eight of which shipped to Nintendo platforms—all eight to 3DS, two of which hit Wii U.

The Second Console

February 10, 2017

Categories: Business

Polygon's newly relaunched Besties podcast, January 2017 episode:

> ***Chris Plante****: If indie game developers care and the make "the switch" from Vita to this hardware, I'll care. Obviously, that wasn't enough to save the Vita, so I don't see that as a big thing for other people.*
>
> ***Griffin McElroy****: I think that's a wack comparison.*
>
> ***CP****: The Wii U had some of the best Nintendo games and that wasn't even close to enough to get people interested.*
>
> ***Russ Frushtick****: Consider that the Vita died primarily because Sony was dividing their time and energy between the PS4 and the Vita and they eventually gave up. Indies filled in a lot of the blanks, but the most part they just gave up and third-parties gave up, etc. Here Nintendo's obviously not going to give up because it's their primary console now.*
>
> ***CP****: They won't give up unless nobody buys it, which is a very real possibility if there are no games from Nintendo or third-party studios.*
>
> ***RF****: There are certainly two to three years of Nintendo games pretty much guaranteed.*
>
> ***CP****: But like I said, that's not enough. That just doesn't work at all for Nintendo. When it doesn't have third-party developers and it doesn't have a mainstream gimmick—something that's going to make people who watch the TODAY Show be like, "Well, I've never bought a video game console, but I'll try this," then it doesn't have it.*
>
> ***GM****: It's not going to be the Wii. It'll never be the Wii. They'll never do the Wii ever again.*
>
> ***RF****: The Wii was an aberration.*
>
> ***CP****: That's a for real problem for them. The thing that they have to [face] right now is, "We are the second console." If they truly don't get third-party support and they only have a new game every five or six months—let's be super generous and say three—then that is a second console for people, which is big money. And unlike the Wii U, which only had to be competing as a second console against people who maybe already owned an Xbox and instead of a PS4 they might buy a Wii U. Now they have to compete with the fact that Microsoft and Sony are going to be releasing new hardware, what, every year? Every other year?*

Leave it to Chris Plante to shake me from my Switch hype hypnosis. And I'm glad he did.

I am very much looking forward to the Switch, but Nintendo certainly does not have an easy road ahead of them.

'On the internet, no one still knows you're a dog'

February 10, 2017

Categories: Media, Society

John Markoff, former technology reporter for the New York Times, in an interview on Kara Swisher's Recode Decode podcast:

> *On the internet, no one still knows you're a dog. I think identity and the fact that you disconnect [real] identity from your internet identity has proved incredibly vexing for society. It played out in this election. It played out in Brexit. (It was a factor in both—I don't know if it was a deciding factor—but I actually do blame the internet.)*
>
> *I grew up with John Perry Barlow and his manifesto in WIRED in which he argued that cyberspace would be this "Socratian" abode above the grimy politics of the world. Then I realized I was wrong.*
>
> *The internet is simply a reflection of all the good and the evil in the world.*
>
> *[...]*
>
> *What's striking to me is that what the science-fiction world saw in the '80s and '90s has actually come to pass; the cyberpunk sensibility. There was a book written by Vernor Vinge in the early 1980s called True Names. The basic premise of that was you had to basically hide your true name at all costs. It was an insight into the world we're living in today.*

Takahashi: 'reach that broader smart device audience and entice them to move towards Nintendo Switch'

February 12, 2017

Categories: Business

Nintendo's Yoshiaki Koizumi and Shinya Takahashi were interviewed by The Telegraph. There's not much new in here, other than confirmation of developing for 3DS through 2018, which also plays into a now confirmed mobile strategy:

> ***Is it more to drive that smartphone audience into buying a Switch?***
>
> ***Takahashi****: Certainly one of our goals in releasing software for smart devices that features Nintendo IP is to reach that broader smart device audience and entice them to move towards Nintendo Switch.*

By 2018, assuming the Switch can hold its own, I believe price drops will squeeze out a new Nintendo handheld console. (Maybe a mini-Switch is a possibility?)

On possible supply constraints:

> ***Finally as we head toward launch there has been some reports of stock shortages. Are you confident that anyone that wants a Switch will be able to buy one?***
>
> ***Takahashi****: Maybe within the first few days! It does sound like there might be a few shortages here and there, but once you get past that I think we'll have a very steady flow. Some of our employees are worried about getting one... but we are making a lot!*

I'm really hoping this is true.

'Metacritic' Still Matters, But For How Long?

February 13, 2017

Categories: Business, Media, Review

Chris Baker, Glixel:

> *The hue and cry around that score is the best evidence that Metacritic deeply matters to many people. And not just fans – the bonus payments that game makers receive from their publishing companies is often tied to the Metascore and those same publishers spend a great deal of time and effort trying to predict the number as it could affect everything from retail orders to returns.*
>
> *But the games business, and games themselves, are changing. In many ways, a snapshot of what the critical consensus is at the time of launch does not reflect the ultimate nature of a game. Is Metacritic still relevant in this new climate?*

A great insight to the inner workings of Metacritic. Must read.

Humble Freedom Bundle

February 13, 2017

Categories: Charity

Humble Bundle:

> ***Take a stand for freedom.*** *Give me your tired, your poor, your huddled masses yearning to breathe free, the wretched refuse of your teeming shore. Send these, the homeless, tempest-tost to me, I lift my lamp beside the golden door. – "The New Colossus" by Emma Lazarus, from an engraving on the Statue of Liberty.*
>
> *We humbly remember that the United States is a nation of immigrants, and we proudly stand with developers, authors, and charities that champion liberty and justice for all.*
>
> ***This special one-week bundle features over $600 in incredible games and books for just $30. 100% of your payments will go to the American Civil Liberties Union, the International Rescue Committee, and Doctors Without Borders/Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF). Humble Bundle will proudly match your contributions up to $300,000.***
>
> *We chose these three organizations because of the inspiring work they do in providing humanitarian assistance to refugees and displaced people as well as in defense of justice, human rights, and civil rights:*

Humble Bundles are a fantastic way to spend your hard earned cash. Here's the deal: you give your money to Humble Bundle and they give you great games, donate your money to amazing charities, and match your donation up to a particular amount. Win, win, win.

I've contributed to a handful of Humble Bundles and I can say the *The Witness*. Also, *Superbrothers: Sword & Sworcery EP* is incredible (and has one of the greatest soundtracks ever!), and boy oh boy I can't wait to play *Stardew Valley*, Polygon's #8 Game of the Year 2016.

Do this. Do this now. Do this for many reasons. But do this now.

(The irony of a charitable organization contributing to your pile of shame!)

GameStop Announces Midnight Switch Launch

February 22, 2017

Categories: Business, Media

GameStop press release:

> *This just in: GameStop, a family of specialty retail brands that makes the most popular technologies affordable and simple, announced stores will have a limited supply of Nintendo Switch systems available for walk-in customers on the March 3 launch day. Customers who were not able to pre-order the system are encouraged to attend GameStop's midnight launch events held at stores across the nation for an opportunity to purchase Nintendo's revolutionary new home gaming system.*

A few thoughts:

1. I'm screwed. Fat chance I'll make a midnight launch. Fatter chance there'll be any Switch(es) left around noon in Tahoe. Fattest chance there'll be Switch(es) days/weeks later.
2. Five out of the six sites I found reporting this news did not source GameStop's press release. Not Polygon. Not GameStop. Not USA TODAY. Not BGR. Not SlashGear. However, Tom's Hardware did. Pitiful.
3. "Simple" is the last word I would use to describe GameStop.

Eurogamer: 'Docked Zelda Stutters in Places Where the Mobile Experience Does Not'

March 3, 2017

Categories: General

Richard Leadbetter, Eurogamer:

> *In terms of performance, it's immediately clear to the naked eye that the docked Zelda stutters in places where the mobile experience does not - and to confirm this, we manually counted frames by eye based on our camera shots to ensure accuracy in producing the performance test below. It's really easy to isolate this issue as it occurs frequently in the open world, right from the beginning of the game. In some places, we see the smooth 30fps update while docked drop down to a momentary 20fps - confirming a basic double-buffer v-sync implementation.*

Home console?

Phil Collins: Crash Bandicoot man

March 5, 2017

Categories: General, Parenting

A fun tidbit from Phil Collins' memoir "Not Dead Yet":

> *Somewhat dazed, I go back to the hotel, the Peninsula Beverly Hills. Lily, now aged nine, is waiting for me, which brightens things up no end. She and I start playing Spyro the Dragon—computer games are one of our new shared passions. I love them, and I love Spyro, although if push comes to shove, I'll declare myself a Crash Bandicoot man. As if by magic, the hearing in my left ear roars back. It's like I've been underwater, but the blockage is suddenly gone. Thank God for that.*

Switch On, Switched Off

March 11, 2017

Categories: Design, Review

I have felt an incredible sense of satisfaction in owning a Nintendo Switch. It sounds absolutely insane and gross, but owning the Switch has made me feel better. I feel less stressed and more focused at work. I feel less anxious as a whole. My mood has lightened. My spirits have been lifted. And unlike Gollum's incessant need to touch and obsess over the Ring of Power, my joy and calm come purely from ownership. In the twisted space of consumerism, something strange is at play.

Federico Viticci, Remaster podcast:

> *This is the console that I've been waiting my entire life for. That's based on the idea—and really the dream that I've been having since I was a kid and I got my first Super Nintendo—that I want to have the same games everywhere on one console that I take with me all the time, and that I can choose whether I want to play as a portable console or on the TV.*
>
> *It's been over 25 years since I've been playing Nintendo games and we've been through a lot of changes in the video game industry. Other companies have tried to do this sort of dual-screen, single console before. When you think about the PS Vita, when you think about the Wii U or the Nintendo DS, a lot of the ideas have been fragmented over the years in the industry. The Switch feels like the unification of 30 years of work from Nintendo. It's the distillation of decades of work in portable consoles, in home consoles, and now in just one console.*

I think the strangeness I'm sensing has a lot to do with what Federico outlines. The Switch is the amalgamation of decades of hardware design, innovation, and childhood fantasies.

Born in 1985, my first memory is of *Mega Man 2* on the original Nintendo Entertainment System. My babysitter owned one. How I yearned for that console. Christmas of 1989, I opened a Nintendo Game Boy. Not quite an NES, with it's 2-bit color palette on green green display, but boy did my imagination soar. Surely, the tech would evolve and those 8-bit color experiences could live in my hands. The dream of taking the vast digital worlds I played on a TV with me on the go was sparked.

In 1995—the year the original 32-bit Sony PlayStation was released in North America—I was gifted a Sega Genesis Nomad. The handheld Nomad accepted standard Sega Genesis cartridges, enabling full 16-bit gaming on the go, albeit with a massive 6 AA battery pack that lasted 2-3 hours. While it was a console generation cycle off, we were getting closer.

In 2005, the PlayStation Portable's (PSP) display and graphic capabilities re-inspired the dream. On it's heels in 2006 was the promise of remote play from PS3 to PSP, later mandatory of PS4 games to the PlayStation Vita. In 2012, remote play was a core gimmick of the now infamous Wii U. Also in 2012 came Sony's cross-buy service launched, allowing for a single purchase (of compatible games) to work on Vita and PS3/PS4. In 2015, the PlayStation Now's cloud-based service would seemingly allow Sony devices, Vita and PS4 included, to access a library of online games from PlayStations 1 through 4. PlayStation Now has discontinued support for all devices save PS4 and Windows PC, including the Vita.

Now, the dual set-top/handheld console is a dream realized with the Nintendo Switch. And the versatility of it's Joy-Con controllers takes it one step further, opening the console to instant local multiplayer. The Switch is a simple and obvious design that delivers and, for some sick reason, fills a hole in my life I never thought existed.

'The schoolyard is the entirety of the internet'

March 13, 2017

Categories: Design

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *Breath of the Wild feels like a return of the schoolyard culture, where friends meet to discuss the latest things they've found in a Nintendo game and share rumors of even bigger possible secrets, except now the schoolyard is the entirety of the internet. It's comfortable with assuming that you're smart enough to figure things out, and it knows that it's not going to be ultimately responsible for everything you miss or even built-in frustration. The answer to every puzzle is a quick Google away, and the game's design seems comfortable with that option being a viable path to moving forward.*

I completely agree.

Hidemaro Fujibayashi, *Breath of the Wild* Game Director, on designing Breath of the Wild's open gameplay at GDC:

> *Let's not forget the fact that all the solutions to all the puzzles that we've painstakingly prepared for a dungeon are made available on the internet.*

Great design decision by Fujibayasha and team. *Breath of the Wild* is clearly not their first rodeo, but this strikes me as forward thinking for Nintendo.

Self-Competing and Time Blocking

April 23, 2017

Categories: Business, Design

Daniel Ahmad, writing on his new ZhugeEX Patreon blog (paywall):

> *This trend isn't going anywhere right now but it is important to note that only a set number of service games can be successful each year. There is a danger of over saturation or poorer sales from self-competing games. We're not quite at the point where this is a real danger but it does mean that games need to have higher production values and enough differentiation within one of the top super genre's to be successful. This is probably something to watch out for at the end of the generation.*

First and foremost, for my dollar, Daniel Ahmad is absolutely crushing video games industry analysis. He's a great follow on Twitter (@ZhugeEX) and his efforts are well-worth supporting via his Patreon.

Now, I've been meaning/trying to write about an idea that self-competing games use game length as a means for competing. That is, the length and release date of a game can block the sale of another similar game with a proximal release date. I've struggled to put together a theory that these proposed "time blocking" tactics are meaningful, coincidental, or off-base:

- *Meaningful* - Publisher X purposefully schedules release date of Game X against the release date of Game Y. (I find this hard to believe due to the large lead times and estimations required for AAA games.)
- *Coincidental* - Publisher X and Publisher Y happen to schedule releases for Game X and Game Y around the same time. (More likely, but rings a bit too innocent.)
- *Off-base* - There are so many massive, feature-rich games released that, like TV series and books, there will inevitably be overlap in release dates.

The latest example of this "time blocking" tactic occurred around March 2017. *Horizon Zero Dawn* and *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* were released three days apart (Feb 28 and Mar 3) and clock in at an average of 45.5 and 72.5 hours respectively. (HowLongToBeat.com) Both games were followed up by *Mass Effect: Andromeda* (61.5 hours) and *Persona 5* (102 hours!) within a month's time.

One could make the observation that the hours necessary to experience these games as intended puts them on a closer par with a modern television series. (As of this post, there are roughly 55 hours of *Game of Thrones* episodes, 72 hours of *Mad Men*, etc.) So, with customers' appetites for feature-rich gameplay experiences, maybe my concept of "time blocking" is off-base. However, I like to believe that this "appetite" doesn't actually exist.

I'm currently 50+ hours into *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* and only 3/5 of the way through the main quest. No doubt that it's an incredible experience with its unparalleled physics-based sandbox, wide-open exploration, and stunning art style. But for me, 50+ hours is an immense amount of a time to spend with a single game. Unlike a TV series, most of the 50+ hours I've spent with *Breath of the Wild* have consisted of wandering a vast landscape, retracing my steps, or banging my head against puzzles. It's a fantastic escape of exploration, but I can't help but think 30 or 40 hours to complete would have felt sufficient.

As a developer, I would certainly want my audience to experience my art and efforts for as long as possible. And as a publisher, I would want players to adopt an affinity for my franchise over another. But as a player, it's hard not to feel that the release dates of similarly massive titles, or "self-competing" games, are beginning to overlap. And this overlap has reached a point that players must now choose which experience will block another.

Hail Mario 2: Electrodrome Boogaloo

April 30, 2017

Categories: Business, General, Review

In 2014, I wrote Hail Mario, a post about Nintendo's aggressive strategy to bolster Wii U sales with the release of *Mario Kart 8*:

> *Nintendo gambled for positive reviews two weeks before launch, is now chalking up at least $40 in games to every US and Canadian Mario Kart owning household, and prays that their Trojan horse will be the spark to move units. Since release, the game has received stunning accolades, Club Nintendo has been brought down by what can only be assumed as immense traffic for free games, and at least one Wii U newcomer is being tugged at by curiosity.*
>
> *When people think of video games, a large majority picture a mustachioed plumber in a red hat, but Master Chief and the Minecraft universe are only 3 points down. There are still many plays to be made but a well-timed, well-calculated marketing play this big could be enough to save the game. Mario Kart 8 may give Nintendo the lead they need to send a message to the HD Twins: Nintendo's race is not over.*

The post was picked up on Daring Fireball and is far and away the most popular Zero Counts post. (Thanks, Mr. Gruber!)

Mario Kart 8's early review embargo showed confidence in the game and got media outlets openly singing the game's praises well ahead of release. In addition to building hype, *Mario Kart 8* came bundled with a free download for one of four AAA games.

For the Switch, Nintendo has released *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe* — a slightly enhanced version with a revived and much beloved battle mode and all cups, courses, characters, and DLC unlocked. To add, what I had already considered the best Mario Kart entry to date, can now be taken on the go and played in a myriad of situations — TV or portable; solo, local split screen, or online; out of the box 2-player with Joy-Cons, 8 paired Switches, or 12 player wired LAN. (Mic has a great breakdown.)

Until this point, the Switch has been a Zelda machine; a single player experience. There were a handful of multiplayer games, but nothing close to a must-have or system seller. With *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe*, Nintendo has released the true test of the Switch's promise — console-level gaming with anyone anywhere. How would new Switch players react? Would previous Wii U owners (and likely *Mario Kart 8* owners) care? How does portable multiplayer hold up?

On *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe*'s_ _release day, I brought my Switch to work. It was the perfect venue to test the Switch's out-of-the-box local multi-player experience. In fact, it was the first time I'd attempted *any* multi-player on the device in *any* of its various forms. As far as I know, I'm the only one in the office with a Switch. Gasps filled the room when I removed the Joy-Con from the display. I handed one over to a colleague, showed him around the tiny controller, and away we went.

While the 6.2-inch display is fantastic for a single player experience, split-screen is a bit uncomfortable, but not impossible. The fun had over bouts of office Mario Kart eclipsed the discomfort, but it was never completely put it out of our minds. Likewise, a few gripes and cramps

were had from the ergonomics when using a single Joy-Con as a primary controller. The situation is tight, but for an experience like *Mario Kart 8*, the pain seemed to be worth the pleasure.

At home, as my wife and I settled into bed, we decided to have a go at one race. I tried to place the Switch on the bed between us — an impossible feat due to the unforgiving kickstand. So, a book was used as the foundation. We peeled away the Joy-Con and we're off to the races. Together we squinted at the tiny screen. I proved to be too uncomfortable for extended periods of play, but we agreed that it would serve well on flights.

The main annoyance came from the placement of the L and R buttons. For her, they felt too close together. To be fair, fitting such a functional controller in the palm a hand is a feat. In fact, there were multiple instances throughout the day when players were shocked to find that the Joy-Con rumbled too.

Breaking out *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe* on the Switch is all fun and good, but there's not much for players of the original *Mario Kart 8*. Mario Kart has always been about the party atmosphere, and this version is the ultimate. And I can see myself jumping into a quick pick up game here and there, but otherwise, I've been there done that. There's nothing to unlock. No new cups, courses, or characters. The portability of the Switch paired with Mario Kart plugs a some gaming holes some may never been the wiser, but nothing more than a quick casual experience romp.

I wish I could speak from the newbie to *Mario Kart 8* experience. For that, see Jeremy Parish's Retronauts review of *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe*. It's a fantastic game, but even for newcomers, what does Mario Kart feel like without triumphing for new cups or characters? Does the high polish of Mario Kart 8 hold its luster without striving for something other than victory? Does the out-of-the-box portable multiplayer feel as novel when you haven't played MK8 on a TV for the past few years?

Mario Kart 8 Deluxe shows off all the Switch has to offer, but other than pure competition, there's no hook. *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe* is a must-have for party moments and quick pick up game, but not a system seller. At least not at $60.

[*Update 7/31/18*]: Nintendo's FY18 Q2 earning report shows *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe as the second-best selling game for the Nintendo Switch* with 10.35 million units sold; 0.82 million units behind best selling *Super Mario Odyssey*, 1.03 million ahead of third-best selling launch title *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*.

While I'm still bummed by the lack of unlockable achievements and content, enough can't be said about the boundless pick-up-and-play experience of the greatest Mario Kart ever on Nintendo Switch.

WSJ is Breaking Nintendo

May 15, 2017

Categories: Business, Media

Takashi Mochizuki, The Wall Street Journal:

> *Nintendo Co. plans to bring its videogame franchise "The Legend of Zelda" to smartphones, people familiar with the matter said, the latest step by the Kyoto company to expand its mobile-games lineup.*

More often than not, it feels like WSJ — Mochizuki in particular — is breaking Nintendo news these days. At the very least, Mochizuki has a keen eye on the beat. Never have I been so inclined to pay for The Wall Street Journal, which paints a picture of Nintendo's audience as much as it does The Journal's.

Here are some other recent scoops from Mochizuki:

5/1: Nintendo Shipped Switch Consoles by Plane to Quickly Meet High Demand

4/27: Nintendo Offers Bright Outlook on Expectations for Switch

3/17: Nintendo to Double Production of Switch Console

Side-note: I really like how tapping/clicking a WSJ byline reveals the writer's bio, Twitter handle, and email address — a treatment I've never realized I've always wanted.

Sold on Cross-Network Play

June 17, 2017

Categories: General

During the Nintendo Spotlight: E3 2017, cult favorite *Rocket League* was announced for the Switch. The announcement included the bullet point "Cross-Network play", officially detailed on RocketLeague.com, emphasis my own:

> *Rocket League will also support all of Nintendo Switch's play modes, including TV Mode (docked), Tabletop Mode, Handheld Mode, and both Online and Local Multiplayer. Online Multiplayer supports up to eight players, and Cross-Network play will be supported as well, allowing Switch players to hit the field with players on Steam and Xbox One.*

The idea that I can play the exact same game with a friend on a different console should not be novel. It is a future I've been hoping for, and honestly, a no brainer from a consumer's perspective.

For non-exclusives, I don't want to have think about shutting out some of my friends based on a console decision. A handful of my friends prefer playing on Xbox One. Another handful prefer playing on PlayStation 4. I'm caught in the middle and certainly don't want to purchase the game twice. (Nor should I be expected to own both consoles!)

Without the knowledge of different online communities, buying a game as a gift can be a tremulous experience for family and friends. Confusion exists for the non-gaming community. There are horror stories of purchasing Wii U games for Wii owners. Hell, there was confusion between NES and SNES games back in the '90s. I would argue that purchasing a game for the correct console, but being locked out of playing with friends simply because they own a different console sounds like lunacy to those without gaming knowledge.

However, as Myke Hurley on the *Remaster* podcast points out, PlayStation will not be partaking.:

> *It's very awesome that [Rocket League] has Cross-Network play. You'll be able to play against players on other platforms. This is just PC and Xbox right now, which is the same for Minecraft. With the new Minecraft, you will sign in with an Xbox Live account to play on the Switch. So this is something it seems like a bunch of different game companies are getting together with one notable absent platform which is PlayStation.*

This is not a technical limitation. It is political.

Jeremy Dunham, VP of publishing at Psyonix, in an interview with Polygon:

> *"It's literally something we could do with a push of a button, metaphorically," Dunham told Polygon. "In reality it's a web page with a checkbox on it. All we have to do is check that box and it would be up and running in less than an hour all over the world. That's all we need to do."*

As an owner of all three consoles, the gesture of Cross-Network play between Xbox One and Switch — even between two games, *Rocket League* and *Minecraft* — is enough to push me over the edge of purchasing and playing third-party titles available for both Xbox One and PlayStation 4 on Xbox One.

Cross-Network play is the future for third-party titles and I have faith Sony will follow suit. Until then, whenever I'm debating which "HD twin" to play third-party multiplayer experiences on, Xbox One gets my money, simply on the potential that their willingness will bring more shared Cross-Network play experiences. (Come on, Overwatch!)

E3 2017

June 19, 2017

Categories: Media

E3 debuted in 1995 — 22 years ago. This year, for the first time ever, the Entertainment Software Association welcomed the public to the expo. As a follower of E3 since age 9, I was overjoyed to have nabbed one of the 15,000 publicly released tickets.

The Event

The days leading up to the event were spent streaming presentations from Microsoft, Bethesda, EA, and Sony. Nintendo's event took place while I was in the air, so I dove headfirst into the tidy 25 minute Nintendo Spotlight upon touchdown. I'd missed Ubisoft's presentation, but felt fairly caught up after scanning headlines during the cab ride from LAX to the Los Angeles Convention Center. I was ready for E3.

As expected, the entry lines snaked around the building. I had braced myself for standing in lines for three days straight. In the meantime, I took to booking appointments for the Sony booths via the Experience PlayStation app. I attempted to sign into the app with my PSN credentials only to find myself in an "incorrect password" loop bug, identifying storefronts and cars for CAPTCHA for upwards of 30 minutes. (Mind you, the likely "slammed by tens of thousands of E3 participants" LTE reception was poor. This did not bode well for my battery.) I could have signed in as a guest, but was hoping for a bit of PSN love if signed in. After several failed attempts, my password was finally reset, I successfully signed into the app, and was able to grab one of the remaining theater demo slots for *Uncharted: The Lost Legacy*. All other demos and theater slots were booked. Try again at 2pm.

Our entry line eventually moved into the Convention Center's south hall where buzz was abound the cacophony of video game themed booths. *Final Fantasy*. *Capcom vs. Marvel*. *Middle-earth: Shadow of War*. Massive projections. Lighting flurries. Dragons. Cram over-the-top Disneyland aesthetics into an overcrowded casino and you have E3. Entering the gates of the video game holy land seemed everything I'd hoped it'd be.

Then we looked for games to play. And looked. And looked. And looked. The massive crowds had overtaken all available consoles for the next handful of hours. All lines were quickly capped. Luck being our only chance to play anything, it quickly became apparent that a three day pass for a single price was less of a steal as it was a requirement to actually feel like you were able to participate in what E3 had to offer. It would certainly take at least three days of waiting in lines for an attendee to play your top five choices of E3.

Clinging to hope that the crowds would thin out over the next two days, my friends and I took to wandering, stargazing, and stabbing our phones for appointment times at the Sony booth. Splitting up and sharing our experiences proved to be the best strategy. Nintendo's construction of *Super Mario Odyssey*'s New Donk City was the star of the show. IGN's production crew and round the clock coverage was captivating. A plethora of fighting game competitions littered both halls. (I was transfixed watching *Injustice 2* fighter Jen annihilate nearly every competitor that showed up.) Ubisoft made their presence known with multiple massive projections, live demos from development teams, and plenty of *Just Dance 2018* performances. (Any tips for getting Hyuna's *Bubble Pop* out of one's head?)

While it was nice to see and play highly anticipated games ahead of release, the real magic of E3 2017 were the extravagant booths, passionate publisher/developer staff, wandering games media personnel, and ecstatic fans. The lines were hellish and I really wish I'd been able to play more. It was an exhaustive, discouraging experience that could have been more conducive to consumers with better line management (Sony's mediocre app was the best experience and even that was painful), more live demos rather than hands-on areas with larger theaters, co-op or multiplayer experiences when possible, more occupied floor space, and simply less people. One full day may have been enough, but three was required to participate in more than one activity. It was certainly a childhood dream come true and I was expecting no less, but I can't say I'll be retuning to E3 without media or industry credentials in the future.

The Games

At the end of day three, I walked away seeing live demos of *Uncharted*, *Spider-Man*, *Monster Hunter World*, *Days Gone*, and *Middle-earth: Shadow of War*, and played *Super Mario Odyssey* and *Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle*. (My friend and I lucked out by standing next to a nearly unoccupied *Super Mario Odyssey* demo and I waited two hours for 16 minutes of *Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle*.) In hindsight, it was not enough to feel fulfilled by the experience.

Of the two games I played, **Super Mario Odyssey** was the better. Odyssey feels like the perfect amalgam of all 3D Mario adventures: The playground of *Super Mario 64*'s introductory courtyard, *Super Mario Sunshine*'s NPCs, *Super Mario Galaxy*'s inventiveness, and *Super Mario 3D World*'s fidelity. Above all, there is a "weird" factor that has been generating buzz. The various worlds Mario can travel to feature a variety of art styles: the playable New Donk City feels like a *Tony Hawk's Pro Skater* / *Sims* hybrid while the Sand Kingdom felt like a traditional 3D Mario world with a new classic 2D side-scrolling mechanic added to the mix. (Think *The Legend of Zelda: A Link Between Worlds*.) The game played as great as you can imagine, but the real allure is looking forward to the variety and trying to figure out just what the hell is going on!

Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle is the game I'm most looking forward to. It's gorgeous and surprisingly deep. I can't recall ever seeing the Mushroom Kingdom in such detail. And like any great Mario game, it feels like it may be deceptively difficult. I've never played an *XCOM* game, and the demo seemed to only scratch the surface, but the number of methods to approaching and evading battle seemed impressive. There is a certain chess-like quality to the game in that you may need to think twice or thrice before executing a move. Enemies lurk in around cover and, if you're not careful, environmental elements can throw off your game. I do worry that variety will be a problem; the old "Sonic" syndrome where the first handful of levels feel great but then feel dull or repetitive or both. We shall see.

Uncharted looks like *Uncharted*. I certainly love the idea of playing as Chole, but the sequence shown did little to suggest that this would be any different from previous iterations. And that may be fine, but unless there is a drastically different element (*Uncharted 2*'s sequences > *Uncharted 1*, *Uncharted 3*'s story > *Uncharted 2*, *Uncharted 4*'s fidelity > *Uncharted 3*), I feel it's a bit soon to jump back into this world.

The live **Spider-Man** demo went a little off script from the Sony presentation but was largely the same. I love the Arkham-like feel, but the reliance on quicktime events is a bit off-putting. Still, I'm looking forward to this game. (Now I want Insomniac to make a TMNT game!)

Days Gone was touted for it's variety of mission approaches and environmental effects on the population, but the post-apocalypse / zombie infestation disenchanted me. How are we not done with zombies yet?

Both **Monster Hunter World** and *Middle-earth: Shadow of War* looked incredibly chaotic yet impressive. The highlight of Monster Hunter World came when a giant iguana-like monster crashed out of a nearby forest to feast on another gigantic beast — albeit lower in the food chain — plumping up like a snake after the meal, and sauntering back into the forest. Back at the nest, the iguana-like creature regurgitated part of his meal, summoning it's offspring to the feast. Later in the demo, the same iguana-like creature would join our battle against a T. Rex-like monster as the T. Rex-like was trespassing on the iguana-like's territory. Quite the world!

Middle-earth: Shadow of War looks to be focused more on castle raids than the previous entry. Players will recruit orc war chiefs throughout their play and choose which ones they will bring into a castle raid, strategizing their recruits' strengths vs. the castle's war chiefs' weaknesses. Before the demo, director of technical art at Monolith Mike Allen touted enhancements to the nemesis system; however, these did not seem evident to me. I was expecting something more along the lines of the beloved Brûz.

There was lots of buzz about **Detroit** throughout the show. It plays like *Heavy Rain*, allowing payers to investigate a scene in attempts to build a successful outcome to a dire situation. While I did not get a chance to play *Detroit*, I did observe four different endings to the hostage scenario players were given the opportunity to partake in: 1 failure, 3 successes. The failure resulted in the hostage being killed. The successes varied in:

1. the player sacrificing himself to save the hostage
2. the player saving the hostage, but being shot during the encounter
3. convincing the rival android to comply, saving the hostage and himself

There are plenty of games that offer a variety of situations and solutions, but to see these different scenarios play out next to each other simultaneous by different individuals' actions was rather interesting to see. I can't say the game is for me, but of those that played it, most felt it was the game for them.

As noted, I wasn't able to partake in much. Nor were all games showcased during the presentations being showcased — *Anthem* and *God of War* most notably. Ultimately, I feel I'd gotten everything I needed from the presentations. A trip to E3 was not warranted.

Kudos to Nintendo's E3 Booth Team

June 19, 2017

Categories: General, Media

Yahoo's Ben Silverman and host Jeff Cannata on the DLC podcast:

> ***Ben Silverman**: I think the problem wasn't that there were fans there, I just think that no one was prepared for this. The management of the [Los Angeles Convention Center] didn't route people in ways that made sense. It was just like everyone go and charge through these gigantic halls. The booths weren't set up to handle that crush of fans.*
>
> *On the first night — Tuesday night — Nintendo furiously reorganized their booth so that Wednesday and Thursday it would make more sense.*
>
> ***Jeff Cannata**: And kudos to them because they did a great job. Tuesday it was literally just a sea of people at the Nintendo booth. It was unmanageable, completely. And kudos to them for staying up late that night and figuring it out. They had structure that really worked for the rest of the show. I mean, it was a six hour line — I wouldn't wish that on my worst enemy — but it still at least allowed movement through their booth.*

My friend and I took note of Nintendo's queue management restructure on Wednesday as well. It was very cool to see. However, the lines for *Super Mario Odyssey* remained completely insane, but at least there *were* lines.


Nintendo booth at E3 2017

I mentioned that my friend and I lucked out in playing *Super Mario Odyssey*. Wednesday morning, after being let into the LACC, we beelined it for *Super Mario Odyssey*, but were discouraged to find that the line was already three hours long. A Nintendo booth actor/temp — dressed in a New Donk City themed suit and fedora no less — whispered "a secret" that the attendees sitting on a bench behind us with Switches in handheld mode were actually partaking in the demo. To a passerby, they looked like attendees playing on their own consoles. We were none the wiser until the fedora-clad "Donkian" gave us the coat full of contraband treatment. (I don't think he was in character, but it fit the bill.) We immediately formed a line next to the bench, sparking another lengthy queue.

In all fairness, the actor/temp should have informed those waiting in the longer line that the Switches on the bench were demo units as well, long before my friend and I arrived. On the flip side, the lengthy *Super Mario Odyssey* line was a for a docked Switch with headphones — the full console experience. The bench Switches were portable mode only and did not feature audio, one of my favorite elements of Mario games.

John Gruber's Review of the Nintendo Switch

June 29, 2017

Categories: Media, Review

John Gruber, The Talk Show podcast, episode 195: '*I Do Like Throwing A Baby', With Special Guest John Moltz*:

> *Here's my one word review:*
>
> *It's very fun and I like it.*

Seconded.

Update:

> *The Nintendo Switch is a triumph.*

Brian Crecente says Goodbye to Polygon

July 11, 2017

Categories: Media

Brian Crecente:

> *So I wrapped things up at Kotaku and joined Grant and crew to help launch Polygon. Then somehow five years whipped by and before I knew it I went from covering presidential press conferences and breaking news on new games to spending my days writing about esoteric pinball machines or the state of gaming and game culture in Cuba.*
>
> *When Rolling Stone contacted me about joining the magazine on its 50th anniversary, I simply couldn't say no. I've spent more than a dozen years talking about how I wanted to build the Rolling Stone of gaming publications. Where better to do that then at Rolling Stone?*

I've always looked forward to Brian's work on Zero Counts was founded upon a very similar message.

Glixel (Rolling Stone's gaming vertical) has been publishing some spectacular pieces as of late. I'm very excited to see how Brian's legacy and institutional knowledge from Kotaku and Polygon bolster Glixel.

Sell My Old Consoles, I'm Off To Handheld

August 5, 2017

Categories: Business, Design

There is a house. In the house, there is a room. In the room, there is a closet. In the closet, there is a box. In the box, is 2013's top-of-the-line consumer hardware technology — dusty and dormant.

I haven't touched my PS4 since my Switch arrived. In fact, I removed it from the living room entertainment center completely, replacing it with the Switch's dock — unnecessary seeing as the Switch functions without being connected to a TV at all. TV optional! Sure, bouts of *Mario Kart 8* aren't quite as great without a TV, but that doesn't happen that often in our house. Still, I was inclined to remove a console dependent on a TV for the *chance* that I might play the Switch in docked mode.

That's not to say I haven't tried playing a home console since. I recently hooked up my Xbox One to a smaller TV in our office with the intention of playing *Overwatch* with some friends. But after a week with *Overwatch*, I canceled my Xbox Live account and haven't touched the console on since.

A friend of mine recently picked up a 3DS. The 3DS has a deep catalog, but Pokémon was his draw. Meanwhile, the Switch was released. He eyed mine, but was reluctant to pick one up due to the limited gaming catalog. He's now put 120+ hours into *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*, completing the game and conquering all 120 shrines — a herculean feat. This friend and I have been going back and forth about Mario Kart, Zelda, and *Splatoon 2*. Should we get *ARMS*? How as *Super Mario Odyssey* at E3?

A colleague of mine took notice of my interest in video games. We got to talking and he let me in that he'd bought a Switch. A recent father, it was the perfect form-factor for him to use while nurturing his newborn. He completed *Breath of the Wild* long ago.

I've had more communication with friends and Twitter users regarding Switch experiences than I've ever had with PS4 or Xbox One. More than the gimmick of being able to play anywhere and with friends and family straight out of the box, people are investing in their experiences with the console and it's reincarnating the schoolyard conversations of yore.

Nintendo's design mastery certainly make their games ripe for conversation, but the fact that players can play the Switch on a TV, in bed, on trains, on planes, ~~at work~~, at the park, in hotels... you name it!... makes conversations fuller and more frequent.

Ben Lindbergh on the Achievement Oriented podcast recently entertained a question I imagine many Switch owners have asked themselves:

> *... As I was trying to make this journey home and failing for a day or so, I wanted to play Tacoma — because we had gotten our review codes for Xbox One and we knew that we were going to do a podcast about it — and I couldn't because Xbox One is not a portable console. I never would have thought anything of this in the past, but now that I am a Switch owner this just seems backwards.*
>
> *It's like I can't play Tacoma on the road? Now, of course you could get Tacoma for Steam, but I only had a netbook with me. I had no mouse or anything — I didn't want to play it that way and it's not quite the same — but what I'm wondering is, do you think future consoles will feel pressure to incorporate Switch functionality?*

> *If they announce PS5 a year from now and it has all the new specs, the graphics look great and a big hard drive and processor and gigaflops out the wazoo, but it doesn't have portability — it doesn't do what the Switch does — would you be disappointed? Do you feel like this has to be a component of every console going forward?*

The Switch should have been a no-brainer decision for consumers at announce. Tech shrinks. We've gone portable. Smart phones rule consumer tech. It was simply Nintendo's strike out with the Wii U that made the public more weary of Nintendo's execution on the promise than the promise itself.

The new PS4 Pro and Xbox One X tout teraflops, but they are still anchors. I've considered selling my PS4 and Xbox One not to upgrade, but to declutter. The Switch on the other hand is the perfect fit for my life. While I can't say I won't be buying home consoles in the future — hell, I purchased my Xbox One on the promise of *Below*, a game that has yet to see the light of day — unless new consoles offer the same portability as the Nintendo Switch, I will certainly be taking my time in purchasing one.

The Cubs Way, Music, and Management

August 12, 2017

Categories: Media, Sports, Work

"Is that Tom Waits?"

"Yeah. Do you like Tom Waits?"

"I love Tom Waits."



I am haunted by a childhood memory. Around age 13, my Little League coach and assistant coach had a falling out. Team practices were put on hold. For a kid unenthused about sports, you'd think this was a blessing. But the team was working well together and... winning!

We had a fantastic cast of characters resembling The Sandlot. There were Bennys, Hams, and Yeah-Yeahs. Maybe a Squints here and there. I myself felt like Smalls. We were a mixed bag, some with little to no skill, but we bonded. We helped each other. The loss of practice was arresting. Devastating.

Mike called me up. He was one of the leaders — very much a Benny type. He was organizing a practice and called me up to summon others. After we got off the phone, I had a thought: we should bring music. I loved doing any activity to music. I called Mike back.

He didn't call it a stupid idea, but he suggest that we didn't need it. I hung up and felt silly for the idea. I've never forgotten how embarrassed I felt for suggesting the idea.

In his fantastic book "The Cubs Way", author Tom Verducci notes an immediate tactic new Chicago Cubs coach Joe Maddon took with his team at the opening of the 2015 spring training — his first spring training with the team:

> *After Maddon's opening speech as Chicago manager, the Cubs took the field—actually, a wide swath of grass out in back of their training center—looking like a different team. The best way to measure the immediate change in the Cubs under Maddon was in decibels. As the team began its morning stretch, a huge speaker blasted "Voodoo Child" by Jimi Hendrix. What followed were more tunes from among Maddon's rock-and-roll favorites, including "Brown Sugar" by the Rolling Stones, "Gimme Three Steps" by Lynyrd Skynyrd, and "Tom Sawyer" by Rush.*
>
> *"I'm a product of the '60s and '70s," he told his new team. "You'll have to put up with that."*

After reading this passage, I felt vindicated. My 13-year-old self's idea was not stupid. Joe Maddon plays music. It's not that big of a deal. Scaling back a bit of focus for a bit of fun encourages free thinking and flow. (A big reminder that my 13-year-old self had shit for brains.)

I've recently taken on a new management role. It is challenging beyond belief. With these challenges, I've put lots of attention into how my manager runs his team. One of the simplest and subtlest tricks he uses is playing music during one-on-ones and meetings. At times, it can feel distracting, but more often than not, it lightens the mood and opens up conversations outside of work. In a recent case, we hit on our shared love of Tom Waits. (What's he building in there? A team. I'll stop.)

I've now applied music to my one-on-ones. Nothing too distracting. No early-'00s post-hardcore, '80s pop, or '70s prog rock. Mellow electronic, jazz, or my Apple Music Chill Mix do the trick. I think it's helping. It's lightened the mood. And — for me at least — makes me feel a bit more connected to my team.

Music can be an equalizer. Embrace it. There shouldn't be rules to how you manage or run your team meetings. Find energy. Find flow. Find commonality. And while you're at it, find a copy of "The Cubs Way".

Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle: "Just looking around is a joy"

August 27, 2017

Categories: Design

Patricia Hernandez in her review of *Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle* for Kotaku:

> *The game's zones are numbered similarly to Super Mario Bros.' in that there are worlds sectioned by levels—1-1, 1-2, and so on. Each area has its own Pixar-esque landscape, all themed in the most video-gamey way possible. Fire and ice world! Lava world! Obligatory starting-area-basic-forest world! It all seems crafted from clay. I don't think I saw a sharp edge throughout my adventures; that cartoon aesthetic, combined with the top-down camera, made me feel like a kid mashing together dolls from different sets.*
>
> *You can poke and prod some stuff around the overworld—there are some light environmental puzzles, and coins to collect—but just looking around is a joy. The haunted world, for example, is dotted with Boos, pipes stuffed with candles, and turbulent waters squeaking with rubber duckies. You move through these worlds controlling a party of three characters. I would run through everything and watch in awe as Mario stuck his arms out at top speed, Rabbids trailing behind him maniacally. The characters' animations oozed so much personality that, dozens of hours in, I still stopped to appreciate them.*

This echoes similar sentiments I published in my E3 recap:

> *Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle is the game I'm most looking forward to. It's gorgeous and surprisingly deep. I can't recall ever seeing the Mushroom Kingdom in such detail.*

I waited two hours to play 16 minutes of _Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle _at E3. Madness. But as crazy it was, the immaculate detail of the game's Mushroom Kingdom saved me from feeling it was a complete waste of time. Simply stunning.


Mario Rabbids Kingdom Battle Environment

Why I love video games

September 11, 2017

Categories: Media

Chris Plante in his first piece since returning to Polygon:

> *I love video games, but what I might love more is the opportunity I've had over the last decade to share the imperfect games with other people, people who might have otherwise passed them on their occasional visit to GameStop in search of Madden or Destiny, Grand Theft Auto or Call of Duty. I like finding greatness in the world's biggest games, too, but I recognize they set an expectation of polish and scope that so many games can't match. When I criticize a game, I do so to set expectations, to provide context, to interrogate what doesn't work and to shine a light on what does.*

This is exactly how I used to approach music and how I currently approach books. With music, it used to be a mainstream vs. indie thing, but I've learned to appreciate the big budget works for what they're worth as well. With books, it's less about popularity and more about topics—granularity.

In any case, it's great to see Plante back at it. A stellar writer and critic. We're lucky to read his work.

Traditional Games

October 19, 2017

Categories: Art, Design, Media

Walt Williams in his book 'Significant Zero':

> *A traditional game is a challenge in which a player's skill comes up again a rigid set of rules. Turn-based strategy, multiplayer death match, platformers—these are traditional. The modern, high-end, blockbuster AAA game is not a skill challenge. If it were, the player might fail and be disappointed, and then we wouldn't sell as many copies. The rules are fluid. We change them to create tension, surprise, or excitement. Saying yes to the player only goes so far, and that distance is the exact length required to make you feel in control.*

Last week, a colleague of mine asked how far I was into *Mario + Rabbids: Kingdom Battle*. I told him that I was in the middle of the fourth (and possibly last) stage — Lava Pit. (For what it's worth, I had recommended the game to him.) I also told him that playing *Mario + Rabbids: Kingdom Battle* was the most fun I'd had with a video game in a long time. *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* was great, but the aesthetic doesn't draw me back. Likewise, *Splatoon 2* is lots of fun, but only in casual, Mario Kart-style doses. *Mario + Rabbids: Kingdom Battlle* has me not only progressing through the main campaign, but backtracking to achieve better, cleaner results in previous battles and optional challenges.

Right now, it seems the "traditional" game is where I find fulfillment. When life feels like a maze, solving simple, zero-stakes problems — in a world you adore — is unbelievably gratifying.

If platformers fit into this bucket, then boy, oh boy am I looking forward to *Super Mario Odyssey*.

Super Mario Odyssey — A Review

November 19, 2017

Categories: Design, General, Review

This review covers the core game, which — arguably — may not be considered the "core" game.


Super Mario Odyssey, image 1

Everyone loves a Mario game. Polish, charm, fun. Mario games are a barometer of execution for each of Nintendo's console generations. Where they don't push boundaries of graphical fidelity or online community, they shape design language, innovation, and soul within the confines of a familiar world.

For the Switch, the promise of a high-fidelity, 3D, sandbox Mario game akin to _Super Mario 64 _has whetted the appetite for many a fan since its reveal in January 2017. It's big. It's beautiful. It's Mario. It's everywhere.

But is it familiar?

I had the opportunity to preview *Super Mario Odyssey* at E3 — an excerpt from my E3 experience below:

> *Odyssey feels like the perfect amalgam of all 3D Mario adventures: The playground of _Super Mario 64_'s introductory courtyard, _Super Mario Sunshine_'s NPCs, _Super Mario Galaxy_'s inventiveness, and _Super Mario 3D World_'s fidelity. Above all, there is a "weird" factor that has been generating buzz. The various worlds Mario can travel to feature a variety of art styles: the playable New Donk City feels like a Tony Hawk's Pro Skater / Sims hybrid while the Sand Kingdom felt like a traditional 3D Mario world with a new classic 2D side-scrolling mechanic added to the mix. (Think The Legend of Zelda: A Link Between Worlds.) The game played as great as you can imagine, but the real allure is looking forward to the* ***variety and trying to figure out just what the hell is going on****!*

It's this last (emphasized) phrase that I'm struggling with. At E3, I thought I was playing a sample of the complete game. I was sure there was something in the game that would tie the experience and aesthetic of the kingdoms together. Unfortunately, the worlds feel as disconnected as my preview experience.

Even for a franchise about an (ex-)plumber in a fantasy land inhabited by mushrooms and turtles, the story is bonkers. A captured Princess Peach is being forcibly wed to Bowser. Bowser is on a quest to find wedding hallmarks (a ring, a cake, etc.) while his wedding-planning henchmen, the Broodals, stave off Mario. The player is thrown into this storyline via an opening cinematic: Mario plunges to his doom from Bowser's airship, his iconic hat shredded to bits in the blades of the airship's motor. Wake to find Mario in a strange, noir themed world and introduced to his new sidekick Cappy. Then, the player is off on an adventure to stop Bowser.


Super Mario Odyssey, image 2

From the start, something feels off. It's disorienting not to kick off in Mushroom Kingdom, solely as a frame of reference. As Mario progresses from kingdom to kingdom, it's not clear how these

aesthetically diverse worlds fit into the once familiar Mario universe. While that's likely the point, they never quite feel like "Mario".

To progress from world to world, the player is expected to collect a certain number of Power Moons to power Mario's airship. While there is a clear target of power moons to collect, it's never clear if the player should collect as many as possible now or if there will be an opportunity to collect later.

I'm not a completionist. If anything, I'll blaze through a game as quickly as I can to relate to the zeitgeist. The idea that _Super Mario Odyssey _rests on the principle of collection is — dare I say — infuriating. Sure, collection is a core tenant of *Super Mario 64*. However, its hook comes from a limited but *achievable* set of 120 Power Stars as rewards for solving puzzles and riddles within the game's 15 stages. However, *Super Mario Odyssey* falls "short" due to abundance — 999 Power Moons spread across a like 15 stages.

It quickly becomes apparent that collecting is the name of this game. Beyond power moons, there are outfits and airship decor to purchase with two types of coin — gold coins as generic, globally accepted currency; purple coins as world specific currency. Purchasable items match the flavor of coin. Outfits purchasable with gold coins are easier to obtain and can be purchased anywhere in the game, while those only purchasable with purple coins require the player to search each world high and low for every specialty coin. Outfits and decorations provide no value outside of aesthetic, but the idea of collecting them sinks its hooks in nonetheless. As for the airship decor, I was not clear what it was initially. In fact, I hadn't purchased my first one until New Donk City.

 Super Mario Odyssey, image 3

Ah, New Donk City — Mario's foray into a world populated by actual humans(?) It's as wild as it sounds, but somehow, it is the most comfortable of the kingdoms the player visits. As mentioned above, the Tony Hawk / Sims vibe makes this concrete jungle surprisingly welcoming. So much so that I found myself trying to complete every little task in the world before moving on — something I hadn't tried in worlds previous and quickly dropped afterward.

It wasn't until New Donk City — 8 kingdoms in — that I felt like I understood the game on an objective level. While it's difficult to put my finger on what felt different, I understood objectively what needed to be done, how to do it, and what to look for. New Donk City feels as welcoming as *Super Mario 64*'s courtyard. It provides the opportunity, aesthetic, and space to mess around; to get comfortable. I can't help but feel New Donk City should have been the first full world in which Mario travels. By wholehearted breaking the art style of Mario games past, it communicates that Mario isn't in Kansas any more — things are going to get weird. But, it's a safe space. The platforming opportunities abound go a long way to bridge Mario games of yore into Odyssey and get the player comfortable with the mechanics and core controls. It is the prize of *Super Mario Odyssey*.

Until New Donk City, I felt like I was tip-toeing throughout the game, afraid to miss something important. Something wasn't clicking, which is a sour experience for a Mario game. At it's core, *Super Mario Odyssey* is awful about communication. It does not communicate what's necessary, what's optional, and of the optional, what is what.

After a week away from the game, New Donk City is what I keep coming back to. I only wish New Donk City was larger. It's a wonderful playground and an iconic area players will remember. My only hope is that _Super Mario Odyssey _— like *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* — is an expansion of what we know of the Mushroom Kingdom, or at least the universe in which it inhabits. I hope this is a

taste of what's to come for the Mario franchise — the characters and worlds introduced — or else what's the point?


Super Mario Odyssey, image 4

While playing, I strayed away from many reviews and opinions. Afterward, I needed validation that I wasn't crazy — that *Super Mario Odyssey* is very, very good, but not great. That something was off. I found solace from Justin McElroy on Polygon's *Quality Control* podcast:

> *It is hard to find — these days — a game where "progression" is not a large aspect of it. At least in the games that I find myself playing a lot. Almost every game has some sort of in-built role-playing system where you're getting better, you're getting more powerful, you're collecting more items, you're collecting more Pokémon — you're building a stable of those — you know. There's a sense of progression.*
>
> *For me, I weirdly felt myself not incentivized to play more Mario. Like, I enjoy my time with it, but I don't find myself... hooked. And I think it is because of that — because you can hunt down a bunch of moons in an individual level. But in the end, I don't feel stronger or that I've accomplished more, necessarily.*

Super Mario Odyssey is beautiful, charming, and expertly crafted — possibly the most polished and well designed game I've ever played. But the desire to jump back in never took hold. Beyond New Donk City, I wasn't particularly enchanted by any of the other worlds and found myself rushing through the game. That said, mid-way through, I'd begun hearing whispers of something amazing waiting at the end of the game.

Truth be told, the end delivered. All of the charm and soul I had been waiting for came to a head. A smile spread across my face — the same smile I imbued upon booting up this new Mario adventure for the first time. I only wish that smile had maintained throughout my experience with *Super Mario Odyssey*.

Good Enough

November 22, 2017

Categories: Business, Design, Technology

After listening to Polygon's Samit Sarkar discuss the Xbox One X on the Achievement Oriented podcast, I was *this* close to writing a piece simply titled "Good Enough" on the premise that the Nintendo Switch is just that — good enough; that bleeding-edge specs are not compelling enough to warrant the masses to upgrade consoles mid-cycle for already gorgeous experiences.

I'm glad Ben Kuchera at Polygon beat me to the punch :

> *Nintendo focused on making a system that was easy to use, relatively inexpensive and could be both a portable and a home console. The stats show that players are taking advantage of these factors, and the sales speak for themselves. In a business where it often seems like companies are killing themselves trying to push for the greatest visual fidelity possible, Nintendo has completely shifted the conversation to convenience and fun. The Switch is being richly rewarded for this approach.*
>
> *Nintendo has also changed the game when it comes to third-party developers. Visual quality is no longer the most important thing, the game just has to run well enough to be playable and enjoyable. A company's back catalog of older games is now a treasure trove of potential Switch ports. Fans are asking for any number of games from any number of companies to be brought to the console, and publishers would be wise to listen to them.*
>
> *The Nintendo Switch once again proves the value of changing the game if you can't win by the existing rules, and there's not much Microsoft or Sony can do to gain the same momentum with strategies that focus on raw power. Nintendo has this market all to itself, and that's a great place to be. The game developers just have to learn that looking good enough is a great way to sell a game to an appreciative audience.*

In August, I wrote about moving to handheld — shelving my PS4 and Xbox One and exclusively playing Switch and 3DS. I've since gone one step further by disconnecting the Switch dock from the TV. It now serves as a holster on my nightstand. There are games I yearn to try, but the thought of anchoring myself to our living room television just to partake in a boisterous chaos for my own pleasure seems irritating, selfish, and wasteful. I much prefer the experience of dipping in and out — sound off — while my wife and I relax together. Conversations aren't drown out. A quick press of the Switch's lock button not only pauses the experience, it completely disengages me when necessary. No static menu hogging the television screen. No anxiety about not being able to pause in certain areas.

I won't go as far as to say that mid-cycle upgrades are outlandish. There are small things I'd love to see enhanced on the Switch: smaller bezel, larger screen; better kickstand; move toward haptics vs. vibrate motors; better speakers. The one thing I haven't craved is better graphics — a statement I would not make for the 3DS. The Switch has hit a fidelity sweet spot.

This has been a long time coming. I would go as far as to say that the boom of pixel art, retro, and minimal art styles is a statement about bearable visuals as much as it is about style. What was novel has become an expected and even desired norm. This extends beyond mobile and casual games to hearty indies like *The Witness* and *Super Hot*.

The fact that new and recent third-party titles are making their way to the "underpowered" system is impressive. While we wait for Nintendo's online service / Virtual Console to make an appearance on the Switch, there is an abundance of third-party back-catalog that could be used as a testing ground. I cannot comment with any authority about cost to port legacy games vs current-gen, but I do know that there exists a wealth of proven titles that will run current hardware rather than gambling resources to *try* to port new titles to the Switch. Really, I'm just jonesing for *Final Fantasy X* and *Kingdom Hearts*.

New Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles Arcade Game

November 22, 2017

Categories: General

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ayM7Q8xnPTs

Arcade Heroes:

> *From what I have played and watched, it fulfills those expectations. The game is a beat 'em up just like you would want it to be. Yes that does mean more button mashing than stratagem but that's part of the charm. The turtles will also do different attacks such as throws and there are items to grab and use such as smoke bombs, shurikens, trash cans, one that makes you spin around in a kind of tornado attack, etc. There are plenty of enemies to duke it out with, there is interaction with your environment, multiple attacks including the ability to throw enemies into the screen, special "Turtle Power" attacks which behave as quick cut scenes, big boss battles, combo tracking, items to use and more. Admittedly it is weird to play a TMNT game that doesn't have the voices for the characters that I grew up with but that's 'old man – get off my lawn as I remember it' syndrome there.*
>
> *Beat 'em up fans can also take heart that the Raw Thrills development team stated that they played a number of classic beat' em ups as they designed this to "get the feel right". Apart from playing the original TMNT Konami titles, they specifically mentioned "Final, Fight, Golden Axe, Streets of Rage, Double Dragon" while also implying that they played through several others.*

TMNT beat 'em ups are a hallmark for a generation. Kids of the late '80s / early '90s cut their cartoon/video game/comic/action figure teeth with this franchise. I probably spent a small fortune of my parents money on the original TMNT cabinet. The NES, Super NES, and Genesis ports were some of my favorite games. I love any chance they get to make a comeback, especially in such a namesake format.

The execution of this cabinet looks and sounds extremely promising. I like to avoid Dave & Buster's whenever possible, but this may be hard to resist.

Big-N's Big Year

November 28, 2017

Categories: Business, General, Review

Since the failure of the Wii U, Nintendo's future had been in question. Sell to Disney? Sell to Apple? Retire Mario?

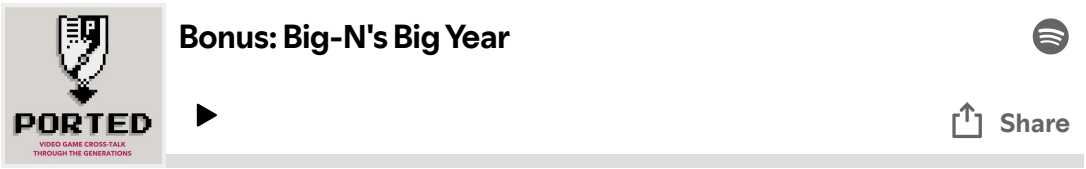
The question marks and judgement loomed with the 2016 announcement of Nintendo's new console, the Switch. A console poised to bring the worlds of mobile and set-top gaming together. The dream. But could a company founded on family friendly, under-powered hardware make a dent against the HD twins (PS4 and Xbox One) and a world where seemingly everyone above age 12 carries around a mobile supercomputer?

Questions. Questions. Questions.

In 2017, Nintendo answered.

Shortly after this piece was published Brendon Bigley, formerly of Anchor.fm, interviewed me to discuss the state of Nintendo. The interview was later added to the Ported Podcast feed.

You can also find the episode here:



Switch



The Switch is a literal game changer and its portable/set-top hybrid gimmick is working.

Released world-wide on March 3, 2017, the Switch has sold 7.63 million units as of September 30, 2017, according to Nintendo's six months financial results briefing for Fiscal Year Ending March 2018. To offer some context, Wii U shipped 3.61 million units in its first 7 months, PS4 sold 7.0 million in its first 5 months; 10 million in 10 months. Microsoft has kept much of the Xbox One's numbers quiet, but the console sold 3.9 million units in the first 2 months, almost 10 million in 12 months. For the long-game, the PS2 sold 155 million units. The anomalous Wii had lifetime sales of 101.63 million. Xbox 360 sold 84 million units. PS3 sold 80 million.

In the same briefing, Nintendo revealed that over 50% of owners play in both portable and TV modes, 30% play exclusively portable mode, and the remaining 20% play exclusively TV mode.

Compromises notwithstanding, there also seems to be a growing yearning for all games to be brought to the Switch. I've unhooked my PS4 and Xbox One. I've moved my Switch dock to my nightstand. I've gone full handheld. Nintendo has successfully untethered the console gaming experience from the TV, and it's difficult to go back. The divided worlds of handheld and set-top gaming have coalesced and

it's everything we'd ever dreamed it would be. Without a doubt, this is a future Nintendo has been envisioning since the wildly successful Game Boy.

The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild


The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild

Launched alongside the Switch in March, *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* came out of the gates a scorcher.

To set the stage, the initial teaser for the Wii U (prior to the announcement of the Switch) gave a glimpse of an open-world Hyrule, an art style blending _The Wind Waker_'s cell-shaded cartoon aesthetic and _The Twilight Princess_'s realism, and an action-packed cinematic:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XZmxvig1dXE

But it was still yet to be determined if Nintendo was truly offering the open-world 3D Zelda adventure fans had been dreaming of since the original?

Could Nintendo actually deliver an open-world game on par with the likes of Rockstar's *Grand Theft Auto* and Bethesda's *Skyrim*? If so, how would it innovate? How could it innovative? Would Nintendo's beloved IP be a fit for an experience of that magnitude? Could Nintendo deliver something of that size and scale?

Nintendo's 2016 E3 trailer would set imaginations ablaze:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1rPxiXXxftE

Nintendo seemed to be offering up answers to every question.

Lo and behold, they delivered one of the greatest, most innovative gaming experiences of all time. It not only checked every box and crossed off every worry, it set new standards for open-world games.

From the onset, the player is cast out into the world. There is little in the way of tutorials and much in the way of freedom. Players can roam anywhere and climb anything. The world is a sandbox that encourages invention by utilizing elemental chemistry. Damn near anything is possible. There is no standard way to play the game. Gating is thrown away in lieu of trusting the player to the creation of the designers. Both player and designer are treated with equal importance. In *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*, respect is a two-way street.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=30jGWna4-Ns

That's not to say that I think the game is perfect. I have my gripes. I feel the music is lacking. Aesthetically, it is not a world I'm keen to revisit. The sword delicacy is maligned. Characters — NPCs and enemies — become repetitive. There is a lack of character present in previous Zelda entries — namely *A Link Between Worlds*. While this list seems like it would break a game, these faults are surprisingly easy to look past. The game is just that good.

The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild is the best selling Switch title to date, now exceeding 4.7 million units. During its launch month, Zelda sold at an unprecedented 100% attach rate for the Swtich. The game maintains a 97 Metacritic score and boasts a 170 hour "completionist" play time on HowLongToBeat.com.

Regardless of your standard of measuring a game, one thing can be said — *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* is a special experience. Nintendo stripped one of their most beloved franchises down to its core and rebuilt it in a way that sets the standard for open-world games going forward.It is a triumph for a myriad of reasons; but most of all, like the Switch, it was reliving on a dream.

Mario Kart 8 Deluxe


Mario Kart 8 Deluxe

Wii U's abysmal sales are no indication of the quality of games produced for the console. Arguably, it's home to some of the greatest Nintendo titles ever — *Mario Kart 8*, *New Super Mario Bros. U*, *Super Mario 3D World*, *Super Smash Bros. for Wii U*, *Splatoon*, *Super Mario Maker*, *The Legend of Zelda: The Wind Waker HD*. The Wii U's hit to miss ratio is sure to be one of the lowest of any console, yet most potential players missed out on surefire classics. Thankfully, Nintendo bolstered the Switch's launch year line-up with one of the best.

Mario Kart is a household favorite franchise, and *Mario Kart 8* is the best of it's form. Selling 4.42 million units, porting the greatest Mario Kart game to the Switch so early in its lifecycle was a brilliant move. It allowed Wii U owners to share the experience with the uninitiated and show off the Switch's built in local multiplayer gimmick. Playing Mario Kart is like riding a bike. With the Switch's ever-present multiplayer, players can crack off the Joy-Cons and immediately share and experience. Maybe even an office tournament:

> *On Mario Kart 8 Deluxe_'s _release day, I brought my Switch to work. It was the perfect venue to test the Switch's out-of-the-box local multi-player experience. In fact, it was the first time I'd attempted any multi-player on the device in any of its various forms. As far as I know, I'm the only one in the office with a Switch. Gasps filled the room when I removed the Joy-Con from the display. I handed one over to a colleague, showed him around the tiny controller, and away we went.*

Mario Kart 8 Deluxe wasn't much more than Mario Kart 8 + the DLC with a new Battle Mode. Whereit falls short is it's insistence to unlock everything the original game had to offer. It's certainly a great value to provide new players with everything there is to offer, but nothing is left for anyone to pursue. I'd have loved to re-race for the cups I'd previously unlocked for the Wii U version. It was truly surprising how demotivating it was to play one of my favorite games when everything had been achieved for me.

However, while I still believe retailing for $60 is a bit high for the title, it can't be understated how great it is to have the highest-fidelity, local multiplayer ready, greatest Mario Kart game with you at all times.

Splatoon 2


Splatoon 2 (Support Local Game Stores)

In the vain of Wii U ports, *Splatoon 2*, the sequel to the Wii U's *Splatoon*, sold nearly 75% of the original within 2 months (3.61 compared to 4.87 million units).

Splatoon takes the shooter genre and turns it into a kid-friendly paintball frenzy. *Splatoon 2* added tot he experience by offering a single-player campaign. But the addictive core of the game is its short, territory-hording Turf Wars. Two teams do their best to ink as much of a stage's territory in their color while warding off the opposing team. The bouts are short and weigh-in much like a Mario Kart race. It's always anybody's game. Players can feel just as important in supporting roles as they can on offense.

Splatoon 2 was the first game to support Nintendo's Switch Online iOS and Android app. Though, much ire was drawn by the app's poor online chat service. (Players are forced to route communications through their smartphone as opposed to the Switch.) I have not had an opportunity to use the app, so I will not comment.

In addition to a problematic smartphone app, my main gripes with *Splatoon 2* are the inability to back out of lobbies while waiting for players as well as the near impossible task of playing with folks on your friends list. It's infuriating.

However, the core game is still a delight and shows off the prowess of the Switch's online multiplayer — at least once a match is underway. _Splatoon 2_'s stylistically original and serves as an inviting experience for all next to its gritty wartime counterparts.

Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle


Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle

In August, Ubisoft delivered the first Mario experience on the Switch. Yes. Ubisoft. Not Nintendo. Ubisoft. Trusted with Nintendo's icon and core franchise, Ubisoft delivered not only a charming title on par with other Mario entries, but a tight, satisfying, and unique strategy game to boot.

In the vain of XCOM, *Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle* plays like cartoon chess. The player selects a team of three (Mario + two other characters, so long as one is a Rabbid) to battle a slew of Rabbid baddies in a series of turn-based bouts across 4 worlds. As players progress, weapons are upgraded and skills are gained. There are plenty of collectibles to keep completionists active. Difficulty spikes are educational rather than infuriating. And the Mushroom Kingdom is more gorgeous than ever.

VGChartz puts the game at 0.51 million units sold, which doesn't seem like a huge disappointment, but for a game that I thoroughly enjoyed, I'd like to see it bump up a bit this holiday season. *Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle* is an absolute delight.

Nindies


Stardew Valley

Say nothing of big third-party titles like *Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle*, *Skyrim*, or *Doom*, the growing selection of top-notch indie — or "Nindie" — titles is nothing to scoff at.

One of the biggest concerns of Nintendo is their seeming inability to attract third-parties to their consoles since the SNES. The Switch is no different. It *is* the "second console". But, boy has it attracted grade-A titles. The current #Nindie Hits roster looks a little something like this:

- *Shovel Knight: Treasure Trove*

- *Rocket League*
- *Stardew Valley*
- *Overcooked*
- *Axiom Verge*
- *Retro City Rampage DX*
- *Cave Story*
- *Severed*
- *SteamWold Dig 2*
- *Golf Story*
- *TumbleSeed*
- *Thumper*
- *and more!*

While Nintendo has been quiet on first-party titles for 2018, the plethora of indies (and major third-parties) porting to the console provides Switch owners a stable of great games for months, nay, years to come.

SNES Classic


SNES Classic in box

Boy howdy, get the nostalgia intoxicated ready. On the heels of Nintendo's wildly... successful(?) NES Classic came the SNES Classic. With a library of 21 classic — arguably essential — games, the SNES Classic was/is the hot item of 2017.

Launching on September 29, 2017, retail lines and online pre-orders were a mess. I'd imagined Nintendo had learned from the missteps of the NES Classic, but seemingly, no. Initially, it may have been easier to stumble across one, but it has again turned into a frenzy for the little throwback.

Whatever the issue, be it awful channel supply or manufacturing woes, the Classic series is another fortune in Nintendo's pocket — if not monetarily, for the press coverage.

Super Mario Odyssey


Super Mario Odyssey - Cloud Kingdom

Super Mario. The pinnacle of Nintendo's franchises.

A new Mario title is something special. The best video game maker does not squander its resources on Mario. Nintendo uses Mario to define console generations, gameplay innovation, artistic direction, and design standards. Mario is as much an icon as he is a vision.

Super Mario Odyssey launched on October 27, 2017 — 7+ months into the Switch's lifecycle. It is a reimagining of the Mario series, with a series of worlds outside of the Mushroom Kingdom in a play-style similar to arguably the most important Super Mario game of all time — *Super Mario 64*. (If that last sentence gives you pause, just wait until you beat the game.)

Like Zelda, I have my qualms with *Super Mario Odyssey*. The world design is too disjointed without a cohesive story. The move-set is over-the-top. The inability to distinguish what Cappy (Mario's new

hat-companion) can and can't possess is frustrating. The music sides cinematic over thematic. The main storyline is… odd, if not gross. Overall, little outside of New Donk City is memorable.

My misgivings aside, numbers speak for themselves. Like Zelda, *Super Mario Odyssey* boasts a 97 Metacritic score. "Within three days of its release, the game had sold over two million copies worldwide." (Wikipedia) Nintendo of Europe claimed that *Super Mario "Odyssey* is both the fastest-selling Mario game and Switch game ever in the region."

Super Mario Odyssey is without a doubt a change of pace for the franchise. While I do wish the execution was a bit tighter, I am likely in the minority. Through and through, it is a quintessential Mario game. It is undoubtedly fun and innovative; charming and warm. It is the perfect nightcap to Nintendo's fantastic year.

Game of the Year


Zeldas on Switch and 3DS

From the launches of the Switch and *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* in March, the announcement of a Nintendo theme park, frenzied and flawed retailing of the SNES Classic in September, to the heralded *Super Mario Odyssey* in October and stable 3DS sales throughout, 2017 was Nintendo's year.

Nintendo has established that great gaming experiences should not be limited to TVs. It's hard to imagine the Switch wasn't always the company's vision. The Game Boy sold 118.69 million units. The DS: 154.02 million. The 3DS: 68.98 million and remaining stable. The Wii U, while a flop, put the writing on the wall. Porting gameplay to the GamePad was a now obvious sneak peek at the future we'd all been dreaming of.

The company is projecting nearly double operating profit from the previous fiscal year, forecasting 960 billion yen ($8.6 billion), up from 489 billion ($4.39 billion). While it seems obvious that the 3DS line will eventually spin down, they've just released the new 2DS XL line as well as decent stream of games. Meanwhile, the Switch is just getting started on what appears to be a very bright future.

‘But then Nintendo released The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild’

December 9, 2017

Categories: Business, Design, General

Victor Luckerson recapping Nintendo's year as "The Best Tech Story of 2017"for The Ringer:

> *It all seemed like enough to burn through the last of gamers’ goodwill for the often maddening company. But then Nintendo released The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild, and a lifetime’s worth of anti-consumer transgressions were suddenly forgiven. In an era filled with cynical IP cash-ins across entertainment, Nintendo used a formulaic, nostalgic franchise to deliver a fresh reinvention of open-world gaming mechanics. The game is an adept mix of old and new, borrowing elements of Skyrim and Minecraft but augmenting them to recreate the whimsy, mystery, and intrepidness that a lot of gamers felt the first time they booted up the original Legend of Zelda or the seminal Ocarina of Time. The gushing praise for the game, the best-reviewed title of the year, proved that endlessly cynical gamers will always have a soft spot for a Nintendo classic done right.*
>
> *Zelda immediately transformed the Switch from a curiosity to a must-have gadget. Gamers like Yai Torres, a 30-year-old resident of Arlington, Virginia, who had skipped out on the Wii U, got the system the day it launched. “It’s been a while since I’ve had a Nintendo product but I’ve always been a follower in terms of the latest games,” Torres says. “The fact that they had such a cool console with such a cool game clicked for me.”*

I'm still pondering whether *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* may be a bigger achievement than the Switch. Would Nintendo have had such a stellar year if the Switch launched with *Super Mario Odyssey*?

(Aside: Fun to see Victor end his piece where I was originally going to begin mine: the insanity of 2017.)

Nintendo Switch Sells 10 Million Units in 9 Months

December 12, 2017

Categories: Business

Wow. 10 million units in 282 days.

Note the Wii U had lifetime sales of 13.56 million units. The highly successful PS4 sold 10 million units in 268 days. The Xbox One sold *nearly* 10 million in 355 days.

What a year it has been for Nintendo and the Switch.

[_Correction_: I originally posted that the PS4 sold 10 million units in 10 months, out-paced by the Switch. This was incorrect.]

Nintendo of America launches Nintendo Power Podcast

December 23, 2017

Categories: General

Nintendo:

> *Nintendo of America has released the very first episode of its new Nintendo Power Podcast. With Nintendo Power Podcast, Nintendo employees, developers and special guests discuss the world of Nintendo – from Mario to the Legend of Zelda, and everything in between.*
>
> *The first episode of the powered-up podcast features an in-depth interview with Nintendo developers Eiji Aonuma and Hidemaro Fujibayashi about the making of the Legend of Zelda™: Breath of the Wild game.*
>
> *Also, Nintendo of America employees Chris Slate (previously editor-in-chief of _Nintendo Power_ ™ magazine), Damon Baker (from Publisher and Developer Relations) and Kit Ellis (co-host of Nintendo's weekly YouTube show Nintendo Minute) take a look back at Nintendo's action-packed 2017.*

I missed the boat on the original Nintendo Power magazine. As a Genesis kid, Nintendo Power was the extra flair that made me envious of my NES and SNES owning schoolyard peers. A brilliant marketing gimmick that helped build Nintendo's IP into cultural touchstones for our generation.

Hearing word of Nintendo's newly launched Nintendo Power Podcast rekindled those old memories — a new marketing gimmick and bolstering of IP for a new generation. And I'm happy to report that the podcast is a quality production that extends beyond news and marketing fluff. The banter from hosts Slate, Baker, and Ellis is honest and really no different than some of my favorite podcasting cross-talk, but with nice perspective from within the company. The quiz section is a great hit of nostalgia. And the interview with Eiji Aonuma and Hidemaro Fujibayashi sheds light on much of the design origins and thinking behind one of the greatest games ever made.

It is with relief that I see potential for depth in this show. It seems Nintendo understands the overlap of podcast consumers and Switch owners — 77% of podcast consumers range between the ages of 18-54; 80% of Switch owners range between the ages of 19-44. That's not a market for pure marketing fluff.

The final touch of polish is that n the theme; an evolution of of Nintendo console sound design. It reminded me of the logo I designed for the Ported Key:



‘In 2017, I Turned to Video Games to Avoid Trump and Conspiracy Twitter’

December 27, 2017

Categories: General, Politics

Justin Charity, The Ringer:

> *These alternative histories are false — but thrilling. My playing through them isn’t exactly productive, but I can’t say that my year-long gaming retreat has felt any more wasteful than the supposedly more mature engagement with politics by way of media, including social media. Wolfenstein II is escapism; and so, for the most part, is the ongoing debate about whether classical liberals should punch Nazis: They both induce fantasies about power and choices that most of us are unlikely to prosecute in the real world. Ideally, we organize. We lobby elected officials, we activate our neighbors and whatever followers we have, and we vote. But American progress is a long haul. In the grand scheme of Trump’s presidency, a 100-hour role-playing game is still a much more sensible way for me to squander my downtime than reading viral strains of conspiracy theory, surrendering what little serenity I have left in these dire times. If I want to obsessively watch the world collapse at the hands of a corporatist egomaniac, I’ll replay Horizon: Zero Dawn.*

The Verge: ‘Nobody would be talking about the Switch if it wasn’t for the games’

December 27, 2017

Categories: Business, General

Andrew Webster on Nintendo's A+ "Verge 2017 tech report card":

> *Hardware has rightfully been the focal point of Nintendo’s 2017, but nobody would be talking about the Switch if it wasn’t for the games. And Zelda isn’t enough to make a successful console. That was one of the Wii U’s biggest issues; while it had some excellent titles, there were often months that went between notable releases. Since the Switch debuted in March, Nintendo has released a steady stream of acclaimed games, several which were ports or sequels to Wii U games that not enough people played. Mario Kart 8 got a deluxe edition, for instance, while the colorful shooter Splatoon received a revamped sequel. And while most of the third-party games on Switch were ports, with older games like LA Noire and Skyrim, they felt new and exciting again on the hardware.*

I still believe there is a valid debate for Nintendo's greater achievement of 2017: The Switch or *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*.

(*Note*: Nintendo received the first A+ Verge tech report card.)

Joy-Confirmation

December 28, 2017

Categories: General

Andrew Goldfarb reporting for IGN:

> *According to Koizumi, part of Switch's appeal may be the hardware itself, which allows playing to be a different social experience than smartphones can offer.*
>
> *"Just to add a little bit to this idea of how people viewing smartphones as an influence on the future of portable gaming, I certainly wanted to see all the possibilities of having controllers that could be separated from the hardware, so that you could be able to hand one to another person in a variety of different environments," Koizumi added. "I think that really represents an amazing advantage over smartphones. That was something that we had focused on very clearly as something we could achieve to reach that distinction."*

It may not add much weight, but here's an image after my younger cousins swarmed me at Christmas, asking if I owned the Switch:


Switch dreamz

Miyamoto: ‘I always look for designers who aren’t super-passionate game fans’

December 30, 2017

Categories: Business, Design, General

Simon Parkin reporting for The New York Times:

> *Even people like Mr. Miyamoto, 65, a leading figure at Nintendo since the 1980s, is ceding control at the company’s Japanese headquarters.*
>
> *“More and more I am trying to let the younger generation fully take the reins,” Mr. Miyamoto said.*
>
> *This younger generation has been carefully chosen; Mr. Miyamoto says he wants people who are more likely to create new kinds of play, rather than merely aim to perfect current ones.*
>
> *“I always look for designers who aren’t super-passionate game fans,” Mr. Miyamoto said. “I make it a point to ensure they’re not just a gamer, but that they have a lot of different interests and skill sets.” Some of the company’s current stars had no experience playing video games when they were hired.*

Switch Sales Top PS2 in First-Year, Wii U Lifetime in Japan

December 30, 2017

Categories: Business

Allegra Frank, Polygon:

> *Nintendo Switch has had a huge December over in Japan, with nearly 900,000 systems sold by Dec. 24. Based on the most recent cumulative sales data from Famitsu, the country's biggest gaming publication, Nintendo has now sold just under 3.3 million Switch consoles in its homeland — both edging out PlayStation 2's first-year sales numbers and matching Wii U's lifetime sales to date.*

Astonishing.

Dark Souls: Remastered Announced for Nintendo Switch

January 11, 2018

Categories: Business

During today's Nintendo Direct Mini, Nintendo announced *Dark Souls: Remastered* will be heading to the Switch on May 25, 2018. The title will also be launching on PC, PS4, and Xbox One.

This continues a trickle of AAA third-party ports to the hybrid portable/set-top console. In 2017, among other third-party ports, Bethesda released *Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim* and *DOOM* to the console and will soon to be releasing *Wolfenstein 2: New Colossus*.

Dark Souls was originally released in 2011 for PS3 and Xbox 360. It spawned two sequels and riff *Bloodborne*.

I have never played a *Souls* game. The idea of sitting in front of a TV, beating my head against an insanely difficult boss for hours on end is not a luxury my life can afford. However, doing so on a portable console is a whole different story.

Killing hours traveling, accompanying my wife on the sofa, relaxing in bed, stealing myself away to *any* place to chip away at a game are the reasons I've tucked my consoles away. Furthermore, the ability to quickly put the Switch to sleep and seamlessly launch back into a title make it my ultimate gaming device. For all of these reasons, I feel the Switch will allow me to join the *Souls* conversation, finally.

While *Dark Souls: Remastered* is the first of the series, the announcement of another classic PS3/Xbox 360 port to the Switch extends my enthusiasm for the console. I'm reminded of how tickled I was seeing this tweet by Jon Cartwright:

https://twitter.com/NomComms/status/948645714036273152

Honestly, it's remarkable to see a Nintendo console glean so much third-party support. I'll just keep my fingers crossed for *Cuphead*.

‘Everyone feels lost all the time’

January 14, 2018

Categories: Business

Uncharted director and writer Amy Hennig and Campo Santo (*Firewatch*) founder Sean Vanaman in conversation for Polygon's excellent *2017 Year in Review* essay series:

> ***Amy Hennig:*** *I talk to students and young developers sometimes, and they’re always sort of amazed to find out that everybody has imposter syndrome.*
>
> ***Sean Vanaman:*** *I still feel like I’m ripping everyone off.*
>
> ***Amy Hennig:*** *You look back at your own work and go, “I’m not even sure how I did that.”*
>
> ***Sean Vanaman:*** *Exactly.*
>
> ***Amy Hennig:*** *So even though you have this underlying sense of faith and tell yourself, “Well, I’ve been here lots of times, and I’ve always figured out a way to solve these problems, so I’ve got to relax and assume that I will figure it out again,” in the moment you’re like, “I don’t know how I did that before. I don’t know what I’m doing.” And everybody feels that way. It’s something I haven’t heard creative people talk about that much until recently. I always hear this sigh of relief when I bring it up. Everyone feels lost all the time.*

This is a wonderful conversation between polar perspectives. Whether you're running a large ship or a tiny dinghy, self-doubt is inevitable. I'll add that it's not just the captains that encounter it.

The quicker everyone and lay bare their uncertainties, the quicker the entire crew can sail in the same direction.

Nintendo: Crazy Toy-Con Maker

January 17, 2018

Categories: Business, Children, Design, Education

Michael McWhertor, Polygon:

> *Labo will let Nintendo Switch owners build cardboard versions of real-world items like a 13-key piano, fishing rod or motorbike. Nintendo calls those cardboard creations Toy-Cons. And, by inserting Joy-Con controllers into those Toy-Cons, players will be able to play games themed to the cardboard creations.*
>
> *"With each Nintendo Labo kit, kids can transform modular sheets of cardboard – specially designed to interact with the Nintendo Switch console and Joy-Con controllers — into creations called Toy-Con," Nintendo said. "As you build, you will have fun discovering how the technology works, and might even invent new ways to play with each Toy-Con!"*

No one could have predicted Toy-Con. Try as you might, cardboard attachment kits for the Switch are not just out of left field, they are on a different pitch altogether.

There is an increasing wealth of junior robotics and toy-to-life experiences on the market. This is a clever, unique take on that market — and does Google Cardboard one better.

When folks call Nintendo a crazy toymaker, they're not joking.

Nintendo Stock Jumps 4.2% After Labo Reveal

January 20, 2018

Categories: Business, Children

Christopher Dring, GamesIndustry.biz:

> *Nintendo's share have risen more 4.2% and hit an almost ten-year high following the reveal of its Labo concept.*
>
> *Nintendo Labo is a toys-to-life style Switch project, which combines the Switch hardware with DIY cardboard models to create new gameplay experience. The concept is targeted at younger gamers, although judging by the online reaction, is going to appeal quite broadly.*
>
> *We're not entirely convinced by its commercial potential (although it does look great), but Nintendo shareholders clearly are. At the time of writing, Nintendo's share price is the highest it has been since 2008 on the Tokyo Stock Exchange. It currently sits at ¥48,320, which is the highest since September 2008, during the initial comedown of the Wii and DS.*

Cardboard — overhead: low; margin: very high.

Nintendo Switch Is the Fastest-Selling Console in U.S. History

January 22, 2018

Categories: Business

John Ballard, The Moty Fool:

> *The best-selling console ever is the PS2, which launched in 2000 and sold 157.68 million units over its life cycle, according to VGChartz. Sony shipped 10.61 million units in the first year of PS2 sales.*
>
> *Nintendo's all-time best-selling game console -- Wii -- sold more than 4 million units within the first 10 months, and totaled 101.63 million units over its life cycle.*
>
> *As for Switch, management says it expects Switch sales to reach 16 million by the end of Nintendo's fiscal year in March 2018. That puts Switch way ahead of PS2, and on pace to be the best-selling console ever.*

Big-N's Big Year, indeed.

Nintendo Switch breaks records for first-year US sales

March 21, 2018

Categories: Business

GamesIndustry.biz:

> *According to data from the NPD Group, the device has now achieved more year-one sales than any other console in history. While no figure was specified, it's likely to be well over five million, as Nintendo reported 4.8 million sales in the US by the end of 2017.*

Switch Ports Hamstrung by Mario Carts

March 24, 2018

Categories: Design, Technology

Christopher Dring in conversation with Ralph Egas, CEO of Abstraction Games:

> *He continues: "Performance is not really the issue. The issue instead is in the size of carts. The 32GB carts are expensive, you shouldn't be wanting to do that. So we need to fit everything on 16GB, whereas the standard game on PS4 is much, much larger. It's a crazy ratio we're talking about. However, thankfully, there are a lot of opportunities for reduction without changing anything anyone will notice. Another thing we can do is do a cartridge version and then do staggered downloads to make the game complete. That's probably the hardest part. Finding all the new technicalities and quirks that you get with a new platform.*

Interesting and somewhat encouraging that performance isn't the primary challenge of porting to the Switch. Also encouraging that dual-layer DVDs — the ancient technology used by the PS2 and Xbox 360 — maxed out at 8.5 GB. (Apparently, Xbox 360 discs topped out at 7.95 GB.) Thus, I remain hopeful for Final Fantasy X and Kindgom Hearts ports.

Please forgive me for the headline.

Cross-Network Play is "the Next Logical Step"

March 25, 2018

Categories: Business

Matthew Handrahan, GamesIndustry.biz:

> *Epic believes that the same process is starting to happen in markets like the US and Europe, thanks in no small part to refinements and improvements made to the Unreal Engine. During State of Unreal, Studio Wildcard's co-founders Doug Kennedy and Jesse Rapczak came onstage to talk about Ark: Survival Evolved on mobile, and announced that it was being ported for Nintendo Switch. Sweeney also mentioned the mobile version of PlayerUnknown's Battlegrounds, which was first announced in November last year.*
>
> *Another example is, of course, Epic's own Fortnite, which Sweeney believes is "unique" even within the context of the larger trend; principally because the work Epic has done to make it possible will benefit anyone that uses the Unreal Engine.*
>
> *"So that they can do the same thing," Sweeney adds. "And that is build one unified game that runs on all platforms, that is the same experience everywhere, and is a social experience that you can play with friends across all of the different platforms.*
>
> *"What we have is this one engine that's supporting AAA production values and game sizes and content bases that runs everywhere. This is going to be a great setup for the games industry, because it means that now you don't have a divide between casual mobile games and high-end PC and console games."*

For Epic, this all makes complete sense and will give Unreal Engine a massive leg up as a development tool.

I wrote about the need for cross-network play in my piece Sold on Cross-Network Play. Much of the piece — albeit not transparently — stemmed from my frustration of having to hook up my Xbox One to play *Overwatch* with my friends. It was extremely encouraging to learn that players of *Minecraft* and _Rocket League _would be able to share experiences between Switch, Xbox One, and Steam.

Sony claims that their reluctance of opening cross-network play is out of protection of their community. I think that is a fair stance, but is the Sony community any less toxic than others? I think the real fear is losing an amount of ability to lock in players to PlayStation 4. It's the same case made for exclusive games and content, the latter I vehemently oppose.

Maybe it's just the era I grew up in, but I believe in exclusive first-party experiences. Beyond the console wars which were somewhat steeped in technology battles as much as publishing and political ones, there is something to be said for the marriage of first-party hardware and software. Nintendo and Apple are prime examples this, creating unique and often stellar experiences by leveraging both sides of the stack.

Sony can hold their own when it comes to exclusives. It's time to open the network.

Building Zero Counts

March 25, 2018

Categories: General

Note: You will find several edits from 1/27/19 below as I made dramatic changes away from a separate mobile theme to a fully responsive site.

Since launching Zero Counts in 2014, I've spent a number of hours overhauling the 'Chunk' WordPress theme into a design of my own.

In 2017, inspired by reading Huffington Post Highline's 'Millenials Are Screwed' feature on iPhone X, I decided it was time for Zero Counts to introduce a mobile theme — an OLED-first one at that. (Also, I needed to beat Gruber at his own game.) But I had no idea how or where to start.

My workflow for editing Zero Counts' theme consisted of searching for the theme's style.css on my host, copying the file to my desktop, guessing the appropriate CSS changes, copying the file back to my host via FTP, and crossing my fingers.

Meanwhile, my day job was increasingly spent in Sublime Text, Sourcetree, Github, and leveraging a CI/CD (Jenkins) — most of which had been foreign to me months prior. I was learning the benefits of local testing, change tracking, and automated deployments.

In a fit of panic, I realized how risky it was to be iterating on the Zero Counts theme in production. Whoops!

With my desire to launch a mobile theme, so grew my desire to overhaul my development workflow. At the top of 2018, I got cracking.

Goals

- Test locally
- Track changes
- Break out child theme
- Create mobile version
- Deploy automatically to production
- Bonus: Develop on iOS

Tools

- Domain: Hover
- Hosting: Dreamhost
- CMS: WordPress
- Text editor: Sublime Text
- FTP client: Transmit
- Local server stack: MAMP
- Git repo: Atlassian Bitbucket
- CI/CD: Atlassian BitBucket Pipelines
- Git GUI: Atlassian Sourcetree

- iOS Git GUI: Working Copy

Theme Research

Before doing anything, I needed to get a bit more comfortable with how WordPress themes worked. WIRED's Jake Spurlock kindly pointed me in the direction of WordPress.org's theme documentation.

Local Testing

Luckily, the documentation also included details on setting up a local development environment.

More specifically, I needed to set up MAMP (Macintosh, Apache, MySQL, and PHP) on my Mac. This provides, among other things, a local MySQL database for a local WordPress install to read from. WordPress.org has a great article about setting up MAMP here.

Ultimately, I needed to:

1. Download and install MAMP. (The free version should do the trick.)
2. Set up MAMP Settings. (My set up show Apache Port: 8888, Nginx Port: 7888, MySQL Port: 8889, Web Server: Apache, Document Root: ~/Sites)
3. Start MAMP and create a database. (From the phpMyAdmin, I created a database called zerocounts_net.)
4. Download and install WordPress locally in ~/Sites/[site name].

Because Zero Counts has existing posts, I exported them from my production database on ZeroCounts.net. To import them into the newly created local database, from the WordPress dashboard:

1. Click Tools
2. Click Export
3. Select 'All content'
4. Click Download Export File

An XML file with all of my posts was downloaded to my computer and ready to be uploaded to my local PHP database. With MAMP servers started, I entered phpMyAdmin, selected my newly created database, clicked the 'Import' tab, chose the XML file that was downloaded from ZeroCounts.net, and specified format: XML. This injected all of my existing posts (plus lot of other stuff) into the local MySQL database.

Finally, I had to update the `siteurl` and `home` fields in the new imported database's `wp_[suffix]_options` table to point to my local site. These were both updated to 'https://localhost/[site name]'

At this stage, my local site had all of my content, but certainly didn't look like Zero Counts. I still needed to inject my custom theme. Before that, I wanted to begin tracking changes.

Change Tracking

I won't go into the technical details of git repositories (repos) as I'm still getting my sea-legs. What I will say is the primary use case is to see a log of code changes and comments associated with the

commits for quick investigation, reversions, and collaboration.

Git repositories can exist locally and/or remotely. In the case of Zero Counts, I develop locally using the local WordPress install I configured above, commit (save with a comment to myself) my changes, then push (upload) those code changes and commit details to my remote git repository. I can then go to another device — say my iPad (more on this in a bit) — pull (download) those code changes and commits, and be running/viewing the same code locally on another device. Think of it as a very manually, albeit safe, way of syncing my website's code between devices.

GitHub is seemingly the standard when it comes to remote git repositories; however, with a free account, one can only create public repositories. I.e. my code would be publicly viewable. Private repositories are available on GitHub to paid accounts starting at $7/mo. [EDIT 1/27/19] — GitHub now offers unlimited private repositories with their free membership.

As a hobbyist, paying for a private repo that I may not use frequently seemed silly. Luckily, there is a solution in Atlassian's Bitbucket. For a novice like myself, seeing little difference between GitHub and Bitbucket, Bitbucket offers free private repositories and therefore a membership from me!

Atlassian also offers a robust Git GUI for macOS and Windows called Sourcetree. There's some peace of mind using a single developer's sibling software and service together. As a bonus, I already had some familiarity with Sourcetree from my day job.

With a Bitbucket account created, I downloaded and installed Sourcetree. I created a new local repository in directory /wp-content/themes/ titled [theme]-child, where [theme] is the name of my default theme. (This will make sense soon.) [EDIT 1/27/19] — I created a new local repository in directory /Sites/[site name]. I checked the "create remote repository" box and signed into my Atlassian account. This created an empty repository on my Bitbucket account for my entire WordPress child theme install.

[EDIT 1/27/19] — Now, before pushing the local repository to the remote repository, it's import to ensure git is ignoring the file wp-config.php. This file contains the variables that point your WordPress install to the appropriate database where your raw content lives. Ie. The wp-config.php file on computer should be pointing to your local database while the wp-config.php file on your remote host should be pointing to your remote database. Sourcetree allows you to easily add wp-config.php to your .gitignore file by simply clicking the "..." next to the file name in the File Status menu before your first push.

Child Theme

WordPress themes are great starting places. Chances are, a WordPress user will want to make changes to the theme's style. With most themes, users can make small appearance tweaks (colors, fonts, etc.) using the simple Appearance editor. Some users many want to go a bit further with how their theme looks and begin digging into the actual CSS.

Some WordPress themes allow for custom CSS that overrides the default theme's style.css via the Appearance editor. However, there may be bits of the theme that don't exist within style.css and users will need to poke around in the theme's many PHP files. This can be a bit overwhelming if you have no familiarity with code. If one is able to successfully make changes to the PHP files, be careful. Changes

to themes are typically overridden with regular theme updates. Instead of editing the theme directly, one should create a child theme from the default theme.

In an FTP client, copy the contents of folder /wp-content/themes/[theme] into the new local directory /wp-content/themes/[theme]-child.

Open the new child theme's style.css file and edit the initial comment as follows:

```
/*
Theme Name: [Theme] Child
Theme URI: https://domain.com/wp-content/themes/[theme]-child/
Description: [Theme] Child Theme
Author: [Your name]
Author URI: https://domain.com/wp-content/
Template: [theme]
Version: 1.0
License: GNU General Public License v2 or later
License URI: http://www.gnu.org/licenses/gpl-2.0.html
Tags: [comma separated tags]
Text Domain: [theme]-child
*/
```

With a child theme established, the child theme will adopt core PHP updates from the default theme without interrupting your CSS and miscellaneous PHP changes.

Responsive Design

[EDIT 1/27/19] — In the original version of this post, I detailed hacking WordPress JetPack's mobile theme to offer up a drastically different look and feel of Zero Counts to mobile users. While novel, this provided some problems:

1. Managing two different themes
2. Drastically different UI elements between the "white" desktop site and the "black" mobile theme
3. Spotty results when visiting from difference device types
4. SEO incompatibilities
5. Constantly dismissing JetPack mobile theme files upon JetPack updates

Turns out, the crew at JetPack does not recommend using the built in mobile theme. During some troubleshooting back and forth, their recommendation was not to use the built in mobile theme as it hadn't been updated in several years.

I took this as a sign to rethink my mobile theme strategy and simply rebuild Zero Counts to be truly responsive. I decided that I must preferred my "black" mobile theme and would use this as the theme for all devices. I just needed it to scale between screen/window sizes. Luckily, there some pre-built open-source frameworks that provide easily controllable grid systems for truly responsive site design. I chose Twitter's Bootstrap. Bootstrap includes plenty of bells and whistles, but all I wanted to leverage is the grid system — a system that allows you to place your content into a 12 column grid. This allows me to define specific elements to resize depending on a few common device screen sizes.

Adding the Bootstrap grid to my theme was as simple as downloading the compiled CSS and JS, copying the /css/ folder into my child theme's directory, and invoking it by adding the following `wp_enqueues` to my child theme's functions.php:

```
wp_enqueue_style( 'bootstrapgrid', get_stylesheet_directory_uri() . '/css/bootstrap-grid.min.css' );
wp_enqueue_script( 'bootstrap-script', get_stylesheet_directory_uri() . '/js/bootstrap.min.js', array(
```

From there, I needed to add new HTML into some of my child theme's PHP files.

In my index.php file, I wrapped my `<div id="contents">` in the following:

```
<div class="row">
<div class="col-xs-1 col-lg-2"></div>
<div class="col-xs-10 col-lg-8">
…
</div>
</div>
</div>
```

The Bootstrap grid requires elements adhering to the grid to be placed in rows; hence, the first `<div>`.

The second `<div>`, `<div class="col-xs-1 col-lg-2"></div>`, carves out a "margin" in the first column for extra small, small, and medium sized devices; but on large devices to span the "margin" to two columns.

The third `<div>`, `<div class="col-xs-10 col-lg-8"></div>` — where my "content" lives — tells my theme to span the container containing my content 10 columns on extra small, small, and medium sized devices; but on large devices to span the content container only 8 columns.

So, on extra small, small, and medium devices, 1 column + 10 columns (+ the remaining 1 column) = 12 columns. On large devices, 2 columns + 8 columns (+ the remaining 2 columns) = 12 columns. My content is centered and tailors for difference device sizes.

Push Child Theme to Bitbucket

Now that I've added my child theme to my local repository, it's time to push it up to Bitbucket.

I use the following terms remind me how to use git:

- Commit: Save with notes
- Push: Upload
- Pull: Download (We'll come back to this.)

Sourcetree recognizes the addition of the files I copied from my hosting server. In Sourcetree, I clicked the 'Commit' button, left a note such as "Initial commit", checked the 'Push to remote repository' box, and committed. This committed (save with notes) and pushed (upload) the files to Bitbucket. The entire batch of files included the note "Initial commit" (or whatever comment I left).

From here on, any changes I make to the files in [theme]-child automatically appear in Sourcetree, ready for commits and pushes.

I try to make it a practice to commit any single change I'm satisfied with. Occasionally, multiple theme changes will be included in a single commit, because I'm human and forget to save and note every little thing I'm doing.

Automatic Deployments to Production

At this point, I was able to make changes and test locally. Once satisfied with my changes, I was able to commit and push these changes to Bitbucket for change tracking and safe keeping.

Now, if you are truly comfortable with your changes, you can set up an automatic deployment to your production server. Note that a safer practice is to set up a staging server to push to first. This ensures your changes are reflected to your liking on the web, saved in the event something detrimental occurs to your local server, and allows you to build on several changes before deploying to production. For Zero Counts, I feel safe with my only testing locally and pushing directly to production. The changes I'm making are usually minimal and the audience size doesn't necessitate that I be coy about changes as they hit my site. I leverage my small readership for design feedback and make small, visible tweaks often.

Bitbucket includes a feature called Pipelines that will detect when changes have been pushed to my Bitbucket repository, triggering a push of the changed files from Bitbucket to my production server.

For a thorough step-by-step tutorial on setting up Bitbucket Pipelines with WordPress.org, look no further than Peter Brumby's excellent article, 'Continuous delivery for WordPress using Bitbucket Pipelines'.

To enable Pipelines, I needed to provided Bitbucket with my SFTP username and password.

1. Sign into Bitbucket
2. Select my repo
3. Choose 'Settings'
4. Under PIPELINES, choose 'Environment variables'
5. Add SFTP username: Type variable = SFTP_username, Type value = [SFTP username]. Click Add.
6. Add SFTP password: Type variable = SFTP_password, Type value = [SFTP password]. **Check the Secured box.** This will obfuscate the SFTP password on Bitbucket.com for additional security. Click Add.

Once I set up my SFTP login credentials as variables, I needed to write instructions for Pipelines to sign into my SFTP and copy the changes I pushed from my local repo to my remote repo ultimately to my SFTP, thus, to ZeroCounts.net.

Pipelines are controlled with a YAML (.yml) file. This essentially provides Pipelines with a set of instructions once a ping from a webhook is detected. (A webhook is like a push notification for servers.)

The YAML file for Zero Counts looks like this:

```
image: php:7.0.27

pipelines:
default:
- step:
script:
- apt-get update
- apt-get -qq install git-ftp
- git ftp push --user $SFTP_username --passwd $SFTP_password --verbose sftp://ftp.[host]/home/[usernar
```

The gist of these instructions allows Git to log into my SFTP and copy only the changed files to my production server. The aforementioned article by Peter Brumby explains these steps in more detail.

iOS Development

With having a mobile theme in place, I began thinking about how neat it would be to develop on a mobile device. This is far from perfect, but it's gotten me out of binds a few times now.

A little app called Working Copy allows me to latch on to my remote Bitbucket repos, make changes to the files, and push those changes up to Bitbucket, thus triggering a deploy to my production server.

The free version of Working Copy can be upgraded to the Enterprise version. Bonus: The dark icon sticks around.

I wanted to be able to use a full iOS compatible IDE and wanted Coda to be that tool. After paying for Coda for iOS, I found I was mistaken. It doesn't seem to offer the ability to latch on to remote git repos like the desktop app does. Someday…

Next

This whole endeavor was my January 2018 project. [EDIT 1/27/19] — The move to a truly responsive theme with Bootstrap was a December 2018 project. I've only recently been able to sit around and write this all out.

There are certainly steps I've missed and efficiencies to be found. If you are following along and find glaring issues or gaps, let me know. I'm happy to help and update this post. If you find issues with this process, I'm also all ears. The biggest potential issue being the lack of a staging environment. I'll put that next on my docket. [EDIT 1/27/19] — My staging environment is complete. I tackled this during the Bootstrap work. It really only involved creating a password protected subdomain with a separate WordPress install and a re-configuration of my Bitbucket Pipelines. Maybe I'll document this at a later date.

Mobile Theme

The above is all well and good for desktop theme development, but mobile proved to be a different beast.

I use Jetpack for WordPress analytics and my mobile theme. Jetpack comes with a default mobile theme that can be altered, much like the default WordPress theme. I installed Jetpack on my local install of WordPress from the local WordPress dashboard. The mobile theme lives at ~/Sites/[domain]/wp-content/plugins/jetpack/modules/minileven/theme/pub/minileven.

To set up the remote repo for the mobile theme, I copied the contents of minileven/theme/pub/minileven from my local WordPress install to a folder on my desktop. I then deleted the minileven folder and created a new local (+ remote) repo from Sourcetree named 'minileven' in /wp-content/plugins/jetpack/modules/minileven/theme/pub/ and copier the contents of the copied directory back into it. It seems a little redundant, but I wasn't sure how to initialize the

existing minileven directory as a local repo. Once the files were copied back in, I ran an initial commit to the remote repo. Now I was able to track changes to the mobile theme.

Remember the bit above about updates to WordPress themes not affecting the child-theme? Jetpack does not support child themes. After a Jetpack update, a customized mobile theme is overridden by Jetpack's default theme. (I'm sure I can find what controls WordPress child themes, but that's another project for another day.) Therefore, after accepting a Jetpack update, the custom mobile theme needs to be pushed back up to Bitbucket to override the default Jetpack theme that sits on the production server.

In this case, there are two types of deployments:

1. Regular mobile theme updates (like my desktop theme updates)
2. Replacing Jetpack's default theme after a Jetpack update

Remember that YAML file I set up for desktop theme updates? A nearly identical set of instructions can be used to cover item 1. Item 1 is the default pipeline that will run with regular pushes to the remote repo.

For item 2, I needed to create a custom pipeline that I can manually trigger from Bitbucket. I cleverly named this pipeline "full-deploy-after-jetpack-update". I only run this after a Jetpack update.

```
image: php:7.0.27

pipelines:
default:
- step:
script:
- apt-get update
- apt-get -qq install git-ftp
- git ftp push --user $SFTP_username --passwd $SFTP_password --verbose sftp://ftp.[host]/home/[usernar
custom: # Pipelines triggered manually
full-deploy-after-jetpack-update:
- step:
script:
- apt-get update
- apt-get -qq install git-ftp
- git ftp init --user $SFTP_username --passwd $SFTP_password --verbose sftp://ftp.[host]/home/[usernar
```

The difference between these pipelines is push vs init. Because the Jetpack update wipes out my custom theme, it also wipes out the git tracking sitting on my production server. The git files need to be replaced and therefore re-initialized. (Initialization is still a little beyond my full comprehension, but I basically understand.)

Now that I was tracking changes of the mobile theme, I could begin work on my OLED-first (black/dark) mobile theme. As of this post, it's still a work in progress, but I'm pretty satisfied.

In Rainbows

April 8, 2018

Categories: Design

After publishing 'Building Zero Counts', I became curious about syntax highlighting — the walls of rainbowed text you see splayed out in front of developers.

In 'Building Zero Counts', I used a gradient from sea foam green (#00fa92) to Zero Counts blue (#004992) to denote code. Here's the Bitbucket Pipeline YAML example I used:

```
image: php:7.0.27

pipelines:
 default:
 - step:
 script:
 - apt-get update
 - apt-get -qq install git-ftp
 - git ftp push --user $SFTP_username --passwd $SFTP_password --verbose sftp://ftp.[host]/home/[userna
 custom: # Pipelines triggered manually
 full-deploy-after-jetpack-update:
 - step:
 script:
 - apt-get update
 - apt-get -qq install git-ftp
 - git ftp init --user $SFTP_username --passwd $SFTP_password --verbose sftp://ftp.[host]/home/[userna
```

The color scheme and implementation is completely useless, but it's meant to abstract how I perceive syntax highlighting. In the tech industry, it's impossible not to see engineers, developers, and designers living in front of colorful walls of text. And for me, it's impossible not to want to live and work in this world of rainbows. So, the way I display code on Zero Counts is a window into the beauty I see, the envy I have, and my ignorance of what is actually going on with syntax highlighting.

Poking around, I found some interesting posts about syntax highlighting and some methodologies behind color schemes and implementation. Ethan Schoonover's Solarized is a simple color scheme that shares the same syntax highlighting between light and dark themes. It's inspired by reading in the shade vs direct sunlight and incorporates fixed color wheel relationships:

> *Solarized works as a sixteen color palette for compatibility with common terminal based applications / emulators. In addition, it has been carefully designed to scale down to a variety of five color palettes (four base monotones plus one accent color) for use in design work such as web design. In every case it retains a strong personality but doesn't overwhelm.*

Meanwhile, Evan Brooks notes switching to *semantic highlighting* from *syntax highlighting* — an inverted use of highlighting, moving away from colorizing built-in keywords such as `let`, `var`, and `function` to coloring user-defined variables, methods, etc.:

> *We think syntax highlighting makes the structure of code easier to understand. But as it stands, we highlight the obvious (like the word function) and leave most of the content in black. Rather than highlighting the differences between currentIndex and the keyword*

> *function, we could highlight the difference between currentIndex and randomIndex. Here's what that might look like:* *Semantic Highlighting Example*

Brooks' method has been incorporated in a variety of text editors. Beyond that, KDevelop had actually incorporated semantic highlighting in 2009 — five years before Brooks' post:

> ***Understand code****: The real facility that helps you understanding global code-structure is the navigation-tooltip or the code-browser. However those are not very useful to understand local algorithms. The following picture illustrates my favorite part of the semantic highlighting: Local Variable Colorization. That colorization assigns a semi-unique color to each variable in a local context. This allows much easier distinguishing those variables, largely without reading their full name at all. By freeing you of actually having to read all the variable names, this allows grokking local code relations faster, and has already helped me fixing quite a few very stupid bugs right away.* 🙂

Great minds!

Syntax highlighting is a silly reason to want to learn to code, but well designed colorization and implementation certainly make it an attractive work environment. Who wouldn't want to live in rainbows?

Demystify Technology

April 8, 2018

Categories: Education

Janice Jackson, CEO of Chicago Public Schools, during Recode and MSNBC's interview with Apple CEO Tim Cook:

> *But, to answer your question, yes — everybody has to code in Chicago because it's a graduation requirement. I want to be clear on that.*
>
> *The goal is not to turn 380,000 students into computer scientists, but really to demystify technology, and to make sure that they understand that this is a language, and these are skills that transcend disciplines; that they can use it in math courses — they can use the logic that they learn in any course that they're taking. It really is about bringing in the type of robust learning that we see in schools around the country to every school in Chicago.*
>
> *When I first heard about it— I'm former history teacher, so I couldn't imagine what that would look like in my classroom 15 or 20 years ago. But the teachers are really embracing it. Through the training that we're going to offer our teachers at North Western through Apple support is just amazing. It'll demystify coding — not only for the students, but for the adults. I know at Escuela — we were just over here chatting about how the students are teaching the teachers. I think as adults we're coming into this and learning the importance and it's being driven by the technology. But it's mostly being driven by the demand from our students. They learn differently and they are asking us to catchup with the 21st century.*

One of my biggest regrets is not leaning into programming in high school.

In middle-school, I found it fascinating. But, during high school, caught up somewhere between punk ethos and popularity, I opted out of taking programming courses. I always felt like I'd get my ass kicked for taking a computer programming course. However, that didn't stop me from enrolling in the chess club and taking AP physics, calculus, and government. Such is the confusion of high school identity.

Needless to say, programming was not required. It fills me with joy to learn that it *is* required in Chicago. Technology is as fundamental as history, math, and writing. It goes beyond revamping home economics. Everyone should learn to code, just as everyone should learn algebra and about World War II. It doesn't mean they'll be forced into computer science any more than they'll be forced to become mathematicians or historians, but they'll be better equipped to problem solve and understand how the world around them works.

More Original Xbox Games Coming to Xbox One Backward Compatibility

April 10, 2018

Categories: Business

Xbox Wire: The official Xbox blog:

> *Starting today, fans can play Sonic Generations for the first time on the Xbox One family of devices alongside other Xbox 360 favorites that will receive Xbox One X Enhanced updates such as _Darksiders, Gears of War 2, Portal 2, Red Dead Redemption, _and Star Wars: The Force Unleashed.*
>
> *Later this month, we'll release two batches of Original Xbox games – the first on April 17 and the second on April 26. All of these Original Xbox games will take advantage of the power of Xbox One with up to 4X the pixel count on Xbox One and Xbox One S, and up to 16X the pixel count on Xbox One X. See below for the full list of titles that will be available later this month, and don't forget to visit https://majornelson.com/blog/xbox-one-backward-compatibility/ for the full list of backward compatible titles available on Xbox One.*

This is an impressive list of titles.

Microsoft's continued focus on backward compatibility is a smart move. It certainly won't be enough to sell the tens of millions of units necessary to catch up to PlayStation 4's sales figures, but in conjunction with increasing cross-network compatibility and the impressive power in the Xbox One X (vs. the PS4 Pro), I think Microsoft has turned a story-telling corner.

That said, for the same reasons I think backwards compatibility is a winning strategy for Xbox One, I think the Nintendo Switch will hold the lead on the conversation for a long while. After only 1 year on store shelves, the Switch's sales trajectory (14 million units) will likely surpass Xbox One's total 25-30 million units in 2018. PlayStation 4 has a much greater lead at 76.5 million units sold over 4.5 years. However, 14 million units in one year is without Nintendo breaking the seal on their back-catalog. And unless Microsoft or Sony glom on to exclusive licenses for third-party back-catalog — they won't — there's no telling who else may hop aboard the Switch train. (Come on, *Final Fantasy X* and *Kingdom Hearts*!)

Polygon's God of War Review: 'You don’t find collectibles; you find entire chunks of story'

April 12, 2018

Categories: General

Chris Plante, Polygon:

> *All of which is to say that the game is relaxed to the point of bordering on indifferent. Many of _God of War_’s most interesting surprises are optional, branching from the game’s sturdy throughline: secret rooms giving way to hidden caverns winding to towering statues or belligerent dragons — which I would have missed altogether had I just followed my compass to the next objective. You don’t find collectibles; you find entire chunks of story tucked behind a mossy wall or under a tropical island. God of War, like last year’s Nier: Automata and The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild, rewards the player who inspects its immaculately designed world as if it were a hidden object game.*

This reminds me of *Star Fox 64*. A player could "beat" *Star Fox 64* without ever visiting over 50% of the areas/missions created for the game. ("Beat" in quotes as the path the player uncovers indicates a level of completeness, ultimately leading to a truer ending.)

It's one thing to sprinkle trinkets throughout a game. It's another to build entire stories and environments that may never be found. *God of War* sounds remarkable.

The rise of the ambient video game

April 17, 2018

Categories: Design

Lewis Gordon, writing for The Outline:

> *Both The Legend of Zelda and these ambient records channeled the natural elements of water, earth, and air — phenomena of increasing rarity in the modern Japanese city. To step into such video game worlds was to stabilise oneself within the frenetic noise and anonymity of the expanding urban spaces. The Famicom allowed players to experience video games from the comfort of their home while Yoshimura, alongside other ambient artists of the era such as Satoshi Ashikawa, designed their records for public spaces whose mood they attempted to subtly augment. Later, in 1993, Haruomi Hosono, member of Yellow Magic Orchestra, released Medicine Compilation From the Quiet Lodge, an ambient album touching on house and techno but infused with Japan's past and elementalism. Its title articulated the healing potential of music created outside of the metropolis.*

A lovely observation and read by Gordon.

Most Video Games Are Too Long

April 17, 2018

Categories: Design

Patrick Klepek for Vice's Waypoint:

> *Minit knew what it wanted to accomplish, and how long it took to accomplish it. Done. But it also left me wanting more. If they announce a sequel—may I propose Another Minit?—I'll be there with bells on. Too many games leave me exhausted, as if my dozens of hours have only made a small dent. (This is especially true for open world games.)*

I recently played and completed *Florence* on iOS in 40 minutes. In that short stint, it hooked me, filled me with hope, sadness, and nostalgia, much like Disney's *Paperman* short. It left a lasting impression on me.

I understand the feeling of immersion, but even with *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* — as focused on in the previous post — I was yearning to finish. Many of the most impactful gaming experiences I've had have been shy of four hours; *Journey* — again, mentioned in Lewis Gordon's 'The Rise of the Ambient Video Game' previously linked to — has been the most impactful of all. Another being *Dear Esther*.

Speaking of both *Journey* and *Dear Esther*, see also 'Why the Two-hour Game is the Future'.

Video Game Music's Tremendous Power

April 18, 2018

Categories: Music

Voice actor David W. Collins digging into the *Super Mario Bros.* 'Ground Theme' on his recently debuted Soundtrack Show podcast:

> *As a general concept, game music is very often written to loop back around, seamlessly. This composition is meant to loop endlessly into itself so you can play for hours and hours and hours. But the actual composition that we just listened to was only 80 seconds long. 80 seconds! And there's repetition within that 80 seconds; there are repeating parts.*
>
> *There are other pieces of music in this game — the underground music, the underwater music, the castle music, a series of music fanfares, etc. — but in total, the amount of music written for this game adds up to less than 5 minutes. 5 minutes of music. 40 hours of gameplay, give or take on average. 40 million copies.*
>
> *Now we're starting to get a picture of the power of video game music. The amount of times that we heard that 80 seconds. That's what I mean about video game music's tremendous power. It's why we have to talk about it.*

Don't take repetition for granted. When done poorly, repetitious music can become jarring — quickly. When done well, a great loop can increase the feeling of immersion in the game's world. When done well, a standalone soundtrack's standard of two loops per song feels wrong.

Nintendo has a knack for this. Koji Kondo — composer of many first-party Nintendo titles, including *Super Mario Bros.* — is without a doubt a master at this. But even Kazumi Tokata painted his masterful stroke with the Wii's heavily repeatable 'Mii Plaza' and 'Wii Shop Channel' themes, both of which continue to live on in today's mainstream.

While today's AAA titles can incorporate orchestral arrangements through to procedurally generated soundscapes, repetition in video game music was born with the medium and will continue to live on. For those of us who grew of up listening to 8-bit repetitions to orchestral repetitions, we've had the great fortune of experiencing the evolution of a music technology, medium, and experience, as I touched on in my piece 1985: Burst and Bloom:

> *The sounds, visuals, and interactivity provided a pool of imagination. The limitations of early consoles could not provide orchestral arrangements. Instead, repetitious patterns were drilled into our heads. They not only encapsulated the game we were playing, but they opened the world outside to a new soundtrack, creating a wealth of memories that could be tapped into from a few simple chirps. Hearing these primitive arrangements evolve felt like experiencing the birth of music. As hardware progressed, so did the complexity if the music. Repetitive pieces turned into grand and iconic themes, each game re-shaping the idea and importance of video game music.*

Final Fantasy X, *Kingdom Hearts*, *Mega Man 2*, *Super Mario World*, *Super Mario 64*, *T&C Surf Designs: Wood & Water Rage*, *Vectorman* — these are some of my favorites.

The Verge: 'My Xbox One S is now a meaningfully different console to my PS4'

April 21, 2018

Categories: Business

Sam Byford, The Verge:

> *It's also something that Sony simply isn't able to offer, given the complexity of the PlayStation 3 hardware and consequent difficulty of emulating its software. And to be clear, Sony doesn't really need to do it — the PS4 library is more than strong enough to make the console worth buying. If I only owned an Xbox and had the choice of being able to play the likes of Nier Automata, Uncharted, and Horizon Zero Dawn instead of a bunch of games from the last decade, I'd take it. It's the paucity of Xbox One-exclusive content that is forcing Microsoft to find other ways to get people to use the platform.*
>
> *That's actually fine with me. I like that my Xbox One S is now a meaningfully different console to my PS4 Pro, with different use cases and functionality. It's the box I go to for 4K Blu-rays, Forza Horizon 3 in HDR, or Ninja Gaiden Black with a usable controller. It's the box I switch on to browse through when I'm not sure what I feel like doing, or when I'd rather play Cuphead on the couch than at my desk.*

As I said, I think Microsoft has turned a story-telling corner.

Griffin and Justin McElroy Depart Polygon

April 24, 2018

Categories: Media

Griffin McElroy, Polygon:

> *With that sage wisdom in mind, it's time for us — Griffin and Justin, who have, for the purposes of this introduction, fused into a singular, fraternal hivemind — to announce some big and bittersweet news: This Friday will be our last day as full-time employees at Polygon.*
>
> *We've written our own individual letters below, but understand that everyone's attention span might not sustain them through both; especially now that you know we're leaving, and our relevance to you slips away like so many grains of sand through the hourglass. So, here's a TL;DR, as the kids say: We're leaving to focus on our other projects, and to have more time to live functional human lives. We're gonna keep doing Monster Factory on some kind of recurring basis, as well as a couple other of our pre-existing Polygon projects. Our departure is completely amicable — so, SORRY, beef-hunters. No beef to be found here. This exit is strictly vegetarian.*
>
> *Now that we've spoiled all the big surprises, here's our individual takes. Thank you all so much.*

This one hurts.

When my wife and I moved to San Francisco for my job, I felt alone when outside of her company. On my commute or wandering the city, I'd listen to Polygon's The Besties with Griffin and Justin McElroy, Russ Frushtick, and Chris Plante. Their humor and camaraderie comforted me. On one episode, I caught wind that Griffin and Justin had another podcast: My Brother, My Brother, and Me. It was a treasure trove of wit and goofs; things that helped me through my days.

Even with their plethora of amazing and innovative endeavors outside of games journalism, I will always associate Griffin and Justin with Polygon. They're perspectives and writing are exceptional. I always looked forward to their articles.

But the writing was on the wall. Their bylines on Polygon.com appeared with decreasing frequency, while their amount of "side-projects" began to seemingly multiply.

In their departure letters, they both reflect on Polygon's editor-in-chief Chris Grant's friendship — how he helped kick off their games journalism journey. It's amazing to see how much adoration is paid to Grant for his support and willingness to allow them to balance their dream job while pursuing other endeavors.

The piece of this news that hits the hardest comes from Justin's letter. It speaks to the heart and humanity I believe the folks behind Polygon harbor. It also speaks to why I write Zero Counts and the countless other blogs I left in its wake:

> *So for years, I wrote for myself. I created and maintained no fewer than three different blogs with a readership of, statistically speaking, nobody. I pitched myself to every major gaming site and magazine and was ignored by all of them. But I kept applying, kept*

> *pitching, and was eventually ignored by almost all of them. After a few years, I was able to cobble something that looked like a resume in dim light, and things got a bit easier.*
>
> *The call that changed my life though came from Chris Grant, the EIC of Joystiq who remembered liking my submissions when I had applied for a job (six months prior, didn't get it, natch). He was reminded of my existence after I emailed him trying to get Joystiq to post about some videos I had made about a laserdisc lightgun game featuring prop comedian Gallagher. I owe Gallagher so much that I'll never be able to repay.*

I'm happy for Griffin and Justin and look forward to supporting their other adventures. But this one hurts.

Godspeed, boys.

Some Numbers That Illustrate Nintendo Switch's Massive Success

April 26, 2018

Categories: Business

Jason Schreier reporting for Kotaku:

> *Nintendo today reported its earnings for the 2017 fiscal year, which means a whole bunch of interesting new sales numbers to look at. They're all impressive, and they all show the massive appeal of Nintendo Switch.*
>
> *Here are a few numbers that, taken together, make for some good perspective on just how successful Nintendo's latest console has been throughout its first year on the market.*

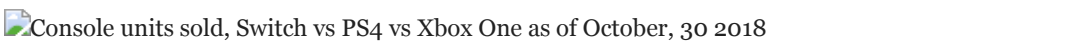
Wild numbers to the Switch's set-top predecessor, the Wii U.

The Switch is more or less tracking the same sales pace as PS4. It took a little over one year for the PS4 to reach 18.5 worldwide hardware sell-through units — November 22, 2013 - January 4, 2015.

Microsoft has been mum on sales figures, but in 2016 slipped that the Xbox One had sold "around 18 to 19 million" units, two years after launch.

[*Update*]: Here's a sales trajectory visual. Data source: Wikipedia.

[*Update 10/30/18*]: Nintendo announces 22.86 million Switch unit sales since launch. Updated sales chart below.



Adjustable Charging Stand for Nintendo Switch

May 8, 2018

Categories: Design

Nintendo:

> *The adjustable charging stand allows the Nintendo Switch system to be charging while in Tabletop mode, enabling longer play sessions.*

Home console?

Virtual Console kinda sucked

May 8, 2018

Categories: Business

Chris Kohler, Kotaku:

> *Virtual Console is no more, but that doesn't mean that Switch won't become the best place to play classic games. It'll just be done in a different way than what Nintendo's tried in the past. And that's a good thing, because Virtual Console kinda sucked.*
>
> *Now, by "Virtual Console kinda sucked" I do not mean "Nintendo's old games are bad," or even that Virtual Console's game selection was bad, or anything like that. In case you are wholly unfamiliar with my work, I love old games and think that as many of them as possible should be kept in print on modern-day hardware. I just think that Virtual Console, the feature, was an inefficient way of implementing this idea, and that there is a better way. Virtual Console died so that retro gaming on Switch could live.*

My knee-jerk response to Nintendo Switch Online was disappointment. 20 8-bit games, while great, seemed paltry.

However, heeding my own words, Nintendo doesn't need to release any more than this for the new service. The games are the lure. The online play and cloud saves are the lock-in. Nintendo will trickle classic titles out over time when needed. Additions of consoles (SNES, N64,... GameCube) will be tentpole announcements — when needed.

That said, I agree with Kohler. And Adult Swim Games' Chris Johnson. Truth is, as much as I loved playing NES, SNES, and N64 games on my Wii and Wii U, I hated not knowing what releases to expect and when to expect them. Likewise, as Kohler mentions in his piece, the pricing structure seemed bananas. Virtual Console kinda sucked.

I do wish Nintendo was offering up more than NES titles, but I get why they aren't. I'll take this handful for now with the excitement that lots more classics will arrive at the low fee of $20 per year.

Ben Thompson: ‘Humans Run on Stories’

May 14, 2018

Categories: Art, General

Ben Thompson on *The Talk Show with John Gruber* podcast:

> *Stories matter. Humans run on stories.*
>
> *I look at my own site and the articles that often resonate are not the ones with brilliant analysis or something clever. It’s the ones that tell a story.*
>
> *People know it implicitly, but have a very difficult time articulating it. If you’re selling to consumers, there’s so much that goes into it that doesn’t go on a spreadsheet. That sort of stuff matters.*

I subscribe to Ben’s *Stratechery* Daily Update newsletter. I read a lot of it and consider Ben’s insights priceless. But it’s typically his free weekly articles that grab me.

His most recent, ‘Tech’s Two Philosophies’, had me reeling. After reading it over morning coffee, I raced to work to share it with my team.

I shoehorned Ben’s ideas into something relevant to our work. It was a stretch, but I don’t think overly so. Regardless, I was so moved by the story in the piece that it woke me up better than any cup of coffee.

Humans run on stories. They absolutely do.

Microsoft's Xbox Adaptive Controller

May 16, 2018

Categories: Accessibility, Design

Microsoft Story Labs has a great piece by in-house writer Deborah Bach about the development of the Adaptive Controller. It's great storytelling through and through; chock full of touching stories, business cases, and design implementation all the way down to the packaging.

Here's the opening story:

> *Dan Bertholomey awoke in a hospital in June of 2010, four days after a hit-and-run driver almost killed him while he was riding his motorcycle, to the sinking knowledge that he'd lost the use of his right arm and hand.*
>
> *As he lay in his hospital bed, Bertholomey pondered his future. He thought about his daily life and the things he loved to do. How am I going to game again, he wondered? He'd been an avid gamer since age 10, when an original Pong console from Sears magically transformed his family's television set into an electronic playground that he could control. Bertholomey was instantly hooked. He loved the competitiveness of gaming, loved the places it took his imagination.*
>
> *Bertholomey continued gaming into adulthood, playing often with his son and daughter. In 2005, when he was 40, Bertholomey placed sixth on "Madden Nation," a televised competition of the U.S.'s best "Madden NFL 06" football video game players. For him, gaming wasn't just a hobby, something he did in his spare time. It was a lifestyle.*
>
> *"You can't fathom losing something that you love so much, said Bertholomey, 52, who lives in Mesa, Arizona. It's incredibly devastating."*
>
> *Bertholomey began looking for ways to play with one hand. He found someone to hack him a foot pedal that connected to his Xbox, but it didn't work well for him. He eventually taught himself to play with his left hand, but it was awkward and he couldn't play at anywhere near his previous capacity.*
>
> *The solution Bertholomey needed is now a reality — and it has the potential to make gaming accessible to players with disabilities worldwide. The new Xbox Adaptive Controller, which will be available later this year, can be connected to external buttons, switches, joysticks and mounts, giving gamers with a wide range of physical disabilities the ability to customize their setups. The most flexible adaptive controller made by a major gaming company, the device can be used to play Xbox One and Windows 10 PC games and supports Xbox Wireless Controller features such as button remapping.*
>
> *Bertholomey, who is among a select group of gamers who have been testing the device, said the controller makes it easy to create different setups for various types of games and seamlessly switch between them. Gamers can set up three different gaming profiles on the controller and don't need to reset the device every time they change games, as they sometimes do with modified controllers.*

This controller is really something else. There should have been steps taken to get to this point a long time ago, but this is wonderful, nonetheless.

I've recently wondered how to make games more accessible. The thought (rather shamefully) finally occurred to me while playing *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* for Switch in handheld mode. I have perfect eyesight, but the text was just small enough to be uncomfortable to read. Seeing as the game was originally intended for a TV experience on Wii U, it's not terribly surprising that the experience wasn't tailored for the Switch's 6.2-inch screen. However, with the success of the Switch and *Breath of the Wild*, it's surprising Nintendo hasn't patched the text size while in handheld mode.

More recently, I've been playing *God of War* on a 720p TV. Golly, is the text tough to read.

Software accessibility is difficult, let alone manufacturing a piece of hardware for a niche audience. But it's a niche audience that *must* to be considered. Where many companies seemingly glance over serving mental and physical handicaps, it's wonderful to see Microsoft doing the right thing by enabling play for as many people as possible.

Switch 2nd Unit Set

May 22, 2018

Categories: Business, General

Sam Byford, The Verge:

> *Nintendo is now selling a cheaper Switch package in Japan that doesn't include the TV dock. The "Switch 2nd Unit Set" is ostensibly aimed at households that already have a Switch hooked up to the family TV and therefore don't need a second dock, but it could also be an option for players who only plan to use the system as a handheld device.*

Home console?

Pokémon: Let’s Go!

May 29, 2018

Categories: General

https://youtube.com/watch?v=9jRtpMKLsts

Finally.

PS4 Fortnite Accounts Are Blocked On The Nintendo Switch

June 11, 2018

Categories: General

Luke Plunkett, Kotaku:

> *Fortnite players who had an Epic account on PS4 and have tried to play the new Nintendo Switch version of the game are reporting that they've run into a problem: they're not allowed to use the same account.*
>
> *That's right, if you have played the game on PlayStation 4—even just once—that's enough to have got your account locked to that system. It goes the other way too; if you link your Epic account on Switch, you're locked out on the PlayStation 4.*

This is maddening, but it comes as no surprise. To Sony's credit, cross-network/crossplay is fairly new to the console world. That said, as I noted in my piece Sold on Cross-Network Play, "this is not a technical limitation. It is political." The fact that *Fortnight* crossplay is supported across Switch, iOS, Android, Xbox One, macOS, and PC tells you as much.

In Cross-Network Play is "the Next Logical Step", I noted the following:

> *Sony claims their reluctance of opening cross-network play is out of protection of their community. I think that is a fair stance, but is the Sony community any less toxic than others? I think the real fear is losing an amount of ability to lock in players to PlayStation 4. It's the same case made for exclusive games and content; the latter I vehemently oppose.*

Looking at Sony's sell through numbers, it's easy to see where their comfort of lock-in comes from. They likely have an overwhelming majority of the console base on their platform. Here's a visual from my piece Some Numbers that Illustrate Nintendo's Switch's Massive Success:



Sony is going to run that lead dry of ~~security~~ loyalty to their platform.

But the majority of consoles aside, the masses are playing *Fortnight*. And if they aren't on PS4, they are everywhere else. If that's not enough for Sony to about-face, I don't know what is.

Sometimes Failure Leads to Opportunity

June 11, 2018

Categories: Business

Ben Thompson, Stratechery:

> *I've been pretty critical of the Xbox over the years, arguing that it failed at its strategic goal (winning the living room not just for gamers but for everyone) and didn't make sense for Microsoft in the long run. Microsoft, though, has continued to insist that it was committed to gaming, and it backed that up at the ongoing E3 game conference.*

First and foremost, if you're not paying for Ben's Daily Update, you're missing out on the best business x tech analysis out there.

Ben's latest regarding Xbox is a great snapshot of Microsoft's motives for the future. Here are some choice quotes to summarize.

On Microsoft's *big* acquisitions announcement of studios Ninja Theory (*DmC: Devil May Cry*, *Hellblade: Senua's Sacrifice*), Playground Games (*Forza Horizon*), Undead Labs (*State of Decay*), and Compulsion Games (*We Happy Few*):

> *The Xbox One originally lagged behind the PS4 this generation due to its misguided focus on the living room (including charging $100 more at launch because of the now-discontinued Kinect that was at the center of that effort), but the bigger problem has been a lack of exclusive titles relative to the PS4. One way to counter that is to simply produce them yourself, and these purchases augment Microsoft's ability to do just that.*

On Microsoft's announcement of a game streaming service, "dedicated to perfecting your experience everywhere you want to play -- your Xbox, your PC and your phone":

> *Still, PlayStation Now requires a PS4: what EA and Microsoft are talking about is a service that works on any device, from a phone to a smart TV to a PC to a console, because all of the computation is done in the cloud, and that right there is where the Xbox suddenly starts to make a lot more strategic sense: Microsoft has a massive advantage in a future where games are predominantly cloud-based.*

Ultimately, I think Ben summarized the Microsoft showcase perfectly. I do hope you read it. To end:

> *Indeed, I find this idea so compelling that I must formally withdraw my recommendation that Microsoft get out of gaming; I still believe that the Xbox was a failure in terms of its original goals, but sometimes failure leads to opportunity, and streaming seems to be a significant one, for both Xbox specifically and Azure generally.*

I have to say, the Xbox event was my favorite of E3, with Nintendo in a close second. With that, I truly think Microsoft has turned a storytelling corner.

Nintendo Tops E3 Tweets

June 21, 2018

Categories: Business

Rishi Chadha, Twitter:

> *A look at the most Tweeted about topics during the annual event offers a fascinating glimpse at what got gaming fans most excited.*
>
> 1. *Nintendo (@Nintendo)*
> 2. *Xbox (@Xbox)*
> 3. *Super Smash Bros. (#SuperSmashBros)*
> 4. *Fallout (@Fallout)*
> 5. *Playstation (@PlayStation)*
> 6. *Kingdom Hearts (@KINGDOMHEARTS)*
> 7. *Ubisoft (@Ubisoft)*
> 8. *Elder Scrolls (@ElderScrolls)*
> 9. *Death Stranding (#DEATHSTRANDING)*
> 10. *Fortnite (@FortniteGame)*
>
> *These were the most Tweeted about newly-announced games:*
>
> 1. *Super Smash Bros. Ultimate*
> 2. *Kingdom Hearts 3*
> 3. *Fallout 76*
> 4. *The Last of Us 2*
> 5. *Death Stranding*
>
> *These were the moments that generated the most conversation on Twitter:*
>
> 1. *Super Smash Bros. Ultimate release date is announced*
> 2. *Ridley announced as newest character added to Super Smash Bros. Ultimate*
> 3. *Elder Scrolls VI trailer is revealed at @Bethesda press conference*

I felt Microsoft's conference was the most compelling, but this is pretty neat.

I'm curious to see how Nintendo handles social for Smash Bros. Ultimate. Social is Nintendo's Achilles heel. I'm not sure how great Twitter is as a global barometer, but I think this is good motivation for Nintendo to double-down on it as a focus.

Xbox Switch “Better Together” Campaign

June 22, 2018

Categories: Business

https://youtube.com/watch?v=0l8nJ_liqrw

Twisting

The

Knife

The Hard Times' Hard Drive

June 30, 2018

Categories: Humor

Hard Drive:

> *A lead change occurred in the final lap of the Rainbow Road Grand Prix last night during what was supposed to be a friendly game of Mario Kart amongst friends, when a blue spiny shell struck the leading racer mere inches from the finish. The driver, Marty Witten, fell from first place to last before creeping over the finish line.*
>
> *"Fuck shit goddamn motherfucking ass shit fuck," said a visibly perturbed Witten, who had led the entire race before the shell struck. "Fuck fuck fuck I hate this stupid bullshit game AHHHHH!"*

Hard Drive kills me. I chuckle at damn near every one of their headlines.

Part of The Hard Times, it's essentially The Onion of video games. Whether you're deep into video game culture or you simply reminisce on days spent playing *Mario Kart 64*, it deserves a follow.

Blue shells. Fuck shit goddamn. Haven't we all been there?

Bloomberg Businessweek: The Legend of Nintendo

July 1, 2018

Categories: Business, General

Felix Gillette:

> *More symptoms emerged in November, when the company released the NES Classic Edition, a miniaturized, rebooted version of the Nintendo Entertainment System, the console that had made the company a household name in Europe and America in the '80s. The updated version was carefully calibrated to rekindle the latent passion of lapsed fans, with 30 of the most popular NES games built in. (Unlike the original, there were no cartridges.) From the start, supplies were scarce. Stores were constantly sold out, so customers lined up for hours to await shipments of even a few units. But what seemed to some like a supply-chain disaster looked to others like a calculated strategy. At $59.99 per unit with no additional games, NES Classics were a low-margin item; much more important for the company was to whet the world's appetite for Nintendo games in preparation for the Switch. To that end, Nintendo and DeNA also released Super Mario Run for iOS and Android, giving hundreds of millions of people an opportunity to help Mario scamper across their smartphones or tablets.*
>
> *The strategy worked. By the time the Switch arrived in the spring of 2017, legions of people had been enticed to reconnect with their favorite childhood game characters on a proper Nintendo device. Over the next fiscal year, the Switch accounted for $6.8 billion of revenue. Nintendo's existing handheld platform, the 3DS, kicked in an additional $1.7 billion, and sales of smartphone games rose 62 percent, generating $354.9 million.*

This is a fun write-up on the current state of Nintendo — from its headquarters to the injection of young talent to its now iconic business ebbs and flows. To toot my own horn, I think it works as a macro companion piece to my micro view in Big-N's Big Year.

Needless to say, I'll forever be tickled by major news outlets covering Nintendo and video games at large. It's a no-brainer considering the size of the industry, but for someone who grew up in a time where video games were a niche, nerdy hobby, it's extraordinary to watch a company like Nintendo become as culturally significant and observed as Disney.

(Link via MacStories)

FastCoDesign: Why tech's favorite color is making us all miserable

July 4, 2018

Categories: Design

Amber Case:

> *A decade after my experience with the LED fans, I started seeing blue displays everywhere. From mobile phones to in-car displays, blue lights were becoming the norm. It's hard for me to think of any examples of prominent high-tech products on the market now without pale blue screens or indicator lights. LED-based bulbs with more blue light are fast replacing incandescent bulbs. The default display to our iPhones and Androids operates along the blue spectrum, as do our laptops; new cars, especially those like Tesla which aspire to be "futuristic," come with blue-lit dashboard displays, and so do our "smart" appliances, televisions, video game consoles, watches–the list goes on.*

Unless it's the post-apocalypse, imagery of the future is generally always depicted by some form of light. This article provides a brief history and effect of shifting from red and orange light (function) to blue light (form) on screen and in real-life.

I was obsessed with the blue eject light on the original PS2. When powered on at night, married to the start up chime, the blue light was a beautiful touch to round out the futuristic design and marketing of the console. The Wii's disc drive bay gave me a similar feeling.

The poet in me would say it's vast and mysterious sea, sky, and stars that make blue so extraordinary. While I agree that red and orange are preferred from practical standpoint, there's no denying that blue is gorgeous. The Zero Counts design is certainly guilty of leaning on blue — ZC blue (#004992).

Regardless of your feelings about the film, try imagining *Tron: Legacy* with an orange Grid. Gross.

(Link via The Loop)

Kotaku: Octopath Traveler Is Nothing Like Final Fantasy VI

July 7, 2018

Categories: General

Jason Schreier:

> *The producer of the gorgeous upcoming Switch game Octopath Traveler made waves this week with a quote in which he said that mechanically it was a spiritual successor to Final Fantasy VI. Other people have made similar comparisons. But Octopath is nothing like _Final Fantasy VI_—it's more like a SaGa game, with some experimental ideas that work, and some that really don't.*

I've played a little over an hour of the *Octopath Traveler* demo and am chipping away at some initial thoughts. One of those thoughts — contrary to both Takahashi-san and Schreier — is that *Octopath Traveler* feels like *Final Fantasy X*.

Each character has an individual relationship, conflict, and narrative, the visual turn-based system is akin to that of FFX, and there is an odd mismatch between the writing style and voice acting; the writing feels high-brow English juxtaposed to the modern American voice acting. While it's certainly not the same problem, it is reminiscent of *FFX*'s infamous laughing scene.

Polygon: Captain Toad feels like “Nintendo experimenting within the Mario Universe”

July 12, 2018

Categories: Design

Polygon's Michael McWhertor on the Quality Control podcast with host Dave Tach:

> *For a few years now, I have promoted and evangelized Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker. To the point where I think even people at Nintendo are like, "hey, send this guy the Captain Toad review code first."*
>
> *I love the game. I love the character. It's a great little puzzle game. It was one of those things that was released on the Wii U — which didn't have a ton of great games, but this was a real standout in my opinion — and not a lot of people owned the Wii U. [Captain Toad] was something that was overlooked by a lot of people. It's a fun little package. Now that it's out on Nintendo Switch and Nintendo 3DS, people have no excuse not to go play Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker.*
>
> *...*
>
> *In 2013, Nintendo released Super Mario 3D World, and excellent platformer for the Wii U. In that game, there were a handful of levels featuring Captain Toad. You gave up control of Mario, Peach, Luigi, etc., and you played as Captain Toad in these tiny little diorama-style levels where Toad would walk around with a headlamp and a heavy backpack.*
>
> *He couldn't run and jump. He could basically just walk around levels. He could fall down things. There were switches you could pull to raise him up on platforms. But each one was just this cute, clever little puzzle level that felt like Nintendo experimenting within the Mario Universe.*

Mike and I share similar feelings about *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker*. The game itself is a charming, clever, puzzle game. But beyond that, it's a wonderful expansion on a more realized Mushroom Kingdom. And it was great to see the character return in *Super Mario Odyssey*.

I've said it once and I'll say it again, *Captain Toad* is genius.

Hard to feel bad for a middle-aged white man

July 12, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Less by Andrew Sean Greer:

> *There is an old Arabic story about a man who hears Death is coming for him, so he sneaks away to Samarra. And when he gets there, he finds Death in the market, and Death says, "You know, I just felt like going on vacation to Samarra. I was going to skip you today, but how lucky you showed up to find me!" And the man is taken after all. Arther Less has traveled halfway around the world in a cat's cradle of junkets, changing flights and fleeing from a sandstorm into the Atlas Mountains like someone erasing his trail or outfoxing a hunter—and yet Time has been waiting here all along. In a snowy alpine resort. With cuckoos. Of course Time would turn out to be Swiss. He tosses back the champagne. He thinks: Hard to feel bad for a middle-aged white man.*
>
> *Indeed: even Less can't feel bad for Swift anymore. Like a wintertime swimmer too numb to feel cold, Arthur Less is too sad to feel pity. For Robert, yes, breathing through an oxygen tube up in Sonoma. For Marian, nursing a broken hip that might ground her forever. For Javier in his marriage, and even for Bastian's tragic sports teams. For Zohra and Janet. For his fellow writer Mohammed. Around the world his duty flies, its wingspan as wide as albatross's. But he can no more feel sorry for Swift—now become a gorgon of Caucasian male ego, snake headed, pacing through his novel and turning each sentence to sone—than Arther Less can feel sorry for himself.*

He had discovered Time and Death and God

July 13, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Brave New World by Aldous Huxley:

> *All alone, outside the pueblo, on the bare plain of the mesa. The rock was like bleached bones in the moonlight. Down in the valley, the coyotes were howling at the moon. The bruises hurt him, the cuts were still bleeding; but it was not for the pain that he sobbed; it was because he was all alone, because he had been driven out, alone, into this skeleton world of rocks and moonlight. At the edge of the precipice he sat down. The moon was behind him; he looked down into the black shadow of the mesa, into the black shadow of death. He had only to take one step, one little jump…. He held out his right hand in the moonlight. From the cut on his wrist the blood was still oozing. Every few seconds a drop fell, dark, almost colourless in the dead light. Drop, drop, drop. To-morrow and to-morrow and to-morrow …*
>
> *He had discovered Time and Death and God.*

Bloated from all he had acquired

July 16, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Americanah by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie:

> *He climbed out of the car. His gait was stiff, his legs difficult to lift. He had begun, in the past months, to feel bloated from all he had acquired—the family, the houses, the cars, the bank accounts—and would, from time to time, be overcome by the urge to prick everything with a pin, to deflate it all, to be free. He was no longer sure, he had in fact never been sure, whether he liked his life because he really did or whether he liked it because he was supposed to.*

The nationalism of liberal Americans

August 4, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Americanah by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie:

> *"I'm Kelsey," the woman announced as though to the whole room. She was aggressively friendly. She asked where Mariama was from, how long she had been in America, if she had children, how her business was doing.*
>
> *"Business is up and down but we try," Mariama said.*
>
> *"But you couldn't even have this business back in your country, right? Isn't it wonderful that you get to come to the U.S. and now your kids can have a better life?"*
>
> *Mariama looked surprised. "Yes."*
>
> *"Are women allowed to vote in your country?" Kelsey asked.*
>
> *A longer pause from Mariama. "Yes."*
>
> *"What are you reading?" Kelsey turned to Ifemelu.*
>
> *Ifemelu showed her the cover of the novel. She did not want to start a conversation. Especially not with Kelsey. She recognized in Kelsey the nationalism of liberal Americans who copiously criticized America but did not like you to do so; they expected you to be silent and grateful, and always reminded you of how much better than wherever you had come from America was.*

Old things

August 14, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Brave New World by Aldous Huxley:

> *"But why is it prohibited?" Asked the Savage. In the excitement of meeting a man who had read Shakespeare he had momentarily forgotten everything else.*
>
> *The Controller shrugged his shoulders. "Because it's old; that's the chief reason. We haven't any use for old things here."*
>
> *"Even when they're beautiful?"*
>
> *"Particularly when they're beautiful. Beauty's attractive, and we don't want people to be attracted by old things. We want them to like the new ones."*

Obama could actually win this thing

August 16, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Americanah by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie:

> *Blaine's knife stopped moving. He looked up, eyes lit, as though he had not dared hope she would believe the same thing that he believed, and she felt between them the first pulse of a shared passion. They clutched each other in front of the television when Barack Obama won the Iowa caucuses. The first battle, and he had won. Their hope was radiating, exploding into possibility: Obama could actually win this thing. And then, as though choreographed, they began to worry. They worried that something would derail him, crash his fast-moving train. Every morning, Ifemelu woke up and checked to make sure that Obama was still alive. That no scandal had emerged, no story dug up from his past. She would turn on her computer, her breath still, her heart frantic in her chest, and then, reassured that he was alive, she would read the latest news about him, quickly and greedily, seeking information and reassurance, multiple windows minimized at the bottom of the screen. Sometimes, in chat rooms, she wilted as she read the posts about Obama, and she would get up and move away from her computer, as though the laptop itself were the enemy, and stand by the window to hide her tears even from herself. How can a monkey be president? Somebody do us a favor and put a bullet in this guy. Send him back to the African jungle. A black man will never be in the white house, dude, it's called the white house for a reason. She tried to imagine the people who wrote those posts, under monikers like SuburbanMom231 and NormanRockwellRocks, sitting at their desks, a cup of coffee beside them, and their children about to come home on the school bus in a glow of innocence. The chat rooms made her blog feel inconsequential, a comedy of manners, a mild satire about a world that was anything but mild. She did not blog about the vileness that seemed to have multiplied each morning she logged on, more chat rooms springing up, more vitriol flourishing, because to do so would be to spread the words of people who abhorred not the man that Barack Obama was, but the idea of him as president. She blogged, instead, about his policy positions, in a recurring post titled "This Is Why Obama Will Do It Better," often adding links to his website, and she blogged, too, about Michelle Obama. She gloried in the offbeat dryness of Michelle Obama's humor, the confidence in her long-limbed carriage, and then she mourned when Michelle Obama was clamped, flattened, made to sound tepidly wholesome in interviews. Still, there was, in Michelle Obama's overly arched eyebrows and in her belt worn higher on her waist than tradition would care for, a glint of her old self. It was this that drew Ifemelu, the absence of apology, the promise of honesty.*
>
> *"If she married Obama then he can't be that bad," she joked often with Blaine, and Blaine would say, "True that, true that."*

Third Worlders are forward-looking

August 19, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Americanah by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie:

> *"When I started in real estate, I considered renovating old houses instead of tearing them down, but it didn't make sense. Nigerians don't buy houses because they're old. A renovated two-hundred-year-old mill granary, you know, the kind of thing Europeans like. It doesn't work here at all. But of course it makes sense because we are Third Worlders and Third Worlders are forward-looking, we like things to be new, because our best is still ahead, while in the West their best is already past and so they have to make a fetish of that past."*

You will find the future where people are having the most fun

August 23, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Wonderland by Steven Johnson

> *This phenomenon turns out to appear consistently throughout the history of humanity's trifles. The guilty pleasures of life often give us a hint of future changes in society, whether those pleasures take the form of English ladies shopping for calico fabrics in London in the late 1600s, or ancient Roman feasts laden with spices from the far corners of the globe, or carnival hucksters promoting strange optical devices that create the illusion of moving pictures, or computer programmers at MIT in the 1960s playing Spacewar! on their million-dollar mainframes. Because play is often about breaking rules and experimenting with new conventions, it turns out to be the seedbed for many innovations that ultimately develop into much sturdier and more significant forms. The institutions of society that so dominate traditional history—political bodies, corporations, religions—can tell you quite a bit about the current state of the social order. But if you are trying to figure out what's coming next, you are often better off exploring the margins of play: the hobbies and curiosity pieces and subcultures of human beings devising new ways to have fun. "Each epoch dreams the one to follow, creates it in dreaming," the French "historian Michelet wrote in 1839. More often than not, those dreams do not unfold within the grown-up world of work or war or governance. Instead, they emerge from a different kind of space: a space of wonder and delight where the normal rules have been suspended, where people are free to explore the spontaneous, unpredictable, and immensely creative work of play. You will find the future wherever people are having the most fun.*

Modern life itself could make you sick

August 26, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Wonderland by Steven Johnson

> *Visible in these perplexed diagnoses is a new way of thinking about the psyche. Diseases of the mind did not have to be rooted in some biological deformity, as the phrenologists had contended; nor was it attributable to some abstract "lesion of the will"; nor was it tied to basic biological realities like menstruation or masturbation. Instead, the root cause of the disorder was to be found somewhere else: in the lived history of social and economic change. Modern life itself could make you sick.*

Music seems to send us out on a quest for new experiences

August 26, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Wonderland by Steven Johnson

> *One premise unites both sides in this debate: that music "presses our pleasure buttons," as Pinker describes it. Yet there is something too simple in describing our appetite for music in this way. Sugar and opiates, to give just two examples, press pleasure buttons in the brain in a relatively straightforward fashion. Given a taste of one, we instinctively return for more of the same, like those legendary lab rats endlessly pressing the lever for more stimulants. And we put our ingenuity to work concocting ever-more-efficient delivery mechanisms for these forms of pleasure: we refine opium into heroin; we start selling soda in Big Gulp containers. But music—like the patterns and colors unleashed by the fashion revolution—appears to resonate with our pleasure centers at more of an oblique angle. The pleasure in hearing those captivating sounds doesn't just establish a demand for more of the same. Instead, music seems to send us out on a quest for new experiences: more of the same, but different.*

The television equivalent of the novel

September 1, 2018

Categories: Media

Wonderland by Steven Johnson

> *Art is the aftershock of technological plates shifting. Sometimes the aftershock is slow in arriving. It took the novel about three hundred years to evolve into its modern form after the invention of the printing press. The television equivalent of the novel—the complex serialized drama of The Wire or _Breaking Bad_—took as long as seventy years to develop, depending on where you date its origins.*

I've often thought about today's serialized, bingeable, Golden Age of Television as the visual equivalent of the novel. Rich worlds. Deep investment in characters. Time to marinate with relationships and stakes.

Before the Golden Age of Television, I was captivated by trilogies — hell, I still am — namely Peter Jackson's *The Lord of the Rings* (Extended Editions!) I hadn't read the books, but I felt an attachment to the characters. Its cohesive production, year-over-year release schedule, and follow-through of Tolkien's parallel stories and stakes built a world I was able to immerse myself in.

Peter Jackson's *Lord of the Rings runs 9 hours in total*, the extended editions running 11 hours — not dissimilar from a Golden Age television series.

Xbox All Access Pass hardware, software, and services subscription

September 5, 2018

Categories: Business

Ben Thompson, Stratechery Daily Update:

> *That noted, it is not too difficult to imagine this program morphing into something much more significant in the ninth-generation, which is due in 2020. I've already discussed the anticipated shift to streaming, at least for some titles; that, naturally, fits a subscription model perfectly.*
>
> *What is particularly compelling, though, is idea of assuming regular hardware upgrades throughout the generation. Microsoft could, of course, simply charge its best gamers for those slight upgrades every time they come out, but what if instead of financing new consoles the model was more akin to leasing? Pay one monthly fee, get access to online services, streaming games, and new hardware every few years?*

Consumer hardware as a service.

The limitations make games fun

September 9, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Play Anything by Ian Bogost

> *The lesson that games can teach us is simple. Games aren't appealing because they are fun, but because they are limited. Because they erect boundaries. Because we must accept their structures in order to play them. Soccer sees two teams of eleven players attempting to use their feet, torsos, and heads to put a ball into a goal. Tetris asks you to position falling arrangements of four orthogonally-connected squares in order to produce and remove horizontal lines. And yet the experiences games like soccer and Tetris create are far larger than those boundaries convey on their own. That bounty results from the deliberate, if absurd, pursuit of soccer and Tetris on their own terms, within the limitations they erect. The limitations make games fun.*

Under the sail of generosity rather than selfishness

September 15, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Play Anything by Ian Bogost

> *My daughter's mall game illustrates these principles. She saw and acknowledged the tiles, which are separately laid and grouted for the ease of manufacture, transport, installation, and maintenance. But rather than allowing that material distinction to recede into the background, to become mere substrate for our far more urgent pursuit of retail commerce, she made the tile / grout pairing the focus of her attention. She added to them the speed of her gait as pulled along by me, my hand and body as it attached to and pulled her to and fro erratically, the shape and size of her feet, the traction or slipperiness of her shoes, the vectors along which runs counter to our ordinary conception of play as a release of tension and responsibility.*
>
> *Then, even though I was merely an accessory to her game rather than a party to it, she forced me to recognize and acknowledge the space she'd created. The tiles, the grout, her shoes, and so on—I became newly aware of these things simply by virtue of attending to her indirectly. We must seek to capture that magic everywhere; in everything. Not the pleasure of realizing our own goals—as if we even know that they are or ought to be—but the gratification of meeting the world more than halfway, almost all the way, and reaping the spoils of our new discoveries made under the sail of generosity rather than selfishness.*

We've misunderstood fun to mean enjoyment without effort

September 15, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Play Anything by Ian Bogost

> *What does it mean for something to be fun? If you wanted to design a fun toaster, or lead a fun classroom, or advertise a fun job, or write a fun book, how would you go about it? If you wanted to find a fun appliance to buy, or a fun course to take, or a fun career to pursue, or a fun book to read, what heuristic would you choose to select one? Most of us have no idea. We don't even know what fun is, even though we claim to want it in everything. We've misunderstood fun to mean enjoyment without effort. Nothing has been spared the cursed attempt to "make it fun"; everything whatsoever hopes to transform itself into a delightful little morsel of sugar in your mouth.*

The paradox of fun

September 15, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Play Anything by Ian Bogost

> *The paradox of fun is this: we think fun is enjoyment, but in practice it often feels like quite the opposite. On the one hand, we'd never think to describe uncomfortable or distressing experience as fun ones, but on the other hand, discomfort or distress often characterize the experiences we later describe as fun. A fun match of soccer might involve physical and emotional injury; a fun trip to the zoo might entail heat exhaustion and stained overalls. And yet fun doesn't feel like suffering either, exactly, even when it literally involves suffering. Otherwise we'd not call it fun, but hardship.*

The Nintendo 3DS and the Importance of Ports

September 15, 2018

Categories: Business

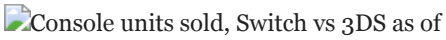
Viewers of Nintendo's 9.13.2018 Direct were witness to a treasure trove of future Switch titles. To name a few:

- *Animal Crossing*
- *Luigi's Mansion 3*
- *Mega Man 11*
- *Final Fantasy VII, IX, X, X-2, XII* ports
- *Yoshi's Crafted World*
- *New Super Mario Bros. U* port
- *Diablo III*
- *Civilization VI*

But the one announcement I keep coming back to is the 3DS port of *Kirby's Epic Yarn* — a 2010 Wii title — in the form of *Kirby's Extra Epic Yarn*.

This is not the first Nintendo home console port to the 7-year-old portable console — *Donkey Kong Country Returns* (Wii), *Xenoblade Chronicles* (Wii), most recently *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* (Wii U), to name a few — but it was the first during this Nintendo Direct. Shortly after, a port of the GameCube launch title *Luigi's Mansion* (2001) was announced as a ~~marketing tactic~~ fix to hold fans over for *Luigi's Mansion 3* on the Switch.

Current sales numbers of the Switch reflect that of the hugely popular PS4. But even with that success, it's fascinating to see Nintendo port back-catalog console titles to it's aged handheld. The telling reason is the 3DS's continued sales numbers, continuing to post 6.4 million units sold during Nintendo's fiscal year 2018 ending March 31, 2018 alone.


Console units sold, Switch vs 3DS as of September, 15 2018

It's one thing that Wii U titles are seeing new life on the Switch — *Mario Kart 8*, *Hyrule Warriors*, *Donkey Kong Country: Tropical Freeze*, *Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker* — but it's even more interesting the see the same tactic for a device that third-party support has all but dried up.

Nintendo sees continued life in the 3DS — a 2017 version in the New Nintendo 2DS XL is probably one clue — and seems to have found a method to maintaining the growth of an already stellar catalog with it's own IP.

Short of the minority who still own a Gamecube or Wii, there is no other place to play Nintendo titles like *Kirby's Epic Yarn*, *Luigi's Mansion*, *Donkey Kong Country Returns*, or *Xenoblade Chronicles* — all of which have or will have a Switch sequel. If you don't have a 3DS/2DS, these games may be attractive enough to pick one up on the opportunity to play or replay alone. But even for existing owners of the 3DS/2DS, this stable of first-party ports are certain to whet appetites for their Switch sequels.

The 3DS is a brilliant promotional tool for the Nintendo Switch.

Books Are My New Albums

September 24, 2018

Categories: Media

The perfect song is “Have You Forgotten” by The Red House Painters.

Not the official album version on “Songs for a Blue Guitar”, but the version that only appears on the soundtrack for Cameron Crowe’s 2001 film *Vanilla Sky*, of which the song only appears for a brief moment during the film: six minutes in, lasting only 20 seconds, and tucked into the background under banter between Cameron Diaz and Tom Cruise. Easily missed if you’re not paying attention.

So, how did I find it?

Some time around 2003, I was on a family trip to Oregon. My brother and I were driving through Oregon’s lush mountains, trailing my parents and grandparents who were navigating. It was a beautiful day in a beautiful space. Tired of the CDs we had been spinning, I decided to pop in the *Vanilla Sky* soundtrack. It was my favorite film at the time.

I came to own the CD after hearing a song at the end of the film that moved me profoundly. The lyrics were foreign and I never heard sonics like it. Certain it must be on the soundtrack, I tracked a copy down and scoured. Not Radiohead. Not Peter Gabriel. Not Afrika Bambaataa. Of those artists I’d never heard of: not two seconds into the Red House Painters track it sounded too structured — skip — but Sigur Rós sounded close. It was not quite right, but I was tracking the right scent.

Fumbling around the early-‘00s internet, Sigur Rós’s website listed a slew of live recordings, one of which was the track used for _Vanilla Sky_’s finale; what would become known as “Untitled 4” or “Njósnavélin” or “The Nothing Song”.

Needless to say, I had never listened to the full *Vanilla Sky* soundtrack before. I had only purchased it on the chance of obtaining “The Nothing Song”.

So, a time came during our trek to Oregon that I was sick of the other albums I’d brought, and decided to give the *Vanilla Sky* soundtrack a spin.

“Have You Forgotten” came on and the world became a painting. After the first listen, I listened again. And again. And again. It was perfect. Lyrically, sonically perfect.

This version is not available via traditional streaming services like Apple Music or Spotify. I could — maybe should — encourage you to purchase the *Vanilla Sky* soundtrack, but I’ve done the leg work to discover this gem, so I’ll save you the trouble. Just this once:

https://youtube.com/watch?v=8mb1ILIQvdM

The perfect song. Full stop.

Music discovery as we knew it is a thing of the past. Radio is still a powerful tool to promote Top 40 and the latest singles. Deep cuts are just a click away. A playlist will introduce you to bands and tracks of particular themes or influence. But the archeological process of obtaining limited releases, a band’s first EP, or a compilation for a single track have been fast removed in the day and age of streaming. Albums can be thrown away after a track or two in instead of considered an investment; not pilfered

or appreciated for their concept or the one magic gem hidden before Track 1, tucked away at Track 7, or 10 minutes after the last song. It's free to listen and time is money.

That's not to say it's a bad thing. Quite the contrary. I would have killed to have all of this music at my disposal as a teenager. Money was tight but my craving for new music was not. $5 would score me a new *Punk-O-Rama* compilation with 20 tracks. $10 would buy an album at Best Buy — maybe not the one I was looking for, but anything was better than nothing. $20 for something more desirable but a little harder to find at Tower Records. I recall finding The Appleseed Cast's *Low Level Owl: Vols 1 and 2* at two different stores in Berkeley — my crowning music discovery bounty.

For better or worse, those days are long gone. Even a local punk band can release music on Apple Music for $20 and a few clicks. It's (virtually) all there.

If the music discovery itch has been scratched, what is the next frontier? Truth be told, it's quite possibly the oldest form of media discovery out there: Books.

Amongst the centuries of tomes, the mountains of paper and ink, books are ripe with treasure. One that speaks to me may not speak to you. Chapter 4 is not Track 4. Jumping to the good part is not an option. Short of a collection, books must be taken in as a whole. And that whole is an investment up front. Choose wisely. And if you're short on dough, hopefully your choice nets out a sentence or two that you can hang your hat on. Something meaty. A compass. An inspiration. A goal.

It's all very obvious, but for someone who lived and breathed music and didn't take up reading until age 29, it feels like rediscovering an old me. I've read 16 books this year. 12 in 2017 and 24 in 2016. Some are good. Some are bad. I finish all of them. Even a bad book hones my hunt for something perfect. All wash over you. All are an experience. All cost money and time and patience.

I'm still searching for the perfect book; the perfect passage; the perfect sentence. Hear you me, it will be done. (It won't.) But until then, discovery is back in my life. The hunt is on. Thankful, I have not forgotten.

Oh, and the perfect album is Elliott's "Song in the Air".

Cross-platform play coming to PS4, starting with Fortnite

September 26, 2018

Categories: Business

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *Sony has finally stopped fighting the future: A beta for cross-platform play, including support for Fortnite, launches today.*
>
> *"The first step will be an open beta beginning today for Fortnite that will allow for cross platform gameplay, progression and commerce across PlayStation 4, Android, iOS, Nintendo Switch, Xbox One, Microsoft Windows, and Mac operating systems," PlayStation president and global CEO John Kodera wrote on the PlayStation Blog. "We see the beta as an opportunity to conduct thorough testing that ensures cross-platform play is best on PlayStation, while being mindful about the user experience from both a technical and social perspective."*
>
> *This is a major reversal of its longstanding policy of keeping PlayStation fans segregated from the rest of the industry, after arguing that cross-platform play might even be unsafe. Others in the industry had argued that the policy was due to monetary concerns. Many publishers, including Bethesda, had been pressuring Sony to make this change, and developers such as Psyonix have already spoken openly about how easy the change would be to implement from their end.*

This is industry shaking news. With this breakthrough, cross-platform play will become a new norm.

Not to belabor the "console wars", but I suspect this will encourage deeper investment in first-party exclusives (Nintendo's game) leading to more studio acquisitions (Microsoft's new game), as well as bigger deals for third-party exclusives (Sony's game, traditionally).

Finally. Finally. Finally. Finally.

There are too many video games. What now?

September 28, 2018

Categories: Business

Excerpts from Steven Wright's Polygon Cover Story, emphasis my own:

> *"**Everyone can make games**, but be realistic. … It used to be that you could do something that nobody had ever seen before, or you could do something familiar really well. Now, it has to be innovative and have incredible quality."*

Games are surely easier to make than ever before. Easy for me to say as I've never made a game, but I have to believe that today's technology has decreased the barrier of entry to development. That's not to say it's easy to create a *good* game. Like any good art or media, that is an incredibly difficult feat.

The tech to create games is more accessible than ever. Formal eduction to learn how to make games has become readily available. The distribution of games becomes increasingly easy via tools like Epic's Unreal Engine which allows developers to "more easily ship games and seamlessly optimize gameplay across platforms."

For those developers creating online experiences, the choice and complexity of platform to develop for and release to shrinks ever more with cross-platform play becoming increasingly popular.

It begs the question there is inevitably one experience everywhere, how do the plethora of games become seen? I believe indies will come to depend on large publishers for marketing budgets to cut through the cruft. But those publishers will be increasingly looking for guarantees on their investments. Not a chance on a new indie title.

> *When Finnish studio Housemarque released a twin-stick shooter called Nex Machina into the wilds of Steam in 2017, it didn't exactly expect the game to to set tills alight. Even with those lowered expectations, however, the team behind the acclaimed defend-'em-up Resogun found itself **shocked at the lack of impact that the Housemarque name seemed to have on the droves of consumers scrolling through Steam every day**. When the sales numbers finally trickled t in — Housemarque declined to discuss specifics for this story, but SteamSpy and this recently patched achievement leak puts the number slightly below 100,000 copies sold as of summer 2018 — the mood was somber, with the studio's head of publishing, Mikael Haveri, describing it as "devastating."*

The past few games I've played (and enjoyed!) on iOS have been published by Annapurna Interactive. The brand has made its impression. I couldn't tell you the developer of any of these games.

The frequency at which a publisher for multiple developers can get its brand in front of the player is far greater than any indie developer. Recognition by saturation.

If the publisher is able to consistently publish top-notch experiences, they also become a trusted curator of which players will seek new titles.

If a developer seeks to have the same level of recognition, they are absolutely required to create something "innovative and of incredible quality" to compel a player to invest in their complete experience, thus building a relationship. The longer the experience lasts, the deeper the relationship becomes.

Blizzard and Epic have created addictive experiences that continue pull players back in over and over, again and again, for hours on end; drilling their brand in with each launch of the game as well as their proprietary launchers and stores.

Nintendo iterates on familiar and successful franchises to deepen the association of a particular IP to Nintendo, thus deepening the player's relationship with and trust in Nintendo. Should a new Nintendo IP comes along, chances are those with a relationship with Nintendo will give it a try. And because Nintendo consistently creates stellar experience, the trust will likely grow.

Capybara Games released an innovative title of incredible quality for iOS in *Superbrothers: Sword & Sworcery* days after the iPad 2 was released — arguably the first experience of its kind. The title was of novel design, mysterious, tonally unique, integrated social sharing to encourage peer-to-peer marketing, and was immersive and long enough to draw players back in through to completion during the early days of a platform. While Capybara may not be a household name, their design and tone is now familiar.

All of this said, the chances of a developer becoming a household name are far slimmer than a publisher who's essentially become a curator. The same could be send for indie record labels and film distribution/production houses.

> *Devolver's Nigel Lowry says that although many industry veterans and gamers alike think of the gaming market as a finite amount of money that hungry consumers are willing to spend in a given time period — say, this bloody holiday season, which is particularly awash with high-profile franchises that must duke it out, such as Assassin's Creed and Red Dead Redemption —* ***in the past few years, it's become apparent that the limiting factor isn't measured in dollars, but hours****. In a climate where every game is stuffed to the gills with five tiers of colored loot, massive open worlds, reams of optional content and a dozen content patches lurking on the schedule before the core package even hits store shelves, it seems that game developers are battering each other harder than ever before to compete for the attention of games worldwide.*
>
> *"Even if the most hardcore gamer plays 14 hours a day, that's still a finite amount of time," he says. "And if you're spending 10 of those in a PUBG, or a Fortnite, what does that leave for the rest of us? It's true that timing of release is critical, sure, and I don't think that single-player, smaller-scope games are going to go away; there's always going to be room for that. But time is something that you really can't move, and you have to account for that when people move into these long-term relationships with games.*

See Self-competing and Time Blocking.

I truly don't know what the future of indies is, but it doesn't look great.

Hunch: Nintendo Revives “Super” Branding

October 3, 2018

Categories: Business, Media

Moments ago, WSJ broke news that WSJ is breaking Nintendo news.

Earlier this evening, after seeing reviews for *Super Mario Party* emerge, it dawned on me the appropriateness of the "super" brand in an era of mid-cycle console refreshes. The Super Nintendo Entertainment System was a next-gen console at the time, but "Super" now feels like a supreme version of an existing console.

My crack-pot hunch is that this new Switch will be named the "Super Switch" (as opposed to "Switch XL") and will feature a larger display (smaller bezel), richer speakers, better kickstand placement, and Bluetooth headphone support at a minimum. Just a hunch.

The Xbox One X makes a lot more sense in 2018

October 29, 2018

Categories: Business, Technology

Ben Kuchera, Polygon:

> *The ability to play classic games in 4K is one of the most interesting, and sometimes under-discussed, features of the Xbox One X. The system currently provides the only way to play the first Red Dead Redemption in 4K, and doing so is absolutely worth your time. The list of Xbox One X-enhanced games that are backward-compatible isn't huge — there are currently only 21 as of this writing — but there are some jewels in there, from the original Mirror's Edge to Portal.*

I bought a 4K HDR TV last weekend. My first thought after purchasing it was, "PS4 Pro or Xbox One X?"

Thankfully for my wallet, the original PS4 supports HDR, and that's more meaningful than 4K in my book. But had I owned neither, I'd be all over the Xbox One X.

While the breadth of catalog isn't there, there's certainly enough for my casual needs. But most importantly, for cross-platform games, I'd know I'm getting the best console experience on the market. That's tough to swallow for a snob like me.

Between (enhanced) backwards-compatibility, early adoption of cross-platform multiplayer, and unmatched performance, I agree with Kuchera. This will be a holiday to watch Microsoft.

Storytelling. Corner.

Hot Wheels don’t teach auto mechanics

November 11, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Deep Work by Cal Newport

> *The complex reality of the technologies that real companies leverage to get ahead emphasizes the absurdity of the now common idea that exposure to simplistic, consumer-facing products—especially in schools—somehow prepares people to succeed in a high-tech economy. Giving students iPads or allowing them to film homework assignments on YouTube prepares them for a high-tech economy about as much as playing with Hot Wheels would prepare them to thrive as auto mechanics.*

Washed Up Emo: ‘It felt like you were turning a page of a book that you’d never opened before’

November 14, 2018

Categories: Media

Tom Mullen, host of the Washed Up Emo podcast, interviewing Justin Courtney Pierre of Motion City Soundtrack fame:

> ***JCP**: Now we’re all on Twitter and Instagram. We can see at least a version of ourselves that we want to put out to the world, which is still more than when you had to find that one article of the band where they had a few paragraphs. You had to read it. You didn’t get to see video of the person that’s speaking.*
>
> *It’s just so much easier to connect to people now. There less mystery involved. I think back then, everyone just seemed way cooler than they probably were.*
>
> ***TM**: This is brought up a bunch because of the time period of some of these bands and their age. You knew it before [the internet/connectivity], and now you have it. You have this context of being able to know when you didn’t have it and that feeling, versus someone today who’s younger doesn’t. They’ve only always had a phone. They’ve always had Wikipedia.*
>
> *You talked about that feeling, but it’s also that sense of discovery. It felt like you were turning a page of a book that you’d never opened before. That feeling I try and replicate as much as I can today.*

More and more I realize how detached I am from new music. As much as I looked forward to the new Cursive, Minus the Bear, Saves the Day, and Thrice records, they are new records from old bands. Plus, there was little for me to chew on aside from the music itself. Little in the way of liner-notes, thank yous, etc. Or maybe it’s just my lack of focus, time, and energy.

Even more is that my pendulum of consumption has swung far in the opposite direction of video games to books this year. I don’t think I’ve finished a single game I’ve purchased in 2018.

Together, I now get the sense of discovery I used to have with music intertwined with the insatiable appetite I had for video games rolled into reading. I’m on pace to read more than I ever have in a single year.

I’ve said it before and I’ll say it again, books are my new albums.

If God cannot do this…

December 8, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Letter from a Region in My Mind by James Baldwin for *The New Yorker*, 1962:

> *If the concept of God has any validity or any use, it can only be to make us larger, freer, and more loving. If God cannot do this, then it is time we got rid of Him.*

One needed a handle, a lever, a means of inspiring fear

December 8, 2018

Categories: Commonplace

Letter from a Region in My Mind by James Baldwin for *The New Yorker*, 1962:

> *It was a summer of dreadful speculations and discoveries, of which these were not the worst. Crime became real, for example—for the first time—not as a possibility but as the possibility. One would never defeat one's circumstances by working and saving one's pennies; one would never, by working, acquire that many pennies, and, besides, the social treatment accorded even the most successful Negroes proved that one needed, in order to be free, something more than a bank account. One needed a handle, a lever, a means of inspiring fear. It was absolutely clear that the police would whip you and take you in as long as they could get away with it, and that everyone else—housewives, taxi-drivers, elevator boys, dishwashers, bartenders, lawyers, judges, doctors, and grocers—would never, by the operation of any generous human feeling, cease to use you as an outlet for his frustrations and hostilities. Neither civilized reason nor Christian love would cause any of those people to treat you as they presumably wanted to be treated; only the fear of your power to retaliate would cause them to do that, or to seem to do it, which was (and is) good enough.*

What's in a Creator?

December 16, 2018

Categories: Media

I visit Daring Fireball, Stratechery, Chorus.fm, and Polygon religiously. I support MacStories, Washed Up Emo, and Relay FM. Their content doesn't always land for me and I've become increasingly less wild about their design. So why do I keep coming back? In a nutshell, it's the relationship I have with their creators.

I have a background in the podcast industry. What drew me to it was not the business potential or the medium itself, but the intimacy of the format. I was able to develop a pseudo relationship with the voices at the other end. Only ever consuming podcasts in moments solace while commuting or on a jog, the intimacy intensified. I formed such a bond with the voices on the podcasts I listened to that I wanted to support them. In my mind there was no better way than to join the industry.

The same could be said for my want to join the ranks of the news industry — namely the gaming news industry. In 2013, I'd come across Polygon.com — namely their PS4 and Xbox One reviews. I fell in love with their design and the rich content they were producing. It was a stark contrast from my then favorite gaming site IGN.com. Less clutter. Sharper design. Higher quality writing and videos. I became so engaged with the site that I began deep diving into their creators. Allegra Frank, Ben Kuchera, Tracey Lien, Griffin and Justin McElroy, Ashley Oh, Chris Plante, Dave Tach — the list went on.

I began listening to Polygon's Besties podcast, hosted by Russ Frushtick, Griffin and Justin McElroy, and Chris Plante. Hearing them speak at length, episode after episode, helped me build an intimate, albeit one-sided, relationship with these folks.

And the cherry on top: their custom "Polygon-ified" avatars used on both Polygon.com and Twitter. This made the staff feel like a unit; a family. Many voices that made up a larger whole. Their credit was not mired or obscured as a monolithic publication — one reason I cancelled my subscription to *The Economist*. Much of their team — and Vox Media CEO Jim Bankoff — still use the avatars today.

Needless to say, I connect to outlets not for the outlet's sake, but for the creators I enjoy. Mediums such as podcasts and Twitter bring the personality out of the individuals; and on occasion, the latter allows for actual interaction with these them.

Realizing Polygon was (then) one-third of the greater Vox Media, I took to learning about the creators of the other verticals. And as Vox Media grew, so did their rosters.

Dieter Bohn, Lauren Good, Nilay Petal of *The Verge*. Dan Frommer, Walt Mossberg, and Kara Swisher of *Recode*. Ezra Klein, Dylan Matthews, Libby Nelson, and Matthew Yglesias of *Vox*.

Over the weekend, after seeing a tweet and retweet by Vox Media COO Trei Brundrett and CEO Jim Bankoff respectively, I listened to Vox Media publisher Melissa Bell on CNN's Reliable Sources Podcast with Brian Stelter:

> *Audiences love our work and they care deeply about our creators. Often times we see them asking our creators, "do have a Pateeon account? Is there a way we can donate money to continue to contribute to your sites? Can we participate in the journalism in some way?"*

> *We want to explore those options for sure. We want to make sure we're building a business that supports our creators. We'll be looking at every business model as we grow.*

I certainly don't know how much of this is true while not working within the walls of the company, but it's certainly something I've felt as an audience member and fan.

Since reading Polygon in 2013, I've been a fan and critic of Vox Media. They've made great technological choices, and some questionable ad and social integrations. But more than anything, they put a focus on their talent. Their creators aren't just a byline — assuming those stick around. They are featured in their text, audio, *and* video. Their engaging — and often times incredibly long — features are showcased on other Vox Media verticals. And talent from one outlet will appear on another's podcast.

I have asked several Vox Media staff if I can somehow, someway contribute — donate through their sites or via Patreon; hell, publish print and take a margin. I want these creators to succeed! And I want the platform that gives them such a voice to be bolstered. I haven't seen anything concrete yet, but I did buy Polygon's *500 Years Later: An Oral History of Final Fantasy VII* by Matt Leone as soon as it went up for pre-order.

I feel I have a connection and loyalty to Vox Media's creators first, their sites second; much like I do for independents John Gruber (*Daring Fireball*), Ben Thompson (*Stratechery*), Jason Tate (*Chorus.fm*), Tom Mullen (*Washed Up Emo*), and others. It's the talent that always brings me back. And I'll continue to do everything in my power to support the creators.

Vox Video Lab

December 17, 2018

Categories: Media

Vox.com:

> *You know that feeling you get when you learn something that blows your mind, something new, something that perhaps you didn't even think to ask about? That's our goal with every Vox video: We want to help you understand the world in a visually clear, creative, and hopefully beautiful way.*
>
> *If that sounds like a mission you support, and you love our videos, then we ask that you consider joining the Vox Video Lab, our brand-new membership program on YouTube that will help us give you even more ambitious explainer videos and series.*
>
> *Why are we doing this? The core reason is pretty simple: Our videos take a ton of work.*

Well, how about that. The day after divulging my affinity for Vox Media's creators, they establish their first membership program.

Thrilled to be a Video Lab Advisory Board member.

2018 Reads

December 30, 2018

Categories: General



This year, I did a bit of catching up. No thanks to Nintendo and the Switch, 2017 was largely spent scavenging Hyrule and the Mushroom Kingdom. In 2018, I leapt back into books — many of which I'd been meaning to read for a few years.

Needless to say, I quite possibly read more in 2018 than any other year of my life. Honestly, I can't say any of these reads were horrible (though I'm one to find good in anything). Some certainly better than others. All a bit scattered amongst genre.

Without further adieu, here are my 2018 reads, ordered from most favorite to least.

The Handmaid's Tale

Margaret Atwood



Horribly chilling in light of the US today. The extreme justifications of Law and Government's Will as God's own feel too real and terrible. Published in 1985, no less.

My god, what a read.

Americanah

Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie



Shortly after we moved to San Francisco, I found a copy of *Americanah* in our building's shared laundry room — in the communal stack of books and magazines. I had heard great things on *The New York Times Book Review Podcast* and swooped it up immediately. (Truthfully, nothing stands between me and a beautifully formatted hardcover.)

A gut-wrenching love story, relatable and not. A story of America, relatable and not. A bare truth of race in this country that's all so evident, yet can never be reinforced enough — now more than ever. A perspective unlike any other.

"Love was a kind of grief. This was what the novelists meant by suffering."

Less

Andrew Sean Greer



What is seemingly a 2-star novel warps and wraps itself into a top-shelf, lovely comedic, and heartfelt story by a 5-star genius. So many “I’ve been there” moments and callbacks to “insignificant” details that the heartfelt and hilarious pangs resound with gut-wrenching timbre.

The story of Arthur Less is a comedic one, filled with the kind of silly anxieties, ghosts of the past, self-deprecation, self-destruction, and self-loathing we all find familiar. Best of all, a story of itself and meta and multiple levels. A protagonist no one should feel sorry for and that’s just the point.

We are all more or less Less.

Creative Selection

Ken Kocienda



A superb look inside software development at Apple and what it means to create team culture. Hard to put down.

I came to this book by way of John Gruber’s *Daring Fireball*. As a manager leading a cross-functional publishing and platform development team, this is a critical peek at what makes Apple quality software.

I’m thankful to have a team staffed with creatives, designers, developers, editors, producers, and writers. Truly the intersection of technology and liberal arts. But success goes beyond the right mix of people. It takes direction and focus. I shared the seven elements Kocienda identifies with my team, asking them which element stood out most to them. Unsurprisingly, we had a healthy mix of craft, taste, inspiration, diligence, and empathy. I’ve since gone on to outfit my team with Kocienda’s book as an artifact of what it takes to get to where Apple is today and to never forget what can be accomplished with a small team.

I advise everyone to read this book.

Brave New World

Aldous Huxley



How did I miss this in high school? A chilling premonition of Today from 1932. Truth vs happiness. No sweet without the sour.

God in the safe and Ford on the shelves.

A masterpiece.

Annihilation

Jeff Vandermeer

As dreamlike, entrancing, and lush as Area X. Vibes like *Sunshine*, *LOST*, *The Abyss*, and *Dear Esther*. Extremely my jam.

The movie is way different, but just as awesome.

The Three-Body Problem

Cixin Liu

How do you even begin to write something this vast, imaginative, complex, and yet entertaining? Such a fun, big read. Awesome first act to a trilogy, but I'm going to need a breather before diving into book two.

Sing, Unburied, Sing

Jesmyn Ward



Imaginative. Mystifying. Infuriating. Poetic. Vivid. Captures an uninhibited train of thought perfectly.

A lonesome and dooming dusk.

The Boys in the Boat

Daniel James Brown



Layers upon layers. Part bio, part sports rivalry, part pre-war omen. Paces like a race: quick off the line, measured through the middle, blasts-off at the end. The descriptions of the competitions had me gripped. Maybe could have been 50-100 pages shorter, but likely meant to portray the weight of perseverance.

The Guernsey Literary and Potato Peel Pie Society

Mary Ann Shaffer and Annie Barrows



This book came as a recommendation from my wife. She'd become insistent on me finishing so we could watch the Netflix film.

While fluffy, it's a fascinating look at the German Occupation in the Channel Islands during WWII — a story not often told, and in the format of letters no less. An easy read full of wonderful characters and whimsy. An easy holiday read.

Deep Work

Cal Newport



I came to this book via The Ezra Klein Show podcast. Cal and Ezra discussed some interesting tips about maximizing productivity during large chunks of the workday. I found the idea of leaving my mornings free and scheduling meetings on the back half of my day compelling. It quickly fell apart as a manager, but the idea is beginning to help some of my employees.

For knowledge workers — engineers, academics, etc — large chunks of uninterrupted time can be critical for working deeply and making large strides in productivity, innovation, and creativity. If you can't always be out of the shallows, find ways to minimize its impact: use a to-do list to track big items/projects; clear your inbox to remove the nagging distraction of something beckoning you; send clear correspondence with precise action items and expectations. If you have a project, find 1–4 hours to focus on it.

The one I'm working on: sign-off by 5:30 and stop thinking about work!

You'll Grow Out of It

Jessi Klein



I'd heard about this book from (once again) *The New York Times Book Review Podcast*. They deemed it something like the better Amy Schumer biography.

With only a blip of a mention of Schumer, I get it. An honest, humbling, and humiliatingly hilarious look into the female experience — womanhood, comedy, writing, aging, and sexuality.

Klein shows that it's truly impossible to empathize with everything everyone goes through. As a male, I'll never understand the twists and turns of womanhood, no matter how many women I have in my life. On the other hand, there's a shocking amount of humiliating and shitty situations we all share.

A light, fun, funny read that will shine a light on experiences you have had, may have, and never will have.

S. / Ship of Theseus

J.J. Abrams and Doug Dorst

If not entirely satisfying, a wholly original work and impressive feat. Glad to have given it a go.

I learned about this book while posting an Event at the Apple Store to the iTunes Store during my time on Apple Podcasts — an interview with J.J. Abrams and Doug Dorst. I couldn't resist the complexity and mystery of the book. My inner-*LOST* nerd needed it. It only took me five years to get to it.

The Kite Runner

Khaled Hosseini



“It was only a smile, nothing more… but I’ll take it.”

A gauntlet and another solid recommendation from my sister, Megan Starr.

A Wrinkle in Time

Madeleine L’Engle



Alice in Wonderland meets *The Little Prince*. A wild, snappy adventure filled with witches, aliens, and — of course — space and time travel.

Wonderland

Steven Johnson



I came across this book from its companion (and clever marketing vehicle) podcast Wonderland.

We are all wired with natural instincts: hunger, thirst, sex. (Hypothalamus keeping us right!) Yet, we crave and are fascinated by surprise. “When the world surprises us with something, our brains are wired to pay attention.” Even without any seemingly productive ends, we explore and yearn for new experiences. We play. “The pleasure of play is understandable. The *productivity* of play is harder to explain.” Play propels our creativity and innovation.

“You will find the future wherever people are having the most fun.” Humans are funny space creatures. If only we would all just play a little more.

Underground Airlines

Ben H. Winters



Gripping, thrilling, tight. Cinematic and easy to envision. A take on the reality of fending for oneself in the direst of situations. Sympathy for an antihero. Ego vs Id. Battle of conscience. Complexities unraveling themselves hours after finishing.

Power-Up

Chris Kohler



Great historical reference and a fun look back on video game history. Made even better by reading during a trip to Tokyo! Ended a bit misty-eyed at the Iwata remembrance. Thanks to Pavan Rajam for

the recommendation.

Play Anything

Ian Bogost


Play Anything

I picked this up after reading a triple-review of *Death by Video Game* (ultra fav!), *The Tetris Effect* (fascinating), and *Play Anything*. I tweeted a photo of the review — proud I had read two of three books in an NYT Book Review. With permission, Mr. Bogost used the photo for his own tweet. Photo credit would have been cool, but it was still a neat moment.

Play Anything reads like an academic paper on how we define "fun". There are plenty of choice quotes and great insights. However, they are mired in thick sets of highbrow, like diamonds in tons of rough of proof and reference. As much as Bogost preaches the ability to find fun in challenge, I couldn't find much fun here. Bogost would call this "hardship". At the very least, amongst bits of beautiful insight, Bogost's writing has a musical quality. It's easy to wade around in it, even if you're not taking it all in.

Maybe my expectations were initially misaligned by a NYT review of books about games. I'd also argue Bogost's title doesn't help. Rather than "Play Anything", this should have been titled "The Paradox of Fun", "Fun Theory", "The Power of Limits", or simply "Read David Foster Wallace".

Bogost proves to be an incredibly smart philosopher, but his philosophy of fun may be better as a longform feature rather than an entire book.

Hillbilly Elegy

J.D. Vance


Hillbilly Elegy

I'm a firm believer of education, but nothing benefits like a happy home. The Rust Belt is under a microscope, but these problems affect California, too.

Into the Water

Paula Hawkins


Into the Water

Fun first 2/3. Tedious final act. Illuminating epilogue. Unlikeable characters. Can't say I'd recommend it, but suffices as a page-turner.

Gruber: ‘There is a thing to being “Mac-like”’

January 1, 2019

Categories: Design

John Gruber, with guest Jason Snell, on his podcast *The Talk Show with John Gruber*:

> *There is a thing to being “Mac-like”. And there was, and it was strong. It’s literally what kept Apple alive.*
>
> *If Mac-likeness hadn’t been an important thing, there’s no reason everybody wouldn’t have switched to Windows at the time — that there was more to it than, ‘OK, you’ve got a rectangular window and the windows all have “close” buttons and “zoom” buttons, and then there’s a menu bar with an agreed upon set of typical things like “file”, “edit”, “font”. You double-click on an app. There’s a mouse that moves around. You can select text. There’s a scroll bar over on the side you can drag up-and-down to move up-and-down on a document. And there you go — there’s a GUI. If you can use one, you can use any one and that’s all there is to it.’*
>
> *It is true that that is the description of the modern graphical user interface of a windowing system. But there’s so much more to the Mac-way of doing things and of organizing things. And of feeling at home. It’s such an amazing thing when you feel at home in an app you’ve never used before because it uses all these familiar conventions. Those conventions went so much deeper than just draggable windows with a “close” button and a menu bar.*

This is a great discussion of the level of detail and consideration for human interface guidelines. I encourage you to give it a list. It struck me as I closely followed Twitter’s branding guidelines for the redesigned footer of Zero Counts.

I became a Mac convert in 2004 with the iBook G4. Before that, I was put off by the consistency of Mac apps, which is a wild thing to consider. I mistook variety in user interfaces for freedom, and thus, the Mac as a restrictive system. This notion was reinforced by the Mac’s minimal amount of hardware customization. Together, the Mac was but a toy for casual users. I had completely missed the point of the Mac, and apparently had no consideration for elegant design.

The level of consistency displayed in a majority of the most popular Mac apps makes it all the more apparent when something doesn’t quite feel right. Not to mention when something is completely disorienting. The app that jumps out to me most is *Pixelmator*.

Pixelmator includes loads of floating windows and tools. If I’m not mistaken, this was inspired by the original Photoshop GUI. I’ve been a big fan of *Pixelmator*, but I’ve always felt lost in it’s GUI.

Now, with the single window design of the new *Pixelmator Pro*, I feel at home. It’s not to say I’m completely familiar with all of the ins and outs, but I was able to immediately jump in and find my way around.

As the successor to a heavily used app, reworking the entire GUI is incredibly risky. But the ease at which a longtime *Pixelmator* user can dive into *Pixelmator Pro* with little effort is a testament to the macOS HIG.

The year in gaming controversies

January 2, 2019

Categories: Business

Colin Campbell, Polygon:

> *These events must lead most observers to the view that game companies have a long way to go before they can truly present themselves as caring about their employees, their customers, or the world that they inhabit. But they are at least now subject to vociferous disapproval when they make their most grotesque mistakes.*
>
> *Perhaps meetings are taking place right now, in which execs are noting the previous damage of their own actions, and making necessary alterations. More realistically, as we enter the new year, the issue of unions is in the air. If and when employees organize themselves into unions, game companies will have more to worry about than bad publicity. In 2019, maybe we'll see a change for the better. Maybe.*

This article is a great retrospective of an industry on the cusp of being held accountable. I don't say that lightly. These are incidents on record. There's bound to be many, many more that have not been to light. It's wonderful to see focus put on these issues by media outlets.

I'll admit that I remain glued to the video game industry for the fun and surprise of it all. But to see the harsher reality elevated more than ever is refreshing.

In any case, the comments on this article are something else. No one should ever be harassed. No one should ever be expected to work 100 hours per week. No one should be subjected to cheap gambling tactics or unjustified lockout to earn a company an extra penny or two. In 2019, maybe we'll see a change for empathy and maturity from companies and audiences alike. Maybe.

UK video games market is now 80% digital

January 3, 2019

Categories: Business

Christopher Dring, reporting for GamesIndustry.biz:

> *It seems a bit negative for the physical market, but these figures do not include hardware. And actually more consoles were sold in 2018 than in 2017. GamesIndustry.biz can reveal over 2.4 million games machines were sold in the UK last year. PS4 was the biggest selling console, with sales flat year-on-year, but Nintendo Switch was the biggest growth area, with Switch console sales up more than 20 percent.*
>
> *Indeed, physical remains a strong part of the games retail business. According to ERA, the best-selling game of the year was FIFA 19 with 2.5 million units sold... 1.89 million of those sales came physically. That means when it comes to AAA releases, digital sales only account for around 25 per cent of the games sold. However, that percentage is getting bigger. Last year, 20% of FIFA 18's sales were digital.*

I don't find it terribly surprising that an annual sports title garners the top spot for physical game sales. I can already see the GameStop shelves littered with used copies of FIFA '19 this fall.

The trend of the rise in digital also comes as unsurprising when physical games are all met with a barrage of software updates. Sure, one may be able to save a few bucks on a physical copy — and sell it back — but in the world of instant gratification, digital download — albeit a tens-of-gigabytes download — is quicker than a trip to the store plus a tens-of-gigabytes update.

20 Years of StarCraft

January 5, 2019

Categories: History

Kosta Andreadis, writing for IGN:

> *In the mid-to-late 1990s, the real-time strategy (RTS) genre was not only popular but ubiquitous. RTS games of various styles and settings were everywhere, and a company named Blizzard Entertainment was at the forefront. The studio had become a household name with gamers thanks – primarily – to three titles: 1994's Warcraft: Orcs & Humans, 1995's Warcraft II: Tides of Darkness and an action role-playing game released on the final day of 1996 (and developed by Blizzard North), Diablo. These games cemented Blizzard as a company that made high quality cinematic story-driven experiences that were fun, accessible, and infinitely repayable.*
>
> *With StarCraft, its third real-time strategy game, Blizzard would leave behind the fantasy world of the breakout Warcraft franchise and set its sights on the distant future. It would take players to a science-fiction setting where humans and strange alien races engaged in isometric high-tech warfare. And the studio would go on a journey of its own; in the time between Warcraft II and _StarCraft_'s launch in 1998 the look and feel of the game would change drastically - alongside its story, characters, vehicles and other player-controlled units. This is the story of that evolution... and the success beyond.*

I remember seeing the original *StarCraft* trailer for the first time. If memory serves, the trailer was included in the *WarCraft II: Beyond the Dark Portal* expansion set CD-ROM. At the time, the trailer felt like something out of a Ridley Scott film, only grander. Comedic space goons alarmed and destroyed by a large, brooding, mysterious craft. I was bewildered.

Andreadis has put together a tight, well-written retrospective of *StarCraft*. If you enjoyed the original in the late '90s, there are lots of great bits of development insight in here.

The following might be my favorite bit:

> *Compared to the advances made in digital recording technology available today, to create the sounds and music for StarCraft the team made use of a suite of external synthesizers and outboard hardware, utilising more traditional recording techniques. "Early versions of some of the sounds were pretty cringeworthy," Glenn admits. "Certain units required more experimentation to get something really unique and special. The first version of the Hydralisk was just plain silly until we figured out how to make them 'talk' without words." This experimentation led to some interesting sources for what many consider to be some of the best sound effects for an RTS of any era.*
>
> *"Lots of units in the game started with voice as the origin; our voices," Glenn reveals. "Though most are tweaked beyond recognition. We also used voice for sound effects, such as the Marines' walkie talkie static. Voice and mouth sounds, like whispers, hisses, and breathing were a big contributor to creating source material to be processed into various strange effects, sweeteners, ambiences and even in the music. One of the chittering Zergling sounds is just me grabbing my cheeks and flapping them open and closed quickly. Processed with pitch and other effects afterwards."*

Unfortunately, no details on the Nintendo 64 port.

Jim Guthrie and the Below soundtrack

January 18, 2019

Categories: Music

Polygon and Bandcamp recently profiled and interviewed composer Jim Guthrie (*Superbrothers: Sword & Sworcery EP*, *Planet Coaster*) on his soundtrack for the years long project *Below*.

The game has been receiving luke warm reviews, but the aesthetic and score are something else entirely. In fact, the *Below* announcement trailer that debuted at E3 2013 propelled me to (illogically) purchase an Xbox One. The game wouldn't actually be released until 2018. I still have yet to purchase it.

In any case, these bits from the aforementioned interviews stuck out to me:

Polygon:

> *A few years ago, he happened upon a series of YouTube tutorials about a studio technique using a four-track cassette recorder. The idea was to record a single, sustained note — hence the EHX Superego — and stack it on top of several similar, harmonic pitches to form a chord.*
>
> *"You record that drone for one whole side of the tape," Guthrie says, "so it's like a 30-minute drone. Then I did that on the other three tracks, so I had four different chords made up of drones. And you basically run all that through a bunch of delay and reverb. You press play on the tape, and then you can essentially play the faders, and just swell the volume up and down really slowly and cycle through different chords. That's when we hit a mood that was really dark and pretty, and sort of lonely. I managed to get a lot of mileage out of that."*

Bandcamp:

> ***I noticed that when you're crafting items in the game, there's this tonal/harmony thing that happens there. Did you have a hand in that?***
>
> *Yeah, I don't know where the idea really came from, but that was super intentional. I made noises that would sort of stack on top of each other and create a chord. I worked with Kris on that. But yeah, we're always looking for things like that where you're making music with the game. It wasn't so subtle. It's a little happy succession of notes that sort of lead up to a moment when you craft.*

This reminded me of a version of Silent Night I'd recorded years ago. I looped single, droning notes performed with an Ebow into a Line 6 DL4 to create chords. These were then recorded into GarageBand and used as samples:



If you'd like to hear more Death Starr, why not check out my cover of _The Talk Show with John Gruber_'s theme song "Pickin' Booger's with John".

Activision, Microsoft, and Platforms

January 20, 2019

Categories: Business

This post comes heavily inspired from a recent GamesIndustry.biz Podcast episode, "What now for Activision":

> *Whether part of the ten-year agreement between the two firms or due to a change in strategy, there's no denying that the break-up leaves a Destiny-shaped hole in Activision's limited portfolio (NB: We mean Activision specifically, which is left with Call of Duty and the Crash/Spyro remakes -- the wider company of Activision Blizzard is doing just fine, as is Bungie).*
>
> *Matt, Chris and James ponder whether Activision will seek its next billion-dollar franchise from another third-party studio like Bungie or perhaps turn to the many developers it already owns (most of which are working on Call of Duty) to come up with fresh ideas.*

To get you up to speed, Activision Blizzard recently announced the departure of a partnership with Bungie and *Destiny*:

Joint Statement from Activision and Bungie:

> *Today, we're announcing plans for Bungie to assume full publishing rights and responsibilities for the Destiny franchise. Going forward, Bungie will own and develop the franchise, and Activision will increase its focus on owned IP and other projects. Activision and Bungie are committed to a seamless transition for the Destiny franchise and will continue to work closely together during the transition on behalf of the community of Destiny players around the world.*

Additionally, from Bungie:

> *We have enjoyed a successful eight-year run and would like to thank Activision for their partnership on Destiny. Looking ahead, we're excited to announce plans for Activision to transfer publishing rights for Destiny to Bungie. With our remarkable Destiny community, we are ready to publish on our own, while Activision will increase their focus on owned IP projects.*

Activision Blizzard accounts for the following companies (Q3 MAUs for the games companies provided for context):

- Activision (46M)
- Blizzard (37M)
- King (262M)
- Major League Gaming (MLG)
- Activision Blizzard Studios
- Activision Blizzard Consumer Products

Q1 2016 was the last time Activision Blizzard included their "Portfolio of Compelling Owned Franchises":

Activision

- *Call of Duty*
- *Destiny*
- *Skylanders*

Blizzard

- *Warcraft*
- *Diablo*
- *StarCraft*
- *Overwatch*
- *Hearthstone*
- *Heroes of the Storm*

King

- *Candy Crush*
- *Pet Rescue*
- *Bubble Witch 2*
- *Farm Heroes*

In 2018, that list looks like this:

Activision

- *Call of Duty*

Blizzard

- *Warcraft*
- *Diablo*
- *StarCraft*
- *Overwatch*
- *Hearthstone*
- *Heroes of the Storm*

King

- *Candy Crush Saga*
- *Pet Rescue Saga*
- *Bubble Witch 2 Saga*
- *Farm Heroes Saga*

There are two notable titles missing from that list, both under the Activision banner.

Now, Activision Blizzard can (and probably should) be looked at as a whole. But as a player of many Activision titles of yore — *MechWarrior, Tony Hawk, Guitar Hero* (and while not yore, the *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles* franchise, mi amor) to name a few — it's difficult to separate the name from the reality. It doesn't help that aside from Nintendo, Blizzard might have been the only recognizable gaming name to me, quality or otherwise, growing up. It's hard to look past a name.

With only *Call of Duty*, is Activision still a name? If so, if not, what's next?

Launcher Wars


Snapshot of macOS gaming launchers on January 21, 2019

Launched in 2003, Steam boasts 150 million active users and 27,000 games. The sheer number of games is in large part thanks to the Steam Greenlight and Direct developer programs. Steam has traditionally been known as a bastion for indie developers. However, the recent drastic increase in velocity of titles launching on Steam is making it harder and harder for indies to break through the noise. But it remains that Steam is the standard for PC/Mac gaming.

In 2013, Activision Blizzard launched the Battle.Net Launcher — a one-stop-shop to launching Blizzard IP *Warcraft*, *Diablo*, *StarCraft*, and now *Hearthstone*, *Overwatch*, and *Heroes of the Storm*. In 2017, this list expanded to Bungie's *Destiny 2* under the Activision banner. In 2018, Activision's *Call of Duty: Black Ops 4* was added to the launcher. Upon the announcement that *Destiny 2* would be arriving on the launcher, Blizzard released a statement that there were no plans to expand to other third-party titles:

> *Our focus in terms of supporting non-Blizzard games is solely around Destiny 2. Aside from potentially evaluating needs or opportunities for future Activision games, we don't have any short- or long-term plans to support third-party games with Battle.net. It's important to us to maintain our quality standards for any experience or service we're putting in front of our players, which represents a big investment of time and effort on our part, so this is not something we're jumping into lightly.*

With only two launchers to choose from — one with Blizzard exclusives two behemoth franchises *Destiny* and *Call of Duty*, one with everything else — it'd make sense to keep the Battle.Net Launcher tightly curated to first-party IP.

2018: Enter the Epic Games Store. Dissatisfied with the 30% cut Steam was taking from sales, Epic decided to compete with Steam by releasing their own store, only taking a 22% cut of DRM-free game sales. While the Epic Games Store is slim pickings now, Epic is home to *Fortnite*, arguably the biggest video game ever with 200 million accounts. As of this post, *Fortnite* can still be downloaded independently of the Epic Games Store launcher on Mac/PC, but I imagine in due time the launcher will be required. To add, the Epic Games Store is signing exclusive titles such as Ubisoft's *Tom Clancy's The Division 2* and Early Access to Supergiant's *Hades*.

If I'm reading the tealeaves correctly, my hunch is that the Epic Games Store is attempting to marry the two models of Steam and Battle.net — loads of third-party content with an attractive revenue model, plus first- and third-party exclusives.

The Platform

More often than not, it seems like I can play any third-party indie title on the platform of my choosing. Let's take *Celeste* as an example. I have the option of playing *Celeste* on my Mac, PS4, Xbox One, and Switch. I chose the Switch as the benefit of portability outweighs online community or big-screen gaming. The Switch has also become my platform of choice as I'm a big fan of Nintendo's IP. Having all of the content I care about on a single, portable console is a huge draw. (Cue "put everything on Switch" chant.) The friction of bouncing between consoles or being couch-locked is removed.

But the Switch doesn't have everything, nor can it. It is underpowered to run a healthy majority of AAA games released on PS4, Xbox One, and — the furthest in the power spectrum — the PC. Where HD Twins PS4 and Xbox One compete on the basis of exclusives and online communities/features, the PC competes on the basis of quantity and power; quantity curated by a slew of game launchers. I'd wager to bet most PC/Mac gamers have installed *Steam* — the heavyweight PC/Mac games store — *Battle.Net Launcher* (Blizzard) — the exclusive franchise launcher heavyweight — and, as of December 2018, the *Epic Games Store* — the home of the heavyweight game *Fortnite*. Regardless, short of a download and account setup, there is no friction involved open multiple game launchers for different titles on the same hardware platform.

If friction doesn't exist, what's the benefit to the user? None. So, what's the point of a launcher? Other than a marketplace for multiple titles or first-party content, it's a marketing opportunity. Third-party games have an opportunity to be showcased and sold alongside large exclusives — exclusives which attract a core audience to the launcher — which in turn nets revenue for both the platform and the third-party. Without a subscription service à la Netflix and Hulu, it's effectively the same à la carte model used by the Nintendo eShop, Playstation Store, and Xbox One Game Store.

However, in the case of Battle.net, the launcher is now being used as a vehicle to attract Blizzard IP players to Activision titles. At the time of this post, the first featured image on Blizzard.com is a trial offer for *Call of Duty: Black Ops*. This offer is also available through the Battle.net launcher, which on a PC can launch both *Call of Duty: Black Ops* and *Destiny 2*.

Does this signaling Activision Blizzard's next move?

Microsoft

I'm going to recall my previous post "Sometimes Failure Leads to Opportunity" with a little help from Ben Thompson:

> *On Microsoft's big acquisitions announcement of studios Ninja Theory (DmC: Devil May Cry, Hellblade: Senua's Sacrifice), Playground Games (Forza Horizon), Undead Labs (State of Decay), and Compulsion Games (We Happy Few):*
>
> > *The Xbox One originally lagged behind the PS4 this generation due to its misguided focus on the living room (including charging $100 more at launch because of the now-discontinued Kinect that was at the center of that effort), but the bigger problem has been a lack of exclusive titles relative to the PS4. One way to counter that is to simply produce them yourself, and these purchases augment Microsoft's ability to do just that.*

This gets at purchasing many smaller studios to begin bolstering IP.

Meanwhile, Microsoft continues taking strides away from the traditional console wars.

Jason Schreier, Kotaku:

> *Truth is, as Team Xbox has been signaling for quite some time now, and as we've gathered from our own conversations with both people in and outside of the company, Microsoft is no longer interested in competing directly with Sony. That's a battle it lost as soon as Xbox executives started outlining its original, odd plans for Xbox One in 2013. The PS4 has*

> *outperformed the Xbox One so resoundingly, Microsoft stopped providing hardware sales figures.*
>
> *Instead of licking its wounds and trying to fight Sony yet again next generation, the Xbox division under Phil Spencer has taken a drastically different approach. What Microsoft wants most today is studios that will help boost its impressive Game Pass subscription service, its upcoming streaming platform, and its continued stabs at PC gaming. Developing big Xbox exclusives is no longer a priority for Microsoft, and in fact, the company decided in 2016 that it would release future games on both Xbox and PC. Soon enough, Game Pass will also be available on PC, and it wouldn't be shocking to see Microsoft embrace Steam—or overhaul the Windows store—as it tries to reach the hundreds of millions of people who play video games on computers.*

Microsoft embracing Steam would have been interesting as it may open doors to the Mac audience as well, but the latest signal from Microsoft paints a different picture.

Satya Nadella via Stratechery (members only):

> *We are in, quite frankly, the early days in all of this, but good momentum and we do have ambitions outside of this which I don't think we covered particularly today with you all. Some things that I'm really invested in is gaming, and the simple idea there is we have as much of a shot to build a subscription business as anybody else. So we describe it as shorthand, "Netflix for games", we have a structural position in that we have both a console business as well as a PC business which happens to be in fact bigger than the console business when it comes to gaming and the idea is to aggregate those sockets with a subscription service, we won't be the only ones, there will be competition just like with other content, there may be a few subscriptions that will be successful, so we are going to go after it. The good news is, we have a huge back catalog, which is we have our own games, we bring not only users, we bring already a social network in Xbox Live, we bring content, and we're going to go after it. We're going to go after it with current sockets, and of course streaming is another element to it, because then can you plug in an Xbox controller into even an Android phone and play a Triple A game? We know that's feasible, now the question is when does the cost curve on it going to be viable. So those are at a high level what we are trying to get done.*

If we put this together, not only does Microsoft have a wealth of great back-catalog, they are investing heavily in smaller studios to continue the growth of first-party titles. If they do pull off the "Netflix for games" — like the Netflix model — the back-catalog and new first-party titles should come along with a rich collection of third-party games. I'll be curious to see if Microsoft would/could bring this "Netflix for games" service to the Switch.

To take a step back, here's the historical and (potentially) future lay of the land; color indicating first-party, gray indicating third-party, solid border indicating some sort of paywall, dotted border indicating free entry:



What should Activision do?

Putting aside if it *needs* to do anything differently, the question of whether or not Activision *should* do anything differently is nagging at me. If looked at on the whole, even with the departure of *Destiny 2*, Activision Blizzard accounts for monster franchises *Call of Duty, Candy Crush*, and all of Blizzard's franchises. But I'd wager to bet that's not enough. To me, that looks like a lot of eggs in only a couple of baskets. If I'm in Activision's shoes, I'm beginning to ask myself if I should get the jump on a subscription-based service in the Battle.Net Launcher.

If Activision Blizzard were to open a third-party storefront in the Battle.Net Launcher, indie (and potentially AAA) developers would have an opportunity to see their content alongside Blizzard IP. With an attractive revenue model, as much as I'd hate to see Blizzard's catalog muddied with third-parties and King, Battle.net becomes an attractive service. To keep the water a little less murky, a tightly curated games store would help. To find the middle-ground between Blizzard IP and random third-parties, the utilization of Activision's existing nine studios and/or the purchase of several indie studios a la Microsoft would bridge the gap. Battle.net would become a launcher for Blizzard's first-class titles, Activision owned subsidiary titles, and collection of top-tier indies.

This is certainly a "let's spend Activision Blizzard's money" post, but short of spelling doom for Activision Blizzard with the rise of *Fortnite*, departure of Bungie, and Microsoft's "Netflix of gaming", Activision Blizzard needs a model that will continue to drive revenue in a PC world without the friction of a hardware platform. If the battle is lost, Activision Blizzard titles join the ranks of third-party titles vying for the top-spot on other launchers and platforms.

Switch Is Selling Like Wii, Thanks To Traditional Nintendo Games

January 22, 2019

Categories: Business

Chris Kohler, Kotaku:

> *NPD didn't release the exact sales number for Smash, but it gave us enough to roughly figure it out. It said that Ultimate exceeded the launch month sales of Super Smash Bros. Brawl by over 70 percent. Since that number is known (2.7 million), we can add 70 percent to it to get rough first-month sales for Ultimate at a little over 4.5 million units—again, not counting download sales.*
>
> *In fact, _Ultimate_'s debut was, NPD said, the best launch month for a console-exclusive game in "video game history." The strength of the Switch overall also boosted the sales of its major games, sending 2017 games Mario Kart 8, Breath of the Wild, and Super Mario Odyssey into 2018's top 20. Overall, NPD said, Nintendo made more money on software than any other publisher this year, a feat it hadn't achieved since—you guessed it—the salad days of Wii, in 2009.*

Back-to-back big years?

Polygon: The battle between Steam and Epic Games Store is heating up

January 28, 2019

Categories: Business

Ben Kuchera, writing for Polygon:

> *The good news for players is that everyone wants their business, and the battle for that business is structured in such a way that prices are going down, while profits — at least, in some cases — may be going up. Epic Games has found a way to get players to more closely consider the economics of storefronts, and it did so with both exclusives and a lower price. This won't be the last time we see this approach as the platform wars continue in 2019.*

I nearly titled my piece Activision, Microsoft, and Platforms "Platform Wars".

Nintendo FY18 Q3 Earnings

January 30, 2019

Categories: Business, General

A blockbuster holiday. Lowered expectations. Three pillars of business. Nintendo's recent earnings report was interesting if nothing else.

Brian Crecente at Variety gave a tight business side recap:

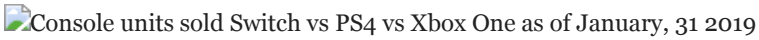
> *Despite a strong holiday, Nintendo on Thursday lowered how many Nintendo Switch it believes it can sell for the fiscal year, dropping the goal by three million, down to a new target of 17 million, the company announced in its latest earnings report.*
>
> *The company also increased its Nintendo Switch game sales forecast by 10 million, saying it will sell 110 million copies of games for the system in the fiscal year, which ends in March. Finally, the company nearly halved its estimates for the sales of the portable 3DS systems, down from 4 million to 2.6 million.*

The following are pulled from the presentation:

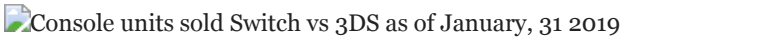
On Switch sales:

> *And cumulative global sell-through, including sales outside of the major markets you saw on the previous slides, has surpassed 30 million units as of the end of January, and the Nintendo Switch business is on a trajectory for further growth. Also, all of the new titles released in succession during the holiday season also showed exceptional sales.*

Comparison to PS4 and Xbox One sell-through looks like this:



Comparison to the Nintendo 3DS looks like this:



On games:

> *Super Smash Bros. Ultimate has achieved a sell-through of over 10 million units. The title has continued to show explosive growth after its release, with the fastest start for any title on any Nintendo home console ever.*

Right in-line with NPD's numbers.

Continued:

> 
> *Nintendo evergreen title sell through trends chart*
>
> *This chart shows the combined sell-through in Japan, the US, and Europe since April of 2018 for the four titles you see here. All four were released in the year before last, 2017. Sell-through of each title continued at a reasonable pace, then spiked upward toward the end of the year. As the spread of Nintendo Switch progresses, the number of new*

> *consumers is increasing. And to consumers who just purchased Nintendo Switch hardware, every existing title seems new.*
>
> *One of Nintendo's strengths is how easy it is for consumers with past experience playing Nintendo games to become interested in new Nintendo-brand titles. And if the steady sales of our evergreen titles can reliably support our overall software sales, we believe that will help fill any gaps between releases of new titles.*

Mario Kart 8 Deluxe is the top selling title for the Nintendo Switch at 15.02 million units. *Super Mario Odyssey* is second at 13.76 million units. I still wouldn't call *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe* a system seller, but certainly a must-have. Electrodome Boogaloo, indeed.

On third-party titles:

> *Titles from other software publishers are also seeing a steady rise alongside Nintendo Switch. Nintendo's revenue related to software from other software publishers was more than twofold during April through December of 2018.*

The idea that Microsoft would put games on Switch doesn't seem so crazy.

On strategy:

> *Based on our basic strategy, we've organized the company's initiatives into three pillars of business. The three pillars are the dedicated video game platform business, the mobile business, and the IP expansion business.*
>
> *Each pillar has a different purpose and a different scale. They are each considered critical to the company, and we intend to grow them according to their unique traits and potential for growth. Let me explain each of these businesses in order.*

Executives have made mention of IP expansion, but I don't think I've ever seen it as core a pillar spelled out next to "video games".

Microsoft's Super Bowl Ad

February 1, 2019

Categories: Accessibility

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vQYzsiVscNg

I love seeing Microsoft spend the big bucks on such a meaningful product.

OK. Back to cutting onions.

Real World Playbook

February 2, 2019

Categories: Education

Jean Case, early AOL exec, on Recode Decode hosted by Kara Swisher:

> *I see remarkable female founders. I've been mentoring one for a long time. She has a startup in New York called Real World Playbook. She says it's the Warby Parker for adulthood.*
>
> *She realizes she's a privileged person. She went to Princeton. She got a JD MBA from Georgetown. And when she got out of school, she didn't really know what to do about her taxes. She didn't know how to pick a healthcare plan. No one had ever really taught her that.*
>
> *So, she's got this really great platform that universities all of the United States are embracing and putting their kids through — to teach them how to go into adulthood. I mean, who would thing we'd have to disrupt that industry?*

Good idea, but it's a shame it's needed. It's silly that we don't provide these tools in high school. Add in technology basics (backups, privacy, etc.) and it sounds a lot like Home Economics 2.0.

Microsoft to Bring Xbox Live to the Switch

February 4, 2019

Categories: Business

Jez Corden, reporting for Windows Central:

> *At GDC 2019, Microsoft is set to debut a new cross-platform development platform with the goal of bringing Xbox Live support to games on Android, iOS, Nintendo Switch, in addition to PC and Xbox consoles.*
>
> *Microsoft already has a few games with Xbox Live support across mobile devices, most notably via Minecraft, which requires an Xbox Live login on Android, iOS, and Nintendo Switch. Until now, Microsoft reserved Xbox Live support on those platforms for its own games, but now now, Microsoft is aiming to bring Xbox Live cross-platform play to even more titles. Developers will be able to bake cross-platform Xbox Live achievements, social systems, and multiplayer, into games built for mobile devices and Nintendo Switch, as part of its division-wide effort to grow Xbox Live's userbase.*

Oh?

Activision-Blizzard Employees Brace For Massive Layoffs

February 9, 2019

Categories: Business

Jason Schreier, reporting for Kotaku:

> *This news comes after a tumultuous year for the publisher, which consists of two entities, Activision and Blizzard. Both Activision and Blizzard operate autonomously but are governed by the same C-suite of executives, including CEO Bobby Kotick (whose salary in 2017 was roughly $28.6 million).*
>
> *At Blizzard, 2018 was a year full of cost-cutting, under chief operating officer Armin Zerza, whose mandate has been to reduce spending and produce more games. (Other than expansions and remasters, Blizzard has not released a new game since Overwatch in May 2016.) Employees all across Blizzard have been told to cut their budgets and spend less money, and there's general concern about Activision's creeping influence as the company looks to make more financially-driven decisions. In October, Blizzard CEO Mike Morhaime stepped down, to be replaced by Blizzard veteran J. Allen Brack—not as CEO, but, notably, as president. In December, Blizzard abruptly killed the Heroes of the Storm esports program and cut down the development team for that game, its least successful.*
>
> *People who work or have worked at Blizzard told me that they expect Tuesday's layoffs to be primarily in non-game-development departments, such as publishing, marketing, and sales. Some of those jobs and roles may then fall to Activision proper, further reducing Blizzard's autonomy.*

My recent piece Activision, Microsoft, and Platforms amounted to what I'd consider a nothing-burger. I'd considered the question "what now for Activision?" after they ended their partnership with Bungie, and sought an answer. After laying everything out, short of spelling doom, I didn't really net out with much other than an allusion of the company leveraging Blizzard's IP to build a paid platform:

> *This is certainly a "let's spend Activision Blizzard's money" post, but short of spelling doom for Activision Blizzard with the rise of Fortnite, departure of Bungie, and Microsoft's "Netflix of gaming", Activision Blizzard needs a model that will continue to drive revenue in a PC world without the friction of a hardware platform. If the battle is lost, Activision Blizzard titles join the ranks of third-party titles vying for the top-spot on other launchers and platforms.*

This news of layoffs is what I was afraid of, and I think it will extend passed Activision employees.

At this rate, I see the brand "Activision" as an albatross around Blizzard's neck. Sadly, at the expense of the employees, they should shed the name Activision, divert resources to Blizzard, and focus on Blizzard's colorful core and new IP.

Activision Blizzard cuts hundreds of jobs despite ‘record revenue’ year

February 11, 2019

Categories: Business

Allegra Frank, reporting for Polygon:

> *Before announcing the layoffs, Activision Blizzard noted that it posted record revenues for the 2018 fiscal year. According to its fourth-quarter earnings report, the company made $7.26B in physical and digital sales, compared to $7.16B in 2017. But CEO Bobby Kotick explained that the numbers failed to meet expectations.*

> *“While our financial results for 2018 were the best in our history, we didn’t realize our full potential,” Kotick said in the report. During the Q&A portion of the investor call, he described the layoffs as a “top-five career-difficult moment for me personally.”*

> *Despite the self-proclaimed underwhelming revenues and the layoffs, Activision Blizzard said that it plans to expand its development teams on key, internally owned games (like Call of Duty, Candy Crush, and Overwatch) by 20 percent. Funding this will come through “de-prioritizing initiatives that are not meeting expectations and reducing certain non-development and administrative-related costs across the business,” according to its fourth-quarter fiscal earnings release. Other non-core positions will be eliminated to rededicate resources toward beefing up its development slate, the team said on the call.*

This news is awful. No way around it. Record revenue and cutting 800 jobs. Sure, increasing margins, non-core development, loss of Bungie, blah blah. But 800 jobs?! Banking on a single IP (*Destiny*) and not anticipating what CEO Bobby Kotick called a “top-five career-difficult moment for me personally” is insane. And how is the loss of 800 jobs not number one?

Per Kotaku reporter Jason Schreier, Kotick took home 28+ million in 2017. I get the reasoning behind highly paid executives; I wouldn’t want their jobs. But to say the loss of 800 jobs is “top-five” is an insult. It should be number one, with a bullet.

I feel for the employees. I feel for fans. I don’t see a great outlook for core Blizzard properties outside of *World of Warcraft* — a recurring revenue behemoth. And that’s sad. I would have loved to see the A/B 800 reallocated to other Blizzard franchises. If the focus is entirely on a *Call of Duty*, *Overwatch*, and *Candy Crush*, I fear the end of Blizzard as we know it.

‘A thin blanket against the cold reality’

February 19, 2019

Categories: Business

Michael Futter, Polygon:

> *The sad truth is that the die was cast at Activision Blizzard months, if not years, before these layoffs were first hinted. What makes this so exceptionally painful is that there is an understandable mental link between layoffs and poor financial performance. It’s nigh impossible to rationalize or justify 800 people being shown the door as a company reports record sales.*

> *And yet, here we are. Poor planning, a failure to adapt to current market conditions and consumer desires, and too much investment in trends (like toys to life games) has left Activision Blizzard in a place where it needs to make drastic cuts. That’s a thin blanket against the cold reality that executive pay is broken and now hundreds of people are out of work.*

Rumor: Microsoft Bringing Game Pass And Published Titles To Switch

February 20, 2019

Categories: Business

Imran Kahn, Game Informer:

> *According to a report from outlet Direct Feed Games, an outlet that has a strong track record for rumors especially centering around Nintendo, Microsoft and Nintendo are about to get together in a big way in the near future. Not only will some Microsoft games find their way to the Switch, but it looks like the entire Game Pass library might arrive via the magic of streaming.*

Oh?

‘But the answer is simpler when it comes to the real money maker for Microsoft’

February 22, 2019

Categories: Business

Chris Plante, Polygon:

> *But the answer is simpler when it comes to the real money maker for Microsoft: Xbox as a streaming platform available on every app store. Microsoft could bring its streaming service to any smart TV and streaming device without all this backroom dealmaking necessary for Switch, and reach a considerably bigger audience.*
>
> *I wouldn’t be surprised if we see all of the above. Going off the others’ reporting, it seems Microsoft is certainly trying to bring Xbox Game Pass to Switch, but the real game changer will be if — like Netflix, Hulu, and Amazon — Xbox becomes an app pre-installed on your next TV.*

Leave it to Plante to identify the obvious. I’m over here kicking myself that I didn’t think of an Xbox app pre-installed on TV in ‘Activision, Microsoft, and Platforms’. Especially after CES and the growing number of pre-installed services on smart TVs.

If we do see a pre-installed Xbox app, has Microsoft already positioned themselves as the dominant controller manufacturer? In addition to their standard wireless controller, they offer the Elite and classic “Duke” designs as well as the Adaptive Controller, a huge service to those in need of accessibility features.

I personally can not stand the Xbox controller and much prefer Nintendo’s Pro Controller or the PS4 DualShock 4. But if neither of those two options open themselves to an Xbox app — the former due to hardware limitations / lack of foresight, the latter due to some bizarre proprietary lock-in strategy — as an Xbox owner, Microsoft is already poised to be my go-to controller. And with an already broad selection of controllers tailored for the Xbox experience, it makes them the clear winner.

Nintendo Knew How

March 9, 2019

Categories: Accessibility

Shahid Kamal Ahmad on the Remaster Podcast, looking back on Reggie Fils-Aimé's legacy:

> *This is a real problem with video games, right. You go into video games as a new person who hasn't played video games. You play a modern AAA game, and first of all, you have tutorials that are extremely patronizing for the really experienced player. But still bewildering for new players. How do you get those players in? Nintendo knew how.*
>
> *Nintendo knew that they had to make the controls more accessible, and Reggie knew [those controls] were coming with the Wii. He knew that would be suitable for people who were intimidated by the controller. Personally, I thought that was an absolute genius move.*
>
> *I've had issues with controllers for a long time. Not personally, but in terms of accessibility. There's been this steady increase in the complexity of a controller. It hasn't become easier to use; it's become more complicated to use. Yes, it's got more features — now you have touchpads; now you have analog buttons; now you have analog sticks; now you have two or three or four more buttons on the thing; now you have pro controllers and elite controllers, £120 controllers. What Nintendo recognized was, "oh, we can do something that does away with all of that and introduce an entirely different type of technology that 'hey! It's actually not that expensive to manufacture.'" It was utter genius.*

Keying in on the phrase, "I've had issues with controllers for a long time": You and me both, Shahid. You and me both.

Game Boy Restored

April 20, 2019

Categories: Design, General, Technology

Today marks 30 years since the Game Boy's initial release in Japan. After seeing loads of Game Boy tributes for the handheld, I decided to dig up my old system for a first-hand experience down memory lane.

It was in pretty shoddy condition — unable to power on, battery corrosion inside, possible paint markings on the back, and general grime throughout. I've been reluctant to open it up to attempt a repair, concerned about the reliability of the plastic around the screws after 30ish years.

Well, there's no better time than Easter — a day of resurrection — to take a crack at it. At least I could say I tried to bring this gamer boy back into the world.

Throughout the teardown, I took a few photos of some of main unit and boards, posting them to Instagram. At the compliment of friend Sam Gross, I've decided to post them here as well.

My photo setup is nothing fancy:

- iPhone XS
- IKEA Malm desk (white)
- generic table lamp
- Philips Hue White Extension Bulb A19 E26
- Apple Photos app auto-enhance
- Instagram editing tools
- Video: Apple's Clips app + Instagram's 'Lark' filter

The Game Boy, pre-spa treatment:


Game Boy Restoration, Part 1

Both sides of the brain:


Game Boy Restoration, Part 2

Motherboard (3)


Game Boy Restoration, Part 3

Display circuit board


Game Boy Restoration, Part 4

I didn't take a picture, but there was considerable battery corrosion on the battery contacts. This was the likely culprit of the power issue. To clean, I popped out the battery contacts and submerged them in distilled white vinegar for about 10–15 minutes. They came out looking brand new.

Once all of the guts had been removed, I took a baby wipe to the exterior and buttons. For interior grime, I soaked a Q-tip in the white vinegar and swabbed it out.


Game Boy Restoration, completely dismantled

After all plastic had been cleaned, it was time for reassembly and the moment of truth…

https://youtu.be/3-OMIiliYXU

Happy 30th, Game Boy.

Retr0bright Update

A restoration is not complete without attention paid to the appearance. The more I looked at the end result of my Game Boy restoration, the more I was bothered by the yellowing of the casing.

The yellowing of ‘80s and ‘90s electronics plastics is caused by a combination bromine — afire retardant — and exposure to UV light. The plastic is known as acrylonitrile butadiene styrene, or ABS.

The method to reverse the effect of bromine is referred to as retr0bright and includes a mixture of hydrogen peroxide, xanthan gum, glycerin, and “oxy” laundry booster. Being the lazy sap I am, I decided to opt in for a discovered alternative: Salon Care by Sally Beauty.

Wearing latex gloves, painted a generous amount of the Salon Care on to the disassembled casing of the Game Boy, wrapped it in Stretch-Tite plastic wrap, and placed the piece outside in direct sunlight.


Game Boy disassembled during retr0bright process

Essential: The Salon Care coated plastic should be exposed to UV light for 4–6 hours total. However, it is **critical** to massage the plastic wrap + Salon Care every 45–60 minutes or so. This helps avoid air bubbles which can contribute to blotchiness in the end result. (This is where I goofed.) Likewise, you should rinse the plastic and re-apply the Salon Care every 90–120 minutes as it begins to evaporate after lengthy exposure. (Another goof of mine. I had to redo the process the next day as the Salon Care seemed to lose its effect after about 2 hours.)

After the process was complete — which is to say the color reversal was at a point that was good enough for me — I rinsed and thoroughly dried the plastic and reassembled the Game Boy and photographed a side-by-side before and after:


Game Boy retr0bright before and after

If you look closely, you will notice some of the blotchiness I mentioned above.

Overall, I’m quite satisfied with the end result. This restored Game Boy teleports me back to Christmas 1989, unwrapping my first console ever, and playing *Super Mario Land* for hours on end.

A Video Game Developed To Detect Alzheimer's Disease Seems To Be Working

April 28, 2019

Categories: Health, Science

Zack Zwiezen, Kotaku:

> *According to researchers, every two minutes spent playing the game is equal to five hours of lab-based research. Because _Sea Hero Quest_ has been out for a few years and downloaded and played by over three million players they've collected the equivalent of 1,700 years of research data on Alzheimer's*
>
> *Researchers involved with the project studied people who carried the APOE4 gene, which is thought to increase that person's risk of developing dementia, as they played the game. They then compared these people's results to the results of folks who played the game who don't have that gene.*
>
> *"We found that people with a high genetic risk, the APOE4 carriers, performed worse on spatial navigation tasks. They took less efficient routes to checkpoint goals," said Professor Michael Hornberger, a member of the team.*

Two minutes. 99.33% of time shaved off. Truly incredible.

Playdate

May 21, 2019

Categories: Design


Playdate handheld console

Playdate press release:

> *Playdate is both very familiar, and totally new. It's yellow, and fits perfectly in a pocket. It has a black-and-white screen with high reflectivity, a crystal-clear image, and no backlight. And of course, it has Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, USB-C, and a headphone jack. But it also has a crank. Yes, a crank: a cute, rotating analog controller that flips out from the side. It's literally revolutionary.*

> *There's more: Playdate includes games — a full season of them. The games will be delivered over-the-air, once a week for 12 weeks, and they'll be a surprise: when the new game light flashes, you'll never know what you're about to play. Panic recruited some of the world's best game designers — some well known; others under the radar — to make games exclusively for our system. Playdate isn't just hardware: it's a complete experience.*

Hot on the heels of the 30th anniversary of the Game Boy, this little handheld console is a sight to see.

Since bringing my Game Boy back to life, I've been yearning for the good ol' dot-matrix days. But I've also had the feeling they'd likely disappoint. Rose-colored glasses and all. Seeing the Playdate feels like a realization of that pining. Something new of something old:

> *Playdate's 2.7-inch (68mm) screen is a unique, black-and-white, low-power LCD from Sharp, with a resolution of 400×240. On the surface, it might be tempting to compare the screen to, say, the Game Boy. But Playdate's display is quite different: it has no grid lines, no blurring, is extremely sharp and clear, and has much higher resolution. It sounds odd to say, but: it's truly a "premium" black-and-white screen.*

And it wouldn't be the same without Teenage Engineering. At initial glance, I knew something looked familiar. Sure enough, I noticed that Teenage Engineering had a hand in the design (and crank!) of the Playdate. I keep a PO-20 in my nightstand and am constantly enthralled by its ingenuity.

I encourage you to read the press release in full — ideally on an iPhone or iPad as there's a very cool AR experience to check out. The damn thing is so cute!

I'm signed up to receive updates about the Playdate and I recommend you do too.

‘It’s like friendly punk’

May 22, 2019

Categories: Design

Bennett Foddy, Playdate game developer, in an interview with Edge Magazine (via Apple News+):

> *We’ve standardised around two hardware platforms: the touchscreen, and ten buttons, two analog sticks. That’s got its benefits, but you miss out on novel experiences. So yeah, there is something that is kind of punk about it, and that yellow case. It’s like friendly punk.*

I recently restored my Game Boy. I don’t play it. It just sits on my desk. But I pick it up every now again because, aside from nostalgia, there’s something so pleasing about it.

As I’ve been thinking about Playdate today, it dawned on me — that something is the buttons.

‘But when I play video games, I begin feeling guilty and even bored’

July 7, 2019

Categories: Health

I had the great fortune of hearing a question I’d asked to the hosts of the *Into the Aether* podcast via Discord repeated on the episode “There’s a Troll in this Chili’s”, timestamp 34:51. (Honest to god, the question is more serious than the title of the episode.)

Yours truly:

> *Howdy! I love video games. I love the idea of playing video games. At work, I get excited by the idea of sitting down for a long bout of video games. But when I do, I begin feeling guilty and even bored. Am I broken, or am I just playing the wrong games? Have either of you dealt with this?*

Hosts Brendon Bigley and Stephen Hilger spent nearly 25-minutes thoughtfully addressing these questions, ranging from living in the moment, mental health, and easing up on the burden caused by zeitgeist and “completionism”. Even if this weren’t my question, I’d tell you it’s worth your time.

If you’re unfamiliar with *Into the Aether*, the hosts bill it as a “low-key video games podcast”, but I think they’re selling themselves short. It’s funny and intelligent; the commentary on video games is never one of snobbery; the subject matter spans beyond just games and into art, community, and culture. It has honestly become one of my favorite shows. And over the past few months, it has quickly jumped up my priority listening queue. Seeing as I only listen to podcasts while out on a jog, I find myself running a bit more often these days.

Additional note: Prior to launching Into the Aether, Brendon Bigley interviewed me about Zero Counts and about my piece “Big-N’s Big Year”. You can find the interview at the bottom of the post or on the Ported Podcast feed.

Fire Emblem: Management Simulator

August 29, 2019

Categories: Work

A new day dawns. Another Wednesday in the office. The hours go by; meetings and one-on-ones had. But something feels different.

I care for my employees. It's normal for me to wear their burdens — work-related and otherwise — upon my shoulders. But today, it feels like my attention of their emotional well-being and performance has gone a level deeper. Maybe it's because it's review season and I've been carefully reflecting on their year? No. This is different than years past. I can't shake the feeling that I've been a sounding board and observer of each of them a bit more as of late.

Then it dawns on me. I haven't been spending more time in the office, but I have spent at least 20 hours of my free time playing *Fire Emblem: Three Houses* — a game that puts me in the role of a military academy professor intently focused on the subtleties of my students' personalities and behaviors, strengths and weaknesses. The better I can guide them down the right paths, uncover hidden talents, or find deeper relationships, the better they will perform in battle.

Many a review and commentary focus on _Three Houses_' Harry Potter-like setting and structure. Garreg Mach Monastery is a sizable castle (Hogwarts) with its students divvied up between three houses — the Golden Deer (Gryffindor?), Blue Lions (Ravenclaw?), and Black Eagles (definitely Slytherin). In addition to students, staff and several members of the Church of Seiros walk the halls helping you train, build relationships, and assist in battle. Consider these the professors of Hogwarts. You will spend a majority of your time wandering the monastery speaking with students and staff, teaching your recruits different skills, analyzing individuals over tea, fishing, forcing conversation between students over a meal, fishing, taking exams to unlock a new military class, and fishing.

This is a game focused on education and academy life. It's not about a 9-5. That said, since I become a manager, I've felt there is a direct parallel between teaching and managing. Harvard Business Review will tell you the best leaders are great teachers. It's no surprise that I began to see my own work-life take place within the walls of Garreg Mach.

Fire Emblem: Three Houses is my first foray into the Fire Emblem series. Jumping into the 50 hour TRPHPFS (tactical role-playing Harry Potter fishing simulator) took very little deliberation. Since *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*, every core Nintendo franchise title released on Switch has been the fully realized version of itself. I figured this would be a good place to dive in. I wasn't wrong. I haven't been sucked into a game like this since *Breath of the Wild*. Even then, it was less about the game itself and more about the zeitgeist propelling me forward.

Three Houses taps into something true to my core: empathy. I legitimately care about the cast as I care about my real-world contacts. Will Ignace realize his full potential as an artist? Will Raphael, the jovial brute, realize he can master the battlefield? Will Marianne realize she is a wise warrior… that can talk to… horses? Will Lorenz stop fucking harassing women?! If none of them can on their own, can I help them get there by revealing chinks in the armor of their ignorance?

These are not the same issues as the employees I care for. But I care nonetheless. Will they approach ambiguity with unease or confidence? Will they understand the subtleties of negotiation within a large

bureaucracy? Will they learn to lean on the specialities of someone with less “professional” experience? Will they feel comfortable leading a particular project?

I take these thoughts home with me. And when I pick up the game, they come back to life. I think carefully about which skills to stretch, not entirely sure my judgement will pay back the greatest dividend. I think beyond the workplace and wonder how home-life may be influencing my employees’ creativity. Are they committed? Are they motivated? Do they care? Is this what they really want? Do they need a break?

Fire Emblem: Three Houses asks these same questions with every explore-teach-fight loop, ultimately growing my cadets. And they do throw it back at me. If I offer and incorrect response or pair incompatible personalities together, they’ll let me know. No two students are alike. No two employees are alike. No two human are alike.

And like management, the more students I have under my purview, the less time I can spend teaching them individually. Who is more critical to grow? How balanced does my team need to be? Should I round out each individual, or focus on their strengths? And ultimately, who are my favorites?

And there in lies the beauty of *Fire Emblem: Three Houses*. There is a repetitive loop, yes, but there is also painstaking care put into each of the students. And the fact that you will likely only experience 1/3 of them on your first play through is quite incredible. There are two other houses, two entirely different yet connected campaigns to explore. (I’m a sucker for games where only a fraction can be played through, leaving more to discover again and again. Think *Star Fox 64*.)

What is more is understanding how to balance the comfort of an individual for individual-growth. The best path forward may not be the easiest or the one that suits an individual’s strengths. There is pain in growth, for the individual(s) involved as well as for the leader calling the shots.

Where things divide — where a game cannot mirror reality — is balancing the growth of an individual and the goals of the bureaucracy. A role-playing game will almost always propel you to win, regardless of the “feelings” of its characters. In reality, it’s impossible — or should be impossible — to ignore the feelings of our own kind. As a manager, it’s a more difficult and existential challenge to prioritize the company’s goals over the fulfillment of your employees. More often than not it’s your job to move the company forward — increase revenue, decrease cost; increase productivity, decrease bottlenecks.

Fire Emblem: Three Houses rewards you as a professor with growth whenever you successfully pair students in activities or win a battle. These are balanced by days on a calendar. Will you converse with students this week, or will you fight? Either way, you’re leveling up. In reality, those choices are not and will never be as clear cut. Your professional growth is measured by the value you provide the company. Creating a great culture amongst your employees ultimately pays the company back, but the time it takes to build that culture versus hard and quick calls will always be under the omnipresent eye of the corporation.

Video Games Do Not Exist

October 1, 2019

Categories: General

I was invited to write an original piece for the then patron exclusive 'From the Aether' newsletter, the text extension of the wonderful Into the Aether podcast. As of December 9, 2019, the piece became available to the public.

With permission from Into the Aether, I've published the full piece here, but I'd love it if you gave it and the other wonderful accompanying pieces a read on Medium.

I encourage you to listen to the podcast. If you're so inclined, become a patron of an insightful and welcoming low-key video games podcast.

The year is 20XX. Video games do not exist. They never have.

But tomorrow they will.

And when they come, all of today's modern technology and tools will be available to their creators. There will have been no precedent other than their analog counterparts, which — come to think of it — consist of cardboard, cards, metal or plastic tokens, dice, tiles, paper, pencils, backpacks, guns, talking… walking… geese…

The first ones will be clunky; nigh unplayable. But without limitations in technology, we'll quickly learn what's acceptable, butt up against new limitations, and impose our own.

The first will feature a camera moving around a space. The next will include music. Then voice over. Then a third-person perspective and objects to interact with. Some will simply be digital recreations of analog forms. Maybe you'll simply speak to them. Maybe you'll move a character from left to right, or maybe right to left. Maybe you'll console a character. Maybe that character is actually a real person. Maybe you'll discover the nuance of an intimate relationship, or the complexity of geopolitics. Maybe all you'll do is observe and sustain an ant farm, a household, or a city. Maybe it'll strictly be text, or nothing at all — just a voice.

You'll play them on a smartphone, a first-party handheld device, a TV, a computer, a watch. Perhaps you'll play these through goggles or virtual assistants. Maybe your phone will ring or you'll receive a text message that informs you to open an email that tells you to navigate to a particular GPS coordinate in your neighborhood, then open an app to reveal a new clue.

Each is an experience. Each requires an interaction. But they are not simply interactive experiences. The act of reading these words, right now, is an interactive experience. The mode of input varies. The goals vary. The display, playback, or broadcast will vary.

Perhaps the constant is a digital device. It may not be the only artifact necessary to partake in the experience, but it's a requirement.

Perhaps the other requirement is agency or the illusion thereof. You've been spewing thousands of opinions on social media, but you know damn well that you have no control or influence to change the world in a single tweet. But in this limited, digital experience, you play god. An analog god over a digital domain.

So, what are these things? What are these experiences? Some are games. Some are simulations. Some are stories. Some are lessons. The same as any form of book.

But they don't come on paper. They come to us through video — "an electronic medium for the display of visual media"; a screen — but maybe also a speaker, or require a pen and paper.

With unlimited creativity and technologies that can produce images that rival reality, these things reshape what we know of interaction and storytelling. They unlock our ideas of what worlds and systems should or shouldn't be — human-made full-sensory utopias and dystopias. They are as simple as connecting dots and as complex as connecting people.

So, what do we call them?

[Edit] This piece was updated on December 9, 2019 to reflect the public availability of 'Video Games Do Not Exist'.

[Edit] This piece was updated on December 28, 2020 to include full text of 'Video Games Do Not Exist', with permission from Into the Aether.

Polygon's 100 Best Games of the Decade

November 5, 2019

Categories: Culture, Design, Review, Society

Polygon Staff:

> *We began with a long list of around 300 games that team members nominated. Then we individually voted for the 50 we most wanted to see in the list. After we tallied the votes, we gathered together to sort out the unholy mess, and to argue the merits and faults of the top 150.*
>
> *After a surprisingly calm and erudite discussion, we agreed on the following list. It is, by its nature, a compromise, but it's the best we've got.*

A fun look back at a decade that now seems shorter than it felt — I'll blame that on the past three years.

I played 23.5 of the 100 titles mentioned in this list. Honestly, that's more than I thought I would have. (While _Red Dead Redemption_s 1 and 2 are counted as a single entry, I only ever played the first, so it counts as half.)

As I have a soft spot for Nintendo games, I'm happy with Polygon's Mario pick over what I assumed would be the shoo-in. Likewise, I'm happy to see an overwhelming industry/fan/consumer favorite sit extremely high in the list at number 2, but not receive top honors. Societal/cultural impact takes precedence here, as I argued back in 2016.

My biggest takeaway is that the past 10 years of games have broadened the scope of what constitutes a "video game" more than any other decade. That seems an obvious observation as there's evolution in any medium, but video games by their infinite malleability allow for innovation and creativity beyond any other. Video games can be anything (and therefore video games do not exist). Just read Polygon's justifications for *Device 6*, *Johann Sebastian Joust*, or *Journey*.

If 2000–2009 cracked the door on infinite possibilities, 2010–2019 blew it wide open.

Hail Mario 3: Revenge of the Stock

November 8, 2019

Categories: Business

Cameron Faulkner at The Verge:

> *Nintendo has announced its Black Friday deals, and chief among them is a $299.99 Switch console bundle that includes a free download code for Mario Kart 8 Deluxe. This deal will start on Thursday, November 28th, and will be available at several retailers. So far, we've seen it confirmed in Target's Black Friday ad, but expect it to pop up at the other major players, like Best Buy, Walmart, Amazon, and more.*
>
> *Getting a free game with the Switch is great, especially one that's as good as Nintendo's popular kart racer, but there's some fine print with this deal that you may, or may not, care about. You'll only get the free game with the HAC-001 version of the console, the original launch model that has been superseded by a new version with vastly superior battery life (a range from 4.5 to nine hours versus the original's 2.5- to 6.5-hour claim, depending on the game).*
>
> *…*
>
> *This deal might read as a way for Nintendo to clear out its remaining stock of launch units without cutting the price, but thankfully, the older version is no less capable, and crucially, no less fun to play on.*

I'm willing to bet Faulkner is correct here.

I've written about Nintendo's use of *Mario Kart 8* as a unit mover. For the Wii U, it was used as a final Hail Mary to reinvigorate Wii U sales with not only the game, but a very early review embargo and a free additional game. For the Switch, it was a the first widely recognized party game to offer local multiplayer support, allowing early Switch adopters to showcase the console's unique modes of play ahead of the holidays, namely table-top mode — the mode that allows two local players to play anywhere, each leveraging a single Joy-Con as a controller and prop up the Switch as the screen.

Here we are on the other end of the spectrum. With the wild popularity of the Switch and a relatively new SKU that boasts better battery life, what better way to exhaust stock of the original SKU than to throw in arguably the most polished, popular, and accessible game in Nintendo's library for free.

Star Wars: The Rise of Skywalker — A Review

December 18, 2019

Categories: Review

Star Wars is about balance. Light versus Dark. Jedi versus Sith. One versus one. Should the Force fall out of balance, chaos ensues.

The Rise of Skywalker epitomizes balance — balance in story; balance in heritage; balance in its namesake.

This will not spoil. It is intended to be read after viewing the film. This is due to a balance in context versus content.

It is fun to watch J.J. Abrams play in the sandbox of Rian Johnson before him, as it was fun to watch Johnson play in the sandbox of Abrams before him.

Abrams built up what Johnson tore down, and thus Abrams is challenged to rebuild from those pieces. To construct a cohesive narrative, Abrams must construct something cohesive from the rubble Johnson laid before him.

Like *Empire* after *Hope*, Johnson laid waste to the monomyth laid before him. He'd done away with nearly every construct setup before him. Rey's parents are nobodies. Snoke was an easy kill. Luke's saber means nothing. Like an angsty teen, Johnson throws away legacy. He wants to define his own path. *The Last Jedi* is punk.

By blowing *The Force Awakens* to hell, the return to its author had to be nothing but a challenge. Abrams is forced to not only to piece together loose ends, but also tie it up with a satisfying bow.

If Kylo's helmet is a symbol for this third act, *The Rise of Skywalker* is the valiant effort to salvage the pieces it was born from.

Fast vs. Slow

The Rise of Skywalker is fast. Maybe a little too fast. Fast to the point where it feels like it's doing its best to ignore *The Last Jedi*. It simply wants to snap into *The Force Awakens*, working as it's own Star Wars trilogy second and third acts in a single film. But as soon as one feels that way, there are questions and weight from *The Last Jedi* that must be answered — Jedi books, helmets, and Force ghosts, etc.

The Rise of Skywalker is slow. This is a third act that feels like a single film full of third acts. It's relentless, but moves at a slower pace than that of *The Last Jedi*. There is less plot than there is filling gaps or doing the grunt work of attempting to reconstruct Johnson's deconstruction. By the end, I had a hard time remembering the beginning or even caring about it for that matter.

Big vs. Small

The Rise of Skywalker is big. This film above all other Star Wars films feels massive. The scale of the fleets. The cinematography of the ships. The velocity of light-speed chases. The variety of planets. The

sheer magnitude of the shots is breathtaking. Impossible odds haven't felt so impossible since the first front on the Death Star in *A New Hope*.

The Rise of Skywalker is small. The relationships feel small. Where *The Last Jedi* expands familial, friendly, and sexual bonds, *The Rise of Skywalker* contracts them into a focused few. The stakes stay within the family. The stressors are on individuals. Our heroes and their connections to each other and themselves are at the heart of this story.

Fan-service vs. Familiar

The Rise of Skywalker is fan-service. Every "I" dotted". Every "T" crossed. *The Rise of Skywalker* pays tribute to the series to date as a whole. Yes, to the point of eye-rolling, but that could be seen in *The Force Awakens*, between the Death Star 3.0 (Starkiller Base) and the new Cantina band. *The Rise of Skywalker* goes above and beyond these callbacks by embracing Johnson's (or even Gareth Edwards' (Rogue One)) ideas and even playing them up every now and again. Anything seems possible in the Star Wars universe, and if I surrender to the idea that this is all make-believe, I'm ok with that.

The Rise of Skywalker is familiar. While the fan-service is welcome, we've seen this story before. None of the encounters feel magical. None of the cameos feel surprising (save for one, maybe two). *The Last Jedi* and *The Force Awakens* before it did a great job shocking the audience with unexpected moments, be it live-action puppeteering or reappearances of deceased characters. *The Rise of Skywalker* has plenty of fun, but it feels like we've been there before.

Rise of Skywalker

Between these three aspects — fast and slow, big and small, fan-service and familiar — it may be the speed that gets in the way the most. I struggled to care about the characters. I remember them from the previous films, but I did not have time to reconnect with them. If *The Rise of Skywalker* has shown anything, it's that Johnson is the gravity to Abram's lightness. *The Last Jedi* made us feel the depths of characters and the internal demons they were facing. *The Rise of Skywalker* seemingly doesn't have time to dwell on that and tries to race to the finish line, soon realizing it still has another hour of story to tell.

Where *The Rise of Skywalker* shines is in its balance. There is balance in how Abrams and Johnson handle the saga. There is balance in the pace of each of the films. But speaking to *The Rise of Skywalker* in particular, the title speaks to balance most of all.

Estimates: Nintendo Switch passed the Xbox One in hardware shipments

January 31, 2020

Categories: Business

Daniel Ahmad, senior analysts at Niko Partners, regarding Nintendo's FY19 Nine Months Financial Results Briefing:

> *Also worth pointing out that according to our estimates the Nintendo Switch passed the Xbox One in hardware shipments during the holiday quarter last year.*

> *The Xbox One is not too far behind, but it has only taken Switch 34 months to achieve what the Xbox One did in 74 months.*

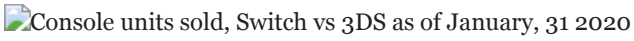
Nintendo reports that they have shipped 52.48 million Switch units since launch. It's estimated that Microsoft has sold 46.9 million Xbox One units since launch. 5.58 million more units in nearly half the time.

On the Playstation front, while it's been a back-and-forth race, it took Sony over 37 months to ship the same number of consoles as the Switch.

Here's an updated chart for perspective:



The Switch also appears to be leaving it's older sibling—the 3DS—in the dust:



NBCSW will broadcast video game simulations of Wizards and Capitals games

March 20, 2020

Categories: Sports

Scott Allen reporting for The Washington Post:

> *The NBA and NHL seasons, which were suspended last week due to the novel coronavirus outbreak, will resume — in video game form — in the coming days. Monumental Sports Network and NBC Sports Washington on Friday announced that they will broadcast hour-long simulations of the Wizards' and Capitals' previously scheduled regular season games using NBA 2K20 and NHL 20, respectively.*

I don't see this as something that will be successful. Just a bit of fun during a growing and tumultuous problem for sports franchises, players, and employees, as well as broadcasters, advertisers, and bookies.

What may have been a success would have been a virtual March Madness tournament.

On March 12, as soon as the NCAA canceled March Madness due to COVID-19, I became eager to tweet that exact idea. Upon researching, to my surprise, there hasn't been an EA Sports NCAA Basketball game since 2010. Tweet canceled.

An "I called it" would have been in order had I blogged or tweeted this idea. My wife is my only alibi. Alas, I've been neglecting Zero Counts. Lesson learned.

GameStop is a garbage company

March 20, 2020

Categories: Business

Jason Schreier reporting for Kotaku:

> *The struggling video game retail chain GameStop told all of its stores this afternoon to stay open even in the event of state or city lockdowns to protect against the covid-19 pandemic, emphasizing that it is "essential retail" alongside groceries and pharmacies and should therefore be exempt from enforced closures.*

> *"Due to the products we carry that enable and enhance our customers' experience in working from home, we believe GameStop is classified as essential retail and therefore is able to remain open during this time," the retailer said in a memo to staff this afternoon, obtained by Kotaku.*

> *"We have received reports of local authorities visiting stores in an attempt to enforce closure despite our classification. Store Managers are approved to provide the document linked below to law enforcement as needed."*

> *...*

> *Meanwhile, GameStop employees all across the United States have feared for their safety in the wake of the company's misguided responses to the covid-19 crisis. "Been with company almost a decade," one told Kotaku this afternoon. "This is indefensible."*

Said document is revolting:

> *While GameStop is best known as a provider of gaming and home entertainment systems, we also offer a wide array of products and devices that are important to facilitate remote work, distance learning, and virtual connectivity. As millions of Americans face unprecedented challenges adapting to virtual learning, working and interaction, there is significant need for technology solutions and we are one of many providers of these products that are remaining open at this time. Schools, businesses and families are now suddenly dependent on being able to connect through technology. While there are many businesses and organizations far more critical than ours, we believe we can have a positive impact during this very challenging time. The health and safety of our employees and customers is of utmost importance and we have and will continue to take extensive precautions consistent with CDC guidelines. We are complying with all state, county, city and local ordinances and we will continue to adjust to any future developments.*

What's perhaps the most despicable part of this is the "technology" angle. I'd wager a bet having your computer or smartphone repaired ASAP is a bit more critical in a time where we are "suddenly dependent on being able to connect through technology," yet the largest retailers/repair centers in the world have shut their doors in the name of public safety.

GameStop is a garbage company.

[*UPDATE*]: Later on March 20th, Kotaku reported that GameStop began closing stores in California. A single state.

On March 21st, GameStop decided to close all of its stores, offering curbside pickup at select locations.

Their reluctance is flat out gross.

The Comfort of Childhood Media During Lockdown

March 29, 2020

Categories: Culture

Amanda Hess, writing for The New York Times:

> *Myst Time is the opposite of News Time, Twitter Time and Doom Googling Coronavirus Projections Time. The immersive beauty of Myst feels particularly suited to a quarantine: At a time when I can't go anywhere, it makes me feel far away, surrounded by lapping waves and opulent rugs and actual mist.*

> *But sheltering in place has also activated a strong nostalgic urge. In this, I don't think I'm alone. Last week, my colleague Astead Herndon imagined being quarantined with old Windows computer games like Minesweeper and 3D Pinball Space Cadet; I recently caught my husband playing a reconstruction of The Oregon Trail on a browser. ("You died of dysentery," he told me.)*

> *When I saw Herndon's tweet, I immediately searched for iPhone versions of early '90s point-and-click adventure games like Sam & Max, Day of the Tentacle, The 7th Guest and Myst — and commenced my reversion. The demand for isolation has knocked me out of my adult life and sent me into a state weirdly reminiscent of childhood, which is the last time I was confined to my bedroom, my free will constrained by a higher authority. I used to play Myst hunched over my family's hulking PC, home-office doors closed to the rest of my family, and now I play it with my phone in my face, mind blinkered to the rest of the world.*

Hess is definitely not alone in this. I am now re-examining my media choices since quarantine began.

When quarantine was imminent, I fought the urge to find a functioning CRT television and Nintendo 64 before lockdown. Since, I've been reading Jeff Tweedy's memoir which reads like a long lost journal of my own childhood, at least before Tweedy's and my musical careers deviated — he has one, I don't. We've been spinning a lot of '80s records in the house. (As I write these words, we are listening to Apple Music's "80s Soft Rock Essentials" playlist.) We watched Back to the Future last night. And like every other Switch owner, my wife and I are escaping to Starrbucks, our *Animal Crossing* island — serenaded by sloshing waves and an acoustic guitar loop that somehow never overstays its welcome. (Friend code SW-2603-2234-0921. Come visit. Bring oranges.)

I have extremely fond memories of *Myst* — experiencing it with both step-father at home and my father 350 miles away. (I touched on this in my review of The Witness and a post about a rumored *Myst* television series.) I've jumped into it once or twice on iOS. It is nice to tap into those old memories. And the mystique of *Myst* (no pun intended) is one that I'm always chasing. (Queue yearning for *LOST*, *BioShock*, *Annihilation*, *The Room* iOS games, etc.)

What I could really go for is an iOS port of the 1992 remake of Sierra's *Quest for Glory: So You Want to Be a Hero* and a macOS port of Sierra's *Johnny Castaway* screensaver.


Quest for Glory Death Sequences Animation

VGC: 'Nintendo will reveal plans to re-release most of Super Mario's 35-year back catalogue this year'

March 30, 2020

Categories: Business

Andy Robinson, reporting for Video Games Chronicle:

> *Multiple sources have told VGC that the platform holder is planning to hold an event to coincide with this year's anniversary, which marks 35 years since the start of the mainline Super Mario series in 1985.*

> *As part of its anniversary celebrations, Nintendo will reveal plans to re-release most of Super Mario's 35-year back catalogue this year, remastered for Nintendo Switch, VGC was told.*

> *As VGC's network partner Eurogamer reported in a follow-up to our story, these remasters will include 1997's Super Mario 64, 2002's Super Mario Sunshine and 2007's Super Mario Galaxy.*

> *Nintendo will also release several other Mario titles in 2020, including a new instalment in the Paper Mario series and a Deluxe version of 2013's Super Mario 3D World.*

Speaking of childhood comforts.

'Listen to me, motherfucker, listen'

March 30, 2020

Categories: Health

An excerpt from Jeff Tweedy's excellent memoir:

> *I would feel guilty. I'd sit in group sessions and listen to other patients talk about their lives, and what they'd endured was beyond anything I could imagine. They came from homes where they never felt safe; being physically and emotionally abused was just a day-to-day reality. Food was scarce, hope was scarcer, and it was a toss-up whether there was more danger outside or inside. One guy told us about seeing his father murder his mother when he was nine and that he had his first taste of alcohol that night because his father forced him to drink whiskey, thinking it would make him forget what he'd seen. Hearing a story like that made me ashamed of how little I had had to survive and how much pain I'd derived from so much less actual trauma. What was I gonna say when the group got to me? "Um . . . I cry a lot. I get scared sometimes. I have headaches, and it makes it hard to make music." That was the worst of it. I was out of my league.*
>
> *One time, after a group session, a few of us were in the smoking room and I confided to them, "I feel like I shouldn't even open my mouth. I don't want anyone to get the idea that I think my situation compares."*
>
> *This big black guy, who towered over me, turned around and started shouting at me. "What the fuck is that shit? Shut the fuck up! We all suffer the same, motherfucker!"*
>
> *"I'm sorry," I said, backing away. "I didn't mean—"*
>
> *"Listen to me, motherfucker, listen." Getting right up in my face. "Mine ain't about yours. And yours ain't about mine. We all suffer the same. You don't get to decide what hurts you. You just hurt. Let me say my shit, and you say your shit, and I'll be there for you. Okay?"*
>
> *It set me straight. I still think it's one of the wisest things I've ever heard. I was trying to put things in perspective by pretending I had no perspective, by denying my own feelings. It's always going to be important to acknowledge someone else's pain, but denying your own pain doesn't do that. It just makes their pain relative to yours, like a yardstick to measure against. It's a waste of pain. After that I started listening more and I started feeling again.*

This knocked me back. Wow.

'We’re not necessarily expecting [a setting like Animal Crossing] to be the real world, and maybe that’s partly why it works'

April 12, 2020

Ashley Fetters, writing for The Atlantic, with a quote from Nicole Ellison of School of Information at the University of Michigan:

> *The runaway success of the online Nintendo Switch game Animal Crossing also speaks to the appeal of unfamiliar virtual spaces. In Animal Crossing, players can interact with other online players rather than just the characters created by the game, and players who are friends in the physical world can link up in the game and host one another virtually on their “islands.” Crucially, in spaces like this, the norms and communication patterns of face-to-face interaction don’t exist. “We’re not necessarily expecting [a setting like Animal Crossing] to be the real world, and maybe that’s partly why it works,” Ellison said. She added that she wouldn’t be surprised if virtual-reality experiences also become more popular for much the same reason: They can offer people the ability to roam around and interact in unstructured ways, but with just enough novelty to avoid unfavorable comparisons with face-to-face interactions.*

The most appealing multiplayer experiences I've had have been those that skirt normal real-life situations for something novel or limited.

Animal Crossing's success stems from its low barrier to entry, simple obstacles, and limitless opportunity. Quite simply, it's a sandbox. The hook is personalizing and collecting; both of which, by their very nature, are greatly enhanced by social interaction. And for a digital world, there's no easier social interaction than digital socialization — i.e. social networks.

Social networks are asynchronous; not every post requires the attention of all, nor are posts layered on top of one another vying for attention; and they don't require speaking, listening, or being bound to a location. Social networks are as individual as they are communal. For a game that's being experienced in real-time in both hemispheres in every time zone, there's an endless amount of creativity, exploration, and fun to be shared wherever and whenever you are.

Other novel multiplayer experiences I've had include puzzle solving *The Witness* and chirping in *Journey*.

Video games, hell yeah

May 13, 2020

Tweet thread by Tiffany Pitts:

https://twitter.com/snickerpants/status/1256755201207201792?s=21

The whole thread; read it. (h/t Tom Mullen)

EndeavorRx: First Video Game Approved by FDA

June 17, 2020

Rebecca Robbins, reporting for STAT:

> *The game, known as EndeavorRx and developed by Boston-based Akili Interactive Labs, can now be marketed as a way to improve attention function in kids with ADHD as measured by computerized testing. Physicians can prescribe it to children between the ages of 8 and 12 who have an ADHD diagnosis and have demonstrated an issue with attention.*

> *The FDA's move is a landmark decision in the emerging digital therapeutics sector: In addition to being the first game to be marketed as a therapy for any type of condition, EndeavorRx is the first digital therapeutic meant to improve symptoms associated with ADHD, the FDA's announcement said.*

> *The game sends players through landscapes like a molten lava river and an icy winter wonderland, rewarding them with stars and points as they finish tasks. Akili sees the video game as a delivery system for targeted algorithms that can activate and strengthen certain neural networks in the brain. It's more ambitious than the many digital health apps and software programs that aim to help patients manage medical conditions with education, tips, and reminders — and it's long been seen as a crucial test case for the potential of the sector.*

Good Sudoku and The Grid

July 31, 2020

Brendon Bigley, writing at his new site, Wavelengths:

> *After playing daily for about a week after its release, I've noticed Good Sudoku activating the same brain-space as roguelikes in the vein of Spelunky or The Binding of Isaac. These are games meant to be played hundreds of times, and for thousands of hours. After years of playing Spelunky I immediately go into auto-pilot when starting a new run because I've seen so many permutations of the level generation I can't help but feel as though surprise is unlikely. But that comfort with such a hostile environment has come from thousands of runs. I've died in Spelunky more times than I can count, and each death brings with it a small lesson for survival in future attempts. At this point, my head is crammed so full of strategies and techniques and possibilities that I feel more equipped than ever to survive the next run. I mean I probably won't... but it's nice to feel confident sometimes!!*

I haven't played *Good Sudoku*, nor *Spelunky* or *The Binding of Isaac*, but I know enough about vanilla sudoku and these roguelikes to understand that Bigley's observation is striking. I'm having of those, "How didn't I see this before?" moments.

To the uninitiated or uninterested, sudoku puzzles all look the same — a 9x9 grid with numbers sprinkled about. How many variations could there be? How is sudoku not a solved game? But the number of variations of sudoku puzzles is staggering — far more than any human could experience in their lifetime. Nigh-endless possibilities within a consistent environment. And what is the procedurally generated experience of a roguelike if not nigh-endless possibilities within a consistent environment?

Thanks to Bigley, it's now hard to think of roguelikes and procedural generation as something made possible with today's technology, but something conceived from a 9x9 grid.

'[Sports are] forging a trail which the games industry would be wise to follow'

August 28, 2020

Chris Plante, Polygon:

> *As members of the video game industry consider the power of solidarity, as video game streamers question the sustainability of their labor and the parasocial demands of their audience, as the industry-at-large considers its responsibility to the greater culture, I believe sports could and should serve as a compass.*

I'm no sports nut, but this piece cracked me. And it's made more poignant after watching the sunshine and rainbows Netflix video game docuseries 'High Score'. Great observations by Plante.

Super Mario 3D All-Stars Announcement

September 2, 2020

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CPJcaGWoO2c

I've been searching for the right words all morning. "Inevitable" certainly is one, but I think "overjoyed" feels better.

Ever since rumors began circulating about the release of these games on Switch, the hype has felt insurmountable. We've been stuck at home for six months due to a pandemic, clamoring for comfort content. A dose of nostalgia this heavy is certainly what the doctor ordered. (A **clinically proven** vaccine wouldn't be bad either.)

While omitting *Super Mario Galaxy 2* and making this collection limited until March 31st 2021 is a real bummer, it's a thrill that this will be released in two weeks time. Tick Tock Clock is counting down.

From WordPress to Gatsby

September 13, 2020

As of today, I no longer have a CMS backing Zero Counts, my analytics have been wiped away, and most of my posts have been removed from the website.

No, this is not the next catastrophic event of 2020. The internet is not slowly dissolving like a post-Thanos snap. Quite the opposite. This is self-imposed (and maybe a huge mistake), but it's a project I've been meaning to take on since the beginning of quarantine. (As if I didn't have enough to worry about this year.)

As the title states, I moved Zero Counts from a self-hosted WordPress instance hosted with DreamHost to a static site built with Gatsby.js and hosted with Netlify CDN. What does this mean? In short, Zero Counts is faster, more efficient, and better suited for SEO and accessibility.

For those unfamiliar, with WordPress, all of my posts were published with the WordPress CMS and stored in a database. When you visited the website, your device had to make several roundtrips to a server to fetch each post. However, with Gatsby, the site gets regenerated every time I make a change to the codebase, including posts. Therefore, most everything — HTML+CSS and content — is compiled into a single static application that your device fetches (generally) once from a server.

On top of that, when visiting the WordPress version of Zero Counts, upwards of 10 CSS files were downloaded onto your device — including the Bootstrap CSS necessary for the grid system I used for page layout — totaling 225KB, give or take. This may or may not have been WordPress's fault; maybe just my inexperience with PHP and Wordpress themes. With the Gatsby version of Zero Counts, I wrote a single bare minimum CSS file including a Bootstrap grid clone using CSS grid.

On the authoring side, all of the website's code and content are stored in a single code repository that I push to GitHub. I no longer write or manage any content in a CMS (for now). Instead, I write raw Markdown files and push them straight to GitHub. (God, I love Markdown.) I can write these in an IDE like VS Code or a Markdown compatible word processor like iA Writer. Once I finish a post, I push the file to GitHub, Gatsby re-generates the HTML for zerocounts.net, and the new post appears.

I won't go into a lengthy piece about how all of this was done. Instead, I'll point to some resources that helped me get here:

- Tania Rascia's "The End of an Era: Migrating from WordPress to Gatsby" pointed me in the direction of ExitWP — a tool to convert Wordpress XML to Markdown.
- While Rascia leveraged the Gatsby Advanced Starter, I decided that was overkill for Zero Counts and began with the Gatsby Starter Blog and incorporated bits from the gatsby-paginated-blog.
- Many WordPress to Gatsby posts (including Rascia's) pointed to Netlify for CDN hosting. If you're not familiar, think of a CDN as a global network of servers. When a user visits Zero Counts, the user gets pointed to the server closest to them for the fastest download. (The internet still abides by physics, folks.)
- I'm fairly proficient in Markdown, but I did reference John Gruber's Markdown spec several times.
- Chris Wachtman's "How to Replicate the Bootstrap 3 Grid Using CSS Grid" was immensely helpful.

The migration is not entirely complete. While ExitWP is a great tool, each post requires a bit of Markdown clean-up. Therefore, I've only ported over posts from 2019–2020 as well as any interlinked posts prior to 2019. I'll be chipping away at the remainder of posts from 2013–2018 over time.

Zero Counts began as a Tumblr blog called The Starr List back in 2013 or so. Over time, I moved over to WordPress.com, dabbled and stumbled around in code, migrated to a self-hosted WordPress site using a stock theme, created my own child theme, and eventually moved everything into a single codebase, allowing me quickly develop locally and offer up an optimized version of Zero Counts.

It's been a lot of work and education, and finding time is not easy. In any case, here's to another iteration of Zero Counts. Here's to you, old sport.

IGN: ‘The Xbox Series S will not run Xbox One X enhanced versions of backwards compatible games, but will instead run Xbox One S versions of Xbox One and Xbox 360 titles’

September 14, 2020

Categories: General

I consider myself plugged into to the industry, but I’m with Martin on this one. The longer I stare at this tweet, the more I’m convinced that I’m the crazy one.

Ben Thompson on Microsoft's Game Plan

September 17, 2020

Categories: Business

Ben Thompson, Stratechery:

> *In fact, if you would have subscribed to the $15 Xbox All Access anyway, you actually save money by paying monthly: $19 in the case of the Series X, and an impressive $59 in the case of the Series S.*
>
> *That last discount is the tell as to what Microsoft is up to: the truth is that anyone buying a "cheaper" console that, unlike the PS5, is in fact worse in performance, is pretty unlikely to sign up for an additional $15/month gaming service. Subscribers, though, are exactly what Microsoft wants, and when you consider the fact you can pay only $25 a month, get all of those free games, and "save" $60, the offer becomes pretty compelling to more casual game players, and parents.*
>
> *More broadly, Microsoft is seeking to get out of the traditional console business, with its loss-leading hardware and fight over exclusives, and into the services business broadly; that's why Xbox Game Pass, the cloud streaming service that is available not only on Xbox and PC but also on Android phones (Apple has blocked it from iOS for business model reasons), is included. In Microsoft's view of the world the Xbox is just a specialized device for accessing their game service, which, if they play their cards right, you will stay subscribed to for years to come.*
>
> *This also explains the hardware differences: Microsoft actually wants developers to focus on scalable games that work anywhere, as opposed to targeting one specific hardware configuration; their strategy is just as aligned as Sony's, it's just pointing in a very different direction.*

This is the best take on Microsoft's gaming strategy I've read.

Vintage Nintendo games are good vibes made playable

October 4, 2020

Categories: General

Allegra Frank, Vox:

> *Finding comfort in games is what's drawn me to them the most this year. Which is why I've turned obsessively toward the types of games that exude friendliness. I've found this most in the nostalgic charm and childlike wonder of (mostly) vintage Nintendo games. Gone is my interest in the new and buzzworthy; I'm here to revisit the kindly faces I can find on my Switch.*

> *And it doesn't matter if you have pre-established nostalgia for the halcyon days of simple, E-for-Everyone-rated Nintendo games or not. In the same way that Nintendo's small-town-life simulation game Animal Crossing found mass appeal earlier this year for its coziness, these games promise morally uncomplicated fun from the onset. They're good for anyone who's craved some virtual, pleasant, joyous worlds to escape to.*

This harkens back to Amanda Hess's feelings at the beginning of lockdown in the US — nearly seven months ago, for those counting.

The handling of the situation globally has been fraught with anxiety. In the US, it's a complete shitshow. I can't take my eyes off of the news. Email newsletters pile up in my inbox — two from The New York Times, one from Vox, one from Apple News, and Dave Pell's NextDraft to add some levity and (surprisingly) reality to the avalanche nay cavalcade of bad news. Even tech focused newsletters from Ben Thompson, Casey Newton, and Dieter Bohn ring with a tinge foreboding. OK, more than a tinge.

Every day feels the same. Whether I'm trying to navigate corporate bureaucracy, social unrest, brain chemistry, or electrical wiring — there's lots of home improvement going on in the Starr Household these days — every day feels the same. I miss my friends. I miss my family. I miss my co-workers. Thank every otherworldly being that my wife and I pair like chocolate and peanut butter. She's my saving grace.

Yes, I have distractions. We watch great TV like Watchmen, Seinfeld, and Ted Lasso. We cook together, clean together, and decorate together. We have it as good as it gets. Solitarily, I work on remotely recorded '90s covers with a group of dudes (less often than I should be) and I'm in a book club.

But in the flood of bad news and rip current of quarantine space-time, I find great serenity wading deep in the waters of childhood comforts. The latest of which is *Super Mario 3D All-Stars*.

There are better sources to explain the strengths and weaknesses of *Super Mario 64*, *Super Mario Sunshine*, and *Super Mario Galaxy*. After much consideration, I don't aim to do that on Zero Counts. What I will say is that *Super Mario 64* is my You've Got Mail. If you're my wife or have a fondness for bouquets of newly sharpened pencils, you get it. That's a big deal.

This is a long way of saying that I agree with Allegra — vintage Nintendo games *are* good vibes.

How Games are Changing the World

October 12, 2020

Categories: Business

Colin Campbell, previously of Polygon and IGN fame, has launched an important newsletter devoted specifically to idea of How Games are Changing the World.

I've been enjoying some recent issues and figured I'd share an excerpt from one in particular that had an especially profound effect on me.

The talent of empathy:

> *Chris Metzen retired from game development in 2016. He'd spent 23 years in the game industry, working at Blizzard on some of its key games, including Warcraft, Diablo, Overwatch, and Starcraft (a solid bio is here). Yesterday, he spoke about his struggle with mental health challenges, and the game industry's long-standing absence of understanding the centrality of mental health.*
>
> *Speaking at The International Games Summit on Mental Health, with Take This executive director Eve Crevoshay, he talked about his experiences in an industry that saw itself as a warrior culture where performance was all that mattered, and where a relentless competitive spirit was valued far more than empathy or care. The session was called "The talent of empathy." (Note. I've tidied up some quotes, for clarity.)*
>
> *"Part of my leaving was I started having some serious issues with anxiety and panic and horrific imposter syndrome," he said. "It was there all along. The psychology of being afraid, of feeling unworthy, and not being able to ask for back-up from friends and co-workers. There's a lot of shame that can come with that. It doesn't feel safe to talk about that."*
>
> *He acknowledged his privilege in being at a point in his career that he was able to step away from his work and find "perspective and time". Most people have to endure the particularity of their workplace, and to compete for position, recognition and career survival.*
>
> *He began at Blizzard when he was 20 years old. "It was a frat-house. Even though we were all nerds, everyone was trying to be a tough guy. The expression of emotions like tiredness or fear was not culturally acceptable. If you feel overwhelmed then you feel like a weak link, like you're breaking a grand tradition, like you're breaking a contract."*
>
> *As the years went by, and despite a record of high level success, Metzen was struggling. "I was a grown man and was feeling things that I didn't know how to process. My performance was linked to my self-esteem and my sense of purpose. I was terrified by the question of 'who am I', if I wasn't this creature who was here to perform in this way."*

I strongly encourage you to read the rest of the piece and subscribe to Campbell's newsletter.

One of the ideas behind Zero Counts was to share positive impacts video games have on the world. But I remain an outsider to the industry — simply observing and playing here and there. Yet, I recognize the toxicity in it, which hurts. It sucks to have such a pleasant part of your childhood

associated with so much pain for others. Video games are joyous marvels of engineering and art. They spark conversations of curiosity and wonder and should be just as fulfilling to work on.

I'm so glad there are more outlets popping up with the mission of sharing positivity within the industry. But positivity holds no weight without also holding others accountable. Outlets like Into the Aether, Polygon, and Gamesindustry.biz not only showcase positive stories and emphasize fun, the hold feet to the flame of injustice, discrimination, and exploitation. I'm happy to add How Games are Changing the World to that list.

Feminist Frequency: Gender Breakdown of Games in 2020

October 16, 2020

Categories: Gender

Anita Sarkeesian and Carolyn Petit of Feminist Frequency, contributing to Wired:

> *This year also marks the narrowest divide between games featuring defined female protagonists and games featuring defined male protagonists that we've yet seen, with games starring male characters making up 23 percent of this year's total, or just 5 percent more games overall. In previous years, there have always been at least three times as many games centering men as there were centering women, so the fact that this year both values are at least in the same ballpark is definitely a welcome development. However, while we should perhaps be cautiously optimistic about these numbers, we also shouldn't break out the champagne just yet. It will naturally require another year or two before we can begin to determine if this shift reflects actual changes that are taking place, or if 2020 is a one-off statistical anomaly that will quickly see a return to the status quo.*

I look forward to these reports every year. Readers of Zero Counts (and The Starr List before that) may recall my E3 2013 and E3 2014 Genre/Gender Breakdowns. I find a lot of humble serendipity that Feminist Frequency began running this very similar survey in 2015.

So much of identity is rooted in gender. With video games being such an immersive medium, the ability to not only witness but partake in the story of a character whose gender is the same or different from that of the player can have profound impact, self-identifying or empathetic. That is the reason I surveyed in 2013 and 2014 (and 2012, to some degree), and that is a big reason why Feminist Frequency continues to do so:

> *Each year when we present this data, some people invariably point to the fact that games which allow players a choice between a male and female character, or games in which you control an ensemble of characters made up of people of different genders, make up the biggest percentage of all (55 percent this year), and wonder why that isn't, on its own, enough to satisfy us. The answer is quite simple. Of course we welcome games that allow players the option to create and customize their own characters, but this is categorically different from games that feature defined, specific characters. Each person who plays Horizon: Zero Dawn, for instance, or The Last of Us Part II must step into the shoes of a defined female character, and experience the game's efforts to get them to identify with and relate to that character. In an industry whose output was for decades dominated by male heroes, what we most want to see is a shift toward at least an equal number of games that require players to take on the role of humanized female characters.*

In a year of absolute madness, 2020's Gender Breakdown of Games certainly a sight for sore eyes. I second Colin Campbell in saying "the full article, and its various charts, is definitely worth a read."

'Nintendo’s game streaming strategy is not having one'

October 28, 2020

Categories: Business

Brendon Bigley, blogging for Into the Aether:

> *The thing I find most fascinating about game streaming to the Switch is how antithetical it feels to the way Nintendo markets the device itself. The Nintendo Switch is a home console you can take on the go! Games can be played on your TV or on the train! But not always? The more publishers decide to use companies like Ubitus to provide game streaming instead of building real ports, the more the eShop begins to flood with great looking games that can only be played at home. Yes, you can still swap between TV and handheld, but the actual freedom of the device’s portability fades away when a persistent internet connection is required.*

Bigley's take is so good I'm pissed I didn't think of it myself.

I can't imagine Nintendo including cellular connectivity in the rumored Switch Pro, so a streaming strategy for the Switch most certainly breaks the "designed to fit your life" paradigm if players are forced to have a Wi-Fi connection to play certain games. That said, streaming is another novel mode for the Switch's portfolio — a handheld; a home console; a blank slate.

'Well, Nintendo Is Doing Great'

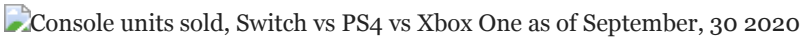
November 6, 2020

Categories: Business

Brian Ashcroft, reporting for Kotaku:

> *In its six-month earning statement ending on September 30 of this year, Nintendo reported that year-on-year net sales are up 73.3 percent, while net profit reached 213 billion yen ($2 billion), an increase of 243.6 percent.*
>
> *Moreover, hardware sales reached 12.53 million units worldwide during this period, which is an 80.9 percent increase year on year. Out of that number, 8.36 million were standard Switch consoles and 5.17 million were Switch Lites.*

Here's an updated look at lifetime Nintendo Switch sales vs PS4 and Xbox One:



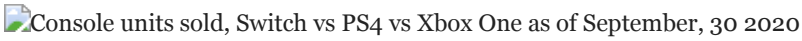
And compared against it's older cousin the Nintendo 3DS:



Ashcroft, continued:

> *Nintendo has modified its forecast for the current financial year, expecting a 50 percent increase in net profit. Previously, Nintendo had forecasted selling 19 million Switch units, but that number has been changed to 24 million, which is higher than the 21 million sold last year. Software sales are forecasted to reach 170 million units, which is up from the previously forecasted number of 140 million units. In comparison, last year's software sales reached 168 million units.*

Here's a look if Nintendo's forecast holds true:



And a look against the goat — PS2 is the greatest selling console of all time at 158 million units; g(sc)oat:



The First Boy

November 28, 2020



This is my first Game Boy mod. About six months into the pandemic, I had a hankering to play some old Game Boy Advance games; namely Final Fantasy Tactics Advance. But I also had an itch to start an project that involved using my hands. Maybe the isolation behind a computer had gotten the best of me. Needless to say, I bought a functioning Game Boy Advance from DKOldies and an IPS display from FunnyPlaying and got to work.

For the first version of this mod, I carved out the necessary plastic to replace the display in the original shell. (The IPS displays are slightly larger than the original displays.) Unsatisfied with my trimming, I later decided to replace the shell with a FunnyPlaying after-market shell, buttons, and silicone. Any mods that required soldering would come later.

GBC, Blue/Gold Version

December 12, 2020



The Game Boy Color, Blue/Gold Version was a gift for a dear friend and former podcast co-host. It was inspired from an episode of our show where we discussed our fondness and memories of Pokémon Blue. I chose a gold shell because a) it was the only color available at the time and b) it played homage to the Pokémon Red/Blue sequel, Gold/Silver.

Video "Games" in 2020

December 27, 2020

Categories: General

In October of 2019, I wrote a piece for From the Aether titled Video Games Do Not Exist. In the piece, I ponder the idea of "video games" coming into existence today — that developers and artists were never constrained by the limitations of those in '70s, '80s, and '90s. The interactive experiences spawned in this alternate reality would not be classified as video "games" as different types of "video" experiences would originate alongside one another.

This premise is of course absurd as video games have been one of the catalysts for technological advancement. Consumer technology would likely look very different without early desires to bring richer gaming experiences into the home. Likewise, limited technical prowess forced early games to be developed with limitations we would find comical today. This is better summed up by computer graphics researcher Thomas A. Defanti in his 1984 paper The Mass Impact of Videogame Technology:

> *However, videogames have seriously and irreversibly affected the computer industry. Game players (mostly adolescents and people in their twenties) are unlikely to react favorably to a half-million-dollar office automation system that does not have joysticks, is not user friendly, and does not offer the simple high-level programmability offered by the simplest home game with BASIC. Color animation, which allows a much closer matching of human and computer bandwidths, is now expected from computing devices. Availability of intense, nonverbal, two-way communication is now taken for granted, spelling an early end to complete reliance on the unpleasant exercise of reading all day from a video display terminal. To a certain extent, we are very fortunate that computer graphics, unlike television, is incapable of transmitting "talking heads" very well, because that would be too-easy a misuse of the power of the medium, one to which educational television has defaulted.*
>
> *In not having a previous medium to emulate, videogames have had to create a new way of communicating. They are truly a new medium. Maturity, still a long way off, will spawn some new form of what may be called interactive literature. Now, however, we can observe an industry in early infancy, struggling and toying to be part of our lives. It is a special time to watch, play, and enjoy.*

But hypothetically speaking, if video games just happened upon us today, with all of the current technology at our disposal, they wouldn't just encompass simple exercises of shooting asteroids, shooting centipedes, shooting invaders, shooting ducks, running left to right, or saving a princesses. These experiences would be so varied we wouldn't classify every interactive video experience under the umbrella term "video game". Don't get me wrong, video "games" would absolutely exist — extending from digital recreations of their analog forebearers to high-fidelity large scale MMORPGs. But birthed along side those would be narrative experiences, simulations, and sandboxes, where the word "game" would not feel appropriate. Being developed alongside one another, these experiences likely wouldn't draw comparisons. At least not like they do in our current reality.

So what is the point of theorizing what we might call video games in the alternate reality? Today, a "video game" is a video "game", right? Well, my friend, in 2020, we may have made contact with the alternate reality.

Publications have published their Game of the Year lists for 2020, and more often than not you'll find some of the following games on their lists:

- **Hades** — An endless rogue-like game that doubles as a relationship simulator, triples as a home decorating sandbox, and is chock-full of a vast tapestry voice-acting and narrative. (It also probably won the GOTY from your choice publication.)
- **Animal Crossing: New Horizons** — A seasonally updated, endless sandbox experience that allows players all over the world to interact with one another while collecting, building, throwing birthday parties, and hosting talkshows.
- **Kentucky Route Zero: TV Edition** — A visual novel with ten years of development, zero plot, a historical account of the travesties of the past decade, and a vibe unlike any you've ever experienced.
- **If Found...** — A visual novel featuring black holes and punk rock.
- **13 Sentinels: Aegis Rim** — A visual novel of time travel and commentary on media; video games included. Also, real-time strategy.
- **Blaseball** — Fantasy fantasy baseball that constantly changes, including lore of biblical proportions wholly developed by the community of observers.
- **Among Us** — An online social deduction game played by friends, families, and politicians.
- **Microsoft Flight Simulator** — A flight simulator by Microsoft. Also a digital replica of Earth that includes your house.

Of course these types of "games" are not new or even novel experiences. Idle games, visual novels, and simulators have existed for decades. But to be so prevalent in game of the year lists across so many publications is simply fascinating. Our definition of what qualifies as a video game is not changing and probably never will. But what qualifies as a masterpiece of the medium is now broader than ever. Sure, on the surface *Hades* is a video-game-ass-video-game — maybe *the* video-game-ass-video-game. But to compare that to an experience like *Kentucky Route Zero*, or *KRZ* to *Animal Crossing* even, is not apples and oranges; it's apples and fabric textures.

The entries on lists of best video games can no longer be quantitatively compared (and probably couldn't have been for the past 5–10 years). More than ever before they must be evaluated based on personal enjoyment with the experience, which... duh. And we all know lists are bullshit. I'm not trying to cement that argument here. (Plus, I like a list as much as the next person.) But the spread of experiences now ranked against one another is so wild that it's worth noting.

Whenever I'm holding my Switch, my wife asks me what I'm playing. This year, more often than not, the answer was, "it's... uh... like... hmmm... kinda like ... it's not *really* a game, but like..." so on and so forth. And I'm certain that's the answer being heard more than ever.

If we're to stick to the nomenclature of "video games" for these experiences, that's fine. But it's high-time we understand that they are no longer games. They are outright replacing, updating, or inventing new art forms, which seems fitting of Defanti's conclusion:

> *Coin-operated videogames, from their pinball heritage to their extreme hedonistic desirability, have emerged as the black sheep, so to speak, of the interactive graphics movement. Yet, they are causing significant technological breakthroughs, especially in the area of cost/performance. We are seeing interactive fantasy emerge as a medium, and, with it, considerable development in the art of nonverbal communication. Coin-op technology quickly (within 2-3 years) passes down to personal computer systems, such that*

> *any home computer now has significantly better graphics and interactive devices than all but a few computer systems available in the lab or the office.*
>
> *Knowledge of how to write games and present information through interactive animation will eventually encode itself into higher level programming structures available to subject-matter experts, teachers, intellectuals, children, and parents. A sizable portion of the computer graphics community already exchanges information on videotape. Floppy disk is now the home computer user's way to send greetings. Animation will surely become a major form of communication once the delivery systems are ubiquitous.*
>
> *Reading is, after all, a terrible waste of our human perceptual bandwidth, even if it is enjoyable. Fortunately, the richness of interaction claimed in the preceding pages can be experienced first-hand for considerably less than this book costs, even playing every game discussed here. You might want to hurry, though, before the classics disappear.*

No other year exemplifies the change in the concept of "video games" than 2020.

ITA Boys

February 16, 2021



This collection of Game Boy Advances were built as gifts for the hosts and producer of the *Into the Aether* podcast. As a long time fan, I wanted to give back to the show with through my new found hobby of Game Boy modding. I packaged these up, shuffled them around, and sent a random unit to each member of the Aether team.

Unfortunately, I don't have build notes from these units.

Nintendo's Wonder Bar

April 24, 2021

Categories: Design

The Top 100 Games Podcast invited Polygon's Editor-in-chief Chris Plante to the show to discuss the importance of game #55, *Wii Sports*.

Not only is the discussion a trip down memory lane that many people will remember, but it is an argument for the historical significance of the Wii Remote in terms of controller accessibility and the wonder in simplicity.

> ***Chris Plante****: In the history of video games, there is no better party game than Wii Sports Bowling. It is the only game you can hand over to people and everybody can play. And not only can everybody play, they'll feel like they're participating in magic. Equally. No matter how much they care about video games. I don't know if I can think of anything that can compare to it.*
>
> ***Jered Petty****: Wow. Ok. Expound. How and why does that work? What is it about the magic bowling game that makes that take place?*
>
> ***CP****: This is going to get into one of my long term issues in video games that ironically I think is just aging out. For a very long time, I have had a beef with how complex video game controllers are. You're expected to learn the D-pad, two thumbs-sticks, four face-buttons, two start-and-pause-buttons, a home button, triggers, and who knows whatever else. That is a ridiculous amount for any newcomer to ever learn. It's a completely prohibitive barrier to entry.*
>
> *Around the time the Wii came out, that's what companies were grappling with. I also think it's what touchscreen controls were grappling with. How do we make computer entertainment more accessible? Both the keyboard and video game controllers are too complex. So we got [the Wii Remote] and we got Kinect.*
>
> *I'm not sure I still believe this any more; video games being so ubiquitous that they are as common as someone having to learn a keyboard. It's just a thing you have to learn as a kid. So fretting over what happens if someone doesn't know how to use a video game controller? The answer is like, "who is this person?" Especially with Xbox making so much more headway into accessibility devices, I think my argument has sort of slipped away.*
>
> *That said, there is still an older generation — there especially was when [Wii Sports] came out — who could not and would not learn a video game controller. Today, if we took every game out from it and put them out for offer for anyone to play, [bowling] is the one I don't think a single person couldn't pick up — minding that they have the capability to use a Wii controller — and that is what I think is inherently special about it. [Bowling] more than any of the games has that "it's literally just like bowling" feel. To make it even better, you can put spin on [the ball]. Not only is it like bowling, but it has that extra Aha! moment of, "they did it. This isn't faking it. I am actually controlling this bowling ball." I think that's special.*

Later in the episode…

> ***JP**: In 1986 or so, I first saw Super Mario Bros. I'd been playing video games for years before then, even as a kid. But it was like something had come down from outer space. Compared to what I'd played before, it was as if the skies had opened and aliens had dropped a new technology on earth that allowed me to travel to 32 different worlds, fighting bosses, jumping, finding secrets. No game had captured that feeling of wonder since. Until I played Wii Sports. That reignited that same feeling from my childhood. That I had never had this much fun doing something like this.*
>
> ***CP**: It's that total novelty. I think it's hard for people to… I hope we get that again. I'm sure we will with different things and different technology and stuff.*
>
> *But I think about that a lot. We grew up in a really unusual time where people were figuring out how to visualize the world through technology. As we were growing up. It's hard to explain just what it felt like in Mario [3] that you could go forward and it scrolled, and you could go backward and it scrolled. There's a whole world here! That single feeling was incredible.*
>
> *I think the same thing about when Pixar movies first came out. The first few of them it was like I am literally seeing something I should not. This should not be possible. Wii Sports is right there in that space of "I'm doing this and I know intellectually how the technology works, yet it still feels like I'm casting a spell." It's the best! Same thing with Mario. I'm controlling another person in a fictional world; how is this happening?*

I've griped about the number of buttons on modern video game controllers myself and praised innovations in accessibility. Plante's retrospective of the Wii Remote clearly illustrates the benefits of simplicity. Removing complexity removes the friction between the player/viewer/user and make-believe. Simplicity in and of itself creates wonder.

For video game controllers, the metaphor I've come up with is puppeteering. Modern video game controllers are marionette control bars — complex by design for the sake of precision and realism. But the Wii Remote, and NES controller before it, is a hand in shadowgraphy — more a bridge between worlds than a tool to recreate them.

Wonder bars.

Game Boy, White

May 5, 2021



This was my first original Game Boy mod, but the first Game Boy I'd ever worked on. In 2019, I decided to crack open an old, broken original Game Boy I had lying around to see if I could fix it. (I think it was my step-brother's old Game Boy.) You can read about that process on my post Game Boy Restored.

In an effort to match my person Game Boy Advance, I decided to add an IPS display and swap the casing of this unit using FunnyPlaying's Game Boy Housing and Button combos.

The Aether

July 5, 2021



As a fan of *Into the Aether*, it excited me to no end to play a small role in the show. When Brendon and Stephen asked me to build three Game Boy Advance units for a giveaway on the Season 4 kickoff GBA episode, I was over the moon. The podcast has provided me much needed levity during heavy times and feels like I'm hanging out with friends more than listening to a show.

The Aether is my own interpretation of the "the aether" — something light and ethereal with splashes of the signature *Into the Aether* purple to pink gradient. I'm a big fan of berndog's, and one of his builds featured a left/right dual-tone which got me thinking…

In total, *The Aether* includes:

- New IPS LCD w/ brightness controls (select + L/R) by FunnyPlaying
- New speaker by FunnyPlaying
- Shell by FunnyPlaying
- Buttons procured from Handheld Legend
- New glass screen
- New stock capacitors
- Power Cleaner Flex by Helder
- One dehum/dehiss capacitor by RetroSix
- Cleaned power switch

The Whale (Scout's Whale)

July 5, 2021



As a fan of *Into the Aether*, it excited me to no end to play a small role in the show. When Brendon and Stephen asked me to build three Game Boy Advance units for a giveaway on the Season 4 kickoff GBA episode, I was over the moon. The podcast has provided me much needed levity during heavy times and feels like I'm hanging out with friends more than listening to a show.

The Whale comes inspired by the whale featured on the cover art of *Into the Aether* Seasons 3 and 4 by Scout Wilkinson. The clear black shell + solid button build is the exact opposite of the companion *White Whale* build which features a solid white shell + clear buttons.

In total, *The Whale* includes:

- New IPS LCD w/ brightness controls (select + L/R) by FunnyPlaying
- New speaker by FunnyPlaying
- Shell by FunnyPlaying
- Prestige Buttons by RetroSix
- New glass screen
- New stock capacitors
- Power Cleaner Flex by Helder
- One dehum/dehiss capacitor by RetroSix
- Cleaned power switch

The White Whale

July 5, 2021



As a fan of *Into the Aether*, it excited me to no end to play a small role in the show. When Brendon and Stephen asked me to build three Game Boy Advance units for a giveaway on the Season 4 kickoff GBA episode, I was over the moon. The podcast has provided me much needed levity during heavy times and feels like I'm hanging out with friends more than listening to a show.

The White Whale comes inspired by the ongoing podcast theme of "white whale" games that hosts Brendon and Stephen are chasing. The solid white shell + clear button build is the exact opposite of the companion *Whale* build which features a clear black shell + solid buttons.

In total, *The White Whale* includes:

- New IPS LCD w/ brightness controls (select + L/R) by FunnyPlaying
- New speaker by FunnyPlaying
- Shell by FunnyPlaying
- Prestige Buttons by RetroSix
- New glass screen
- New stock capacitors
- Power Cleaner Flex by Helder
- One dehum/dehiss capacitor by RetroSix
- Cleaned power switch

Resties Boy Advances

July 30, 2021


Resties Boy Advances

The Resties Boy Advances were commissoned companion pieces for the launch of The Besties: Resties podcast, inspired by its magnificent cover art.

These builds include:

- New IPS LCD w/ brightness controls (select + L/R) by FunnyPlaying
- New speaker by FunnyPlaying
- Shell by FunnyPlaying
- Buttons by FunnyPlaying
- Silicone Pads by Funnyplaying
- Yellow and purple power LED mod
- New glass screen
- New stock capacitors
- Power Cleaner Flex by Helder
- One dehum/dehiss capacitor by RetroSix
- Cleaned power switch

GBA Daiei Hawks Restore

August 16, 2021



When I picked up this broken Game Boy Advance, I had no idea what I'd come across. This unit was in particularly bad shape when I opened it up. There was a large amount of corrosion on the start/select pads and gunk throughout. The headphone jack also had large amounts of corrosion and was preventing the audio from being sent to the speaker. Needless to say, these issues have now been resolved, along with the following repairs and restorations:

- Buttons by FunnyPlaying
- Silicone Pads by Funnyplaying
- New glass screen
- New stock capacitors
- New battery cover
- Cleaned power switch

GBA, Kirby Edition

August 16, 2021



This Kirby themed unit was more challenging than expected. I initially presented a minimal look, but my eyes were opened to how much color Kirby actually has going on! In fact, I used more colors on this GBA than any others I'd built previously, spanning the purple to pink color spectrum in some creative ways. In addition to a range of colors, this GBA includes:

- New IPS LCD w/ brightness controls (select + L/R) by FunnyPlaying
- New speaker by FunnyPlaying
- Shell by FunnyPlaying
- Buttons by FunnyPlaying
- Buttons by RetroSix
- Silicone Pads by Funnyplaying
- Pink power LED mod
- New glass screen
- New stock capacitors
- Power Cleaner Flex by Helder
- One dehum/dehiss capacitor by RetroSix
- Cleaned power switch

Game Boy Advance, Sunset

December 21, 2021



The *Game Boy Advance, Sunset* was a commission build themed after a sunset. This was a challengeing build as I wanted to mimmick the gradient of a sunset. The buyer and I played around with several versions from reds, purples, and pinks, eventually landing on an orange shell, maroon buttons, pink LED, and white accents for clouds.

Unfortunately, I don't have build notes from this unit.

Game Boy Advance, Mint

December 22, 2021


Game Boy Advance, Mint

This might be my favorite Game Boy Advance color palette yet! Initially, I attempted to use a shell by RetroSix, but was disappointed by the display mounting solution and bad branding. Thankfully, I was able to track down a (sold out) light blue FunnyPlaying shell — the preferred shell of most modders — which also fits the FunnyPlaying glass nicely.

The logic board came from an AGB-001 — the first run of GBAs produced in 2001. It was in extremely good condition, save a dirty power switch which prevented it from powering on, and a defective right-shoulder button. I believe this is the first AGB-001 unit I'd worked on.

Here's a breakdown of the full mod:

- New IPS LCD w/ brightness controls (select + L/R) by FunnyPlaying
- New speaker by FunnyPlaying
- Shell by FunnyPlaying
- Buttons by FunnyPlaying
- Buttons by RetroSix
- Silicone Pads by Funnyplaying
- White power LED mod
- New glass screen
- New stock capacitors
- Power Cleaner Flex by Helder
- One dehum/dehiss capacitor by RetroSix
- Replaced R-shoulder button with salvaged button
- Cleaned power switch

Anybody's Game

January 1, 2022

Categories: Reviews

End of the year lists are pervasive as ever. We know they're coming, but the wave seems so relentless that they're both easy to ignore and easily read with indifference. The voices and outlets sprawl from big media to niche publications, from massive awards shows to independent podcasts. The beauty (and horror) of the landscape is that everyone can find a personality or outlet to align with — something that won't challenge their opinions or taste. Validation!

And I'm a sucker for these lists! I used to pour over best of music lists, but the sheer amount of artists, releases, and my dwindling time to incorporate new music into my comfort zone removed my familiarity with most music lists. Books are much the same. There's just so many.

Video games are approaching the same level of proliferation, but following the output still feel manageable to follow. I'm able to have some familiarity with the titles released throughout the year regardless if I've played them or not. To be fair, the majority of my media consumption is spent reading games industry news and listening to gaming podcasts. But even without a devout following of the world of video games, reading a review, watching a video preview, or listening to podcasters discuss a game in detail offers enough description of mechanics and/or fidelity that a general understanding of the experience can be perceived. Most games are judged on the merit of "fun" which is an extremely easy thing to feel, but an extremely difficult thing to create. I'd argue music and books require a deeper level of personal interpretation of the sonics, prose, and style that many video games do not. But even that is becoming less and less true.

Beyond fun, video games are so complex that breaking best of lists into categories similar to movies (and more) feels more appropriate — music, mechanics, narrative, art direction, systems, acting, etc. But even film falls victim to the singular "BEST MOVIE OF THE YEAR" generalization, and video games follow suit. And after reading a few of these lists, one typically finds that the same game is selected by a majority of outlets as "THE BEST"; hence, the inclination to ignore the list entirely or feel indifferent.

All of this is to say that this year felt... unique. "Game of the Year" lists came from individuals, were compiled by an outlet's staff, voted on by jury, or debated through via a brackets. And the games that topped these lists varied wildly. Here are examples from major media outlets:

- Polygon: *Inscryption*
- IGN: *Forza Horizon 5*
- The Game Awards: *It Takes Two*
- The Guardian: *Returnal*
- EDGE: *Deathloop*
- Golden Joystick Awards (GamesRadar+): *Resident Evil Village*
- Ars Technica: *Psychonauts 2*
- Destructoid: *Chicory: A Colorful Tale*
- EGM: *Psychonauts 2*
- Game Informer: *Halo Infinite*
- GameSpot: *Deathloop*
- TIME: *Metroid Dread*

- Esquire: *Ratchet & Clank: Rift Apart*

This observation may not be novel. This very well may have been a trend in years past. But briefly skimming the Wikipedia article for "List of Game of the Year awards", you'll find a much more refined alignment of "Game of the Year" winners:

- 2020: *Hades*, *The Last of Us II*, *Ghost of Tsushima*
- 2019: *Control*, *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice*, *Outer Wilds*, *Resident Evil 2*
- 2018: *God of War*, *Red Dead Redemption 2*
- 2017: *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*

Perhaps 2021 is an anomaly. Many AAA games were delayed due to the ongoing challenges of the continuing pandemic. Maybe this gave a little room for smaller or unique titles to spread their wings. Or perhaps this is a a natural evolution of where "games" are headed.

At the end of 2020, I wrote about the idea that video game masterpieces are becoming so wildly varied in experience that to compare two incredible video games is to compare "apples to fabric textures". Video games are comprised of the same elements but now yield profoundly different experiences. Much like music. Much like books.

This year's "Game of the Year" lists exemplify the changing landscape in not only vast array of great games, but how each one hits players/reviewers/outlets in different ways. Instead of a definitive Game of the Year, players now have a vast spread of opinions to consider that will not only validate or challenge their own justifiable contender, but a litany of incredible choices to fit their preferred experience.

NYT: Making video game history

January 3, 2022

Categories: Media

German Lopez, The New York Times:

> *Hades is the first video game in history to win a Hugo Award, the prize for science fiction and fantasy that has historically honored books, graphic novels and other written works.*
>
> *The game, from the developer Supergiant Games, follows the story of Zagreus — son of the game's eponymous god — as he tries to escape the Underworld. Along the way, he fights all sorts of hellish creatures and meets a wide array of characters, including the gods up on Olympus. He also uncovers family secrets and gains perspective on why his dad has made seemingly unsavory decisions.*
>
> *The Hugo Awards' inclusion of video games, which organizers are considering making permanent, speaks to how far the medium has come. In the early days of Pong in the 1970s or the original Super Mario Bros. and The Legend of Zelda in the 1980s, technology limited how much text a game could include. Today, a game's storytelling can be its primary selling point, whether it's a high-budget science-fiction epic like the Mass Effect trilogy or an indie game made by a small team like Celeste.*

This news broke last December, but I was tickled to see it included in today's NYT morning newsletter. Not only is winning a Hugo award a tremendous achievement for Supergiant Games and the medium as a whole, mentions of specific titles large and small — from *Mass Effect* to *Celeste* — by a publication as massive as the New York Times is particularly noteworthy.

One of the reasons I started Zero Counts in 2013 was to gather and (hopefully) elevate video game industry coverage from major publications. I felt the medium had every right to be taken as seriously as art, big business, and cultural touchstones and should be covered as such by the largest publications in the world. At the time, it was only happening in fits and starts, typically prompted by the latest console craze or "Nintendo's white Playstation 4".

Coverage has changed a great deal since then, putting a spotlight on scandal, working conditions, earnings, and acquisitions. What's more is that most major outlets have now hired staff focused on the video game industry — NYT's Kellen Browning, Washington Post's Gene Park and Teddy Amenabar, Axios' Stephen Totilo and Megan Farokhmanesh, and The Guardian's Keza MacDonald to name a few. Coverage of specific games still feels spotty, but short of a consumer warning, reviews may be becoming less critical. So when specific games are highlighted — namely indies — it magnifies the growing recognition of the industry and the importance and impact of the medium.

On that note, I think I need to give the Underworld one more run.

Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: The Cowabunga Collection

March 10, 2022

Categories: Games

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=R-78FD9xvc0

Konami:

> *Leonardo, Donatello, Raphael, and Michelangelo are back from the sewers with Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: The Cowabunga Collection! Thirteen radical games from KONAMI's entire archive of retro 8-bit, 16-bit, and arcade Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles (TMNT) titles and their Japanese versions* will be coming to PlayStation®5, PlayStation®4, Xbox Series X|S, Xbox One, Nintendo Switch and PC Steam. Physical retail and digital versions will be available in 2022 at SRP $39.99.*
>
> *This incredible collection of thirteen original classics gives chasing down Shredder, fighting the Foot, and tangling-up with Bebop and Rocksteady a fresh look at why KONAMI's adaptations of the heroes in a half shell set the standard in beat 'em up, action games. Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: The Cowabunga Collection includes:*
>
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles (Arcade)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Turtles in Time (Arcade)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles (NES)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles II: The Arcade Game (NES)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles III: The Manhattan Project (NES)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Tournament Fighters (NES)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles IV: Turtles in Time (Super Nintendo)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Tournament Fighters (Super Nintendo)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: The Hyperstone Heist (Sega Genesis)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Tournament Fighters (Sega Genesis)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Fall of The Foot Clan (Game Boy)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles II: Back From The Sewers (Game Boy)*
> - *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles III: Radical Rescue (Game Boy)*

This collection surpasses my wildest expectations. From the inclusion of the Game Boy games to all three versions of *Tournament Fighters*, Konami, Nickelodeon, and Digital Eclipse have outdone themselves.

Growing up a Gameboy + Genesis kid, I have fond memories of *Fall of The Foot Clan* and *Hyperstone Heist*, though, I played my fair share of the original TMNT and Arcade games for NES with my step brother and cousins. I was only able to consume crowd favorite *Turtles in Time* through schoolyard conversations and a handful of quarters at the arcade. And try as I might, Blockbuster always seemed to be out of *Tournament Fighters*. Thanks to the quality-of-life improvements advertised — save anytime, rewind — I can see myself completing all of these titles. I'll be able to conjour up my childhood memories and create some new ones.

Cowabunga, indeed!

Random Access Controls

March 10, 2022

Categories: Design

The Dev Game Club podcast sat down with *Halo: Combat Evolved* designer Jamie Grisemer to discuss the origins of *Halo*'s development, constraints that turned into boons, and design considerations that have become staples in first-person shooters today.

I was particularly fascinated by their discussion around controllers, limited input, and removing friction from action at timestamp 57:43:

> ***Jamie Griesemer**: I think a really fundamental aspect of... I think it is Bungie's design, but also my own, is something I call "Random Access Controls". You can activate any ability with one button press. There's no state or preamble.*
>
> *When we were working on Halo, the way that you would add a grenade to your game is that you would switch to the grenade weapon and use the fire button to throw it. Everybody did it that way. We were like, "I just want to throw the grenade now!" Melee attack is the same way. You don't switch to a melee weapon. It's like, "now!" It's all available right now with no delay. I think that makes your experience much more engaging because instead of having to plan to throw a grenade with your conscious mind, it moves it down into the hypothalamus; like, "no, I'm just going to react with a grenade." At that point, the controls are just going to disappear and you're not thinking about the controller or the keyboard or whatever anymore. You're just thinking and having actions happen. I think that's a really important aspect of games, that I enjoy at least. So I definitely try to recreate that.*
>
> ***Brett Douville**: If you have to plan, you're never going to touch the right stick. You're never going to switch the weapon.*
>
> ***Tim Longo**: You snuck in there "the triangle" (melee, grenades, guns). You melded it into the thirty-second conversation. You wouldn't have that otherwise. It would be so inaccessible if you had to switch between all of those modes. As it is, you can react on the fly and tap, tap, tap.*
>
> ***JG**: We called it the "Golden Tripod". It keeps them all top-of-mind.*
>
> *One thing I've been thinking about a lot over the current project is... we're developing it for the PC and it's really tempting when you have a whole keyboard in front of you to just invent a bunch of new abilities and just assign them all to different letters and numbers and what not. But I really think the controller is the complexity that it is and no more complicated because that's kinda the maximum number of things you can have at the top of mind. Like, you wouldn't improve the Dualshock by adding eight more buttons to it. It would just become more difficult to use, I think at that point.*
>
> *I wonder if controllers got more complicated because players got more capable of holding all those actions in their mind at once.*
>
> ***TL**: I think there's actually some papers out there about this — the evolution of Nintendo's controllers specifically — and how each one of their generations brought something new,*

> *like the D-pad and then the analog stick... not to give them all the credit, but there's an evolution you can see; gamers evolving with it.*
>
> ***BD**: It's interesting that you don't really see that with arcade controls. Those just locked into a stick and two or four buttons. They were always kind of limited in that way. They never matured because you never knew who was going to be plugging quarters into that thing. It had to be lowest common denominator. Anybody could walk up to it an do the thing.*

This bit pairs nicely with Chris Plante and Jered Petty's conversation about Wii Sports and the Wii Remote as well as my thinking about there being too many buttons for casual gaming, of which I'm beginning to turn around on.

(Hat tip to Rahim Sonawalla on the podcast recommendation.)

Reggie Fils-Aimé on the Wii U Struggle

May 20, 2022

Categories: Business

Reggie Fils-Aimé discussing the Wii U's struggle to perform in his new memior "Disrupting the Game:

> *New versions of key software in the Mario Kart and Legend of Zelda franchises were not coming until 2014 or later. Coupled with the announcements that new Xbox and PlayStation consoles were launching during holiday 2013, Wii U sales struggled to gain momentum.*
>
> *Once again, we were faced with a difficult situation that had to be addressed immediately. Wii U had launched with two versions: white with limited storage at $299 and black with four times the storage capacity at $349 including the game Nintendo Land, which we had featured during the 2012 E3 conference. We had hoped this game would be a system seller like Wii Sports, but it did not live up to our expectations. There was not enough volume to support the two different versions at retail, and the black bundle was outselling the white one dramatically, even with the higher price.*
>
> *In the Americas, I took action to eliminate the white Wii U configuration and consolidate the volume on the black bundle. By summer 2013, we had taken the price of the black bundle down to $299. We also worked with NCL to create unique offerings for our market that would appeal to our players. These included black hardware with Zelda graphic elements and the game Legend of Zelda: The Wind Waker HD and a different special hardware bundle that included New Super Mario Bros. U and bonus content called New Super Luigi U.*
>
> *Promotions offering unique hardware and different software bundles are typical in the video game industry. But having to resort to these tactics within one year of launch was unheard of. It was clear that there were not enough product and pricing tactics to keep Wii U alive for a traditional five-plus-year life cycle.*
>
> ***THE SO WHAT***
> *Businesses in trouble need immediate and decisive action. You don't have the luxury of time as the situation worsens around you. Stay true to your principles and the key foundations of the business. Stabilize the situation, then prepare for the next wave of innovation to grow the business back.*

That "next wave of innovation" was the Nintendo Switch — one of the best (and possibly *the* fastest) selling consoles of all time.

On a selfish note, it's too bad Reggie didn't mention a certain Wii U hail mary.

Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Shredder's Revenge Review

June 20, 2022

Categories: Review

Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Shredder's Revenge is tight. Both "tight" in the way Michelangelo would describe a new skateboard and "tight" in the way Leonardo leaves little room for anything other than his focus.

It's Tight 🤙

It's awesome! Righteous! Bossa nova... er... Chevy Nova? Excellent! In the words of the '90s youth, it's tight!

Many reviews have already pointed out how awesome Shredder's Revenge is. It absolutely rules. It's a must-play arcade throwback. It's way more than retro-cool. It's the best nostalgia trip you'll ever have. It's heckin' dope.

The game overwhelming succeeds at recreating the '80s/'90s TMNT arcade beat-em-up experiences. If you spent any time with the original TMNT arcade game (arcade/NES), *Turtles in Time* (arcade/SNES) or *Hyperstone Heist* (Sega Genesis), you'll find the familiar variety of foot soldiers, patterns of obstacles to dodge while riding cheapskates and hoverboards, mutant (and robot) baddies from across the franchise, pizza boxes, and quotes likes, "Turtle Power!" and, "Ugh... shellshocked".

In addition to the familiar, the level designs feature lovingly handcrafted pixel art by Juanito Medina that feels like it was ripped right out of the cartoon — colors pop, tiny details strewn about — with those aforementioned foot soldiers taking part in the scenes as office workers or checkout clerks. You'll uncover cameos from the first two seasons of the original 1987 cartoon. The turtles themselves — voiced by the actors from the original cartoon series — feature their own unique stats and animations. And not only can you play as the four titular heroes, but you can also play as Splinter, April O'Neil, and Casey Jones. There are even clever nods to the legacy of TMNT video games: The overworld map resembles the overworld map from the original NES game, and — follow me here — a video game-based villain from the original cartoon summons other villains from an old TMNT video game who originally appeared in one of the films. (Spoiler: Tokka and Rahzar from the *TMNT 2: The Secret of the Ooze* film are villains in the arcarde/SNES game *Turtles in Time*. In *Shredder's Revenge*, Tempestra — a villain who escapes a video game in the original cartoon — can summon the arcade versions of Tokka and Rahzar, seemingly from an in-game version of *Turtles in Time*. Radical!) It even plays homage to other classic fighting games:

https://twitter.com/ryugainai/status/1538086616258035713?s=21&t=3WJIA2YSi2IyfkB2Vk-7_A

https://twitter.com/ryugainai/status/1538311850630098944?s=21&t=3WJIA2YSi2IyfkB2Vk-7_A

Of course, just like a classic beat-em-up, *Shredder's Revenge* is designed for co-op play. Unlike the TMNT beat-em-ups of yore, *Shredder's Revenge* allows up to 6-player co-op. As of this review, I've only gone as far as to play 4-player co-op which was utter chaos (in the best possible sense). I cannot imagine what mayhem 6-player co-op brings.

https://twitter.com/genepark/status/1538281074865807360?s=21&t=3WJIA2YSi2IyfkB2Vk-7_A

Perhaps the best part of the Shredder's Revenge experience is the ability to jump in to a random party's game. During stage select, you can pull up a menu of other parties currently playing that level, which characters they're playing as, and how far along they are in the level. At the press of a button, you can jump right into their game and fight alongside their party. The experience mimics the feeling of seeing an empty seat at an original 4-player TMNT arcade cabinet, dropping in a quarter, and joining the other three ~~strangers~~ players in their quest to best the Technodrome.

Some of the voice acting feels like a miss, and the final bosses aren't particularly challengeing. But overall, the game rips!

It's Tight 😤

TMNT: Shredder's Revenge is billed as a throwback/sequel to the original TMNT beat-em-up games. And that's exactly what it is. Full stop. Even with all that's new, the game is extremely focused. While it's jam-packed full of character(s), there isn't an ounce of fat on the game. It sets out to recreate the experience shared by many a '90s mall rat and sticks the landing. 10/10. A perfect video game ass video game. Playing it at age 36 sent me back to playing *Hyperstone Heist* on my family's 13-channel TV on loop. Scrolling through Twitter, I've come across well over a dozen tweets about parents playing through with their children, sharing an arcade experience from a bygone era.

A Little Too Tight?

Immediately after my first playthrough (as Donatello, of course), I was left wanting, and I felt extremely conflicted by this. I'd gotten what I wanted of the game, but I didn't feel wholly satisfied. I didn't want my time as Donatello to be over. It felt like the game was missing something. Side quests. Time trials. More Easter eggs to uncover. But that's not the point of this game.

It's probably not a shock to anyone reading this that video games are packed with optional tasks and mini-games. I'd be quick to point to the recently released *Kirby and the Forgotten Land* as an example of a game that tactfully blends the critical path with side-missions/time-trials, town restoration, power ups, and collectables, but this isn't a new concept. *Super Mario Bros. 3* was full of little mini-games, alternative paths, and secrets. Perhaps it's the overworld map in *Shredder's Revenge* that led my imagination to wonder if there was more to this game than its 16 levels. The routes off of the critical path tease, only leading to fetch-quest status screens from the extra characters discovered during the game's story. There's a list of achievements to complete, but I had tackled 70% of those after my first story run and one online level. Essentially, once you've completed the story, all that's left to do is to play the game again.

It's completely unfair to ask of more from this masterpiece, but nonetheless, here I am wanting. This feeling must be akin to seeing Star Wars (A New Hope) in theaters in 1977. Audiences had just experienced something special, but what next? Surely there's more magic in that galaxy, but the the only way to feel it was to watch the film again.

Turtle Power

Amongst friends and family, I'm considered "The Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtle Guy". Whenever someone is watching one of the movies, stumbles upon an old toy, or catches the annual float during the Macy's Thanksgiving Day Parade, I'm notified... and I love it! I own the original set of action

figures in their boxes, have the entire 1987 cartoon series, rewatch the original movie annually, own movie and video game soundtracks on vinyl, and used to run a TMNT blog.

But truthfully, my fandom only runs as deep as the ink of my (bad) TMNT tattoo. I hadn't rewatched any of the original cartoons since elementary school, rarely if ever dabbled in any new video game releases, and ceased following the franchise once I started investing more time in Zero Counts (and, you know, my career). Yet, I still appreciate every text message and memento sent my way. And I actually do see the turtles as a part of my identity; personas I often reflect upon. But I'd begun to feel detached from the franchise. A lapsed "fan for life".

When *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Shredder's Revenge* was announced, I felt an excitement for the franchise I hadn't felt in a decade. The game looked like everything I'd remembered of those classic games with additional fidelity that brought the art direction to closer parody with the original cartoon. When I learned that the original voice cast of the turtles would be reprising their roles and Splinter, April O'Neil, and Casey Jones would be playable characters, my excitement went through the roof. The mention that there would be plenty of nods to the franchise and Easter eggs from the original cartoon prompted me to begin rewatching the show while feeding my newborn daughter during the middle-of-the-night. (We're through the first two seasons and it holds up!) All this is to say that this game has rekindled my affection for the Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles. Not only is it true to the arcade games my nostalgia so deperately yearns to relive, but I can feel the care, craft, and love that went into the game. All at once, I felt like I was back in the arcade, watching Saturday morning cartoons, and having an overnight pizza party with my best friends. It's one of the most wonderful nostalgia trips I've experienced and it only makes me want more.

Tight 🤙

Ten Years of Zero Counts

July 18, 2022

Categories: General

Today, I stumbled upon the Rands in Repose 20th anniversary post. This struck a chord:

> *Sometime during 2022, this weblog turned twenty years old. No one noticed, including me. While I write for this place actively, other creative endeavors increasingly occupy my free time, including the aforementioned Slack community, the podcast, and the bikes. This means fewer articles per year, but the writing… never stops.*

Sometime during 2022, *this* weblog turned ten years old. No one noticed, including me.

In an fit of self-preservation and soul searching, I doled out the history of Zero Counts below. It's amazing to see what this blog has brought me. It was an effort to break into games journalism. Professionaly, that goal was never realized. But the blog exists, therefore my writings on the games industry also exist. So, in a way, the goal was realized from the start.

As I reflect, recognition might have been a more accurate goal. That sounds a bit shallow, but for an industry I've been wanting to break into since childhood, any semblence of affirmation from industy players or adjacent feels great. And by my own definition, I'd call myself successful. Through will and/or luck, my writing has been linked to by Daring Fireball, Stratechery, How Games are Changing the World, and Into the Aether. Some of my favorite writers, journalists, podcasters, and creators have become Twitter mutals. It's a bit mystifying to me, and it wasn't until I wrote out the history that I connected the dots.

An unintended side-effect of the blog has been professional success. Through Zero Counts, I've learned to write and edit better, kept my eye on the digital publishing landscape, and learned enough web dev to be dangerous. All of which have been applied to my career in tech. I'm doing things profressionally that I wouldn't have dreamed of ten years ago, in large part because of blogging. Crazy.

Writing the history was cathartic for me. Maybe you'll find some insipration in it too.

Thanks to anyone who's ever read or shared a post. Retweeted, liked, or replied. Thanks to John Gruber, Ben Thompson, Zach Kahn, Brendon Bidgely, Stephen Hilger, Colin Campbell, Chris Plante, Pavan Rajam, and so many others. I've never received a penny for my thoughts on Zero Counts, but I'll take a link or retweet any day.

Here's to ten more years of writing, developing, and learning. 🥃

Somewhere around April 13, 2012, I simultaneously fell in love with running, podcasts, and blogging. I had relocated for an intra-company internship away from friends and family. I would bide my time between work and sleep with jogging. I had grown tired of listening to music and decided to give podcasts a fair shake. The Nerdist Network of shows all featured cohesive artwork which enticed me to subscribe to a handful. I immediately locked into the (now defunct and delisted) Indoor Kids, a video game podcast hosted by (then small-time comedian) Kumail Nanjiani, his wife Emily Gordon, and a rotating cast of comedy and industry guests. I was smitten. Their mature conversations about video games came off as novel and inspired me to explore my own thoughts on games.

During the internship, I'd purchased an Xbox 360 and *Skyrim* to pass the time. I quickly realized I was chasing more side-quests than focusing on the main objective. I drew a corollary to my own life, wrote my first post "Finding the Rails", and sent a copy to Kumail and Emily. And Emily wrote back! This was a powerful moment. My writing felt validated and these podcasters felt real.

2012–2014

My post to Kumail and Emily wasn't my first writing. I had been writing music reviews, video game reviews, and musings at TheStarrList since 2011. But after Emily's response and with the extra alone time during my internship, I challenged myself to write more often. And I found writing through the lens of video games eased the process.

In an effort to increase readership, I cross-posted my writing on an IGN blog figuring there would be overlap between IGN readers and my gaming focused pieces. On January 29, 2013, I was highlighted in the Community Spotlight on IGN's homepage — "One of the best up and coming bloggers on IGN, Kylestarr writes some of the best non-gaming blogs in our community." Like Emily's response before it, and as a long time fan of IGN, this accolade made my head spin and sent me into overdrive.

I began writing multiple posts a week, squeezing the most fleeting thoughts for tiny morsels of content. I started pushing myself to research. I wanted to contribute back to the video game industry I so enjoyed reading about. Genre/Gender Breakdowns for 2013 and 2014 found traction with IGN reporters. John Gruber's Daring Fireball appeared on my radar prompting me to write link blog style. Polygon.com also became a steady read for me and inspired my writing, design, and content platform curiosity (i.e. Chorus). TheStarrList was growing beyond musings and into an industry and culturally focused blog. It needed to evolve.

INTERLUDE

As fate would have it, it was also around this time that I found myself joining the podcasts industry. After my internship, I'd struggled for more than a year to find the next step in my career journey. However, the inspiration I'd had from The Indoor Kids never left. I'd launched my own podcast focused on my friends' journeys into their dream jobs. Creating a podcast was harder than I thought it ought to be. I happened upon a job listening as a podcast content producer and landed the gig on my background in customer service, my experience launching a podcast, and my misgivings about the barrier to entry. This will serve me in the future...

2014–2020

In a desire to own my content, I took blogging beyond the writing itself and decided to learn the basics of web development. While TheStarrList lived on Wordpress.com, I wanted push beyond its templated limits. With Wordpress.org, I was able to customize the HTML, CSS, and PHP. This allowed me to format my link blogs in a way I found intuitive and attractive.

Seeing as my content was moving in an industry and culture focused direction, I felt a rebrand was also in order. I chose "The State of Gaming". "State" was play on "government", meant to focus on aspects outside of the games themselves — culture, social, education, health, business... government.

This was the lens that Kumail and Emily used for Indoor Kids and inspired me to write in the first place.

With this new format, I felt like I was making active contributions to video game journalism. In doing so, I began analyzing video game companies' business tactics. In "Hail Mario", I took a stab at understanding Nintendo's *Mario Kart 8* release strategy. To my shock, the post was picked up by Daring Fireball. Views on this post shot through the roof. It was also with the Daring Fireball link that I began to meet new acquaintances on Twitter. Folks like Zach Kahn (then at Vox Media), Into the Aether's Brendon Bigley, Stratechery's Ben Thompson. There was a sense that connecting with the media world could become a reality.

But with all of this, I immediately hated the name and look of "The State of Gaming". I needed something fresh, personal, and unique. Not a month later, I rebranded again.

Zero Counts

I still have no idea what "Daring Fireball" means, but it seems personal and is certainly unique. I landed on Zero Counts as a homage to a phrase my step-brother and I would use to describe video games that used x0 to signify "zero lives left". In the early days of gaming, and probably still today, there was a discrepancy between "x1", meaning you're on your last life, and "x0". Finding out a game allowed one more chance at victory when you reached x0 was pure elation. "Zero counts!" we would exclaim.

As for the design, I used blue, white, and black as an homage to Mega Man. My first memory was of Mega Man 2, so it felt appropriate. Personal.

Relaunching The State of Gaming as Zero Counts felt like a sea change in the blog. I would become less prolific, but more comfortable.

INTERLUDE

Work also began to heat up. My passion for online journalism and web development that Zero Counts enabled helped find me on the launch team of a major news aggregation service. This allowed me to peek behind the curtain of web development and CMSes as well as traveling the globe assisting various partners and heroes. Meeting folks like Polygon's then Editor-in-chief Chris Grant (thanks Zach!), Rene Ritchie, Steven Aquino, and Federico Viticci was a dream come true.

2020–Today

The last big change to Zero Counts came slowly. After a few years of working on the news aggregation service, I jumped to managing a team of content producers, editors, and web developers. Professionally, I not only grew my skills in people management, but furthered my web development skills. I applied things I'd learned from Zero Counts like SEO, CI/CD platforms, and front-end dev to my day-to-day.

It was in this role that I came across GatsbyJS. I won't rehash my "From Wordpress to Gatsby" post, but the short of it is that I learned a bit of React and transitioned this blog to a static-site. It was a

huge performance win and allows me to manage the content via GitHub from any of my devices, free of a CMS.

All this is to say that while my blogging has cooled down, Zero Counts itself has been a transformative vehicle. It's a hobby that has acted as a platform for my career. I was inspired to create it from a podcast. I then took a job in the podcast industry. I became intrigued by digital publications, began to understand web development, moved into self-hosting, and eventually took a job in the online news media space. I've taken my experience running this blog into my current role where I can speak to web standards and best practices. When I was writing more often, I became a better writer and editor. I've met a good handful of idols and created some lasting friendships. And while I've always had a desire to work professionally in the video games industry, Zero Counts has helped me learn more about it — highlighting its strengths and calling out its shortcomings. It's made me feel like I've made meaningful contributions to the space.

Nova198Nine

September 5, 2022



I was humbled when NovaNine asked for a custom Game Boy mod to commemorate their debut album. To fit the record's '80s synthwave aesthetic, NovaNine and I settled on the original Game Boy (DMG) from '89 as the base.

This was my first mod with LED backlit buttons. I wanted to highlight the album cover's glowing retrowave sun. Luckily, I was able to find some of Natalie the Nerd's awesome DMG LED flex boards — custom flexible PCB boards with perfectly placed LED lights. Paired with a blue LED power light, this Game Boy vibes like NovaNine.

Nova198Nine includes:

- FunnyPlaying DMG Retro Pixel IPS LCD Kit
- FunnyPlaying Game Boy Housing and Button combo
- FunnyPlaying DMG speaker
- FunnyPlaying GB DMG Buttons
- Lab Fifteen clear silicone button pads
- FunnyPlaying DMG Retro Pixel IPS glass lens
- Pink DMG LED Board by Natalie the Nerd
- Blue 0603 SMD ultra bright power LED from Lighthouse LEDs

Note: In DMGs, the new display requires more power than the original display, thus increasing the noise floor. Buzzing from the speaker is a normal side effect.

Stratechery: Consoles and Competition

December 20, 2022

Categories: Business

Ben Thompson:

> *Forty years of context may seem like overkill when it comes to examining the FTC's attempt to block Microsoft's acquisition of Activision, but I think it is essential for multiple reasons.*
>
> *First, the video game market has proven to be extremely dynamic, particularly in terms of 3rd-party developers:*
>
> - *Atari was vertically integrated*
> - *Nintendo grew the market with strict control of 3rd-party developers*
> - *Sony took over the market by catering to 3rd-party developers and differentiating on hardware*
> - *Xbox's best generation leaned into increased commodification and ease-of-development*
> - *Sony retook the lead by leaning back into vertical integration*
>
> *That is quite the round trip, and it's worth pointing out that attempting to freeze the market in its current iteration at any point over the last forty years would have foreclosed future changes.*

If I rely on Ben Thompson for one thing, it's to distill core principles, milestones, and maneuvers from the complexities of business history into simple patterns and through lines. This piece is a shining example.

Thompson's argument aside, "Consoles and Competition" serves as a succinct and beautiful history of the video game business.

Marvel Snap's Bedlam Highlights Mario Kart's Balance

December 21, 2022

Categories: Design

The Besties Podcast discussing Marvel Snap during their Game of the Year bracket:

> ***Justin McElroy****: Recently, I've found the Locations that will pop up are so wild and random and significant that it sort of makes all your deck building and even the playing of the match irrelevant. I'm running into more and more areas like that. I had the planet "Ego" Location pop-up and that just plays all your cards for you. Like, you don't even play anymore. And there's a lot of Locations like that, where it's so wild that it doesn't matter what I've got in my deck — the match is already over.*
>
> ***Griffin McElroy****: There was a recent Location that had you draw three cards then it destroyed the rest of your hand. I run a deck based around a handful of cards that if I don't draw them, that's it. If that was the first Location on the very first round of the game, I would say, "welp, I'm gonna lose, so bye." And the game's not particularly fun when someone bails out after a round or two. It completely gets rid of the whole Snapping-wager mechanic, which is so brilliant because it forces you to slow-play and bluff sometimes, which are mechanics that haven't really been featured in a trading card game before. But it's rendered completely void by these Locations that pretty much turn it into a roll of the dice.*

Marvel Snap was a saving grace when rocking my infant daughter back to sleep after middle-of-the-night feedings. I could squeeze in five or so games due to its quick-start gameplay, small playfield, six round limit, and low stakes. It's the perfect pick-up and play mobile experience. (Honestly, the 10s splash screen is the most tedious part.)

When the game first launched, I felt like I was able to run quick math to strategize the most opportune plays, which led to informed Snaps, the wagering mechanic Griffin mentions above. But as time went on, the Locations that alter the playfield with unique rules became so batshit insane that I felt like I could no longer track how a particular play would net out. I might increase Iron Man's power 20-fold and obliterate my enemy's cards or somehow sabotage myself by accidentally negating my cards' powers, destroying my cards, or sending my cards to my enemy. Sometimes, a combination of all of the above would be triggered.

Hearing The Besties discuss the chaotic turn *Marvel Snap*'s design has taken initially had me drawing parallels to *Mario Kart*'s "anyone's game" design. But the more I think about it, the more I believe *Marvel Snap*'s wild and seemingly unpredictable behavior highlights the balance and restraint designed into *Mario Kart*.

Monique Judge: ‘Bring back personal blogging’

December 31, 2022

Categories: Media

Monique Judge, writing for The Verge:

> *If what is happening on Twitter hasn’t demonstrated it, our relationship with these social media platforms is tenuous at best. The thing we are using to build our popularity today could very well be destroyed and disappear from the internet tomorrow, and then what?*
>
> *What happens to all the content you have created? Where will the archive of all your funny memes and jokes be? What is going to happen to all those selfies you felt cute in but didn’t delete later?*
>
> *The answer is we don’t know because we don’t control Twitter (or Facebook or Instagram or Snapchat or TikTok). If one of these companies decided to shut down their service permanently, there would be nothing we could do about it.*
>
> *Owning your content and controlling your platform is essential, and having a personal blog is a great way to do that.*

This blog started out on the managed platform Wordpress.com. Wanting to own my own content, I spun up a new self-hosted Wordpress.org site called The State of Gaming (tsogaming.com) which would eventually become Zero Counts. In 2020, I migrated from Wordpress to Gatsby due to (amongst other things) a strong desire to get my content out of a database, into Markdown files, and stored in remote and local repositories, thus backed up via Time Machine, Drobo, Backblaze, iCloud, etc. Zero Counts and my career as a writer may not go anywhere, but it's important for me to own, catalog, and control my work.

I genuinely appreciate the sentiment of Judge's piece — I want to invest much more time blogging on Zero Counts in 2023 — but I struggle to understand how personal blogging crosses the chasms of connection, discoverability, and elevation. Perhaps surfing the web is a muscle I haven't exercised for over a decade thanks to Big Algorithm, but I'm not exactly sure where to start with finding new blogs and outlets. Twitter was my primary source for new and interesting voices through retweets from my favorite writers and outlets. I think Mastodon has become my go-to community, but I don't find myself connected to the zeitgeist, finding new content, or even engaging with my favorite creators on the network due to the lack of an algorithm. And that's OK. It's actually nice! I just hope I can find a way to find and consume the work old favorites as well as new and diverse voices.

I found Judge's post via my RSS reader Reeder, so that's a start.

My Favorite Things of 2022

January 1, 2023

Categories: General

My daughter!

Excuse my lack of preamble, but she is without a doubt my most favorite part of 2022.

It's very hard to describe the joy that courses through my entire mind, body, and soul every time I see her. I've wanted to be a father for as long as I can remember. But hours before she was due, I had this paralyzing fear that some damaged part of my brain would about-face and reject the pride of parenthood. Thankfully, I was very wrong. The second I heard her cry, my heart burst. It was one of the greatest moments of my life, and things only got better. I discovered an incredible force of nature. Instinct took over. I immediately knew exactly how to care for her; how to protect her. And not only her, but my wife who had just endured the incredibly invasive and major surgery of Caesarean section — common, yes, but it will lay out strongest person.

Caring for both my wife and daughter

For the three days we spent in the hospital, I was on constant watch for my family. The second my daughter cried for food, I was awake and ready. Every moment my wife asked for help out of bed or for a breakfast burrito, I was there. I yearned to support and care.

Prior to leaving for the hospital, I had packed my bag with books and video games, none of which I touched post-operation. I found the experience of "being there" riveting. It was the most present I've felt in a long time and I'll cherish it for as long as I'm able.

Now, onto the "things"...

(Favorite) Games of the Year

1. *Loco Looper* — A crafty iOS puzzle game built with Metal, Swift, and SwiftUI. It lulls the player into a sense of calm with very simple 6x6 railroad crafting levels, but eventually turns into an incredibly challenging puzzler, always leaving one piece to frustrate one to their wits end. Continuing the theme of my daughter, I have extremely fond memories working through Loco Looper while rocking her to sleep every 2-3 hours for weeks at a time. Hail portrait single-handed mobile games!
2. *Tunic* — (I'm listening to the soundtrack as I write this. What a joy!) An homage to early 2D Zelda titles, printed game manuals (in foreign languages), and an unparalleled sense of discovery. I started this game on an M1 Mac and finished on Steam Deck — a joy on both. Do yourself a favor and turn on No Fail Mode. The combat doesn't do its brilliant experience of discovery any favors.
3. *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Shredder's Revenge* — I won't go on too much here. Read my review. All I can say is that *TMNT: Shredder's Revenge* is a damn near perfect brawler with wonderful nods to both the original TMNT cartoon as well as the 8- and 16-bit era of TMNT video games.

4. *Kirby and the Forgotten Land* — I have not completed *Kirby and the Forgotten Land*, but that doesn't mean it's any less charming or impressive. For a Kirby game, I was not expecting something as rich and detailed as this. It demos poorly, so just move ahead with the purchase. You won't regret it.
5. *Elden Ring*? — I didn't play many games from 2022 in 2022, but I did pick up *Elden Ring* last week. In the 3–4 hours I've played, this game is incredible. I hate the lack of explanation about the controls, menus, items, builds, etc., and I've avoided any enemy more difficult than two swipes of a sword, but the world, fidelity, animation, and music are jaw dropping. This is my chill game of 2022. I'm sure that will change when I actually start playing in 2023.

Mastodon

For nearly 15 years, I was a heavy Twitter user. I made connections with many people I felt I had no business connecting with, found my tribe, and boosted my blog's reach through some fortunate retweets and endorsements. And I tweeted *a lot*. But the act of tweeting began to feel more like an addiction and ephemeral than something of value. It was far from the feeling I get when I write a blog post, which was becoming fewer and fewer by the year. Once Elon Musk took ownership of Twitter, I bolted. I deleted all of my tweets, more or less bid adieu to the platform, and leaned into the Mastodon account I created in 2018. And it feels fantastic.

Since November 13, 2022, I've been monitoring my social media Screen Time:


Graph of social media time tracked by iOS Screen Time

I find these results shocking. Not only have I reduced my overall social media usage, but dropping Twitter was much easier than I thought it would be thanks to a wide adoption of Mastodon from many folks in the communities I take part in.

While my time engaging with Mastodon is on the rise, that's not due to an algorithm. It genuinely feels like a healthier, friendlier social-network. And the decentralized nature means my content won't just disappear.

In small part, I owe Musk thanks in prompting me to have a healthier relationship with social media. In large part, I owe Mastodon for being there when the rug of a centralized platform was pulled out from under its users. A brilliant technology at the right time.

If you're unfamiliar with Mastodon or think it might be too complex, check out Brendon Bigley's "How to Use Mastodon" explainer at his blog, Wavelengths.

Analogue Pocket Cores

I received my Analogue Pocket in 2021 and loved it then. But in 2022, its firmware was updated to unlock the FPGA technology inside to developers. Through this, multiple open-source "cores" have been released for the device including cores for NES, SNES, Genesis, Game Boy, Game Boy Color, and Game Boy Advance, amongst others.

These cores have changed my relationship with emulation and 8- and 16-bit retro gaming in general. Being able to hardware emulate my catalog of NES, SNES, and Genesis games and take them on the go is a childhood dream realized. In the early to mid '90s, the best we could get was a Game Boy or

Game Gear with slimmed down games, grayscale graphics, and/or poor battery life. Honestly, most of those experiences were great, but they paled in comparison *Super Mario Bros. 3* on the NES, *The Legend of Zelda: A Link to the Past* on the SNES, or *Sonic 2* on the Genesis. We just wanted to carry those experiences in our back pocket. And now we can. At a hardware level. The future.

Steam Deck

I've been missing out on PC gaming for some time. With the Steam Deck, I can finally enjoy classics like *Half-Life 2*, *Halo*, *Mass Effect*, etc., etc. On top of that, the ease of emulation through the Steam Deck is remarkable. While the emulation is not operating at a hardware level like the aforementioned Analogue Pocket, I am able to quickly load-up 3D favorites from PS2, PS3, GameCube, Wii, and many other consoles of yore. The Steam Deck is a wonderful companion to my Analogue Pocket, a great current-gen console (in handheld form!), and a hopeful glimpse into the future of handheld gaming.

Music

New Releases

- Band of Horses - “Things Are Great” — A return to form for pop/party rock indie mainstays.
- Momma - “Household Name” — '90s era alternative wrapped up in a Gen-Z mindset.
- Dawes - “Misadventures of Doomscroller” - Throw Elvis Costello, The Greatful Dead, The Band, and a dash of Elton John into a blender.
- LIES - “Camera Chimera EP” — One half of American Football picks up where LP3 left off.
- The Mars Volta - “s/t” - Modern prog-rock legends return with a pivot into high-pop.
- mitch murder - “Selection 6” — Another collection of b-sides and rarties by the '80s cheese synthwave mastermind.

Vinyls

- Further Seems Forever — "The Moon Is Down" 20th Anniversary Deluxe Box Set
- Thursday - "Full Collapse" 21st Anniversary Edition (3-10" Box Set)
- Sigur Rós - ( ) 20th anniversary edition - Signed Deluxe Box Set

Something Dissonant

January 2, 2023

Categories: Media

David Yee, posting on Mastodon:

> *Something dissonant about the way that my Twitter feed is currently fully in desperation over the terrifying critical injury of Damar Hamlin, a 24-year-old football player, on a field in Cincinnati—a communally-experienced condemnation of the NFL—and how my feed here is… just not? I want to leave that place with an urgency, but the transition is teaching me a lot about network effects and the nuances of specific communities and the intention of spaces and I mostly just want that kid to be okay.*

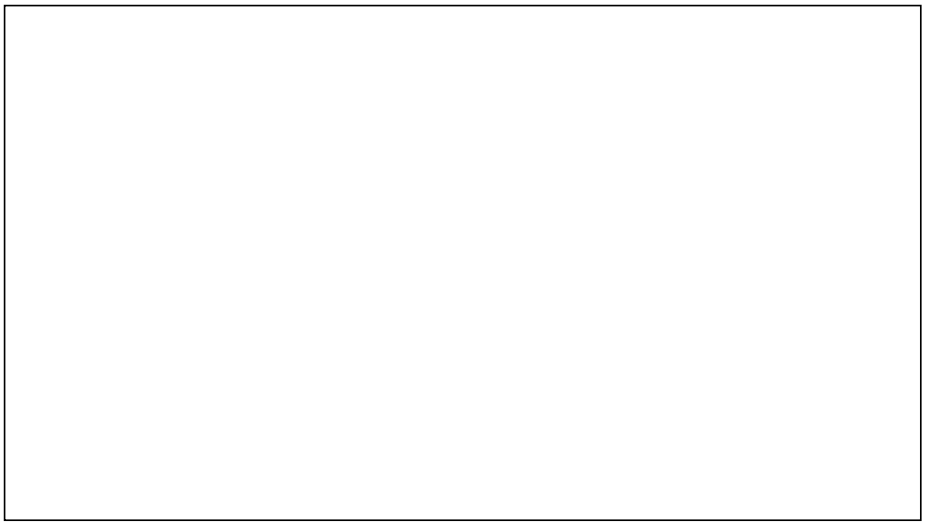
My heart goes out to Hamlin and his family. The footage is ghastly.

Had I not followed Yee on Mastodon from Twitter, I fear I would have no idea about this heartbreaking injury in such a timely and communial manner. I don't follow sports much, and seemingly I don't follow many sports enthusiasts on Mastodon. For as much as I praise Mastodon's tech and positivity, the insight into periphery or even foreign communities through Twitter's algorithm, its large userbase, and (dare I say) its "town square" ethos was a huge draw for me. I felt more informed about topical stories on Twitter than I do on Mastodon. This is a chilling insight from Yee.

MegaMan X: Corrupted

January 4, 2023

Categories: General



This is a seriously impressive fan-made Mega Man project. Gorgeous Mega Man X art. Multiple missions. Metroidvania style level design. And incredible soundtrack by Dominic Nimark. (I hear fan-made Mega Man projects are typically high caliber.)

Perhaps foolish, but I find it inspiring when creators invest in their fandoms to breath new life into beloved franchises. I don't know if or how projects like this survive, but I'm certainly rooting for it. Worst case, I hope this catches the attention of Capcom and these folks get picked up for their talents.

Project Leonardo for PlayStation 5

January 4, 2023

Categories: Accessibility



Playstation.Blog:

> *Through conversations with accessibility experts and incredible organizations like AbleGamers, SpecialEffect and Stack Up, we've designed a highly configurable controller that works in tandem with many third-party accessibility accessories and integrates with the PS5 console to open up new ways of gaming. It is built to address common challenges faced by many players with limited motor control, including difficulty holding a controller for long periods, accurately pressing small clusters of buttons or triggers, or positioning thumbs and fingers optimally on a standard controller.*

This is the most exciting news I've seen out of CES this year.

Project Leonardo comes nearly five years after the Xbox Adaptive Controller was announced, but much better late than never. And coming in at a distant second means Sony has surely incorporated a lot of feedback about the Xbox Adaptive Controller into the design of Project Leonardo.

> *Project Leonardo can be used as a standalone controller or paired with additional Project Leonardo or DualSense wireless controllers. Up to two Project Leonardo controllers and one DualSense wireless controller can be used together as a single virtual controller, allowing players to mix and match devices to fit their particular gameplay needs, or to play collaboratively with others.*
>
> *For example, players can augment their DualSense controller with a Project Leonardo controller or use two Project Leonardo controllers on their own. A friend or family member can also assist by helping to control the player's game character with a DualSense controller or a second Project Leonardo controller. The controllers can be dynamically turned on or off and used in any combination.*

The design of Project Leonardo is radically different from the Xbox Adaptive Controller. The sheer fact that hardware itself is highly customizable, from physical button layout to analog stick distance and size, let alone the ability to map buttons together and pair this device with a DualSense for individual comfort or collaborative, assistive needs, the combinations are seemingly endless. I'd be stunned if some curb cut effects don't come out of all of this flexibility.

So Morimoto, Designer, Sony Interactive Entertainment:

> *"Because players can customize Project Leonardo according to their needs, there is no one 'right' form factor. We want to empower them to create their own configurations. The controller can also flexibly accept combinations of accessibility accessories to create a unique aesthetic. I am excited that the design will be completed through collaboration with players rather than presenting them with a single form factor."*

Competition fuels innovation, and the accessibility space can never receive enough innovation. I'm eager to see the informed reception and comparisons between Project Leonardo and the Xbox

Adaptive Controller, and how accessibility in gaming evolves from here.

Stephen Totilo: ‘Gaming takes over everything’

January 5, 2023

Categories: Business, Media

Stephen Totilo, Axios:

> *Video games will move to the center of the entertainment and pop-culture universe next year.*
>
> ***Why it matters**: Streaming services, Hollywood studios, tech giants — even the Saudi government — are racing to capitalize on gaming's vast and ever-expanding popularity, and its lucrative intellectual property.*
>
> *...*
>
> ***Between the lines**: This is what happens when a subculture has been deepening its roots for a half-century.*
>
> - *Many of the first kids who grew up with gaming become gamer parents, ready to pass gaming to the new generation.*
> - *Power takes notice. Outside elites elbow in.*
> - *Inside, young workers and players look around and see their once-rebellious pastime as an establishment that needs to be challenged.*
>
> ***The bottom line**: From World of Warcraft to Wordle, it's a game-lover's world.*

I'd been thinking a lot about why my blogging on Zero Counts has steadily slowed down. A lot of it has to do with the a busier work-life. Some of it has to do with my duties as a new parent. But I can't help to think that it's simply harder to have unique takes on games and the games industry, and for good reason. Not only has the mainstream popularity of gaming skyrocketed, but so too has solid coverage from mainstream media — Totilo (formerly of Kotaku) writing for Axios as an example. I touched on this one year ago in 'NYT: Making Video Game History'.

The odd bits of coverage I found in mainstream media was an inspiration for Zero Counts. I captured what I could to elevate said pieces, but I didn't feel the gaming space was being covered in a way I wanted to see. I'm no business expert, but I did what I could to fill the gap. Now video game coverage from top-tier veteran games journalists, critics, and analysts is ubiquitous at major media outlets. Meanwhile, traditionally games focused outlets seem to be leaning into the surrounding media (movies, tv, anime, comics, conventions, etc.) more than ever, which makes sense seeing that media at large is incorporating more and video game IP into it's catalog.

None of this is a bad thing. In fact, quite the opposite. I love how big this hobby of mine has become. It's important. It influences so much of the world around us from technology to entertainment to education to culture to art, and it's not getting smaller. There is obviously a huge dark-side to Big Business — "elites elbow in" creating "an establishment that needs to be challenged" — I'm just glad (read "hope") press coverage has grown to a level to hold it accountable.

Or perhaps this new father who grew up with gaming is just happy to see the medium proliferate, is optimistic about the new generation, and was giddy to see this piece published on his birthday.

Pentiment in The New York Times

January 7, 2023

Categories: General

Gilbert Cruz in The New York Times: The Morning newsletter:

> *The world of video games is large indeed. Last year, it encompassed difficult open-world dark fantasy titles like "Elden Ring" (for many, the game of 2022), surprisingly Zen experiences like "PowerWash Simulator" and this one, which I started just before the holidays and am slowly making my way through. "Pentiment" is set in 16th-century Bavaria, and you play as a manuscript illuminator who must eventually investigate a murder. (It sells itself, right?) With a look that tries to approximate medieval art styles, this is a largely text-driven game that becomes more engrossing the longer you play it.*

In 2018, *Pentiment* developers Obsidian Entertainment were acquired by Microsoft, so it doesn't seem fair to call recognition by a widely circulated mainstream newsletter "indie love". But I think it's fair to say *Pentiment* is a niche game. Within games media, it's been widely discussed/praised — immaculate art design and impressive moral system — but it doesn't seem like a title that would typically garner such placement. "Books-level boring" (in a good way) per The Besties.

I have yet to play *Pentiment*, but the more I hear about it, the more I'm itching to invest in it (after the three books on my nightstand). Very cool placement from The New York Times. Congrats, Obsidian.

Nintendo Nintendos

January 10, 2023

Categories: Design

Jeff Cannata and Christian Spicer hypothesizing on Nintendo's next console during their "Bold" and "Cool Ranch" predictions of 2023:

> ***Jeff Cannata****: Your number 3 "Cool Ranch" prediction…*
>
> ***Christian Spicer****: The next mainline Nintendo console — I don't know if we're going to hear about it this year — but it's portable also. I don't think it's going to be the Switch 2, but I think they're gone from having a discrete home console and there's no looking back on portability. I don't think they're going to have a separate "portable" and a separate "home" [console]. From this point for the foreseeable future, the next Nintendo console is also a portable of some form or fashion.*
>
> ***JC****: Why isn't this you predicting Switch 2?*
>
> ***CS****: 'Cause Nintendo's Nintendo. I don't know if it's going to be Switch 2.*
>
> ***JC****: You think it's going to be like a Game Boy?*
>
> ***CS****: Or a Steam Deck? I dunno.*
>
> ***JC****: I mean, Switch is a Steam Deck, basically.*
>
> ***CS****: I don't know if there's money in that name. You already can't "switch" with the Switch Lite.*
>
> *I was surrounded by nieces and nephews at the end of last year and here in 2023, and they almost all refer to it as Nintendo. "I wanna play my Nintendo. Where's my Nintendo?"*
>
> ***JC****: But the Switch has sold 100M consoles, or whatever it is…*
>
> ***CS****: It has! But so did the Wii. And the Wii U… was meh. But Nintendo is not afraid to just name things. Maybe Super Switch?*
>
> ***JC****: Yeah, Super Switch could be. A lot of people have speculated on that.*
>
> *The thing I don't understand about why you think this is "Cool Ranch" is that I feel like it's a no brainer that to me that they're in the handheld place now. You can't go back from Switch to now having, like, a GameCube. It can't just be a home console anymore. I feel like that's a no brainer.*
>
> ***CS****: I wonder if they know how many people play docked vs. handheld? I feel like when I would talk about the console for years on this show, how I was exclusively handheld mode, you and so many people would say, "it hurts my hands. I got these grips and now I can use it," or "I only use it docked and you gotta get a Pro Controller." Maybe I haven't been reading the tea leaves, but to me as a big handheld proponent — and I think 2022 having been the Year of the Handheld, in a lot of ways — I think that's what will push this into happening. I think when the Switch launched, I don't know if Nintendo was like, "yeah, we're going all in on one handheld, one thing pushing forward." I think the progress of*

> *mobile chips has made this a reality that it wasn't before. That's why I feel like we're still living in that "Cool Ranch" world. Nintendo Nintendos.*
>
> ***JC**: I went back and forth. I really struggled. For the longest time I had one of my predictions being Switch 2, or Switch Pro, or Super Switch, or whatever they're going to call it. Part of me was like, it definitely gets announced this year; it definitely doesn't get announced at all this year... I went back and forth. It's too hard for me to predict because I feel like Nintendo could just wait another year at this point. I literally wrote down a "Bold" prediction of "Pikmin 4 is the last big hoorah for the original Switch; the Switch 2 is coming in 2024". I feel like whatever it is, it has to be the next extension of the Switch. The Switch is become the de facto Nintendo console.*

I belabor the above because I find it hilarious in context with my and Scott Taylor's belaboring of the rumored Nintendo NX console back in 2016 on the Ported podcast:

> ***Scott Taylor**: For people like you and I — the older generation, who have the luxury of affording and owning multiple different platforms — how great would it be if I could start on my Wii U — OK I've gotta catch my plane — then pick up on my 3DS. That would be a rad experience!*
>
> ***Kyle Starr**: That's the dream, right?*
>
> ***ST**: Absolutely! And I think that alone would be my incentive to buy a 3DS. That I could take my desktop experience (if you will) and turn it into a mobile experience. That would be a huge win. That would be really, really great to see in the future. I do think that kind of thing is making its way into the industry. I do think we're going to see more and more of that. For years, there was a rumor of a mobile Xbox, which obviously never came to light. I do love the idea of starting in Location A and picking up in Location B.*
>
> ***KS**: Rumor of the Nintendo NX — their next console — is that it's achieved that dream: one console, multiple places. I don't know how... I've been trying to comprehend what that would be like; trying to fathom how that would work, to have a console and mobile experience. One and the same, and not totally break the bank and give you two consoles when you buy the thing. But who know? We'll see. Nintendo's the crazy toy maker.*
>
> ***ST**: They are, but I don't know if I have faith in them to be the one that innovates and really disrupts the market.*
>
> ***KS**: But they did it with Wii.*
>
> ***ST**: But they didn't though, right? To this today, it doesn't matter. Nobody else is doing it. Xbox 360 never picked [motion controls] enough so that they said, "that's a disrupter; we have to do it."*
>
> ***KS**: They went into Kinect which was sort of motion control.*
>
> ***ST**: I don't want to get started on Kinect. Kinect is a joke. Kinect shouldn't exist because they don't even believe in that product.*
>
> ***KS**: But they tried.*

***ST**: They innovated in their own division, I think. They innovated in their little avenue. It was innovative. I'm not saying it wasn't innovative, I'm just saying it wasn't disruptive. It didn't change the rest of the market. I don't know if I have faith in Nintendo to disrupt the market. I have faith in them to innovate, but are their innovations — this is going to sound silly — for the sake of innovating? They can't compete on a CPU level. They can't compete on a GPU level. So what do they do? They create some sort of "gimmick".*

If you remember, Wii was huge. It was monster. It was sold out Monday through Sunday. For months, you couldn't get it. It was definitely something that worked, but I don't know if I'd put my money on Nintendo to be the ones to innovate and disrupt the market.

***KS**: That's a good point. There's a difference between innovation and disruption. If you look at gaming right now, motion controls had their place and then they were gone. You don't talk about motion controls anymore, except in the instance of VR which is way to early to talk about. But I do think that Nintendo's claim to fame truly is innovation. The NES alone was innovative in the sense that they had a great marketing strategy; they had this certification process for games ensuring that when you bought a game it was going to be certified that it's a good game to combat the crash that happened before that (which was before my time, but I've read enough about it to understand that). The SNES was more of a power horse. Nintendo 64 was first to really understand the 3D space, coming out with games like Super Mario 64 and Ocarina of Time and teach people what it means to play a video game in a 3D space. And then the GameCube which was, in my opinion, kind of a weird move — another "let's make this thing a bit more powerful".*

***ST**: That was them trying to get into the disc space to compete with PlayStation and Xbox. People loved the GameCubes. There are people who would absolutely defend GameCube as one of the best consoles that Nintendo put out. I never owned it. It never did anything for me.*

I would say they innovate, but they don't disrupt in terms of hardware. In terms of software, they innovate and disrupt. To your point, 3D worlds is a huge one.

***KS**: Then there was the Wii, which obviously innovated in the space of motion controls. Everybody thought that was the future. For a while there, it felt like that was the disruption point. Xbox followed with Kinect with their own kind of motion controlled thing. Sony came out with the Move, which flopped. And that was the end of the motion control space.*

Then when PlayStation and Xbox went to create their bigger, better hardware, Nintendo decided to take another route and try something new again with the Wii U. It is an innovative platform. I love the experience of it. I think it was poorly marketed. That was the biggest downside of that console.

***ST**: The name itself is confusing for users. "What do I do with that? Is it an expansion? Is it a little bit better? It is a completely different system?" As a customer who's about to give you $300-400, I don't want to have those questions in my mind. I want to know that this is a brand new system. I want to know this is brand new hardware. I want to know this is a brand new experience that I'm about to... experience. Those kinds of questions are going to kill you. And it killed them.*

> ***KS**: One Christmas, I watched my aunt gift my little cousin a Wii U game. He opened it up and freaks out. He didn't have a Wii U. He had a Wii. She had no idea. She didn't understand. If you're in the space, you're going to know. I don't put the fault on her. I put the fault on Nintendo because that marketing was just awful. Needless to say, he had a fit and she was bummed out. It was terrible.*
>
> ***ST**: So you could say Nintendo ruined Christmas for a lot of kids.*
>
> ***KS**: I'm sure it did, and I was there to witness at least one of those kids.*
>
> *Anyway, I think the NX... we have to remember that Nintendo has a ton of cash in the bank from the Wii. They have room to innovate. Their shareholders are probably pushing them in one direction — they obviously want them to compete in the space. But Nintendo has their own priorities with innovation. I think what we're going to see with the NX is something in between. It's going to be an innovative platform, but I think they do understand that they need to compete in the power playing experience which is what Xbox One and PS4 are doing. They have these insanely powerful consoles. Getting tons of third-parties on-board. Nintendo's going to be at a cross-roads with what they internally want to do and what the shareholders want them to do. I don't think they're keen on third-parties. They love their own experiences. But they've got to branch out a little bit more. If they can't come up with a killer console on their own terms with their own first-party content, then they have to expand a little bit.*
>
> *So, I'm super curious about the NX. Again, this all stems from that dream of having the same experience in multiple places. Whether it's on your TV or on a handheld device.*

While I'd love to edit/add/update what was said in the above episode of Ported — (OK, just one: motion controls disupted camera/aiming mechanics with gyro enchancements) — the length of this post is the point. Speculation of what Nintendo will do next are some of the most fun conversations to have in gaming. That's because Nintendo is more than just an innovator; they are an inventor. They garner the same secrecy and mystique as Apple, but rather than perfecting existing experiences, Nintendo is in the business of changing the game, pun half-intended.

What will Nintendo do next? Who knows. I couldn't wrap my head around the NX before the Switch was announced. In hindsight, Wii U was very telling of where Nintendo would go with the Switch — scrap the dual-screen experience and lean into taking games off of your TV screen and into your hands. The writing was on the wall. The Switch has disrupted console design and the direction of gaming. You can see it not only in the Steam Deck, but the promise of cloud gaming — taking console (or greater) experiences on the go.

But where does Nintendo go after the Switch? Where is the writing? Where is the wall? Any guess is wild or "Cool Ranch", in my opinion. The crazy toy maker remains illusive. Nintendo Nintendos.

'I Just Took the One with the Best Story'

January 18, 2023

Categories: Design

Alex Barasch detailing the origins of HBO's The Last of Us for The New Yorker:

> *When Druckmann expressed confidence that the show "will be the best, most authentic game adaptation," Mazin said, "That's not the highest bar in the world." He went on, "I cheated—I just took the one with the best story. Like, I love Assassin's Creed. But when they announced that they were gonna make it as a movie I was, like, I don't know how! Because the joy of it is the gameplay. The story is impenetrable."*

The other day, a close friend of mine sent me a rumor that an animated Legend of Zelda movie is in development by Illumination, the studio responsible for the upcoming Super Mario Bros. animated film. My quick rely was something to the effect of pure agency not translating to film. I.e. Link has (almost) always been a silent protagonist. Unless they give him a voice, I don't understand how the movie is compelling. The world, characters, and music of Zelda are charming and iconic, but refined puzzle solving and discovery — agency — are what makes Zelda games great.

Furthermore, agency is what makes games special. Somewhat shamefully, I only recently came to understand this thanks to C. Thi Nguyen's book/thesis "Games: Agency as Art". After decades of playing video games in wonder, asking myself why these things and this industry captivate me so, telling myself that they are the evolution of story and immersion, truthfully it comes down to agency — I get to play a part in a universe whether it's a pre-determined story on rails or a completely open world that I get to explore on my own.

As for *The Last of Us*, the game itself created such a fervor because there was an incredibly compelling story spliced into the game. But if memory serves, the story beats and gameplay felt very siloed from one another — the latter feeling repetitive and much weaker between the two. Brendon Bigley of the Into the Aether podcast put it best on Mastodon:

> *cards on the table: i've never been a huge fan of the first Last of Us. i found it more impressive than good, if that makes sense. my feeling was always that it used the language of cinema in its storytelling so much the game itself fell by the wayside — i spent all of my time playing wishing i was just watching.*
>
> *point being: the hbo show is GOOD SHIT baybee*

GameDiscoverCo: ‘Compulsion loops’, predatory monetization & you..

January 18, 2023

Categories: Business

Simon Carless, the GameDiscoverCo newsletter (weekly free issue)

> *We’ve been sitting, mulling on this subject for a few weeks now. But it’s time to uncork it. You may have noted that the PC/console game market is changing, with a high supply of new games, and a tendency to reward titles that allow recurring play.*
>
> *Along the way, we’ve been preaching things like: ‘make deep, mechanically complex games that you can additionally monetize with DLC’. We’d defined this as both good business & ‘ethically sound’, whatever that means. (We’ll get there later.)*
>
> *But **what happens when you get too far down the spiral of monetizing your human-computer interface at all costs**? One of the most powerful books I’ve read in the last few years is Natasha Dow Schüll’s ‘Addiction By Design: Machine Gambling in Las Vegas’, which answers precisely that question:*
>
> *“Drawing on fifteen years of field research in Las Vegas, [the book] explores the dark side of machine gambling - a solitary, rapid, continuous form of play that has less to do with the competitive thrill of winning than with the pull of ‘the machine zone,’ as gamblers call the trancelike state they enter.”*
>
> *As an industry, we make video games that give people pleasure. But I do think people should, from time to time, ask - **are we jamming people’s brains with overly ‘addictive’ things?** And **are we taking advantage of that to make money, especially from those less able to afford it?***
>
> *Dow Schüll’s book is relevant because - remarkably - it is both a meticulous history of how machine gambling companies learned to retain players, and a close study of some of the local, less affluent Las Vegas gamblers locked into a vicious cycle of spending - because these machines demand money constantly.*
>
> *One big conclusion from her work? Winning **money back from slot machines** - the thing that makes the government regulate them so closely - **doesn’t actually seem to be why many people play them**. It’s about reaching a ‘flow state’, as defined by psychologist Mihály Csíkszentmihályi - the idea that you can get lost in an experience.*

A good piece from a good newsletter.

Zweisamkeit

January 18, 2023

Categories: General

A passage from "Tomorrow, and Tomorrow, and Tomorrow" by Gabrielle Zevin:

> *"'Zweisamkeit' is the feeling of being alone even when you're with other people." Simon turned to look in his husband's eyes. "Before I met you, I felt this constantly. I felt it with my family, my friends, and every boyfriend I ever had. I felt it so often that I thought this was the nature of living. To be alive was to accept that you were fundamentally alone." Simon's eyes were moist. "I know I'm impossible, and I know you don't care about German words or marriage. All I can say is, I love you and thank you for marrying me anyway."*
>
> *Ant raised his glass. "Zweisamkeit," he said.*

I mostly enjoyed "Tomorrow, and Tomorrow, and Tomorrow". While the tapestry of the novel is of game development (which hooked me initially), as Zevin puts it, it's really a book about work and love, which stuck with me; namely the passage above.

I'm so thankful for my wife and daughter, but I've had similar feelings of loneliness — lonely while in the company of others — in other parts of my life for far too long. I resolve to change that this year.

No Fail Mode

February 13, 2023

Categories: Design

I advocated using *Tunic*'s No Fail Mode in "My Favorite Things of 2022". Here's some neat detail about the feature from Wired's "How Indie Studios Are Pioneering Accessible Game Design" by Grant Stoner:

> *Accessibility may seem daunting, but by listening to experts in the field and the lived experiences of players, it affords disabled individuals the opportunity to play some of this year's best games, and by proxy, makes games better for everyone. In March, developer Andrew Shouldice launched Tunic, a game about an adorable little fox trying to solve a grand mystery. With exploration and puzzle mechanics harkening back to the original Legend of Zelda, mixed with Soulslike combat, Tunic offered quite the challenge, more so for those with disabilities. But rather than expect and force people to overcome potentially inaccessible barriers, Shouldice wanted everyone to play his game.*
>
> *"It's true that challenging combat is a core part of Tunic. However, including options like No Fail Mode does not 'compromise the integrity' of the game or anything like that," Shouldice says. "Really early on, I thought it would be a challenge to incorporate that sort of setting into a game that uses difficulty to gate progress, but in the end, it was a very straightforward decision. The truth is that people who enjoy the combat challenges are just not going to use the option, and those who don't want to engage with the combat will. In the end, the core of Tunic isn't about exclusion based on whether you can press the buttons at the right time. It's about being curious and willing to explore a world you don't understand. Adding some options to let more people experience that part of the game was absolutely worth it."*
>
> *The creation of No Fail Mode did not detract from a central mechanic of Tunic: exploration. Players are actively encouraged to seek out the unknown and regularly return to visited areas with new items. Discovering alternate pathways and searching every nook and cranny of zones is what makes Tunic so enticing to play. Despite the success of No Fail Mode, the feature still needed fine tuning, and proved that accessibility is a continuous process, one that does not stop when a game is released.*
>
> *"A few months before launch we set up a Discord for press folks to collaborate on puzzles prelaunch," Shouldice says. "One reviewer got to the credits, having defeated the final boss using No Fail Mode. It didn't take long for them to realize that they missed out on a big part of the game—you're supposed to fail that fight in order to unlock the game's next act. As a result, we added a special case, where even if you're using No Fail Mode, you can die in that fight. Our rationale was that if someone turned on that option because they preferred the puzzlier aspects of the game, it made no sense to penalize them and lock off some of Tunic more intriguing late-game riddles."*

This is essentially the curb cut effect:

> *…the phenomenon of disability-friendly features being used and appreciated by a larger group than the people they were designed for.*

I learned about the curb cut effect from The Besties episode "Accessible Gaming with Steven Spohn". I'll likely post the excerpt of Spohn's description of curb cutting and it's effect on gaming soon, but it's a must listen episode. And I recommend having a box of tissues handy.

'Regret's a killer worse than death'

February 18, 2023

Categories: General

Jack Billings (Billy Crudup), *Hello Tomorrow!* (Apple TV+):

> *Explain this to me... we live with miracles at our finger tips. We fly to the stars. We split atoms. We've got robots taking out the trash. Why are we all still waiting to live our dreams?*
>
> *Well, there's a technical term for that in my business: That's call a "shit deal". Our best days: they're piling up in the rearview. And that hope that keeps us going: it's wearing down to the bone. Some of us are losing people we love. And just like that "any day now", that turns into "too late". Gone forever. Because every day that we're not living for Now — Right Now — we're waiting around dying. One empty promise at a time.*
>
> *I'm not waiting around anymore, goddammit. Neither should you. The time is Now. And regret's a killer worse than death.*

Great writing that shook me out of a funk. Put it next to "I'm as mad as hell, and I'm not going to take this anymore!"

Rewind My Heart

March 23, 2023

Categories: General

Maddy Myers, Polygon:

> *In 2023, it may sound absurd for Blockbuster to stage a comeback. But it should, and here's why: Video game rentals. Although movies, TV, music, and even books have made the leap to digital subscription platforms with (relative) ease, video games haven't been quite so lucky. Sure, Xbox Game Pass is great, and it's only a matter of time before internet access becomes widespread enough that cloud gaming becomes a viable business concept (pour one out for Google Stadia). But we also live in a world where games suddenly become unavailable or delisted from online stores, like the impending Nintendo eShop situation.*

I can't see myself leaving the house to rent a video game, but I love the idea. I enjoy playing bits of games to get a feel for the mechanics, innovation, and splendor, largely because I want to stay in tune with the zeitgeist and the video game podcasts I listen to.

While digital video game demos remain a thing, they are hit or miss in terms of showcasing the actual game. Some demos provide an accurate taste for the game, even allowing players who purchase the game the opportunity to pick up where the demo leaves off (*Dragon Quest XI*), while others are poor examples of the true heart of a game (*Kirby and the Forgotten Land*).

The notion (and memory) of renting a game for a limited time to play as long as my heart desires, and progress as far as my time can muster, feels like an unappreciated lost love.

Gunpei Yokoi, Game Boy creator: Our competition has a color screen? 'Then we're fine'

March 25, 2023

Categories: Design

An excerpt from the book "Range: Why Generalists Triumph in a Specialized World" by David Epstein:

> *From a technological standpoint, even in 1989, the Game Boy was laughable. Yokoi's team cut every corner. The Game Boy's processor had been cutting edge in the 1970s. By the mid-1980s, home consoles were in fierce competition over graphics quality. The Game Boy was an eyesore. It featured a total of four grayscale shades, displayed on a tiny screen that was tinted a greenish hue somewhere between mucus and old alfalfa. Graphics in fast lateral motion smeared across the screen. To top it off, the Game Boy had to compete with handheld consoles from Sega and Atari that were technologically superior in every way. And it destroyed them.*
>
> *What its withered technology lacked, the Game Boy made up in user experience. It was cheap. It could fit in a large pocket. It was all but indestructible. If a drop cracked the screen—and it had to be a horrific drop—it kept on ticking. If it were left in a backpack that went in the washing machine, once it dried out it was ready to roll a few days later. Unlike its power-guzzling color competitors, it played for days (or weeks) on AA batteries. Old hardware was extremely familiar to developers inside and outside Nintendo, and with their creativity and speed unencumbered by learning new technology, they pumped out games as if they were early ancestors of iPhone app designers—Tetris, Super Mario Land, The Final Fantasy Legend, and a slew of sports games released in the first year were all smash hits. With simple technology, Yokoi's team sidestepped the hardware arms race and drew the game programming community onto its team.*
>
> *The Game Boy became the Sony Walkman of video gaming, forgoing top-of-the-line tech for portability and affordability. It sold 118.7 million units, far and away the bestselling console of the twentieth century. Not bad for the little company that was allowed to sell hanafuda.*
>
> *Even though he was revered by then, Yokoi had to push and shove internally for his "lateral thinking with withered technology" concept to be approved for the Game Boy. "It was difficult to get Nintendo to understand," he said later. Yokoi was convinced, though, that if users were drawn into the games, technological power would be an afterthought. "If you draw two circles on a blackboard, and say, 'That's a snowman,' everyone who sees it will sense the white color of the snow," he argued.*
>
> *When the Game Boy was released, Yokoi's colleague came to him "with a grim expression on his face," Yokoi recalled, and reported that a competitor handheld had hit the market. Yokoi asked him if it had a color screen. The man said that it did. "Then we're fine," Yokoi replied.*

Announcing Y-Button

April 20, 2023

Categories: General

Today, I'm launching Y-Button: a podcast that asks why we care about video games.



Since my previous, short-lived video game podcast Ported went on hiatus in 2016, I've been ruminating on what would make a compelling video game podcast. (I'm not exactly sure why Scott Taylor and I stopped recording after only three episodes, but I'm sure we fall into some statistic.) Video games are space I care deeply about, but I'm not exactly sure why. I don't play video games often, but the majority of media I consume — podcasts, news, documentaries — is video game related.

After seven years of asking myself why *I* care about video games, it dawned on me that maybe I should ask other people why *they* care about video games. (The realization hit me when I was listening to the *Smartless* episode with Rian Johnson and he and Will Arnett went on a tangent about games.)

Y-Button will feature interviews with journalists, enthusiasts, creators, and media personalities covering their origins with video games, why they care about the medium, and what excites them about the future. I'm starting with some friends and aquaintences, but the goal is to branch out to both well known industry insiders and celebrities you may not have known had a passion for video games. Dream guests include Kumail Nanjiani, Emily Gordon, AOC, Chrissy Teigen, Sarah Bond, Reggie Fils-Aimé, Rian Johnson, and Will Arnett to name a few. If you know any of these folks, hook it up! (The late Lance Reddick was also a huge source of inspiration and would have been a great get. RIP.)

Publishing this podcast is a source of immense excitement and anxiety for me. Worst case, I'm very proud of the name and cover art. I spent two nights learning Blender to create the 3D rendered button — my first experience with 3D modeling. I also wrote the theme song featuring my friend Scott Wilkie on a Minimoog with the direction, "make it sound like Steve Winwood".

I hope you listen, provide constructive feedback, and maybe even suggest or connect me with a guest you'd like to hear on the podcast. It's available wherever you find your podcasts including Apple Podcasts and Spotify. You can find the RSS feed here.

Enjoy the show.

Miyamoto: 'The border of video game is becoming less and less set in stone'

January 4, 2024

Categories: Design

Shigeru Miyamoto, in an interview with The Guardian's Keza MacDonald:

> *When Miyamoto started at Nintendo, video games were still yet to be defined. Arcades and early home consoles were sketching out the earliest versions of what would become possible with virtual worlds. In 2023, most of the world plays video games, and the boundaries of what constitutes a game are once again becoming porous. The corporate world is encroaching on the universes of play that gamers have long inhabited, rebranding them as "the metaverse". Everything from shopping and language learning to going for a run is being gamified through apps.*
>
> *"Even grandpas like me know what games are now," says Miyamoto. "Nowadays it's very common to use PCs and smartphones, they're used as pen and paper used to be. The border of video game is becoming less and less set in stone. People are having a broader understanding and acceptance of the term."*

Video games do not exist.

'So don't get worried and sell all your shares'

January 27, 2024

Categories: Business

Gita Jackson, episode 2 of the new Aftermath Hours podcast (edited for clarity):

> *Microsoft is beginning to gear up for their first financial meeting where they're discussing the impact of the Blizzard Activision acquisition. As sort of a runway up to that, they laid off a huge number of roles...*
>
> *What really drives me wild about the Microsoft one [compared to Riot] is that Microsoft is a company that makes profit at a level that if they eliminated their gaming division tomorrow, it would have a minimal impact on their bottom line. By that same token, they could keep their gaming division at exactly the same size and those 2,000 jobs would not actually impact their bottom line all that much.*
>
> *Think about how big Microsoft is. Because of the way that the economy works and the way that I've learned that most of economic projections are just sort of guesstimates and lies, video games for a company like Sony or Microsoft that do other things, that do consumer electronics and software, video games are not even a secondary revenue stream. They're like a tertiary revenue stream. They're like third in priority. They don't need to do this. They really don't need to do this. And by that same token, it doesn't make sense when they have layoffs this huge. This is like a show of force for their investors more than anything else, right? To say that they've identified the profit centers and are trimming the fat in their new acquisition. "So don't get worried and sell all your shares."*

In years past, I would have written extensively about the insane amount of gaming industry layoffs occurring right now. This is exactly the thing I want people paying attention to. Thankfully, there are loads of outlets covering this madness. I also haven't had time to put my thoughts together. My jaw hasn't left the floor. I'm flabbergasted by the current state of things, keep seeing more bad news, and frankly, I'm out of practice of research and reporting. Plus, there are much more informed people dropping insightful takes about this atrocious time, like the folks at Aftermath. (I'm really enjoying the Aftermath Hours podcast. Highly recommend.)

That said, if I had written something, I would have wanted it to echo what Gita has said here. It isn't a coincidence that Microsoft's layoffs came one week before their shareholder meeting. That's not to say these layoffs wouldn't have happened regardless, but this timing does away with any facade.

(Also, if I'm reading this correctly, Gaming accounted for about 7% of Microsoft's FY24 Q1 revenue. I wouldn't say it has "minimal impact on their bottom line", but it certainly isn't their moneymaker.)

'They’re getting away with it because everybody is doing it.'

January 29, 2024

Categories: Business

Bobby Allyn, NPR:

> *“There is a herding effect in tech,” said Jeff Shulman, a professor at the University of Washington’s Foster School of Business, who follows the tech industry. “The layoffs seem to be helping their stock prices, so these companies see no reason to stop.”*
>
> *Some smaller tech startups are running out of cash and facing fundraising struggles with the era of easy money now over, which has prompted workforce reductions. But experts say for most large and publicly-traded tech firms, the layoff trend this month is aimed at satisfying investors.*
>
> *Shulman adds: “They’re getting away with it because everybody is doing it. And they’re getting away with it because now it’s the new normal,” he said. “Workers are more comfortable with it, stock investors are appreciating it, and so I think we’ll see it continue for some time.”*

Avoiding Hell

May 10, 2024

Categories: Business

Matt and the Evil Empire team announcing a delayed release date for Ubisoft's upcoming *The Rogue Prince of Persia*:

> *So it's been a bit of a crazy week for us! It all started when a little game called Hades 2 released - you might have heard of it?*
>
> *Seeing as everyone and their mum is playing that game (including our entire team... and their mums), we have decided to let people have their fun with it before we release The Rogue Prince of Persia.*
>
> *We will still be releasing in May and will be back with a precise date on Monday.*
>
> *While we have every confidence in The Rogue Prince of Persia, it's not every day that a game in the same genre as you, which is one of the most anticipated upcoming games of 2024, will release into Early Access a week before you plan to do the same.*

Years ago, I wrote about self-competing and time blocking. While I'm not sold on the conspiracy, it remains true that the year-by-year, month-by-month deluge of amazing games has titles eating each others' lunch. *Hades 2* — the sequel to one of best and most hooking games ever made — is certain to eat everyone's lunch. This announcement from Evil Empire is the sort I've been yearning to see.

As calendars become packed with incredible releases, many developers and publishers have found their highly anticipated game gets overshadowed by an even more highly anticipated game releasing in the same window. More often than not, it's impossible for release dates to shift due to in-flight marketing campaigns, resource forecasts, and release management on various platforms.

Seeing as this delay is specifically for the Early Access (beta, more or less) version of *The Rogue Prince of Persia*, Evil Empire and Ubisoft have the benefit of a much smaller impact for delaying. Still, it's a small step in the right direction. Even more shocking that this is an Ubisoft title. Maybe I'm naive, but I didn't have "Ubisoft approved game delay" on my bingo card.

My favorite part:

> *This also lets us keep polishing up the game, add even more cool things and kick some stubborn bugs out before release. The Day 1 patch was getting pretty hefty, so gaining more time to test it and add more stuff before launch day has considerably lowered the stress levels of our producer and game director already!*

Wonderful move for both players and the team.

Video games are Millennials too

June 20, 2024

Categories: Business

Kyle Orland, Ars Technica:

> *A 16-year-old who was sinking all their free time into Diablo II when it launched in 2000 is pushing 40 these days. That means the core, nostalgic audience for the series is now very likely to have a career, family, and/or other responsibilities eating into their playtime. There's nothing like a few decades of aging to make the prospect of sinking hundreds of hours into a loot grind seem less appealing.*

I was 15 years old when *Diablo II* released. I'm pushing 40 these days. What is true of Diablo's grind is true of video games in general.

As a teenager, I would dream of playing video games all day. The desire propelled my career ambitions. If I could make enough money to buy any game whenever I wanted, I had made it. (This motivation still lingers…) But it's in the past five or so years that I've had to face the reality that time is scarce. Free time: Scarcer. I'll spare you a write-up on the increased thoughts of mortality that sink in after you have a child, but that's part of it too. Choosing what you do with your ever-decreasing free time becomes paramount.

And while decreased leisure time is not a new phenomenon, decreased time for video games is. Video games were a construct of the '50s–'70s, but they did not become ubiquitous until the '80s. Add 10 to 20 years to that for the first player base, and you get people now in their late 50s/early 60s who grew up with games. But it's likely the Millennials in their 30s and 40s who have the most profound attachment to the medium as they grew up alongside it. Video games are Millennials too.

The fact that we have yet to uncover the full spectrum of age demographics that are native to gaming is exciting but continues to throw wrenches in business models. As people age, how they choose to spend their time changes. In a few decades, we'll understand how to meet every age demographic and their native technological culture where they are, with wider varieties of gaming genres and experiences. Until then, expect the old way of doing things to die on the vine.

Netflix: The New Blockbuster

August 9, 2024

Categories: Business

Stephen Totilo on his excellent Game File newsletter (paywalled):

> *I might have the games-movies-TV comparison on my mind because of Arranger's Netflix connection.*
>
> *The new game is available on Switch and PlayStation for a price, but is also offered on mobile at no added cost to anyone with a Netflix subscription.*
>
> *It's one of many excellent games offered via Netflix on mobile (see also: Kentucky Route Zero, Oxenfree, Poinpy, The Case of the Golden Idol, Storyteller, Immortality, Into the Breach and more).*
>
> *But it's not quite the kind of game that Netflix execs were hyping to investors last week as they made clear they're still bullish on being a big player in gaming. They kept focusing on games that spin off of Netflix shows, and salivated over how a tie-in game can let Netflix "take a show and give the super fan a place to be in between seasons." That's the kind of synergy talk that investors like. It makes sense the way it makes sense to extend a brand by selling official t-shirts and coffee mugs. It might even result in some delightful games tied to TV shows.*
>
> *It's just not what Arranger is.*
>
> *Arranger is something only possible in games that only needs to be a game and have nothing to do with anything else.*

My wife and I resubscribed to Netflix the night before the above newsletter went out (July 26, 2024 — I'm a bit late to posting this). She's been wanting to watch *Live to 100* and is excited about the upcoming *Emily in Paris* season.

After starting our new Netflix subscription, the first thing I saw when launching the app was a row of mobile games, leading with *Arranger*. I had no intention of playing anything that night, but had heard a lot of good buzz about *Arranger*, so I launched it not 30 seconds after becoming a subscriber.

Then I had an epiphany: Netflix feels like the new Blockbuster.

Blockbuster is most fondly remembered as a movie rental store — truly, Netflix/streaming has been seen as the new Blockbuster for decades — but after seeing Netflix's programming layout of movies/TV **and** games, I was teleported back to browsing the shelves of Blockbuster on a Friday night — my parents looking for movies while I looked for video games.

Movies/TV and games are complementary — the former is passive and latter is participatory. This often comes up on my podcast Y-Button. As a child, it was such a treat to browse both movies/TV and games under one roof, asking, "What am I in the mood for tonight?" I doubt Netflix is looking to Blockbuster as a model. And it's not to say one can't experience any piece of media or medium at any given time on their smartphone, or movies/TV and games on their console. But one curated location (the Netflix app) offering two types of experiences feels right.

Switch 2 Teaser Impressions

January 18, 2025

Categories: Business

With Nintendo's announcement and teaser of the Switch 2, a few thoughts have been percelating in my mind. I'll keep this brief, inspired both by Brendon Bigley's ingenius hot take "Switch 2 thoughts but I only have as long as Nintendo's announcement" and the limited time I have while my daughter naps.

I stated the following on my post "Nintendo Switch Presentation 2017 Impressions":

> *Without question, Switch is another unique and possibly industry changing device. Like Apple, Nintendo often skates to where the puck is headed, defining industry trends. And without question, the biggest dream of all is being able to take your home console on the go.*

Boy, if that wasn't an understatement. At 146.04 million units sold (so far), Nintendo Switch is the third best-selling video game console of all time (and only ~14M units away from dethroning PS2 from the top spot). Five years after the launch of the Switch, Valve released the Steam Deck and we've seen a plethora of other manufacturers following Nintendo's lead.

But where does the puck go after the Switch and "home console handhelds"?

So far, the Switch 2 looks like a bigger, more comfortable Switch. The new Joy-Cons seem to suggest some new features such as doubling as a mouse. And we can only assume the Switch 2 will pack a bit more power, if not for the fact that chips have gotten much more powerful in eight years, but the form-factor alone should support better thermals, larger components, and a bigger battery to support said power. It's an iterative upgrade, which would (sort of) be a first for Nintendo considering the fact that they're touting strong backwards compatibility with the Switch.

With that, here are a few unfounded, potentially crackpot throughts on the Switch 2 and Nintendo at large:

- **Switch 2 will not sell gangbusters**. Early adopters are eager to get thier hands on this, and assuming it will pack much more modern power, it will probably do well in the years to come if more demanding games can launch alongside their PC/PS5/Xbox Series counterparts on the Switch 2. But just as the current Switch is "good enough" for many players, I assume the original Switch will continue to be "good enough" for most players until they can no longer find the titles they want to play on their 8+ year-old console.
- **Nintendo will focus on micro-innovations moving forward**. Maybe my imagination has run dry, but I think we're at the end of the road for video game console innovation. Nearly as soon as console video games arrived, players began dreaming of taking them on the go. The original Switch made that a reality (per my quote above). If this is true, that puts Nintendo in a very interesting position. A company known for its video game console innovation may not have much more room for large innovations such as the NES, Game Boy, DS, Wii, and Switch. I do think we'll see micro-innovations on their consoles moving forward (such as the suspected mouse-input on the Switch 2 Joy-Cons), but I don't think we'll see big swings from Nintendo or others in the industry going forward. If Nintendo is seen as prescient of the games industry, the fact that they're only iterating eight years later may suggest that we've hit a plateau. Innovation

will happen — motion input, touch input, XR, etc — but it likely won't be considered the core-gaming experience consisting of… well… buttons.

- **Nintendo will look outside of consoles for innovations**. Maybe an iteration of the Switch was obvious. Perhaps the writing of the the aforementioned plateau was on the wall as soon as Super Nintendo World was announced in 2015. But the fact that Nintendo seems to be making a full-throated effort to reach outside of video games with theme parks, movies, a music app… an alarm clock… may show that there may be limited room to innovate in the hardware space. Video games will continue to be the hub of their flywheel, but expansion beyond innovative video game hardware and into thier franchises seems to make even more sense now.
- **Switch 2 could be the Microsoft handheld**. Probably the wildest idea that I've had for a while. Microsoft has been stressing Xbox everywhere, now even porting games to PlayStation. Depending on the power of Switch 2, it'd be silly for Microsoft not to execute the same strategy on Nintendo's "home console handheld platform". Just like that, Xbox titles would be on an extremely popular handheld device. A boon for both Microsoft and Nintendo (which could blow a hole in my first bullet point). Furthermore, if the Switch 2 does suggest a video game hardware plateau, what's left for Microsoft to do in the space? Why take the loss on building their own hardware? Lean on PlayStation as a powerhouse home console and Nintendo Switch for the handheld-first market.

If this is as far as Nintendo's console innovation goes — yes, I know how ludicrous that sounds — at long last, I'll be able to play my "Nintendo".

Speech Bubbles

January 19, 2025

Categories: Culture

An article from The Atlantic by Derek Thompson titled “The Anti-Social Century” (Atlantic link; free Apple News+ link) has been making the rounds in my feeds. It’s a great piece that says the quiet part out loud — society has become homebodies to the point of extreme danger. We’re glued to our phones and TV, tucked away in the comforts of our own homes, shut away from our neighbors, and afraid to interact with strangers.

There are some great insights and observations in the piece and I strongly suggest you read it. However, I find it shocking that podcasts are not mentioned once.

I empathize with the piece. I’ve been working with therapists and a career coach recently to figure out why I don’t feel fulfilled in my work and how to stave off or work through bouts of extreme depression and anxiety. It’s becoming quite clear that I don’t spend enough time out with other people. Even in the workplace, I find myself working more with colleagues in other parts of the world than I do in my local office. And I’m coming to find that one of my remedies for loneliness is podcasts.

Over the course of a year, I will listen to hundreds of hours of the same voices. One-way conversations where I feel intimately familiar with the hosts’ lives; laughing, nodding, and crying along to their conversations as if they are speaking to me privately. I feel a connection to these people with shared interests, hobbies, humor, and passions, many of which I’ve never met. And just as soon as I have a quiet moment to acknowledge that this intimacy is false, another episode is right there to fill the silence.

I’ve been fortunate enough to befriend some of the hosts of my favorite podcasts. Thankfully, that “connection” and “intimacy” have borne fruit. Now when I listen to thier shows, I know there exists a genuine relationship where I can reach out directly and chat about a topic they brought up, or something else entirely. But that is not the case for the overwhelming majority of podcast listeners. Yet, they likely feel an “intimate connection” to their favorite hosts.

So, when I came across this bit in Thompson’s piece, a chill ran down my spine:

> *AI’s ability to speak naturally might seem like an incremental update, as subtle as a camera-lens refinement on a new iPhone. But according to Nick Epley, fluent speech represents a radical advancement in the technology’s ability to encroach on human relationships.*
>
> *“Once an AI can speak to you, it’ll feel extremely real,” he said, because people process spoken word more intimately and emotionally than they process text. For a study published in 2020, Epley and Amit Kumar, a psychologist at the University of Texas at Austin, randomly assigned participants to contact an old friend via phone or email. Most people said they preferred to send a written message. But those instructed to talk on the phone reported feeling “a significantly stronger bond” with their friend, and a stronger sense that they’d “really connected,” than those who used email.*
>
> *Speech is rich with what are known as “paralinguistic cues,” such as emphasis and intonation, which can build sympathy and trust in the minds of listeners. In another study,*

> *Epley and the behavioral scientist Juliana Schroeder found that employers and potential recruiters were more likely to rate candidates as "more competent, thoughtful, and intelligent" when they heard a why-I'm-right-for-this-job pitch rather than read it.*

This bit about AI is hardly the meat of the article. Perhaps even a distraction from the core thesis. But it did remind me of a fear I've had for a few years now — one that seemed almost too "science fiction" to write about, but is no longer fiction: Personalized AI-generated podcasts.

Years ago, the concept of podcast dynamic ad insertion led me to consider a sci-fi future where beyond ads, podcasts became hyper-tailored to the listener. To Epley's point, speech can create a much stronger bond than text. What if a podcast could tailor itself to you, going as far as to address you by name? This would not only be compelling in the face of loneliness, but extremely dangerous considering the free-range of rhetoric available in podcasts.

So when Spotify announced that they had partnered with Google to create custom Spotify Wrapped AI Podcasts for each Spotify user, you can see why I freaked out a little bit.

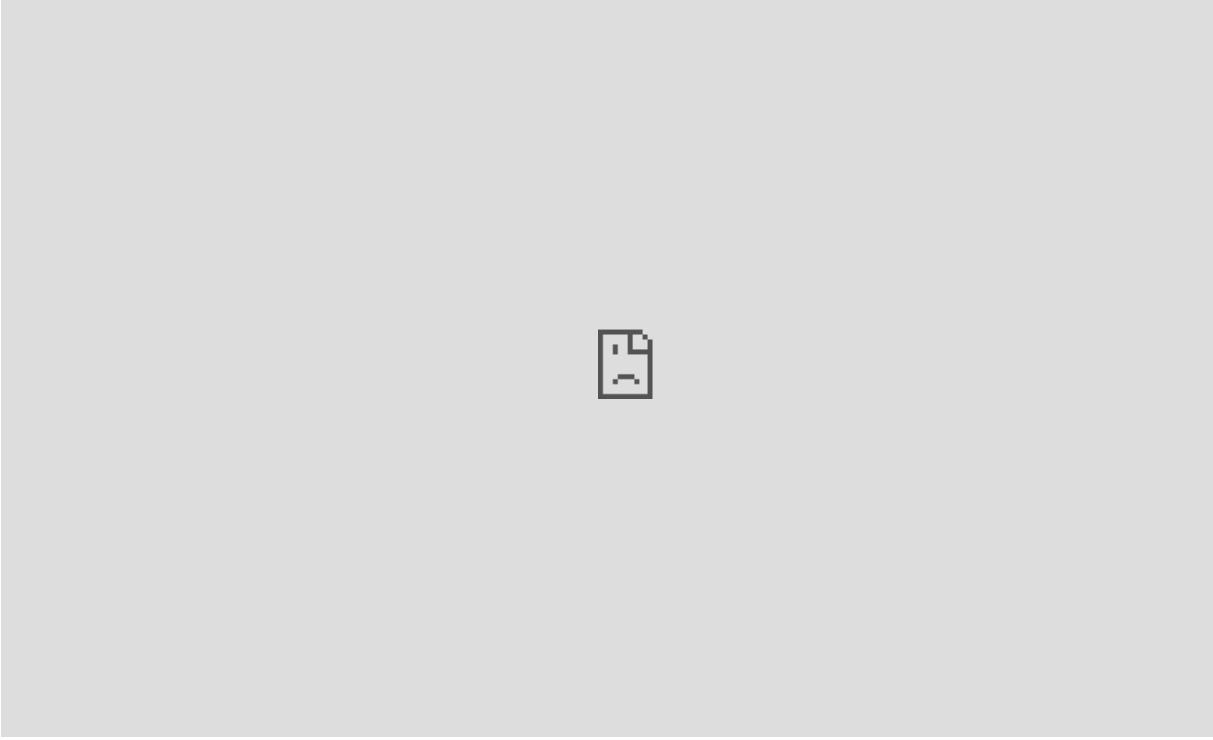
I'm sure I'm behind the curve here, and not only is Google's NotebookLM playing in this space, but people are surely feeding their digital interactions with obedient GenAI content. So what stops a future where we are not only reading what we want to read, but we're hearing what what we want to hear from a voice speaking directly to us for hundreds of hours a year?

Y-Button: Andy Robertson (Ludocene)

February 25, 2025

Categories: Business

Last week, I welcomed games journalist Andy Robertson to Y-Button to talk about his new project Ludocene — a video game recommendation deck-builder in the form of a simple dating app. Ludocene's special sauce lies in its human-centric connections (players who liked this also liked this) and "expert cards" that you can use to augment your recommendations — tastemakers that Andy and team have paid (which is where much of the Kickstarter contributions will go in the future).



About half of the episode is focused on some nitpicky details of Ludocene. The other half gets to the mystery and organic nature of video games, and why adults should lean into curiosity as opposed to dismissal of the new gaming experiences kids prefer.

This episode came together extremely quickly. I read The Guardian's post about Ludocene, I connected with Andy on Bluesky, he recognized me from a conversation we'd had years ago, then he DMed an offer of a press kit to write something up. I agreed, but quickly realized it'd be more fun to talk about Ludocene on my podcast. Andy agreed. The next morning we recorded for an hour (before I rushed to work), I blurted out an intro and outro, sent the recordings to my editor AJ Fillari, I listened back, and we launched the episode in less than 24 hours. Podcasting pros out there may not think much of that, but for three people in three different time zones (and one with an extremely busy day job, speaking for myself), it felt like quite the feat. I'm really proud of this one. And I'm very excited for Ludocene.

Y-Button: 15 - Andy Robertson (Ludocene, Family Gaming Database, Taming Gaming): Website | Apple Podcasts | Spotify | Overcast | Pocket Casts

NYT: ”Metroidvanias: The Video Games You Can Get Lost In”

February 25, 2025

Categories: Design

Lewis Gordon writing for this gorgeous article on The New York Times (Note: This article is walled off. I’m not sure if I was able to access it because we subscribe to the NYT Cooking app, or if it was because I simply signed in with an existing account):

> *The two Metroidvania progenitors — 1986’s Metroid and 1987’s Castlevania II: Simon’s Quest — cultivated a sense of geographical bewilderment by letting players unfurl the secrets of their arcane worlds in any direction along the X and Y axes. Part of the charm is that the entirety of these expansive play spaces is not immediately accessible: Sections lie gated behind power-ups, like the so-called Morph Ball and High Jump Boots in Metroid, and players are forced to rely on a labyrinthine map.*
>
> *Decades later, the genre continues to yield rich rewards. Ultros, Animal Well and Prince of Persia: The Lost Crown were included on many best of 2024 lists, and other notable releases within the past year include Nine Sols, Tales of Kenzera: Zau and Ender Magnolia: Bloom in the Mist.*
>
> *The genre has come to be known for its friction, with a propensity for baffling mazelike settings, acute sense of isolation and often punishing combat. Yet Jeremy Parish, a journalist who helped popularize the term Metroidvania and wrote an upcoming book on the genre, said that in some ways they are more accessible role-playing games that do not get bogged down in stats and menus. Characters grow while exploring a vast world, allowing Metroidvanias to deliver immersion, exploration and a sense of discovery.*

Metroidvanias (referred to as “search-action games” in Japan, as listeners of The Besties will recognize) are some of my favorite games. A few years ago, in anticipation for *Metroid Dread*, I played through the five core 2D Metroid games:

- *Metroid: Zero Mission* (GBA)
- *Metroid: Samus Returns* (3DS)
- *Super Metroid* (SNES (via 3DS))
- *Metroid Fusion* (GBA)
- *Metroid Dread* (Switch)

Before that, I’d played through and loved *Ori and the Blind Forest* and *Ori and the Will of the Wisps*.

To Parish’s point, immersion and discovery are my favorite parts of Metroidvanias. But I’ve learned that locomotion is critical to making them feel great. Ori and Zero Mission: Bingo. Super Metroid: Not so much.

It’s a wonderful genre that continues to innovate, seemingly at all odds with its narrow corridors and repetitive core-loop. How cool that The New York Times gave the genre this beautiful treatment.

(I prefer Into the Aether’s term “Gate-Punk” for this genre.)

Two Switch 2 Bugaboos

April 5, 2025

Categories: Business

The internet is awash with Nintendo Switch 2 takes, from hands-on impressions to business analysis to uncovering the things unsaid by Nintendo. I don't have much to add — I think it looks fine, the price kind of sucks, I'll probably get one ASAP because I just can't help myself with a new Nintendo console — but I wanted to document a handful of "bugaboos" about the Switch 2. (I posted these to Bluesky, but this blog will live in posterity.)

1. No OLED

Upgrading from the original Switch to the Switch OLED felt like a revelation. The inky blacks, brilliant hues, and increased brightness made the device feel premium. Jumping from a 6.2-inch screen to a 7.0-inch screen was much more comfortable. *Hades* is a standout. *Metroid Dread* is gorgeous. All older games almost feel new again. "Seeing" a transition to and from a loading screen go completely black in my already very dark room feels oddly magical. Yes, I am a sucker for OLED.

I was very disappointed to learn that Switch 2 has reverted back to an LED screen (with HDR). Nintendo even neglected to show a Switch OLED during the Switch 2 presentation, likely to create the optics that the Switch 2's 7.9-inch display is notably larger than the original Switch's 6.2-inch screen (as opposed to the Switch OLED's 7.0-inch screen).

In my heart of hearts, I know this won't really affect my enjoyment of the console, but I know I'll be bothered by it, knowing Nintendo will likely release an OLED version mid-cycle with a smaller bezel (thus larger screen) and an even more beautiful picture. While next-gen does not equal "premium", the downgrade feels like a missed opportunity to meet the premium market where it is as a standout device.

Understanding the cost of Switch 2 is $450 US (sans tariffs), perhaps the decision to sacrifice an OLED screen was one that had to be made to counter an even more shocking price tag. And offering a "premium" version alongside a standard version would undercut a mid-cycle refresh and perhaps create additional insult to the injury of the already high price.

The snob in me is not excited to see a big gray box between load-ins.

2. No Built-in Camera

This is at once easy to ignore and completely shocking. Nintendo spent a fair amount of time focused on the Switch 2's GameChat social feature, including their first-party camera that can be used in docked mode to stream your face and/or create in-game avatars.

I repeat: Docked. Mode.

After the first six months of the original Switch's launch in 2017, Nintendo stated that only 20% of users play primarily in TV (Docked) Mode. 30% primarily in Tabletop/Handheld Mode; 50% in both Docked and Handheld Mode.

I'm extremely curious how these numbers have changed after eight years of a gangbusters run, including the Switch Lite (2019) that cannot be docked. But I'm sure primarily Docked Mode has not become any more favorable. So, it's curious that the camera feature of GameChat is only available via the Dock.

In an effort to declutter our house, I've mounted my Switch dock behind my TV. I'm certainly not going to be sticking a camera out from the side it. Without that, I have no way to share my killer facial reactions when I destroy friends in *Mario Kart World* on Switch 2.

GameChat seems to be a feature Nintendo is hanging its hat on for Switch 2 — one that even gets its own dedicated "C" button. Wouldn't a built-in camera for Handheld mode make sense? Unlike an OLED screen, this seems like a hardware feature that wouldn't break the bank. The Wii U Gamepad had a camera. The DSi and 3DS had cameras. Even the Game Boy had a camera! (Yeah, yeah…) This just seems like a very weird miss for a feature Nintendo is building its own hardware accessory to support. Maybe the justification is that Handheld users are less likely to have an internet connection and therefore couldn't use the camera for this purpose. But no internet means no GameChat altogether. And surely a camera could be used for other fun features. Weird!

Bonus: No Wind Waker HD?!

There's surely no better way to advertise GameCube games coming to Nintendo Switch Online than with one of the greatest Zelda games of all time, which is exactly what Nintendo did when they announced *The Legend of Zelda: The Wind Waker* as a launch title for the Nintendo Switch Online GameCube library.

However, we've now gone a full console cycle without said great Wii U HD port of one of said greatest Zelda games of all time. I shouldn't be so dramatic about a Wii U port, but a handful of the Switch's best titles are Wii U ports. Switch launched with Wii U ports *Mario Kart 8 Deluxe* (the #1 bestselling Switch game) and *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* (yes, I count it as a port)! There's long been speculation that the *Wind Waker* port — along with the port of *Twilight Princess* — has been in the can and ready for release at any time, likely a "break glass in case of emergency" situation.

While the release of the original is great for the sake of preservation, it's a gut-punch for anyone eager to play the acclaimed, refined, and enhanced HD port. Now the chances of the port making it to the Switch 2 feel years away.

For now, we can try to ignore that something better is likely sitting on a shelf and relive the magic of the original through pillarboxing. (I only want to see 4:3 on my CRT.)

Gaming is in its big tech era

April 8, 2025

Categories: Design

Phil Bothun, 70 Percent Complete:

> *Which makes sense: after the less-than-stellar sales of the WiiU, Nintendo has had 8 years of massive success, enjoying the success that comes from smart, innovative design and long tail growth from lowering the barriers for indies and third parties. That's only really possible because of that coalescing: porting and selling games becomes easier (and more profitable) when the platforms are more similar.*
>
> *But the downside is where we are now: this massive storyline for the past two or three years of "when is the Switch Pro or Switch 2 coming out?" ends leaving me feeling kinda bored. Sure, price plays a part in that: $299 for a Switch felt good in 2017, but $450 now doesn't feel quite as nice. And yeah, the games look good, but I already have too many games to play on my other incremental consoles. The realm of innovative game design seems to have fallen to indies, most of which don't require the power of a PS5's hard drive, a 5090, or yeah, a Nintendo Switch 2.*

Polygone

May 1, 2025

Categories: Media

Jay Peters of The Verge, reporting on the sale of Polygon to Valnet:

> *Polygon, The Verge's sister site dedicated to gaming and entertainment, has been sold by Vox Media to Valnet, a company that owns brands like ScreenRant, GameRant, and Android Police. Some Polygon staffers will continue with the publication under its new owner, while others have been laid off, according to posts online and an internal message sent to Vox Media employees.*
>
> *Valnet owns more than 27 different brands that cover areas like entertainment, gaming, sports, and travel. A recent report from TheWrap includes one former contributor to a site under Valnet's purview describing conditions as "almost sweatshop-level."*

This is gut-wrenching. Polygon meant so much to me. It's a big reason I dreamed of becoming a games journalist, in turn starting this blog, and likely the sole reason I took any interest in web development.

When the website launched in 2012, the design, articles, and personality forward staff felt like a revelation. I was hooked. Pieces like their PS4 and Xbox One reviews took my breath away. Tracy Lien's No Girls Allowed is an all-timer.

Between 2013–2014, likely even longer, I had daily ritual of poring over Polygon to find pieces to blog about. During my stint working in the podcasts industry, I did everything in my power to help promote their shows like The Besties and Mini Map. During my time working in the news industry, I took a go at building their *Breath of the Wild* review in Apple News format (which turned out great), and had the great fortune of showing it off to then EIC Chris Grant.

Working in games media had (has?) always been a dream for me. For every friend and acquaintance I made at Polygon, that dream had been partially realized. I look up to the folks. I adore their work and how they elevated games journalism. I'm sure I'll have more to say, but for now, tearing up as I write this, I'm absolutely gutted to see Polygon go. All my best to those affected by this news.

Press Reset: The Story of Polygon

May 1, 2025

Categories: Media

Here's a 13 part documentary on the creation of Polygon: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=At1NP_hl7pc&list=PLFECD492AC5E3201F.

I'm so glad this exists. (Truthfully, I couldn't remember if this documentary was real or just a dream I had. I'd first seen it 13 years ago. I don't remember it being carved up into 13 parts.)

The introduction of this documentary is terribly ironic and depressing. Here's a short snippet:

> *The Goliaths inspired a nimble counterpart — the game blog; sites like Kotaku, Joystiq, and Destructoid. Once again, a newcomer had the advantage of speed. Within an hour, a reader saw multiple posts. Within a week, they had a magazine's worth of content. This speed occassionally resulted in misreporting, and pretty visuals took a backseat to getting the post live first. But they were persistent, news-minded, and at least at first, outside the system. The rising tide began to threaten traditional publications. The survivors retreated to the high ground of co-marketed partnerships with console makers and game retailers. But even these publications were a risk.*
>
> *Which brings us to today. A time of shift. Fast blogs creating more original material. Gargantuan networks that are breaking news. Magazines testing their hands online and in apps. Everyone learning from each other. Games writing is stronger than ever and games are covered in almost every conceivable way. There's no shortage when it comes to information about games.*
>
> *Major gaming sites get tens of millions of hits a month. Gaming grows every year. More gamers. More success. More influence. The stakes have never been higher.*

Poring over the somber Bluesky posts, Discord conversations, new articles, and newsletters regarding Polygon's sale to Valnet and the mass layoffs at the site has sent me spiraling down memory lane. In my previous post, I mentioned Polygon inspiring me to become a games journalist and/or web developer. A lot of that sentiment stems from this documentary. I didn't just want to be a games journalist and/or web developer. I wanted to be a games journalists and/or web developer **at Polygon**.

’The people of Polygon deserved better’

May 2, 2025

Categories: Media

Grayson Morley on his Backlog newsletter:

> *I’m a fiction writer who wandered into games criticism. I say “wandered,” but the truth is, I got some serious help early on from Chris Plante, former editor-in-chief of Polygon. When I was a nobody, and not, as I am now, nearly nobody, Plante hopped on a Zoom call with me when I was between jobs, trying to see whether I could pivot into doing some games writing. Our correspondence up until that point had been mostly me emailing him about my short story, “Brent, Bandit King,” which had won an award and was based on an article he’d written at the time for The Verge. Let me be perfectly frank: Very few people on this earth would email back a random stranger telling them they wrote a short story based on an article they wrote. Plante did. And not only that, but he offered sage advice to me when I was first getting Backlog going, a kindness for which I have no way of repaying him.*
>
> *Besides Plante, I owe a lot to current and former Polygon folks like Mike Mahardy, Maddy Myers, and Matt Leone for their edits and guidance. But before I was a contributor, I was a Polygon reader, and that’s the part of me that’s mourning right now. For me, Polygon was my absolute favorite place to read about games, both on the reportorial side, thanks to powerhouses like Nicole Carpenter, and especially on the critical front, with its variety of voices, both in-house and freelance, who offered fresh takes on the art form I so love. For that to be more or less gone this morning is incredibly sad.*
>
> *I don’t have a radical take to propose today besides to say that you should follow these writers wherever they go. People make the publication, and not the other way around, and when the business side loses track of that, we all suffer. I fear there will never be another Polygon, and as someone who cares about this medium, that’s a hard pill to swallow. The people of Polygon deserved better. The readers of Polygon deserved better. The industry deserved better.*

I echo Morley’s sentiments. I’ve had the great fortune of meeting and befriending a handful of folks from Polygon over the years. Their empathy, care, wit, and insight only made me want to be part of their team even more. Some incredibly bright and dedicated individuals that certainly deserved better.

’An implosion supervised by idiots who have been grifted by other idiots who have been grifted by actual grifters’

May 3, 2025

Categories: Media

Brendon Bigley, Wavelengths:

> *I’ve been reading Polygon since the day in launched in 2012. I was an avid fan because of its focus on people — at the time most sites were primarily focused on their own branding which led to sites as monolithic entities. Reviews weren’t by any specific writer, they were by [BRAND DOT COM] and discussed on early social media and in forums as such. Polygon broke the mold by being staunchly supportive of the individuals who made its ongoing success a reality, story by story and brick by brick until it became an institution in the space. They made videos about funny bullshit (complimentary) and reported on troubling labor practices in the game development space in equal measure because different people are good at different things, and all of that is what boiled up to being the brand. It’s why so many freelancers and ex-employees are online today speaking highly of their time working with Polygon. The boots-on-the-ground team that allowed the site to function cared about these people in a meaningful way and there was a tangibility to that care that permeated into the readership.*
>
> *I can’t help but walk away from this news feeling like the very thing that inspired me to spend my time considering games and the industry around them has died a very permanent death. While I’m glad to see independent outlets like MinnMax and Aftermath continue to pave a new path forward and inspire future generations to think critically about the medium, there’s a real sense of loss here that reaches all the way backwards to Facebook’s disastrous “pivot to video” era. What we’re left with is Patreon and Memberful and influencers and IGN. That’s games media now.*
>
> *And what’s left of the sites I used to love and find community within in Polygon and Waypoint and Giant Bomb and so many more is just an AI grind house serving Google of all companies. Google, who are well on their way to speedrunning destroying their own business model at the cost of everyone else’s. It’s an implosion supervised by idiots who have been grifted by other idiots who have been grifted by actual grifters.*

Polygon's Masthead

May 4, 2025

Categories: Media

Aftermath's Luke Plunkett posted a brutal comparison of Polygon's masthead from last week vs today on Bluesky. Eviscerated. A tragic, gross visual of the human cost of senseless layoffs.

Post Games: A new podcast by former Polygon Editor-in-Chief Chris Plante

May 26, 2025

Categories: Media

Are you missing Polygon as much as I am? Do you appreciate in-depth journalism about niche topics with your hobby of choice? Do you like tightly edited podcasts with clear structure? Are you a fan of personality, interviews, and well-crafted story? Are you addicted to gaming podcasts because you have very little time to play yourself and/or you might just love the conversation around games more than the games themselves? Then you're in luck.

Post Games, the new podcast from former Polygon Editor-in-Chief Chris Plante, feels like the canonical audio form of Polygon. Everything I loved about Polygon from its clean yet charming design to its niche stories to its rich journalism with personality is woven into Post Games.

I had the pleasure of providing early feedback on the first episode, which details an under appreciated game award that is damn near prophetic of seminal indie game success and stories and developers I've never heard of, but now can't help but keep my eye fixed upon. Episode 0, an interview with Platformer's Casey Newton, lends great insight into what a career in independent journalism looks like — a world Plante now finds himself in.

While you can find the show for free on Apple Podcasts, Spotify, and any other podcast app via RSS, I encourage you to check out the show's Patreon to both support and receive a bevy of bonus perks.

It's inspiring to see former Polygon folks make haste with a poor situation. Seeing Nicole Carpenter's byline appear on Game File, Aftermath, and 404 Media is thrilling. And now the Post Games podcast from Chris Plante, one of my favorite voices in video game journalism, is leveraging his decades of experience and insight (and a deep Rolodex to boot) to deliver some of the most unique stories in gaming in a wonderfully produced format.

It seems the Polygon legacy lives on.

’I just want more portrait mode games on my iPhone.’

July 24, 2025

Categories: Design

Brendon Bigley and Stephen Hilger, Into the Aether Podcast: S7E48 - “BB's Romhack Shack”:

> ***Brendon Bigley****: I just want more portrait mode games on my iPhone.*
>
> ***Stephen Hilger****: Yeah, that's the dream.*
>
> ***BB****: That's the dream. That's what we're always saying on this podcast. The whole reason we started the podcast.*
>
> *Hello and welcome to Into the Aether.*
>
> ***SH****: Jean d'Arc definitive edition in portrait mode.*
>
> ***BB****: Honestly, it's amazing. Just thinking about that, it's amazing that all of the Dragon Quest games are available in portrait mode on iOS.*
>
> ***SH****: That's for you.*
>
> ***BB****: And it's so wild that they did that. Yeah, even VII. Like they have a port.*
>
> *It's so wild.*

Couldn’t agree more. *Single-handed* portrait-mode games, if I may add.

”I won’t cry if you leave.”

September 7, 2025

Categories: Parenting

“I won’t cry if you leave.”

I left.

She cried.

Détante.

Reset tomorrow.

Those words stung. Not because I’d never heard them before. Because she’s now in preschool.

For the past week, I’ve been baffled by my emotions. Confused. Heightened. Anxious. Excited. Scared.

“I won’t cry if you leave.”

This is one of my biggest fears. In context, it’s a bedtime fit. I’m upset because she seems to have regressed into several potty accidents per day. I raise my voice. I take away books and toys. I’m disappointed and frustrated. She doubles-back with threats of her own.

“I won’t cry if you leave [my room at bedtime].”

It feels like a clear jab at the fact that she does not cry for us when she enters preschool each day. Something I’m proud of.

It’s a few hours a day, but it’s clear: this is the beginning of leaving her exposed to a world that is not overseen by me. She is not aided by me. She is not guided by me. She is not protected by me.

Today, at an older girl’s birthday party, I guard her spot in line from bigger kids; shielded her from bigger kids during a piñata rush; encouraged her to sit with the bigger kids during cupcakes. I’m cognizant of her hearing aides. Is she she’s overwhelmed? Can she hear the kids around her? Is she spatially aware of what’s going on? I’m proud when she leans into her independence, hurriedly leaving the crowds for scaling playgrounds bigger than she ought to for new and exciting slides. Maybe I should let her fend for herself more often. But then there’s the accidents. Maybe she still needs me.

“I won’t cry if you leave.”

It’s all too real when she tells me this when she’s upset with me. When she wants to prove her independence. And it’s all too real when she doesn’t cry when she leaves me for preschool — for a world that is not mine to oversee.

Adam Grant's Mario Kart Theory of Peak Flow

September 16, 2025

Categories: Health

Flow has bubbled up to my attention through the book "Designing Your Life" by Bill Burnett and Dave Evans, as well as various TED talks and podcasts. I'm currently listening to the audiobook "Flow" by Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi.

Outside of identifying flow for future career growth, I'm also intriuied by the idea of "flow" combating "languishing". In the spirit of this blog and its focus on video games, I wanted to share two fun ideas I came across when searching Overcast for the term "languishing", coincidentally within minutes of one another...

Adam Grant, TEDMonterey:

> *Like many of you, [during the pandemic] we were isolated from our extended family. My sister was halfway across the country. One day, we were reminiscing about how much we loved playing Mario Kart as we were kids. She said, "Well, we could all play together online now. WHy don't we start a family game?"*
>
> *Soon we were playing every day with a video call running at the same time. After a couple of weeks, I stopped feeling so blah. I was living zen in the art of Mario Kart. In the mornings, our kids were asking what time we'd play. They loved it when I would gloat about an impending victory, only to be bombed by a flying blue shell only to just sit there watching all three of our kids drive past me to the finish line in tiny go-carts.*
>
> *We had so much fun that we started a new Satuday night tradition after the kids were asleep: Adult Mario Kart.*
>
> *After reflecting on that experience, I'm proud to present to you for the first time my Mario Kart theory of peak flow. It has three conditions: mastery, mindfulness, and mattering.*
>
> ...

Stop here and take 15 minutes to watch the talk. Lots of good stuff here.

> ...
>
> *This all explains why Mario Kart was such a great experience for me.*
>
> *It gave me a feeling of mastery. The sweet satisfaction of a perfectly placed banana peel for my sister to slip on.*
>
> *It required mindfulness too. My brother-in-law was the best player. Beating him demanded total concentration. Especially when my kids were ganging up with him against me.*
>
> *And it wasn't just a game. It mattered. Over the past year, we've all felt helpless in one way or another. I felt helpless to fix COVID. I couldn't even do that much to make online school better, and I'm a teacher. But in Mario Kart, I felt helpful. I was able to give my kids*

> *something to look forward to when we couldn't go anywhere. I was able to keep my family close when we were far apart.*
>
> *We normally think of flow as an individual experience, by playing Nintendo, we were all immersed together. And although we don't play daily anymore, I feel closer to my sister and my brother-in-law than I ever have before. I learned that love is not the frequency of communication. It's the depth of connection. I also realized that the antidote to languishing does not have to be something productive. It can be something joyful. Our peak moments of flow are having fun with the people we love.*

And the other conversation:

Corey Keyes, Good Life Project podcast:

> *When I learned about why pinball machines were created, I was astonished to find out that the man, the person who created pinball, created it because he wanted people to experience during the Great Depression the sense that what they do matters. And to enjoy life because they can get better at accomplishing things and making things happen in the world.*
>
> *And that's what pinball, the whole story of pinball is. And the man who saved pinball, that movie and book, is all about showing the people in Chicago that it wasn't gambling, it wasn't a game of chance, it was a game that you develop skill. Yes you had fun, yes you had to put a little money in there, but he showed them.*
>
> *I learned to get better at something and I learned that whatever I can focus my mind on and do, I can accomplish something. So out of all the things you would think that could lead to that play, can teach your children and continue to teach adults that what you do matters.*
>
> *Yeah, I love that and I've been actively trying to cultivate more opportunities for play in my "for all those reasons, you know. I think it's just, we leave it behind, like sometimes forgetting that it's really fun to do things for no other reason than the feeling it gives you in the moment. And then if you can actually, you know, like build skill around that and gain competence at it also, you know.*
>
> *Connection and all those other.*
>
> *I mean, you look at the world of online gaming these days, and I'm not a part of that world, but I know folks who are. And they will spend hours and hours and not getting paid to do this. In fact, you know, they're paying for the privilege of having access to the games and the machines and, and yet it's just, and it's effort.*
>
> *They're working hard, you know, they're probably working harder from a sort of a creativity and a cognitive and a collaborative standpoint than they may be doing at their jobs. And yet they're doing it simply because they love doing it. You know, it's to them, it is that thing.*
>
> *It's play and they get better at it over time and they do it with other people, you know, and it's"there's something kind of magical about it.*

I don't necessarily find it surprising for video games to make their way into conversations of flow. Most consider video games to be a medium that delivers the fastest path to flow. But hearing two smart folks express why that is was quite fun.

Nothing overly earthshattering here. It's just neat to hear "serious" people bring up games in "serious" talks.

There is no such thing as a video game industry

January 17, 2026

Categories: Business

Christopher Dring, The Game Business:

> *My argument is that Resident Evil is more a competitor to Stranger Things than it is to Clash of Clans. Candy Crush is more directly competing with Tiktok than Fortnite. Roblox is more a rival to the school playground than Street Fighter.*
>
> *I just picked four segments, but you could easily add more to it. I would argue there are games that are akin to toys, for instance. And there are other ways to categorise these player motivations, such as Professor Richard Bartle's four-way 'Bartle types', or Quantic Foundry's motivation model. Or you can just create your own based on your own world view.*
>
> *These different ways of reframing the business helps us understand a few things. For one, being amazing at one type of game, doesn't mean you'll be amazing at another. How many single-player story studios have tried and struggled to develop and launch a live-service multiplayer title? Naughty Dog stopped mid-way through developing its The Last of Us online game with the realization that it wasn't set-up to deliver it. Of course there are exceptions (take a bow Rockstar), but there are far more BioWares, Crystal Dynamics, Remedys and Rocksteadys. It's not that these studios aren't talented, it's just their expertise lie in different areas.*
>
> *Beyond talent, I also think reframing the business is something we need to be doing more with those outside of games, whether that's investors, analysts, legislators, and even politicians. It's not uncommon for me to speak to a non-games analyst who has made the mistake of looking at mobile games and console games through the same lens.*

With so many games published monthly/weekly/daily and "forever" games seemingly dominating the market, I continually wonder who is playing all of these games? Does a 40-100 hour turn-based RPG stand any chance of business success if the market is at once so fragmented and consolidated? (There's room for *Baldur's Gate 3* and *Clair Obscur: Expedition 33*, so I suppose so!)

I think the answer to those questions lies in Dring's statement. Evaluating "video games" as a whole — whether that's due to the legacy of the medium (a new form of entertainment that all looked the same) or to prop industry numbers as Dring's guest Nicholas Lovell points out — is broken. I think "this is no video game industry" is a much healthier way to consider the interest and investment.

This sentiment feels like the perfect follow-up to my piece "Video Games Do Not Exist".

Still Super After All These (10) Years

February 1, 2026

Categories: Business


Electronic Gaming Monthly article titled on the Super Nintendo Entertainment System titled "Still Super After All These Years

I came across this article reflecting on 10 years of the Super Nintendo Entertainment System (SNES) in September 2001 issue of EGM (Electronic Gaming Monthly). I was initially humored by the title — Still Super After All These Years. "All These Years" being ten. Surely, ten years is not that long in video game parlance. It's not a far cry from the spread of proper Zelda or Mario games (5-11+ years).

But then I got to thinking... what happened between the release of the SNES and ten years later? Here's a timeline:

- SNES (1990/1991)
- Atari Jaguar (1993)
- Sega CD/Saturn (1994)
- Sony PlayStation 1 (1994)
- Nintendo 64 (1996)
- Sega Dreamcast (1998)
- Sony PlayStation 2 (2000)
- Microsoft Xbox (2001)

Compare that with the last ten:

- Nintendo Switch (2017)
- Microsoft Xbox Series (2020)
- Sony PlayStation 5 (2020)
- Nintendo Switch 2 (2025)

I wouldn't rush to call this the greatest decade in gaming (though, it very may well be). But I'd argue it was the most magical time in video game history. A breakneck pace of console releases. We were witnessing gargantuan leaps in fidelity, design, and input every year or so — from the perfection of 2D side-scrolling and top-down adventures to the birth of 3D and its evolution into arguably what we know it by today.

While it definitely *feels* like consoles now have diminishing returns —hence Microsoft and Sony's pivot into subscription services, publishing, and porting — I don't think anything has *illustrated* it more than the '91–'01 decade.

Microsoft Gaming CEO Phil Spencer Retiring, Xbox President Sarah Bond Resigning

February 21, 2026

Categories: Business

IGN:

> *Microsoft Gaming CEO Phil Spencer, who has been at Microsoft since he joined as an intern in 1988 and with Xbox since the software giant launched its first console in 2001, is retiring, sources familiar with the matter who are not authorized to speak publicly confirmed to IGN. Spencer's retirement is effective on Monday, February 23. Meanwhile, Xbox President Sarah Bond, long thought by many both inside and outside of Microsoft to be Spencer's heir apparent, has resigned. The new CEO of Microsoft Gaming will be Asha Sharma, currently the President of Microsoft's CoreAI product. Finally, Xbox Game Studios head Matt Booty is being promoted to Chief Content Officer and will work closely with Sharma.*

I'm at once shocked and not shocked by this news. Shocked that Sarah is resigning. I pegged her more as a successor and trying to change the narrative. And I'm sure the money is good.

Not shocked as I had a hard time believing that Phil (and Sarah) could weather the storm that has been Xbox over the past few years — aquisitions, massive layoffs, studio closures, etc. They seemed to genuinely care about the brand (or I would like to believe they did). But at some point, something's gotta give.

Maybe the most comically sad and telling part of this announcement is in the opening paragraph of Satya Nadella's company-wide email (via GameFile, emphasis mine):

> *Gaming has been part of Microsoft from the start. Flight Simulator shipped before Windows, and you can practically **ray-trace** a line from DirectX in the '90s to the accelerated-compute era we're in today.*

Ray-trace? JFC.